Devotion

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/73803431.

Rating:
Explicit

Archive Warnings:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence, Major Character Death, Rape/Non-Con

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Mermista (She-Ra), Adora & Lonnie (She-ra), Minor or Background Relationship(s), Catra & Entrapta (She-Ra), Adora/Glimmer (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Horde Prime (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra), Horde Prime Clones (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Implied/Referenced Rape/Non-con, Implied/Referenced Character Death, Implied/Referenced Underage Sex, Torture, Body Horror, Trans Adora (She-Ra), Clones, Trauma, Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder - PTSD, Angst and Hurt/Comfort, Fluff and Smut, Awkward Flirting, Break Up, Lesbian Disaster Catra (She-Ra), Princess Catra (She-Ra), Adora is in Love with Catra (She-Ra), Catra is in Love with Adora (She-Ra), Rage, Memory Alteration, Memory Loss, Self-Doubt, Marriage Proposal, Angst with a Happy Ending, Blood and Gore, Dead Dove: Do Not Eat, Unreliable Narrator, Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, Not Canon Compliant, Attempted Rape/Non-Con, Background Relationships, loss of sense of self, Self-Sacrifice, She-Ra forms work how I say they work, Gratuitous Smut, Fighting As Foreplay, Oral Sex, Fingerfucking, Come Swallowing, Catra is not a size queen yet but give it time..., Catra is ABBG - Assigned Bottom by Glimmer, Frottage, Catra is a pillow princess, Unplanned Pregnancy

Language:
English

Series:
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Collections:
She-Ra

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Published: 2025-11-07 Completed: 2026-05-15 Words: 180,890 Chapters: 48/48

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Devotion

by cjowofics

Summary

Horde Prime is going to get what he deserves

Notes

Alright-- tags, yeah there's some troubling ones, there's some confusing ones. I maintain some spoilers by not adding some yet but I feel like this has covered most things that could be upsetting to have sprung on readers. I did put the warnings in because of flashbacks throughout and chapter 2 specifically.

Chapters will alternate pov based on what the story needs.

If you're reading this you would probably know that this is based on Captive Prince, book 3 (King's Rising). There's a lot of missing context it you start here, please start at Disposition.

The chapter count can only go up, not down, trust me. Is this earlier than I intended? Yup.

Enjoy 🙂

Chapter 1: Adora

“She-Ra.”

“Adora.”

Her name hit the quiet like a dropped weapon. The sound of it rolled across the courtyard, carried by disbelief.

Adora stood at the foot of the dais. Mermista knelt before her, one knee down, head bowed. Behind her, rows of Salinean soldiers followed suit—shields angled, tridents lowered, the motion spreading like wind through grass. So smooth it was mesmerising.

For half a second, Adora felt the quiet of homecoming. Then the silence broke.

The word passed from soldier to soldier, carried outward to the Horde citizens crowding the walls. The tone changed—first confused, then sharp, then furious.

“Mage-slayer!” someone shouted.

It came again, louder, multiplied. The air tightened.

Something whistled past Adora’s shoulder and clattered against the stone. A rock. Then another.

Mermista was already up. Her hand snapped, and water gathered around her in spiraling arcs, rising from the puddles that had pooled under the morning fog. The surface shimmered and hardened to blade points.

“Stand down,” Adora said, throwing out her arm.

Mermista stopped—but her jaw worked, and her eyes burned. “They’re throwing things at *you*,” she said flatly.

“I said *stand down*.”

The water froze mid-air. Droplets hovered, vibrating.

Adora turned her head. A Horde soldier had drawn his sword—one in grey, shaking so hard the blade rattled against the hilt. Clone 13. She knew him.

“Captain Mara?” His voice cracked on the name.

Adora didn’t blink. “Hold!” she barked, louder this time, her tone all command.

The crowd didn’t listen. Panic started to eat at the edges. Shouting. The sound of boots scraping, of shields striking together. Horde guards pushed toward the front, shouting orders that no one heard.

Mermista’s troops held formation, but barely. The line flexed, tension snapping through every pair of shoulders.

Another sword came free. Then another. The sound of metal being drawn was everywhere.

The Horde soldiers were terrified—some angry, some frozen. Adora could see it all from where she stood: the fear, the split-second weighing of fight or flight. Clone 16’s eyes flicked between her and the gate. He saw what the commoners in the crowd didn’t: Etherian soldiers already inside, already surrounding them, fifteen to one.

Adora’s pulse steadied. She could feel the decision form in her chest, as cold and certain as ice.

This wasn’t going to be saved by words.

She’d misjudged it—the hope that her name could mean unity, that it could bridge the years of war. To the Horde, it still meant death.

She-Ra. Adora. Mage-slayer.

The chant of the latter moniker was starting again. Louder now.

Adora lifted her chin and looked at Mermista. “We end this before it spreads,” she said quietly.

Mermista’s expression hardened. “You sure?”

Adora’s voice didn’t rise. “Take the fort.”

Mermista gave a short nod. “Fine. But you’re explaining this later.”

The water around her surged forward, rippling into shape as she turned away.

✧

Adora’s boots hit stone hard enough to echo down the hallway. Six guards moved with her, fishscale armor clinking in time. Etherian banners hung over the corridors—white cloth, gold trim.

Talon Mountain had changed hands twice in seven days. The first time had taken a whole day of fighting. The second—hers—had taken less than one hour. Adora didn’t feel proud of that. She just knew exactly where to strike.

The Horde garrison had broken before sundown. Now its commanders waited for her. Clone 16. And Lonnie.

The antechamber was bare. One lamp. Stone walls. A single table pushed to the side. Two Etherian guards shoved the prisoners forward and barked, “Kneel,” in thick, broken Horde speech.

Lonnie didn’t. She caught herself with one hand, half a stumble, half a refusal.

“No,” Adora said. “Let them stand.”

Her tone was quiet, but the guards dropped back at once.

Clone 16 was up first, shoulders stiff. Lonnie followed slowly. Her wrists were bound but her spine was straight.

Clone 16 spoke first, "So it's true. You're Adora of Bright Moon."

"It's true," she said.

He spat on the floor. A guard hit him instantly—the smack of metal gauntlet against skin. His head snapped sideways.

Adora didn't stop it.

He wiped his mouth, blood on his thumb. "You going to kill us?"

Adora looked him over, then Lonnie. Dust. Bruises. Hollow eyes. Lonnie's jaw was set in a way she recognized—the same way she had looked when she found out a week prior. The same way she had looked after Catra had verbally torn Entrapta apart. The same way she looked when she had spent an hour saying goodbye to Entrapta.

"I'm giving you a choice," Adora said.

Lonnie gave a short laugh. "Yeah, I've heard that one before. Serve me or die. I was on Prime's flagship for years, remember?"

Adora ignored her. "Etheria isn't here to occupy your fort. We're here to fight Prime. You know what he is. You've seen what happens to those who stand alone."

Clone 16 let out a shaky breath. "And if we '*choose*' wrong?"

"Then you stay here," Adora said. "Prisoners. Or you come with me to Seaspray and help end this before it reaches Bright Moon."

He glared at her. "You don't get it. We don't fight beside you. You —" He stopped himself, jaw locking. "You betrayed her. You *had* her—"

"Get him out," Adora said flatly.

The guards grabbed Clone 16 and hauled him toward the door. Adora gestured for the rest to leave. Only one remained.

Lonnie stayed where she was, breathing hard but steady. When the door shut, the silence thickened.

"You don't have to play commander with me," she said finally. "You think I don't know what this is?"

Adora didn't rise to it. "I made her a promise."

Lonnie's head tilted. "And when she finds out it's you? That She-Ra's the one she's fighting beside?"

"Then that's when we meet," Adora said. Her voice was low now. "For real."

Lonnie looked at her for a long time. Then she gave a small exhale that might've been a laugh. "Yeah. That's gonna go great."

✧

When it was done, Adora stopped in the doorway, her hand on the frame to steady herself. She thought of her name, already spreading through the fort, through the mountains, down into the towns. A sound traveling ahead of her like a wave she couldn't take back.

If she could hold this place, hold her people together long enough to reach Seaspray… maybe that would be enough. Maybe that would make the rest of it bearable.

She pushed the door open and stepped into the hall.

Mermista was there, standing near the table, water still dripping faintly from her armor. She turned at the sound, eyes flicking over Adora, taking in the state of her.

Before Adora could say anything, Mermista dropped to one knee—not fast, not dramatic, just a show of respect.

“The fort’s yours,” Mermista said. “My Queen.”

The word hit Adora like a slap.

Queen.

It was her mother’s title. The sound of it crawled over her skin. For a heartbeat, she thought she could smell the lilies her mother used to grow, hear the echo of her voice in the Bright Moon halls. But that throne was Glimmer’s now. Bright Moon had moved on.

Looking at Mermista—her friend—kneeling there in a captured Horde stronghold, Adora felt it for the first time: there was no Princess Adora anymore. That self was gone.

You get everything you ever wanted, and it still costs you everything else.

Hadn’t Catra said something similar?

Adora blinked the thought away and looked down at Mermista: her damp teal hair sticking to her neck, her armor scuffed, the faint salt smell of salt still clinging to her. Once, they’d raced barefoot through the halls of Salineas, laughing, sand still on their legs from training. Back then, Adora had imagined coming home would feel like that—like sunlight, like laughter.

Instead, her friend was kneeling in a Horde fort.

“Rise,” Adora said quietly. “Please. Mermista.”

Mermista stood, brushing dust from her knee, eyes searching Adora’s face. “You look… alive,” she said after a beat. “Didn’t expect that.”

Adora managed a breath that might’ve been a laugh.

“I thought you were dead,” Mermista went on. “I sent out scallop candles. Swam out to the mourning stones. You were supposed to

be gone.” Her tone wasn’t accusing—just flat, stunned. “What the hell happened?”

Adora looked at the table, at the small flicker of lamplight across it. “Bright Moon was infiltrated,” she said. “A shape-shifter. They killed Angella, faked my death, sent me to The Horde as a prisoner.”

She stopped there. It was enough for now.

Mermista was still watching her. “I saw Glimmer crowned,” she said finally. “She stood under her mother’s Runestone. Said something about loss teaching us to hope again.” Her brow furrowed. “It sounded… kinda rehearsed.”

Adora didn’t answer. She could picture it easily—Glimmer on the dais, Bow behind her, the air thick with incense to cover the stench of death in the castle. The world carrying on without her.

“Tell me,” Adora said.

So Mermista told her.

She told her how Bright Moon had held a procession for *her body*, wrapped in silk and carried beside Angella’s. How Glimmer had spoken, tears perfect and visible, the whole court watching. How the story changed depending on who asked: Adora killed by her own guard, her guard executed for treason, chaos swallowing the palace.

Mermista’s tone stayed even. “Bow’s soldiers locked everything down after. Said they were keeping order. Said no one else needed to die.”

“Did you believe them?” Adora asked.

Mermista’s mouth twitched. “I wanted to. It was easier.”

Adora nodded slowly. “Do you think she knew?”

“I don't know,” Mermista said. “Maybe Glimmer just didn’t want anyone knowing how bad it really was. How easy it was to take out two Queens so quickly.”

Mermista looked down. “Welcome home, I guess.”

Adora didn’t look up. “If it still is.”

“There’s more,” Mermista said.

The words came out like something she hadn’t wanted to say. She hesitated, studying Adora’s face as if deciding whether it could handle what came next. Then she reached into the side of her fishscale breastplate and pulled out a folded piece of paper, stiff with salt and age.

She held it out. “Here.”

Adora took it carefully. The letter had been wet at some point; the edges curled, ink blurred. She unfolded it slowly, the smell of sea air clinging to the parchment.

To the Princess of Salineas, Mermista,

from Catra, Princess of the Horde.

The name alone made Adora’s breath hitch. She ran her thumb over the fading ink. The strokes were familiar—deliberate, sharp at the corners. Catra’s hand.

It was old. She could tell by the wear of the paper, by the brittle fold lines. Adora could almost see her—sitting alone, lamplight on her desk, the edge of her mouth drawn tight the way it always was when she was pretending not to care. *Do you think I’d get on with Mermista of Salineas?* she’d asked once, smirking like it was a joke.

The thought twisted in her chest. It made sense, of course. Catra was always good at doing what she had to, no matter how much

it hurt someone. She could turn loyalty into a tool and friendship into leverage. It wasn't cruelty. It was survival.

Adora skimmed the contents. An offer—aid from Salineas in exchange for proof that Double Trouble had worked with Prime to assassinate Queen Angella. The same truth Catra had thrown in her face nights ago.

Mermista folded her arms. "We didn't know what to believe," she said. "Glimmer always had an answer. Every time someone questioned her, she had some new version ready. She was Angella's true daughter. You were dead. That was enough for most people."

Her tone sharpened. "Castaspella swore loyalty first. After that, everyone else followed."

Adora looked up. "You don't think Glimmer's giving up the crown easily."

Mermista gave a small snort. "Please. Have you met her? She's stubborn."

That pulled the faintest smile from Adora, one that didn't reach her eyes.

She knew what waited ahead—Glimmer's certainty, her defenses. She hadn't dared hope to hear anything else. But hearing Mermista say it aloud turned hope into something painful.

"The west still remembers you," Mermista said after a moment. "The soldiers. The coastal towns. They haven't forgotten what you stand for."

"And if I ask them to fight?"

Mermista didn't blink. "Then we fight. Together."

The words hit her harder than she expected. Not the promise, just the ease of it. No hesitation, no suspicion. Just trust. The kind she

hadn’t felt in too long.

Mermista turned away, went to the chest near the wall, and opened it. Metal creaked. She lifted out a long bundle wrapped in cloth.

“This is yours,” she said. “I shouldn’t have kept it. Treason, technically.” Her mouth tilted, almost a smile. “Guess I’m still bad at politics.”

She unwrapped the cloth. Light caught on polished gold metal.

The Sword of Protection.

Mermista held it out with both hands. “I kept it to remember you. Stupid, maybe. But I couldn’t let them take it.”

Adora reached for it slowly, as though the air between them might break. The metal was cool against her palms, heavier than memory had made it.

“You shouldn’t have risked this,” she said quietly. “Not for me.”

Mermista shrugged, faint amusement ghosting over her face. “Maybe I just wanted to be the next She-Ra?”

Adora quirked an eyebrow at her and Mermista shrugged. “It didn't work.”

Adora looked at her. “You’re too quick to pledge yourself.”

“You’re my Queen,” Mermista said simply.

Queen.

The word didn’t feel like victory. It felt like loss that hadn’t finished echoing through her. She had no time to process her grief.

She gripped Mermista’s shoulder, the touch brief but steady. It was all she had to offer right now.

Mermista glanced down at Adora's uniform—the dark red, the sharp seams, the clean military lines. "You know," she said, tugging lightly at the sleeve, "you really do look like a Horde officer."

Adora almost rolled her eyes. "Yeah, well—"

Mermista froze. Her hand stayed at Adora's wrist, eyes narrowing.

"Adora," she said quietly.

Adora followed her gaze. The sleeve had slipped.

A wide band of platinum encircled her wrist—cold, smooth and unbroken. At her own request.

Mermista stepped back as if struck. Her eyes went wide, her mouth opening, closing, words failing before they formed.

Adora caught her arm. "Mermista. Don't."

Mermista froze, torn between instinct and the part of her that had always followed orders, however apatheticly. Adora could feel the tension in her muscles, the effort it took her not to pull away.

"Please," Adora said quietly. "Listen."

Her voice felt foreign in her mouth, like she was hearing herself from a distance. Her pulse was hammering. "Yes," she said, forcing the word out. "It's true."

Mermista blinked. "What?"

Adora swallowed. "Double Trouble sold me to the Horde. Catra freed me. She gave me command of her troops. She doesn't even know who I really am."

The color drained from Mermista's face. "She freed you?" The word caught in her throat. "Freed you *from what*, Adora?"

Adora didn't answer, but the look was enough.

“You were her—” Mermista started, and then stopped. Her voice thinned. “You were her *bed slave?*”

The *title* hung in the air, small but shattering.

A sound came from behind them—soft and shocked.

Adora turned.

Frosta stood in the doorway, hand still half-raised as if she’d meant to knock and forgot how. Behind her, two Salinean guards stood stiff, eyes down.

For a long moment, no one moved.

Adora felt the heat crawl up her neck. She dropped Mermista’s arm. The room was too quiet.

The platinum cuff caught the light when she moved. That was all it took. The meaning was clear. Everyone in the room knew what a cuff like that meant.

She could feel their eyes on it, on her—and worse, on the picture they were already building in their heads. The kind of picture that couldn’t be undone.

She forced her hands still. “Yes,” she said. “You’re seeing it right.”

Her voice sounded dry. She rolled her sleeve back further until the full band of metal was visible. She said. “I was the Horde Princess’s Slave. And she—” her voice hitched, just once, “—she gave us this fort.”

Mermista’s jaw set. “Stop.” She turned sharply toward Frosta, her voice hard. “You don’t repeat this. You don’t even breathe this to anyone outside this room.”

Adora shook her head. “No. It’s done. People already know.”

Frosta’s eyes were fixed on the cuff. Her voice came out low, clipped. “You served the Princess of the Horde as a *bed slave?*”

Adora met her gaze. “I survived. That’s all that matters.”

Frosta’s mouth thinned. “You’re our Queen. This—” she gestured vaguely, her hand trembling just once— “this is shameful to Etheria.”

Adora didn’t flinch. “You’ll bear it,” she said. “As I did. Or are you above your Queen now?”

Frosta’s stare was sharp, but her silence gave her away. *Not a queen, a slave.*

Adora saw the fight in her eyes—pride, disgust, the same kind of pride that had made her mother’s court unbreakable and cruel. The idea of her Queen marked, owned, made her shoulders tighten.

Mermista broke the silence. “If word spreads,” she said slowly, “I can’t promise the troops won’t turn.”

Adora’s reply was quiet, certain. “It’s already spread. Everyone already occupying the Fort knew I was her slave. Do you think they won't talk?”

Mermista’s throat worked once before she answered. “Then what do you need from us?”

Adora looked between them. Her face had gone still, her voice stripped of anything soft. “You make your pledge,” she said. “And if you’re mine, you gather the soldiers. We fight.”

No one spoke. Frosta bowed her head, just enough to count. Mermista didn’t move.

✧

The plan she'd made with Catra wasn't overly clever. It depended on timing and nerve.

Seaspray wasn't like the Talons. It wasn't open ground—no straight lines, no clear sight. It was a bowl of ridges and hollows, thick with brush and fog that clung to the sand. Easy to lose formation there. Easier to die in one.

Prime had picked it on purpose. He liked traps. He liked control. Inviting Catra to fight there was the same as daring her to walk straight into his teeth.

So they'd turned the trap over. Catra had taken her riders north-west two days ago. She'd swing back around and hit Prime's rear once his forces were pulled toward the coast. Adora's army was the lure.

Before stepping out, Adora sat still for a moment, staring at her wrist. The metal cuff glinted. She left it visible.

Her Horde uniform was gone. She wore She-Ra's form instead—white, gold, and too bright under the daylight. Bare arms. Bare legs from the knee to mid thigh. The cape pinned with gold disks at her shoulders. It felt lighter than it should have. It felt right to take on her form again.

When she walked out onto the dais, the noise in the courtyard died. Thousands of soldiers stood in ranks below—Salinean teal, Bright Moon white, Northern navy. Armor catching light, lines straight and disciplined.

She let them look. Let them see her—the cuff, the sword, the body that rumour said had risen from the dead.

When she spoke, her voice carried clean, unforced.

"Soldiers of Etheria," she said. "I am Adora. True daughter of Eternia. I've come back to fight for you—and with you—as your Queen."

For a heartbeat, there was silence. Then the courtyard erupted. Tridents and spear-butts struck the ground. Voices broke the stillness like thunder rolling down the slopes.

She found Frosta among the first line—face unreadable, hand tight around her weapon.

Adora gave a nod. It was enough that she was here.

The horns sounded. Standards rose. The skiff she'd used at the Talons slid forward on its hover field. She stepped aboard, and the soldiers opened a path through the ranks.

Then came another sound—sharper, off-beat. Metal scraping stone.

A handful soldiers in red and black on skiffs pushed through the crowd.

The Etherian ranks bristled—shields came up, a ripple of tension moving down the line.

Adora raised her hand, palm out. "Stand down."

The red-and-black skiffs slowed. Lonnie, with Clone 16 and Clone 28 flanking her.

The skiffs circled once before Lonnie eased hers close enough to be heard. "We're not here to fight you," she said. "We're here to fight *with* you."

Adora studied the group—the mix of Horde insignia and Etherian eyes on them from every side. Lonnie met her gaze, steady.

Adora gave a short nod. "Then we fight," she said. Her voice wasn't loud, but it carried. "For Etheria. For the Fright Zone."

Adora raised her sword, the light catching across the metal. The sky above the sea had already started to darken—the kind of gray that promised rain.

✧

The fog thickened the closer they got to Seaspray. The air was wet and heavy with salt; the ground under the skiffs had turned from firm dirt to sliding grit. The ridges were uneven, folding in and out of sight like broken waves. Scouts vanished into the haze, their reports coming back in quick bursts: Prime's army pushing from the west and—higher ground, better cover.

Adora's troops were in the bowl, down in the fog. Bait.

She'd never have led soldiers into ground like this without a plan to claw out of it. The numbers were bad, the terrain worse. If Catra didn't hit from the north when expected, they wouldn't make it through the day.

Mermista stared out at the hills. "This is a choke point," she said flatly. "You know that, right?"

Adora didn't look at her. "We need him overcommitted. It has to happen here."

"Yeah, sure. Great place for dying tragically."

Frosta's Elk came up alongside, her voice cutting through the fog. "Visibility's dropping fast. We can't see the treeline."

"Scouts will hold the perimeter," Adora said. "Stay ready. Don't move until I call it."

She kept the plan in her head like a map: Prime advances from the west; Etheria holds the valley floor. Once Prime's troops are fully inside, Catra's division crashes down from the north-west, splits the line, traps them between.

Trust me, Catra had said.

Adora raised her hand. "Form up," she ordered.

The clatter of armor and the scrape of skiff runners and mounts shifted through the fog. Soldiers took their places, shields up, lines tight. The air went still. That particular kind of silence that meant everyone could feel the weight of what was about to happen.

“They’ll open from the west,” Adora said. “Wait for my mark.”

A distant horn sounded through the valley, long and hollow.

“Hold,” Adora said.

Movement flickered in the fog—the outline of enemy banners, glints of light off metal.

“Hold.”

Another horn, this one closer.

Then a ripple of motion to her right—the western flank shifting forward. She turned sharply.

Frosta was advancing her riders. The ice running from her hands hissed as it hit the damp ground.

“Pull them back,” Adora snapped, cutting across the open space to intercept.

Frosta didn’t even flinch. “We’re taking position on the ridge. You’re wasting time.”

“My order was to hold,” Adora said, circling her skiff closer. “Prime’s waiting for this exact mistake. Let him come to us.”

“If we wait, and your Princess doesn’t show, we’re slaughtered.”

“She’ll come,” Adora said, sharper now.

Frosta’s reply was a short, cold laugh. “I know you believe that.”

Before Adora could answer, another horn split the air, this one from the north.

Too close.

Her head snapped up. “That’s not possible—”

But the sound of engines cut her off. A low, fast hum that built until it filled the valley. From the treeline ahead, shadows burst through the fog—Prime’s clones, pouring downhill.

A single Etherian scout broke from the tree line, riding flat out. His voice carried over the noise. “She’s not coming! Catra’s not—”

The crack of a blaster. He dropped mid-sentence.

Frosta turned toward Adora. “There’s your Horde Princess for you,” she said.

Adora didn’t answer. The first volley hit before she could.

Metal screamed. Soldiers shouted, some dropping where they stood. Bullets tore through the fog in whistling arcs. Adora’s voice cut over it — “Shields up! Fire on my mark!”—but the lines were already breaking, forced back under the weight of the charge.

She felt the shock of it, the noise, the bodies slamming against hers in the confusion.

Prime’s plan was clear now—turn her army into the wall Catra could never breach.

Another horn, this one from the northwest. A second wave. The surround was complete.

Adora forced her skiff through the crush, cutting toward the front line. Her shoulder hit something solid—a red and black blur that turned out to be Lonnie, steering hard to stay upright.

“Go east,” Adora shouted. “Now. You can still get clear.”

Lonnie glanced at her, hair plastered to her face, eyes sharp and furious. “She’s not coming, is she?”

Adora didn’t look back. “We’re outnumbered,” she said. “If you run, some of you make it out.”

“Yeah? And what about you?”

Adora gripped the controls tighter. The line ahead was collapsing. “I’ll do what I always do.”

Lonnie’s voice came over the roar. “And what’s that?”

“Fight.”

She slammed the throttle forward and vanished into the smoke.

Chapter 2: Catra

Chapter Notes

> TW: threats of rape/defiling a corpse, torture, sort of mild body horror (I feel like my standards are warped), threatening to disembowel someone, death of a character, reference/implication of sexual abuse of minors, brief SA PTSD flashback, significant injuries.

> I think there's a total of 3 big reveals in this chapter, some have been hinted at through either previous scenes or my art on Patreon.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra woke to the sound of her own breathing. Her wrists were tied behind her, rope biting into skin gone raw. The rest of her body felt wrong—not just sore, *misaligned*.

The sharp pull at her shoulder told her why.

Dislocated.

She stayed still and listened. Water dripping somewhere distant. The air was stale and earthy. No wind. It was uncomfortably cold.

Underground.

When she tried to move, the chair protested with a low, metallic groan. The back of her head throbbed where she'd clearly been struck.

Memory came back in flashes—the ambush at the ridge, the flash of fire, someone shouting her name—then the dark.

Torchlight flickered against the opposite wall. The cell was small, carved from rough stone. A dozen feet across, maybe less. The floor was packed earth, sticky with moisture.

Stars, I hope that's not my blood.

The only furniture was the chair she was tied to.

In front of her stood Hordak.

His eyes glowed red in the dim light, steady, patient.

“Hello, Princess.”

The sound of his voice hit harder than the pain. Familiar in the worst way.

Her pulse jumped, then steadied—she forced it to steady. She lifted her head and looked him straight on.

Hell’s Rest. The name slid into place. That meant Double Trouble was lurking around here somewhere.

Hordak watched her a while before speaking again. “You’ve been out for some time. The others weren’t as lucky.”

She didn’t rise to it. “Guess I’m special.”

He moved closer. “You’re alive because I wanted you that way. For now.”

Her eyes flicked to the torch, to the bars, back to him. “You always had such a talent for hospitality.”

The corner of his mouth twitched, not quite amusement. “You’re trapped. No one’s coming. Even I can’t open that cell door. When I’m done, they’ll collect what’s left. What do you say to that?”

Catra’s voice came out rough but level. “How’s your shoulder?”

The blow came fast. Her head snapped sideways; metal rang as the chair legs skidded slightly.

At least it wasn't bolted down.

When she looked back up, she was smiling. Blood edged her teeth.

“Touchy,” she said.

His eyes narrowed. The next strike landed harder.

Pain radiated down her neck. She swallowed laughter before it could slip out—not from humor, but from the sharp edge of panic she refused to let show.

“I always wondered what hold you had on him,” she said once she caught her breath. “Prime. What made him keep you around all this time.”

Hordak’s voice dropped. “Careful.”

“I mean, it has to be something,” she went on. “You don’t get to play commander forever without a leash. Maybe you’ve got something on him. Some secret. But you know it won’t last.”

His claws flexed once against his palm. “You think I’m a fool?”

“No,” she said. “I think you’re scared. Same as me. Difference is, I admit it.”

He leaned closer until the torchlight caught the edge of his face. “When you die,” he said, voice low, “do you really think *she’ll* care?”

Catra didn’t blink. “You tell me,” she said. “You’ve spent longer being alone than I have.”

“You want to think this is chance,” he said. “That Prime tossed you here to see what happens. But no. I asked for you.”

Catra didn’t look at him.

“He gives me what I ask for,” Hordak went on, pacing a slow half-circle. “He always has. Even you—his favorite, his little pet. He let me have you.”

She smiled without humor. “That’s not a compliment. It’s an admission. He’s tired of you too.”

That made him pause.

“We’re both problems,” she said. “He throws us in a pit, waits for one to solve the other. Saves him ammunition.”

Her voice was dry, stripped of tone. “He’s efficient like that.”

Hordak’s claws flexed once against the knife hilt at his side. “You still think you’re clever.”

“I think you’ve been around him long enough to know how this ends,” Catra said. “Once Prime finishes eating everything, there’s no leverage left. Whatever you’re holding over him, it won’t matter. Kill me, and you’re next. Same dark cell. Different toy.”

He watched her for a long time, then said quietly, “He told me you’d say that.”

Her stomach turned. “What else did he say?”

Hordak’s tone shifted—colder now, pleased with itself. “He said you’d try to talk your way out. Said you’d flatter, stall, anything to stay breathing. He said you’d use that mouth of yours until someone stopped it.”

Catra felt a phantom tug on her hair. The pain in her throat. She had to will back the tears that threatened to spill.

Instead, Hordak drew a knife. The metal caught the light, dull at the edge.

“He told me,” Hordak said, “the only way to keep you from talking is to cut out your tongue.”

Her throat tightened, but she didn’t look away. “And yet here you are,” she said. “Listening.”

That earned a small sound—not quite a laugh, but pretty close.

“You want to hear it,” she said. “You always have. You want to know everything. What he hides from you. That’s what you want, isn’t it?”

Hordak’s hand twitched. The knife turned slightly in his grip. “Careful.”

“You hate being careful,” she said softly. “That’s what he never saw. You wanted to be him. To know everything he knows. You don’t want obedience. You don't want to be another copy. You want control.”

He moved. The knife came down.

Metal met *flesh*.

She saw it before she felt it—the flash of light on the blade, the twist of his wrist. Then pressure, deep and blunt, above her knee.

No pain.

She looked down. The knife was buried to the hilt in her leg. She waited for the white-hot wave, for the nausea, but it didn’t come.

Her leg still felt like hers. She was *sure* she could feel it.

Hordak’s head tilted. Confusion passed over his face, followed by something meaner. He jerked the knife down. A clean line tore through what looked like skin, but wasn’t. No blood. The *skin* was too thick and spongey.

“I had wondered,” Catra said under her breath.

“What did you say?”

She didn’t answer.

It's not real…

Is any of me fucking real?

He pulled the knife free, turned it over, and pressed the blade to her shoulder. “Let’s see which parts hurt, then.”

The steel slid in slowly and his time the pain came fast. The sound that escaped her wasn’t a scream so much as air punched out of her lungs. The longer it went on, the slower he went the more time he had to bring those sound out of her.

By the time it was all the way in, her ears were ringing from the echoes of her own screams.

Hordak’s face was close now.

“Maybe Prime will let me use what's left of you,” he said. “He keeps the ones he breaks. Lines the hall with them. His little trophies. I'm sure that's exactly what he keeps them for. All the important parts are usually intact.”

Catra forced a breath through her teeth. “You cunt.”

He hit her again.

Her head snapped sideways; the taste of blood flooded her mouth again.

“I can make this much worse, Princess,” Hordak said, voice low.

Catra spat blood on the floor. “Then stop promising and fucking get to it!”

He voice raised at the end, echoing painfully off the walls.

He pulled the blade roughly from her shoulder, bringing it down to her gut. A shallow, cruel cut. The pain ripped through her, bright enough to blot out everything else.

He twisted it slightly—moved to the side.

"Move too much—struggle," he said, calm again. "And that opens. You'll bleed out before I'm finished."

Catra lifted her head, breathing hard, meeting his eyes through the haze. "You talk too much," she said.

✧

Time stopped meaning much after the first stretch. Could've been an hour, could've been three. It didn't help that there was no fucking sunlight.

All she knew was the ache that spread every time she breathed.

Her white undershirt hung open to the waist. The fabric had gone stiff with blood, her right sleeve soaked through with red. The knife was back in her shoulder. The angle was wrong—buried deep into the same joint that had been dislocated. Every movement sent a dull pulse of pain up her neck.

Her hair was matted to her face. Sweat and blood had dried into streaks down her collarbone.

Small victories, she told herself. The knife hadn't gone into her throat. Her tongue was still where it belonged. The knife had gone somewhere *less* useful instead. That was something.

She had freed one hand. Her left. The rope still hung loose around her wrist, hiding it. It wouldn't help much, but it made her feel like she wasn't entirely doomed.

Nothing from outside. No voices, no shifting footsteps. Just the occasional crack of settling rock somewhere in the walls.

When the sound finally came—a door scraping open, metal dragging—it was almost a relief.

A voice floated in, too light for the place.

“This is taking longer than I expected.”

Double Trouble.

Hordak didn’t turn. His tone was dry, casual. “What’s the matter? Bored already? Stay. You might learn something.”

Catra’s voice came rough, cracking halfway through. “Do they know?”

That made Double Trouble pause as they looked into the cell. “Know what, dear?”

“The secret,” she said, eyes half-lidded. “What he’s holding over Prime. Purification is only so perfect and Prime knows he'll get his memory back eventually.”

“Enough,” Hordak snapped.

Double Trouble tilted their head, sharp smile fading. “What *secret*?”

Catra coughed, the sound wet, almost a laugh. “You never asked yourself why Prime left him like this? Still calling himself Hordak? Behaving so publicly imperfect.” She breathed through her teeth. “Because Prime let him. Hordak knows someth—”

Hordak’s hand closed around the knife in her shoulder. “Shut your mouth.”

He turned the blade.

Her vision went white, then black. A sound escaped her that didn’t sound like her voice. It was so high pitch, it barely sounded real.

Through the ringing in her ears she heard Double Trouble—

“You’ve been holding something back. An arrangement?”

Hordak’s reply was a snarl. “You’re overstepping.”

“Hardly. If you’ve been negotiating on your own, I deserve to know.”

He let go of the knife and turned toward them.

She distantly heard the scrape of metal moving.

Catra felt the change in the air.

Her free hand found the hilt. She wrapped her fingers around it and pulled.

The pain this time came clean and deep, all through her chest. She made a low, broken noise she couldn’t stop. The sound pulled both their attention.

She slid her hand along the blade, sliced through what was left of the rope on her other wrist. Her legs barely held when she pushed herself upright.

For a second she was sure she’d fall.

She didn’t.

Some small mercy kept her leg together.

She got one foot under her, one hand pressed hard against the wound in her gut, and stood behind the chair. The knife shook in her grip, slick with blood.

Hordak turned back toward her, his expression almost curious. “Impressive.”

Catra’s voice rasped. “That means *so* much coming from you.”

“I'm sure it does.” he said.

Double Trouble stepped back, eyes flicking between them. “Oh, this is rich,” they murmured, tone slipping back into performance, “I do hope you know what you’re doing, darling.”

Catra’s breath came fast. She shifted her weight, holding the knife steady. “Do you?”

For a heartbeat, none of them moved.

“Get her back under control,” Double Trouble said, sounding bored more than alarmed.

Catra’s breathing was ragged. The knife trembled in her hand. The left one—the wrong one. She could feel how useless it was. She had no illusions. Hordak was faster, stronger.

Still, she raised the blade.

Hordak didn’t hesitate. He moved through her guard, one strike. Pain tore through her chest and shoulder as she dropped the knife. She cried out—

She’d felt it before. Pain like memory. Pain that meant: *another me dies here*.

No—

Not this time. Not this body.

She kissed this body—

Would Prime bother to revive her again? Start from scratch? Maybe not. Maybe this was the last copy.

Her right arm hung useless. She grabbed the metal chair with her good one and swung.

The crash was solid and ugly. The corner caught Hordak above the ear with a sound that made her teeth hurt—a hollow thud,

bone and metal. He staggered sideways, hit the wall, went down hard.

Catra nearly followed him. The effort took more than she had left. The room tilted.

Double Trouble flinched, pressing themselves against the wall. "Well," they said, voice tight, "that certainly escalated."

Catra didn't answer. She was already dragging herself toward the door. Each step scraped something raw inside her. The leg barely held.

She closed the cell door behind her.

Silence.

She made it halfway down the corridor before her leg gave out. She caught herself on the wall, slid until she hit a stone bench. It felt like the first welcome thing she'd touched in hours.

Metal clanged behind her. Double Trouble rattled the bars. "You—you absolute *idiot*—"

Catra let out a breathless laugh.

"—you worthless traitor!" they shouted. "You've doomed us both—"

"Double Trouble," Catra said, not looking back. "You locked me in a room with him. You think insults and threats are going to hurt?"

"Let me out!"

"I tried that at some point."

They hesitated. "I'll give you anything you want."

"I tried that too." Her voice had gone quiet, almost conversational. "Turns out I'm not that original after all. Guess we all beg to live the same way."

She opened her eyes. “Want me to tell you what you’ll do when I slide the knife into your gut?”

They took a step back. “You wouldn’t.”

“You’re right,” Catra said. “I'm too tired.” She smiled, faint, crooked. “But I like the thought.”

Double Trouble straightened, trying to find the mask again. “You’re finished, darling. Once you crawl out of here—if you even make it that far—your little alliance is gone. Seaspray’s a mass grave by now. They’ll turn on you.”

“Yes,” Catra said, voice thin but steady. “I missed my meeting.”

The torch flickered. For a moment her vision swam.

“There was someone I was supposed to meet,” she murmured. “She’s got rules. Honour. Mercy. The kind of things that slow her down. I think she was trying to make me better.” Her eyes lifted, unfocused but sharp enough. “She’s not here right now. Lucky you.”

Double Trouble forced a grin. “There’s nothing you can do to me.”

“Isn’t there?” Catra’s tone didn’t rise. “What do you think Prime’s going to say when he finds his pet commander dead and me gone? You think he’ll buy your performance?”

That wiped the grin off. Just for a second.

Catra tilted her head. “Do you think he’ll hurt you?”

The silence held. The torch hissed again.

Then Double Trouble spoke, too quietly this time: “You wouldn’t make it out the front gate.”

Catra leaned her head back against the wall, eyes half-closed. “Maybe not,” she said. “But I’ll make sure you don’t either.”

Double Trouble's hands stayed tight, knuckles pale, like they were still gripping the bars.

"I didn't help you escape," they said. The voice was flat, defensive, too quick.

Catra's head tilted slightly. "Didn't you? Huh. I have a head injury so I must have misremembered… No, no, I'm sure you helped me."

"You want to know what I've worked out?" Catra said. "Prime gave the order—if you caught me, you were to hand me over to Hordak. Which was stupid, but not out of character. Maybe he was indulging his favourite monster. Or maybe he just didn't want to deal with me himself."

She shifted her weight. "You went along with it. Maybe you thought it would please him. Maybe you just didn't care. But what you *didn't* want was your name on the record when the heir turned up tortured to death in some forgotten cell."

Double Trouble's lips twitched. "You give yourself a lot of titles for someone bleeding out on the order of the one you're supposedly successor to."

Catra smiled faintly. "Just the one."

She went on:

"You didn't tell anyone where I was. You didn't bring guards. You used your own key. You didn't want witnesses. You thought you were keeping your options open."

Their breath hitched just once.

She pressed the words in, slow, the way she'd seen Hordak press a knife. "No one knows I'm here. Which means no one knows *you're* here either. No one's coming. No one's looking. No one's going to open that door."

The quiet stretched.

She could see it in their face—the tension around the mouth, the eyes too wide.

“Catra,” they said, finally. The tone was different. The mask of indifference had slipped. “What do you want?”

Catra’s eyes drifted to the floor of the cell.

The knife still lay there, smeared with her blood. Beside it, Hordak’s body. He was breathing but he wasn’t waking.

She looked back at Double Trouble. “You see that?” Her voice was quiet, rough from strain. “That’s the only weapon in this room. And it’s on your side of the bars.”

“Pick it up,” Catra said. “Wake him up.”

Double Trouble’s mouth pulled into a nervous smile. “You want me to *what*?”

“Wake. Him. Up.” Her tone didn’t rise.

They looked down at Hordak, then back at her. “My hands aren’t built for that sort of thing,” they said lightly. “They’re more for… showmanship. Applause. The occasional knife toss, yes, but not—”

Catra turned her head toward the stairway at the far end of the corridor. The light there was faint, uneven. She studied it, as if calculating how far she’d get before her leg gave out.

“Maybe I should try my luck up there,” she said softly. “If someone finds me, they’ll kill me fast. But then they’ll never find *you* down here. Locked in with a corpse. I wonder what alien clones taste like. I'm sure desperation will mean you won't care. Fair warning—he does no bathe.”

Double Trouble went still. Then, with a sigh they crouched.

“Fine. Fine.” They reached for the knife, pinching it between two fingers like it was a dead rat. The metal was tacky with half-dried blood. “Honestly, the things I do to survive.”

They nudged Hordak’s leg with the tip of their boot. Nothing. They glanced up at Catra.

Catra just raised an eyebrow.

Double Trouble grimaced, kicked him harder. Still nothing.

“I don’t think he’s in a talking mood,” they muttered.

Catra leaned her head against the wall, voice flat. “I don’t care. Just start stabbing.”

Double Trouble’s expression flickered—somewhere between disgust and disbelief. “You’re really serious?”

Catra smiled faintly, the expression slow and tired. “I'm so serious, you have no fucking clue how serious I am.”

For a second, neither moved. Then Double Trouble knelt again, knife in hand.

“Slowly,” Catra said.

They swallowed, then slide the knife into Hordak’s side.

He twitched. A small sound left his throat.

Double Trouble exhaled. “You're going to get me killed.” they said.

Catra didn’t answer. She was already thinking about what came next.

A slow, guttural sound came from somewhere deep in Hordak’s chest as Double Trouble drew back and stabbed again. It gurgled slightly—a lung perhaps.

Double Trouble froze. “Oh, stars—”

Catra didn’t look up. “Keep going.”

They stabbed again, less cautiously this time. Hordak’s eyes snapped open. His arm came up fast, swinging wild. It caught Double Trouble across the side of the face and sent them sprawling.

For a few seconds, the cell filled with the sound of struggle: grunts, scraping boots, metal clanging against stone. Hordak lunged, but his balance was gone. The blow to the head had ruined his aim. He staggered; Double Trouble ducked, then struck again, pure instinct. The knife found the base of his neck, once, then again, until he stopped moving.

Double Trouble backed away, gasping, knife still in both hands. Their sleeves were spattered dark, eyes fixed on Hordak’s body like it might rise again.

Catra watched from the bench. Her expression was almost thoughtful. “That,” she said, “was nowhere near slow enough.”

Double Trouble turned on her, voice cracking. “You told me to—”

“I said slow,” Catra cut in. “You rushed the ending.”

She pushed herself upright, bracing on the wall, and started limping toward the stairs.

“Wait,” Double Trouble said.

Catra didn’t.

“Catra—wait!”

She turned halfway, just enough to look over her shoulder. “You’ve got five seconds.”

They swallowed, words tumbling out fast. “I can fix this. I can tell the Etherians the truth. What really happened. What I did for Prime.”

Catra's face didn't change. "You think that's worth something to me?"

"I mean about—about Bright Moon! About how I killed Angella, and Adora—"

She cut them off with a small wave of her hand. "I know. Mara's Adora. I told her everything. Everything you did for Prime."

Double Trouble went still. "You—told her."

"Mm." Catra turned back toward the stairs. "Didn't even have to embellish. It was already such a good story."

"Wait!"

She stopped again, one hand on the railing, shoulders tightening.

She waited.

Double Trouble was still holding the knife, their hands shaking just enough for it to rattle against the bars. "I hate Prime just as much as you do," they said.

Catra's laugh came out like a single breath. "I seriously doubt that."

They gave a small, humourless smile. "Oh, of course. No one could possibly suffer like you, hmm? Is that what this is about? Being Prime's favourite broken thing?"

Catra didn't answer.

Double Trouble's tone shifted. "Is that why you killed Entrapta? So you could keep the title of most fucked up?"

Catra's jaw clenched.

"Or was that just another move on the board?" they went on. "Kyle too—his death fit nicely, didn't it?"

Catra’s throat worked once. She stayed still. Didn’t deny it. Didn’t say *I tried to save him*. Didn’t say *I didn’t kill her.*

She didn’t have to. They both knew the truth: she was the reason either of them had died, one way or another.

Double Trouble studied her face, waiting for a break that didn’t come.

“You really don’t want to talk about them,” they said softly. “That’s fine. We’ll talk about me instead.”

Catra looked up, slow, cold. “You’re always dying to.”

Their smile returned, faint, tired at the edges. “You know, in between you and Entrapta—all Prime’s little toys, his favourites of the week—who do you think filled the gap? Who kept him entertained while he decided which one of you to ruin next?”

Catra’s eyes narrowed.

Double Trouble tilted their head. “Who else but the one person who can be anyone, at any age?”

Chapter End Notes

This chapter has not yet been beta-read

Chapter 3: Catra

Chapter Notes

> Wrote this chapter while listening to "I Want to Live" by Borislav Slavov.
>
> TW: mild-ish presence of a corpse, injuries being treated.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“What else do you want from me?”

Catra didn’t answer. She’d lost track of time—minutes, hours, or maybe her sense of it had just burned out. Her mind kept circling the same problem, again and again.

The stairs.

The stairs would kill her.

Her shoulder was wrecked, her stomach split open, and her leg wasn’t far from collapse. She’d have to climb anyway.

Double Trouble was still talking, but her thoughts were fixed on what waited above. The fort. The citizens. Whoever was left loyal to Prime.

She’d have to walk out there like she owned the place. Like nothing had touched her. The Princess of the Horde, untouchable. If anyone saw weakness, it would be over before she reached the first corridor.

She needed to be seen alive. She needed the story ready—the one she’d already started to build: Double Trouble turned on Hordak, killed him, helped her escape. A neat lie, easy to spread.

She couldn’t let them out yet. Not until it all looked convincing.

Catra had to get up.

Had to go up.

Had to finish the scene.

Everything hurt.

She didn't realize she'd let her eyes close until the sound of metal clanging dragged her back.

"Let me out!" Double Trouble shouted, shaking the bars. "Let me out, let me out, LET ME OUT!"

Catra blinked, dizzy. She was halfway up the stairs, slumped against the rail. The iron was warmed under her palm. Clearly she had been there a while.

"Let me out!" They were screaming now, voice splintering. "You miserable, spoiled, ungrateful traitor! You're not half the woman your mother was!"

Catra let out a short, ragged laugh. "No argument here."

Her leg held, barely. The wrong shoulder brushed the wall, and pain flashed through her like lightning. She gritted her teeth and straightened.

"What are you doing?" Double Trouble demanded. "I'll help you! Isn't my word enough? Damn it, let me out!"

"I'm just—" she drew a breath, steadying herself, "—going for a walk." Another breath. "To clear my head." A faint grin twisted her mouth. "You know, as one does. Maybe I'll look at the gardens. Get some paper for that confession you promised."

Her shoulder left a smear of blood on the wall. Three steps later she had to stop again.

"You let yourself be fucked by Etheria!" Double Trouble screamed after her.

Catra didn’t even look back. “The *entire* planet?” she said. “No wonder I’m so tired. You lot should pick an insult and commit to it —either I’m too cold or too desperate. Can’t be both.”

Their voice cracked into something close to a sob, echoing off the stone. She kept climbing.

The air grew colder the higher she went. The torches flickered, or maybe her vision did. Every few steps she had to brace herself against the wall.

When she reached the top, the door looked absurdly normal— solid, metal, heavy hinges. Too clean for what was beneath it.

There was a key on a hook beside it. She stared at it for a moment before reaching up. Her hand left blood on the wall.

It fit the lock perfectly. The mechanism turned with a quiet click.

The door opened smooth and silent, like it had been waiting patiently for her.

Catra stood in the doorway, one hand still on the key, breathing hard.

Behind her, Double Trouble’s voice rose again.

Catra didn’t look back.

She stepped through.

There was a lip at the threshold. Catra caught her boot on it and nearly tripped. Someone hauling bodies out of here would curse that step every time. She wondered if Double Trouble ever considered practicalities like that. Probably not.

She pushed through the door—

and walked into a pantry.

Rows of shelves lined the walls, all neatly stocked with jars and tins. The smell of dried herbs and grain dust filled her nose.

For a second, Catra thought she must've cracked her skull open halfway through the stairs. Maybe she was bleeding out somewhere below, and this was what dying looked like—a neat little cupboard full of other people's food.

She was starving. That seemed unfair, even for the hells.

She took a few steps forward, slow, testing her balance. Her hand brushed a shelf. Everything hurt in distant waves.

The next door opened into a wide kitchen. Warm light. White tile. A woman stood at the counter, sleeves rolled up, mint-green hair tied back, pink apron dusted with flour. She was humming.

Catra stopped in the doorway, half expecting her vision to tilt again.

The woman turned—and froze. The bowl she was holding hit the counter with a soft *thunk*.

Then, quick as instinct, she dropped to her knees, bowing low until her forehead almost touched the floor.

Catra stared. Then laughed. It came out like a cough.

"Your Highness," the woman said, her voice calm and smooth. "What an unexpected… entrance."

"Yeah," Catra said. "Quite the dramatic reveal. Don't mind me." She limped to the nearest seat, a small padded chair in the corner, and fell into it. Blood spread across the fabric, dark and ugly.

Her fingers found her shoulder again. Sticky. Warm. Still bleeding.

The baker looked up without rising. "Have we been invaded, then?"

“Yes,” Catra said. “How do you think I’m doing?”

The woman tilted her head, studying her face. “Oh gosh, what has Double Trouble done now?”

That voice—patient, disapproving, almost kind—was harder to bear than she thought. It was motherly. It made Catra feel twelve again, caught somewhere she wasn’t supposed to be.

She tried for a smile. “What *haven’t* they done?” she said. “What was our version again? The official one…”

She took a slow breath. “Ah, right. Double Trouble—hero of the hour. Brave, loyal, saved me from the evil Hordak. Pledged their devotion to the rightful Princess of the Horde. Everyone wept or clapped or something. It was beautiful. Truly moving.”

The baker’s mouth twitched. “More likely they set the trap, and you were unlucky enough to step into it.”

Catra snorted softly. “Unlucky’s one word.”

The baker’s tone stayed even. “I’ve never been in their confidence, but I have come to know how they think. They’re a simple creature, underneath the façade. I learned that when I came here from Dryl. Too late to leave by then.”

Her eyes met Catra’s. “Are they dead?”

Catra leaned back, eyelids heavy. “Do you want them to be?”

The baker was quiet for a long time.

The question had come out wrong.

Catra grimaced. She was slipping; that was all. She wasn’t thinking straight.

Baker was from Dryl. That meant she’d served under Entrapta once—back when Entrapta had been a Princess, not a casualty.

Catra tried to make a joke of it. “So you traded one genius for another, huh?”

Baker didn’t react. Not even a twitch.

Catra sighed, or maybe it was just her breathing catching. She shouldn’t have moved her head. The world blurred, edges greying, the walls bending slightly at the corners.

Baker spoke again.

“A pity,” she said. “Still, Double Trouble never did seem to think that far ahead.”

Her eyes tracked Catra, unreadable. “What did they give you?”

Catra tried to sit up straighter, tried to make it look controlled. Always controlled. That was her armour. Even now.

She braced one elbow on the counter, aiming for lazy arrogance. It slipped. Her weight followed.

Something clattered—spoons, a knife, the edge of a pan? Then her shoulder hit the bench.

The floor came next.

The sound left her throat before she could stop it, small and rough.

When her eyes opened again, she wasn’t sure how long it had been. The light was dimmer. Baker stood above her, calm as before.

That couldn’t be right.

Catra blinked, trying to make sense of the shape of the world. Her shoulder screamed; her stomach rolled. Her thoughts turned sideways, slipping toward something warm and painful.

Adora.

Where had she gone?

She wanted her there, just for a moment—to lean against, to hear her voice, to make sense of the air again.

Baker was speaking, but Catra couldn't make out the words. The sound came through like static, distant and underwater.

She remembered, though. The question.

"What did they give you?"

Catra's mouth moved before her brain caught up. "All of you," she said thickly. Her voice didn't really sound like hers.

The room kept sliding in and out of focus. She closed her eyes to stop it from spinning.

Something in her was shouting to stay awake—to keep the mask up, to not let anyone see her like this—but it was far away, muffled by exhaustion.

She managed one more breath, barely a whisper. "Hell's Rest," she said. "Double Trouble gave me everything."

Then the sound of her breathing filled her ears, and nothing else.

✧

The physicians of Hell's Rest were an insult to the word.

She had to swallow blood before she could speak, but her voice still carried. "Send for my medic."

Her own medic arrived later that day. The fort's own doctors were gone, muttering curses and excuses all the way out. They hadn't improved her condition, but they hadn't killed her either—that, she supposed, was something.

When her head cleared enough to take in the room, she realized she wasn't in the dungeon anymore.

Stone walls. Thin light. A real bed, though soaked through with the smell of spirits and blood.

Across the room, Baker sat on a straight-backed chair, hands folded neatly, eyes steady on Catra.

The sound of boots echoed from the corridor outside—her soldiers bringing in another stretcher.

The body was small. Wrapped. Carefully carried.

Entrapta.

Catra's throat tightened. She didn't say anything.

That was how she knew she was safe again—the dead always found her first.

Baker didn't rise, didn't flinch. When Catra's eyes met hers, she began speaking as if continuing a conversation that had started long before.

She told her everything.

How she'd gone down to the cells while Catra was still bleeding out. How Double Trouble had screamed themselves hoarse, certain she'd come to release them. How she'd listened without interruption until the confession spilled out.

Then she'd gone upstairs, washed her hands, and taken command as the servant with the most seniority.

In under an hour, Catra's red and black Horde banners were flying again. The gates were open to Etherian troops.

And Double Trouble's confession was copied, stamped, and signed three times.

Catra let her speak.

Baker was so calm could have been merely reciting a recipe.

When she finished, she stood and smoothed her apron. “I hope I haven’t overstepped, your highness.”

No hesitation, no apology. Only a statement of fact—and a quiet readiness to take orders if they came.

Catra waited until her clone medic finished the last of his stitching of her stomach, then dismissed him.

The other physicians and servants followed, shuffling out with quick, frightened bows.

Two guards remained at the door, posted far enough not to hear.

The room settled into silence.

For a long time, neither woman spoke.

Then Baker’s gaze began to drift—first toward the wall, then down to the bed beside her.

The shroud lay smooth and still. She lifted one hand, touched the fabric at the curve of the face beneath. Her fingers hesitated there, as though expecting to feel breath.

When she spoke, her voice was low, stripped of its composure.

“I know she betrayed you,” she said.

Catra’s reply came quietly. “She was betrayed first.”

Baker’s head turned. Her eyes were darker than before.

“Double Trouble,” Catra went on, “sold her to Prime. It was only a matter of time before she died, even if not by her own hand.”

Baker’s fingers tightened against the cloth. Her back curved in slightly, shoulders pulling forward like something was folding in on itself.

Catra studied her, the faint tremor in the woman’s hands, the effort she made to still them again.

“I don’t imagine you helped me out of loyalty,” Catra said.

Baker drew in a slow breath. Her composure clicked back into place, spine straightening, chin lifted.

“No,” she said. “Loyalty’s a word men use when they mean fear. I don’t fear you.”

“A maid brought word from Talon Mountain this morning,” Baker said. Her voice was steady, at first. “I hadn’t told Double Trouble. I didn’t—”

Her throat closed. The rest came out broken. “They did this. They killed my Princess.”

The words seemed to cost her something. She pressed a hand against her mouth, then shook her head sharply, trying to smother the sound that escaped. “I couldn’t tell them,” she said. “I couldn’t stand to watch them pretend to mourn her. Not after what they’d done. Not after they traded her for a title. As if they deserved to grieve.”

Catra watched her for a moment, unreadable. Then she said quietly, “I hope I live long enough to earn loyalty from you. You seem fairly competent.”

Baker didn’t respond.

Catra stood. Her movements were slow, deliberate; the floor creaked once under her boots.

“By law,” she said, voice flat, formal, “a traitor’s body is to be divided and sent to the corners of the Fright Zone. So that the

soul never finds its way home."

"I am aware," Baker said, her eyes fixed on the floor.

Catra's gaze drifted to the shrouded shape on the next bed. "Then you'll understand," she said, "why I look forward to the day I see Prime's body carried out on dozens of skiffs. Not his victims. Never them."

Baker said nothing.

"My medic prepared her for burial," Catra went on. "But if you want to see to the rites yourself, do it. Dryl's customs aren't the same as Weave's Slope."

Baker's head lifted slowly. "You're… giving her to me?"

Catra blinked once, tired. "Did you think I had her brought here to gloat?"

"No," Baker said quickly, almost ashamed. Then quieter: "Thank you."

Catra inclined her head slightly. "Allies have the right to their dead."

She turned toward the door, bracing her hand against the frame as she passed. "My physician will see me in another room," she said, tone clipped again. "The sight of tears unsettles me."

✧

Catra sat by the window, her arm bare, her uniform half-undone.

Outside, the camp was rising—rows of red tents flaring against the rock like open wounds.

The medic worked in silence until he said, "I'm afraid I'll have to reset your shoulder again, your highness."

“Of course you will,” Catra muttered. “Go on.”

He hesitated. She didn’t. “Get on with it.”

The crack came quick. She hissed through her teeth, but it wasn’t enough. The pain didn’t match what she deserved.

Through the window, she could see the main tent—the biggest, the one trimmed in black. It had been Shadow Weaver’s once. The thought made her stomach twist.

She’d ordered the strongest coffee they could brew, a pot big enough for an army. She needed the heat, the bitterness. Something to burn through the fog.

Her mind was working again, and that was the problem.

She’d gone on that scouting run herself—reckless and stupid. Shadow Weaver wouldn’t have done that. Shadow Weaver had always let others do it for her. Catra had learned from the best and still managed to make stupid mistakes.

She had to face it now, all of it. No lies, no excuses.

She’d missed the rendezvous.

Adora was at Seaspray.

Catra had sent her there—with the Etherians, against Prime’s army—to fight a battle that should’ve been hers.

And she hadn’t been there.

She could still hear Adora’s voice: *Seaspray’s a trap. If you approach it wrong, you’ll lose everyone.*

She’d sent her anyway.

Now Adora was out there in the middle of it—brave, stupid Adora—the girl who’d survived every cruelty Catra could invent. The girl

who'd looked at her like she wasn't a monster, who'd kissed her like the world could still be saved.

Catra shut her eyes as the camp blurred.

The medic pulled her shoulder into place again; the sound was wet, ugly. She stifled the noise that rose in her throat. It hurt, but still not enough.

"Apologies, your highness," he murmured.

"Don't talk to me," she said thickly.

She didn't notice the tears until he handed her a handkerchief. She wiped them away hard, as if she could scrub them off her skin.

"Bind it tight," she said. "I've got work to do. I don't want to feel it."

He nodded. She didn't look at him again.

Adora would see her for what she was—a coward, a liar, the Princess of both. She'd think Catra had used her, had sent her into a slaughter just to keep her own hands clean.

And she'd be right.

Fine. Let her hate her. That, at least, was honest.

He cleared his throat. "I need to take out these stitches first," he said. "They've been botched. It will scar terribly."

Catra's mouth twisted. "Good. Maybe it'll match the rest of me. Stop talking and get on with it."

She turned back to the window.

She still needed Adora.

Still needed the Etherians.

If Adora wouldn’t stand beside her out of love, she’d do it out of necessity. Catra would make it happen. She’d force the alliance, bind it in duty and blood if she had to.

It would hurt—more than this, more than any wound. But pain had never stopped her before.

She’d always known happiness was temporary.

This, of course, was all presuming that Adora was still alive.

Chapter End Notes

> As my friend has been hospitalised again, I am reminded that not everyone can put their dislocated shoulder back into place by themselves.
>
> Honestly, skill issue.
>
> Anyway, this chapter has not yet been beta read. I am usually a couple chapters ahead of what I post and post previews to my patreon for free, [cjowoart].

Chapter 4: Adora

Chapter Notes

TW: war and killing

Also thank you to my beta reader nbc22 ❤️

For this chapter I listened to "Break My Heart" by Hey Violet

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora stilled on a rise of ground that barely deserved to be called a hill. The air was choked with smoke, the horizon gone to a grey blur where fire met fog.

Below her, the field was no longer a field—just churned earth and shattered machines. Prime's army moved across it like something alive, endless, white against the dirt, breaking apart and reforming wherever they met resistance.

It looked like the world itself was falling to pieces.

She'd stopped trying to see it all at once a while ago. She didn't need to. She simply saw what was directly in front of her—where to parry, where to drive the sword next.

"*Mage-slayer*!" they shouted.

As if the name would slow her down.

The first ranks had rushed her. But when they saw how quickly clones before them died, the rest faltered—a wave breaking and sucking back on itself. Those who turned to run only made better targets.

Her sword cut through armour, through alien flesh. The sound was duller than she remembered it being. Every impact jarred her arm up to the shoulder. She kept going. She didn't think about the faces. They all had the same one anyway.

A clone commander came at her, roaring, blade lifted high. Adora turned, parried, split his helm, and moved on.

That was all it was now: movement, reaction and breaths where she could steal them.

The same rhythm, over and over—kill, turn, kill again.

She didn't count how many fell. She only knew the amount that remained: far too many.

Half of Mermista's troops were gone in the first surge. The second wave almost broke them completely. Adora drove into the thick of it, blade flashing in broad, heavy arcs that threw back the front lines long enough for the survivors to regroup.

They would have wiped out Prime's forces if they had the means to push then—if she'd had just one more battalion. But she didn't.

The absence gnawed at her.

Somewhere behind her, Mermista was shouting orders, voice hoarse and low, cutting through the noise. When Adora glanced back once, she saw her—dark hair matted, trident raised, her waves crashing into bodies violently.

"If the Horde's Princess shows her face," Mermista said between her teeth, "I'll put my trident through her myself."

Adora didn't answer. There wasn't time to think or speak. And what would she even say?

The bullets slowed. Not because mercy had entered the field, but because there was no clean line to shoot into. Everything had

collapsed into chaos—Etherians and clones tangled together, fighting hand to hand, stepping or driving over the fallen.

The ground was slick. Mud shouldn't have been possible in this unforgiving heat, but there it was, dark and thick, stinking of salt and metal. Blood mixed with Mermista's water magic, spreading in sluggish rivulets.

Her skiff jolted and stopped. The bodies were too thick to drive through. Adora swung down into the mud, her boots sinking ankle-deep, and kept moving. Every step was a fight.

Hours passed, though it glashed past like it had been minutes. The sky hadn't changed—still threatening a downpour.

Then—movement. A flash of white beyond the smoke.

Still, tall, untouched.

Prime.

Why fight an entire army when you can take its head? Etherian way, right? Catra had said.

Cut off command, and the body collapses. Do it cleanly.

She didn't hesitate. She pushed forward, cutting through anyone in her way. Her sword was heavy now, dragging her shoulder with every swing. Still she carved a bloody path.

When she reached him, she didn't waste breath on words. She struck.

The blade came down in one clean arc—metal meeting metal, then bone. The helmet split. The body dropped like a marionette with its strings cut.

For a second, the whole world went quiet.

Adora stepped closer, wrenched off the helm—

—and stared down into another identical face. Blank. Empty.

Not Prime.

Just another puppet.

Her jaw locked. She threw the helm away; it hit the ground with a wet crack and rolled.

Mermista's voice came from somewhere behind her.

"It's over," she said. "It's over, Dora."

Adora lifted her head, her ears ringing.

The air was hot and sour, thick with the stink of iron and burned fuel.

Mermista was standing a few paces away, unsteady, her armour split open across the chest where a blade had found her. Blood streaked down through the gaps in the plate. Her trident hung loose at her side.

"Dora," she said—the old name, one that belonged to another lifetime, a childhood memory that scraped raw against the present.

Adora blinked up at her and realised she was on her knees. Her hand was still clenched in the grey and white cloth of the fallen clone's uniform, fingers twisted around the Horde insignia like it might still hold shape.

It didn't. It just felt like dust in her hands.

"Over?" The word came out rough, unfamiliar. She had to force it through her teeth.

She looked around—the broken field, the heaps of the dead, the churned mud—and for a second she couldn't tell who had won. "If

Prime’s still breathing somewhere,” she said, “then none of this means anything.”

Mermista’s voice was quieter now, but it didn’t shake. “It’s ours,” she said.

Victory.

Adora looked at her. There was something new in Mermista’s eyes—relief.

And then Adora saw it—saw all of it.

The field stretched out before her, torn apart. The ground was a patchwork of ash and bodies, armour half-sunk in the mud, weapons scattered and broken. The air shimmered with heat and smoke. Her mind started to catch up to what her body had been doing for hours—the weight of it, the impossible number of lives she’d cut through.

The faces came in flashes when she blinked. The same face, again and again, staring back at her as she killed it.

She didn’t let herself look down for long.

Beside her lay an Etherian banner—trampled, half-buried. The sight of it made something old and mechanical in her move again. She picked it up, wiped the blood from her hand against her white dress, and drove the pole into the earth.

The cloth hung heavy, torn, dragging in the muck, but it stayed upright.

“Seaspray,” she said, almost to herself. “It’s ours again.”

The words didn’t sound like victory.

Then, through the haze, movement—a figure driving fast from the west, cutting clean through the wreckage.

Adora squinted.

The skiff was immaculate. No dents. No mud. Its engine purred instead of rattled from overexertion. The banner that streamed from its mast was red and black—the Horde sigil, Catra's colours.

It made her stomach twist.

The rider pulled up hard, stopping just short of the wreckage. His armour gleamed, the emblem on his chest polished bright.

Adora's vision went narrow.

"Where is she?"

She was already moving. The words came out like a growl as she caught the herald by the front of his armour and tore him from the skiff. He hit the ground hard, breath knocked out of him, the air leaving his lungs in a wheeze. Adora's knee pressed into his ribs, her hand closing around his throat before he could speak.

Around them, Etherian soldiers froze, spears and tridents half-raised, arrows drawn. No one moved.

Adora leaned closer. "Where is she?"

The man made a choking sound, eyes wide, fingers scrabbling against the ground.

Adora's hand loosened, just enough for him to drag in a breath. He coughed, rolled weakly onto his side, and reached into his coat. Her soldiers tensed; one of them shouted a warning, but Adora didn't stop him.

He pulled out a small, creased piece of parchment and held it up.

Two lines.

You have Seaspray and I have Hell's Rest.

Below, a second line, written with that same sharp, impatient hand Adora knew too well:

I'll receive you at my new fort.

The wind caught the edge of the paper, fluttering it between her fingers.

She read it again. Then again, the words slowly penetrating her brain like a blade turned inward.

Catra.

She was alive.

And she'd already made the next move.

✧

Hell's Rest loomed out of the haze like it had been carved straight from the bones of the mountain.

It wasn't a fort—it was a monument. High towers, razor-edged walls, black stone polished to an almost mirrored shine. The banners at its heights were red and black, hundreds of them, catching the wind like they belonged to it.

Catra's colours. Everywhere.

Adora slowed her skiff at the ridge, the machine hissing and rattling beneath her. Behind her, the Etherian army—what was left of it—spread in a jagged line. Tridents drooping, banners torn, soldiers hollow-eyed from lack of rest.

She had ordered them to march less than an hour after the battle at Seaspray. It hadn't been fair.

Out of the three thousand who had fought, just over half still moved under their own power. The rest stayed behind until clean-up was finished—their armour piled neatly beside their bodies,

their weapons stuck upright in the dirt as impromptu grave markers.

Lonnie and a handful of Catra's Horde soldiers rode closer, unsure where to look or what to say.

The numbers came to her hours earlier: twelve hundred Etherians dead. Six thousand clones. It should have sounded like victory.

It still didn’t.

Since the end of the battle, the soldiers had started to keep their distance—not out of ceremony, but instinct. When Adora walked past, they gave her space. They didn’t talk. They stared. Some looked at her like she was something godlike.

Others, like she was something out of a nightmare.

She could feel it pressing in on her now, all that silence at her back.

Hell’s Rest glimmered under the midday sun. Rows of scarlet tents rippled at its base—too neat, too perfect, like a festival. Each one new, untouched, bearing soldiers in polished armour gleaming in the light.

Catra’s army. Rested. Ready.

Untouched by the slaughter at Seaspray.

It was a performance—every red pennant, every unsoiled tent. A stage dressing for her arrival.

The message couldn’t have been clearer: *While you were breaking yourself to win, I was here, waiting for you to come crawling back.*

Mermista pulled up beside her. Her armour was cracked down the middle; dried blood marked her throat and chin.

She squinted at the view and said, flatly, “Prime and Catra are basically the same. They both sit back and watch while everyone else does all the hard work.”

Adora didn’t answer right away. Her jaw worked once. She stared at the fortress until the sunlight off the banners made her eyes ache.

“She fought with me once,” she said quietly. “She didn’t send others.”

“Yeah, well,” said Mermista, “people change.”

Her voice was stripped of any sympathy.

Adora’s hand tightened on the grip of the skiff. Her knuckles went white. “She’s not him.”

Mermista gave a humourless little snort. “You keep telling yourself that.”

Adora looked at the fortress again. Inside, she could almost feel Catra waiting.

“I’m not telling myself anything,” Adora said.

They waited in silence for a while.

Then Adora’s gaze caught movement—a handful of riders coming from the camp, sunlight flashing off polished helmets. The lead rider carried another banner in Catra’s colours.

Adora reached for the white and grey banner still tied to her skiff—Prime’s colours, stiff with dried blood—and tore it free.

“Just me,” she said, and gunned the engine.

“Adora, wait—”

“Stay with the line.”

She was already gone, wind snapping at her bloodied white cloak, the skiff kicking up a storm of dirt behind her.

The heralds met her halfway across the plain, five of them, faces pale and perfect as if they'd never seen a battle. The lead one started to recite something—an introduction, a formal greeting—before Adora cut the engine and swung herself off the skiff.

"Move," Adora interrupted, "she's expecting me."

The herald shut his mouth.

Inside the camp, the silence felt wrong. Soldiers watched her from the corners of their eyes, uncertain, curious. No one stopped her, no one spoke.

At the camp's centre stood the largest tent, silk layered in red and black, its edges embroidered with sharp gold thread. She recognised the pattern.

Adora stopped in front of it. The guard at the entrance shifted her spear uncertainly.

"Go," Adora said.

The soldier stepped aside.

Adora didn't wait for permission. She pushed the flap open herself.

Inside, the air was still and perfumed, like it was pretending to be a garden. The ceiling rose high above her, silk panels stretched between six black poles wrapped in ribbon. Cushions lay in neat piles around a low table set with silver dishes—sugared fruit, bright oranges, figs split open like wounds.

The tent was beautiful, and utterly false.

She let the flap fall behind her, and the noise of the camp faded to a faint hum. For a moment, there was only her breathing, the

quiet rasp of it catching in her chest.

Adora crossed the tent once, slowly, eyes tracing everything. The rugs. The fruit. The wine. All the luxuries of someone who hadn't fought a war.

Adora's gaze followed the sound before her eyes adjusted to the low red light of the tent.

Catra was there—half in shadow, one shoulder propped against a silk-wrapped pole, her posture lazy in that deliberate way she liked to present herself.

"Hey, Adora."

The tone was light, almost bored. It landed like a blade point pressed against the skin.

So. She already knew. Someone had already told her by now.

Adora's throat felt tight. She made herself move anyway, crossing the rugs one heavy step at a time. The mud from her boots left dull brown marks across the floorcloths.

She didn't bother apologising.

Prime's banner hung over her shoulder, stiff with blood. She dragged it off and dropped it onto the low table in front of Catra. The pole struck wood with a flat, ugly sound.

The silk folded in on itself, wet and red.

Adora straightened. "Seaspray is won."

Catra didn't blink. "I thought it would be."

Adora’s jaw tightened. She forced herself to breathe through it. “Your own soldiers think you hid here while we died for you,” she said. “Mermista says you sent us into a slaughter and never planned to come—that you tricked us all along.”

Catra tilted her head, the corner of her mouth twitching—not quite a smile. “And what about you?”

“No,” Adora said. “I know you better than that.”

“Do you?”

Adora’s eyes tracked the set of Catra’s stance. The right side of her coat hung stiffly, like she was guarding it. The fingers of her left hand stayed hooked around the silk-wrapped pole.

Adora moved closer—one step, then another. Catra didn’t flinch, didn’t move at all.

When Adora reached her, she laid a hand on Catra’s right shoulder.

Nothing.

She pressed harder. Her thumb dug into the muscle beneath the coat, searching, waiting. Catra’s breath hitched, almost imperceptibly.

“Stop,” Catra said, voice low.

Adora’s grip loosened. She stepped back.

Catra turned away from her, clutching her shoulder where a dark stain had spread through the fabric. Blood.

They stared at each other.

“You wouldn’t break an oath,” Adora said. “Not even to me.”

Catra blinked once. Then, quietly, “Even to you?”

Adora didn’t answer. She took a few steps back, needing space, needing distance to think.

Catra’s hand was still pressed to her shoulder, her fingers slick. The way she looked at Adora now wasn’t mocking.

Adora’s chest ached. She remembered the one night they’d shared —the fragile, half-panicked tenderness of it.

Outside, she could hear the camp: banners shifting, soldiers murmuring, the dull sound of metal being moved. Two armies, one heartbeat away from tearing each other apart.

It was all about to come apart around them.

And Prime was still winning.

“I came here to tell you who I am,” Adora said.

Catra’s head tilted slightly. Her pupils were thin slits now, gleaming in the light.

“I already knew,” she said.

The air inside the tent thickened. The light shifted, like the sun had drawn away. Every bright colour dulled; red turned muddy, silk turned flat. Even the sound seemed to sink into the ground.

Catra didn’t move, didn’t raise her voice.

“Did you really think,” she said, almost lazily, “I wouldn’t recognise the woman who killed my mother?”

The words landed one by one, all the more forceful in the quiet.

Adora froze. The tent tilted. Her heart stumbled once, then again.

Catra’s eyes stayed locked on hers.

“I knew,” she went on, her tone thin as wire. “On the cargo ship. When you were pretending to be someone else. I knew in the

baths, when I tore the skin from your back. I knew *exactly* what you were at—”

Adora’s throat felt raw. “At Talon Mountain?”

Catra’s tail flicked once against the floor.

“If you knew,” Adora said, her voice hoarse, “how could you—”

Catra cut across her. “Let you fuck me?”

Catra’s hand curled against the table behind her; her claws made a small scraping sound on the wood. The fur along her neck bristled, but her face stayed infuriatingly calm.

“I needed Seaspray,” she said, as if explaining strategy, not betrayal. “You gave me that. It was worth surviving your… affections.”

Adora’s mouth went dry. “You’re lying.”

Catra just looked at her.

“You’re lying,” Adora said again, louder. Her voice cracked halfway through. “You didn’t know about Seaspray until *after*. You thought I was leaving. You *told* me to go.”

Something flickered in Catra’s eyes — gone too fast to read.

“You knew,” Adora said, a little breathless. “You knew the night we —”

Catra’s chin lifted. “Say it.”

“You weren’t sleeping with a slave,” Adora said. “You were with me. You knew exactly who I was.”

Catra’s shoulders tightened, the motion small.

Adora stepped forward. “Seven years ago, when I fought Shadow Weaver—”

“Don’t.”

The word was low, bitten off, almost a growl.

“Catra—”

“Don’t *say her name!*”

Catra’s claws dug into the edge of the table; the wood gave a faint crack. Her breath came too fast, too shallow. “You killed her. You cut her down like she was nothing.”

Adora shook her head. “That isn’t—”

“Do you want me to ask how it happened?” Catra said, voice rising now, sharp and shaking. “Do you want to tell me what she looked like when your sword went through her?”

Adora’s stomach lurched. “No.”

Catra took a step forward. “Do you want me to tell *you* what it’s like to give yourself over to someone who took someone so dear to you?”

“Stop.”

Catra’s breath hitched. “Do you want me to tell you about the woman,” Her tone dropped suddenly, almost breaking. “the one who gave me good advice? Who said she’d never lie to me.”

“I *didn’t* lie to you.”

The silence that followed was jagged.

Catra’s eyes glistened, but her face stayed a mask. “*Catra, I'm still your slave,*” she said, the imitation cruel and perfect.

Adora flinched like she’d been struck.

“Don’t talk about it like that.”

“Like what?” Catra’s tail lashed once. “Like what it was?”

“Like it was calculated,” Adora said. Her voice was low, uneven, like she was forcing the words through grit. “Like I stood there and thought about it. Like it wasn’t both of us—” she hesitated, jaw tightening, “—closing our eyes and pretending we were someone else.”

Her throat ached. The next part came out quieter.

“I *was* your slave.”

The silence that followed was a living thing. Even the flap of the tent barely stirred.

For a long moment, Catra didn’t speak. When she finally did, her tone was cold.

“There was no slave,” she said. “That girl never existed. Whoever you think you are now—” she gave a small shake of her head, her hair shifting against her jacket, “—I’ve never met her before. Not until right now.”

Adora’s muscles felt locked, her lungs dragging for air. “She’s still here,” she said. “She’s me.”

Catra’s eyes narrowed. The faintest twitch at the corner of her mouth.

“Then prove it,” she said. “Kneel.” Her voice softened into something dangerous. “Kiss my boot.”

Adora didn’t move.

Catra stood with one boot braced slightly forward, her weight balanced and waiting. Her tail moved once before stilling again.

Adora’s pulse thudded behind her eyes. She could feel the dirt on her boots, the sweat on her neck, the exhaustion in her bones. But she kept her gaze steady.

She couldn’t do it.

She couldn’t kneel.

All she could do was meet Catra’s stare, her breath shallow, her hands shaking at her sides.

When she spoke, the words came out hollow and sharp. “You’re right,” she said. “I’m not your slave anymore. I’m the Queen."

"I killed your mother," she added, mouth suddenly dry. "And now I hold your fort in the Talons.”

Her hand moved. The knife came from her belt in one clean motion—a gesture she didn’t fully think through. The faint ring of metal filled the tent.

Catra’s pupils flared. Her body went sstil. Her shoulders rose just slightly, the faintest twitch under the fabric where a wound was hidden. She didn’t so much as glance at the weapon. Her eyes stayed locked on Adora’s.

Adora could feel the pressure of that look like heat against her skin.

“Now you’ll talk to me,” Adora said. “Like you would to a Queen. You’ll tell me why you called me here.”

And then she let the knife fall.

The thud of it hitting the carpeted floor broke the air between them.

Catra didn’t even glance at it. Her gaze stayed fixed on Adora’s face.

For a moment, neither of them breathed.

Then Catra spoke, quiet and almost conversational.

“Didn’t you know?”

Her mouth curled into her smallest, meanest smile.

“Horde Prime’s in Bright Moon.”

Chapter End Notes

I will get around to updating the previous chapters with the beta-read copies.

Chapter 5: Catra

Chapter Notes

Listened to Break My Heart again for this chapter, but I also Nosebleed by Sophie Powers (not in the playlist yet)

Thank you to by beta reader nbc22

“Catra, what did you do?”

Of course. It had to be Catra. It was always Catra’s fault—Catra’s invisible hand behind the disaster, Catra’s shadow in the wreckage.

Catra’s mouth curved, but there was no real smile in it. The panic had burned off, leaving the cold that she knew all too well.

“Does it hurt,” she asked, “to think about him tearing through your kingdom?”

Adora didn’t answer at first. The muscle in her jaw twitched. “You know it does,” she said, her voice rising. “You want to turn this into a game of planets and gods? It won’t bring her back.”

For a second, Catra couldn’t breathe. Adora wasn’t usually cruel—not like this. For a heartbeat, she was back on that battlefield, watching Shadow Weaver’s body fall.

“Horde Prime knew who you were,” Catra said. “He waited. He waited for us to end up in bed so he could tell me who you were. He wanted to see what it would do to me.”

She could picture it still: Prime’s pale hands folded, the patient smirk on his face. He’d known exactly how to break her—how to make even her need feel like yet another weapon turned inward.

Adora said nothing.

“What, did you already figure it out? You just decided to fuck me anyway?” She bared her teeth in something that wasn’t a smile. “Couldn’t help yourself?”

Adora’s face changed. All that tight control turned into anger and grief. She looked dangerous in her silence.

“You ordered me to your room,” Adora said at last. “You pushed me down.” Her voice trembled, but it wasn’t weak. “I said to wait.”

Catra froze. A spike had suddenly pierced her chest.

Her stomach twisted. The words dug under her armor in places nothing else ever had. The thought — *had she forced her? had she become Prime?* — was sickening.

“No,” she blurted, too quickly. “You said— you said, ‘Kiss me.’ You said, ‘I want you—’” Her voice shook. “You wanted it. You wanted *me*. Don’t you dare stand there and act like—”

She stopped herself. Her claws were digging into her palms, her breathing ragged.

She wanted to sound sure. She wanted to believe her own words. But the memory wavered—the look in Adora’s eyes that night, the way she had held her and touched her...

No. No, she wasn’t going to let herself unravel now.

Her voice turned brittle, mocking. “What was it you said as you came? ‘I won't forget,’” she mimicked in First One’s, breathless, cruel. “‘I'm yours, I'm yours—’”

“Stop.”

Adora’s tone made her flinch. The fury in it—the horror—was real.

Catra’s mouth went dry. The room tilted. The words she’d spit like venom now divided her from Adora like a wall of smoke.

The night replayed behind her eyes, jagged and wrong. She'd thought it had meant something. She'd thought it had been mutual, even if it was broken. But now— now she didn't know what she'd taken, what had been given, what had been *allowed*.

Sickness rose up in her throat. Her balance started to go. Everything in her wanted to tear something apart.

And still Adora was looking at her like someone she didn't even recognise.

How *dare* she.

How dare she stand there, judging, after everything they'd both done.

How dare she look at Catra like she wasn't worth saving anymore.

"Seaspray was a distraction," Catra said. "Double Trouble filled me in. Horde Prime's already in Bright Moon and has been for three days."

It was easier to talk politics. Strategy. Numbers.

Easier than looking at Adora. Easier than desperately reframing the sound of her voice saying '*wait*', trying to figure out whether the tone had really been meant as refusal.

Adora turned away. Her movements were sharp, restless—like she couldn't fit inside her own body. She paced the tent's edge but never crossed the space between them. That invisible line held.

Catra wanted it over. Wanted Adora gone. Wanted to stop wanting anything at all.

"I see," Adora said finally. "And my soldiers are supposed to die for you again? Like they did at Seaspray?"

My soldiers.

Catra blinked. It was a small thing—a word, a claim—but it landed like a slap. They'd trained soldiers together. Fought beside them. For months, it had been *their* army. She'd believed that without thinking, her own soldiers were still theirs.

Apparently, she'd been mistaken. Etheria's soldiers were Adora's alone.

Catra forced her mouth into a smile.

"There's a list on the table," she said. "Troops. Supplies. You'll have them. For your campaign to the west."

Adora's voice was all steel. "And what do you want in return?"

"Salineas," Catra said.

For a heartbeat, Adora just stared at her—and in that moment Catra saw the raw, unguarded shock underneath the armour. It was almost enough to make her stop. Then Adora's expression hardened, color rising in her cheeks.

"Was this the plan from the beginning?" she asked. "All of it? You and me? Seaspray?"

Catra laughed—or tried to. It came out thin, brittle. If she let the real sound out, it would tear her throat open. If she cried, Adora would see the weakness at her core. When she didn't, Adora would still see a monster. There was no right way forward.

She smiled instead.

"The hard part," she said, "was convincing Double Trouble to open their gates for me."

Adora didn't react. Not even a blink. That was worse.

Catra could feel herself slipping back into old habits—the ones that kept her alive. She'd learned long ago that if someone was going to hit you, you might as well give them a reason.

She tilted her head, voice soft, deliberate. “What’s wrong, Adora? You don’t like when someone plays you?”

“On the flagship,” Adora said, “you had me drugged. You threw me into a pit with one of Prime’s beasts. No weapon. No armour. You clawed my back open yourself.” Her eyes were cold fire now. “Then you tied me down while Double Trouble pretended to be you.”

It had been playfully mentioned before they had made lo—fucked. Catra had thought Adora to be unaffected by that time in the gardens with Double Trouble. Clearly that was just another way Catra was no better than Prime.

Adora took a step closer, low and steady. “And now you’re asking me to hand you Salineas?”

Catra didn’t move. Couldn’t.

She wanted to bare her teeth, to say something cutting—anything to reassert control.

Adora’s eyes stayed on her, full of anger. Catra could feel the weight of it pressing against her chest.

She held her smile until it hurt.

Catra didn’t answer *you murdered my mother.*

She didn’t say *you took Shadow Weaver from this world, and when the monsters came for me there was no one left to stop them.*

She didn’t say *do you want to compare pain? compare your scratches and soft little games to what Prime did to me when I was thirteen?*

She didn’t say *do you want to know what it feels like to love your enemy so much you think you’re healed—right up until she reminds you she was never really yours?*

Instead she said nothing.

She looked down at her claws as if in idle maintenance of them. They were clean, polished, too perfect. They should have been cracked, blackened with dirt, marked by all the blood she'd shed. They weren't.

"Why don't you tell me," Adora said, low and furious, "why I shouldn't hand you over to Horde Prime myself? Trade you for Etheria's safety."

Catra tilted her head, almost amused. "Because," she said evenly, "I knew who you were. When you killed Keldor, when you embarrassed Prime's fleet, I made sure the story spread through every corner of the Fright Zone. So if you ever came crawling back to your throne, there'd be no chance of peace between you and him."

It wasn't true. Not yet. But it would be, if Adora forced her hand.

She couldn't tell her the truth of her own thoughts—*you threw your sword to save me. Why would you do that for me if you were just going to hand me over to Prime in the end? I thought—*

"You want to play this game?" Catra said. "Try me. I'll tear you apart."

"Tear me apart?" Adora repeated, her tone all disbelief and scorn. "If I fought you, your tiny scrap of a kingdom would be crushed in a week. You'd have enemies on every side."

Catra remembered the way Adora would look at her—the warmth in her voice, the promise in her hands. *You were mine*, Catra had said the morning they'd parted.

I won't forget, Adora had sworn.

Now her voice was ice.

"Believe me," Catra said softly, "you'd have my full attention."

Adora’s eyes cut over her, the same way soldiers looked at prisoners—detached and disgusted. Catra could see it plain: whatever tenderness had existed between them was gone. Adora wasn’t seeing *her* anymore. She was seeing a mistake.

Maybe that was fair.

Catra told herself she didn’t care. That it was better this way.

But everything hurt.

“You’re alone,” Adora said.

It hit like a punch. Catra’s body swayed before she could stop it.

“You don’t have allies. You don’t have friends.”

You were my friend, Catra thought.

You have a friend in Etheria.

Friends? That's what this is?

Adora’s next words came quiet, final:

“You’ve proven everything Prime ever said about you.”

Catra didn’t flinch, but her hands were shaking.

She could almost hear Prime’s voice behind Adora’s.

Lazy. Weak. Unfit to rule. I don't know what I ever saw in you.

She stared at Adora, and for a moment she almost said it — *you don’t get to use his words on me.*

But she didn’t.

She just smiled.

Because even now, broken and cornered, that was the only weapon she had left.

"You made deals with Etheria," Adora said. "You even slept with an Etherian."

Her voice was rough, the words bitter from too much restraint. "By now everyone knows. You're clinging to a single fort and the scraps of a name that used to matter. So here's what's left of your alliance."

She stepped toward her, every movement radiating command. She'd never had to raise her sword against Catra—her presence alone could be the most dangerous weapon.

Catra didn't move. It wasn't pride that kept her still; it was emptiness.

She felt stripped out, scooped hollow. All of it—fear, anger, love—was there, pressing at the inside of her ribs, but none of it reached her face. She was bone-tired, past caring, and some small voice inside whispered that this was justice. That she'd earned this feeling.

A smaller, more foolish part still wished Adora wouldn't look at her like that.

"You'll give me everything on this list," Adora said, pointing to the parchment on the table. "In return, I'll fight Prime's army with you. Salineas stays under Etherian command. Don't pretend you've got anything left worth bargaining for."

She was still three paces away—close enough that Catra could feel the heat of her breath—and yet she might as well have been a world away.

Catra blinked slowly, then said, "There's something else I have that you want."

The air changed. It was subtle—a shift in pressure, the way the silence seemed to bend around them. Adora went still, and the authority in her posture shifted to something darker, heavier. It wasn't tenderness. It was hunger twisted from anger and confusion.

Catra saw it, and the realization landed like a punch.

Adora still wanted her.

Even after everything, Adora wanted her. Not forgiveness, not trust. Just her body.

How easy, Catra thought distantly, *for Etheria's golden hero to turn to appetite.*

She kept her expression neutral, because what she wanted most was to laugh. Or scream. Or both.

"Double Trouble," she said calmly, "has agreed to sign a statement detailing their role in your capture. And with Queen Angella's death, it'll give you your throne back without a fight."

Adora flushed—visibly, achingly human in that moment. Like she knew what Catra had seen—the assumption that was written across her face.

Catra stared back, unblinking. She didn't ask for an apology; she didn't expect one.

At least with Scorpia, she'd thought about sex in political terms. That had been pragmatic—honest, even. Adora's kind of sex was messier.

"Go on," Catra said at last. "Tell me again how I ruined myself by fucking you. How it cost me everything." Her voice cracked around the edge of a laugh that didn't make it out. *You were supposed to ride into Talon Mountain with Mermista. I was going to meet you at the gates. We were supposed to talk, to plan, to fix this—together.*

Her throat burned.

But you let Prime take that from us. You let him take me from you.

Adora didn't answer.

Catra looked at her and saw nothing of the woman she'd once imagined she could love—only the Queen of Etheria, only She-Ra standing tall and righteous and ready to condemn.

And she knew then that she had nothing left. No army. No cause. Not even hate to keep her warm.

Just Adora, standing in front of her, looking at her like everyone else eventually did.

Like she was something that had to be put down.

Prime had ruined everything.

Rogelio was dead. Kyle was dead. Entrapta was dead. Seaspray had been a slaughter. And Adora—Adora believed every foul thing ever said about her. The worst part was that Catra couldn't even deny it.

"As if being fucked by the Queen of Etheria was ever going to be anything but degrading," Catra said.

She could still feel Adora's hands, the warmth of them turned sour in memory. She'd believed in her too easily. Believed that Adora was different—that she was the one good thing left in the universe. It was laughable now.

Adora's jaw tightened. She said nothing.

Catra lifted her head, eyes cold. "Go on, then. Say whatever it is you came to say."

"Catra—"

“Don’t call me that.” Catra snapped. “You don’t get to say my name anymore.”

“Did you think I’d let you walk into this tent while I was unarmed?” Catra went on, forcing her voice steady. “I have the only evidence of Double Trouble’s betrayal that doesn’t rely on you.”

Adora’s tone was quiet but steady. “My word is enough for the people who matter.”

Catra laughed once—short and humorless. “Is it? Then by all means, prove it. Turn me down. Watch me burn their confession and slit Double Trouble’s throat myself.”

She moved toward the desk, her steps uneven, pain threading through her body. Her hand brushed the corner of the black-silk-covered box—the one that held what little she had left of Kyle—and she froze.

Behind her, Adora’s voice cut through the air. “Are we pretending again? That it never happened?”

Catra’s breath stuttered.

When she turned, her face was composed. “If you’re afraid I’ll forget,” she said, “don’t be. Everyone in my camp knows you served me in bed.”

Adora flinched like she’d been struck. “So that’s what it was now? A transaction?”

“How else?” Catra asked. “You thought I’d let you parade me through Bright Moon? Your own conquest of war; a Horde Princess concubine?”

I had the nerve to imagine it once. You—standing beside me. Touching me like I mattered. Like you’d chosen me, not out of guilt or pity, but because you wanted to.

“I won’t move without Mermista,” Adora said at last, tone flat. “And she won’t give up Salineas.”

Catra smiled thinly. “She will. Once you give her Bright Moon.”

The realization hit Adora in waves—confusion, then disgust, then fury again. She needed a general in Bright Moon to command their military, even after Adora was Queen again. Glimmer and Bow would have been obvious choices before, but now they were uncertain pieces. Mermista would be the most logical choice.

Catra likely wasn’t going to live long enough to take Salineas. She didn’t even want it. What she wanted was standing three paces away, looking at her like she was filth.

But she needed to seem ruthless. She needed to play the part.

So she smiled like it didn’t hurt.

So Adora would never see the wound she’d left.

Adora’s answer came slow, wound tight with hurt and something like disgust. “You planned for everything,” she said. She turned as if to walk out—leave the tent, leave Catra’s bargaining unanswered—but stopped. Her fingers went through her hair, palms coming away dark with dried blood and dust. She swung back to face Catra, breathing hard.

There was no grand fury in her eyes now, nothing theatrical. Just a broken look that pulled at whatever fragile thing remained between them.

“It didn’t have to be—” She broke off, swallowed. “You could’ve come to me,” she tried again, steadier, taut with an impossible hope. “You could have asked. I would have—”

Catra cut her off, “—and then what? You’d have killed the rest of my family?”

It had been a long time since Catra had considered Prime a father figure. He had pretended at it for such a brief period, and perhaps a child mourning their mother was the perfect victim for that particular ploy. Still, even after everything he had done, it was like a part of her yearned for that fatherly approval.

They hung in the tent and Adora's face fell apart. For a second the woman looked smaller than Catra remembered, shoulders folding inward.

"Congratulations," Adora said finally, raw and exhausted. "You've forced my hand. You get what you asked for. Salineas stays with Etheria, you get our aid to the west. Nothing is given—everything is bought or coerced. Bloodless deals, tidy on paper."

"Then say it," Catra snapped. "Agree."

Adora's jaw tightened. She looked at the list on the table, then back at Catra.

"You have my agreement," she said, flat.

"Good." Catra's answer was small. "Now go."

Adora hesitated a heartbeat, then turned and left the tent. The flap fell behind her; Catra watched the shadow of her shoulders move away and felt, for an instant, the familiar ache of something taken and unreturned.

Chapter 6: Adora

Chapter Notes

TW: slavery

Thank you again to my beta read nbc22. They are truly amazing 👏

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The clone was speaking—Adora couldn't even remember his number designation.

At first the words reached her like they had travelled through glass—distorted, distant, the sense stripped out of them. His lips moved. The world went on without waiting for her to return to it. Behind him, a small escort of her own soldiers hovered, stiff-backed and uncertain, clearly meant to accompany her back across the field.

She forced her mouth to shape something that resembled a response.

Whether it was intelligible hardly mattered—the clone bowed, stumbled backward, and left her.

Then everything was still.

Her thoughts hadn't resettled. They were ash floating through her skull, nothing she could grasp.

Catra had known.

Not guessed. Not suspected.

Known.

Known from the first moment—when she was nothing but humiliated cargo. Known in the baths, in the cold stone corridors of Talon Mountain, soft lamplight in Catra's quarters. Known when she kissed her. Known when she made love to her.

Adora's breath stuttered, and the first true pulse of pain hit her like a delayed blow.

Her body was remembering, all at once, what it had been through all day.

Her ribs seized under a bruise carved deep by a clone's spear shaft. Her right knee buckled slightly as she shifted her weight; she had forgotten she'd been clipped by a skiff blade. Her knuckles were split. Her left shoulder screamed when she inhaled too deeply. She could taste the metallic tang of blood in her mouth—someone else's or her own, she didn't even know.

For hours she had felt none of it.

She delayed the impact until she knew that Catra was—

Catra was alive. That wasn't—

That wasn't the pain she felt. It hurt to realise that she had expected Catra to be dead—captured and tortured and dead. Her anger and pain had been smothered by relief at the fact none of that had happened.

Now the pain returned with interest.

She had always imagined that the truth would come like an execution: swift, decisive, cleansing in its finality. That Catra would learn who she was, recoil, lash out, and the story would end in violence.

That would have been easier.

Instead, the revelation lay on her chest like a slab of stone. An ongoing pressure. A weight that refused to give.

Catra had said it so calmly.

As though the knowledge had been folded into her every breath from the beginning. As though every touch, every whispered sound, had been offered with full awareness—not ignorance, not innocence, not trust.

And Adora—

Adora had believed in something fragile. Something impossible.

If Catra could endure this, if she could look at the woman who killed her mother and still posture, still stand straight, still conduct negotiations as she was haggling over a border treaty, then Adora could match it.

She would not collapse.

She would not beg.

She would not show the hurt clawing its way up her throat.

Queenship demanded this of her.

The ache in her chest didn't matter. It couldn't matter.

Catra had never been hers; this thing between them had been an anomaly, an indulgence carved out of borrowed time.

Now that time was gone.

She turned toward her waiting soldiers. They stood rigid as carved figures, eyes lowered but darting up at her in small, frightened glances. The battle had changed them. Changed how they saw her. They didn't know how to look at a Queen who split an army like a blade through silk.

She stepped onto her skiff, each motion a negotiation with her battered limbs. Dirt crumbled from her boots. The handle was

slick from sweat under her fingers; she gripped it as hard as she dared to keep her hand from shaking.

It was only a quarter mile to camp.

It felt like an eternity.

The wind stung her face. Her eyes burned. She-Ra's form seemed suddenly too heavy, pulling her forward. Her heartbeat thudded in her ears slowly and painfully.

She forced her spine to stay straight, her chin up in the air, her gaze fixed on the distant shape of her own banner.

She would not falter here, in the open, where every soldier could see.

This, the pain, was the cost of a crown.

This was the weight of surviving when everything inside her felt scraped hollow.

She would bear it.

She was She-Ra. She had no other choice.

✧

There was still one duty left.

By the time Adora reached the Etherian encampment, the field had transformed into a mirror of Catra's—rows of ordered canvas, poles driven into softened earth, banners snapping in the cooling night air. She had ordered it built; her soldiers had obeyed without question. Now she walked through it still feeling the weight of She-Ra like an extra piece of armor.

Her own tent stood on the southern edge of the encampment, its flap tied open in invitation: a pallet, clean sheets, the promise of unconsciousness. She didn't linger. Instead, she called for

Mermista and went to the command tent, the one set in the center as the heart of the army should be.

Pink-torch light flickered at the entrance, the flames hovering waist-high, unnervingly steady despite the wind. Inside, six blue-green braziers made shadows leapt up the tent walls—a shifting, restless audience surrounding the central table and its single high-backed chair, positioned to face the entryway.

This close to a Horde force, Etherian patrols overlapped with theirs. Scouts doubled back on their own routes. A dropped shield would set three companies spinning toward imagined danger. They trusted her implicitly, but hatred crept in with the perceived enemy so close. They didn't know why she'd brought them here; only Mermista would hear the truth first.

Adora thought of the pride on Mermista's face the day she had accepted the mantle of Princess of Salineas—of what that legacy meant to her. And Adora was about to strip it away, in the most calculated act of governance she had ever performed.

If she could give up Catra, she could do this.

Mermista entered the tent.

Her armor was bandaged over the split from earlier, her hair tied back roughly. Her eyes searched Adora's face, looking for the girl she'd grown up with; she wouldn't find her.

Adora stood straight as an arrow. Mermista faced her Queen.

The Queen explained the situation, matter-of-fact, refusing to let emotion creep in.

"So let me get this straight." Mermista's voice was tight, but not raised. "The Horde Princess gets my home. And we're calling her your primary ally?"

"Yes."

“You’ve already decided.”

“I have.”

A muscle in Mermista’s jaw ticked. Adora had imagined once that returning to Etheria would restore some version of the friendship they’d had as children—fresh snow on the palace steps, whispered secrets under blankets. It felt absurd now. The Horde had burned that out of her.

“She’s playing you,” Mermista said. “Playing us. This is strategy. She wants you weakened.”

“I’m aware.”

A beat.

“It’s what she does.”

Mermista’s expression hardened. “She kept you as a slave. She abandoned us at Seaspray.”

“There was a reason.”

“Can I at least know it?”

“No.”

The list Catra had given her laid upon the table; supplies, soldiers, siege equipment. More than she’d expected. Not enough for what she was giving in return. Mermista knew it. So did Adora.

“I wouldn't do this to you this if I had another option,” Adora said.

Mermista pressed her lips together. She was controlling herself only with significant effort. Her silence was sharper than a shout.

“Tell me the cost,” Adora said quietly.

Mermista exhaled through her nose. “Frosta will leave your side first. Some battalions will go with her. The others will hesitate.

You'll get fewer volunteers, fewer reinforcements. On the march, morale will suffer. In battle... cohesion will fracture."

She paused.

Then: "And they'll talk."

The words slipped out, as if through clenched teeth.

"About—"

"No." Adora cut her off. "We're not discussing that."

Mermista hesitated. Then, unable to help herself, "If you would at least take off the cuff—"

"No."

She made herself hold Mermista's stare. "It stays."

Adora let the silence sit between them. Mermista didn't break it; she stood with her palms pressed flat against the war table, arms locked, shoulders tense under the braided teal of her hair.

Adora could feel the tremor in her own hands, the exhaustion crawling up the backs of her legs. She refused to sit.

Mermista didn't look at her. "Do you know what people will say?" The words were ground out between teeth. "What the *soldiers* will say? The princesses? The court in Bright Moon?"

Adora didn't flinch. "Yes."

"They'll call you compromised." There was bitterness in every syllable. "They'll say you surrendered a kingdom to the Princess who kept you chained. That you traded my home away because she—"

"Mermista." Her voice was low, not gentle, just controlled. "This isn't about that."

Mermista’s gaze flicked up sharply. “Isn’t it?”

Adora felt something twist in her chest. She kept her tone even. “It’s about Horde Prime in Bright Moon.” Her hands curled, slowly, into fists.

“Prime.” Mermista pushed away from the table and paced a short, tight line — three steps, turn, three steps back, her movements clipped and restless. “And the fact that you’re doing exactly what Catra wants—that’s just a coincidence, right?”

Adora’s jaw tightened. “Catra wants me weakened. She wants my allies divided. I know that. I know *exactly* what she’s doing.”

“Do you?” Mermista snapped. “Because from where I’m standing, it looks an awful lot like she snapped her claws and you handed over a coastal kingdom.”

Adora didn’t move. “If I had any other option—”

“You did.” Mermista stopped pacing and stabbed a finger toward the table. “You could have trusted me, you could trust Etheria. We don't *need* her help.”

Adora felt heat crawl up the back of her neck. She forced herself to meet Mermista’s eyes.

“There are things I can’t say. Not yet.”

“Not to me.”

“To no one.”

Mermista’s throat worked, once, as if swallowing back something sharp. “I just fought with you at Seaspray because you were certain Catra would meet us there. I trusted you. And you’ve just… given my kingdom away.

“I know.”

That quiet acknowledgement stopped Mermista more effectively than any apology. She pressed both hands to her brow, rubbing her temples like she was holding her skull together.

"Tell me what loyalty is to look like now," she said. "Tell me how I'm meant to stand by you when you hand the sea to someone who would no doubt drown us without blinking."

Adora exhaled, slow and steady. "Loyalty is standing beside me when I make the choices that hurt. Not because they're right for you, but because they're right for Etheria."

Mermista laughed once—a sharp, humorless sound. "Gods, you sound like your mother."

Adora didn't rise to it.

"I need you," she said simply.

Mermista's gaze sharpened. "And the cuff?"

"It stays." Adora's voice didn't waver. "I won't hide what happened."

The pause between them stretched until it felt like the whole tent was holding its breath. Still, she forced herself to speak the one question she'd been choking on since she'd returned.

"*And you?*" Adora said at last. "Will I lose you?"

It came out overly controlled, as if she was afraid any looseness in her voice would unravel her.

Mermista didn't answer immediately. She stood there, rigid, her jaw working as if she was chewing down emotion she refused to show. Then, slowly, as if dragged up from a trench, the words surfaced:

"…I want Bright Moon."

No attempt to mask what she was asking: command of Etherias primary military force.

The breath left Adora's lungs in a quiet, stunned exhale. Not because the request was shocking, but because she suddenly saw the shape of it. Catra hadn't been playing *them* against each other. Catra had been playing *to* Mermista. Playing to her pride. Catra had known precisely how far Mermista's loyalty could stretch before it strained.

Catra had known the exact price.

"Listen to me," Mermista said, stepping closer. Her voice had lost all its usual languor; it was steel drawn over rock. "If you ever valued my opinion; she is not on our side. She's Horde. She's marching Horde soldiers into Etheria with your blessing."

"To fight Horde Prime," Adora answered. "Not us."

"If someone kills your mother," Mermista said, "you don't rest until they're dead."

The blow landed squarely in Adora's chest. She didn't flinch.

She saw Catra's face in the pavilion again, cold and perfect and feral with control. The way she had been holding herself upright by sheer force of will. The way her eyes had burned when she spoke of Shadow Weaver. The way she had spat those words—*You killed my mother.*

Mermista shook her head, frustrated, helpless. "Do you really think she's forgiven you?"

"No," Adora said quietly. "She hasn't. She *hates* me."

"But she hates Horde Prime more," she continued. "And she needs us. We need her. This is the only way."

"You need her enough," Mermista said, "that you would tear my home out from under me. Because *she* asked for it?"

Adora didn’t even blink.

“Yes.”

Mermista recoiled slightly. Her hands opened and closed at her sides, as if she was resisting the urge to smash something. Perhaps she wanted to grab Adora by the shoulders and shake her.

Adora didn’t move. She didn’t soften. She was tired past the point of trembling, her body held together by discipline and the knowledge that every decision she made now carried the weight of an entire world.

“I’m doing this for Etheria,” she said.

“If you’re wrong,” Mermista said slowly, her voice splintering at the edges despite her best effort, “there won’t *be* an Etheria left.”

✧

Adora spoke to a few soldiers on her way back through the Etherian encampment—short, spare exchanges, habit more than conversation. A nod here, a quiet “Steady,” there. She’d done it since her first command at fifteen, when the smallest acknowledgement from a superior could stop a conscript’s hands from shaking. Now the soldiers stiffened as she passed and murmured only, *“My Queen,”* their voices catching like they were swallowing fear or awe. No shared fireside warmth. No rumpled jokes or whispered scandals.

Lonnie and the Talon Mountain Horde soldiers—those who had fought beside her at Seaspray—had already been sent back to Catra’s ranks. Adora hadn’t seen them go. She wasn’t sure if they’d avoided her or if she’d simply been absent or occupied.

The night was thick and warm. The kind of air that felt almost soft, touched by the last breath of summer. No need for extra fires except to cook or to guide the patrols. The Etherian camp had sprung up with military precision—neat rows of tents, perfectly

measured walkways, water barrels stacked by the supply tents, weapons racked and gleaming clean from post-battle care. Discipline radiated from every direction. Even the shadows seemed orderly.

Her own tent waited at the far southern edge, plain white canvas against a sea of varying blues—unadorned, austere, a contrast to Catra's lush pavilion draped in silks. Two guards stood outside it: Juliet, older, stone-faced from years of campaigning, and Keston, young enough that the honor of guarding the Queen's rest turned his posture rigid with pride. Both snapped to attention as she approached. Adora inclined her head to them, a small gesture, but one she never neglected. Their spines straightened even further, if that was possible.

She pushed aside the tent flap and let it fall behind her.

The interior was minimalistic but not unwelcoming—Etherian magic globes drifted beneath the canvas ceiling like drifting bubbles of light, casting soft violet and blue hues across the space. These floating lights—so distinctly Etherian—made something in her chest tighten unexpectedly. A memory of childhood. Of her real home.

The quiet inside was immediate. A mercy. Her body sagged under it. She felt the pulse of exhaustion in every tendon, every joint. She wanted—fiercely, desperately—to drop She-Ra's form, to shed the Power, to collapse on the pallet and let the world stop for even a minute.

She took one step forward.

Then froze—every sense sharpening painfully.

She wasn't alone.

A woman knelt at the foot of the pallet, nude, folded into a deep obeisance. Her forehead touched the ground, hands flattened before her, the posture of a trained offering. Her tanned skin flushed with nervousness she lacked the training to hide; her dark

hair pinned away from her face with a delicate Salinean shell clasp. She was maybe nineteen—twenty at most—her body toned, prepared, shaped for service. A shallow wooden bath, decorated with shell inlays, steamed faintly beside her.

The girl had been readied for her. For the Queen.

Adora's stomach churned violently. She might have once known how to navigate this without faltering. Once she would've taken in the sight, the expectation, the way she'd been taught. She might have allowed the girl to wash her, dress her, sit at her feet. She might have even bedded her, in the way young nobility did.

Slaves were from Adora's culture. Etheria had kept the Eternian tradition, one that dated back to the First Ones settlers a millennia ago.

Mermista had known her type and catered to it well.

Her voice came out rough, the command too sharp, too wrong:

"Get up."

The slave obeyed instantly. She rose with trained grace, but her hands trembled. Her eyes stayed lowered. A metal collar circled her throat—simple, functional. Matching cuffs gleamed at her wrists. The same as the one Adora herself—

A breath hitched painfully in her ribs.

"My Queen," the slave asked, quiet and frightened. "What is wrong?"

Adora realised she'd been silent too long. That her breathing was uneven. That the air in the tent felt wrong, pressing at her like suffocating cloth.

"No slaves," Adora said. Her voice sounded foreign in her own ears. "Tell them. I can dress and bathe myself."

The slave blinked, startled. Confused. Embarrassed. But she bowed with flawless obedience.

“Yes, my Queen.”

She turned toward the exit—still naked—and Adora felt a bolt of shock at the idea of sending her out into the camp like that, exposed.

“Wait,” Adora said abruptly.

She unfastened her own cloak—heavy, white, edged in gold thread—and draped it over the slave’s shoulders. It dwarfed her, pooling at her ankles. Adora felt the impropriety of it. A Queen didn’t cloak her slaves. A monarch didn’t offer such warmth to someone considered property.

But Adora couldn’t bear to see another’s body pressed into obedience. Not after—

“The guard will escort you back,” she said, steady once more.

“Yes, my Queen,” the girl whispered. She clutched the cloak like it was something precious—and hurried out.

The tent fell silent again.

Adora was alone.

Finally, devastatingly alone.

Chapter End Notes

> There might be a small pause as my tablet broke. There's definitely going to be pause in any of my art if you were following that. My new tablet arrives next week.

Chapter 7: Catra

Chapter Notes

> For context, this chapter picks up right after Adora leaves the tent with Catra. Another emotional one 😳.
>
> Thank you again to my beta reader nbc22. Seriously some of the edits they make 👌
>
> Also, someone has been trying to get into my account for 4 days now. I keep getting alerts about it. Support assures me they can't get in without my password or access to my email, but it's definitely been stressing me out.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It felt like the ground had tilted beneath Catra's feet and upended her—not a slow spill but a catastrophic collapse. Pain surged through her body in one monstrous, ungovernable wave. There was no distinguishing where the hurt began or ended: her torn shoulder, her stitched up stomach, sour grief for Kyle, the gut-wrenching humiliation she'd just endured, the weeks of tension, the hours in the dungeon, the blood, the stairs, the betrayal, the hope—and its abrupt destruction. All of it crashed in, mercilessly. Her body gave out. Her knees struck the floor.

She barely registered the impact.

She braced her palm against the cloth covered floor and felt tremors running through her arm. The tent’s air seemed suddenly too thin, as though she couldn't get enough oxygen to remain upright.

She had made Adora promise not to forget.

She had made her *promise*.

Like some sweet, simple village girl, losing her virginity.

Had Adora repeated it later to Mermista, laughing in disbelief? Leaning in over a goblet of wine, sharing the absurdity—*the Horde Princess, imagine, thinking this meant something*. Catra could hear their voices in her mind: Mermista's dry drawl, Adora's soft, embarrassed laugh. *She actually asked me to remember!*

Stupid.

Pathetic.

And the worst part—the part somehow causing the most pain of all—was that it hadn't been Adora who betrayed the fantasy. It had been Catra, misreading her entirely. Catra had known Mara, the girl with golden curls and a reckless grin, the teasing mouth, the sly warmth in her voice. She had known the woman who murmured in the dark, who touched her, who coaxed moans from her like a magician drawing silk from a sleeve. She had known the shape of that affection.

But she didn't know *Adora*.

She didn't know the Queen.

She didn't know She-Ra.

She had never known the woman who walked into this tent.

That woman had not come because of concern for Catra missing the rendezvous.

She had not come due to fear that Catra might have been snatched, or wounded, or bleeding out in some back corridor.

She had come because she smelled deception. Because she sensed her own exposure. Because some part of the story had threatened to slip out of her grasp, and she had to seize control of it before Catra—or Horde Prime—could do so first.

Adora hadn't finally confessed her identity out of guilt or fear for Catra's safety; she confessed because it was strategically

necessary. Because she needed to give shape to the lie before someone else did. Her remorse, her urgency—none of that had been for Catra.

She forced her breath out through her teeth. The tent fluttered at one corner from the night breeze, but the space around her felt coffin-small. She pressed the heel of her palm to her brow, trying to keep the room from lurching again.

Adora had slept with her without telling her truth. Adora had not even *considered* telling her first.

Catra felt a crackling heat growing in her chest—shame, anger, grief, confusion, a dozen jagged things pressing against each other until she could barely stand it.

She was a fool. A child. A naïve little kitten who mistook hunger for affection, strategy for devotion, tension for intimacy. She'd spun herself a pretty story: the noble slave who looked at her like she was something good, something worth choosing. The woman who pressed her lips to Catra's shoulder and whispered she wanted her. The woman who touched her so tenderly, who sighed her name like a vow.

All a lie.

All a role.

All a deception.

Adora had been planning her escape, her return, her ascension. That night had been nothing more than the final lock she needed to open. The last sweet flourish in a con that Catra had willingly—enthusiastically—walked into.

If Catra hadn't been chained in Double Trouble's dungeon, if she hadn't missed Seaspray—would Adora have come at all? Would she have bothered to speak with her? To look at her? Or would she have vanished like morning fog, leaving Catra with her army, her fort, her impossible war against Horde Prime—all of it alone?

Catra’s throat closed, choking her breath.

All this time, she had believed Adora’s presence at her side was loyalty—something fragile and growing between them.

But the truth was much simpler: Adora had been securing her freedom. Bedding Catra had been the means to an end.

She lowered her head, trembling, breath wet and shuddering in her own chest. The shame was enough to make her retch. She swallowed it back down.

Of course the Queen of Etheria didn’t want her. Of course the unstoppable She-Ra didn’t see her as a future.

As anything more than a convenience. A bed. A way out.

She had wanted the impossible. To be chosen. To be loved.

And all she ever was—

all she had ever been—

was broken.

A political liability. A problem to manage.

A body to use, if convenient.

She put a clawed hand to the floor and rasped out a breath that sounded more like a sob.

Catra did not lift her head from the carved box on the ground before her. She kept her gaze on the little wooden courtesans, whose faces had begun to warp under the haze of her vision—as if their lacquered smiles disapproved of her, too. As if even the trinkets created for her gaze were turning away.

Of course Adora believed that one night between them granted her leverage—some imagined right to Catra’s choices, her

alliances, her body, her future. Queen of Etheria, saviour of all she touched, who surely thought her bed was a throne unto itself.

Nothing born of tenderness. Nothing born of intimacy.

Only power.

Only presumption.

What feeling is that, lover?

The revulsion in your eyes? The pity? The embarrassment that you let yourself touch something so unclean? Was it your first time rutting with a gutter-born creature?

A laugh scraped through Catra's throat—bitter, voiceless, without breath. Hordak's knife had merely broken flesh; Adora had managed to reach bone. A spiritual flaying, slow and meticulous. A neat disassembly of everything she had tried to believe in.

She needed Etheria more than ever. She needed this alliance. And she had never been so completely, utterly alone. Even when Prime had dragged her into his chambers at thirteen. Even when she had been a trembling little girl kneeling at his bedside. Even then she had not felt this hollow.

She rested her clawed fingertips against Kyle's box. The black silk lay discarded like shed skin beside her knee. Her hand was trembling without her permission—steady, then faltering, then steady again. If she put her palm flat, she could feel how uneven her breath had become.

She had miscalculated. She had miscalculated catastrophically.

She'd tied her war, her future, her people to a woman she did not know. A façade she had mistaken for something true. A slave she had thought honest—who had simply been more accomplished at deception than Catra could ever hope to be.

She knew better.

She knew better.

Gods damn her, she *knew better*.

The tent flap snapped open.

She flinched.

Only then did she realize she was sitting on the floor, her legs curled under her in a graceless sprawl, her shoulders hunched over the little box like she meant to shield it from thieves. She did not recall lowering herself to the rug. The last thing she remembered clearly was standing. After that—nothing but fractured moments of pitiful crying.

She looked up. Her eyes took too long to focus.

For a blink her heart lurched—because the silhouette in the doorway was broad, tall, framed by the torchlight. For a half-second her bruised mind whispered *Adora*—

—but the figure resolved into a different outline: weary, sharp-edged, dust-streaked.

Marzo.

Her breath left in a shake, something like a scoff, something like disappointment.

"Do I look," she rasped, "as if I have need of you?"

Her voice didn't crack. She took that as a small victory.

Marzo did not comment on her posture, her pallor, the sweat at her temple, or the dried blood flakes still crusted at her sleeve. His face was its usual blend of sharp disapproval and reluctant duty.

"There is someone wishing an audience," he said.

"Oh, are you demoted now?" Catra muttered. "Errand boy? I thought you were my captain."

“I volunteered,” he said stiffly, “to act as chaperone.”

Catra blinked at him, slow and unfocused. She lifted a clawed finger and pointed to the box. “And what—pray tell—do you think *this* is, if not a chaperone?”

Marzo did not flinch. He also did not get the joke.

The hollowness inside Catra swelled, almost enough to topple her again. She closed her eyes briefly. They burned. Everything burned.

“And how is the baker?” she asked. “Is she done burying the body yet?”

Marzo’s jaw tightened. “I know you possess manners,” he said. “I will not call her in until you recollect the use of them.”

Catra tilted her head back far enough to see him properly. The motion sent a fracture of agony through her shoulder. “Oh,” she said, a thin smile stretching across her lips, “then we will be here for a very long time.”

“I’ve let myself in,” Baker announced coolly.

The flap fell closed behind her. The torchlight vanished. Her silhouette steadied into the room: the broad apron, the pale mint hair braided back, the eyes that had seen entirely too much death for kitchen staff.

She wore no grief openly. She also wore no warmth.

“So her highness can rest assured that we are now on equal footing when it comes to manners.”

“I doubt,” Marzo said sourly without turning, “that such a thing is possible.”

Baker ignored him, stepping further into the space until she stood before Catra. Her gaze flicked to the carved box, lingered—pain

passing across her face as quickly and then returned to Catra.

Catra stared back, completely numb.

"Well?" Baker asked softly. "Shall we?"

And something in Catra broke again, silently, invisibly, beneath her ribs—because for the first time in hours, she was no longer entirely alone. Baker was here, filling in as a mother she hadn't realised she still needed.

Catra remained where she was—cross-legged on the rug, back slightly bowed, one hand braced on the floor, the other resting protectively atop the carved lid of Kyle's box. Her pride should have made her stand, or at least climb to a chair, but Kyle would have howled with delight knowing they'd caught her on the ground talking to a head in a box. The thought was absurdly comforting, and so she stayed exactly as she was.

Baker stepped fully into dim view, skirts whispering faintly, the scent of vanilla trailing after her. Catra registered the change in her clothing at once: the apron unchanged, although clean, but beneath it a dress of deep Drylian mourning violet. Her eyes were reddened at the rims; she had not concealed her crying well at all. Her face was drawn.

Marzo—massive, silent, too solemn for his own good—shifted back a pace, making himself smaller in the room. Or as small as a man of his size could ever manage.

"You may take the desk chair," Catra said lightly, in almost sing-song sweetness. "Or, if you prefer, there's always the floor. Seems to be my preference today."

Baker faltered only slightly, as if she truly had never imagined a Princess of the Horde and Scourge of the Fright Zone sitting on a tent rug with a dearly departed head boxed between her knees. Her expression suggested a woman whose understanding of the world had been abruptly—if not irreparably—rearranged.

“Your highness is bleeding again,” she observed, tone clipped but steady.

“Yes,” Catra said. “The Queen of Etheria insisted. Said it suited me. Red brings out my eyes.”

Marzo made a noise that was almost a groan.

Baker dragged the desk chair across the floor—not scraping, not clumsy, but careful, as though noise might shatter the fragile peace of the tent. She set it before Catra, lowering herself with rigid posture, smoothing her skirt with both hands. A camp was no place for her; Catra could see it in the set of her shoulders, the tension at the corners of her mouth. Baker belonged in a kitchen filled with warmth and spices, not amidst tents and soldiers and death.

Catra considered leaning back, but her shoulder sent a bright lance of pain at the mere thought. She stayed.

Then Baker surprised her.

“You speak like her,” she said quietly.

Catra’s brows rose. “What?”

The woman swallowed, her throat bobbing. “Entrapta. When she was in one of her moods. Not the cheerful, experimental ones. The sharper ones. When she cut with her words instead of her tools.”

Catra’s smile froze, the expression turning brittle, edges cracking. “I doubt it.”

“She was never cruel,” Baker went on, gaze drifting down to the carved box. “Not intentionally. But there were… similarities. You’re cruder, of course. She always had such an eccentric way of being terrible.” She hesitated. “You were always a reader, weren’t you? Entrapta never had the patience for books—she wanted to build, not sit. I imagine the two of you would not have suited each

other's company. Temperament alike, interests entirely at odds. You must have found her irritating."

Catra stared at her.

The tent felt too close. The air too warm. Baker was not setting a trap—Catra would have felt it. There was no predatory gleam, no circling hunger. Only exhaustion. Only sorrow. Only grief.

Still—she did not lower her guard. Sometime in the interminable minutes leading up to this conversation, she had promised herself she would never lower it again.

"I wanted to thank you," Baker said softly, "for Entrapta. For Entrapta's—"

"Corpse?" Catra supplied flatly.

Baker flinched. "For her *body*," she corrected, gently but firmly. "We will hold a small service tonight. More after the war, when there is time to honour her properly. As she deserves."

"As she deserves," Catra echoed, voice dry.

Baker's jaw tightened, but she pushed onward. "I wished to offer the use of the Hell's Rest crypt. For your—" her eyes dropped to Kyle's box, her breath catching.

"My brother," Catra said without hesitation.

Baker's look softened—not pity, but recognition. "Friend," she said. "But yes."

"If the child in that casket is your family," she added, after a second to think, "then so is my Entrapta."

A dangerous thing to name. A dangerous bond for a Drylian servant to claim. Catra did not blink, but Baker raised her hand gently, as if to stave off the thought flickering behind Catra's eyes. Baker *knew* what happened to Entrapta. Baker had noticed the

same damage in Catra, as if it was plain enough to read on her face.

"You may place him in the crypt," Baker continued. "Just for the war. For peace. You may take him when it is done."

"No," Catra said immediately.

Three beats stretched. Four. Five.

Then, quieter: "Thank you."

Baker nodded once, as if she had expected that answer. "Why not leave him at rest, just for now?"

"Because he would not be resting." Catra said. "The dead do not rest unless they are burned or buried whole. Why would I curse him to roam? To be hungry for centuries? To suffer?"

"A superstition from Weave's Slope," Baker began—but stopped when Catra leveled her with a flat, feral stare. The kind that warned: *finish that thought and you will regret it.*

Baker closed her mouth.

Marzo shifted again. Baker and Catra watched each other with an intensity that left him visibly uncomfortable. Finally, he exhaled through his nose, muttering something—but Catra didn't catch it.

Catra understood perfectly well what Baker's offer could have meant had it come from an enemy rather than a grief-stricken Drylian servant—an offer so generous it could be turned into leverage later, a quiet threat wrapped in civility. Let us keep what you love. Let us hold it safe. And then, when the war was over—No, not yet. Not until you give us what we want.

It was exactly the kind of tactic Catra herself would have used.

But she did not voice that observation. She simply met Baker's gaze until the woman's composure cracked just enough for her to

bow her head.

“Of course,” Baker said quietly. “My apologies, your highness. I meant only to offer comfort. I did not intend to presume.”

“Your kindness is noted,” Catra said.

Baker inhaled slowly, steadying herself. “And I am deeply appreciative of *yours*. More than I can say.”

Catra gave a small sound—something between a scoff and a laugh, except humour had nothing to do with it. “I have no kindness,” she said. “Ask anyone. Ask Marzo. Ask Prime’s clones. Ask Kyle—look, he’s right here. See where my kindness got him.”

Catra continued, voice turning deceptively airy. “Ask Entrapta. I found her unbearable, remember? Tiresome. Irritating. You said it yourself—you saw it all without seeing a single conversation between us. I despised your Princess. Thoroughly. She made my skin crawl.” She tilted her head. “There. Does that satisfy you? Do I sound like the monster everyone prefers?”

Baker did not recoil. She sat straighter, surprisingly steady. “Entrapta admired you,” she said softly. “Very much.”

Catra made a rude, incredulous noise, as though the idea were so far removed from reality that it physically offended her. She rose in a sharp movement that made Marzo’s hand twitch toward his sword. Catra ignored him. She reached down, scooping Kyle’s box up with care. She tucked it beneath her arm, an almost protective cradle.

“I’m not interested in lies,” she said. “They bore me. If you try them again, I won’t pretend politeness. I haven’t even warmed up.”

She took a step toward the table, then another, but Baker’s next words halted her mid-stride.

“I was fond of your mother.”

Catra stilled. Slowly, she turned her head.

“A change of topic. How chic,” she said. “Were you, then?”

Baker nodded, tightly but sincerely.

“Well,” Catra said, with a brittle brightness, “then tell me—where were you when her daughter was taken in by Horde Prime? Where were you when your *own Princess* was taken by the same creature? I find it fascinating,” she went on, voice gaining a harsh momentum, “how many people adored my mother. As it turns out, so many admirers—but none with an ounce of interest in what became of her child.”

Baker’s lips parted, caught between shock and confusion. “You—”

“Me?” Catra cut in, smiling razor-thin. “Yes. I was very busy, wasn’t I? That’s the usual excuse. Allow me to save you the trouble. I was busy becoming an unmanageable, foul-mouthed little brat. I drove away everyone who tried to help. Only Prime could ‘handle’ me.”

“I was terrible,” she said. “Oh, yes. And Prime was reasonable, and patient, and benevolent. A saint from amongst the stars.”

“I know the litany by heart,” she continued. “My sins, his virtues. A charming scripture. Thank the gods a grieving thirteen-year-old is held to such exacting standards. Imagine what horrors might have occurred if compassion had been permitted.”

Baker looked stricken.

“You are dismissed,” Catra said, stepping aside with a stiff, regal pivot. “Both of you. I have work.”

Marzo bowed his head briefly. Baker rose slowly, her movements stiff with some mix of sorrow and shock. She opened her mouth—perhaps to apologize, perhaps to say Entrapta’s name again—but Catra’s stare froze the words in her throat.

Baker inclined her head instead. A quiet retreat. She slipped past the tent flap and into the night.

Marzo lingered a heartbeat longer, studying Catra with his brow faintly furrowed. An expression you might see on someone whose respect had deepened in spite of—or perhaps because of—the cruelty he had just witnessed.

He left without a word.

✧

Catra had meant for the tent to be silent—coffee, the mess cleared, her shoulder re-bandaged, and then no interruptions unless Prime himself fell out of the sky. That was supposed to buy her a moment to breathe. Instead, her mind kept running laps she couldn't stop: Kyle's empty box, Lonnie's betrayal, the smear of blood on her jacket, and Adora's face when she realised Catra had known who she really was.

Her body ached. Her ribs throbbed. Her shoulder burned. And still, the worst hurt sat somewhere deep, raw and grinding, as if someone had wedged a stone between her lungs.

Her bed on the Flagship drifted back into her mind—not because it had ever been soft or warm, but because it had been *predictable*. A slab of padded metal she understood, an engine hum that muted her thoughts. Even that was gone. Everything changed too quickly now. Even breathing felt like an unstable affair.

The familiar ache of wanting things to stop—just for a moment—itched beneath her skin. She couldn't rest. Not now. Not with everything falling apart.

"Hurry with that coffee—her highness cannot possibly change herself with her shoulder in that condition! Was *no one* monitoring her?"

The voice burst into the tent with all the subtlety of a fired pulse-cannon.

Catra didn’t even snarl. She just went still—ears pricked, pupils blown wide—because the tone was unmistakable. Bright. Cheerful. Thoughtlessly earnest. Slightly too nasal.

And impossible.

She turned.

Entrapta walked straight into the tent as if she belonged there—hair bouncing behind her in pigtails, goggles perched on her head, expression open and curious. She looked fresh faced and alive, so far from the dead-eyed woman she had found a week prior.

Catra lurched backward into the table. The legs screeched across the rug.

No. This wasn't real.

This was Double Trouble’s idea of a joke—their most vicious one yet.

Entrapta stopped a few steps away, blinking at her in innocent confusion. “Are you okay, Princess? You look… pale. And sort of wobbly. Do you need to sit? Or lie down? Your heart rate looks elevated—your pupils are dilated, too, that’s usually a stress response—”

“You’re—” Catra’s voice buckled. “You’re dead.”

Her lungs refused to work. Her throat felt scraped raw. She tried again.

“You’re—Double Trou—”

The tent flap swung again.

Double Trouble slipped inside with a flourish, spinning like they were debuting on an amphitheater stage. They bowed with one hand sweeping toward Entrapta as if they'd unveiled a priceless exhibit.

"You are *so* welcome," they said, beaming.

Entrapta gave a little wave as if this were all perfectly normal.

Catra felt tears slide down her cheeks before she had even realized she was crying.

"What," she managed, "did you *do*?"

The words shook. She hated that. She hated that she couldn't hold herself still—that her hands were trembling, that her breathing was too fast, that she couldn't tear her eyes away from Entrapta's face.

Entrapta took a tentative step closer, her pigtails dragging in long lines behind her. "Catra? Do you need water? Or sugar? You look like you might faint, and statistically speaking, fainting whilst standing increases your risk of neck injury by a surprising percentage—"

Catra let out a rough, cracked laugh.

Entrapta wasn't an illusion. The way she shifted her weight, the way her hands twitched when she spoke, the way her hair curled where the humidity caught it.

Double Trouble lounged against a support pole like they'd been waiting all afternoon for applause, voice lilted and smug. "Baker let me out not long after you *dramatically collapsed*. I know she told you otherwise—sorry about that, kitten." Their grin sharpened. "But *this*—oh, this was a surprise just for *you*."

They paced a little, hands steepled in front of them. "It was child's play once Prime toddled off to Bright Moon. Slip through the

Flagship dressed as one of his clones and suddenly, I'm strolling down the clone halls with a brand new Entrapta in tow."

Catra felt something cold lance down her spine. Their grin widened, delighted by the reaction.

"And since your old prosthetic was beyond repair—just tragic workmanship—I brought you a new leg!" They clapped loudly, palms never quite touching. "And a mechanic! And I cleaned up your little 'oops' in killing her so carelessly."

"I didn't—" Catra's voice broke. She didn't finish. Her eyes were on Entrapta again. Entrapta, who shifted curiously from foot to foot. So bright. So whole. So—untouched.

Too untouched.

Had she experienced anything? Known anything? Or had Prime pressed a button and forced her into adulthood like shaping dough?

For all Catra knew, this Entrapta's worst trauma was a burnt cupcake.

Double Trouble hummed and rolled their wrist. "Unfortunately, I could not locate Entrapta's memory chip on her body." They sighed theatrically. "It's astounding how precious things get misplaced. But!" They pointed at the living girl with both hands. "Our new friend is a blank canvas—with all that charming curiosity, and none of those pesky recollections of… well." Their eyes flicked to Kyle's box.

Catra flinched and *willed* herself not to look at where she kept Entrapta's real chip, buried beneath her writing tools.

Her voice rasped when she spoke. "Kyle?"

Double Trouble blinked, then snapped their fingers as if remembering a trivial detail. "Oh. The boy. No. That one's gone for good, I'm afraid." They said it lightly, and Catra's stomach

knotted. "Entrapta was invaluable. Prime—sadly—does not archive every fad he plays with. Clones take space, you know."

"Get out." Catra's breath shuddered. "*Get out!*"

She thought they might flinch. They didn't. Their smile only dipped for a heartbeat before returning, brilliant and mocking.

"Of course. Everyone needs time to adjust after such a miraculous resurrection." They touched two fingers to their brow in a jaunty salute. "Entrapta will be back in the morning to fit your new leg."

"Double Trouble—wait—you have to avoid—"

The words died in her throat.

Because Lonnie stood in the entrance.

Frozen. Mid-step. Staring at Entrapta like she was seeing a ghost. Then her gaze slid to Catra. And what lived in that look wasn't confusion.

It was *judgment*.

Assumptions blooming like rot.

Catra felt her throat close. What did Lonnie think? That Catra had engineered this? That Catra was so warped she'd fake Entrapta's death to break her? Or worse—that Catra had simply replaced her out of boredom, like Prime replaced clones?

"Lonnie, I—I didn't know." The words spilled too fast, too soft. Too young.

Lonnie forced her spine straight, jaw flexing hard as she swallowed whatever she wanted to say. "Your Highness," she clipped out. "Message from Mara—Sh—the Queen's camp."

She thrust the note out. Catra took it. Lonnie saluted, half-broken, then pivoted sharply and nearly fled.

When Catra looked back, Double Trouble was still grinning.

"I'll break the news to dear Baker," they purred, and with a matching nod between them, Double Trouble and Entrapta swept out of the tent.

Catra barely made it two steps before her body lurched and revolted. She staggered toward the basin at her vanity, fingers slipping on the edge as she doubled over and vomited until her ribs cramped. Her breath came in thin, sharp gasps; every inhale scraped at her throat like broken glass.

When the dry heaving finally stopped, she stayed there for a beat —on her knees, hunched, trembling—trying to remember how to stand. Her ears rang. Her vision pulsed too fast for her to keep up. The tent felt too small, too close, like it was folding in on her.

She forced herself upright. Her legs didn't quite obey. She leaned heavily against the vanity, swallowing bile, then turned toward her desk.

She walked to it as if wading through deep water.

Slow. Reluctant. Fighting every step.

She opened the drawer with numb fingers and sifted down to the very bottom. Her hand brushed familiar velvet. She drew out the tiny pouch. Inside: two earrings and the microchip.

The silver chip clung to the pouch like it didn't want to come out. Like it had weight beyond its actual material composition.

Catra set the earrings aside carefully. She cupped them in her palm for a moment, thumb grazing the little carved swirls in alien gems, then lifted them to her lips.

A kiss, smudged by her own tears.

As though she could will Kyle back into existence. As if she was a princess from the stories, for whom such a gesture might allow a

wish to be granted.

She put the earrings away, closing the pouch with painstaking care—like she would a lover's wound. Then she set it aside and stared at the chip.

Such a stupidly small thing.

Catra lowered herself into the chair, elbows on her knees, regarding it with the care she would grant to a venomous creature coiled to strike.

She could bury it. Hide it in the fort's walls. Tuck it beneath a stone. If Entrapta ever asked… if she ever grew curious… Catra could—

But what would that change? Entrapta—*this Entrapta*—didn't remember Prime's hands on her. Didn't remember the last night Catra had spoken to her, the poison she'd spat, the things she couldn't take back.

Entrapta had killed herself because she couldn't bear Catra's words.

So why was Catra even hesitating?

Her hands shook as she reached for the water pitcher. It felt heavy, like lifting a slab of iron. She raised it over her head, both arms taut—then brought it down.

The sound was horrible. Metal on wood. Metal on metal. Her own voice tearing out of her throat in a raw scream she hadn't meant to make.

Again.

She lifted it again. And slammed it down.

Again.

The chip skittered, cracked, and she barely heard herself sobbing. She barely heard her ragged breathing or felt the splashes of water hitting her face. Pain radiated down her arm, her shoulder screaming under the strain, but she welcomed it. *Wanted* it.

Let the pain be simple. Let it be clean. Something a medic could fix.

Not like the other pain. The kind she couldn't possibly scream loud enough to be rid of. The kind she couldn’t wash out of her body if she scrubbed until the end of time.

Her breath broke. She lifted the pitcher once more—hands slippery with water—and brought it down with a grunt that dissolved into another sob.

The tent went silent. Her heartbeat was thunder in her skull. Her shoulder throbbed deep and hot, almost numb with how sharply it hurt.

She didn’t realize she wasn’t alone until movement flickered at the edge of her vision.

A servant girl stood at the entrance, stiff with horror, clutching the steaming pot of coffee like a shield. Her eyes darted over the splintered chip, the drenched desk, the water dripping from the pitcher in Catra’s hand. Catra could see her trying not to stare. Trying not to make it worse.

Catra straightened. Slowly. Her breath still shook, but her voice, when she forced it out, was flat.

“Your Highness,” the servant whispered, stepping forward. “Your coffee.”

Catra swallowed hard. Her mouth tasted like bile.

“I need more water,” she said. “And my medic.”

A beat.

“Quickly, this time.”

Chapter End Notes

She's back 🤗 Yay? 😅

Chapter 8: Catra

Chapter Notes

> Tw: brief mention of attempted/intended sexual assault and Prime being a creep in Catra's memories.
>
> Sorry for the delay, I've had a shit week and I can barely even keep my eyes open right now. Thank god for my beta reader. I trust them so much that I have no idea what they edited because I can't keep my eues open. ✌️

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“You can be suspicious of me.”

Catra stared at her, eyebrows nearly climbing high enough to crawl off her forehead entirely.

“Oh,” she’d said dryly. “I have permission? What a blessing. Truly. Let me fall to my knees in gratitude.”

“I only meant you don’t have to worry about hurting my feelings,” Entrapta insisted, perfectly pleasant.

“Don’t I?” Catra drawled.

Entrapta nodded with absolute sincerity. “No. I remain objective.”

“Oh, good,” Catra muttered. “That makes one of us.”

Entrapta, unbothered, uncapped Catra’s inkwell with nimble fingers and picked up a pen, posture straight. Her expression stayed neutral, but Catra didn’t miss the quick flick of her eyes toward the mottled bruises across Catra’s ribs, or the way she held herself a fraction stiller—as if she was cataloguing damage.

Catra forced herself to sit upright, spine rigid, refusing to show how everything hurt: her shoulder, her chest, her pride, her heart.

“You don’t find it degrading to play secretary?” Catra asked, intentionally arch and biting. “I assumed you’d be offended.”

Entrapta beamed. “Oh, I like tasks! And Double Trouble said me being helpful might make things easier for you.”

Catra felt the faintest spike of irritation, but Entrapta was already tapping the end of the pen against the paper.

“First,” Entrapta said. “How do you want to frame our approach to negotiations?”

Our.

Catra shut her eyes and inhaled once, long and slow.

“Adora will demand I come to her.” The admission tasted bitter. “So demand the opposite. Loudly. Stubbornly. She’ll think she’s won something important when I ‘reluctantly’ agree.

Entrapta wrote quick, neat lines

Catra kept talking, though she hated every word, hated the picture of Adora that the words conjured—practical, earnest, gullible in certain ways, proud in others.

“She’s… simple in that sort of arena,” Catra finished.

She didn’t want to think about Adora. She especially didn’t want to think about the way her stomach still lurched when she remembered the look on her face, the way her voice had cracked, the way Catra herself had been so stupid—so willing—to misread it all.

She focused instead on Entrapta’s fingers as she wrote. On the scratch of the pen. On coffee cooling in a forgotten cup. On anything but the war swelling around them and the memory of Talon Mountain and a dead boy’s head.

Night stretched long.

Entrapta never drooped, never slowed—never even yawned. She adjusted the servants' work without seeming imperious, intercepting minor mistakes before they could irritate Catra enough that someone's job would be in danger. She sent for fresh coffee without being asked. She asked gentle, factual questions about supply lines, structural vulnerabilities, fallback routes—small things that anchored Catra to the moment.

Catra worked because she couldn't stop. Because the moment she stopped, her mind would go back to the box, to Kyle's slack face. To the moment she had looked up to find Adora in her tent and believed—so stupidly—that Adora had come for *her*.

She would not survive sitting alone with those thoughts all night.

So she didn't. She clung to strategy as if it were a rope thrown to a drowning woman.

By the time dawn bled pink across the edge of the tent flap, Catra almost didn't register it. A servant slipped inside carrying yet another pot of coffee, her expression wary as she took in the mountain of papers, Entrapta's scribbles, and Catra's rigid posture.

Sunlight touched the table. A new day dawned.

A new set of expectations came with it.

Catra blinked—just once—and sat back, feeling the ache of her entire body throb in slow waves.

Pain was familiar. Pain was safe. Pain made sense.

She had made it through the night.

She'd known she would.

Today she would face an entire world set against her—Etherian soldiers who wanted her dead, Adora who no longer looked at her with anything but fury, a war she could not win without allies she didn't even trust.

She would face them with a straight spine and a steady voice. She would convince them that she was worthy of their cooperation. That all of Etheria could fight side-by-side. That she wasn't a liability. That she wasn't broken.

She did not believe a single part of it.

But belief wasn't required. After all, Catra had always been an exceptional liar.

Especially to herself.

✧

Catra washed her face until her skin stung. She dressed without rushing, every layer of uniform pulled into place—fabric, buckles, gloves, the stiff collar that made it harder to breathe. She stood there for a long moment afterward, gripping the edge of her vanity to steady herself as a rolling wave of nausea climbed her throat. Her knees wanted to give. Her stomach twisted. Her shoulder ached in a steady rhythm that matched her heartbeat.

She drew in a breath, and, with the same resolve she used to walk into a battle, pulled aside the curtain covering her mirror.

The reflection staring back was an insult.

She looked… normal. Not untouched—no, she could hardly pass for unscathed—but nowhere near as ruined as she felt. Her jaw carried a blooming smear of yellow where Adora's fist had landed. A small cut marred the high apple of one cheek. Her eyes, ringed in tired shadows, still glowed in two different shades.

She was still beautiful.

The thought curdled instantly. *Beautiful*. As if that were a virtue. As if that were anything but a weapon other people had always been eager to claim.

Prime's voice slithered up from memory, slow and oily:

A little roughing up makes you look sweeter. Bruises give the fruit a tempting softness, don't you think?

Catra clenched her jaw, hard. She forced the memory away. But others crept in, unbidden, eager to fill the silence.

Adora had hit her. Fair. It was deserved.

The raider in the Crimson Wastes had slugged her across the jaw. Fine. He was dead now.

Those injuries faded fast. Too fast. They hardly ever left a mark that lasted long enough to mean anything.

Prime had always been careful with her face. That was the currency. The value. The part of her that mattered. Everything else was interchangeable, replaceable, disposable.

Her reflection blurred as another memory surged up—one she didn't want, didn't summon, didn't permit:

Hordak's breath against her cheek. The metal of the blade kissing her face, cold and steady. His hand gripping her hair as he spoke against her ear.

"I'm going to take my time with you."

His voice, low. Savouring. Cruel.

Her body in the chair. The ropes biting into her wrists. Her breath hitching when she failed—not for lack of trying—to stifle a whimper. His hips grinding against her arm, deliberate and revolting. His excitement building when she recoiled.

She had known what was coming. She had known she had to distract him, delay him, stall him. She had known—

Catra yanked herself out of the memory so hard her vision pulsed white.

As she continued to stare into the mirror, her mind went perfectly blank—a slate wiped clean, empty, airless. She felt nothing. Her limbs weren’t hers. Her face wasn’t hers. The world had gone thin around her edges, muffled and distant.

This wasn’t her usual cold. This wasn’t that familiar, convenient freeze she could slip into. This was something deeper. Something that gutted her from the inside out. Something that swallowed whatever she still had inside of her and left a shell in its place.

At this point, she didn't know if she would be able to climb back out. She wasn’t sure she wanted to anymore.

She stayed standing, eyes locked with her reflection, for what could have been an eternity.

It was Marzo that finally broke through.

Not the sound of him—no, his voice only reached her as if spoken underwater. It was the touch. His fingers brushing her shoulder; gentle and cautious.

The world snapped back into harsh clarity.

Catra jerked away from him. Her lungs filled. Her muscles remembered themselves. Her eyes refocused.

Marzo stood behind her in the mirror, posture straight, expression too carefully neutral to be anything but concern. Or maybe Catra imagined that part. Maybe the morning's light changed things. Maybe the mirror's glass was warped.

She didn’t check.

She pulled the curtain closed over the mirror with a sharp swish. Buried the reflection.

“I suppose it’s time,” Catra said, her voice brisk and cold. “Tell me you bathed. I refuse to walk beside you if you smell like you look.”

Marzo nodded once. “I maintain good hygiene, your highness.”

“Good.” She said sternly. “Keep it that way.”

He stepped aside, letting her pass from the tent. Catra walked ahead without looking back, without checking whether he followed—knowing he would.

✧

The Etherian camp did not stink—not in the way a Horde barracks did. It was its own kind of assault, a layered haze of sharp incense and charmed smoke, a sweetness that burned the inside of Catra’s nose. Mages drifted between the tents like perfumed ghosts, carrying bundles of foreign wood that hissed and crackled as they burned. It reminded her more of the Crimson Wastes than the Fright Zone—wild, unfamiliar scents, ritualistic little fires glowing everywhere. No stink of oil, no metal tang of war forges. Everything too neat.

It made her want to claw her skin off.

She walked with a steady rhythm as she entered the heart of the camp, but it wasn’t the smell that nearly undid her—it was the eyes.

Hundreds of them. Row after row of precise, uniform blue tents, every Etherian stationed between them turning to stare at her with open hostility, barely restrained curiosity, or outright murderous intent. Adora’s soldiers; Salineans and Snows. All of them watching one lone Horde Princess walk straight into their lines like she belonged here.

Her honour guard might as well have stayed home. They were a visible gesture, nothing more. Decorative and insufficient.

Catra didn’t let any of that show. Her spine was straight. Her hands steady at her sides. Her expression bored, faintly annoyed—as if she were walking through a market she found beneath her notice.

Inside, her heartbeat skipped so hard that she felt the impact jar her rib cage.

She was outnumbered beyond any reasonable measure. Under normal circumstances, she would never have risked approaching an enemy camp without a show of force, but this wasn't meant to be intimidation.

It was a stage.

A performance.

You are no threat to me, she wanted the camp to read on every line of her body. *I walk alone because I do not tremble.*

And she was, as always, a very convincing liar.

She wore red. Only red. No black trim. No shadows sewn to her sleeves. She would not give this army—nor its Queen—the satisfaction of thinking she mourned anything or anyone anymore. Even if the effort of holding her chin up made her stomach flutter with nausea

Then she felt it.

Adora's attention. Like a spotlight. Like a hand closing around her throat. She could sense it even before she turned her head, before she fully halted—as if Adora had reached out and hooked straight into her spinal column, dragging her forward by something beneath her skin.

Catra barely let herself stop before she looked.

There she was.

The true and rightful Queen of Etheria. Not Mara, not a slave, not flirtatious and loving beside her in bed. Adora stood on a raised wooden platform, seated moments ago on a throne carved of dark wood and bright runes.

She-Ra's form was resplendent—Bare arms, bare thighs, the gleam of gold, the cut of strength visible in every shift of her posture. Her hair bright, her face drawn and tired and still devastatingly composed. Catra knew the feel of that body. She felt it now like memory echoing under her palms—if a little smaller.

Catra had to bite down on the urge to imagine her in this form above her as she—

And around Adora's wrist, glinting in the sunlight.

The cuff.

Still there.

Why? Why in all possible worlds was she still wearing that?

It didn't matter. It couldn't matter. It was bait, a trap, a symbol—she refused to let it pull at the soft, stupid part of her chest that still wanted to believe anything good about the woman who had left her.

Adora rose.

Every soldier's eyes dropped.

Not one of them did the same for Catra.

Catra stepped forward, her boots striking the ground with slow strides. They had cleared a path for her, though she knew she deserved none of the courtesy. Enemy soldiers lined the way like teeth in a jaw.

She passed within arm's reach of dozens of weapons. Swords. Spears. Bows strung tight. She heard someone inhale sharply as she drew near, as if readying themselves to lunge.

She imagined—briefly, painfully—how quick it could be. How simple. How welcome. A blade slipping beneath her ribs. A spear through her stomach. Pain that had an ending.

Finally.

But none of them moved.

Adora didn’t look away from Catra. Catra didn’t look away from Adora.

Bits of the past flashed sharp at the edges of her mind—

I hear we have a new shipment of potential soldiers, she had said.

Catra had felt thirteen again seeing Adora on that cargo ship. She felt justified in having her stripped, collared, kneeling before her.

Now Adora looked at her with that same disturbing intensity—but it wasn’t fury.

It wasn’t a carnal lust.

Catra’s breath stuttered in her chest.

When they reached speaking distance, she lifted her chin, ignoring the tremor in her stomach, and addressed her in the First One’s tongue.

“My sister of Etheria.”

Her voice did not waver.

Adora’s reply matched the formality, matched the ritual—but not the tone.

“My sister of the Horde.”

And her eyes—those infuriating, honest, earnest eyes—held something Catra hadn’t been prepared for.

Not hatred.

Not disgust.

Not that cold, righteous judgement she'd steeled herself to endure.

Longing.

Raw and terrible longing.

Catra felt something inside her twist so sharply she almost staggered.

She could have handled anger. She could have handled contempt. She could have handled threats, insults, accusations—

But longing?

She didn't know what the fuck to do with longing.

Adora extended her hand.

Protocol made the gesture inevitable—expected, even—but Catra still felt her body lock up, her instincts clashing with every civil rule she'd drilled into herself overnight. She did not take Adora's hand. Not properly. She let her own hover, then lowered it just enough for her fingertips to rest lightly atop the Queen's palm.

Even that slight touch sent a shock through her skin, sharp and painful.

She kept her expression bored. Detached. She would sooner bite off her own tongue than betray the way her pulse jumped at the contact.

Those hands had held her with such impossible gentleness—warm, steady, so careful with her body as if every inch of her mattered. Catra shoved the memory down viciously. That had been Mara. That had been a lie. She would not indulge in familiar ghosts now.

Adora's hand was warm. And the worst part was how familiar she still felt beneath Catra's fingers. How easy it would be—too easy—

to fall right back into thinking that meant anything.

She removed her hand the second etiquette allowed.

Adora only inclined her head and escorted her forward, her movements as polished and practiced as any queen born to authority. Catra matched her step for step. A performance. A compromise.

This was the arrangement: the Queen would lead her to the seat placed beside her own. Catra would accept the gesture without bristling. They would sit. They would pretend their alliance was unshakable. She would behave as if the night before had not flayed her open.

Catra lowered herself into the chair.

Instantly, the temperature in the tent seemed to drop. The outrage from the surrounding, staring Etherians was not subtle; they didn't want it to be. Fury crackled along the ranks like a storm.

Soldiers glared. Mages hissed things under their breaths. One woman actually spat on the ground in front of her.

And Catra smiled back as if it pleased her to invite so much fury.

Adora did not glance at them. She did not reprimand them. She simply straightened in her throne, shoulders squared, jaw set, and spoke with a voice that carried over the murmured outrage:

"We have called you here today to witness our accord. Today we mark the alliance."

The outright uproar was immediate.

Muffled curses. Startled shouts. People stepping forward without forethought before being yanked back down by comrades. The sound of a hundred hands dropping to hilts.

Catra didn’t flinch at any of it. Not at the venom. Not at the sneers. Not at the way one soldier actually reached for her bow before Adora shot her a glare that made het spine lock straight.

She could feel Adora beside her—solid, unmoving, a wall of radiant power. It was infuriating how steady she felt. How grounding her presence was, even after everything. Catra hated that she drew a breath more easily simply because Adora was not flinching. Hated it so much she wanted to snarl at herself.

But hate or not, Catra used it.

She used Adora’s steadiness. She used the memory of how strong those hands had felt holding her. She used every scrap of stability she could steal because she needed it, and she was done lying to herself about needing anything.

There would come a day when she didn’t look to Adora for strength.

Today was not that day.

When the crowd had quieted enough to be spoken over, Catra lifted her own voice:

“In the Fright Zone,” she said, “it is customary to bestow a gift upon a favoured companion.”

Not friend. Not ally. *Companion*. A word chosen for its edges—diplomatic, but intimate enough to twist in the Etherians’ guts.

And twist they did. Catra saw shoulders stiffen. Saw eyes widen. Saw one soldier mutter something to his neighbour that made the other choke on air.

She kept going.

She kept her voice steady and smooth. She did not falter. She would not falter.

She had read enough speeches—her mother's sparse, razor-edged orations, the stiff old tomes she forced herself to memorize. She had survived enough arenas, enough humiliations, enough crowds baying for her blood. And humiliation had a way of sanding down a child's fear until she could speak before a kingdom without blinking.

There was no natural grandeur. No divine glow. No heroic aura.

But she could still hold a crowd.

She could still bare her teeth and speak like a ruler who knew exactly what she was owed.

And she did not stutter. She did not blush or look away, as she might have seven years ago.

She spoke like the Princess she had become—sharp, scarred, and unafraid.

Catra flicked two fingers toward her attendants.

They moved at once—trained to read her smallest gestures—and brought forth the object she had ordered them to conceal beneath a length of embroidered red silk. A ridiculous level of formality for what lay beneath it. A level of formality Catra had insisted upon anyway.

There was a strange, sour twist in her stomach as they approached. She couldn't tell whether it was dread or anticipation. She didn't favour either option.

She shouldn't have brought the damn thing. She shouldn't have kept it after that night—not in her tent, not near her skin, not hidden away like some pathetic love-token. She should have thrown it into the sea the moment she woke in the bed they'd shared.

But she hadn't.

She had tried, more than once, to understand why. She had yet to come up with an answer she liked.

It felt almost absurd now, thinking back to the woman she'd been a week ago—softened by closeness and trust, believing she'd found something real. A possibility for a future that was not poisoned.

The woman she had been then felt like a stranger now.

Her chest tightened—not with hatred. That would had been easier, cleaner. What she felt now was worse in its smallness: a hollow yearning for something that had never really existed, a bruise where hope had been, and the tired, embarrassed ache of someone who had let herself be made the fool.

Hands still, face perfectly composed, she watched as the silk was pulled away.

The leather-wrapped handle gleamed dully in the morning light.

What it had been made from was almost completely unrecognizable.

Unless you had intimate knowledge of the original item in question.

Anyone else would see only a finely crafted ceremonial gift. But Adora was not anyone else. Catra saw the exact instant recognition struck her. The tightening of her jaw. The sharp inhale she tried—and failed—to hide.

Good.

Good. Let her remember.

Let her feel it.

The handle was a message, and Catra did not care whether Adora understood it fully or only in fragments. Either possibility served a

purpose.

Catra held it out, her expression poised and controlled. Her voice even.

“A symbol of favour,” she said. “And of trust.”

Trust. The irony nearly made her laugh.

She let her gaze drift to the whip handle—resized, polished, meaningless to anyone who didn’t know. All evidence of its former purpose cut and cleaned away, lacquered over, turned into something respectable and presentable.

But Catra remembered the truth of it.

She remembered the way Adora—Mara—had used it in those moments when Catra had wanted her so badly it bordered on agony. She remembered how it had felt deep within her body.

Adora had wielded it.

Adora had been inside her.

Adora had made her unravel.

And now Catra was giving it away like the useless, sentimental scrap it was.

She would not keep any relics of that night. She would not cling to anything that could weaken her.

She watched Adora take the whip's handle. Watched the flicker of shame, or anger, or desire—Catra couldn’t really tell, and she didn’t care. She watched Adora fight to keep her expression still.

Catra felt nothing. Not satisfaction. Nor triumph. Nor grief.

Just the echoing, cavernous numbness that had hollowed out inside her.

This was not about their night.

It was not about old wounds or the new ones they'd inflicted on each other.

It was about Prime. Ending him for good.

She would endure until the last breath left Prime's body.

Everything else was *nothing*.

Chapter End Notes

Catra is the Queen of misreading emotions.

Chapter 9: Adora

Chapter Notes

Beta read by nbc22 ❤️

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora kept her face still. Her spine straight. Her breathing was measured. She had done battle with clone armies, thrown herself into impossible odds, stared Horde Prime himself in the eyes—and yet none of that had prepared her for the tight, sickening pull low in her stomach as Catra unveiled the whip.

"These are the men who attacked the Etherian village," Catra announced—calm, controlled, sure of every syllable. "Clan mercenaries. Loyalty bought by Prime. Sent to slaughter your people and sabotage the fragile peace."

A ripple went through the Etherian pavilion—shock, revulsion, fury. Frosta's face went white under its usual scowl; her soldiers stiffened. Adora felt the weight of their anger rolling off them, heavy as winter surf.

She tried not to look at the thing sitting on the cushion beside her chair. Catra's *gift*.

The handle alone was enough to make her ears burn red with shame. Smoothed leather, refinished wood—utterly innocuous to anyone who had not once buckled it between her thighs and used it on the woman now sitting beside her. But Adora remembered. Every part of her body remembered how it had felt to use it on Catra.

And tlooking at he lashes—the five heavy cords, each tipped with a weighted obsidian barb—it was all she could do to keep herself from balling up her fists so tightly that a bone or two cracked.

Catra stood at the center of it all as though she were immune to scrutiny—like the hatred pouring off half the pavilion and the awe pouring off the other half simply slid over her skin like water.

"The whip and the men," Catra said, voice cutting through the humid quiet, "are The Fright Zone's gift to Etheria."

Then Catra turned her gaze—slowly, deliberately—toward Adora.

"The first fifty strikes," she said, quietly, "are mine to give you."

A hard, hot jolt went through Adora's chest before she could stop it. Shock, humiliation, the way those five barbs could just as easily be five sharp claws—whatever it was, she strangled it immediately. Her face didn't move.

But the pavilion reacted.

A thrum of approval, vicious and eager. Soldiers relaxing. Officers nodding once, sharp. The Princesses exchanging raised brows and satisfied murmurs. It was ugly, the way more pain soothed people who had been dealt nothing but pain themselves. Ugly, and horribly effective.

Catra had read the mood perfectly.

Adora watched Horde handlers hammer the whipping blocks into the packed dirt, testing the stakes. Watched the stripped mercenaries dragged forward. Watched the way Catra didn't so much as blink as they were strapped down.

A part of Adora—some sharp, self-loathing little shard she didn't like to examine—recognized the brilliance of the maneuver. Catra had slapped her across the face in the most intimate way possible, and simultaneously handed her entire army a feast of righteous vengeance to soothe her allies.

Adora heard herself say, with the flat, ritual dignity expected of a monarch, "The Fright Zone is very generous."

Catra did not smile. But her blue and gold eyes gleamed.

"After all," Catra said, voice low, too soft for anyone but Adora to hear, "I remember what you like."

Adora's throat closed. Her pulse thudded painfully at the base of her skull. She felt heat claw up her neck, and she forced it down—forced her hands not to clench, forced her gaze forward, forced everything in her to stay still, stay formal, stay *Queenly*.

The call went out.

Five Horde handlers raised five long whips. One Etherian soldier, from the Kingdom of Snows, raised the gifted whip.

Adora did manage to hold back her cringe as the Snows Soldier lifted the whip by the handle.

It was clean. I cleaned it. It—

Adora didn't let herself look at Catra again. She fixed her eyes forward as the first strike cracked through the air—and the first mercenary arched off the block with a hoarse, animal scream.

It took time. Fifty lashes was not a moment. It was an ordeal—muscle and effort. Each handler had to pace themselves to avoid tiring. The blows landed in slow, brutal rhythm. Flesh split. Blood spattered. Some men sobbed; others tried to hold back sound until pain pulled the noises from them anyway.

Adora forced herself to watch.

This is justice, she told herself. *For what they did to our villagers. To the children. This is the price*.

But the truth scraped at the back of her mind: Catra understood better than anyone how to feed a crowd's hunger. How to make violence into currency.

And how to make Adora remember things she needed so desperately to forget.

When it was done, the handlers moved in, efficient and almost gentle as they cut the men down. Some bodies slumped bonelessly, clearly dead. Others trembled, limp with shock. It took several soldiers to lift each one; no one could tell who was still breathing.

Catra spoke again, voice carrying clean and sharp:

"Furthermore: Hell's Rest's bounty is yours. Our physicians will tend your wounded. Our granaries will feed your soldiers. The victory at Seaspray was earned by Etherian blood. The Fright Zone will not profit from what you suffered to secure."

A murmur—astonishment, approval, grudging respect—rolled through the pavilion like a change in wind.

Mermista had warned her she would lose Frosta.

Adora realized, with a twist in her gut, that Catra was doing something far more dangerous:

Winning her.

Winning *all* of them.

Catra hadn't moved from where she sat but Adora felt pulled toward her.

Her army wanted to follow this woman.

And Adora… Adora didn't know what she wanted.

Only that she didn't want to stay away.

Adora said, "We have a gift too."

Catra's display had held the Etherians' tempers in check, but barely. Adora could still feel the split.

She reached into herself for the steadiness She-Ra gave her, yet she still needed to be Adora for this. Or maybe she needed to be Mara—the one Catra once knew.

"Everyone here knows what happened to me in your hands," Adora said, loudly enough to carry. "You all know she kept me as a slave."

There was no gasp—everyone had already heard the rumors. But hearing it from Adora herself made something tighten in the crowd.

"I wear her cuff," she went on, lifting her wrist. "And today, the Princess of the Horde will stand at my side as an equal."

She motioned, and a servant brought the wrapped item forward. The weight of it was familiar in a way Adora hated.

"You asked for this once," Adora said.

The cloth dropped. The platinum cuff gleamed—unmistakably the twin to hers.

Catra didn't move. Her expression didn't break. But something flickered through her eyes—barely there and then gone.

Then Catra extended her hand. Palm up.

"Go on," Catra said, voice low, steady. Not soft. Not mocking. Just… exposed in a way she was desperately pretending not to be. "Put it on."

Every pair of eyes in the tent burned into them.

Adora leaned closer. She unbuttoned Catra's sleeve with fingers that she forced not to shake. Catra's skin was warm, the tendons shifting under Adora's hand. Her pulse was quick under Adora's touch.

“My throne for your throne,” Adora said quietly, but clearly enough that the front rows heard every word. “Help me take back Bright Moon from Prime—and I’ll make sure you are Queen of the Horde.”

She locked the cuff around Catra’s wrist.

The click was too loud. Or maybe Adora just felt it too strongly.

Catra didn’t pull away. She lifted her wrist slightly, letting the light catch on the metal. Showing it off. Daring the Etherians to react.

“Oh, I’ll cherish it,” Catra said. Her tone was dry, smooth, almost bored—except for the look she gave Adora. “It's nice to have something from you to remember our time together."

The horns sounded. Refreshments were brought. The ceremony resumed.

Adora sat beside Catra as the display duels began. She kept her posture perfect, her expression unbothered.

Catra watched the fighters with polite interest, chin propped on one hand, as if cataloguing threats was just another pleasant task.

Adora could feel Frosta’s cold stare like a shard of ice being slowly pushed between her ribs.

The young Princess sat rigidly among her soldiers, expression carved clean, not a flicker of reaction visible—but Adora had known her long enough to read the tautness in her jaw, the anger she was clamping down on with iron control. Frosta didn’t melt easily.

Across from her, Entrapta was joyfully piling sweets onto a plate, humming to herself. Her hair drifted and curled, reaching politely (and then impolitely) over bowls, brushing serving platters, coiling around a goblet to carry it haphazardly back to Catra’s accompanying soldiers.

Entrapta—

Adora swallowed. Steadied herself. Then: “Are you going to tell me how Entrapta is alive?”

Catra didn’t even bother with a sympathetic pause. “Double Trouble.”

Adora blinked. “That’s Double Trouble?”

“No,” Catra said, tone bone-dry. “That is a present from them.”

She didn’t elaborate. And after a beat, Catra added with a curl of her lip, “Prime and his clones. He's never met moral line he didn’t want to cross.”

Before Adora could press—before she could ask the fifty questions boiling in her chest—Frosta approached.

Catra’s posture changed, just perceptibly, the way a cat tenses when another predator enters its space.

Frosta stopped before the twin thrones. She dipped her head to Adora with crisp, formal respect.

Then she looked at Catra.

She did not bow. Not even a nod.

Her gaze slid over Catra slowly—unapologetically disdainful. Frosta’s hatred of the Horde ran deep; she’d grown up on stories of mangled villages and mourning families. Her opinion of Catra had been near abysmal even before Seaspray.

“If this is supposed to be an alliance between equals,” Frosta said, voice cool enough to frost the braziers, “it’s a shame we aren’t seeing any Horde fighting on display.”

Adora winced internally.

You’re watching more than you know, she thought.

“Or we could enjoy a duel,” Frosta continued. Her chin lifted a fraction, her voice carrying clearly to the back ranks. “Horde versus Etheria.”

Catra said lazily: “I don't think Entrapta is up for combat right now. Dying makes one rather lethargic I'd imagine.”

Entrapta perked up cheerfully at her name, then immediately lost interest when she spotted a new pastry.

Adora could see exactly what Frosta saw when she looked at Catra—lounging like a cat in a sunbeam, posture loose and elegant, wearing title and rank like perfume instead of armour. To Etherian eyes, she didn’t look like a commander. She looked like a coward.

Frosta’s stare swept Catra up and down again. “Our Queen,” she said, voice hard and cutting, “has an excellent reputation on the battlefield. If this alliance is real, prove it. A demonstration fight between you both.”

Before Adora could even react, Catra spoke.

“But Frosta,” she said sweetly, smiling without warmth, “Adora and I are practically like sisters. I couldn’t bear to hurt her.”

Catra’s fingertip brushed against the back of Adora’s hand—barely a touch, just enough for Adora to feel the tension coiled inside her, the tightness hidden beneath that velvet drawl. Catra looked relaxed, but Adora knew her too well; she recognized the way Catra held herself together by sheer spite.

Heralds entered then, breaking the moment. The treaty was carried forward—parchment in two scripts, side by side, equal, neither above the other. A simple declaration, stripped of ceremony and flourish:

The Fright Zone and Etheria, united against Horde Prime, allied in friendship and common cause.

Adora took the quill first. Her signature came easily—Adora of Bright Moon.

Catra followed. Her handwriting was tidy but strange, the letters sharp, almost too neat. Catra M. The M enormous, looping with a flourish that looked almost absurd.

“To our wondrous union,” Catra said lightly, raising her glass.

Adora matched it, because she had to.

And just like that, it was done.

Catra rose. Her retinue rose. Red banners streamed behind her like a river of blood in silk. She didn’t look back as she left the pavilion, her procession retreating across the field in a straight, slicing wound.

✧

The Etherians filed out in orderly streams—princesses, commanders, squires, and even the slaves assigned to break down the pavilion—until the tent felt suddenly cavernous. Then it was just Adora and Mermista.

Mermista didn’t bother to hide her expression. Her eyes were cold, furious, and—most painful of all—utterly knowing. The look of someone who had grown up beside her. A piercing gaze, spearing right through the mask to which she was still trying to hold so tightly.

“You gave her Salineas,” Mermista said flatly.

Adora stiffened. “It wasn’t—”

“A lover's gift?” Mermista cut in.

“That is—too far.”

“Really?” Mermista’s brows arched. “Because I remember Ephre. And Hima. And Naqhis’s daughter. And Sibs—the villager from Tiggress—”

“That’s enough.” Adora’s jaw locked. She couldn’t stand to hear those names dredged up now—paraded out like charges in a trial. She stared down at the goblet instead. After a breath, she lifted it, hoping for steadiness. The wine hit her tongue like bile.

“You don’t need to talk,” Mermista said. “I *saw* her.”

“I don’t care what you think you saw.” Adora’s voice came out harder than she meant. “It’s not that.”

“Oh, I think it’s *exactly* that.” Mermista folded her arms. “She’s beautiful and impossible and you—Adora, in your whole life you’ve never been told ‘no’ by someone you wanted. So you did the predictable thing: you dragged an entire world into an alliance because the Princess of the Horde has cool eyes and a feisty attitude.”

Adora’s grip tightened on the goblet. She wanted—absurdly—to crush it in her hand. Let the glass cut her palm. Something sharp, something real. Something she could bleed for instead of sitting here being dissected by someone she loved.

“How many times,” Mermista said in a low, awful voice, “does Etheria have to suffer because you can’t keep it in your—”

“I said that’s enough.” Adora surged to her feet. Her whole body was shaking—anger or shame or both, she couldn’t tell. “Don’t finish that sentence.”

Mermista stopped, but she didn’t look away. Adora hated that most of all—Mermista’s calm, relentless honesty. She’d always been like that: blunt, bracing—like ice water to the face.

“Do you honestly think,” Adora said, each word ground out, “that I would risk Etheria because I—because I was—attracted—to her?”

Mermista stared at her. “Yes. I do. Because she’s the Princess of the Horde, and she doesn’t care about Etheria. And you—gods, Adora, you’re pretending you’re not affected by her. Open your eyes.”

Adora turned away. She stalked to the open front of the pavilion and stopped there, the daylight washing over her. The Horde camp sat across the field like a wound in the landscape—Catra had already vanished inside.

“You want her,” Mermista said behind her, quiet but unwavering. “Why wouldn’t you? She’s… she’s striking. And she’s unfamiliar here. And she’s your rank. And she hates you, which—fine—apparently you like that about her, too.”

Adora made a sound like someone had punched her.

“So here’s my advice,” Mermista continued. “Fuck her. Get it out of your system. Then remember that she’s just another princess. You don't need to blow up an entire political future because you’re curious about what she’s like in your bed.”

The silence that followed was raw and jagged.

Adora didn’t move.

She could feel Mermista realise what that responding silence meant.

When Adora finally turned, Mermista’s expression had gone dreadfully sour.

“So Salineas really was just a token of your affection…” Mermista whispered.

“Yes.” Adora forced the word out. “I slept with her.”

Her throat clenched. She pushed through it.

"It was one night. She barely even… *let go*. I won't pretend I didn't—want her. But she's the Princess of the Horde. I'm the Queen of Etheria. This, *now*, is politics. Nothing more."

It sounded unconvincing. Even to her own ears.

"Do you think it helps," Mermista said bitterly, "to know she's beautiful and clever and cold enough to turn you inside out?"

Adora closed her eyes.

Because no—no, it didn't help at all.

The words hit her like a fist to the sternum. For a moment, Adora couldn't draw breath at all.

Her thoughts travelled back to that humid midsummer night on Bright Moon's balcony when Mermista had tried, still gently, then, to warn her.

Now the softness was gone.

"It's not the same," Adora said quietly.

"No?" Mermista's eyes were dark, sharp. "Catra is not Glimmer?"

"I'm not the girl who trusted her," Adora said. "Not anymore."

Mermista's expression flickered. "Then you're not Adora."

Adora let out a brittle laugh—one that hurt her throat. "You're right. I'm not. Adora died in Bright Moon when she didn't listen to you."

She heard the echo of Mermista's words from that night:

Glimmer has always believed she deserved the throne. That you took it from her.

And her own foolish reply:

She wouldn't hurt me. We're family. We're—

"Catra and I are nothing," she said now, voice scraped raw.

"Then listen this time," said Mermista.

"I am listening. I know exactly who Catra is. And that's why I can't—" She stopped herself. "Why I can't have her."

"No. You're not listening at all." Mermista stepped closer, lowering her voice as if speaking to a stubborn recruit. "You trust with your whole chest. It's… infuriating. When you see someone as an enemy, you're immovable—you see a straight line to the fight. But when you love someone? When you give a woman your loyalty, that's it. She's perfect in your eyes. You'd defend her with your last breath. You'd shut out every warning. You'd go to the grave smiling with her dagger between your ribs."

Adora swallowed. Hard.

"And don't act like you're any different," she shot back. "I know what standing with me costs you. If I'm wrong, you won't just lose Salineas. You lose everything."

Mermista held her gaze, then let out a long, weary exhale and scrubbed a hand over her face, dragging her fingers across her cheekbone like she could massage the exhaustion away.

"The Princess of the Horde," she muttered, voice dripping with disbelief. She lifted her brows in that exaggerated way she'd had since childhood—a silent *seriously*? that once would've made Adora laugh.

For a heartbeat, they were kids again. Bare legs kicking in the surf. Hair plastered to their faces with seawater. Teasing, bickering, trying not to get caught stealing sweetcakes from the kitchens.

Then reality returned.

“Can you imagine,” Mermista said dryly, “what your mom would say if she knew?”

“Yes,” said Adora. Her lips twisted. “Probably something about poor life choices. She would be smart to be wary of Catra.”

A pause.

“Which one was Sibs, again?” Adora asked.

Mermista blinked. “All of them. It was a whole village of white tiger-folk. You gave the ones you slept with the same nickname so you wouldn't slip up and call them the wrong name.”

Adora winced. “Right.”

Mermista took a step closer. Her voice softened, but only slightly. “You can’t trust Catra.”

“I know that.” Adora tipped back the last of the wine. It burned down her throat, too warm, too bitter. Outside the pavilion, the camp bustled—shouting soldiers, clanking armour, dozens of demands waiting for the Queen of Etheria. “You’ve spent one morning with her and you’re warning me off,” Adora said. “Just wait.”

“Wait for what?” Mermista asked incredulously. “To like her more?”

Adora gave her a long look. “Wait until you’ve spent a full *day* with her.”

Mermista stared at her. “You mean she gets better?”

“Not exactly,” Adora said. “You'll just… acclimate.”

Mermista groaned. “Stars help us.”

Chapter End Notes

My partner really said to me today, "You don't get more than like 200 hits on your stories on ao3, right?" 🥹

I love how much you guys love this fic and I'm slightly afraid of finishing it 😅

That's a problem that's 33 chapters away.

And I'm planning the next She-Ra series I want to write which will be exploring an Etheria where the First Ones succeeded in taking the magic from Etheria. (I already have a playlist started)

So once this is gone, I will keep writing She-Ra/Catradora, don't worry.

Chapter 10: Catra

"Name?"

The serving boy froze like someone had hit him with a stun baton. His elbows jerked, the pitcher in his hands swayed dangerously, and he nearly sloshed water all over the floor before he managed to set it down. His cheeks went instantly pink—he was *absolutely* the blushing type.

"My name is Ryen, your highness."

"Stop that," Catra said flatly. "The blushing. It's pointless. I'm not complimenting you by learning your name, and I'm certainly not going to start… what do people call it—*bonding*." She wiggled her foot, trying to ease her heel out of her boot. It refused to budge. "I'm warning you now: I do not get nicer. I will not become invested in you as a person. And if I have to repeat myself, it will only make me angry. Are we communicating clearly enough for your two functional brain cells?"

Ryen swallowed hard. "Your—your highness?"

With an irritated huff, Catra braced both hands on the floor and yanked her foot free. The boot finally released her with a wet pop. She flung it toward the pile of gear near her bedside; it thudded loudly, and Ryen flinched.

"I asked your name because you're *slightly* less incompetent than the rest of the recruits Prime threw at me." She rubbed her aching arch with two fingers, wincing. "Do not misread that as interest. My last servant won't be returning from her current *situation*—so I need one of you idiots to be marginally trained before I lose another morning to poorly brewed coffee and dropped trays."

His mouth worked soundlessly.

"And before you panic," Catra said, reaching for her other boot, "I don't expect you to volunteer whether or not you're spying for

Prime. I don’t care. If you admit it out loud, you’ll only annoy me. But regardless, you'll bring my coffee. I’m not training you out of trust; I’m doing it because I refuse to be inconvenienced by Mara’s absence.”

This second boot was determined to make her suffer. Frustrated, she went to tug at it with her bad arm before realizing her mistake. Fiery pain shot all the way up her shoulder. She snarled under her breath and switched arms, finally getting the boot, grudgingly, to wiggle.

Still silence.

She snapped her gaze upward. “Say something, Ryen. Anything. A grunt would do. I need to know you grasp even one word of what I just said.”

Ryen blurted, face going a deeper shade of pink, “Your highness… do you… do you really keep a head in that box?”

Catra stared at him. Very slowly, she turned her head toward the carved wooden box to which he referred, now sitting in the chair that had once been reserved for Adora during their nightly councils. Then back to him.

She sighed through her nose. “Well. This is a disaster.”

“I—I’m sorry?”

“You’re dismissed. Go. Before I say something you’ll cry about.” She waved vaguely toward the tent flap. “On your way out, fetch Marzo. He’s skulking somewhere.”

“I was not skulking,” Marzo said, stepping inside almost immediately. He folded his arms as if he intended to scowl the accusation away.

Catra didn’t bother acknowledging the lie. “Good. You’re here.”

Marzo entered as though he'd walked through a hundred war tents and seen a thousand rattled commanders—and he probably had. He did not bow or look reverent or stand hovering at attention the way Lonnie once had. Nor did he possess Adora's aggravating swagger, that unconscious assumption that any battlefield, throne room, or hallway was improved by his presence.

Marzo simply strode in to take his proper place: a seasoned general consulting a commander. Nothing more, nothing less.

He glanced at the maps on Catra's table—the ones she and Adora had once leaned over together, shoulder to shoulder, arguing about troop formations until dawn. His eyes seemed to unerringly follow a thread only he could see.

"I've heard," Marzo said at last, "that you and the Queen of Etheria once spent entire nights planning together." There was no accusation—just wary interest. "I'm beginning to see the shape of the path that led to my defeat." He moved toward the chair nearest the maps. "Not that it matters. Whatever tricks the Etherians have, a Horde soldier can match them."

"I didn't call you here to compare combat resumés," Catra snapped.

Marzo frowned. "I am your Captain. Your Second. If you have concerns—"

"We have a strategy meeting in the morning," she cut in. "With our *allies*."

The word tasted sour.

Marzo's jaw flexed. Not anger—disapproval. He was bracing for her to do something reckless. He didn't understand her, not yet. He would, eventually.

Right now, though, they were both stiff-backed, annoyed, and entirely unwilling to back down.

They stared at each other across the room—Catra tense and coiled on the stool, Marzo standing straight as a pike, both of them radiating irritation—locked in a silent, stubborn stalemate.

"Don't tell me," Catra said, stretching her leg out with calculated laziness, "you've already forgotten our *glorious* alliance? The Etherian who knocked your army on its ass and killed your Lord? I'm not strategizing without her."

Marzo's jaw worked. "No—how could I forget? Not even *your mother* managed peace with those creatures." He didn't raise his voice; he didn't need to. His eyes said everything. *Child*. *Fool. Traitor to your own. You let an Etherian between your legs and call it diplomacy.*

Catra's answering smile was small, sharp, and vicious.

"Yes, well," she said lightly, "I doubt my mother ever tried bending over for one."

The words hit their mark. Marzo's mouth thinned to a white line.

"Your highness—"

"It's true," Catra went on, silk-sweet and obscene. "You wouldn't *believe* how cooperative an Etherian gets when you're bouncing in her lap—suddenly very open to negotiation."

"Your—your highness!" His voice cracked over the edge of propriety. Catra leaned back, privately delighted, wondering how far she could push him. Could she make him snap? Make him spill treason in his irritation? Or shake him until he admitted the thing he clearly thought—that she'd traded her dignity for an Etherian's bed?

He saw the intent forming in her eyes.

He refused to break.

“I assumed,” Marzo forced out, slow and taut, “that you called me here for a reason.”

Catra blinked innocently at him, then extended her foot.

“I can’t get my boot off,” she said, pairing the words with an exaggerated little pout, childish and venomous all at once.

The flare of fury that lit Marzo’s face was almost beautiful

“I’m not your damned *slave*,” he snapped, turning sharply away. “Get Entrapta to do it. She was practiced at kneeling for others, wasn’t she?”

Catra’s smile widened despite her rage at his comment.

“Spend a second night with Entrapta in my tent?” she said. “What a scandal that would be.”

Marzo’s gaze flicked—briefly, darkly—to the carved box on Catra’s chair. Kyle’s box. Something in his expression soured, like milk left in the sun.

“You already have a chaperone,” he muttered.

Catra’s smile did not falter. Not even a tremor shifted her expression.

And her foot—still stretched toward him—didn’t move.

✧

They couldn’t march for Bright Moon at once. Not unless they wanted their armies to arrive hungry, disorganized, and missing half their supplies. Even the Etherians, coiled with impatience to tear Prime off his stolen throne, understood the necessity of planning.

So breakfast at Hell’s Rest it was.

The audience chamber—the pride of the fort, a cavernous room of carved stone and ribbed vaults—had been transformed into something absurdly domestic for the occasion. Baker had pushed two long tables to face one another, draped them in her best lace cloths, and set out a third table groaning with food she pretended not to have stayed up all night preparing.

It was strangely intimate, this forced civility atop centuries of bloodshed.

Catra entered last, leading Entrapta and Marzo behind her. The Etherians were already in their places—no surprises there. Adora held the center, practically springing to her feet the moment Catra crossed the threshold. She was quick about it, not graceful; as if she'd been caught off-guard by her own impulse to rise.

Mermista, at Adora's right, stood more slowly. One could mistake it for poise, if not for the flicker of judgment she didn't bother to hide.

Frosta remained seated. Predictably. Arms folded, jaw tight, radiating teenage attitude. Catra imagined her plate icing over under the intensity of that glare.

"I do hope we didn't keep the Queen of Etheria waiting," Catra said lightly, settling into First Ones with an inflection that was almost completely fluent.

Adora opened her mouth, but Frosta cut across her.

"Trouble picking a ribbon for your tail?" she asked without looking up.

"Of course," Catra said smoothly. "But as you see, I heroically chose to deny the world the experience. I trust you'll recover."

Frosta's snarl was very nearly audible.

Catra let her eyes sweep, unhurried, to Mermista. "Princess," she said in cordial greeting. "My apologies for not addressing you

yesterday. Our letters have been the highlight of my month, I assure you. Shall we sit?”

Mermista looked genuinely startled that Catra could identify her without prompting, as if the fishy lower half wasn't a massive giveaway. That mild satisfaction sustained Catra long enough to ignore the way Adora’s gaze tried to snag hers.

Not today. Not while Catra still had a kingdom to salvage and her own heart to keep trussed and gagged in the back of her chest.

She motioned Baker forward with a sharp flick of her fingers. “I’ll be working while we eat. But you knew that, or you wouldn’t have cleared so much table space. Coffee?”

“Yes, your highness,” Baker said, already anticipating her needs.

“And writing supplies. I won’t be eating.”

Baker left immediately.

Servants flocked to the table, taking requests. Mermista asked for parchment without looking up; Entrapta requested six different inks and a plate of fruit—cut as tiny as possible; Marzo merely grunted for water. Frosta refused both paper and food entirely.

Catra waited until her second cup of coffee was poured before she continued.

“My companions are not fluent in First Ones,” she told the Etherians. “Forgive me if I translate. Now—word of the Queen’s return has surely spread. How many Princesses do you anticipate will declare for you?”

She asked the question with the dispassionate cadence of strategy.

But underneath, she savoured Frosta’s flinch, Mermista’s frown, and the quick, subtle stiffening of Adora’s shoulders.

Catra wasn’t here to please them.

She was here to win a war.

✧

It had been a good meeting. *Good* in the sense that no one threw a chair, no one challenged anyone else to a duel, and Catra’s temper hadn’t ignited the tablecloth. By her standards, that meant success.

“We’ll do another one tomorrow morning,” Catra said once the hall had emptied. “And the morning after that. Until we leave.”

She didn’t look up when she said it—she was still sprawled in the same chair she’d occupied throughout the meeting, her boots propped on the table’s edge, notes scattered in a wide semicircle so she could glare at all of them at once. She’d shoved the lace tablecloth aside just enough to keep her heels from scuffing it. She wasn’t completely uncivilized.

Baker didn’t rush to speak. She moved quietly between the other servants, overseeing the cleanup, giving small gestures of instruction that somehow conveyed both “efficiency” and “do not make me repeat myself.”

Catra twirled her pen, watching the painted faces on the wall regard her with infuriating serenity. “And—” she said finally, “I’m… sorry. About the new Entrapta.”

Silence.

Of course.

It was, in its way, the politest possible answer from Baker.

Catra sighed through her nose and leaned back further. “I got your note. About Hordak.”

Baker’s hands paused on a stack of dishes before she answered. “Do you wish him buried?”

“You can feed him to your pigs. If they get sick, I’ll assume it was from his personality leaking into the meat.” Catra flicked her eyes toward Baker, gauging. “Did he have anything interesting on him? Papers? Letters? Some thrilling declaration of undying loyalty to Prime?”

“I will have his effects brought to you,” Baker said. No hesitation. No accusation. No suggestion that she had tampered with them.

Catra’s mouth twisted. “I’m not going to insult you by asking whether you knew what Double Trouble had planned for me. You didn’t.” She scoffed at her own words. “Believe it or not, I’m as shocked as you.”

Baker’s expression barely shifted. “And I will not insult you by advising that you temper your expectations regarding your arrangement with Double Trouble. They will abandon it the moment it ceases to amuse them. Horde Prime has given them comfort.” A small, almost wry tilt of her head. “You, decidedly, will not.”

“They like their cushions and luxuries,” Catra said. “I know.”

“They like being unbound by duty,” Baker replied. “If it comes to choosing between their comforts and you, they will choose themselves.

Catra huffed something that might have been a laugh. “Sounds like you used to run logistics for their conscience.”

Baker ignored the remark—politely, expertly—and glanced toward the spread of notes again. Then she stood, smoothing her apron.

“The room is yours for as long as you need,” she said. “I’ll send more coffee, and I’ll instruct the staff not to disturb you. It may be easier to think in here than in your mother’s tent.”

Catra tossed her pen onto the table, letting it bounce. “Actually, no. I need to see your storerooms.”

That made Baker lift a brow—barely, but Catra caught it.

“Feeding an army costs more than feeding Prime’s ego,” Catra said. “We march by week’s end, and I already promised the Etherians full access to Hell’s Rest’s stores. I need to see the numbers myself so I can calculate exactly how much they’ll drain us.”

Baker inclined her head, the motion crisp and almost regal.

“Hell’s Rest’s bounty is yours,” she said. “I will show you everything.”

Catra pushed herself out of the chair, boots thudding against the floor, and gathered her notes.

“Good,” she said. “If I’m going to bankrupt this place, I’d like to do it accurately.”

✧

It was uneasy, and it wasn’t peace, but it wasn’t war either.

Catra had known worse balances. Whole alliances had collapsed over less.

She managed her… situation… with Adora the only way left to her: by ignoring her as aggressively as one could ignore a woman who must have stood fifteen feet tall, all cut muscle and divine glow, wearing a dress short enough to be considered a declaration of intent. It was no wonder none of the "devastating" outfits Catra had tried on her had worked. Adora had never understood shame. Or modesty. Or how humiliating it was to try not to stare at the thighs of the woman held your heart.

So Catra looked into her eyes.

It was safe there. Less dangerous. A place she could pretend she felt nothing.

The rest—her hand in Catra's, the quiet promise in her voice when she fitted the cuff to her wrist—was shoved into a locked room inside Catra's mind.

This was politics. Strategy. Survival.

Not a playground for her humiliation.

They were going to work with her. Every last one of them. And if any fool thought otherwise, it would only be a matter of time before Catra bent them neatly to her will. She didn't care what slur they muttered or what coward's fantasy they invented about her motives.

When Marzo arrived with his new report—a handful of soldiers making trouble—she cut him off halfway.

"Give me the names," Catra said. "I'll handle it."

She was slouched in her chair, legs stretched out, ankles crossed and resting atop Kyle's box—still on the chair Adora used to take during late-night planning sessions.

The box kept her grounded. Kept her from drifting. Kept her focused on what she owed Prime.

Except it wasn't Kyle.

It was hollow. Heavy. Wrong.

Death stuffed into wood.

Marzo didn't seem to notice it—but his hands tightened slightly on the back of the opposite chair at her command.

"Your highness…" he started.

“What now?” Catra didn’t bother looking up. She made a neat note in the grain ledger, then underlined it twice. “You did the right thing coming to me. I’ll put the matter down fast.”

“There is… another matter.”

His discomfort was unmistakable—tight jaw, eyes flicking anywhere but at her. Catra resisted the urge to savour it. She kept writing.

“My schedule is not expanding,” she said. “If you want to raise the mystery topic, do it before we’re climbing Bright Moon’s walls.”

“I wish to marry,” Marzo blurted.

Catra answered without pause, “I’m flattered. Really. But you don’t bring nearly enough to make a political marriage worth the headache.”

Silence.

Catra finally looked up.

Marzo was wearing field leathers and an expression that was halfway between offense and grim determination.

“You aren’t wearing the right shoes for overthrowing a Princess,” Catra said dryly.

“I'm suppressing the violent urges you inspire the best I can,” he said before realizing what came out of his mouth. He straightened sharply. “Your highness.”

Catra let her feet drop from Kyle’s box. She sat upright, folding the ledger closed with a soft thud.

“Well?” she said, flat.

“I would like to wed before we march,” Marzo said. His tone was controlled now, calculated. “We both know the odds of invading

Bright Moon with Prime holding it. I want the chance to father a child before throwing myself against those odds."

"How practical of you."

"I deserve—" He bit the word off, inhaled once, tried again. "If you won't grant it based on my service to you so far, then grant it based on what I earned under Lord Keldor. I have given a lifetime already. I want something to show for it."

Catra studied him—really studied him—for the first time since he'd entered.

Marzo was loyal, irritating, stubborn, occasionally insubordinate, and absolutely convinced that the universe owed him a queue of rewards he had simply not collected yet. She almost respected it.

Almost.

She leaned back slowly, drumming her claws once against the armrest.

"At least you're honest," she said. "Even if your timing is garbage."

Marzo's jaw clenched, but he held her gaze.

"Keldor," Catra said, dragging the name out like it tasted rotten, "my enemy."

Marzo didn't flinch. "Yes."

"Keldor," she continued, "who never once thought you deserved so much as a wedding day."

Marzo's jaw tightened. "…yes."

They stared each other down. Marzo's grip on the back of Kyle's chair had gone so tight the wood creaked.

"Stop," he said through his teeth. "Stop looking at me like that."

Catra tilted her head. “Like what?”

“Like you’re enjoying yourself.”

“*Stop looking like you’re enjoying yourself, your highness,*” Catra corrected him with hideous sweetness.

He looked a breath from tearing the chair apart—and where would poor Kyle land then?

“How can I not enjoy this?” Catra mused. “For a horrible moment I thought you’d come to confess some tragic, doomed passion for me. I really don’t have time to break in another Captain. Think of the rumours everyone will spread about me then?”

Marzo’s eye twitched. “You flatter yourself.”

“Oh, Saints forbid,” Catra snorted. “Can’t have that.”

She expected him to bristle. Instead, he snapped.

“You want rumours?” he said, stepping forward. “Half the Etherians think you scorched their Queen between the legs as punishment for touching you. They’re saying she hasn’t bedded a single slave since she got back. That she trains herself bloody every night. That the only reason she’s working with us is because you promised to fix her—”

He stopped himself too late. “—with your mother’s magic.”

Catra went motionless.

Every flicker of amusement vanished. Even the twitch of her tail stilled.

“Captain,” she said quietly, “that… is the kind of rumour you bring to me immediately.”

“You—what? You’re not—angry?”

“Oh, I’m absolutely furious,” Catra said brightly. “I just prefer my fury pointed in the right direction.”

Marzo swallowed. “You… didn’t actually—”

“Burn her?” Catra said, leaning forward like she might start laughing or killing someone. “Yes. Obviously. Couldn't resist the temptation to fry a Queen’s crotch in her sleep.”

He stared.

“You’re serious?”

“You really think I’m serious?”

“…no?”

“*Correct*.” Catra snapped upright, arms crossing like armor. “Use your brain, Marzo. If I had done that, Etheria wouldn’t be signing treaties—they’d be skinning me alive.”

Catra for a moment pictured herself as a fine pelt, worn over Adora like a symbol of victory. Sometimes that was how she felt she ought to be.

Marzo scrubbed a hand over his face, then turned toward the tent flap, muttering something that definitely wasn’t respectful.

“Hey,” Catra said sharply.

He froze.

“One more thing.”

He turned back slowly, like he suspected she was about to throw something at his head.

“This woman you intend to wed.” Catra’s tone had shifted into a courier's composure. “Is she actually in agreement? Or were you planning on grabbing the first available uterus and calling it yours?”

Relief washed down his face so fast it was nearly indecent.

“She wants it,” he said. “Very much.”

Catra stared at him a beat too long.

“Good,” she said. “I’d hate to lose you to an angry mob before Bright Moon gets its chance.”

Chapter 11: Adora

Chapter Notes

Thank you to my beta reader nbc22 😊

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The problem, Adora kept reminding herself, was that they couldn't leave yet.

Normally she could keep a mismatched force in line with ease—she'd done it for weeks now. But this wasn't a scrappy, castoff group of whatever mercenaries and clones Prime felt were low enough for Catra. Instead, she had to deal with opposing forces who carried decades of grudges and a talent for escalating small irritations into diplomatic disasters. One half bristled if a Horde soldier breathed too loudly. The other was in a constant state of recoil, as though an Etherian would attempt to stab one of them at any moment.

Frosta rode through Hell's Rest's gates for the meeting wearing her usual expression of someone who had been made to attend a tea party under duress. Adora waited in the audience room, straight-backed, trying—failing—not to anticipate Catra's entrance before she even saw her.

And then she arrived, Entrapta and Captain Marzo trailing her like mismatched punctuation marks.

Adora stood, too quickly—that instinct to submit to Catra was intrinsic now.

It felt pathetic.

Adora couldn't tell which version of Catra she'd get: the quiet knife's edge that sliced with a single sentence, or the chaotic cat who said something so outrageous it stunned everyone into silence.

But Catra was neither. She was… businesslike. Crisp. Every frayed thread of emotion was tucked away under armour and entitlement. She ran the meeting like she was born with a treaty in her hand, speaking First Ones with a fluency that made Adora's chest tighten. Two weeks ago Catra had been asking her how to conjugate a verb. Now she was delivering military recommendations without a single hitch.

Adora didn't know if she wanted to applaud her or throw something.

Later, walking back toward their own camp, Mermista crossed her arms, studying Catra's retreating figure.

"Well," Mermista said. "Isn't she just conveniently multilingual."

"Nothing Catra does is convenient," Adora answered, her voice dry.

When Adora finally had a moment alone, she stood in the entrance of her tent. The wind pushed at the canvas and lifted the sweat cooling along her temple. The fields looked calm, deceptively so. Soon they'd be marching toward Bright Moon—toward everything she'd left behind and everything she needed to reclaim.

She traced the distant hills with her gaze, then forced herself not to look toward the Horde encampment.

They'd agreed—separate camps. It was best for the two factions to remain apart.

The Etherians didn't like the sight of Horde tents spreading over the hills: Horde laughter drifting over on the wind. After Seaspray, after Catra's absence at the critical moment, what could have been a fresh start had curdled.

The Horde's opinions weren't any gentler. Etherians were "half-naked forest barbarians with glitter problems," apparently. That one came from Clone 28. He'd also taken to wolf-whistling at a

Salinean soldier named Keston every single time the man walked by, which was doing nothing for morale.

And now, the rumours. The kind that skittered through camps like rats: half-true, half-invented, all corrosive. Catra's name came up often. So did hers.

One evening, as Adora was going through reconnaissance notes, Mermista appeared beside her, silent until she wasn't.

"You should just take a slave," Mermista said. Flat. Pragmatic. As though suggesting Adora borrow a horse.

Adora didn't even let the words settle. "No."

Mermista didn't push, which somehow made it worse.

So Adora worked instead.

All day she immersed herself in planning—routes, food supplies, messenger networks, rotation schedules. She trained troops until her voice rasped, then corrected their stances until they were perfect. She made lists. She checked them. She remade them.

At night, she trained alone.

Her sword felt heavier than it used to, or maybe she was just tired enough that the weight finally meant something. She fought imaginary battles until sweat dripped from her knuckles. She let the ache blot out thought, let exhaustion swallow the pieces of her she didn't want to look at.

Then she returned to her tent, stripped down, washed fast, waved the squires away before they could linger.

She lay alone in a bed that used to feel too big and now felt too small.

This, she told herself, was good. Clean. Controlled. Exactly what she'd wanted.

No confusion. No longing. No foolish idea that she could bring Catra to Bright Moon's balcony and watch her eyes go wide at the view of the sea. No pretending that belonging was possible.

So she worked.

She wrote letters to the Princesses. Soon she'd know who still stood with her. Soon she'd have a fully formed map of her world again.

And she absolutely did not look toward Hell's Rest, where a red and black tent shone bright in the morning light, where Horde banners snapped, where Catra was pretending she didn't think about Adora, while Adora was pretending the same.

She had come back to her tent after nearly three hours of beating herself senseless with drills—forms, reversals, punishing repetitions of the same overhand swing until her shoulders burned and her palms stung. Sweat soaked the collar of her tunic and clung stubbornly to the small of her back. She didn't bother cooling down; she'd dismissed every slave sent her way, and she refused to allow any of the body squires closer unless absolutely necessary.

She sat at her desk still flushed with exertion. The candles leaned in their holders, wax pooling, flames guttering whenever the wind slipped through the seams of the tent. It wasn't much light, but it was enough to see the empty pages waiting for her.

These letters had to be written in her own script—no dictation, no polished versions from a scribe. Personal, measured, formal without being cold. She didn't say anything about Talon Mountain. Nothing about collars or cuffs or Catra's bedchamber. The truth would only distract, only fracture what was left of Etheria's already-shaken faith in her.

She gave them her purpose. Not her wounds.

Outside, the evening had settled into the dull rhythmic noise of an army preparing for a march that still felt too far away. The tent's

canvas muffled everything—the clank of armor, someone shouting for a misplaced saddle, the distant hum of magic torches—but it all pressed in faintly, a dim reminder that she was not as alone as she felt.

Her mind flickered to the Horde encampment across the fields.

Lonnie would be there. And Clone 28, and whatever remained of the Princess's Guard after the last two hellish months. Lonnie in the same camp as that… new Entrapta. Fresh-faced. Bright. Cheerful. Empty. A girl who didn't remember the work, the battles, the laughter, the fear, the bond they'd built—or the way she'd died. She remembered nothing of Lonnie or the relationship they had—

Adora remembered Lonnie's voice, cracked from crying:

"You ever wonder what it would feel like to find out you had fucked for your mother's killer?" A bitter laugh. *"I think it'd feel as devastating as this."*

It had made Adora sick—because Lonnie wasn't wrong.

She rubbed the heel of her hand over her eyes and forced herself back to the letters. One more to go.

By the time she finished, the candles had burned so low she had to tilt the page to see it. Her hand ached. Her back ached. The silence inside the tent felt too heavy, the kind that crept along the ribs and whispered that sleep would not come easily tonight.

The final letter sat in front of her. Short. Direct. No diplomacy, no honourifics.

To Prime, she sent a single line:

I'll see you when I get to Bright Moon.

She didn't watch the runner disappear into the dark. She dropped the pen, flexed her hand, and finally exhaled.

The night did not become any less suffocating. But at least the letters were done.

✧

Double Trouble was waiting in a chamber that resembled—almost too closely—the place where Entrapta had died. Same stone. Same narrow windows. Same echo. But they themselves looked nothing like the girl who had bled out there. Not the same race, not the same build, not the same softness. Just another singular creature who seemed to have no kin left anywhere in Etheria.

When they spotted Adora at the doorway, they swept into a deep, elaborate bow. The kind they used to give Prime—spine bent, head lowered, every line of their performance oiled and easy.

"Your Majesty," Double Trouble purred.

Adora's jaw tensed. "And just like that, you're on our side."

Her disgust wasn't hidden. She didn't bother. What bothered her more was that Double Trouble wasn't shackled, wasn't confined, wasn't even watched. They roamed the fort as though it were still theirs. Whatever deal they'd carved out with Catra, it had been lucrative. They looked comfortable—too comfortable. And unbothered.

"I do have a knack for slipping out of the noose," Double Trouble said, spreading their hands. "But sadly, no magic tricks. Only talent can guarantee you anything in this universe."

Adora stared at them. They weren't wrong—Prime's forgiveness was nonexistent. If Double Trouble ever wanted a future anywhere, it sure as hell wasn't with him. But the ease with which they lounged—their loose limbs, their relaxed posture, their casual grin—made something inside Adora grind.

People had died at Seaspray. Her people.

And Catra—Catra had been in her tent broken, trembling beneath her attempts at posture, blood still easily drawn through bandages she'd pretended weren't there. That image kept flashing behind Adora's eyes: Catra gripping the table to stay upright, refusing to breathe too sharply for fear it would show she was in pain.

Adora had come intending to question Double Trouble about strategies, positions, Prime's movements, anything useful. But the only words that made it out of her throat were:

"Who hurt her? Was it you?"

Double Trouble lifted a brow—delighted, if anything. "She didn't tell you?

Adora folded her arms. Held her ground. "Catra doesn't betray her allies."

"Mm. Loyal, isn't she?" Double Trouble mused. "It's very… vintage of her."

Adora didn't react. She just stared.

Double Trouble sighed theatrically. "Fine, fine. I'll ruin the mystery. I intercepted her before Seaspray. Brought her—well, dragged her—back here to Hell's Rest. She and I… negotiated terms for her release." Their smile grew feline. "And by the time we reached an understanding, she had enjoyed a brief stay in the cells and encountered a small mishap involving her shoulder and her stomach."

Adora kept her face still.

Double Trouble went on anyway, savouring the story. "The real tragedy, of course, was Hordak. Your Horde Princess smashed his skull rather decisively. Very messy. I had to finish him off myself. Put him out if his misery."

Adora felt something cold coil low in her gut—not shock, not horror; those she'd already exhausted. No. This was closer to

anger, sharp and controlled.

But her voice, when she finally spoke, stayed level.

“Of course she fought,” Adora said. “It’s what she does.”

Double Trouble’s grin widened, delighted.

“And yet,” they said softly, “you still look surprised.”

“You put Hordak,” Adora said coldly, “in a cell. With Catra.”

“Yes,” Double Trouble replied, bright and airy as if discussing seating arrangements at a banquet. They lifted their hands, palms out, mocking innocence. “Just as I orchestrated your queen’s assassination. And your own abduction. But now—” their smile stretched, pleased with itself, “—now you require my testimony to reclaim your throne. That’s how politics works, Your Majesty. The Princess understands the game. That’s why she still works with you.”

Adora kept her voice steady only by sheer will. She hadn’t come to fight with Double Trouble. She had come for information they might actually possess—information she couldn’t get from her own soldiers.

“Did Prime know who I was?”

Double Trouble gave a slow blink. “If he did?” They let out a theatrical sigh. “Letting Catra get her claws on you was… well. Even Prime isn’t immune to a catastrophic misread.”

Adora didn’t look away. She watched as color rose up Double Trouble’s cheeks—whether from excitement, nerves, or the thrill of their own storytelling, she couldn’t tell.

“If Prime knew,” Double Trouble continued, leaning forward slightly, voice dropping into a conspiratorial lilt, “then he gambled on Catra cracking. Maybe he thought that once you stepped foot on the Flagship, she’d recognize you and do something

catastrophically stupid. Or—" they tilted their head, eyes glittering, "perhaps he hoped she'd drag you into her bed. And once the mask came off? Once she realized who she'd touched?" Their smile sharpened. "The guilt alone might have undone her. Convenient, no?"

A pulse of heat hit Adora's chest—a protective instinct.

"How lucky for you that didn't happen," Double Trouble added lightly.

Adora stared at them. No more patience for riddles or theatrics.

"You betray anyone," she said. "Whoever's in reach. Whoever gives you the next step up. And for what? What has any of that earned you?"

For the first time, the performative ease in Double Trouble's posture faltered. Not much—just a small tightening around the mouth, a quiver in their breath.

"She killed Entrapta," Double Trouble said. No flourish. No theater. A single hard note.

Adora didn't flinch. "You killed Entrapta," she answered, "when you shoved her toward Prime."

Double Trouble froze—perfectly still, perfectly silent—for a beat too long.

Then their smile came back, thinner, strained around the edges.

But Adora didn't care for the show anymore. She'd seen the truth land.

✧

Adora knew exactly what to watch for in a divided camp—she'd lived it on the march from Dryl to Talon Mountain. Missing food.

Armories quietly "miscounting" spears. Rations that mysteriously spoiled on only one side of the field. It was all familiar.

But she hadn't yet dealt with Frosta.

Round one started at breakfast, before Adora had even gotten her first cup of tea down.

Frosta flatly refused the additional Hell's Rest provisions available to her troops.

"We don't need pampering," Frosta said, arms folded, chin tipped up in that practiced, unimpressed way of hers. "If the Horde wants to gorge on pastries and fatty meat, that's their business. Etheria doesn't rely on charity."

Adora inhaled—ready to de-escalate, explain, redirect—

—but Catra cut cleanly across her.

"Perfect," Catra said. "Then we'll match you. No one gets more than anyone else. Soldiers, captains, *queens*. You pick the portion size, Princess Frosta. Name it, and we'll all live with it."

Frosta's head jerked up, annoyed that Catra had beaten her to her own point. "Fine," she said. "I'll have the quartermasters calculate something realistic."

Catra gave a gracious nod that wasn't gracious in the slightest. "Wonderful. I love consistency."

Round two came by midday: a Horde soldier with a broken arm, an Etherian soldier with a nose leaking blood down his shirt—and Frosta describing it all as "a friendly competition."

"Only cowards are afraid of real sparring," Frosta added, very pointedly in Catra's direction.

Catra didn't blink. "Great. Then from now on, any Horde soldier who hits an Etherian will be executed for violating orders. I

assume you trust your people to show restraint. Only cowards hit someone who can't hit back."

Adora recognized the shift. She remembered what it felt like to be outmaneuvered by Catra—how the ground kept tilting beneath you until suddenly, arguing became pointless.

Catra didn't need brute force or charm. She just *cornered* you until the only remaining option was compliance.

The Horde swallowed the terms easily. Many were already talking about her with their old reverence—cold, sharp, untouchable. Except now there was a new layer of awe: *cold enough to fuck her mother's killer.*

Later, in the strategy tent, Mermista pushed another marker into the sand tray.

"The pledge should follow tradition," she said. "A night-feast for the bannermen. Ceremonial combats. Games. We'll meet at the borderline forts."

Frosta nodded curtly. "Strong location. Those walls have never been taken. Only conceded."

The Etherians kept their attention on the tray, not on Catra. It wouldn't have mattered—her face showed nothing.

"It's essentially a twin of Hell's Rest," Mermista added, addressing Catra now. "Large enough to house both armies. You'll understand the logistics once we arrive."

"I've been there," Catra said.

Mermista paused a beat, surprised. "Then you already know the terrain. That helps."

"Yes," Catra said. Nothing more.

Adora felt something catch behind her ribs.

That night, Adora took her sword and went to her clearing on the camp's edge—the one spot untouched by noise or politics. She let her muscles guide her, driving through form after form, sweat beading along her shoulders, breath coming short and hot.

She pushed harder.

Strike. Reset. Turn. Lunge. Again.

She poured the churn in her chest into the rhythm of blade and body. It still refused to drain completely It clung—an ache that tightened the closer they came to leaving Hell's Rest.

The borderline fort. Shared halls. Shared courts. Shared nights greeting bannermen. Side by side.

She didn't know what she wanted.

But she knew what she kept imagining: Catra glancing her way when Mermista named their destination—*the place where, seven years ago, Adora had killed her mother*—and showing even a flicker of anything. Anger. Fear. Hatred. Grief. Recognition.

Catra had looked straight ahead.

Not at Adora.

Not for a second.

And Adora felt that cold, quiet pressure in her chest deepen—not sharp enough to call pain, but close. So close.

She paused mid-swing, blade still humming in her hand, breath burning in her throat.

There—off to the west. A muffled laugh, a shuffle, the low *thunk* of something hitting wood. Then a sharp whistle of air. Not an attack. The cadence was wrong. Too careless. Too loud. Someone playing games where they shouldn't.

Her jaw tightened. Soldiers sneaking off for midnight sport—she'd dealt with that before. But she had thought, perhaps stupidly, that this tense new alliance kept everyone too cautious for antics.

She moved toward the noise, quietly, weaving through tree trunks that smelled of sap and dust. A small part of her felt almost sheepish; she knew perfectly well that no one expected their Queen to stomp out into the woods to lecture them like unruly cadets. It was absurdly overkill for whatever she'd find.

Until she saw the clearing.

Five Snows soldiers—Frosta's colours clear even under moonlight—ringed a makeshift practice range. They'd dragged a bundle of spears from camp and wedged a target board against a pine trunk. Several spears already jutted from the wood.

And a boy was tied to the board.

Spread-eagled. Horde uniform. Barely sixteen, maybe seventeen. His shirt half torn down the front. One eye swollen shut. He held himself unnaturally still, like movement itself might provoke another hit.

A spear was lodged in the space between his arm and ribs. Another just left of his head.

The girl at the throwing mark hefted her spear with deliberate confidence. She didn't even glance at the boy—just at the board and her audience of snickering peers.

Adora froze. She didn't dare shout; startling the thrower could kill the boy.

The spear left her hand in a smooth, practiced rotation. It cut through the quiet with a whistle and buried itself in the wood between the boy's legs—close enough to kiss the fabric of his trousers without breaking skin.

The Snows burst into laughter. Boastful, savage. The boy made no sound at all.

Adora stepped into the clearing.

“Who’s up next?” she asked.

The effect was instant. The thrower jerked around and went bone-white. Every soldier dropped to their knees so quickly the pine needles scattered.

“Stand,” Adora said. “If you’re going to break discipline, don’t pretend to be worms about it.”

They scrambled upright, stiff, terrified, eyes flicking anywhere but her face. They didn’t recognise her tone—level, collected. Most lEtherians only ever saw her lose her temper honestly, visibly. They didn’t know what it meant when her anger condensed into ice.

“Explain,” she said. “Now.”

A beat. Then a voice somewhere in the group—she couldn’t tell whose—offered, thinly, “Training. For the games, Your Majesty.”

Several others winced at the excuse. Their uniforms were unmistakably Frosta’s navy, and judging from their posture, they were half-hoping she’d praise them. Frosta encouraged toughness. Frosta liked spectacle. Frosta would have called this “initiative.”

Adora’s stomach curdled.

“Do not speak again.”

She crossed the clearing in three strides.

Up close, the boy looked even younger—thin, dirt-streaked, his Horde uniform hanging crooked where the Snows had torn at it. His shirt sleeve was stapled to the tree by a spear. Blood had

dried in a tacky smear across his temple where another had grazed him. His pupils blew wide when she approached, like prey spotting a new predator, and the fear in his face punched clean through her chest.

Adora wrapped her hand around the spear jutting between the boy's legs. She didn't ease it out; she yanked it free in one vicious motion, teeth clenched. The soldiers behind her flinched at the sound. She reached for the next—by his head—and ripped that out too. Then the one pinning his sleeve.

His breath hitched at each violent tug, but he never cried out in fear.

The ropes at his wrists and ankles were knotted too tight to undo. She drew her sword. The moment metal slid from its sheath, the boy's breathing went high and thin, as if he were trying not to scream.

"I'm cutting you loose," she said—but he didn't understand First Ones. His eyes rolled. He braced for pain.

She cut clean, quick strokes to sever the ropes, catching him before he sagged to the ground. He couldn't support his own weight. He folded like someone who had already been pushed past endurance. Bruises bloomed dark down his arms, across his ribs. His left wrist—

Adora's stomach flipped.

They'd clamped an iron cuff on him. Crude, heavy. Not platinum, not ceremonial, but unmistakable. A message, written in steel she couldn't ignore.

Her breath turned to stone in her chest.

The boy mumbled something panicked and unintelligible. She switched languages immediately.

“You’re safe,” she said in Horde-Etherian, softly, slowly. “You’re safe. Look at me.”

He blinked, dazed, until her voice cut through the haze.

“Tell the Princess,” he whispered, “I didn’t fight back.”

She swallowed the taste of iron in her mouth.

Adora turned her head just enough to catch the nearest soldier’s eye. “Run,” she said. “Bring Frosta. Now.”

The young soldier bolted.

Adora stayed kneeling beside the boy, murmuring steady reassurance in the slowest Horde dialect she knew. He couldn’t look at her face—Etherian soldiers didn’t dare—but he leaned toward her voice, clinging to it as though it were the first kindness he’d heard all night.

Frosta did not arrive quietly.

Two dozen of her Snows soldiers marched in with her, boots pounding, torches flaring. A heartbeat later, Mermista strode in with her own detachment, carrying twice as many torches—an unmistakable, deliberate counterbalance.

Mermista’s expression said it all: *If Frosta starts something, I’ll finish it.*

Adora rose to her feet.

“Your soldiers have broken the peace.”

Frosta glanced at the boy—really looked at him—at the bruises, the fear, the cuff on his wrist. Her expression tightened into something grim.

“They’ll be executed,” Frosta said flatly. No protest, no excuses. “They’ve disgraced the North.”

And it was genuine. Frosta didn't care what the Horde thought of her—but she cared deeply about how her soldiers represented her kingdom. She cared about honour. About discipline. About never giving the Horde any reason to hold moral high ground.

Adora saw all of that flicker through her.

The Snows soldiers dragged the five culprits forward. Two kept thrashing and were knocked unconscious. The others were bound with the same rough rope that had held the Horde boy.

Adora turned to Mermista.

"Take him back to our camp," she said. "Send for the Horde physician. Then go straight to Catra and tell her what happened."

Mermista's nod was sharp, immediate. She gathered the boy carefully, lifting him as though afraid he'd break apart, and vanished with the torches into the trees.

Adora looked at the rest of Frosta's soldiers.

"You're dismissed."

Then, colder:

"Not you."

The clearing emptied until only Frosta remained, the torches fading behind the trees and leaving them in dim, shifting shadows.

Adora faced her.

"Frosta of the Kingdom of Snows," she said, voice low. "You were loyal to my sister. You've known her since childhood. That matters to me. I care for Glimmer. I trust your loyalty to her. I need your strength. I need your warriors."

Frosta looked straight ahead, shoulders taut.

“But hear me,” Adora continued. “If your soldiers lay a hand on any Horde soldier again—any—then you and I will settle it at the end of a blade.”

Something in Frosta’s posture cracked. She bowed her head sharply, hiding her eyes.

“Yes, my Queen.”

✧

Mermista found her just past the camp boundary, walking back from the clearing with purpose like she was marching straight into another fight.

“You’re skating on thin ice with Frosta,” Mermista said, falling into step beside her. Her voice was even, but the kind of even that meant *don’t make me drag you into the lake to talk sense into you.*

Adora didn’t slow. “Frosta’s the one skating. I’m standing still.”

“She’s a traditionalist,” Mermista said. “Maybe the most First-Ones-minded monarch we have. She supports your claim because it’s the old way. But she’s not Glimmer. She’s not going to bend herself in half just because you’re the Queen.”

“I’m not asking her to bend,” Adora said. “I’m asking her to keep her soldiers from torturing children.”

Mermista let out a sharp breath through her nose—agreement and frustration both. “Just remember she’s already swallowing more than half her kingdom thinks she should. Keep pushing and she might choke.”

Adora didn’t answer. She already knew all of that. Frosta’s loyalties, Frosta’s limits. None of it mattered when she thought about that boy’s face, pale with fear, the cuff around his wrist.

She didn’t go back to her tent. She headed straight for the marked medical tent where they had brought the boy. The green-lit torch outside the door guttered in the wind, casting sharp shadows across the canvas. She dismissed the Etherian guards with a curt motion and planted herself outside.

From here she could see the flickering lights of the Horde encampment to the west—bright colours, movement, occasional bursts of laughter. Her own camp was quiet, the night cool and still around her. She was aware, distantly, of how absurd she must look: a Queen loitering outside a healer’s tent like a stray dog hoping for news.

She straightened the moment the clone physician stepped outside.

The medic stopped short. His posture snapped rigid. “Your Majesty.”

“How is—” Adora asked. Her voice came out tight and clipped—too many thoughts pressing behind it.

The clone blinked, thrown by the question. “The boy? Bruising, one fractured rib. Dehydration and shock.” Then, after a beat, “He’ll live.”

“No—I meant—” She faltered, the rest catching in her throat before she could shove the words out.

The clone’s expression shifted minutely. He understood. Slowly, carefully, he said, “The Princess is stable. Knife wounds were clean. She lost dangerous blood volume, but… she is recovering. Her body heals quickly.”

Adora’s shoulders loosened just a fraction. “Thank you.”

She should have stopped there. She heard herself speak anyway.

“I know I lied to all of you,” she said, voice low. “About who I was. Why I was there. I don’t expect you to forgive that. Any of it.”

The clone stared at her—not hostile, not warm, just *looking*, as if weighing whether she meant it.

She inhaled, steadying herself. “Will she be able to ride tomorrow?”

“You mean the ride to the borderline,” he said. Not a question. A quiet acknowledgement.

She nodded.

He considered her, then said simply, “She will ride.”

The clone added, “You should prepare yourself as well. Past the border is the only place you’ll truly see the shape of Prime’s designs.”

Adora looked at him sharply. “Double Trouble claims they don’t know Prime’s plans for Bright Moon.”

He gave a faint, humourless huff—the closest a clone medic ever came to a scoff. “Double Trouble knows plenty. But it doesn’t matter.”

He met her gaze evenly, his voice flattening into something bleak and factual.

“Every clone knows what Prime intends for Etheria.”

Adora’s pulse thudded. “What is he planning?”

“To erase it,” the clone said. “Completely.”

Chapter End Notes

> Does anyone want to be my beta reader for my next She-Ra series? I'm itching to start writing it already.

Chapter 12: Catra

At sunrise, in front of both armies, Adora executed five Etherian warriors with her own two hands.

Catra stood with her soldiers on a high outcropping and watched, arms folded, tail twitching with each blow of the sword. Adora's face was carved from stone—just like it had been the day she'd hurled the same blade at an Etherian soldier rather than let Catra be cut down. Catra remembered the look on her face then, the horror after. *Don't use me against my own people. Not again. I can't,* she'd begged*. I can't do that again.*

Catra wondered how many times Adora had replayed that moment. How many times she wished she had made any other choice.

The crowd—in its entirety—lapped it up. Soldiers always relished the spectacle of bloodletting, even when their own Queen so clearly hated every second of it. The air buzzed with that ugly excitement—like the moment before lightning strikes and no one knows who it will hit first. Etherians wore bright, brittle smiles that only made the way Frosta stood apart, frosted around the edges, more obvious.

All five bodies wore navy blue.

The Etherian horns that screamed across camp to mark the morning felt sharper than usual—thin needles of sound piercing straight into Catra's skull. She blamed the lack of sleep. And the coffee. Whatever Baker's staff had brewed tasted like burnt dirt pretending to be a beverage. Still, it made her heart knock uncomfortably against her ribs. Her nerves felt stretched tight, rubbed raw.

Every cheerful Etherian face reminded her of another morning, another border, her mother's blood soaking into the canvas beneath her.

When Adora finally approached on her gleaming new white horse—She-Ra tall and unreadable in the saddle—the whole world seemed to tilt. She rode up beside Catra with that stiff, dutiful posture that said: *I'm here because I have to be, not because I want to be.* Even Catra, for all her idiocy where Adora was concerned, couldn't lie to herself about that.

This was performance. A tableau. A necessary illusion so the troops didn't tear each other apart. A Queen and a Horde Princess riding shoulder to shoulder. Stability on horseback.

Catra kept her posture sharp, her expression colder still. She knew what Etherians whispered when they thought she couldn't hear: that they owed their Queen vengeance—for humiliations real or imagined, for the thin silver cuff around Adora's wrist, for the stories they'd spun in their tents about what happened between them.

Let them whisper, she thought*. I can't give them a reason to act.*

She asked after you, the medic had said. Catra still couldn't make sense of it. Couldn't understand why Adora would waste a thought on her. This wasn't the woman Catra had known—had loved. That woman had been an illusion built on stolen time and lies. And yet sometimes, infuriatingly, She-Ra moved the same, looked the same, even softened her voice in the same way as Adora had—and Catra's stomach tightened like she hadn't eaten in days.

Adora didn't even glance in her direction.

"At the Borderline," Adora said, gaze forward, jaw set, "your rooms will be beside mine. That's the protocol."

Her tone was flat, clipped—professional bordering on resentful. Like she was reading orders aloud.

Catra kept her eyes fixed on the road ahead. "Naturally."

The Borderline fortress had been a wreck when their factions last fought—broken stone, rotted gates, scorched beams. Etherians had rebuilt it, poured pride into it. A monument to their great triumph over the Horde.

Does it make your tongue taste like ash, Catra thought*, knowing I'll sleep under that roof?*

She didn't say it.

She just nodded again, cool and polite, as if the question hadn't burned its way up her throat.

It was all she allowed herself.

"Welcome home," Mermista said.

She didn't say it with pomp or theatrics. She said it the way she said anything real—with that quiet sincerity she reserved for the handful of people she actually cared about. And Adora… Adora reacted as if the words were a key turning in her ribs. Her spine straightened; her shoulders rolled back; she breathed in like the air here was somehow different—holy—like she'd been drowning for years and had only now reached the surface.

Catra watched the entire transformation. Watched Adora soften, brighten, flash Mermista one of those open, guileless smiles that should have made Catra feel nothing by now. The first real smile she'd seen from her in weeks.

And when Adora's gaze slid toward Catra—expecting something, or checking something, or trying not to check something—it vanished.

Fine. Catra wasn't about to give her anything back. Not a blink, not a flinch. Nothing.

The Etherian horns blared again—those painfully triumphant, self-satisfied blasts—and Catra had to grit her teeth to stop herself from flattening her ears.

The air wasn't different here. Borders were nothing but ink and dead kings and whoever won the last battle. Five steps behind them had been Horde territory. Five steps ahead was Etheria. The ground didn't magically change allegiance. Adora had already been free a long time before they crossed some invisible line.

"Do you remember that place—?" Mermista said, nudging Adora. "The tiny village near Seaworthy? The one with the horrible little—what were they, sand crabs? The ones that chased you?"

Adora barked a laugh. Loud. Warm. Familiar.

Catra's stomach knotted. She hated both of them.

The column moved over tidy fields, across orchards braced with fresh timber, past watchtowers that hadn't existed the last time the Horde marched their way through. Catra remembered the old route—images of her mother's army passing farmlands, families pouring out of their homes just to see them, danced in her brain. Children running barefoot. Old farmers bowing. The border hadn't been dangerous back then; the peace had held for two decades. People trusted the sight of Horde banners. Counted on them.

The memories felt oddly shiny when she focused on them. A lot of her memories of Shadow Weaver felt that way—as if they were clouded by her own tears.

Shadow Weaver had ridden ahead of the column, her dark robes snapping in the wind. Catra had been thirteen—small, determined, trying so hard to impress her.

"These are our people," Shadow Weaver had said, her voice low. She had stopped her horse, forcing Catra to stop with her. "Remember this well. Not the soil. Not the fortifications. Not the throne. *Them*."

She had pointed to the farmers—tired, hopeful, waiting for reassurance.

“They depend on us,” she’d said. “You must understand that responsibility before you can ever hope to lead.”

Catra understood it. She had never forgotten.

Now those same farmlands had walls—thick stone barriers, iron gates, watchtowers with archers scanning the horizon. No open fields full of waving hands. No smiling families rushing out to greet the armies that would protect them. All Catra saw were shuttered windows, silhouettes lurking behind doorframes, faces that vanished the moment a Horde banner moved past.

Adora didn’t notice at first. Mermista kept her talking—light conversation, little memories tossed back and forth like pebbles skipping on water. Adora kept laughing. Kept smiling. Kept pretending, maybe, that Etheria was exactly how she remembered it.

Then the first village appeared.

A long street. Stone houses. Orderly groups of people standing outside with stiff backs and unblinking eyes, watching the armies march as if awaiting a verdict.

No cheers. No bows. Just silence.

That was the moment Adora’s smile slipped—imperceptibly at first, then all at once, draining out of her face like colour from a dying ember. Her shoulders stayed square, but the air around her shifted. She felt it. She finally saw it.

Catra saw the exact second recognition struck her.

Good, Catra thought, not unkindly. *Get there. See it.*

Adora hadn’t been here when the old peace died. She hadn’t seen the terror. She hadn’t walked these roads surrounded by farmers begging for reassurance, desperate not to be forgotten.

But she could see the aftermath.

She could see what seven years of fear had carved into the faces lining the road.

Catra watched her take it in…and hoped—quietly, fiercely—that she understood this part of her mother's legacy too.

✧

Inside the forts at the borderline, slaves waited for them.

Catra had known the Etherians had restored the place—Mermista had been bragging about it for days: new walls, new wards, new defensive structure, "tasteful" renovations. Catra had braced herself to see the field where Shadow Weaver died swallowed up by flowers and creeping vines. She'd prepared herself to see the old stone fort smoothed and prettied over with Etherian fabrics and those gaudy curtains they all seemed to love.

But she hadn't prepared for *this*.

Rows of kneeling girls—two dozen at least—perfect and silent, their foreheads pressed to the polished floor, their hair arranged like they were decorations and not human beings. Not moving. Not looking up. Not even *breathing*, from the look of it.

Catra stopped breathing for a moment too.

She should've expected it. Slavery wasn't just an institution here. It was a tradition. A civic habit. A First Ones relic they all still pretended wasn't rotten. Etheria could be all shimmering sunlight and moral high ground when it suited them, but behind it all were the same collared, broken bodies.

Mermista saw it too. Her expression went sharp and ugly-fast. "Seriously?" she snapped, stepping toward the woman at the head of the line—the overseer, or handler, whatever title these people used for the one in charge of arranging other women like décor. "The Queen's made it clear she's not—she doesn't want—"

The woman bowed deeply but without fear, her tone maddeningly even. “These slaves are provided,” she said, “for the use of the Queen’s guest.”

She gestured toward Catra.

Catra heard a faint choked sound. When she glanced toward Adora, she saw the woman had let out a shocked, humourless puff of disbelief—approaching a laugh. Adora’s mouth had gone soft at the corners, that familiar almost-smile she used around things that horrified her and that she couldn’t fix on the spot.

Catra didn’t know if she was included in the joke. She hated that she even cared.

Her own mouth tightened. Her heart jolted traitorously at the flicker of Adora’s expression—because it had been days since Adora had looked at her with anything that wasn’t exhaustion or cold formality.

Catra inhaled slowly through her nose.

Then she moved.

She didn’t stomp or snap or bare her teeth—though she wanted to. She walked with eerie calm, the kind she used with volatile soldiers and diplomatic threats and things she couldn’t punch. She let herself seem like she was making an inspection.

She wasn’t.

She was trying not to be sick.

She felt Adora watching her now—Mermista too, tense, wary, caught somewhere between disgust and apology.

But it was the slaves Catra couldn’t look away from. Perfect posture. Foreheads to the floor. Not a twitch. Not a flinch. Bodies braced to be useful or discarded. Girls who would remain like this

until someone told them otherwise—even if that order never came.

If commanded, they would die kneeling.

They had no will except obedience.

The sight made Catra's fur prickle, made something in her chest coil tight and furious.

She stepped closer to the nearest girl—no older than the original Entrapta had been—and crouched, her shadow spilling over the neat braid laid down her back. The girl didn't lift her head. Didn't shift. Didn't shiver.

It was like kneeling in front of a grave.

Catra's throat felt tight.

She hated Etheria. She hated this place. She hated this *system*. She hated that Adora's people used slaves this way and still thought themselves righteous. She hated that she was being offered a compliment she didn't want. She hated that part of her wanted to look at Adora just to see if Adora knew what this felt like now.

She kept her eyes forward. Her voice, when she finally spoke, came out low and razor-thin.

"Tell me," she said, without turning, "which of you decided this was appropriate."

The woman in charge lifted her head half an inch.

"It is tradition," she said. "And an honour."

Behind Catra, Adora sucked in a sharp, pained breath.

And Mermista muttered, under her breath but very much audible:

"Etheria is so unbelievably embarrassing sometimes."

Catra didn’t smile. But a muscle in her jaw twitched.

Because—just once—she and Mermista agreed on something completely.

They were beautiful. Of course they were. Etheria polished its slaves the way Horde Prime polished his mirrors. Curated. Decorative. Hollow. A torment in of itself.

None of them were beautiful like Adora, though.

A few had builds close to Adora’s real one—before all the gold light and impossible muscle that She-Ra leant her. That made it worse, somehow.

Catra jabbed a finger vaguely, not trusting herself to look too long at any of them. “Fine. That one.”

Total randomness. All she cared was that the girl wasn’t blonde.

The chosen woman—*Isobel*, apparently—lifted her head only high enough that Catra caught a blush blooming across her cheeks. She rose at the command, then immediately sank back down to her knees so fast Catra thought she’d collapsed.

This was supposed to be erotic? Was this how Etherians liked it? A partner who flopped over like a dying fern? Even *pet* felt like too generous a word—pets had personalities. Preferences. Protests. This girl moved the way a puppet moved before it broke.

The slave master beamed, pleased with herself. “We will have her washed and prepared for you this evening, your highness. For her First Night.”

Catra tore her stare away from Isobel—morbidly fascinated and repulsed all at once.

“Her… First Night,” she repeated. The words tasted rancid in her mouth.

Instinctively—damn her—she glanced toward Adora. She didn't even register doing it until it was too late.

Adora's face was thunderous. Not confused. Not politely neutral. *Angry*. Catra didn't recognize the exact expression, but she recognized the *heat* behind it.

Catra's ears pricked. Good. If Adora wanted to make a scene? If she wanted to voice an opinion? Catra could work with that. She held Adora's gaze deliberately—and her chin lifted in a dare.

Say something.

Please say something.

The slave master stepped in, oblivious to the war being waged two feet away.

"Slaves here receive full classical training," the woman said with patronizing patience. "Like at the Bright Moon palace or Castle Chill. They study pleasure arts for years, but remain untouched. Completely pure. Their body is given only once—to their rightful master."

Catra stared at the girl's bowed head. Then back up at Adora.

Adora looked like she might vibrate out of her own skin. Her jaw had gone sharp enough to cut glass. Catra's heart kicked once, traitorously, at the intensity of those blue eyes.

She smothered it.

Fine. If Adora wanted to silently judge her, she could return the favour.

Catra let her voice go light, lazy, cruel in exactly the way Etherians expected of her. "You'll have to teach me the rules, then," she said. "I never did pick up the etiquette for ordering around bed slaves."

She didn’t blink. Didn’t look away from Adora for even a heartbeat.

The slave master mistook the tension entirely and hurried to clarify, bowing her head again. “They do not speak Horde-tongue, your highness. If you wish to command her, the plain First Ones form is correct. And…” she hesitated, choosing her words carefully for this allegedly unsophisticated Horde Princess, “…any command of intimacy is considered an honour for a slave. The more personal the service, the greater the honour.”

Catra’s mouth twisted. Honour. Right.

Adora’s expression darkened further—something stricken, something furious, something she probably didn’t want anyone to see.

Catra let herself enjoy that for all of half a heartbeat.

Then she hated herself for it.

And she hated Adora for making her feel anything at all.

“Really?” Catra said under her breath, and it came out a low, dangerous purr. She remembered—too well—how Adora had fought her on every command unless she wanted something from her. How she had bristled at the idea of service, except in those rare moments when she’d pretended they were equals.

It sure didn’t seem like an honour when you were mine, she didn’t say.

Instead: “Come here.”

The command wasn’t sharp. It was almost lazy. It was also unmistakably directed away from the slave.

Adora’s head jerked toward her, jaw tight, brows drawn down as if Catra had just spat in the holy water of Bright Moon itself. Catra

didn’t look away—not once—not even as Isobel rose shakily and crept forward like a nervous fawn.

Isobel folded herself down again, forehead to the ground. Catra barely glanced at her.

She lifted her foot, extended it with a bored elegance.

“Kiss it.”

Soft. Not cruel. Almost conversational.

The sound that left Adora—half exhale, half teeth grinding—was worth the price of physical contact.

Isobel pressed her lips to the soft leather at Catra’s toe, then trailed reverent kisses up to her ankle. When she reached Catra’s calf, she nuzzled there, slow and grateful, the way pampered pets tried to curry favor.

Catra didn’t watch the girl. She watched Adora.

Adora’s face flushed deep and ugly—anger, disgust, and even something wounded beneath the redness that Catra recognized far too easily.

Catra murmured, “Good girl,” and let her fingers slide through the slave’s hair. Isobel’s red curls were coarse, nothing like the silken spill Adora used to shake out of her face when she laughed into Catra’s mouth.

Adora looked like she might vomit.

Catra finally tore her gaze away, turning bright-eyed toward the slave master. Innocent. Curious. Dangerous.

“Can she serve me in the baths as well?” Catra asked, lightly, as though discussing towel colours.

The Etherian attendants lit up. Of course they did. No greater compliment to their hospitality than the Horde Princess indulging in their little luxuries.

Adora did not light up.

Adora looked like someone had peeled her open and poured salt directly inside.

Catra felt something tight and mean unfurl in her chest. She wasn't sure what the emotion was—victory or spite or pain—but she enjoyed it enough not to question it.

This was exactly what she was supposed to do. Accept the slave. Use the slave. Refusing would insult the household; dismissing the girl would insult them. Catra was following their rules perfectly.

Adora had no excuse to object.

And yet the protest was right there on her face, raw and unhidden.

Catra leaned back slightly, chin tilting up, letting the moment stretch. Letting Adora see the lazy curl of her smile.

What's wrong, sweetheart? Jealous? Or do you want to volunteer? Go on—say the word. Everyone here would love to hear it.

She didn't speak any of that aloud.

She didn't have to.

The message was clear on her face.

Adora broke first. Her jaw set, her shoulders locked, and she turned away so sharply her hair whipped over her shoulder.

Catra felt the smallest, sickest flicker of triumph.

It rang hollow.

✧

Mermista herself escorted them through the long, echoing corridor—two sets of heavy doors at the very end, adjoining suites as Adora had promised. Royal chambers that once would have housed a Queen and her Consort. Now they would house a Queen and the woman she could barely look at.

The Princess of the Seas tried—honestly tried—to make conversation. Catra could hear the effort in every word.

"And here," Mermista said, gesturing vaguely at a painted archway, "we fixed the leak in the roof, replaced the supports, and, uh… redid the friezes. They used to be all… I don't know—skulls and teeth? Very Horde. Now they're flowers."

Adora did not respond. She stared ahead, face iron-flat, shoulders locked in a posture Catra recognized from months of watching her desperately try not to feel anything. A posture Catra had once yearned to break open with a kiss.

Now she let the silence stretch, amused at how hard Mermista was working to fill it.

Instead of giving her anything to work with, Catra took Isobel's arm and folded it through her own like they were two noblewomen strolling through some sunlit palace garden. The slave froze for a heartbeat, then turned a shade of red so violent it almost clashed with her hair.

Catra lowered her head toward her, brushing a curl with the tip of her nose. The poor thing nearly melted onto the floor.

"Tell me something," Catra said, voice pitched for pleasant, audible conversation. "Are you really going to follow every order I give you? Every single one?"

Isobel's breath hitched. Mermista turned sharply, eyes wide. Adora did too—her face tightening, a muscle jumping in her jaw.

Good.

Let them hear it.

Isobel stammered, "This slave… this slave will be grateful to obey whatever the Princess of the Horde desires. She won't wish to refuse. She won't—"

Catra clicked her tongue and tilted Isobel's chin up with two fingers. Not gently. Not cruelly. Just enough to make Isobel tremble. But Catra wasn't looking at her—her eyes were fixed on Adora, on the stiff line of her throat, the way Adora's hands balled at her sides.

For just a moment, Catra felt that same thrill she'd felt in the hall. Sharp. Vicious. Sweet.

"Close," Catra murmured to Isobel. "But try again."

She brushed her cheek against Isobel's hair, slow, intimate, deliberate—all for Adora.

"It's 'your highness.'" She said it in Horde-Etherian first, then in First Ones, the simple, court manner they'd agreed upon. Soft, like a lover might say it. As if she were teaching Isobel how to whisper it against her throat.

Isobel trembled. "Y-your highness," she repeated, breathless, vowels mangled, eyes shining with desperate eagerness to please.

Catra let her chin go. "Better."

Mermista looked like she wanted to drown Catra.

Adora looked like she wanted to shatter the nearest stone column with her bare hands, but only if strangling Catra was really and truly off the table.

Catra smiled.

“Anything I order?” she repeated, letting the question unspool lazily, like she had all the time in the world to push and prod. She didn’t even bother lowering her voice. She wanted the echo of it filling the corridor, bouncing off the polished Etherian stone.

Up ahead, Adora’s shoulders tightened—one fraction, one heartbeat—but she didn’t look back. Of course she didn’t. She was trying to pretend she wasn’t listening.

Catra made sure she was.

“If I decided I wanted a massage in the baths—right now—would you do it?”

Isobel nodded so quickly she nearly swayed. “This slave was trained for that purpose—in all manner of pleasure—your highness. She… she would be honoured.”

Honoured.

Catra fought the urge to sneer.

The poor girl was shaking—terrified, eager, trained to swallow both instincts as if they were the same thing. And they had taught her to believe it was an *honour* to be used.

“My pleasure,” Catra repeated, lightly. “Etherians suddenly care so much about that?”

Isobel flushed crimson. “This one looks forward to serving the Princess of the Horde.”

Catra felt something like a headache pulse behind her eyes. “Of course you do,” she said, and the smile she gave her was sharp and fake and hollow. “That’s what you’ve been told to feel.”

She brushed the woman’s hair aside—barely touching her—and raised her voice just enough for Adora to hear every syllable.

“And if I told you to get on your knees right here,” Catra murmured, “and put your mouth on me—would you?”

Isobel’s breath hitched. “If that is your wish, your highness.”

Behind them, Adora *stumbled*. Not much. Not enough for anyone but Catra to catch it. But Catra caught it. And it brought a smile to her face.

She leaned in further, her lips a breath from Isobel’s cheek. “I’ve been riding all day,” she said softly. “Haven’t even washed. Would you lick me clean just because I told you to?”

Isobel made a tiny, mortified sound that she probably thought was cute.

“Princess,” she whispered—then corrected, “your highness…”

She trembled like a candle flame.

That was when Adora cut in.

Her knuckles smacked hard against a door—Catra’s door—and Adora said, in a voice carved from sheer willpower, “Your chambers are here. Next to mine.”

Catra lifted her head, blinking as though she had honestly forgotten Adora existed.

Then she smiled, slow and cutting.

“Oh,” she said. “How convenient.”

She let her hand fall from Isobel’s flushed cheek and looked Adora straight in the eye.

“I do hope the walls are thick,” Catra added. “I’d hate to disturb my dear sister of Etheria.”

Adora’s jaw was clenched so tight Catra could practically hear her teeth grind.

Chapter 13: Adora

Home wasn't supposed to feel like this—hollow, stifling, wrong.

Adora pulled familiar magic into herself once more, letting the golden light burn away the tremor in her hands, the tightness in her throat. She didn't trust her own, human body not to flinch. The transformation steadied her, kept her spine straight while her mind unraveled.

She had dismissed the slaves. Again. As she had in the camp. They had left her chambers quietly, their eyes lowered, their bodies moving with that trained, soft-footed glide that Adora could barely look at now without swallowing bile.

Her new squires were on their way—chosen, of course, from among the nobly born, because only those with lineage were permitted the honour of attending a Queen. Adora stood in the thick quiet of her rooms, unable to ignore the wall just to her left.

Catra was roomed in the Consort's suite. Not a guest room. Not a commander's quarters. The Consort's suite—one wall away, as though Etheria itself had decided to twist the knife.

Adora closed her eyes. She tried not to picture it.

Isobel—small, tentative, trembling in a way Catra would either find amusing or irritating—unfastening the row of buttons down the back of Catra's jacket, her fingers fluttering at the collar before moving to the front. Or Catra shrugging off her coat in the baths, letting the steam cling to her soft fur, Isobel kneeling to undo each fastening with reverence.

Attend me.

A sick, sharp heat flared in Adora's chest. Her hands curled into fists.

She forced her thoughts elsewhere—into politics, into camp structure, anything that did not revolve around Catra's hair, slipping over her shoulder while someone else touched her.

Tonight she and Catra would stand together before the lesser princesses. There would be wine, and posturing, and pledges made with great ceremony. Mermista's allies would come forward one by one to join their forces. There would be feasting. There would be laughter. There would be eyes on Adora, weighing her, measuring her return.

Adora breathed once, deeply, and stepped out of her chambers.

Her squires fell into place behind her as she entered the grand hall.

The space was drowning in colour—saffron draperies, coral silks, gilded columns. The princesses and their retinues reclined on couches, lounging like they had recently woken from sunlit naps. Low tables overflowed with food: candied fruits, perfect pastries, sliced citrus arranged like jewels. Frosta leaned on one elbow, plucking a strip of peeled orange. Keston relaxed nearby, posture smug and graceful in a way only Salinean nobility ever seemed to master.

Every available princess of rank had gathered, and the sheer number of them filled the hall to its edges. Voices overlapped in bright threads—warm, perfumed conversation Adora could barely register over the pounding in her ears.

Horde soldiers were scattered among them, looking stiff and out of place—backs straight, eyes darting. A few hovered awkwardly near benches, apparently unsure whether they were permitted to sit. Others stood rigid in small clusters, hands clasped behind them as if awaiting inspection.

And everywhere there were slaves.

Men and women in hip cloths carrying trays of sugared figs. Pouring wine into carved crystal cups. Slaves kneeling beside

couches to fan lounging princesses with palm leaves the size of shields. A girl with silver rings around her wrists holding out a bowl of rose water so an Etherian noble could wash her fingertips without breaking the flow of conversation.

A harp thrummed somewhere behind a cluster of silk curtains, and a dancer's shadow drifted across the wall—barefoot, masked, her movements slow and measured, designed to be admired and ignored in equal parts.

Adora stepped fully into the hall, and the weight of it all suddenly pressed down so hard she could almost feel her shoulders rounding—this place that claimed to be home, this place that looked nothing like the world she believed she had left behind.

Still, when she took that first step, the room quieted instantly.

No fanfare or announcement. Just her silhouette in the doorway—and the hall folded to the floor as one. Etherians didn't elevate their Queen with ceremony; they dropped to their knees and let her decide when they could breathe again.

Catra, of course, didn't move.

She reclined exactly as she pleased, draped over her couch like she owned the place—arm thrown across the back, one knee bent just enough to show off the cut of her thigh through Horde tailoring. Her hand dangled lazily, the picture of bored authority.

At her feet, Isobel bowed so low her forehead hovered by Catra's fingertips. The girl was nearly naked, skin gleaming in the torchlight, collar snug at her throat. Catra's posture made the whole display look intentional, curated. She looked as though she could have posed for hours: unbothered, untouchable.

Adora forced herself forward, ignoring the way all eyes tracked her, hungry, evaluating, as if whispering behind closed mouths.

Their couches sat side by side—two parallel thrones, whether anyone wanted that or not.

“Sister,” Catra said lightly, just enough warmth to pass as polite, just enough bite to make Adora’s teeth clench. She didn’t rise; she didn’t have to.

Adora sat. The fullness of the hall pressed around her once more—eyes flicking from her face to the platinum cuff she wore, then to the Horde princess beside her. The air buzzed with tension.

She lifted her hand, and the room rose.

“Princesses of Etheria,” she said, steady, “thank you for answering my call. You’ve heard the lies spread in my absence. You’ve seen the usurper in Bright Moon claiming to rule Etheria in my sister's absence. Know this: my mother’s death, my disappearance—both can be laid at the feet of Horde Prime. He betrayed me. He betrayed the Princess of the Horde. Together, we intend to end his hold on this world.”

A low, uneasy shift ran through the gathered princesses.

Frosta had pledged to her at Talon Mountain—but that was before Catra had walked into the picture. Before seeing Catra seated beside her, as though she had every right to be there.

Netossa stepped forward.

“I want assurance,” she said, “that the Fright Zone isn’t going to be steering Etheria from behind the throne.”

Adora’s voice cooled. “If you have something to say, say it plainly.”

“With pleasure,” Netossa said. “The rumour is that the Princess of the Horde is your lover.”

A beat of stunned quiet.

Angella’s court would never have tolerated the question. But this wasn’t that court—this was a hall full of warriors who’d grown up hating the Horde.

Adora felt anger spark low in her gut. “Who I take to my bed is not your concern.”

“If our Queen is bedding the Horde,” Netossa replied simply, “it absolutely is.”

Adora’s pulse hammered.

Catra gave a soft sound—half a laugh, half a purr of dangerous amusement.

“Oh, come now,” she said, stretching like a cat in sunlight. “Why don’t I just tell them what actually went on between us? Gods know they’re dying to hear it.”

Her smile curved, wicked and sharp.

And the entire hall leaned in, hanging on the next breath.

Catra didn’t hurry. She slipped open the cuff of her sleeve, letting the fabric fall back until the gleam beneath it was exposed to the hall at large.

The platinum slave cuff caught the lamplight, and a shiver of whispers rippled through the room. Hearing rumours was one thing. Seeing Catra wearing that metal—seeing the symbol that meant submission, ownership—was an entirely different shock.

Catra rested her wrist against the carved armrest, sleeve open like a loosened shirt collar. Her expression was mild, almost bored.

“In case I’m misunderstanding,” Catra said, switching to flawless First Ones, “you’re asking if I’ve been sleeping with the woman who killed my mother?”

She didn’t flinch. She wore the cuff like it was a bracelet she’d chosen, not something forced on her. No one with eyes could imagine Catra as owned. She radiated the same dangerous poise she always had, every line of her body arranged just so. The idea

that anyone could possibly have true power over her was a distant fantasy.

Netossa's jaw tightened. "A woman would have to be frostbitten to bed the murderer of her own mother."

Catra tilted her head. "Then your question is answered."

Silence followed as Catra held Netossa's gaze without blinking.

"…Understood, Your Highness," Netossa said at last, bowing her head.

Adora's voice cut cleanly into the pause. "Well, Netossa?"

Netossa stepped forward, dropped to one knee, and said, "I pledge. I see the Princess of the Horde stands with you openly. Swearing loyalty here—where you won your greatest victory—is fitting."

The rest of the pledges went through. Adora accepted them, thanked each princess in turn, kept her face steady even when she felt the tension pulling at her ribs.

When the food came in—carried by slaves—the hall shifted into the subtle chaos of a feast. Squires attended Adora, the arrangement she'd insisted on. The choice irritated nearly everyone, but she didn't care.

Isobel attended Catra.

The girl practically glowed with purpose. She hovered at Catra's elbow with quiet devotion, offering each dish like a jewel, selecting the choicest pieces, arranging everything in tiny bowls. She refreshed the water for Catra's fingers before her mistress thought to ask. Perfect posture. Perfect silence.

Her eyelashes fluttered too much.

Adora forced her gaze elsewhere.

In the center of the hall, two slaves stepped forward: one settling with a harp, the other—older, poised—prepared to recite.

Catra didn't wait for an introduction. "Play The Duel of Hunger and Fire," she said, and a warm ripple of approval passed through the Etherian crowd. The Keeper of Slaves beamed, praising Catra's familiarity with their oldest epics.

Catra turned her head, eyes cutting sidelong toward Adora.

"It's one of your favourites, isn't it?" she said, voice sweet.

It was one of her favourites. She had requested it more times than she could count—winter evenings in Bright Moon, harp strings rising under the high vaulted ceiling. She'd always liked the way the epic framed the world before the rule of the First Ones, Etheria as a wild place watched over by Guardian Beasts—vast, thinking creatures who judged courage and mercy as sharply as any man.

One tale followed a young war-leader who met a starving Guardian after a brutal winter.

By the rules of survival, the beast should have torn her apart.

By the rules of the hunt, she should have struck before it could rear its head.

But their eyes met—too close—and neither party leapt into action.

And when Moondown Vale burned, that same creature returned from the treeline to save her army.

Adora didn't want to hear it tonight.

L'animal que j'ai laissé fuir dans l'ombre, indemne, sombre,

Étais-je vraiment brave, ou jouais-je la comédie?

Il tremblait de faim, de désir, dans cette même ombre,

Mais ses yeux trop proches m'ont fait longtemps hésiter.

Si te briser avait été facile, tu serais déjà défait.

Et maintenant tu reposes à mes pieds, près du feu qui dissipe l'ombre,

Douce bête apaisée… et moi, toujours en vie, loin de la comédie.

The room swelled with appreciation—murmurs of delight, the warm "ah" of listeners recognising an old favourite. Every stanza seemed crafted to charm them.

Adora reached for her cup and found it bone-dry. She lifted it slightly. A squire stepped forward at once, refilling it. She drank before thanking him.

Movement to her left caught her eye—Lonnie approaching the pair seated at the next couch. Double Trouble lounged; Baker sat stiffly beside them, her hands folded with the politeness of someone hoping not to be noticed.

Lonnie stopped directly before Baker.

Baker glanced up, one eyebrow raised. "Yes?"

A beat of hesitation. Lonnie cleared her throat. "I… wanted to say I'm sorry. About Entrapta. I know she isn't—she isn't who she was. She told me stories about you. From Dryl. When she was young."

"Thank you, soldier." Baker's voice was precise, clipped, almost formal. The compliment (if it was a compliment) clearly sat wrongly with her. Lonnie looked just as uneasy.

It struck Adora, belatedly, that Lonnie must have planned this conversation before Entrapta had returned like a stranger wearing her own skin.

Without thinking, Adora lifted a hand in quiet summons.

Lonnie startled, then immediately crossed to the dais. She bowed —too fast, too stiff—and made the three prostrations required by protocol. Normally she moved like she'd been born in armour; tonight she appeared off-balance, as if none of her limbs were quite where she expected them to be.

Likely inebriated.

"Rise," Adora said.

Adora heard herself say, before she'd even decided to speak further, "Your instincts are solid."

It was the first thing she'd said to Lonnie since Seaspray.

The first words since the blood, the screams, the unending chaos.

Lonnie stood stiffly before her, hands behind her back like she wasn't sure if she should salute or run. It made the distance between this moment and their old campfire nights feel even wider. Then, everything had been easy teasing, familiar stories swapped back and forth. Now it was all brittle; like the air between them could crack if she breathed too hard.

Lonnie lifted her chin in Catra's direction. "I'm glad you two… worked things out."

Her voice wasn't bitter. Just tired.

The lights were too bright. Adora went to drain her cup again, though she knew it was already empty.

Lonnie went on, quieter. "Honestly? I figured when Catra found out who you really were, she'd vow some big, dramatic revenge

quest. You know—storm the heavens, avenge her mother, all that."

"She knew from the start," Adora replied.

Lonnie blinked at that. Something in her shoulders eased. "Then I'm glad you trusted each other enough. Before you showed up, I think she didn't trust anyone."

"She didn't," Adora agreed.

Across the hall, laughter spiked—sharp, overflowing, wine-thick.

Isobel knelt beside Catra's couch with reverent intensity, offering grapes in a shallow bowl. Catra said something—indulgent enough that Isobel lit up like a lantern—and patted the cushion beside her.

Isobel climbed up onto the edge of the couch, trembling with eagerness. She plucked a single grape and raised it to Catra's mouth.

Catra accepted it lazily, curling a finger into the red hair at her shoulder. A slave feeding a queen.

Adora felt her jaw go tight.

On the far side of the room, an Etherian noblewoman tapped her slave's wrist—a silent instruction to retire somewhere secluded. Others followed suit. Wine and performance had eaten away the last scraps of decorum.

Adora lifted her own cup again; nothing. The emptiness mocked her.

Catra leaned closer to Isobel, murmuring something low—too low for anyone else to hear. Isobel flushed scarlet. The recitation crescendoed, blades clashing in the tale's final triumph, and in that same moment Catra touched Isobel's shoulder lightly… and stood.

Scorpia's voice rang through her memory like a bruise pressed too hard: I'll wager you never thought a princess could be jealous of a slave. But right now, I would trade places with you in a heartbeat.

Adora heard herself say, "Excuse me."

Dozens of people surged upright as she rose. Protocol suffocated her. Every step she took sent another ripple of bodies bowing or parting too slowly, too ceremoniously. She lost sight of Catra almost immediately—just a flick of a tail, a sliver of dark hair at the door, then gone.

She should have brought a slave. Protocol would have cleared the way in an instant. Queens with slaves were allowed privacy. Queens without them were expected to endure the crowd.

She shoved her way through anyway.

The corridor outside the hall was silent, stripped of music and chatter. She turned sharply into the next passage—

And stopped short.

Isobel knelt beneath an archway, alone, looking lost. The confusion on her face was so raw that she didn't even move when she first saw Adora—instead staring, wide-eyed, like a startled fawn.

Then she seemed to realise what she was doing, and folded down fast, forehead to stone.

Adora asked, "Where is she?"

Isobel's voice was soft, trembling, but trained. "Her Highness of the Horde has gone to ride."

"A ride," Adora repeated, flat. "Where?"

"At the stables… the handlers may know her chosen path. This slave can inquire—"

“No.”

Adora shook her head sharply. The location had hit her the moment she’d internalized Catra's goal.

“I know exactly where she went.”

✧

At night, Etheria never looked like Etheria.

Not to Adora.

Under moonlight the land turned strange and ancient—nothing like the bright fields she had crossed with her armies, nothing like the maps she had endlessly studied. The Borderline was a graveyard of memories. Jagged stone, broken archways half-eaten by moss, deep cuts in the earth left by battles no one alive remembered.

She rode quietly, letting her new horse pick its careful path as the ground dipped and heaved around them. The ruins made a kind of skeletal outline in the dark: a toppled stair, a shattered column, blocks of old stone sunk halfway into the dirt. She remembered every shape perfectly. Armies had once funneled around them like water dividing around rocks.

These ruins had been old even before the First Ones carved Etheria into realms. They were the only things left unchanged on this field. Everything else had been rewritten—in blood, in loss, in choices she still carried.

She passed the spot where their left flank had collapsed.

A few strides more—where she had ordered a retreat she’d been too young to command, where she’d made herself believe she deserved to lead because her mother believed it.

Another step—the spot where she had driven her blade into the last of the Shadow Weaver’s Guard, looking up to find the woman

herself standing alone in the dust and smoke, eyes blazing.

She'd been fifteen.

Shadow Weaver had been a grown woman.

And she had fought anyway, because people were dying and she hadn't known any other way to keep them alive.

Adora dismounted, looping the reins loosely around a cracked pillar. The stone flaked under her touch. Everything here felt sharpened by memory, too vivid, too loud in her mind. She walked forward, pushing through a tangle of overgrowth—and then stopped.

There, perched on a chunk of fallen masonry, was Catra.

She sat with one knee lifted, a white undershirt loose around her shoulders, her jacket folded beneath her to keep the cold of the stone from biting into exposed skin. Her throat was bare in the moonlight, her wrists unguarded.

She looked… young, in a way Adora wasn't prepared for. Neither the haunted commander in Horde armor nor the woman lounging like an empress at dinner. Something quieter.

The scrape of rock under Adora's heel gave her away.

Catra turned fast, ears up, pupils blown wide for a split second before her face shifted—clicking into something cool, deliberate, unreadable. It was like watching a door slam shut.

"Oh," Catra said, voice low and flat with something Adora couldn't parse. "Perfect."

Adora swallowed. Her throat felt too tight. "I thought maybe you wanted—"

Catra arched a brow. "Wanted?"

“A friend,” Adora managed. “If you don’t… if you’d rather be alone, I can go.”

Catra huffed a laugh that wasn’t quite a laugh. “Why drag it out?”

Her gaze flicked down Adora’s body and up again. She-Ra’s body.

“Let’s just fuck.”

It hit Adora like a blow. Not the vulgarity—Catra had always weaponized bluntness—but the inevitability, as though Adora’s desire was something Catra held in her fist.

“That’s—” Adora forced the words out. “That’s not what I meant.”

“Maybe not.” Catra leaned back, shirt falling open a little more in the wind. “But it’s what you came for.”

Adora flinched. “Catra—”

“You want me,” Catra said, tone deceptively light, like she was pointing out the weather. “You’ve wanted me since Talon Mountain. Since Ghost’s Ridge. You don’t have to pretend you didn’t.”

The worst part was that Catra wasn’t teasing Adora.

She was daring her.

Standing in the ruins where she’d once killed Catra’s mother, Adora felt her past and present collide like blade on bone.

And Catra watched her—eyes bright, unblinking, challenging—as if waiting to see whether she would tell the truth, or escape it by any means necessary.

Anyone else would have been sloppy with wine.

Catra, infuriatingly, was razor-sharp—sober.

Adora could still feel the phantom memory of Catra's palm on her sternum, pushing her back onto the bed that night—easy, confident, like she'd been born with the right to manhandle her. She had always worn provocation like armour—sharp edges on every word, every touch. Adora should have braced for it.

"I came," she said carefully, "because I thought maybe you wanted to talk."

Catra's eyes flicked over her, unimpressed. "I don't."

"About your mother," Adora tried.

Catra's laugh was short and wrong. "I never fucked my mother," she said, voice cutting sideways, brittle. "Not that it would've been incest, technically. Adoption and all that."

Adora straightened, instinctively slipping toward the same voice she used when reprimanding soldiers. "It would've been wrong because you were a kid, Catra. That would've been on her. Not you."

Something in Catra's face stuttered—pain, startled and defensive.

"She didn't," she said quietly.

And suddenly Adora felt the ground tilt.

They were standing on the field where Shadow Weaver had died.

And they weren't going to speak about Shadow Weaver at all.

No—they were circling *this* instead. The mess between them. The want between them. And the wound that went far beyond Ghost's Ridge.

"You're right," Adora said, voice thin. "I've been thinking about it since Talon Mountain. I haven't been able to stop."

Catra's smirk came too fast. "Why? Was I that good?"

“No,” Adora said, and watched the smirk freeze. “You fucked like a virgin half the time. And the other half—”

Catra’s eyes sharpened. “Like I knew what I was doing?”

“Like you were doing what you were used to,” Adora said. “Not what you wanted.”

The hit landed so cleanly Adora almost regretted saying it.

Catra rocked back a fraction, jaw tightening—not hurt, exactly, but *struck*.

“I’m not sure I can handle your whole honesty crusade right now,” Catra muttered.

Adora inhaled. “If it helps, I don’t prefer… experience. Or performance. Or whatever you think I want.”

“That’s right,” Catra said, soft and vicious. “You like it simple.”

The words cut straight through Adora. She felt weirdly naked, like Catra had shoved a hand inside her ribcage and squeezed.

Will you weaponize even that?

She didn’t say it. The thought alone scorched her.

Catra wasn’t doing much better—her breathing uneven, pupils too wide, fists flexing like she didn’t trust her own hands.

Adora forced steadiness into her voice. “Your mother died well.”

Catra’s head jerked up.

“She fought better than anyone I’ve ever faced. It was clean. It was fast. She didn’t suffer.”

“Like gutting a pig?”

Adora felt like the ground had tilted under her. Her ears were full—not with Catra's voice anymore, but with a growing, low thunder.

Catra's head snapped toward the dark. "Seriously? You sent out a search party for me too?" Her mouth hooked in a humorless twist.

"No," Adora said—and grabbed her.

She shoved Catra bodily into the shadow of a toppled pillar, pressing her back against cool stone just as the sound broke open around them: hooves, dozens—no, hundreds—pounding straight across the old battlefield.

Then the riders were on them.

A flood of horses surged through the ruins, close enough that the ground trembled. Adora braced one hand against the stone and the other against Catra, holding her tight, pinning her fully out of sight. Any stumble, any shift, and they'd be crushed under iron-shod hooves. The air whipped with mane and dust and the thunder of hooves hitting uneven earth.

Catra froze beneath her—tense, every muscle rigid, offense and adrenaline fighting inside her. Adora felt the sharp inhale under her own ribs, felt Catra's fingers flex like she wanted to shove Adora off her body right now, and couldn't.

Adora's mind flicked—Catra's jacket left out on the stone, their horses tied just beyond the arch. If the riders spotted either—if they were Horde deserters, Etherian fanatics, Prime's scouts—capture was one outcome. Execution was another.

The horses streamed past, a terrible rhythm that shook the stones themselves.

And then—like a storm finishing its sweep—they thinned, turned north, and vanished across the fields.

Silence settled abrupt and ringing.

Adora didn’t move. Catra’s breath was shallow against her collarbone, their bodies still flush from necessity, this time, rather than choice.

Then Catra shoved her—hard—stepping out of the shelter with her back to Adora, breathing in sharp, staccato bursts.

Adora stayed where she was, palm still flat to the stone, watching Catra’s outline reform in the moonlight—thin white shirt clinging to her, shoulders drawn tight, hair ruffled by the wind. She looked like she’d been carved out of the night itself.

“I know you’re not frostbitten,” Adora said quietly. “You weren’t when you attacked me in the baths. You weren’t when you pushed me onto your bed.”

Catra didn’t turn. “We need to leave,” she said. Her voice was flat, controlled—too controlled. “We don’t know who that was, or how they got past our scouts.”

“Catra—”

She turned then, sudden and sharp. “A fair fight?” Her laugh was thin and hurting. “There’s no such thing. Somebody’s always bigger. Somebody’s always stronger.”

Before Adora could answer, the warning bells from the fort shattered the night—clanging, urgent, late.

Catra bent, snatching up her discarded jacket, shrugging into it without bothering to fasten the front. The loose fabric flapped as she swung into her saddle.

Adora untied the reins with stiff fingers, mounted, and kicked her horse forward. Catra didn’t wait. She was already a dark blur ahead, riding hard toward the fort, toward the ringing bells, toward whatever danger had arrived.

Chapter 14: Catra

Chapter Notes

> As always, thanks to my beta reader, they know how amazing they are 😊

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra had spoken to the woman first—calmly, politely—but the horror in the room and the sudden crush of soldiers at the doorway had frozen her stiff. The slack, vacant stare told Catra she could ask questions until she was blue in the face without getting anything coherent.

So Catra turned to the young girl instead.

"Herbs," Catra said in Horde-Etherian. "Medicinal. Anything. Poppy if you have it, willow bark if you don't."

The girl jerked like a frightened animal and vanished through the doorway at a sprint.

By then the bells had ratcheted up, howling mightily from the fort towers.

Adora had taken command the moment they'd ridden through the gates—She-Ra's height and presence settling over her like armour, clean and absolute. Whatever softness she'd shown on the battlefield ruins, whatever vulnerable thing had cracked open in her voice—gone. The second there were people to save, orders to give, she reshaped herself into the soldier she had always needed to be. Her voice carried across the courtyard before her feet even hit the ground.

She led the pursuit herself.

Catra rode beside her, silent, watching the shift happen with a familiar tightness in her chest. And when they reached the village,

nothing they discovered surprised her. Catra had been waiting for something like this—waiting for Prime's hand to close around the borders of Etheria, waiting for the usual ugliness of war.

But Adora—

Adora broke.

She didn't cry. She didn't scream. She just… *stopped*. Like her heart had stalled mid-beat.

Adora had been a soldier since her teenage years began. She'd seen battlefields, watched people die, carried weight no child should have had to bear. And still—still—the cruelty of the world hit her like new every time. Catra thought it was simultaneously one of the stupidest and most admirable things about her: Adora kept believing people could be better, long after most would have stopped trying.

The village was ashes and bone.

Bodies in the street. Homes burned to the foundation. And a girl—maybe sixteen—with a cracked stare and dried blood down the back of her dress.

"All my friends are dead," she'd whispered. Flat. Empty. "Please… don't open that door."

Adora had signaled her soldiers forward anyway.

Catra held the girl when the door was forced open—held her steady when she didn't so much as flinch at the splintering wood. Catra knew that kind of numbness. Knew what bruises on a young woman's back meant. Knew that if she ever got her hands on the men responsible, she would not bother with mercy.

Inside, they found a man clinging to life.

He had tried to rise when he saw Catra—eyes shining with a desperate, feverish loyalty.

“My Princess…” he rasped. “Forgive me. I tried—I could not save them. I failed the village.”

He didn’t add what Catra already knew: *If only you had gone to Prime. If only you had given yourself up. All of this is your fault.*

Adora stood like a stake driven into the earth—unmoving, furious. Her jaw worked like she was clenching against something unbearable. Her hands balled into fists, the muscles of her arms taut, her whole posture coiled like she meant to rip the world open.

"Who did this?” she asked the girl, voice low, dangerous, nothing gentle left. “Tell me, and I swear to you I will find them. I will make sure no one else suffers.”

The girl stared through her. Not defiant—just completely and utterly broken.

“Adora,” the girl said. “Adora did this. She said it was her message to Glimmer.”

The words hit Adora like a lash.

Adora didn’t respond. Her throat bobbed once. She turned without a sound and walked out.

No orders. No explanation. Not a single glance back.

Catra didn’t follow.

Someone had to stay and keep from unraveling.

She had sent for her medic long before, knowing the man on the floor wasn’t going to see sunrise. It wasn’t him she needed examined. Catra knew how to brew a pain tea. Knew how to sit with a dying man.

She didn’t know how to brew contraceptives. But she knew her medic did.

“Your Highness—were you looking for me?”

Catra didn’t even flick an ear in his direction. She was kneeling over the dying man, sleeves pushed to her elbows, hands slick with blood that had dried in streaks across her forearms. She was operating on instinct alone, stripped of everything except stubborn purpose.

“I called for my *medic*,” Catra said, flatly. “Not you.”

She sounded bone-tired. Not even irritated—just *tired*. Something, she thought humourlessly, he was likely hearing in her voice for the very first time.

Marzo didn’t retreat. His posture stayed ramrod-straight, chin up, but something guarded flickered through his eyes. His tone was careful.

“I can assist until he arrives.”

Catra didn’t question it, didn’t look up, didn’t even snarl—just, “Then get some water boiling.”

Marzo obeyed in silence. The tone he took—obedient without being servile—was unusual for him. He moved as if braced for her to snap, but she simply continued to work. Every part of her focus was bent on easing the man’s breathing, on keeping him comfortable as his grip on life thinned to a thread.

By the time the medic arrived, the girl had returned with an entire basket of herbal bundles—roots, leaves, stems, anything she could find in the village gardens before they burned. The man’s eyes had gone soft and unfocused, his pain held at bay by something Catra had brewed and fed him in tiny drops, patient as a priest giving last rites.

The medic didn’t need to be told what she wanted him for. He simply rolled up his sleeves and stepped in, issuing crisp instructions. Catra and Marzo moved automatically to fulfil them—heating water, grinding herbs, measuring out doses—while the

medic pulled the woman and the girl aside to check them for injuries.

Outside, soldiers began trickling in with more survivors. Not many. The handful of villagers still alive were those quick or lucky enough to hide from the attackers. Too many who needed care had died before dawn reached them.

Catra worked as though she was outrunning the very concept of fatigue. Her jacket lay discarded in a corner; sweat darkened the collar of her undershirt. The cuff at her wrist was smudged with ash and blood. Her hair clung damply to her temples where it fell from its tie.

Marzo kept pace, awkward but willing. He was no healer—he moved like someone accustomed to breaking things, not mending them—but he did everything she told him to, swiftly, without talking back.

Catra barely noticed him except as another pair of hands. Her mind had narrowed to a tunnel: anatomy diagrams she'd memorized as a child; the ratios for numbing teas; which herbs slowed bleeding and which stopped pain. Laboring like this, with her mind able to run only on autopilot, spread relief through her body alongside the exhaustion.

Time blurred. The sky outside shifted from black to a pale, sickly wash of grey. Dawn. Catra barely registered it.

She had just finished binding the last of the salves when the sound split the morning haze—

Shouting. Urgent. Multiple voices. Boots pounding the dirt.

Catra's head snapped up, expression sharpening instantly from healer's focus to something cold and alert. Marzo straightened beside her, hand going to the hilt of his weapon as a well-honed reflex.

For the first time in hours, Catra's mind began to activate.

✧

Soldiers had gathered—mostly Etherian. A loose ring around the pair in the center, not yet closed, like they were waiting to see whether this would be a scolding or a slaughter. Catra could still watch everything—still slip through gaps, pushing past Etherians twice her size, the ones who still wiped their palms on their tunics like Horde proximity dirtied them.

Adora's voice cut through the noise. There was a discarded navy jacket at her feet—war-torn and clearly all the proof she needed.

"Draw."

The sword was already in her hand. Catra had seen this before—the moment when the kind, patient Adora vanished and something far older, far more dangerous, stepped forward wearing her face. This was the Adora who could lift warhorses with one arm. The Adora who broke siege lines by walking straight into them. The Adora who killed to protect. This was She-Ra. An ancient fury born from the need for a shield.

And today? Today she wanted Frosta's head.

Frosta laughed right in her Queen's face. A brat disguised as a general, talking up to her ruler like she was a nagging babysitter.

"This is the Princess's doing!" Frosta barked, loud enough for the entire ring to hear. She jabbed a thumb toward Catra. "She's twisted you against your own people."

The tone wasn't even hateful—it was scolding. Condescending. The voice you used on someone you couldn't believe was making such a humiliating mistake.

You let the Horde Princess get in your pants, and now you've betrayed the planet.

Adora's jaw clenched. "Don't speak," she said, low and lethal, "unless it's a final apology."

The snickers spread through the navy-clad ranks like rot. Catra counted uniforms, counted faces. Frosta's loyalists outnumbered Adora's and Catra's combined. They were hungry for blood.

"I won't pretend to care about a dead Fright Zone village." Frosta said, and conjured a spear of solid ice with a flick of her wrist.

Fright Zone village, as if this hadn't been Etherian territory for the last seven years.

Abruptly, she charged headlong at her Queen.

Adora met the attack without a moment's hesitation, stepping forward like she was meeting an equal—and then proving Frosta was anything but. The clash sent a crack through the dirt. Frosta's spear struck with all the strength of her kingdom, and Adora caught it as if catching a broomstick. Muscle rippled under her skin as she held the strike, pushed back, and tore the weapon aside like ripping weeds from the ground.

Frosta skidded back several paces, boots gouging the earth. She blinked, like she was seeing Adora clearly for the first time.

Adora wasn't the adolescent Queen Frosta remembered from Princess Proms. Not the polite girl raised in polished Bright Moon. She was a full-grown warrior who had fought armies, killed monsters, broken chains. This was She-Ra standing in front of Frosta now, every inch of her.

What, exactly, did you suppose would happen? Catra thought.

But Frosta didn't bow, didn't yield, didn't even hesitate. Deep within her blood, pride outweighed sense. She spun another spear into being and rushed again like she could batter down the force of a mountain.

And Adora—who had never been one to step away from a challenge—met her blow for blow.

It was painfully stupid. Two giant egos smashing rocks together. Catra almost rolled her eyes. *They may as well have dropped their weapons and compared metaphorical cock sizes. At least that would've been entertaining.*

Instead she sprinted forward, cutting through the crowd as ice shattered on steel. The second exchange was worse—Frosta's spear went spinning out of her hands, clattering across the dirt.

Adora didn't stop.

Catra saw the future unfold with terrible clarity: Adora's sword rising, Frosta's shocked face split in two, a spray of blood across the dirt. Then the howl—raw, animal—rising from Frosta's soldiers as they charged. Etherian turning on Etherian. A civil war breaking loose in seconds. A bloodbath right here on the border.

And when it was over?

Prime would reign as the ultimate victor.

He would have Catra—broken, alone, condemned by those from Etheria and the Horde alike—and he would tell her it had been inevitable.

Just as he intended.

"Stop!"

Catra wasn't thinking—rational thought was gone, burned out somewhere between the ringing of the bells and the sound of Adora's sword slamming against ice. Her body moved on instinct alone, a streak of red and black through the circle of soldiers. Marzo lunged to grab her, fingers brushing her sleeve; another Horde soldier reached as well. Both far too slow.

She burst between Adora and Frosta just as the younger girl dug in her heels to brace for another swing. Frosta's weight faltered. Catra shoved her—hard—and the girl toppled backward into the

dirt with a sharp grunt, a puff of dust rising around her like smoke.

And then Catra was *there*, filling the space that had been Frosta's, her body between Adora's blade and a corpse that hadn't happened yet.

The world sharpened to an unbearable clarity, each detail almost painfully bright. Frosta's breathless wheeze as she hit the ground. The shifting expressions of the crowd—bloodlust flashing to panic on Etherian faces, silent horror on the Horde's. Marzo's mouth open mid-shout. The glint of sun against Adora's sword. And Adora herself—beautiful, terrifying, twisted up by fury into something Catra barely recognized.

Is this the face you wore when you killed her?

Her mother's death rose like a ghost, not a memory but a presence—Shadow Weaver hovering just out of sight, lingering in the stones of this cursed borderland. Watching.

Catra felt her own breath catch. Prepared as best she could for whatever came next.

But the sword never landed.

Adora stopped it—somehow—mere breaths from Catra's throat. A sliver of space separated them, close enough that the air between them felt electrified.

Why?

The question hit her like a blow. She had been ready. Part of her —an ugly, aching part—had braced for it. Longed for it. To be finished. To be free. To join her mother in whatever lay beyond this—

But Adora stood there trembling, fighting herself, not striking.

The ghost was gone. Only the choking heat, the sweat down Catra's spine, the ring of hushed soldiers remained. And Adora—Adora, with murder still banked in her eyes, and something else underneath that made Catra's chest ache.

The same woman who had held her with reverent hands on the battlements of Talon Mountain. Who had kissed her like she was something fragile and irreplaceable.

Now she looked at Catra like she was merely an obstacle keeping her from blood.

Another heartbeat. Another rise and fall of Adora's chest.

Catra felt the faint sting as the tip of the blade kissed her skin. A thin line of warmth trickled down—blood welling.

You can have both mother and daughter, a traitorous thought whispered.

Finish it. End our story where it began.

Catra's voice came out steadier than she felt.

"Another inch," she said, her eyes locked on Adora's, "and I'm no longer your problem."

Adora's grip spasmed on the hilt. Her breath was ragged, almost shaking. Fury rolled off her in waves—black, hungry, roaring beneath the skin.

"Get out of my way," Adora growled. Her voice was low and dangerous, nothing like the woman Catra had known, nothing like the woman who had gazed upon her like a promise. "Catra—*move*."

She didn't. Catra stayed exactly where she was, shoulders squared, chin lifted, that trickle of blood still sliding down her throat. She could feel how close Adora was to breaking. How desperately she needed something—someone—to strike.

If Catra breathed wrong, the blade might split her open.

A part of her welcomed it.

And she had to crush that part down with everything she had, because wanting to be hurt—wanting *her* to be the one to do it—was a luxury she couldn't afford.

Not now.

Not with their entire rebellion teetering on the edge.

"Look around you," Catra said. Her voice carried—a cold, flaying thing. "This massacre wasn't some mindless raid. It was crafted. Calculated. Someone wanted your own people to doubt you. Frosta doesn't think in long games."

"She slaughtered a village in the Fright Zone," Adora shot back. Her breath was ragged fury. "You've seen the wreckage she left behind."

"That was retaliation," Catra said sharply. "After Prime hit her people first."

"You'd defend her?" Adora's voice cracked.

It took restraint—real, conscious restraint—not to let herself revel in that wildfire of anger. Not to push her luck and feel the unique thrill of Adora's blade leaning in, just a little more.

"Anyone can throw on a navy jacket," Catra said, clipped and cold. "Anyone can claim to be from the North. That's the point."

Adora's grip convulsed around the hilt again. The sword trembled, and the faint line across Catra's throat opened just slightly—just enough that a thicker bead of blood rolled down, warm, slow through her fur.

Adora's eyes tracked it.

Catra felt that dangerous flicker behind them—the hunger for violence, for release. And she waited. Steady. Unmoving. If it came, it came.

Instead, Adora ripped the blade away from her neck with a hissed inhale, then slammed it back into its sheath so hard the metal rang. She stalked a few paces away like heat seeking escape—then whirled back, fury coalescing, her eyes glowing like lightning trapped in glass.

When she spoke, she switched back to First Ones—a deliberate shift.

"She just saved your life," she snarled at Frosta.

Frosta sat in the dirt where Catra had knocked her over, face flushed with humiliation and rage. Frost crystals clung to her palms where she'd tried to brace herself. She sneered up at her Queen.

"I'm supposed to thank her?"

"No," Catra said before Adora could answer, her tone bored and vicious all at once. "If it were my call, you'd already be dead for what you did in the Fright Zone, the same way I killed the men who slaughtered the Etherian village."

Her neck throbbed. The small blood-warm line made her feel strangely exposed—stripped bare in a way she hated. Frosta saw the mark, and instead of showing shame, she curled her lip and made a crude gesture with two fingers and her tongue.

So much for diplomacy.

"Your carelessness," Catra said, voice suddenly cold as the grave, "is exactly what Prime wants. I didn't save you for *you*. I saved you because this tantrum would have cost us a rebellion."

Across the ring of soldiers, Adora paced again—tight steps, shoulders rigid, jaw clenched. Rage still shook her posture, but

something else had joined it: dawning horror. A brittle edge. She looked like a woman who now knew she had nearly done something she couldn't take back.

Catra watched her. Watched the rise and fall of her chest. Watched Mermista catch up at last and plant a steadying hand on her back. Adora stilled at the touch, leaning forward slightly as Mermista spoke—too softly for Catra to hear.

The sight hit her like a punch to the sternum.

Catra turned away before anything showed on her face. Whatever she felt—whatever ugly, knotting thing twisted under her ribs—she would confront it alone. No one else got to see that.

As she passed, Marzo's voice broke through, quiet but urgent.

"Your highness—your neck—"

Catra brushed him off with a small, irritated flick of her hand. "It's fine," she said. "It's stopped."

It hadn't. But it didn't matter.

She straightened, inhaling once, deeply—resetting.

"Gather the soldiers," she ordered. "We're finished here."

✧

There wasn't much left to do at the village. Not many survivors to tend, not many bodies left to move, and no hope of catching the riders—not with the lead they had, not with tracks already muddied by smoke and ash. Catra led her own soldiers back first. Routine. Something familiar to hold in her hands while her stomach slowly unknotted from the kiss of a sword point at her throat.

The Etherians returned later.

Catra watched them from a lookout post high on the inner wall, where the shadows swallowed her silhouette and no one would bother her with questions she wouldn’t answer. She half expected Mermista to be riding next to Adora—leaning in close, maybe trying to talk her down, maybe smoothing away the storm Adora had carried out of that village. Maybe even making her smile again.

But the column funneled through the gates, and Mermista was nowhere to be seen.

Adora rode alone.

Even from a distance, Catra could tell the mood hadn’t lifted. The anger still clung to her like a second aura, the kind Catra could feel in her bones without needing to see her face.

Catra had made a study—an art—out of avoiding Adora lately. A dozen ways to slip out of a corridor before they crossed paths. A hundred excuses to talk to anyone else instead. She wasn’t stupid enough to get caught alone with her—but now she was still off-balance from the life or death moment they'd shared mere hours ago.

Numbness played tricks. The world kept feeling like it was half a step to the left, and Catra kept drifting toward the places she should’ve avoided.

Her mind was still scattered—still trying to formulate a clean outline of events. Adora following her to the battlefield. That cracked-open, reckless conversation about Shadow Weaver. The sword at her throat. The silence after. Every feeling cut loose, floating somewhere she couldn’t quite reach just yet.

So she went looking for Adora.

Not because she wanted to. Absolutely not. Hells, she told herself that on every stair she descended. She wasn’t seeking comfort, wasn’t looking to give it. She wasn’t hoping for anything. She

certainly wasn't walking toward the vague, humiliating echo of Adora's voice saying, *I thought maybe you wanted—a friend.*

No. She just needed to know where the woman landed after almost killing her. Needed to know if the fury had burned out or calcified. Needed to know whether Mermista had already swept in to anchor her, to whisper reminders that Adora wasn't a monster, wasn't capable of the kind of cruelty Catra knew too well.

Maybe she wanted to see the guilt on her face. Maybe she wanted to see nothing at all. Maybe she wanted to see whether the part of Adora that reached for her—wanted her—was still there under the wreckage.

Or maybe she was just a fool who couldn't leave impossible questions alone.

What mattered was that she was numb enough now to take any answer without it breaking her open again. And Adora was angry enough not to lie, not to soften, not to pretend to be anything she wasn't.

Catra told herself that was all this was—timing. Strategy. Curiosity.

Not need.

Not want.

Not the stupid, continuous echo of a voice in her skull:

I thought maybe you wanted—

—a friend.

Catra didn't have to ask around for the Queen—not that she would've. If she'd had to hunt Adora down, she would've turned around and gone right back to her room. Instead, she found her in the first place her instincts pointed toward: the training yard.

Empty, except for Adora.

Not She-Ra.

The sight hit like a fist to the gut. Adora was in skin tight clothing —mercifully not a She-Ra style skirt—muscles pulled taut and glistening, the air around her rippling from the heat she continuously exuded. Her hair had half-come undone, loose gold strands sticking to her temples as she cut through another form with a two-handed sword Catra would've struggled to lift, let alone wield.

The door slammed behind Catra—those damn old fort doors always sounded like thunder when they closed—but Adora didn't so much as acknowledge the sound. No hesitation, no break in rhythm. Just raw, violent purpose carved into a body that refused to tire. A body that had once fucked an entire tribe with barely a pause.

Catra stayed where she was, arms crossed, eyes narrowed. She watched the way Adora forced herself through each form—the precision, the control, the unnatural discipline it took to keep that much strength from breaking loose. Every strike was clean. Every pivot economical. If Adora wanted to, she could've taken a head off with a single motion. Catra knew that now. Knew it intimately.

She found herself tracking each stance automatically, cataloguing them, recognizing pieces of routines she'd seen only in fragments —never the full sequence, never performed with this much fury coiled into every line of her body.

She hated how mesmerizing it was.

Time blurred. Minutes, maybe an hour—Catra wasn't keeping track. Adora only slowed when her body finally demanded she stop. Her last strike sheared the air open with a sound like ripping cloth before she let the blade fall to her side, chest heaving. Sweat rolled down her ribs like molten silver.

When she finally noticed Catra, it was clear she hadn’t known she had an audience.

The fury in her eyes didn’t dim. Not even with She-Ra’s glow having disappeared. If anything, it looked sharper on her bare skin—anger without the armour.

Catra felt it hit her, hot and bladed, like standing too close to an open furnace.

She let her voice cut across the space, cold enough to frost over Adora’s steel.

“If you’re this angry,” she said, tone flat as a dead man’s heartbeat, “you should fight a real opponent.”

Here is something I drew on the 8th of Oct, the scene has changed in my head, so perhaps I will draw something new for the next chapter:



Chapter End Notes

My plan is to write 2 chapters a week from now on ❤️

Chapter 15: Adora

Chapter Notes

Thank you again to my beta reader 🥰

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The indoor training hall stretched long and narrow. Its walls were paneled in dark wood scored by years of strikes, the floor layered thick with sawdust that dulled sound and swallowed blood. At one end stood a scarred post, gouged and splintered from a thousand drills. Torches burned along the walls, their flames casting pink and green light that slid unevenly over racks of mounted weapons—knives in pairs, tridents, swords both blunted and meant for real killing.

Adora sent everyone away.

Soldiers. Squires. Slaves. A single, sharp order, and the space emptied, boots retreating, voices fading until the hall belonged to her alone.

She drew the Sword of Protection.

The familiar weight settled into her hands, solid and unyielding. She adjusted her stance, grounded herself, and began to move.

Again. And again.

She didn't want discussion. She didn't want explanations or apologies or questions that pretended there were clean answers to any of this. She came here for the one thing that still made sense—motion, force, consequence. A strike either landed or it didn't. Steel didn't lie.

She let She-Ra's glow fall away. This was her body she needed to feel working.

Her shirt clung to her almost immediately, cotton darkening with sweat. Muscles pulled tight under her skin as she drove herself harder, pushing through the forms without mercy. Every movement demanded precision; every mistake would punish her. She welcomed it.

It felt good to burn.

To strip everything down to sinew and breath, to the ache in her shoulders and the tremor in her arms. Here there were no politics, no calculated cruelties, no smiling deceptions dressed up as necessity. Just weight, balance, and the truth of a blade that could end a life if she let it.

She fought until there was nothing left but her body—lungs pulling air too fast, blood pounding loud in her ears, sweat slicking her skin. Until thought narrowed to a single line of intent, the certainty of steel moving where she told it to.

When she finally stopped, the silence hit hard.

She lowered the sword and turned.

Catra stood in the doorway.

Adora hadn't heard her enter. Had no idea how long she'd been there. The awareness of being watched landed late and unwelcome. She didn't bother to straighten, didn't care how she looked—sweat-soaked, breathing hard, raw with exertion. Whatever this was between them, it wasn't finished. But it didn't need to be resolved now. It could stay open. She wanted it to, in fact.

"If you're this angry," Catra said lightly, eyes sharp, "you should fight a real opponent."

"There's no one—" Adora began, then cut herself off. The rest of it pressed heavy between them. No one she wouldn't seriously hurt. Not like this. Not when her restraint was all but gone.

Catra's smile was all teeth. "I'm standing right here."

Adora's pulse spiked.

It was a *terrible* idea. Every instinct she had said so. She felt it in the restless hum under her skin as Catra stepped fully inside, reaching up to take a sword from the wall. Adora remembered Catra's movements—quick, exact, vicious when she wanted them to be. Remembered watching her dismantle Hordak, the way her hands never hesitated.

She remembered other things too.

The tug at her collar. Claws raking down her back. The shock of being driven to her knees. Memory slid in where it wasn't wanted, sharp and uninvited.

Her voice came out low, rough. "You want me to put you down?"

Catra's gaze didn't waver. "You think you could?"

She let the sheath drop without looking. It vanished into the sawdust as she settled into position, loose and ready, blade bare in her hand.

Adora tightened her grip on her own sword.

Care had fled her body entirely. Control was already thinning. She could feel how close she was to letting all of the strength go where it pleased.

She had warned Catra. That would have to be enough.

Adora went in first.

Steel rang as she drove a sharp, three-beat combination straight at Catra's guard. Catra met it cleanly, blades kissing and sliding, then pivoted away in a smooth arc, turning so the open length of the hall lay behind her instead of the door.

Adora followed immediately, pressing. Catra gave ground—measured, deliberate—using the space, letting the distance stretch. Step by step she retreated, light on her feet, always just out of reach.

Too familiar.

Adora felt the recognition hit, unwelcome and sharp. This was the same mistake Hordak had made—assuming Catra would meet force with force, that the fight would resolve itself quickly if you just hit hard enough. Instead, Catra slipped away from commitment. Her blade flicked in, withdrew. Bait, then vanish. No wasted motion. No follow-through unless it mattered.

It grated.

Tap.

Tap.

Tap.

They had crossed nearly the entire arena now, the scarred post looming to Adora's right. Catra's breathing stayed even, almost lazy.

When Adora closed again, Catra ducked low and spun around the post, using it like a hinge, so that once more the hall stretched out behind her.

Catra glanced over her shoulder, amused. "We planning to march back and forth all night, or are you going to make this interesting?"

Adora answered with violence.

She drove a full-strength cut straight in, fast and uncompromising, leaving Catra no room to slip away. Catra barely got her blade up in time. Steel screamed as they met. Adora felt the shock run through Catra's arms, saw the jolt travel up her shoulders as the

impact wrenched her balance loose and sent her stumbling back several hard steps.

“That enough for you?” Adora said.

Catra recovered quickly, but she gave another step, eyes narrowed now, posture tighter. The ease had bled away, replaced by attention.

Adora smiled. “I figured I’d let you warm up first,” she said. “Before I strip you down.”

Catra snorted. “Funny. I thought the whole reason you came here was because you couldn’t have that.”

This time, when Adora attacked, Catra met her properly.

She sank into the blow, took it through her body instead of her arms, blade scraping violently down Adora’s as she rolled under the guard and surged in close. Adora had to react on instinct alone, steel flashing in a quick, ugly scramble before she forced Catra back with a violent shove of momentum.

Her pulse thundered. She realized she was smiling.

“You’re pretty good,” Adora said, and heard the satisfaction in her own voice.

Catra’s breath was no longer perfectly steady. That pleased her too.

Adora didn’t give her time to reset. She pressed in, relentless, turning each opening into another strike, driving Catra back into constant defense. Catra blocked with both hands now, the force shuddering up her arms, down into her stance.

And still—she struck back.

Quick. Precise. Dangerous.

Catra could pivot on nothing, turn inside a heartbeat, and Adora felt herself pulled deeper into her, attention narrowing, the world shrinking to the space between their blades. She didn't rush the finish.

Not yet.

That would come later.

Catra's sword work drew Adora in despite herself.

It wasn't brute or showy. It was all fine lines and misdirection, a web of small movements layered over one another—feints folded into feints, invitations that vanished the moment you reached for them. Experiencing it firsthand felt like studying an intricate knot: beautiful, clever, and designed to tighten the harder you pulled. There was a perverse regret in Adora at the thought of breaking it apart.

She eased back, letting the blades separate, and began to circle. Not retreat—never that—but grant space, deliberately. Catra took it without comment, shoulders rising and falling a little faster now. Sweat darkened the hair at her temples. She adjusted her grip, rolled her wrist once, testing.

Adora tracked it all.

"How's the shoulder holding up?" she asked, lightly.

Catra's mouth twitched. "It's offended you're wasting time," she said. "So am I."

She lifted her blade again, sharp and ready.

Good.

Adora surged forward, driving straight into Catra's counters, forcing her to commit. This was what she wanted—not the evasions, not the teasing slips, but honest steel meeting steel.

Catra gave it to her, beautifully, turning each blow aside with infuriating precision.

And still—there it was. The same pattern. The same refusal to meet her head-on unless there was something to gain. Adora felt irritation burn hotter, thoughts bleeding into motion: the way Catra fought mirrored everything else about her. The careful sidesteps. The clever redirections. Never taking the obvious path when something else could be placed in the way instead. Slaves. Civilians. Whole villages used like terrain.

Enough.

Adora broke through.

She knocked Catra's blade wide with a brutal sweep, stepped inside her guard, and drove the pommel of her sword hard into Catra's stomach. The air went out of her in a sharp, startled sound. Before Catra could recover, Adora hooked her and threw her down.

Catra hit the sawdust with a thud that rattled through the room.

Adora followed her down, blade already leveled, point hovering at the line of Catra's throat. Catra lay sprawled, one knee bent, chest heaving under her thin shirt. Her fingers dug into the sawdust, dragging lines through it as she fought for breath. The sword tip traced down, unhurried, from throat to belly.

"Are we done?" Adora said, voice steady and cold.

She held there, absolute control.

"Yield."

For half a heartbeat, Catra didn't move.

Then grit and darkness exploded across Adora's vision.

Adora swore, squeezing her eyes shut as sawdust burned into them. Instinct saved her—she pulled her blade back just enough as Catra twisted away. By the time Adora cleared her sight, Catra was already rolling to her feet, sword back in hand, breathing ragged but eyes bright with something sharp and feral.

Adora wiped her forearm across her face and stared at her.

"That's cheap," she said. "And it wouldn't save you in a real fight."

Catra straightened, shoulders squared, a grin tugging at her mouth. "I don't fight for your approval," she said. "I fight to stay standing."

"You won't," Adora replied. "Not like that."

The smile vanished.

The change in Catra was instant—no warning, no flourish. She came at Adora with full intent, blade cutting through the air with lethal speed, no tricks involved now.

Adora cut hard to the side, then back again, boots skidding in the sawdust as she brought her blade up just in time. Even so, she was forced to yield ground. For a handful of heartbeats there was nothing in the world but steel—silver edges flashing too close, too fast—every scrap of her attention narrowed to survival.

Catra had stopped holding anything back.

The careful elegance was gone. The teasing half-steps, the coy retreats—burned away. What was left was raw intent, her eyes bright and fierce, jaw set, every strike driven by something unguarded and incandescent. Rage, yes—but not only rage. There was a wild, reckless joy in it too, the thrill of finally cutting loose.

Adora felt it answer something in her.

She met the assault head-on, blade ringing again and again, her arms humming with the impact. Step by step, muscle by muscle,

she began to turn the tide, pushing Catra back despite the ferocity of it.

Catra's sword sliced clean through a tension rope. Adora heard the crack before she saw the shelf above her start to give way. She lunged back just as mounted armor thundered down, metal crashing into sawdust where her head had been. Catra didn't pause—she kicked a bench into Adora's path, sending it skidding sideways. Loose helms and shields turned the floor treacherous, forcing Adora into uneven footing.

She registered it with a flash of grim admiration. Catra wasn't just fighting her—she was fighting the room.

Still, it wasn't enough.

At the central post, Catra dipped low instead of meeting the blow. Adora's sword bit deep into the wooden beam with a jarring thud, stuck fast. Adora released it instantly, ducking as Catra's blade cut through the space where her throat had been. She tore the sword free just in time—

—just in time to see Catra snatch up a knife and let it fly.

The blade whistled straight for her neck.

Adora knocked it aside with a sharp, practiced flick and kept coming, closing the distance before Catra could reset. Steel clashed again, slid, locked. Adora leaned in, strength pouring through her arms. She felt Catra's injured shoulder give, just slightly—and that was all she needed.

She wrenched the sword free from Catra's grasp.

The next heartbeat, Catra was slammed back against the wood-paneled wall. The sound she made was rough and helpless, breath punched from her lungs as her teeth clicked together. Adora crowded her instantly, forearm braced hard against Catra's throat, pinning her there.

She flung her own sword aside without looking.

Catra's hand shot out anyway, desperate, feral—fingers closing around another knife from the wall display and driving it toward Adora's ribs.

"No," Adora said.

She caught Catra's wrist mid-strike and smashed it back into the wall. Once. Again. The third blow jolted the knife loose; it clattered to the floor between them.

Adora held her there, breathing hard, forearm still firm at Catra's throat—close enough to feel the tremor running through her, close enough to feel how alive she was.

Catra bucked hard beneath her with feral force, a sudden explosion of motion that slammed their sweat-slick bodies together. It was ugly, desperate fighting—no finesse left in it at all. Adora absorbed the surge and drove them both back into the wall, crowding Catra there, using her weight to lock her in place.

It almost worked.

Catra's free arm snapped up and struck Adora straight in the throat. The blow stole her breath in a raw, choking rasp, just long enough for Catra to wrench her hips forward and drive a knee into Adora's stomach with everything she had.

White-black flashed across Adora's vision. Pain flared, bright and blinding—but instinct cut through it before thought could catch up. She hauled Catra off the wall and threw her down, hard. Catra hit the sawdust with a solid, bone-rattling impact that knocked the air from her lungs in a harsh gasp.

She didn't stay down.

Catra scrabbled up immediately, wild-eyed, unsteady, fury written into every line of her face. Her hand went for the knife again—fast, reckless—

Too slow.

“That’s enough,” Adora said, her voice low and final.

She drove her knee into Catra’s stomach, folded her in half, then forced her flat onto her back and followed her down. Her weight came down fully this time, pinning Catra to the floor. Adora caught Catra’s wrist mid-reach and slammed it into the sawdust once, twice—hard enough that the knife fell from numb fingers.

Adora locked both of Catra’s wrists to the ground and leaned over her, breathing hard, every muscle coiled and burning. Catra lay rigid beneath her, chest heaving, heat radiating up between them. Adora tightened her grip, not letting her move an inch.

Catra fought it for a few seconds more—one last futile surge—then let out a raw, broken sound and went still. Not relaxed. Never that. Just spent. Furious. Panting.

They were both breathing hard, sweat dripping, bodies trembling with the aftershock of violence held barely in check.

“Say it,” Adora demanded.

Catra’s jaw clenched. She stared off to the side, eyes blazing.

“I yield,” she bit out at last.

Adora didn’t move. Her weight stayed firm.

“I want you to understand this,” Adora said, her voice thick, stripped of any softness. “You think I was powerless when I was your slave? I wasn’t. I could have tried this then. Any time.”

Catra laughed, sharp and bitter. “Get off me.”

Adora released her and pushed back. Catra rolled away immediately and dragged herself upright, bracing a hand against the post. Sawdust clung to her skin and hair, streaked across her back.

Catra turned on her, breathing hard. “You want me to say it?” she snapped. “That I never stood a chance?” Her voice wavered, twisted with something raw. “Fine. I couldn’t beat you. I never would have.”

Adora met her gaze without flinching. “No,” she said quietly. “You couldn’t. And if you’d come for revenge, I would have killed you. That’s the truth. That’s what it always would have been.”

She let the words settle, heavy as a blade laid down between them.

“Is that what you wanted?” Adora asked.

Catra didn’t hesitate. Her answer came immediate and brutal.

“Yes.”

Her voice dropped, stripped bare.

“She was everything I had.”

The silence that followed was thick enough to choke on.

“I know,” Catra said, the words coming flat and stripped of bravado, “that I was never good enough.”

Adora didn’t hesitate. “Neither was your mother.”

Catra’s head snapped up. “That’s not true. She was—”

“What?” Adora pressed.

“She was more powerful than me.” Catra’s voice hitched, then sharpened, as if she could cut the feeling short if she spoke fast enough. “She would have—”

She stopped herself. Her eyes shut tight. A breath escaped her that might have been a laugh, if laughter could sound so hollow.

“She would have stopped you,” Catra finished, distantly, as though she were talking about someone abstract, not the woman standing in front of her.

Adora bent and picked up the knife from the sawdust.

Catra’s eyes opened at the sound. Before she could speak, Adora placed the hilt into Catra’s hand, closing her fingers around it. She guided the grip, then drew the blade in until it rested against her own abdomen—close enough to feel the cold bite of metal through fabric. Catra’s back met the post again, the same geometry as before. The same terrible familiarity.

“Then do it,” Adora said quietly. “Stop me.”

She watched Catra’s face fracture—anger, hunger, grief, instinct all warring at once. Catra’s hand trembled. The knife wavered.

“I know that pull,” Adora said, softer now. “I know what it’s like to want it.”

“You’re unarmed,” Catra said hoarsely.

So are you, Adora thought—but didn’t say. The moment was already slipping, destabilizing, turning into something else entirely. Her grip on Catra’s wrist loosened without her quite deciding to let go.

The knife dropped. It hit the sawdust with a dull, final thud.

Adora stepped back at once, as if distance were the only thing keeping the moment from collapsing in on itself. She found herself two paces away, chest rising too fast, breath rough for reasons that had nothing to do with the fight.

The arena around them bore the scars of what they’d done: benches knocked aside, bits of armour strewn across the floor, a banner hanging torn and crooked from the wall. Proof of violence. Proof of restraint.

“I wish—” Adora began.

But there was no way to finish her sentence.

They couldn’t rewrite the past.

Chapter End Notes

I really warred with myself over which pov to put this in... But Catra’s would have hurt a lot more I think.

Another chapter tomorrow ✌️

Maybe 2

Chapter 16: Catra

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Isobel was already in Catra's rooms when she returned.

The girl dropped to her knees the instant the door closed, too fast, too fluid—like something poured rather than something choosing to move.

Catra stopped just inside the threshold.

"Still here," she said. Her voice gave her away: scraped thin, exhausted past the point of performance. It had cost her everything she had left to make it back here upright—to school her step, to pause long enough for Marzo's report, to let Entrapta chatter cheerfully at her elbow about some improvement Catra hadn't heard a word of. She had been holding herself together on habit alone.

She had been counting on being alone when she finally let go.

Isobel's presence shattered that hope.

"Your Highness—" Isobel began, panic sharp and immediate.

Catra shut the door harder than necessary. "Stop. If you're about to beg, cry, or abase yourself, save us both the trouble."

Isobel's breath hitched anyway. "Princess, forgive this one—this one was not permitted to return to the slave halls without formal dismissal. The masters would not—" Her voice wavered. "This one could not bear to confess that she had offended the Princess of the Horde."

Catra pinched the bridge of her nose. Gods. Of course. Etherian etiquette—cruelty wrapped in silk and rules and ritual so dense no

one could move without permission.

“I came here to fall apart in private,” Catra said flatly. “I don’t have the energy to manage your meltdown on top of that.”

Isobel looked up at her then, tears standing bright and confused in her eyes, as if she couldn’t quite reconcile the words with the tone. Catra exhaled, long and sharp.

“You’re all astonishingly high-maintenance,” she muttered. “No—don’t apologize. If you apologize again, I swear I’ll have you whipped just to make you stop.” She waved a hand. “Get up. I can’t get out of this on my own.”

That was true, and she hated it. The walk back from the arena had taken more out of her than she’d admit to anyone else. The jacket was too stiff at the shoulders, the fastenings fiddly, her muscles screaming in protest.

Isobel scrambled to her feet at once, hands hovering uncertainly until Catra snapped, “Buttons.”

“Yes, Your Highness,” Isobel breathed, relief flooding her voice at having something concrete to do.

“And I’ll need ice,” Catra added, shrugging out of one sleeve with a hiss. “A lot of it. See what can be procured.”

Isobel blinked. “This one… will still be permitted to serve?”

Catra shot her a look. “I’m not dismissing you.”

The girl sagged with visible relief—then froze, as if afraid to hope too much.

“I’m also not sleeping with you,” Catra said bluntly. “In case that was part of the fantasy.” She softened it not at all. “That doesn’t mean you failed. It means I’m done.” A beat. “With sex. Entirely. Lifetime ban. You’ll live longer without it, trust me.”

Isobel swallowed. The disappointment was immediate, naked—and then, worse, comprehension dawned. Her eyes widened. Color rushed into her cheeks.

Catra closed her eyes. “Don’t,” she warned.

Too late.

“The bond between Your Highness and the Queen,” Isobel said in awed reverence, “must be legendary—if both deny themselves all others—”

Catra groaned and dragged a hand down her face.

“That is not what is happening,” she said tightly. “And if you finish that sentence, I will personally throw you out a window.”

She pointed at the door. “Ice. Now. Before I change my mind.”

✧

Somehow—against her better judgment and every expectation she had of her own limits—Catra managed to get herself undressed without calling Isobel back.

It wasn’t graceful. It wasn’t painless. But she did it.

She peeled herself out of stiff fabric and buckles with clenched teeth, folded the clothes away because old habits died hard, and scrubbed the blood and sweat from her skin with a vicious thoroughness that bordered on punishment. She worked the taps herself, remembered which levers controlled heat and depth, filled the tub until steam crawled up the walls.

She lowered herself into the water like someone stepping into a trap.

Sending Isobel away had been the right call. Catra knew that. She didn’t want soft voices or anxious hands or wide, reverent eyes

cataloguing every mark on her body. She didn’t want concern. She didn’t want devotion. She didn’t want to be seen.

The cost was complete silence.

It pressed in immediately, thick and merciless. No footsteps. No breath that wasn’t her own. No one to occupy space so she didn’t have to occupy her head.

That was her mistake.

She bruised easily. Always had. Even with fur, even trained, even armoured in spite. Her skin was already blooming dark beneath the water, purple and green shadows surfacing where Adora’s hands, knees, forearms had landed. By morning it would be unmistakable. The soak wouldn’t help. The ice wouldn’t help much either.

Isobel would help, when she came back—too much. She’d gasp, hover, fetch pillows and ointments and the softest shirt she could find, like Catra was something fragile that had cracked.

Catra closed her eyes and sank lower in the tub.

She didn’t have time to cry. She didn’t even know if she could anymore. And if she *could*, she wasn’t about to give herself that luxury—curled up and shaking in a bath like a child who’d lost something precious.

But the truth didn’t care about her rules.

It settled in anyway, slow and absolute.

She had been wrong.

There was no clever angle she’d missed. No trick she could have pulled faster, harder, smarter. Adora had always been exactly what she appeared to be—good, and brutal, and honest to the point of stupidity. Strong in ways Catra could never counterfeit. There had never been a version of this where Catra won.

Not fairly. Not cleanly. Not without becoming something completely ruinous.

She could never have beaten her. And worse—she shouldn't have.

If Catra had somehow found a way, if she had taken Adora out of the world the way Shadow Weaver would have wanted, it would have been the same unforgivable crime she'd always accused Adora of: destroying something rare and irreplaceable because it was inconvenient.

Adora was a light. Unbearably bright. Unmatched.

All those years of sharpening herself on hatred. All that careful cultivation of rage and survival and spite. All of it had led her here, to the undeniable fact that it had never been enough.

She had never been enough.

The water was scalding. Her skin stung. She shook anyway, teeth chattering, unable to feel warmth through the ache in her bones.

Tomorrow the games would start.

Tomorrow she would walk, and sit, and sneer, and trade barbs, and pretend she wasn't marked head to toe. Tomorrow she would take her place beside Adora—Princess and Queen, shoulder to shoulder—and sell the lie of unity to two armies desperate to believe in it.

A friendship. A myth.

A thing Catra had broken long before she ever understood its worth.

She sank until the water lapped at her chin.

Tonight there was no performance left in her. No calculation. No edge to lean on.

Just the truth, settling deep and heavy: that she had been utterly, entirely wrong—and that there was no road back to what she had lost, no matter how much she wanted one.

✧

Whatever condition Isobel found the Princess of the Horde in when she returned with the ice never left that room.

If Isobel discovered her slack and unmoving in bathwater gone lukewarm—if she saw the swollen eyes, the telltale tracks of tears Catra would rather have bled than displayed to anyone—Isobel absorbed it without comment, without reaction, the way all well-trained things learned to do. She had been taught what silence was worth.

Catra did not speak again that night.

She let herself be lifted from the bath, compliant in a way that would have alarmed anyone who knew her well. She endured the towel, the careful hands, the scented oils rubbed into bruises that made her jaw tighten even as she said nothing. She swallowed a mouthful of wine before realizing what Isobel had put to her lips—and then, sharply, viciously, she hurled the goblet across the room. Glass burst against stone.

Isobel did not flinch.

Catra allowed herself to be put to bed. She let Isobel lie beside her, cool cloth of ice pressed to her ribs, to her shoulders, to places that throbbed with memory. She turned her face away. She slept.

Morning came anyway.

Light crept in through the windows, warm and intrusive, painting the walls in soft pink and amber as if the night had not left anything behind. Catra rose before Isobel stirred. She dressed herself in a uniform cut tight and unforgiving, the kind that held

her together whether she liked it or not. She drank an entire pot of coffee strong enough to scrape the back of her throat raw.

Then she became the Princess of the Horde again.

Entrapta was waiting for her, of course.

“You look terrible,” Entrapta said immediately, peering at her over the rim of a steaming cup. There was no concern in her tone—just blunt assessment, like she was diagnosing a malfunctioning machine. “If you skipped sleep again—”

“Is that a threat?” Catra muttered, not looking up from her coffee. “Please allow me the dignity of finishing this before you decide to discipline me.”

Entrapta recoiled. “Oh! Ew. No. Absolutely not.” She waved a hand, appalled. “That’s not my department. I'll get Marzo to do it. Unless you'd prefer Isobel.”

Catra took a slow sip. “Tragic. I’ll have to decline the generous offer of corporal punishment, though. I slept. See? Functional. Vertical.”

Entrapta squinted at her.

They stood there, mirror images in posture if not temperament—Catra with her dark, bitter brew; Entrapta cradling a cup that smelled aggressively of flowers. Lavender and rose drifted between them.

“I don’t believe you,” Entrapta said flatly.

“I slept,” Catra repeated.

“I am not risking another near-total operational collapse because you decided sleep was optional,” Entrapta shot back. “I've already done that once. Statistically inadvisable.”

Catra did not think about the bruises. About the way her back screamed when she moved, or the ugly constellation blooming beneath the uniform's stiff internal plating. She had chosen the outfit carefully—layers, reinforcement, compression. Armour masquerading as clothing. If Entrapta so much as suspected the extent of the damage, she would be halfway to summoning a medic before Catra could blink.

And then there would be questions.

And fussing.

And tea.

"Your concerns have been logged," Catra said coolly. "They will be reviewed and ignored in due course."

Entrapta sniffed and took another sip of her tea. "You know, rose and lavender are excellent for calming the nervous system."

"Fascinating," Catra replied. "You should drink two."

Entrapta watched her over the rim of the cup, thoughtful, sharp-eyed. But she let it go.

Catra made a point of taking breakfast in the grand hall.

Not because she wanted to eat there—she didn't—but because another absence would be read as weakness, and she refused to give anyone the satisfaction. Least of all Adora. Least of all after last night. If Adora thought she was skulking in her rooms, bruised and humiliated and licking her wounds, Catra would rather choke on stale bread in public than allow that illusion to stand.

And—because she was painfully aware of her own contradictions—she had hoped Adora might come.

She had told herself it was strategic. Optics. Control, even. But the truth sat sharper beneath it: she wanted one more chance to

pull Adora aside. Somewhere quiet. Somewhere without swords or witnesses or blood in the air.

She wanted to say she was sorry.

The thought alone tasted like rust.

Catra had spent the morning turning the words over, discarding them, reshaping them. She'd woken early, long before the fort stirred, her head already full and aching. She summoned Marzo first—confirmed what she'd suspected: Frosta was preparing to pull her forces back. No delay. No hesitation.

Over her first pot of coffee, Catra drafted the letter.

She did not allow herself poetry. She did not allow herself sentiment. She wrote it clean and sharp, the way one carved something into stone and trusted it to last.

Whatever doubts you harbor about this alliance—about me, my motives, my past—I urge you not to mistake them for flaws in the Queen of Etheria. Adora is not naïve. She is not weak. She is the rarest kind of ruler: capable, honorable, and willing to bleed for those she protects. There is no worthier claimant to Etheria's throne. Do not place yourself in opposition to her at a moment when she still believes in you.

She sealed it, handed it to Marzo, and sent him off before the sun cleared the horizon. No ceremony. No second-guessing.

Then she went to breakfast.

Adora did not.

Catra waited.

She drank a second pot of coffee that tasted like punishment. Isobel hovered, earnest and determined, depositing fruit and bread and small pastries with the optimism of someone convinced

nourishment solved everything. Under Entrapta's unblinking stare, Catra even ate some of it.

Double Trouble arrived with Baker not long after, both far too relaxed for Catra's liking, moving together with the casual familiarity of people who enjoyed surviving. Catra endured the sight of them with narrowed eyes and finished her coffee out of spite.

Adora still didn't come.

The hall filled. Plates cleared. The noise shifted from morning murmurs to the low buzz of anticipation as people prepared for the games.

Adora never appeared.

Catra checked the time once. Then again.

Finally, she pushed back from the table, irritation and something sharper knotting beneath her ribs. If Adora was avoiding her, that was her prerogative. If she was working herself into exhaustion instead of eating, that was infuriating—but familiar.

Catra rose, adjusted her jacket, and left for the games.

Whatever words she'd rehearsed would have to wait.

✧

The borderline fields had been scraped clean and remade for spectacle.

Once, this ground had been nothing but churned earth and broken bodies—Etherian banners ground into the mud, Fright Zone standards trampled underfoot, the soil dark with old blood. Now it had been tamed. Leveled. Dressed up in silk and order, as if that could erase memory. The games were meant to mark unity: the return of Etheria's Queen, the binding of two enemies into

allies. Catra noted, with a detached attention, that the site had been chosen carefully.

Nowhere near the ruins.

Shadow Weaver's death-place lay well beyond the horizon, deliberately hidden. Catra doubted that was an accident.

The field had been transformed into something almost festive. Benches and tiered stands rose in careful arcs. Tables overflowed with chilled fruits, sugared pastries, jugs of wine already sweating in the sun. Targets had been planted at measured distances. The grass rings had been trampled flat for wrestling and sparring. Beyond them, tents flapped lazily—kitchens, rest shelters, discreet latrines kept immaculate by silent hands.

At the center stood the canopy.

Silk stretched overhead in pale blues and whites, shading the royal seating. Two thrones waited beneath it, identical in height and ornament, positioned side by side with conspicuous symmetry. Additional chairs fanned out behind them for attendants and honored guests.

The soldiers were already arriving in force, spilling across the slopes, clustering in groups that told their own story. Etherians with Etherians. Horde with Horde. The mingling was cautious at best. That, Catra knew, was the point of all this pageantry—to soften edges, to somehow trick proximity into familiarity.

She scanned the field once.

Frosta wasn't there.

Neither was Adora.

That absence sat wrong in her chest.

"It's a good day for it," Mermista said, coming up alongside her.

Catra didn’t look at her right away. She already knew how the woman was smiling—measured, diplomatic, pleasant in the way of someone who never forgot how sharp the knives under the table were. Mermista didn’t trust her. Catra had known that from the start. She questioned this alliance. Questioned Catra. But she did it properly, behind closed doors, in deference to Adora’s desires.

To Catra’s face, Mermista had become unfailingly polite.

“The weather held,” Mermista continued. “The soldiers need something like this. An outlet. Stars know they’ve been coiled tight.”

“How thrilling for them,” Catra replied flatly. “Where is she?”

Mermista’s smile strained, just a fraction. “She’ll come. She was… encouraged by how many of your soldiers signed on for the events.”

“Ah,” Catra said. “Nothing inspires unity like competitive violence.”

Mermista let that pass. “You’re not competing.”

Catra reached the canopy and took her seat, crossing one leg over the other. She glanced up at Mermista, who was still standing, hands folded, posture impeccable.

“My involvement would skew the results, I fear.” Catra said lightly. Mermista huffed, unconvinced, but before she could respond Catra added, casually, “While I have you—about the slave. Isobel.”

Mermista’s brow furrowed, irritation surfacing despite herself. “She was worried she’d offended you. If you’d prefer another, I can have the Keeper arrange—”

“No,” Catra cut in. “I’m very satisfied with her.”

Mermista blinked. “Do you want to… keep her?”

“I want her services,” Catra corrected. “Not ownership.”

Mermista’s patience visibly thinned. “So, you’re not asking to purchase her?”

“I don’t buy people.”

Silence, sharp and uncomfortable. She *had* owned Adora.

Mermista stared at her. “Then what exactly are you asking?”

“That you release her,” Catra said smoothly. “So I can offer her employment. Wages. Terms. Choice.”

Mermista’s composure cracked just enough to show the calculation underneath. “You realize what you’re asking.”

“I do.”

“This isn’t how things are done.”

“Consider it a cultural exchange.”

Mermista studied Catra’s face, searching for mockery, provocation, a trap. Catra gave her none of it—only calm entitlement, as if this were the most reasonable request in the world. It should have been.

“You put me in an impossible position,” Mermista said finally.

Catra tilted her head. “I thought you'd like the challenge.”

Mermista’s jaw tightened.

Catra had been fully prepared to sit there, staring, until the sun burned itself out of the sky.

She could outlast Mermista. She knew that. Patience was a skill she’d honed the hard way. But the roar that rolled across the field—the sudden swell of voices, the scrape of boots and benches—ended the contest for her. Etheria had announced its Queen.

Catra looked up despite herself.

It was a mistake. Her eyes found Adora instantly, as they always did, and in that heartbeat of distraction Mermista took her escape—turning neatly away, smoothing her skirts, retreating to her seat without offering so much as a promise. No answer. No refusal. Just gone.

Catra swallowed her irritation and kept her face smooth.

Adora arrived in She-Ra's form—impossible height and gleaming strength, as though the night before had never happened. As though Catra hadn't left pieces of herself pressed into sawdust and splintered wood. While Catra hid a livid map of bruises under stiff layers and plating, Adora wore almost nothing at all—bare arms, bare thighs, that infuriating scrap of white fabric that barely counted as a dress.

The skirt rode obscenely high. Her boots wrapped her calves like sculpted metal. The platinum cuff and silver bangles gleamed at her wrists, bracelets stacked along her forearms. Her crown—gold wings flaring back from her temples—caught the light as she moved.

Perfect. Untouched. Untouchable.

Adora's gaze flicked to Catra out of instinct—and slid right past her.

She didn't smile. She didn't nod. She sat without a word.

Something cold settled in Catra's stomach.

"She's not coming," Mermista said quietly, following Adora's glance toward the empty space where Frosta should have been.

Catra tipped her head just enough to catch Marzo's eye. He gave the smallest nod. The letter had reached its mark before the northern troops broke camp.

"Give her time," Adora said, though the words lacked conviction. Her shoulders were tight, her posture rigid.

Mermista still didn't look at Catra. "Horde Prime took half our army with two hundred soldiers."

Catra smiled sweetly and leaned back in her chair. "And a blue coat," she added.

Adora ignored them both. Her stare stayed fixed on the field ahead, jaw clenched hard enough Catra could see the tension ripple down her neck. Catra resisted the urge to glance at Marzo again, to demand details—tone, posture, reaction. If the letter had failed, she didn't want Adora catching even a hint of it.

Marzo, in any case, was wholly occupied. His new wife sat tucked against his side, dressed far above her station in a gown Baker had clearly splurged on. They held hands openly. Every so often, he leaned in to murmur something that made her laugh, soft and bright, cheeks coloring like a girl half her age.

The contrast was… loud.

Between them, Entrapta's cheerful absorption, and the brittle, wordless distance between Baker and Double Trouble, the space beside Catra felt cavernous.

Finally, Adora spoke.

"Well," she said, forcing something like levity, "at least the javelin throw won't be a foregone conclusion this year."

The attempt at humour fell flat. The defeat in her voice lingered, souring it.

When Adora stood, the reaction was immediate—soldiers and nobles rising as one, a ripple of obedience rolling outward across benches and grassy slopes alike.

Catra stayed seated.

She crossed her arms and watched.

Adora lifted her hand, palm out, and the field quieted at once. Every eye turned to her.

Catra felt the distance between them stretch—measured now not in feet, but in silence.

"Today, we remember the dead," Adora declared, her voice carrying cleanly across the field. It was steady, measured—Queen's cadence, not warrior's bark. "We honour them by standing together. Horde and Etheria. Compete with respect. Fight clean. Let the games begin."

The response came like a breaking wave. Cheers, whistles, shouted boasts. Whatever unease still lingered between the factions loosened under the promise of spectacle and sanctioned rivalry. Competitors shook out shoulders and rolled wrists. Horde soldiers heckled the Etherians with loud, good-natured filth. Etherians answered in kind.

"Oh, good," Adora said, bright with interest, turning toward Mermista as if Catra weren't there at all. "Looks like Keston decided to enter."

They bent their heads together, talking easily about the lineup—strengths, odds, gossip. Catra leaned back in her chair and folded her arms, fixing her attention on the field with deliberate focus. If she was being excluded, she would not give the satisfaction of noticing.

Isobel returned once her labouring was finished, slipping into place beneath the canopy with practiced quiet. She set a fan near Catra's shoulder and arranged a tray within easy reach: black coffee, water, juice. No wine. A small bowl of grapes. She kept her eyes down, presence minimal, anticipating needs without prompting.

Catra barely noticed as she tried to not notice Adora and Mermista's easy friendship.

The competitions blurred together. They should have been entertaining—skill on display, camaraderie edging into bravado—but Catra found no pleasure in it. Every shift of her weight reminded her of last night. Every breath pulled tight against bruises she couldn't afford to acknowledge.

And beside her—

Adora laughed. Applauded. Leaned forward with her elbows on her knees, wholly engaged.

Adora, who did not look at Catra.

Adora, who did not glance over with that familiar heat, that searching intensity Catra had come to expect—had learned to brace for.

Adora, who did not speak to her at all.

Catra held herself rigidly upright, gaze forward, expression composed.

Clone 28 took the marksmanship trial, preening shamelessly afterward—strutting, flexing, blowing kisses at scandalized Etherians. The Horde roared their approval. Later, Lonnie won the short sword bout, clean and efficient.

Once, Catra would have felt pride flare sharp and bright. Once, Lonnie would have lifted her blade toward Catra's seat, victory offered up like a vow.

Today, Lonnie gave a neat bow toward the canopy—formal, distant—and slipped back into the ranks. She avoided Entrapta's eyes entirely.

Catra's mouth curved briefly. Nothing more.

By afternoon, the smell of roasting meat drifted in from the cooking tents, smoke curling lazily into the sky. The wrestling ring was cleared, and the crowd pressed closer.

Etherians stripped down to little more than wraps and underlayers, skin gleaming with oil and sweat. Horde soldiers shed armour but kept more coverage, bulk and padding lingering out of habit if not need. Clone 28, predictably, reduced himself to the bare minimum and seemed delighted by the excuse to grapple half-naked men. He lost almost immediately—Keston put him down with embarrassing ease.

The Horde didn't mind. They cheered louder for wrestling than anything else so far.

Entrapta barely looked up from her screens.

Keston won. Again.

Short sword. Trident. Wrestling.

By his third victory, the Salinean was breathing hard, hair plastered to his forehead, tanned skin flushed with exertion. He crossed the field and dropped to one knee before Adora, still stripped down, still smiling like he could barely contain it.

He tried—credit where it was due—to sober his expression, to lend the moment its proper weight.

"If it pleases my Queen," he said, voice steady despite his grin, "I claim the right of challenge. I ask the honour of fighting with She-Ra."

Catra had been half-watching the games at best, counting the minutes until she could plausibly disappear without it looking like a desperate retreat, when the roar of the crowd snapped her attention back into focus.

Adora was already on her feet.

There wasn't even a pause—no ceremony, no false modesty. She-Ra's magic peeled away cape and dress at a thought, fabric dissolving until Adora stood stripped down to something barely

more than training wraps. Sunlight caught on bare skin and silver cuff alike.

And then she *bounded* down the steps of the dais, all reckless momentum and easy confidence, like this was exactly where she'd always meant to be.

"Ohhh," Entrapta murmured, glancing up just long enough to register the scene before going back to her screens. "Okay, I get it now. That explains why you're obsessed."

Catra didn't answer right away. She'd seen Adora completely naked before—too many times, in too many contexts—but never like this. Not as a Queen. Not as She-Ra standing in front of half an army, unguarded and radiant and utterly unashamed.

She wasn't even fully nude.

It still had an effect on her.

This Adora was… free.

"I assume she took the lead," Entrapta added absently.

"I assume," Catra said coolly, without looking at her, "that she took the lead, *Your Highness*." She flicked her fingers toward Isobel. "Water."

"If she keeps bounding down the steps like that," Entrapta went on, "she's going to Knock herself out. Nice enough to look at though,"

They weren't *that* big.

Down on the field, Adora was laughing—actually laughing—as she and Keston squared up, hands braced on each other's shoulders. There was no posturing, no cruelty in it. Just strength meeting strength, mutual anticipation.

They went down together.

It was clean. Powerful. Joyful.

Two fighters at the height of their bodies, moving without fear.

And Adora was enjoying herself.

That, more than anything, twisted in Catra's chest.

At least Keston didn't look like her. Didn't move like her. Didn't have Catra's lean build or sharp angles or familiar weight. If he had, the crowd would have been halfway to imagining things they had *no* business imagining.

Even so—

Adora wrestled the way she fucked. Loose and confident and devastatingly physical. Muscle and momentum. The flex of her arms, the power in her back, the brutal grace of her thighs as she shifted her weight—

Gods, that ass…

Catra crossed her legs and stared very intently at the far edge of the field.

The match stretched on, an eternity measured in sweat and cheers and Catra's own teeth clenched hard enough to ache. When it finally ended, Adora was still grinning, still breathless, waving to the crowd as a towel was tossed at her.

She redressed in a shimmer of magic and flopped back into her seat like she hadn't just wrecked Catra's composure beyond repair.

"Good fight," Adora said brightly to Mermista, reaching for wine—

—and then, at last, she looked at Catra.

Really looked.

Her eyes were warm, alive, gold curls mussed in that careless way Catra hated how much she loved. Whatever she saw on Catra's

face made her grin sharpen.

“What?” Adora asked, innocently.

Catra looked away immediately. “Nothing.”

Beside her, Entrapta’s mouth curled into something dangerously delighted, eyes still fixed on her screens as if she hadn’t noticed a thing.

“Mmm,” Entrapta said. "How exciting.”

Catra stared at the field until the heat in her face eased.

Mermista stood. Catra missed the announcement entirely, because Adora rose with her and followed without hesitation, the two of them moving off together in low conversation.

Catra’s hands clenched. Unclenched.

She swallowed.

Then, without quite deciding to—without thinking it through at all—she stood and followed them.

Chapter End Notes

> The next chapter is a little short so that's why I'm posting it today as well 😙

Chapter 17: Adora

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"I'm going to look over the weapons for the last event," Mermista said lightly. "I'd appreciate the company."

She addressed it to Adora, tone casual, but the invitation landed squarely on old habit. Adora had always checked her gear herself—had learned young that blades and bindings failed when you trusted them blindly. The idea of the Queen walking the tents between events, greeting stewards and competitors alike, inspecting what would be used in her name, felt… right.

So Adora rose.

They walked together through the lanes between tents, trading memories the way soldiers did—half boasting, half teasing. Mermista reminded her, smugly, that Adora had never lost the final game. Adora countered that Mermista was still the only one who could land a turning trident throw without cheating physics. The easy familiarity loosened something tight in Adora's chest.

Competing again would feel good.

She lifted the flap of the weapons tent and stepped inside.

It was empty.

Adora turned—just in time for Mermista to close the distance and seize her arm. The grip was hard, sharp enough to sting. Adora froze in surprise more than pain; it never occurred to her to resist. She let herself be driven back a step, let Mermista grab a handful of her cape at the shoulder and *jerk*.

"Mermista—"

The fabric tore. The cape slid loose, taking the top edge of her dress with it, baring her shoulder and back to the cool air.

They stared at each other.

Then Mermista's gaze dropped.

"Your back," she said.

Heat rushed up Adora's neck. She *knew* there were scars. She knew how far they spread, how pale and smooth they'd been rendered by careful tending. They didn't pull. They didn't ache. Even in hard training, they were quiet.

She'd never looked at them.

Now she didn't have to. Mermista's face told her everything.

Mermista reached out again, hands splayed, touching without permission, as if her palms needed proof of what her eyes refused to accept. Her fingers traced scar tissue across Adora's shoulders, down toward her spine.

"Who did this to you?" Mermista demanded.

"I did," Catra said.

Adora spun.

Catra stood framed in the tent opening, posture composed, expression infuriatingly serene. Her attention rested on Mermista with lazy precision, like a blade balanced on a fingertip.

The air between them went very still.

"I meant to kill her," Catra said calmly. "Prime wouldn't allow it."

Mermista lurched a step forward on instinct, fury snapping through her like a breaking wave—but Adora's hand was already on her arm, firm, restraining. Mermista's fingers had gone white around the hilt of her dagger. Her eyes never left Catra.

“I had considered removing her tongue at one point, too.” Catra continued, unbothered. “I'm glad I didnt, though,” she hummed, theatrically pleased. “She is *far* too skilled with that thing.”

She licked her lips to drive the point home.

For an instant, Adora could think of nothing but the taste of Catra on her tongue.

Mermista made a sound—half disbelief, half revulsion. “Adora,” she said tightly, every word dragged through clenched teeth, “I formally request leave to challenge the Princess of the Horde. A duel of honour. For the insult.”

“Denied,” Adora responded immediately.

Catra’s mouth curved, sharp and satisfied. “You hear that? She’s forgiven me for the small matter of my claws. I’ve forgiven her for the small matter of killing my mother. Long live unity.”

“You stripped the skin from her back,” Mermista spat. Her anger was barely contained now; it sat on her like a sickness. “How many strikes? Fifty? A hundred? She could have died.”

“Yes,” Catra said mildly. “That was the intention.”

“That’s enough,” Adora said, tightening her grip as Mermista surged again. Then, louder, absolute: “Leave us. Now, Mermista.”

Mermista shook with it—but training won out over rage. She stepped back, jaw locked, eyes burning holes into Catra as she turned and strode from the tent.

Silence fell hard.

Adora stood facing Catra, one side of her dress torn and hanging loose, skin bare where the fabric had been ripped away. She didn’t bother to cover it.

“Why would you do that?” Adora demanded. “You think this won’t drive her away? You think she won’t break, like Frosta did?”

“She won’t defect,” Catra said. “She worships you. You’re her Queen.”

“So you test her until she shatters?”

Catra tilted her head. “Was I supposed to *lie*? Tell her I hated it?” Her eyes were bright, unflinching. “I didn’t. I liked it. Especially near the end. When you stopped fighting. When you blacked out. When you nearly drowned.”

The words landed heavy, poisonous.

They were alone—truly alone. Adora felt the weight of it, counted the rarity of it without meaning to: the tent, the field at night, the training hall with blades between them. Always moments edged with malice.

“What are you even doing here?” Adora asked.

“I came to get you,” Catra said. “Mermista was dawdling.”

“You could’ve sent someone.”

Catra didn’t answer right away. Her gaze slid, just for a heartbeat, to the polished mirror behind Adora.

Adora felt it immediately—that prickle along her spine. She followed the look without turning, understanding dawning as their eyes met again.

The scars.

Catra looked away first.

The ache hit Adora, sudden and sharp. “Enjoying the view?” she asked quietly.

“You’re expected back in the stands,” Catra said, deflecting.

“I’ll come once I’ve fixed this,” Adora replied, fingers brushing the torn fabric. “Unless you want to help mend it.”

Catra scoffed. “Why would you need me? Your clothes can fucking fix themselves.”

✧

By the time they returned to their seats, the course had nearly taken its final shape. Posts stood driven deep into the earth, flags snapping in the hot wind. Adora sat beside Catra without a word between them, the space tight with everything unsaid.

The crowd had tipped into something feral. This game always did that to people—the speed, the risk, the promise that someone might break a bone or worse. As the second target was hauled upright and fixed into place, a ripple of sound moved through the stands, a rising hum like insects trapped under skin.

Then the hum broke.

Frosta came in hard from the southwest, mounted on Elk, ice-blue armour catching the sun. She had brought soldiers with her—too many for comfort—and the reaction was immediate. Mermista half rose, instinct sharp, while the guards behind her shifted their grips on their tridents.

Frosta reined in directly before the canopy.

She didn’t dismount.

She didn’t bow.

She turned her elk so they faced Adora head-on.

“You missed javelin,” Adora called, keeping her voice level.

“A village burned with my name on it,” Frosta shot back. “I’m not here for stupid sport.”

Her voice carried—clear, commanding, sharpened for battlefields rather than courts. She wanted everyone to hear her. Adora felt it land in the stands, felt the soldiers lean in.

"I have eight thousand fighters ready to stand with you," Frosta continued. "But I won't march for a Queen who hides behind alliances and lets others bleed for her."

The insult was deliberate, but not for Adora.

Frosta's gaze slid to the field—then snapped sideways, fixing on Catra.

"I'll swear my banners," Frosta said, loud and certain, "if the Princess of the Horde rides."

The reaction came in a wave. Adora felt it without turning: surprise, disbelief, the quick cruel tallying. To Etherian eyes, Catra didn't look like a rider. She didn't train in public. She didn't compete. She sat like she did now—composed, languid, untouched by the dust and sweat of the day.

"The Horde doesn't train for these games," Adora said carefully.

"In Etheria," Frosta replied, "this is the sport of Queens." Her mouth curved, sharp and knowing. "And our Queen will ride. Does the Princess of the Horde lack the spine to meet her?"

There it was.

Refusing would stain Catra. Accepting would gut her. Frosta wanted the spectacle—wanted Catra humiliated in full view of both armies, needed her reduced to prove that this alliance was a mistake.

Adora waited.

She waited for Catra to deflect. To mock. To turn the moment sideways and escape it, the way she always did. The rustling of the flags overhead was the only sound that could be heard.

Catra didn’t move.

She didn’t even look at Adora.

“Why not?” she replied, lightly, as though impossible tension didn't hang on every word.

Chapter End Notes

See you guys next weekend 👋

Chapter 18: Adora

Chapter Notes

> The app I use to draw crashed for a couple days and I only had the inspiration to work on this so SURPRISE! It's early!
>
> I have been thinking of a couple scenes, especially the end of this chapter for a while.
>
> Thank you to my beta reader for also being available to get this proofread and edited early 🥰

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Mounted and waiting at the line, Adora faced the course with both hands steady on the reins. Her horse danced beneath her, keyed tight with anticipation, muscles bunching and releasing as if it could hear the horn already. She murmured low in its ear, grounding it the way Angella had taught her, eyes forward.

Even two horses down the line, she could feel Catra's presence.

The colors were unmistakable. Catra’s spears gleamed red at the tips. Adora’s were gold. Keston—already crowned three times today—had teal. Juliet’s were white, earned cleanly on the flat. Frosta’s burned ice-blue, sharp as her stare.

The sport of Queens was not pageantry. It was violence given rules.

Mounted spearwork demanded more than strength or aim. Riders cut a relentless figure-eight between paired targets, throwing as they rode, never breaking stride. Spears had to be gathered on the run—lean, grab, rise, throw—again and again, eight full circuits, hooves flashing past one another close enough to feel breath and heat. Hits were counted. Bullseyes mattered.

Misses mattered more.

A missed throw didn’t vanish harmlessly. It flew. If it struck flesh, bone, or horse, that was the end. If a rider fell, the hooves finished it. Injuries were common. Deaths were not rare.

Adora had grown up in this game. She hadn’t been allowed onto the field until months of drills had ground the fear and hesitation out of her. Even then, her first ride had left her shaking for hours afterward.

You didn’t improvise this.

Catra, to her credit, could ride. Adora had seen that much in battle—had watched Catra cut across broken ground at speed, pivoting her mount with frightening precision, striking cleanly without losing balance. She wasn’t reckless in the saddle.

But riding wasn’t enough.

The spear wasn’t a Horde weapon. Maybe Catra had thrown one before. Maybe not. Even if she had, that meant nothing here. Timing, spacing, instinct—those were learned the hard way, over years, and the price for mistakes was written plainly into the dirt.

Adora caught sight of the physicians waiting at the edge of the field, Catra’s clone medic among them. They stood ready with bandages, needles, saws. Royal blood drew urgency; it didn’t prevent disaster.

She couldn’t help Catra. Not here. Not with both armies watching. If Adora faltered, she weakened herself. If she favoured Catra, the Etherians would tear the alliance apart. The other riders would show no restraint. If anything, they’d ride harder for the chance to humble the Horde Princess publicly.

Catra lifted her first spear.

She studied the course with a detached focus that felt out of place beside the others’ tension. No flexing. No theatrics. Just calculation. It struck Adora, suddenly, that Catra might not feel

anything about the game at all—not fear, not excitement. Only assessment.

For a heartbeat, Adora wondered what Catra had been destined to do, before everything else. Magic, perhaps. Purer forms of strategy. Anything that didn't end in blood.

The horn cut through the thought.

The start was staggered. Catra had drawn first.

The sound split the air. The crowd roared.

And Catra surged forward alone, red-tipped spear poised, racing into the field with every eye fixed on her back.

Any hope Frosta had carried of exposing the Horde as lesser shattered almost immediately.

Catra could ride.

Not competently—not adequately—but beautifully. She sat her horse like she'd been born there, narrow frame aligned perfectly with the animal's movement, weight and balance flowing without effort. No wasted motion. No visible strain. When she loosed her first spear, the red tip cut clean through the air and struck dead center.

A bullseye.

The stands erupted.

Before the noise could even crest, the second horn rang out. Keston surged forward in pursuit, riding hard, teeth bared in something like delight. Frosta followed, her elk pounding the ground with raw power. Adora drove her own horse into a gallop, the world narrowing to speed and spacing and breath.

With rival royalty on the field, restraint vanished. The crowd roared as if blood had already been spilled. Adora caught flashes

at the edge of her vision: another red arc—Catra again, flawless. Teal followed—Keston matching her. Juliet's spear landed wide, scraping the right edge. Frosta's came up short, biting turf instead of target and forcing Keston's mount into a sharp swerve.

Adora adjusted without thinking. She threaded past Keston cleanly, eyes forward, trusting her arm. She didn't need to see her own throws land. She felt them land—solid, true, gold ringing against wood.

By the end of the first circuit, the shape of the contest was unmistakable.

Catra.

Adora.

Keston.

Three riders, perfect so far.

Juliet faltered under the movement, her skill on foot failing her at speed. Frosta's strength worked against her; the elk was powerful, but too slow to pivot cleanly, too broad for the tight turns this game demanded.

At the far apex, Adora leaned low and gathered her next spears in one fluid motion, never breaking stride. She risked a glance sideways.

Catra cut inside Frosta's line without hesitation, slipping past the elk's shoulder to take her shot. Frosta's spear flashed past Catra's ribs—close enough to feel—but Catra didn't flinch. She rode as though danger were hypothetical.

Another bullseye.

The crowd's excitement sharpened into something almost feral. Perfect games were rare. Three riders playing one together bordered on myth.

Circuit after circuit blurred—hooves hammering, turf tearing loose, spears flashing like streaks of fire. Adora heard the dull thud of impact to her left—Juliet again, barely on target. Three circuits remaining. Then two. Then one.

They thundered into the final loop nearly abreast, adrenaline lifting them, the noise of the crowd swelling into a single roaring pulse. For a heartbeat, it felt impossibly balanced—as if the three of them were parts of one machine, moving in brutal harmony.

And then it went wrong.

Juliet released too soon.

Adora saw it instantly—the angle, the timing, the mistake. The spear struck not the target, but the support strut beneath it. Wood cracked. The structure shuddered.

At full gallop, there was no stopping.

Frosta and Keston threw on instinct. Both spears flew true—but the target was already collapsing, swaying out of alignment, falling away from their aim.

Frosta's spear veered across the course, no longer bound to harmless wood. It was surely going to hit someone—Keston or Catra, riding dangerously close together.

Adora shouted, but the wind tore the warning from her mouth.

And then she saw Keston's spear.

It was coming straight for her.

There was no room to dodge—not without risking driving it into another rider's path. No time to think, only the brutal certainty of speed and distance that the game demanded.

Instinct moved faster than fear.

The spear was already there—already too close—its teal tip aimed straight for her chest. Adora caught it midair, her hand snapping shut around the shaft with a jolt that tore through her shoulder and nearly ripped her from the saddle. The impact dragged her arm back; pain flared, sharp and immediate. She locked her thighs around the horse's barrel and absorbed it, breath tearing from her lungs as she forced herself to stay upright.

The crowd screamed in amix of horror and joyous relief.

She barely heard them.

She barely registered Frosta's face beside her—white with shock, eyes wide, mouth open. Adora's focus was elsewhere, snapping instantly to the other spear. The one that mattered.

The one flying for Catra.

Her heart stuttered, then slammed hard enough to hurt.

Across the course, Keston's instincts had frozen.

It wasn't cowardice—it was the paralysis of an impossible choice. If he swerved, the spear would take Catra. If he held his line, it would take him. There was no clever solution, no heroic maneuver left to him. He was trapped by the rules of the game and the speed of it, and Adora saw the moment he understood that his life and Catra's had collapsed into the same narrow line.

Catra had understood sooner.

Adora saw it in the way Catra moved—not frantic, not panicked. Calculating and calm. She'd clocked the falling strut, the broken angle, the fatal arc, and in the thin margin of time all of it gave her, she didn't hesitate.

She let go of the reins.

Adora's breath caught as Catra *jumped*—not away, not to safety, but straight into the spear's path. She vaulted from her own horse

onto Keston's, colliding with him hard enough to jolt them both sideways. Catra dragged him down in the saddle, forcing his weight low, her body braced against his as the spear tore through the air where their throats had been a heartbeat earlier.

It missed.

It buried itself in the grass with a brutal thunk.

The stands exploded with cheers.

Catra was already moving—already leaning, already reaching. She plucked Keston's final spear from his grasp, as he kept the horse at a full gallop, and threw.

Teal flashed.

The spear struck dead center.

Perfection. A perfect score.

The roar that followed was deafening, a wall of sound that crashed over the field. Catra finally slowed her shared mount, circling once, and lifted her gaze to Adora. One brow rose, faintly smug, unmistakably her.

Well?

Adora laughed—a sharp, disbelieving sound torn straight out of her chest. She hefted the spear she still held, turned her horse, and without ceremony hurled it across the full length of the field. It flew impossibly far, arcing clean and true before slamming into the target beside Catra's, the wood shuddering as it stuck, quivering.

Chaos.

Adora barely remembered dismounting. She was riding toward Catra, then on the ground, then Catra was there—solid and real and alive—and suddenly Adora's arms were around her, crushing

her close. She didn’t care who saw. She didn’t care where they were. Her hands were everywhere, rough and frantic, checking Catra’s shoulders, her ribs, her neck.

Catra let her.

“You’re insane,” Adora shouted over the noise, breathless and shaking. “You’re completely out of your mind!”

Catra was grinning, wild and bright, eyes alight. “Took you long enough to notice.”

Adora laughed again, helpless with it, and before she could stop herself she cupped Catra’s face and pressed a grateful kiss to her forehead—too quick, too instinctive to catch in time.

Then the crowd surged in around them.

They were lifted, jostled, swept along on hands and voices and laughter. Catra caught Adora’s hand for a second—just long enough for their fingers to lock—before the press of bodies tore them apart again. They were carried back toward the dais, breathless and dizzy, flower crowns pressed into their hands.

Adora bowed for Catra without thinking.

Catra slipped the gold-winged crown from Adora’s head, fingers brushing through her curls as she set the flowers in its place. Adora retaliated immediately, messing Catra’s hair with a laugh until Catra swatted at her and ducked away, still smiling. Then Adora crowned her in turn, hands lingering at Catra’s jaw, thumbs warm against her skin.

This wasn’t longing.

It wasn’t the ache, pain, and even need she'd felt for so long.

It was warmth—bright and overwhelming—and when Adora looked into Catra’s eyes, she saw it there too.

She wanted to kiss her.

Not the grateful brush to the forehead, or something careful, hidden.

A passionate kiss, right there in front of everyone.

Instead, she leaned in and pressed her forehead to Catra's, breathing her in. Around them, wine casks were being cracked open, cups filled and passed. Food appeared in abundance—platters of lamb and bread, bowls of honey and fruit, steam rising from great cauldrons of stew.

Adora barely noticed.

All she could see was Catra.

And Catra was only looking at her.

✧

Wine loosened tongues and tempers alike. The sense of shared victory settled over the hall like a warm spell, and Adora felt it humming in her chest every time she let her eyes find Catra. She made herself look away more often than not. The feeling was too easy to name if she lingered on it.

As afternoon slipped into evening, the celebration folded inward. Loud cheers softened into conversation; tankards gave way to shallow cups; a lyre threaded the air with something gentler. What had begun as spectacle was becoming fellowship—tentative, fragile, real. Etherians and Horde sat much closer than they had that morning. Laughter crossed lines that had once been borders. It gave Adora a cautious, hard-won hope for what tomorrow might demand of them.

The games had done what speeches never could.

They would ride out together. Whatever cracks remained were hidden well enough. She and Catra, at least, knew how to play

their parts.

Catra reclined on one of the low couches as if she'd grown up on it, all careless grace and sharp-eyed composure. Adora took the place beside her. Candlelight caught on metal and skin, throwing the rest of the hall into a comfortable blur.

Suddenly, the blur was cleaved in two.

Frosta stepped straight through it.

She wore her navy like a challenge, flanked by two of her soldiers and an attending slave. She didn't hesitate, didn't glance aside. She stopped directly in front of Catra.

The room stilled, conversations dying mid-sentence. Even the lyre faltered.

Frosta and Catra regarded each other in silence.

It stretched.

"You think like a snake," Frosta said at last, her voice carrying.

Catra didn't shift. "And you charge like an old bull," she replied mildly.

Neither smiled.

After a beat, Frosta flicked her fingers. The slave stepped forward with a squat bottle of Snows spirits and two shallow cups, poured without spilling a drop.

"I'll drink with you," Frosta said.

She was sixteen—young, by any count—but armies bent rules. Adora had learned that early. When you were old enough to send people to die, no one begrudged you a cup.

Frosta's face didn't soften. The offer wasn't warmth; it was a door cut into stone.

Every eye swung to Catra.

Adora knew exactly how much pride Frosta was burning to stand there—to offer even this much to a Horde royal. She also knew Catra's habits. She followed Catra's gaze to the cup and felt a spike of dread.

If it was wine, Catra wouldn't touch it.

Adora braced herself for the fallout—for insult taken, goodwill shattered, Frosta storming out with her banners and her army behind her.

Catra lifted the cup.

She didn't sniff it. She didn't hesitate. She drained it in one smooth swallow and set it back down.

A murmur rolled through the hall.

Frosta gave a slow, considering nod. She lifted her own cup, matched Catra, and swallowed.

Then she tipped the cup toward the slave again.

"Again," Frosta said.

And just like that, something significant had shifted.

✧

Much later—after the low table had been reduced to a battlefield of overturned cups and sticky rings—Frosta leaned across it and insisted that Catra try *Moroz*, the sharp, glacial liquor of the Snows. Catra drank it without ceremony, grimaced, and declared it tasted like gutter runoff.

Frosta barked a laugh. "Exactly."

That earned her a cheer.

Later still, Frosta recounted her first appearance in the games, when she'd been certain she would win and had instead been soundly beaten by Mermista. Mermista, for her part, accepted the retelling with exaggerated dignity and a raised cup, and a hearty laugh spread across the hall.

Later, Catra stacked three empty cups, one atop the other, perfectly balanced on the edge of the table. Frosta tried to match it and failed immediately, her cups collapsing in a clatter that sent her soldiers howling. Catra inclined her head, smug and precise.

Later, Frosta leaned close to Adora and said with drunken gravity, "You shouldn't judge the Horde so harshly. They drink like warriors." As if this were a revelation of statecraft.

Later, Frosta had an arm slung around Catra's shoulders, talking at length about hunting in the Snows—how the mammoths were gone now, but there were still beasts worthy of a Queen's spear. The stories grew broader with each cup, the gestures wider, until half the table was solemnly toasting mammoths that no longer existed.

By the time Frosta clasped Catra's shoulder again—this time in farewell—and rose to her feet, the room was loud with affection. She departed with her soldiers in tow, their navy cloaks swaying as they stumbled toward sleep.

Catra held herself together until they were gone. Her posture remained immaculate, but her pupils were blown wide, her cheeks faintly pink. Adora draped an arm along the back of her seat and waited.

After a moment, Catra said, very carefully, "I'm going to need assistance standing."

Adora rose—and immediately had Catra's full weight handed to her, an arm looped warm and heavy around her neck. Adora's breath caught. Her hands came up on instinct, steadying Catra at

the waist, the closeness sudden and dizzying. It felt illicit in a way that made her chest ache.

"The Princess of the Horde and I are retiring," Adora announced, and waved the remaining slaves away before anyone could pretend not to hear.

"This way," Catra said. "I think."

The hall they left behind was littered with the remains of celebration—abandoned cups, sagging cushions, the air sweet with wine and heat.

"Is this the first time you've lost that game?" Catra asked as they walked.

"Strictly speaking," Adora said, "it was a tie."

"*Strictly*." Catra huffed. "I told you I could ride. I used to race Shadow Weaver all the time. I beat her constantly. Took me until I was nine to realize she was letting me win. I just assumed I had an exceptional pony." She paused. "You're smiling."

Adora was. Moonlight pooled in the corridor around them, spilling in through open arches.

"Am I talking too much?" Catra asked. "I don't drink. Ever. This was a miscalculation."

"I'd noticed."

"It's my own fault," Catra continued, earnest. "I should have anticipated circumstances like this and trained myself accordingly. Built tolerance."

Adora shook her head, fond despite herself. "Is that really how your brain works? And '*never drink*' is generous. You were drunk the first night I met you."

“I made an exception,” Catra said. “Two and a half bottles. Had to choke it down. I thought it would make things easier.”

“Easier how?” Adora asked.

Catra blinked at her. “*How*?”

Adora stopped walking.

Catra looked up, eyes unfocused but intent. “You,” she said simply.

The word crawled over her skin.

Catra had said it lightly—almost idly—as if stating an obvious fact. Her arm was still hooked around Adora’s neck, her weight warm and unguarded, her mismatched eyes blurred with drink and something softer. They had stopped in the corridor without meaning to, caught in the half-light.

“My Etherian bed slave,” Catra murmured, “who just *happened* to be the woman who killed my mother.”

Adora’s breath caught, sharp enough to hurt.

“That’s—” She stopped herself. There was no answer that didn’t make it worse. She swallowed and forced her voice into steadiness. “It’s close. We’re almost there.”

They walked on.

They passed beneath high arches and along the western windows, iron-grilled with Horde workmanship. The corridor smelled faintly of stone cooled by night air. Two women moving unsteadily through the halls after a feast was nothing remarkable—not here, not after a victory. Adora let herself pretend, just for a few steps, that this was only what it looked like from the outside. Companions. Equals. Friends who had drunk too much and laughed too hard.

The guards at the inner doors did not react. They never did. Their eyes stayed forward as Adora guided Catra through, across the threshold into the private chamber beyond.

The room opened onto the night. The bed was Etherian—low and wide, marble-veined and gilded, its curved headrest framing a slice of starlit sky. Lanterns burned low.

"No one enters," Adora said.

The order landed heavy with implication. She ignored it. If anyone wondered why the Princess of the Horde had dismissed her servants tonight, they could wonder quietly. Catra would not tolerate an audience while the alcohol burned itself out of her system. Tomorrow she would be razor-tongued and merciless again, and Adora knew better than to fear that.

Now—

Now Adora intended to steer Catra forward, give her a nudge between the shoulders, and let her collapse the few steps to the bed.

She disentangled Catra's arm from her neck.

Catra wobbled, steadied herself, blinked at her own hands as if surprised to find them attached. She reached for the fastening of her jacket on instinct.

"Attend me," she said, distracted, automatic.

Adora snorted softly. "Habits die hard?"

She shouldn't have said it.

She stepped closer anyway. Her fingers found the buttons at Catra's chest and began to undo them, one by one. The fabric slid under her hands. She felt the narrow curve of Catra's ribs as the fabric slid free, the warmth of her skin bleeding through layers.

The jacket snagged at Catra's wrist. Adora had to tug the buckles loose, and in doing so disturbed Catra's shirt, pulling it askew.

She froze.

Beneath the fine cloth, Catra's shoulder was tightly bound—clean, professional wrappings meant to brace and reinforce. Adora had known. But lower, more bandaging circled Catra's abdomen, hidden with deliberate care.

Guilt hit her like a blow.

Sixteen throws. Full circuits. Hard riding. After yesterday. After their fight.

Catra would never have shown her this sober. Adora's hands stilled, still caught inside the jacket, as the weight of it settled in her chest.

Adora stepped back, giving Catra space, and said lightly, a brittle edge under it, "Congratulations. You've *officially* been waited on by the Queen of Etheria."

Catra's mouth twitched. "I could've claimed that months ago."

The lamplight washed the room in blue-green light, catching on clean lines and quiet wealth: the low chairs, the narrow table, the bowl of freshly gathered fruit. Nothing ostentatious. Nothing wasted. It felt like a place meant for control.

Catra looked out of place in her white undershirt—stripped of aoutur, stripped of posture. Bare. They stood facing one another, neither quite moving. Behind Catra, the light pooled around the bed, picking out the curve of the marble base, the spill of pillows left careless from earlier.

"I miss you," Catra said suddenly. Her voice was soft, unguarded in a way that made Adora's chest tighten. "I miss talking to you."

That—of all things—hit too close.

Adora's mind flashed, unbidden, to steam and to Catra's claws and her own helplessness, to lines drawn hard and sharp in sobriety.

She had crossed them. They both had.

"You're drunk," Adora said, too quickly.

Catra blinked at her, eyes heavy-lidded. "And you're pretending you don't know me." A pause. Then, quieter, "You should put me to bed."

Adora swallowed. "Yeah. I should."

"Then do it," Catra said, tilting her chin up in challenge that didn't quite land.

Adora didn't argue. She guided Catra across the room, the way she'd hauled exhausted soldiers to their pallets a hundred times before—half steering, half catching her weight. She deposited her on the bed with a decisive push.

Catra stayed where she landed, sprawled on her back, shirt loose and open, hair fanned dark against pale stone. One knee had fallen outward. Her breathing slowed, already drifting, the thin fabric rising and falling over fur and bandages alike.

"You don't like me like this?" Catra asked, eyes half-closed.

"You're not yourself," Adora said.

Catra's mouth curved. "Aren't I?"

"No." Adora shook her head. "You'll wake up tomorrow and regret not killing me."

"I already tried," Catra murmured. "You keep ruining my plans."

Adora turned away before her face could give her away. She found the pitcher, poured water into a shallow cup, set it by the bedside. She tipped the fruit from the bowl and place it onto the

floor beside her—close enough to reach if Catra woke sick and disoriented, the way soldiers did after too much celebration.

“Sleep,” Adora said quietly. “Tomorrow you can decide whether to punish us both. Or forget. Or lie about forgetting.”

Her hands were steady as she moved, though she had to pause before pouring the water, bracing herself against the table until the tightness in her chest eased. She draped Catra’s jacket over a chair. She shut the shutters against the dawn.

At the door, she hesitated, looking back once.

Catra was already slipping under, her features slackening, thoughts scattering. As sleep finally took her, she murmured, distant and wrong,

“Yes, Horde Prime.”

Adora’s hand tightened on the doorframe before she quietly closed it behind her.

Chapter End Notes

I technically might have also written chapter 19 and 20 and 21

And 22.

There's going to be a pretty big twist coming up that specifically didn’t tag so... get ready for that and don't hate me I guess?

Chapter 19: Catra

Chapter Notes

> Lo siento, Pollito de colores, por favor acepta este capítulo antes como mi disculpa.
>
> This was meant be posted tomorrow... but I'm just as impatient for everyone to read it as you are read it.
>
> Edit: *Oh shit, right, TW: PTSD and memories of sexual abuse

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra was dressed—everything but the jacket—and that alone felt like an accomplishment worth a medal. Her head throbbed as if someone had split it clean down the middle and left the blade behind. Her throat scraped raw with every breath. Her mouth tasted like acid and regret.

She had thrown up until there was nothing left. Then she'd kept going anyway, dry-heaving, spitefully, her body refusing to admit it was finished.

This wasn't new. Not really. It had just been a long time.

There had been a period—after Shadow Weaver's death—when waking up like this had been encouraged. Curated. Prime had liked his wine strong and his additives stronger, little powders and syrups stirred in with a pleasant smile. Things that softened the edges. Things that made Catra warmer, looser, easier to steer. He'd said she was sweeter that way. More agreeable. Less work.

Prime enjoyed boldness in public. He demanded obedience in private. And he despised resistance.

Catra could almost feel the press of his hands against her chest and thighs and—

The feeling refused to go away no matter how hard she tried to push it down. It wasn't until she felt wetness on her finger that she looked and realised she had clawed through her own skin. The red was already blooming through the white fabric of her undershirt.

Lying flat made the full-body pain tolerable. Mostly. Sitting up would be a mistake. Vomiting again might actually kill her. Catra stared at the ceiling and debated which indignity she preferred.

The decision was made for her.

"Is she dead?"

"I dunno—poke her."

"Absolutely not. If she wakes up, she'll flay me."

"Then use your finger, not your dick, idiot."

"Gods, what *is* that smell?"

"Blighted royal bitch. Ryen, she doesn't hate you—clean it."

The door had opened. Of course it had. Her Horde attendants came in the way Horde attendants always did: loud, shoving, already annoyed about it. There might have been an attempt at discretion, somewhere near the start. It had died immediately.

They thought she was unconscious.

"I've got coffee duty," Ryen said, defensive. "I'm not touching puke. You two sort it out."

"Must be nice," Serifa muttered, rifling through the wardrobe without permission. "Being important. Drink all night. Screw whoever. Let everyone else scrape you off the floor in the morning."

“Yeah,” the third one snorted. “Play at being general, sit prettily, even call it ruling.”

They laughed. Serifa and the third one, anyway. Ryen, predictably, kept quiet.

Catra had pushed herself upright.

None of them noticed.

Ryen’s back was to her, carefully arranging cups on a tray with the exaggerated delicacy of someone who knew exactly how much trouble he could be in if he spilled. Serifa was halfway inside Catra’s wardrobe, tossing fabrics aside with no regard for rank or expense. The third—Number Three, because Catra couldn’t be bothered to remember his name—had planted himself at her writing desk, boots up, like he owned the place.

Catra watched them through half-lidded eyes, head pounding, mouth still sour.

Interesting.

“I heard letting the Queen bed her knocked something loose,” Three said, snickering. “Explains why she’s been acting so strange. Word is they were at it again last night. Probably left her brainless.”

Catra’s voice cut in, cool and level. “How reassuring.”

All three froze.

“Truly,” Catra went on mildly. “Thinking *is* such an exhausting habit. You should all count yourselves fortunate to have been spared it.” Her gaze flicked from face to face. “No, please—don’t stop. I’m fascinated. Tell me everything.”

Serifa, a girl of about fifteen, went corpse-pale. Three’s mouth opened, closed, opened again.

“Your—your highness, we didn’t mean—”

“Ryen,” Catra said, pleasantly, “would you be so kind as to ask my guards to step inside?”

The coffee pot clattered as Ryen nearly dropped it putting it back on the tray. He didn’t look at anyone, instead bolting for the door like his hair was on fire. Catra vaguely recalled Clone 28 being posted nearby.

She reclined back against the pillows, expression thoughtful. “It’s remarkable, really. Rumours. They sprout out of nothing at all, don’t they? One wonders who waters them.”

“Your highness,” Three tried again, voice cracking now. He’d scrambled upright from the desk, knocking into Kyle’s box in his panic. Serifa’s carefully chosen clothes slid from her hands to the floor.

Catra tilted her head. “You look dreadful. Like a fish gasping on a dock. Breathe.” Her smile was gentle enough to be cruel. “I’m certain you’ll explain all of this *beautifully* to Marzo. He so enjoys a complete account—every word, every name. A misunderstanding this entertaining deserves a thorough retelling.”

She sighed, as if regretful. “Sadly, I won’t be there to enjoy it. Obligations.” Her eyes gleamed. “Fucking the Etherian Queen keeps my schedule terribly full.”

Ryen returned at a near-run, Clone 28 looming behind him.

Catra gestured lazily. “Escort them out. And see that this room is put back in order before they leave.”

Clone 28 didn’t need clarification. He steered them toward the door with efficient force. The loud one stumbled—or was knocked purposefully by 28; the contents of the fruit bowl sloshed down the front of his shirt. Catra noted it with approval.

When the door shut, the room fell into a brittle quiet.

Ryen kept his eyes down and immediately set about doing the work of three people. He moved fast. His hands shook as he fastened Catra's jacket.

She hadn't expected him to speak.

"Your highness," Ryen said quietly. "I just—I want you to know. I didn't say anything. I wasn't part of it."

Catra regarded him, unreadable.

"Ah," she said at last. "And how often did you try to stop them?"

Ryen swallowed.

He said nothing.

Catra closed her eyes, head pulsing, patience razor-thin. "Finish the buttons," she murmured. "Then get out of my sight."

✧

Two pots of coffee. Bread so dry it might have been packing material. Catra arrived late anyway, skull split open behind her eyes, pain throbbing like someone had let a forge hammer loose inside her head.

And, as if the morning hadn't already made its point, Adora was there.

Catra had entertained—briefly, desperately—the hope that today might be one of the rare days Adora chose distance. That she might decide to be restrained, even professional.

The gods, it turned out, were still cruel.

The meeting had started without her. The holo table was already crowded: Entrapta perched half on a stool, half on the table's edge; Marzo standing at ease with his hands folded behind his back; Mermista leaning on one elbow with the long-suffering air of

someone who had been bored for the bulk of the ongoing conversation. And Adora—Adora at the center of it, bright and animated, hands braced on the table as she listened.

She looked up the moment Catra crossed the threshold.

Her face lit up.

It was instant. Unrestrained. Catra had seen that expression on the battlefield, on the dais, in moments of victory—but never aimed so directly at her.

Oh. No.

"Good morning," Adora said, warm and unmistakably pleased.

Catra stopped dead.

Fuck.

She stared. She scowled. She waited for the smile to fade.

It didn't.

If anything, it deepened—softened at the edges, like Adora was trying not to laugh outright. Like she was remembering something fond. Something shared.

Catra's headache flared viciously. Somewhere in the wreckage of her thoughts was the deeply unsettling suspicion that Adora hadn't fucked her last night—but had absolutely wanted to. And worse, she was looking at her like a woman who fully expected that to be remedied sometime soon.

Horror prickled down Catra's spine.

She had a fragment of memory—blurred, traitorous—of deciding, with drunken conviction, that telling Adora she loved her was an excellent idea.

Adora's smile made her chest hurt.

It took Catra far too long to realize she had stopped moving. That the room had gone quiet not because the discussion had reached a natural pause, but because of her.

Entrapta's eyebrow climbed, slow and speculative. Marzo's face smoothed into perfect neutrality. Mermista's gaze slid to Catra, quietly measuring how much damage she might have to clean up.

Catra forced herself to breathe.

"Good morning," she said, evenly.

She turned and made for her chair with all the dignity of someone who absolutely was not retreating. Unfortunately, due to rank and its trappings, that chair was directly beside Adora.

Catra sat rigidly. She did not look at her. She stared at the holo table like it had personally offended her. She could *feel* Adora's attention—bright, steady, infuriatingly warm—pressing against her like sunlight on skin that had spent too long in shadow.

It felt… good.

That was unacceptable.

Catra concentrated on not flushing. On keeping her breathing measured. Whatever she'd said, whatever she'd done, she would address it later—privately. Adora would behave herself in front of witnesses.

For now, the others were a shield.

"Catra!"

She flinched.

Frosta was grinning at her.

Not smirking. Not challenging. *Grinning*. Wide and unguarded and —gods help her—fond.

“Well,” Frosta said, bright as fresh snow, “you’re late.”

Catra’s stomach dropped.

She had apparently lost more of the previous night than she’d thought.

She closed her eyes for half a heartbeat, then opened them again, pasting on something that might pass for composure.

“This is shaping up to be a very educational morning,” she said dryly.

Frosta laughed.

Catra did not remember earning that.

Frosta leaned straight over the holo table and caught Catra by the shoulder, fingers digging in with unselfconscious strength. She gave her a brisk shake for emphasis, as if sealing a bargain with muscle instead of ink.

“I’ll take you up on your offer,” Frosta announced. “We’ll hunt together on Weave’s Slope once this campaign’s finished.”

Catra went very still.

She recognized the gesture in theory—something between camaraderie and challenge, a thing done between soldiers, between equals. Friendship, if one believed in such things. Sisterhood, if one had ever been invited into it.

“My offer,” Catra repeated mildly.

She kept her voice even. She kept her face arranged into something neutral and royal. She did not allow her bafflement to show, nor the deep, instinctive revulsion she felt toward hunting for sport. She did not look at Adora for clarification. She could feel her there anyway—could feel the weight of her attention, bright

and entertained, like she was watching Catra navigate a trap she hadn't seen set.

Frosta's grip tightened, just shy of painful. She shook Catra again, this time turning her head to include the rest of the table.

"I'm looking forward to seeing what kind of beasts the Fright Zone breeds," Frosta went on, cheerfully. "Big ones, I hope."

Oh. Fuck. They had actually discussed this, hadn't they?

One of the Etherian princesses—Catra didn't bother recalling her name—wrinkled her nose. "You hunt *with* the Horde now?"

Frosta's head snapped toward her. She jabbed a finger in the woman's direction, sharp and unmistakably threatening—then, just as abruptly, she barked a laugh and pulled Catra back in against her side, squeezing again. The ongoing ritual seemed to demand physical contact. Repeatedly. Enthusiastically.

Catra endured it, teeth clenched, body carefully held away from Frosta's chest. Her thoughts were rattling nearly as much as her bones. The only mercy was that Frosta had missed her injured shoulder.

"One cup of Moroz and she's out cold," Frosta boomed, apparently to the ceiling. "This one drank *six*!"

She shook Catra again, bellowing loud enough to rattle the maps on the wall. "And you question her will? Her steadiness? Her arm in the hunt?"

Gods. Stop fucking shouting.

"That wasn't *your* family's Moroz," someone protested weakly from the far side of the table. "Right?"

Frosta laughed, delighted. "Exactly."

She clapped Catra once more on the shoulder—hard—and grinned around at her retinue. “With the two of us riding together, there won’t be a beast left standing on the slopes.”

The Snows contingent cheered.

Catra smiled. It was tight. Polished. Perfectly regal. She did not look at Adora. She refused to give her the satisfaction—because she was certain that if she did, she would see open amusement there. Or worse: fondness.

Perhaps Adora sensed it anyway. Perhaps she took pity.

She raised her hand. The noise ebbed at once.

When it fell, Adora smoothly drew the conversation back to troop movements and supply lines.

✧

Frosta had begun speaking to Catra again before the meeting had even properly adjourned.

She’d simply solved the problem of distance by trading places with Catra’s neighbour without asking, then leaning fully into Catra’s space again—one hand settling at the back of Catra’s neck with proprietary familiarity. Her voice dropped, conspiratorial, but it was still far too loud, a low droning insistence that set Catra’s headache pulsing harder.

Shut up. Shut up. Shut up.

“Some idiots sweeten it,” Frosta murmured. “Honey, berries. Completely wrong. Ruins it. You mustn’t add sugar of any kind. Are you listening? This matters.”

Catra pressed two fingers to her temple, eyes half-lidded now, the effort of remaining upright a careful, deliberate act. She nodded once. Slowly. She hoped it read as attention rather than pure survival.

“The only way iron tea works,” Frosta continued, relentless, “is with blood. One spoonful. Bull’s blood. Not cow. Bull. A big one, a strong one. You don’t even have to kill it—look.”

She gestured at her own throat, then mimed a neat little cut and the careful placement of a cup beneath it.

Catra swallowed. She nodded again. She arranged her face into something approximating gratitude.

She did her absolute best not to wish—fervently, vividly—that she had let Adora run Frosta through yesterday.

Or was that the day before…?

“Iron tea’s good for more than headaches,” Frosta went on, satisfied. Chairs scraped as the others began to rise. “Stops hair thinning. Builds muscle. Keeps you sharp.”

She punctuated the thought by slapping Catra solidly between the shoulders as she stood. Catra nearly went face-first into the table.

“You should have your slave fetch you some,” Frosta added, as an afterthought, thumping her once more for emphasis.

Desperation overrode thought.

Without looking up, Catra flicked her hand vaguely in Adora’s direction. “Fetch me some,” she ordered.

Adora was on her feet instantly.

The realization hit them both at once.

Adora froze mid-motion, caught between instinct and awareness. That reflex—obedient, immediate—was the same one that had saved Catra’s life in the village, when steel had hovered a breath from her throat. Here, now, it promised only spectacle. Humiliation. Confirmation of everything they worked so hard to bury.

The blood drained from Catra's face.

Mermista recovered first.

"That concludes this meeting," Mermista announced, too loudly, clapping her hands together. Her smile was thin, unpleasant. "The Queen has preparations to attend to."

The soldiers, who had been lingering and stretching, chatting lazily, found themselves abruptly herded toward the door under Mermista's brisk direction. The room emptied faster than Catra would have believed possible.

When the last of them were gone, Mermista shut the door with finality and leaned back against it, arms crossed.

Catra lifted her head slowly, hands falling from her temples. The pain was still there—splitting, insistent—but now it had competition.

Mermista was staring at her.

Do you think I'd get along with Mermista of Salineas?

She could remember asking it, once. Casually. As if it had been a reasonable thing to wonder.

The answer, it turned out, was simple.

No.

Mermista of Salineas despised her—and Catra could hardly fault her for it. Given the scars on Adora's back. Given the history. Given Catra herself. The idea that she'd ever let herself speculate otherwise felt juvenile now, faintly embarrassing. Adora wasn't her suitor. Catra didn't need—didn't deserve—the approval of Adora's closest friend. Their alliance existed because it had to. Because Catra had engineered it. Because Adora had been left with no other viable option.

When this was over—if they survived—everyone would go their separate ways. Adora would return to Etheria. Mermista would remain at her side. Maybe they would even find their way into something softer together. Something uncomplicated.

Catra told herself she wouldn't care. She decided it firmly. She would not allow herself to care.

Mermista's stare burned straight through her.

There was no trace left of the courteous diplomat from moments before. What looked back at Catra now was fury held on a leash—tight, shaking, ready to snap.

"You," Mermista said quietly, venom in every syllable. "You vile, miserable—"

"Mermista," Adora said sharply.

"What is it with you?" Mermista demanded, stepping forward. "Where's the line? How much damage is enough? How much pain before you're satisfied?"

"Mermista—"

"You flay her back," Mermista pressed on, voice rising despite herself. "You shatter her trust, and now you humiliate her in front of everyone—"

"Mermista."

Adora was on her feet now. The warning in her posture was unmistakable. Mermista held her gaze for a long moment, jaw tight, chest heaving—then, at last, she inclined her head.

"My Queen," she said, bitterness threading every word.

"Leave us," Adora said. Then, softer—unnecessarily so—"Please."

Mermista's eyes flicked once more to Catra, sharp and unyielding. Then she turned and left, the door slamming hard enough to rattle the walls.

Silence rushed in to fill the space she left behind.

Catra and Adora left alone.

Catra wasn't convinced this was better—especially not with the way Adora was looking at her. Careful. Concerned. Guilty. Her stomach rolled. She lifted her chin anyway, out of habit more than pride.

"Nothing happened," Adora said at once.

She was a spectacularly bad liar.

"Something happened," Catra replied flatly.

Adora sighed, dragging a hand down her face, pinching the bridge of her nose like she was nursing a headache of her own. Not wine, not Moroz—just Catra. Finally, when evasion failed her entirely, she dropped her hands.

"You were drunk," Adora said, as though that settled it.

It didn't.

Catra's nausea sharpened.

When Catra didn't respond, Adora continued, more reluctantly. "I took you back to your rooms. You… told me to attend you."

"What else?"

Catra kept her voice level. It took effort.

Adora shifted, the earlier brightness gone as if it had never existed. "I… helped you remove your jacket."

Catra didn't blink. "What else."

For a moment Adora just looked at her. Really looked—measuring, cautious, suddenly stripped of all that easy warmth. Catra held her gaze by sheer will.

"Oh." Adora let out a breath, half laugh, half disbelief. "No. Stop right there. You were so far gone you could barely string a sentence together. You probably didn't know where you were, let alone who you were really talking to." She hesitated, then frowned, genuinely startled by the direction Catra's mind had gone. "Do you honestly think I'd touch you like that? In that state."

"No," Catra said at once.

The certainty in her own voice surprised her.

She meant it. Completely. Adora—impossible, infuriating Adora—who spared enemies on principle, who stepped between blades without thinking, who had never learned how to harden herself even after everything Catra had done to her. Adora, who could not lie, who would not take. Catra had been incoherent, unsafe in her own body—and Adora had kept her safe anyway.

Like always.

"I don't think you would," Catra repeated, quieter now.

Her stomach twisted as memory caught up to her: Adora's grin that morning. Too bright. Too pleased. She swallowed, suddenly lightheaded. "Did I… say anything?"

Adora didn't answer immediately.

When she finally moved, it wasn't closer—it was back. She sat down again beside Catra, deliberately, as if giving her space was part of the answer.

"You said you missed me," Adora said.

There it was. Catra heard what Adora didn't say just as clearly—the care with which she offered it, the way she'd guarded the words all morning. Like something fragile she hadn't been sure she was allowed to hold. Like something she'd been afraid Catra would deny the moment she heard it out loud.

Catra felt heat crawl up her neck.

"That's all?" she asked, because she had to.

"That was enough," Adora said, simply.

They hadn't slept together. Catra hadn't confessed anything earth-shattering. She hadn't bared herself open. She had only said she missed her—and somehow that had landed hardest of all.

"I see," Catra said. She chose every word with care, the way one does when stepping around something cracked and sharp. "Then… thank you. For not indulging me further last night."

Adora didn't reply right away.

The silence stretched—thick, weighted, full of things neither of them was saying. Catra could almost feel the moment where Adora might have reached for her, might have crossed that final inch.

She didn't.

Adora kept her hands folded in her lap.

Her voice, when it came, had lost all its steadiness. It was stripped down to something bare and earnest.

"I miss you too," she said. Then, after a breath that caught halfway in her chest, "And I'm— jealous. Of Isobel."

"Isobel is a slave," Catra said, and the bitterness coated her tongue. She hated that she could hear it in herself.

Adora didn’t flinch. “So was I.”

The room tilted.

Catra, I’m still your slave.

The echo of it—unspoken, but unmistakable—rang loud in Catra’s head. Not accusation. Not manipulation. Longing. A want so deep it had never learned how to disappear, only how to wait.

Catra shut her eyes.

When she opened them again, it took conscious effort to lift her chin, to meet Adora’s gaze without looking away.

“You were never a slave,” Catra said. Her voice came out steadier than she felt.

It hurt more than she expected—saying it aloud. Hurt worse than letting go. Worse than knowing Adora cared, too. Worse than understanding that it changed nothing.

“You were born to rule,” Catra went on, quieter now. “That could never be taken from you. No matter what I tried to make you believe.”

And that was the cruelest truth of it. Because duty couldn't be erased, or even loosened, by love.

Adora didn’t argue. Didn’t insist. She lifted a hand instead, reaching without thinking, as if muscle memory had outrun sense.

Catra stood up before she could touch her.

If you had been a slave, I could have kept you.

The thought burned hot and poisonous. She swallowed it down. Wanting someone small enough to cage them was not love. Catra knew that better than anyone.

“Excuse me,” she said.

She didn’t wait for permission.

Mermista was exactly where Catra had known she would be—posted outside the chamber like a stormcloud with opinions. Waiting.

“She’s yours,” Catra said flatly. Whatever she felt, she locked it down behind the familiar chill. Another small mercy of Moroz. “We’re done.”

“I was waiting for you,” Mermista replied.

Catra closed her eyes for the space of a single breath. “Then you’ve misjudged my tolerance,” she said coolly. “I’m not accepting another sermon cataloguing my moral failures. I assure you, between Horde Prime and your Queen, I am intimately acquainted with all of them.”

She opened her eyes and looked straight at her.

“If you genuinely believe you have something novel to contribute,” Catra continued, acid-smooth, “I recommend committing it to paper and leaving it with my secretary. Assuming I still have one by the end of the week. Staffing has been… volatile.”

Mermista’s scowl deepened.

Catra felt the ache finally catch up to her—behind the eyes, in the bones. She was tired. Past tired.

“If you’re not careful,” Catra added, turning away, “your face will freeze like that. And then no one will want you at all.”

She didn’t stay to hear a response.

She walked down the hall without looking back.

Chapter End Notes

I really want to post chapter 24 by Christmas, as a gift.

Chapter 20: Adora

She found herself drifting into the old residential wing of the fort.

It was quieter here, the noise of occupation softened to a distant murmur—no groups of boots striking stone, no voices raised in command. The Etherian presence thinned the deeper she went, as though her soldiers understood that this place was not meant to be loud.

For her, this was goodbye.

She wouldn't return after the war. Or if she did, it would be as a guest with the fort had been restored to Fright Zone hands, set right in a way conquest never allowed. The Borderline forts, once the clearest proof of Etherian victory, would be relinquished without ceremony.

The thought unsettled her.

Once, these walls had meant triumph. Now they felt like a marker of everything that had shifted inside her—how victory no longer looked like ownership, how power no longer felt clean. She moved through the corridor slowly, seeing it not as it had been taken, but as it ought to be returned.

She stopped before an old door.

A soldier stood watch, more out of habit than necessity. Adora lifted a hand; he stepped aside without a word.

Inside, the rooms were warm and lived-in. A fire burned low in the hearth. Etherian reclining chairs had been drawn close, and a rough wooden chest padded with cushions sat near a low table. On the table lay a simple game—bright coins scattered between two players.

The girl from the village sat cross-legged on one side, pale and thin but intent. Opposite her was an older woman in grey skirts,

stiff-backed, her hands hovering uncertainly over the pieces. At Adora's entrance, the girl jolted to her feet, coins clattering to the floor.

The older woman stood too.

The last time Adora had seen her, she had been gripping a broken spear like a lifeline, blocking a doorway with feral resolve.

Adora spoke carefully, in Horde-Etherian. "What was done to your village—I promised I would find who was responsible. I promised I would answer it. I meant that." She gestured faintly around them. "You can stay here, if you wish. With allies. With protection. These forts will be returned to the Fright Zone. I give you my word."

The woman studied her, jaw tight. "They told us who you were."

Adora met her gaze without flinching. "Then you know I can keep my word."

"You think if you give us—" The woman cut herself off, breath sharp.

She moved closer to the girl, placing herself half in front of her. Adora was clearly a force to be braced against rather than welcomed. The resistance between them was palpable—raw, furious and exhausted.

The girl broke the silence. Her voice was small, but steady. "You should go. You're frightening her."

Adora looked again at the woman—and saw it clearly. Not fear. Anger. Anger held so tightly she shook with it.

"What happened wasn't just," Adora said quietly. "There's no such thing as a fair fight. Someone always has more power. But I swear to you—you will have justice."

The girl didn’t hesitate. “I wish someone had been stronger than you.”

She turned her back on Adora immediately after—an act of defiance so stark it stole Adora’s breath. A child turning away from a Queen. Then the girl knelt, picked up one of the fallen coins, and spoke to the woman instead.

“It’s okay,” she said, gently. “Look—I’ll show you something. Watch my hand.”

Adora felt her skin prickle.

The girl closed her fist with deliberate care, arm extended, posture unconsciously mimicking something Adora knew—

An echo.

Adora knew who had been here before her. Knew who had sat on this floor, who had distracted a grieving child with clever fingers and a crooked smile.

The girl’s trick was clumsy—her coin slipped into her sleeve with effort—but when she opened her hand again, it was empty.

The woman startled, a sound that was half laugh, half sob catching in her throat.

✧

The field ahead of them was alive with motion.

Two armies stood braided together across the plain—columns of soldiers, outriders circling like watchful birds, supply wagons creaking under canvas and iron, physicians already establishing their tents, livestock corralled and restless. Beyond the ranks, the noncombatants were being settled, Entrapta animatedly directing her equipment.

Above it all, banners rippled.

Angel wings in white and gold. Bat wings in black and iron.

They rose in such number that the army looked less like a host on the march and more like a fleet preparing to sail—standards catching the wind, stretching to the horizon until the plain itself seemed to move. Adora sat her horse at the rise and took it in, steadying herself. All of this was hers to lead. This was what she had been shaped for.

She saw Catra.

Mounted a short distance away, Catra looked every inch the Horde Princess—spine straight, shoulders squared, armour polished to a hard sheen. Her hair had been left deliberately untamed, as if daring anyone to comment on it. Except—now it was cut. She had shortened it in the last day since Adora had last seen her.

It suited her.

Her expression was all command: distant, sharp, emptied of softness. The Moroz still clung to her, a shadow behind the eyes, and Adora thought grimly that if Catra needed killing to keep her steady today, she would not lack for enemies.

When Adora glanced back, she found Mermista watching her.

Not with the brittle anger from earlier. Not with outright hostility, even. Something else had settled into her expression.

Adora tightened the reins, slowing her horse. “You’ve been listening to gossip,” she said flatly.

Mermista didn’t deny it. “You were in her rooms.”

“I was in her rooms for barely ten minutes,” Adora replied. “If you think that’s enough time for me to do anything scandalous, you underestimate both my stamina and my priorities.”

Mermista still didn’t move her horse aside.

“She maneuvered Frosta,” Mermista said. “At the village. She set the board, let Frosta think she was choosing freely, and watched her walk exactly where Catra wanted her.”

“Mermista.”

“No. You listen to *me* now.” Mermista leaned forward slightly in her saddle, voice low but unyielding. “We’re riding back into Etheria because the Princess of the Horde decided to carry her war into your territory. Etheria will bleed first in this alliance—our land, our people. And when the fighting is over, when everyone is exhausted and desperate for order, someone will step forward to claim control. Make sure that someone is you.”

Adora’s jaw tightened. “You think I don’t know that?”

“I think,” Mermista said, carefully, “that Catra is very, very good at getting people to do want what she wants. She commands without banners. She persuades without asking. And you—” Her gaze softened, just a fraction. “You want to see the best in her.”

Adora exhaled sharply. “So this is another warning not to sleep with her?”

Mermista shook her head. “No. I know you’re going to. I’m telling you that when she decides to let you, you should ask yourself what she’s trying to gain.”

Mermista finally shifted her horse aside, giving Adora room to move. Adora didn’t look back again. She guided her mount forward, lining up alongside Catra at the head of the column.

Up close, Catra was all steel and stillness—no trace of the unguarded woman from that night, no flicker of doubt. Just the clean, ruthless profile of a commander about to march.

The horns sounded.

Trumpets answered.

The ground itself seemed to tremble as the united armies began to move, banners surging forward like wings catching a shared wind.

Two former enemies rode side by side at the front, neither looking at the other, both all too aware of the weight between them.

✧

The watchtowers were empty.

That was the message the scouts brought back, riding hard on blown horses, shouting it even before they reached the line. Adora shouted back, voice tearing itself raw against the roar of the march. Noise blanketed the landscape—wheels grinding, tanks clanking, skiffs rattling, hooves pounding, armour striking armour, the ground itself trembling under the weight of thousands. Horns split the air again and again, the sound carried down the long spine of the column.

Her army stretched from one hill to the next, segmented blocks of colour sliding forward in disciplined motion. They were meant to fall on the watchtowers in force.

But the watchtowers were empty.

Mermista didn’t hesitate. “A trap.”

Adora lifted a hand and peeled a unit off the column. “First tower,” she called. “Carefully.”

She watched from the rise as they approached at a canter, then dismounted. The tower stood against the sky like a wrong note—solid, intact, expectant. Not a ruin softened by time or vines, but a structure meant to be alive and wasn’t. The soldiers brought the wooden ram up, struck the door, broke it in.

Nothing.

Minutes dragged past. Too quiet. Adora felt it in her teeth. Then the soldiers emerged again, mounted up, and rode back.

Empty.

No traps. No murder holes. No oil, no arrows, no ambush waiting behind doors. Just bare stone and stale air.

The second tower was the same. Then the third. Then the fourth.

Understanding crept in as her gaze lifted past the towers to the fort beyond—thick grey limestone at the base, mud-brick fortifications above. The low, tiled-roof archer tower should have bristled with movement. The slits were dark. No banners stirred. No sound carried.

Adora exhaled. "It's not a trap. They pulled back."

Mermista's mouth tightened. "If they did, it wasn't planned. You don't abandon ground like this unless you're running."

"From something," Adora said.

Mermista followed her look—back to the vast, advancing army, blue and white riding alongside red. "From someone who scared them."

On they rode.

Past broken stone and sharp outcrops, up the steep rise toward the fort. The forecourt gates—four squat towers designed to turn an approach into a slaughter—stood open and silent, a dead mouth yawning wide. No fire. No resistance.

The ram broke the main doors easily.

Inside, the quiet became oppressive. The atrium was empty, columns casting long shadows. The fountain at its centre was dry, its basin holding only dust. An overturned basket lay abandoned

on the marble floor, as if dropped and forgotten mid-step. A thin, half-wild cat bolted along the wall and vanished into shadow.

Adora felt it settle in her chest—not victory, not relief.

Just absence.

They advanced inward in measured sweeps, from the public halls into the residential wings. Here, the truth of the retreat showed itself plainly. Rooms stood half-undone: chests left open, bedding stripped, a tapestry ripped from one wall while its pair still hung untouched across the room. It had the feel of haste layered over indecision. Adora could almost see it—the last arguments, the raised voices, the order that finally broke the stalemate and sent everyone running.

Whoever had ordered the raid on the village had miscalculated badly. It hadn't fractured her alliances. It had welded them together. Her name had gone ahead of her like fire.

"Here!" someone called.

The shout came from deep within the fort.

Adora raised a fist. Soldiers closed ranks instantly, weapons up, breath held. At the very heart of the structure stood a single door, reinforced and barred from within.

The first real resistance.

"Careful," Adora said, and didn't need to raise her voice to be obeyed.

They brought the ram up. One strike. Two. The wood cracked and gave way in a shower of splinters.

Beyond it—

Light.

The room was a solar, airy and elegant, untouched by the chaos outside. Sun spilled in through tall windows. Fine furnishings stood exactly where they belonged: a reclining couch with a delicately carved base, bronze tables polished to a soft gleam, cushions arranged with deliberate care.

And at the centre of it all, as if the world had not just ended outside her walls, she waited.

She sat on the couch with her spine straight and her chin lifted, seven women gathered around her like a living shield. Two wore the unmistakable collars of slaves. One was an older maid, hands folded tight with worry. The rest were noblewomen of her household, faces set, prepared.

The crash of the door had earned only the faintest reaction from her—a slight lift of her brows, irritation more than fear.

She'd escaped Bright Moon.

Prime must have thought she would run straight to Adora. Instead, she'd vanished here. The timing fit now, too—the exhaustion shadowing her eyes, the careful stillness of her posture. The birth had come early. Recently. Too recent for travel. That was why she'd been left behind, guarded by those loyal enough—or brave enough—to stay.

Adora hadn't expected so many.

She looked different, and not in any way that dulled her. The shimmer had gone from her hair, its pinks and purples muted, but her neck was still carved and graceful, her face pale in a way that sharpened rather than softened her features. New lines touched her brow, fine and precise, like a crown earned rather than worn.

She was beautiful. That fact landed and was immediately dismissed—because beauty had never been her real weapon.

It was her determination.

Dusty pink eyes met Adora's without flinching.

"Hello, Adora," Glimmer said.

Adora forced herself to look at her properly. To remember her as she was: the bargain with Double Trouble; the exchange that had bought Bright Moon its safety at Adora's expense. The gentle press of Glimmer's fingers against her bruised cheek. The quiet goodbye.

Then Adora turned away.

She addressed a foot soldier at her side, her voice calm, almost bored, as if assigning a watch rotation.

"Take her into custody," she said. "The fort is ours."

Glimmer didn't move. She only watched Adora with that same intent gaze, as if already planning her next move—even as the soldiers stepped forward to close the distance.

Chapter 21: Catra

Chapter Notes

Tw: Kyle mentioned

Some of you have figured out one of the twists... well, one part of the same twist.

And as always, thank you to my beta reader

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora was an honourable woman. Recent months had taught her—belatedly—that honour was far from a universal language. She ordered the fort searched inch by inch anyway.

Catra wasn't with her when they found the locked door. She wasn't there when the ram splintered it open, or when the room revealed its prize. No runner was sent to Catra, no careful report delivered. She learned what had happened only in fragments: a flash of cotton-candy hair, the soft glide of silk, Glimmer escorted past under guard.

Arrested.

Catra felt it then—that familiar tightening at the base of her spine, the sensation of invisible threads drawing taut. Horde Prime, watching. Waiting. A spider patient enough to let others exhaust themselves struggling.

Adora never spoke of Glimmer if she could help it. The silence around her name was deliberate, like stepping around a wound that hadn't stopped bleeding. Catra didn't fully understand it. She'd never had a sister. She didn't know what it meant to have someone carved into your life so early that their betrayal felt like the loss of a limb.

But she understood this much: Glimmer hadn't just chosen a lover Adora trusted. She hadn't just lied. She had handed Adora over to Prime. She had taken a Queen and turned her into property. That kind of damage didn't heal.

So Catra went looking for Mermista.

She found her and, without ceremony, seized her by the arm and pulled her into an empty side chamber. Mermista stumbled once, then recovered instantly, her expression snapping from surprise to open disdain.

Catra didn't bother with pleasantries.

"What did she do?"

Mermista's lip curled. "Excuse me?"

"Don't play stupid," Catra said coolly. "Adora. She walks into a room and finds her sister waiting—unguarded, helpless. What did she do?"

Mermista laughed once, sharp and humourless. "What is this? Have you run out of your own cruelties and come shopping for someone else's?"

"Answer me," Catra said. Her voice was flat. "I'm not in the mood for Etherian theatrics."

For a moment it looked like Mermista might actually hit her.



Instead, she set her jaw, stubborn as a reef against the tide. Catra recognised the stalemate immediately. Mermista wasn't hers to command. She was an ally, not a subordinate, and Adora would never grant Catra leave to discipline her—even if she deserved it.

Catra exhaled slowly.

"I'm not asking for secrets," she said. "There were half a dozen witnesses. I asked you because you know Adora better than anyone else in this cursed fort. Your read is the one that matters."

Mermista's eyes flashed.

"She broke her heart," Mermista said, voice rough. "How do you think she reacted?"

Catra blinked, the words landing heavier than expected.

"I think she didn't react at all," Catra said. "She stood there and took it. Like she always does."

Mermista's expression shifted, then sharpened into something wary, like she had seen a truth slip through her adversary's guard before she could keep it close. Catra felt a grim, vindicated calm settle in her chest. She exhaled and rubbed at her temples; the sharp spike of her headache had dulled into a steady, punishing throb.

"She can't keep doing that," Catra said. "Nobody can absorb that much and stay intact."

Mermista's eyes flicked back to her, flinty. "You think I don't know that?"

"I think," Catra said evenly, "that if she collapses under the weight of everything she's been swallowing down, it will be catastrophic. Strategically. Politically. Militarily."

"Oh, spare me," Mermista said. "You're worried about her now?"

Catra's lip curled. "Don't be stupid. This is logistics."

Mermista scoffed. "Right. Of course it is."

The contempt didn't sting the way Adora's disappointment did. Mermista didn't know her. She never had. And Catra no longer needed her approval. The fantasy that she might one day fit neatly into Adora's circle—be tolerated by the people Adora loved—had always been just that.

They had the fort. Cazzle Cove was an obvious next stop. Prime would have anticipated it. He always did. From here on out, every step toward Bright Moon would be tighter, bloodier, more cruelly designed.

Prime had noticed Adora.

Catra knew exactly what that meant.

He would strip her allies away piece by piece. Turn the taste of victory bitter in her mouth. Force her to choose between compassion and command. He would do to Adora what he had done to Catra—only cleaner, quieter, and in front of everyone who mattered.

If Adora was going to break, she needed to do it here. Now. Somewhere contained.

Before Prime decided to do it for her.

"I am asking you," Catra said carefully, each word measured, "to look after her."

Mermista stared at her as though she'd started speaking another language.

"…What?"

"Do I need to slow down?" Catra asked mildly. "I find repetition boring."

“I heard you,” Mermista said. “I just don’t believe you.”

“Tragic.”

“You want *me* to comfort her?” Mermista demanded. “You?”

“Yes,” Catra said. “You. The one she trusts. The one she listens to when she’s pretending everything is fine.”

Mermista threw her hands up, pacing once across the small room. Her frustration was beginning to grate on Catra. “I can’t just walk up and—what—ask her how she’s *feeling*?”

Catra arched a brow. “That’s usually how it starts.”

“You are unbelievable.”

“Five syllables,” Catra said. “Don't hurt yourself.”

Mermista rounded on her. “This isn’t a joke.”

“No,” Catra agreed. “It isn’t. Which is why I’m delegating it to someone who might actually succeed.”

Mermista opened her mouth, then shut it again. Her scowl deepened.

“Adora has her pride,” Mermista said. “I won’t rip it open just to see what’s underneath. She’s my friend. She’s my Queen. I won’t corner her like that.”

“Fuck her pride,” Catra snapped. “Better she bleeds here, where we can steady her, than out on the field with Prime watching for the moment she falters.”

For a heartbeat, Mermista looked like she might agree. Her jaw tightened; her eyes flicked away. Then she shook her head once, sharp and final. “Adora doesn’t *talk* about her feelings. If she needs me, she’ll come to me.”

“Then you’re useless,” Catra said, already turning away.

A hand closed around her arm.

Catra stopped.

She turned back slowly, the temperature in the room seeming to drop with the movement. Her gaze slid from Mermista's face to the hand gripping her sleeve, then back again—a flat, cold look. Mermista released her, unrepentant. Titles meant little to her. She had grown up beside Adora; she did not bow easily to anyone, least of all her.

"Are all Etherians this suicidally bold," Catra asked, "or is it a personal failing of yours?"

"Don't hurt her," Mermista said.

Catra blinked. Once.

Mermista held her ground.

"That's what you're doing, isn't it?" she pressed. "That's your solution. If I won't step in, you will."

"You mean after you've proven yourself spectacularly ineffective?" Catra replied.

"You're using her," Mermista said. "You've all but admitted you're a practical person. You know she loves you. You know she'll excuse anything—cruelty, humiliation, pain—if it means she gets to keep you a little longer. And you're ruthless enough not to waste that leverage."

"I'm asking you," Mermista continued, voice roughening, "no—I'm begging you. Leave her alone."

Then beg, Catra thought.

The words lodged somewhere behind her teeth and froze there.

You know she loves you.

The cold that flooded her wasn't the familiar, cultivated chill she wore like armor. This was sharper. Unwanted. It locked her jaw, stilled her breath.

"She's given you her army," Mermista said. "She's given you her body, her loyalty. How much more do you plan to take? When will you finally have enough?"

"When I've finally had enough." Catra echoed, softly.

Mermista threw her hands up. "I don't know why I'm trying to reason with you."

She shoved past, her shoulder striking Catra's.

Catra didn't move.

She stood there, rigid and silent, and let Mermista go.

✧

Prime's heralds reached Cazzle Cove before noon.

That alone told Catra everything she needed to know: the summons had gone out long before they had the fort. Prime had expected this. Or feared it. Either way, he had not waited to confirm the loss before moving his pieces.

Even numb, even hollowed out by Moroz and sleepless nights, Catra wasn't surprised. Adora terrified him. A siege at Bright Moon would have been a nightmare—every commoner and noble alike rallying behind She-Ra, every sword raised willingly. No clone would even remain loyal with Adora at the gates. And Prime knew that Adora would out-rank anyone he could put in the field.

Even himself.

So he did what he always did when brute force failed him: he set traps at a distance. Smears. Delays. Fractures. He would already

be whispering poison into receptive ears, eroding alliances before steel ever met steel. He wouldn't wait. He never did.

He would be hoping—desperately—that numbers would save him in the end.

Catra almost smiled at that.

Numbers hadn't saved him at Seaspray.

Despite the absence of resistance, Adora wore the victory easily and visibly. Catra arrived at the audience chamber after Adora had already taken the throne, and for one treacherous moment, the sight of her made everything else feel insignificant—even Glimmer's capture, even Prime's looming shadow.

Adora sat like the throne was made in her image.

She wore She-Ra's armor again—ridiculous, impractical, scandalously brief. Bare arms. Bare thighs. A skirt so short it bordered on indecent. And yet nothing about it diminished her authority. If anything, it sharpened it. The muscle on display wasn't decoration; it was a promise and a threat. Capability made flesh.

Adora had always been like that. Even on the Flagship, even collared—she had wielded her body like a weapon, and she knew exactly what it communicated. Strength. Certainty. Dominion.

Catra could see her, sitting just like this on a throne in Bright Moon—victorious—with Prime's head in her hand.



You know she loves you.

Catra took her place on the throne beside her. Adora turned slightly, offering a nod that was polite and nothing more.

"Our sister of the Horde," Adora said.

The phrasing caught Catra off-balance. She let the pause stretch just long enough to be noticed before answering.

"My sister of Etheria," she replied.

Her voice came out cooler than she intended. Guarded. Adora noticed—but, mercifully, didn't comment.

When the chamber filled, when the murmur of officers and advisors settled, it was Adora who lifted her hand. She had kept Prime's heralds waiting on purpose—long enough to remind them where they stood.

"Send them in," Adora said.

The doors opened.

Seeing Prime's clones enter was different now.

Not from a courtyard, not from a position of surprise—but from a throne, seated beside She-Ra herself, within walls that had been occupied by Prime's loyalists only days before. Cazzle Cove joined a growing list of losses. A pattern. A warning.

The clones advanced in perfect formation, faces blank, posture immaculate. But Catra could read the tension anyway. She had lived among them long enough to know when discipline was compensating for fear.

Prime was nervous.

Against every expectation, against everything Catra herself had once believed immutable, they were doing more than surviving.

They were beginning to look dangerous.

There were seven of them.

The herald, four guards, and two so-called dignitaries—clones dressed in ceremonial severity, every line of their posture rehearsed. Seven Horde emissaries, standing in a room dense with Etherian steel and muscle. Counting Catra made eight.

Eight Horde, surrounded.

Catra was not wearing the uniform she usually favoured. She had chosen something heavier, darker—structured, severe. She knew the stories being told about her. That seated beside Adora, she would be read as spoils. That her body was the price Etheria had exacted. She had ordered her own soldiers excluded from the chamber to help the fiction along; being underestimated had always been useful.

But she had refused to don a silk dress and play the part of bedded whore.

She would not sit soft and ornamental among warriors, polished into something decorative at Adora's side. She would not look like a jewel set into another woman's crown.

Prime had chosen the delegation carefully.

The herald was the clone who had once been before her with a bag of obscene contents, who had presented his offering with reverence and obedience and a smile she still felt sometimes in her throat.

Catra did not let the memory bloom. She did not picture the box that travelled with her still, unpacked first wherever she slept. She did not allow herself the sharp, useless ache that remembering the boy always brought.

The herald did not bow.

Of course he didn’t.

To him, Catra was a traitor princess who had forfeited legitimacy by crawling into an enemy’s bed. A coward. A whore. Adora was irrelevant. Catra didn’t need to know the particulars to understand the shape of the lie. Prime always told stories that made himself the only possible solution.

And it hardly mattered. Prime intended to raze Etheria. Glimmer’s claim would end the moment Adora was broken. Prime might once have imagined ruling from behind a pliant figurehead, but Catra’s refusal to dance had cured him of that fantasy.

He would never be satisfied without everything in his grasp.

The herald saw no reason for courtesy. In his world, Catra was no Princess.

Adora was no Queen.

Adora smiled.

It was wide and brilliant and sharp-edged—an animal baring teeth. Catra saw the almost imperceptible motion of Adora’s hand, the silent signal that kept Etherian guards from stepping forward to correct the insult with force.

Adora let the herald draw breath.

Then she spoke over him.

“We accept Prime’s surrender at Seaspray,” Adora said, serene and generous.

The herald faltered mid-step. Colour flared across his face, rage and humiliation bleeding together. Around the chamber, Etherians reacted openly now—smiles spreading, laughter half-contained. The air thickened with confidence, with appetite..

Catra watched it all without moving.

She thought, distantly, that Prime would hate this most of all—not the words themselves, but the ease with which Adora wielded them.

The herald, it quickly became clear, had survived this long by luck rather than judgment.

He ignored Adora entirely.

Raising his voice so it rang against the stone, he declared, "The rightful sovereign of the Horde sends his word."

Adora blinked. The look she put on her face was so transparently manufactured that Catra almost choked—wide-eyed, guileless, the expression of a woman honestly trying to understand a very simple problem.

She gestured, open-palmed, to Catra at her side.

"The Queen of the Horde is seated here," Adora said mildly, as if explaining a seating arrangement to a confused guest. "Are you confused?"

The herald drew breath to protest—

—and Adora cut him off again.

This time there was no softness in her voice. No playfulness. It dropped low, carried cleanly, and every Etherian in the room felt it with pride.

"We do not recognize Horde Prime's authority," she said. "Here, or anywhere in Etheria."

The herald swallowed. His mouth twitched once before he mastered it. He did not look at Adora again.

Instead, he turned fully toward Catra—though even that was done badly, his gaze sliding past her, addressing the space above her shoulder as if she were beneath notice.

“Catra of the Horde,” he announced to the air, “Horde Prime offers you his goodwill. He extends to you the opportunity to reclaim your standing. He—”

“No head in a bag this time?” Catra said.

She timed it perfectly—her words cutting straight across his syllables, her tone idle, almost bored. She didn’t shift in her seat. Didn’t lean forward. Didn’t raise her voice.

The herald jerked, startled, eyes snapping fully to her at last.

Catra smiled slowly, lazily, the kind of smile that said: *I'm right here, you fucking prick*.

“Horde Prime is an honourable ruler,” the herald snapped, heat flaring through his composure. He took a half-step forward before the subtle movement of Etherian guards gave him pause. He stopped himself, visibly recalibrated, and forced calm back into his voice.

“His followers have demanded your execution,” he continued, stiffly. “But Prime has refused them. He does not believe the rumours that you have betrayed your own.”

Catra tilted her head.

“He wishes to give you the chance to prove otherwise,” the herald said, conviction strengthening his spine. He believed this. Entirely.

“Prove otherwise,” Catra repeated, scornfully.

“A lawful trial,” the herald declared, spreading his hands as if offering mercy. “Come to Bright Moon. Stand before the people. Speak in your defense. If you are innocent, all that was taken from you will be restored.”

For the first time since the delegation arrived, something icy slid down Catra’s spine.

“All that was taken from me?” she echoed, confused.

Another clone found his courage then, voice trembling but earnest. “Your Highness—Horde Prime has been just to those who remained loyal to you.”

Catra almost laughed until the sight of Kyle's severed head flashed behind her eyes again.

“He wishes to welcome you home,” the clone pressed. “This trial is only to satisfy appearances.” He meant it. That was the worst part. His eyes flicked toward Adora, then away again, as if burned. “Even if there have been… misunderstandings.”

Repentance, his look said. Submission.

“He will forgive you,” the clone finished, desperate. “If you show contrition, he will open his heart.”

Catra leaned back at last, folding one leg over the other, her expression unreadable.

Catra held the clone in her gaze without blinking.

It felt as though she had slipped free of herself—of the weight of her limbs, of the press of the throne beneath her, of the audience chamber and the watching soldiers. *All that was taken from you will be restored.* Prime would open his heart. Prime always opened his heart when he meant to cut something out of you and hold it up for inspection.

He wasn’t speaking of the throne. That had never truly been on the table. He wasn’t speaking of Shadow Weaver, whose ghost was long beyond any reach Catra still possessed.

He wasn’t even talking about Weave’s Slope, stripped from her in ink and ceremony and then promptly abandoned, as if it were already beneath Prime’s notice.

No.

Whatever Prime meant to return, Catra had not yet realized she had lost it.

But the clone was still talking.

“He understands,” the second dignitary said, voice tight with effort. “As do those still loyal to you. The things being said in Bright Moon—about you—they are not…” He faltered, eyes darting, conviction buckling under its own weight. “…they cannot be true.”

He wanted them not to be true. The need for that rang painfully clear.

“You are no traitor to the Horde,” he finished, and the words landed wrong—thin, uncertain, offered like a plea rather than a declaration.

Catra did not soften. She did not reassure him. She did not acknowledge the insult inherent in his need for comfort.

Instead, she leaned forward a fraction.

“All that was taken from me,” she said coolly. “Restored. Those were *his* words?”

The herald answered this time, crisp and practiced. “If you present yourself in Bright Moon and submit to trial, all that was taken will be restored.”

The wrongness did not ease. It deepened.

Catra’s brow furrowed slightly, as if examining a flawed blade. “And if I decline?”

The herald did not hesitate.

“Then you will be executed,” he said evenly. “As a traitor. Your death will be public. Your body displayed.”

Catra saw it with perfect clarity: the spikes, the square, the careful arrangement meant to maximize spectacle. She had watched Prime do this before—back when she still believed that those on spikes deserved it. Back before she understood how much he savoured the ritual.

"Your remains will not be interred with your mother," the herald continued, voice utterly devoid of mercy. "Your name will be erased from record. The Horde will not remember you. What has been taken from you will be scattered and claimed by the elements. This is Prime's promise."

Catra inhaled slowly.

Prime thought her death was leverage. Prime thought humiliation still frightened her.

Prime thought her beauty—once so carefully cultivated, so obsessively possessed—was the axis upon which her pride turned.

He thought decay would be punishment enough.

Catra leaned back again, eyes distant, calculating.

All that was taken from you.

She hated how the words kept circling, how Prime had polished them until they sounded benevolent. As if he were offering a kindness instead of sharpening a knife.

I have nothing left, she thought, distantly*. What does he imagine he can still take from me?*

Then Adora spoke—and the wave of sickness that rolled through Catra had nothing to do with the words themselves.

No.

"Carry this back to Prime," Adora said, voice steady and ringing with command. She sounded untouchable—every inch the Queen

the Etherians believed her to be. The platinum cuff on her wrist flashed as she gestured, and Catra's eyes caught on it against her will. Against that gleam of metal. Against the echo of her own cuff hidden beneath fabric, cool and familiar, suddenly constricting. "Tell him this: what is Catra's will be returned to her when she takes the throne. We have no interest in false mercy or staged repentance."

Adora's gaze swept the chamber, daring contradiction. "We are the Queens of Etheria and the Horde," she said, with a breath of dismissive amusement, as if to say anything else would be giving credence to an absurd rumor. "We will not crawl to Bright Moon. We will ride there at the head of armies. United. And Prime will fall."

There was no doubt in her voice. Not a shred.

Nor in the faces of the Etherians arrayed around her, all watching their resurrected Queen as if she were a certainty made flesh.

Once, Catra thought bleakly, Shadow Weaver had looked just as inevitable.

Her chest tightened.

Because Catra understood: there *was* one thing left she could still lose.

"Your Highness—please." One of the clones stepped forward, desperation cracking through his rehearsed calm. "You can't align yourself with her. Not after what's said. Not after what she's done." His voice pitched higher, fraying. "Her crimes are worse than yours."

The words reached Catra as if through water. She stared at him, unblinking, struggling to stay anchored. To stay present.

Adora laughed—a short, sharp sound, all contempt.

"Oh?" she said lightly. "And what crimes would those be?"

Catra tried to speak. She couldn’t. Her tongue felt thick, unresponsive, as though her body had decided it was done cooperating.

The herald stepped in before the other clone could falter further. He switched to First Ones deliberately, ensuring every soul in the chamber could understand him.

“You are accused of matricide,” he said, voice precise. “Of murdering your own mother—Queen Angella of Etheria.”

Catra felt it then: the quiet, unmistakable click of a piece sliding into place on Prime’s board.

Chapter End Notes

> There are some heavy chapters coming up and I have been focusing all my energy into them. This week has been very hard as I am Australian and I'm assuming at least most of the world has seen the news.
>
> I will add trigger warnings as necessary, but please take care of yourselves.
>
> Thank you 😊

Chapter 22: Adora

Chapter Notes

> The next 3 chapters are a sort of slow reveal as Catra and Adora are out of sync with the information each other hold. So if you're confused, that's intentional, I'm sorry. If you're suspicious of certain characters, good. If you figure out the whole plot-twist from this chapter alone, wow 🙀👏
>
> Tw: grief

See the end of the chapter for more notes

She nearly leapt from the large wooden chair she'd been so calmly occupying a moment before, scraping it hard against the stone. The sound echoed in the emptied hall. Quickly, she crossed to the nearest window and braced her hands against the sill, even though the thick, warped glass showed her nothing but a pale smear of the courtyard beyond.

Adora focused on breathing. In. Out.

Behind her, the chamber was silent now—cleared on her order, the echoes of outrage still ringing in her ears. Etherian voices, furious, incredulous. She clung to that.

Anger on my behalf. Not doubt. No one would think—no one could think—

Her head throbbed. The pressure sat behind her eyes, pulsing with every heartbeat. Double Trouble had killed her mother, and Prime had taken that truth and twisted it until it was poison he could use, until it could be flung back at her like a blade. Until he could stand there untouched, as he always had, and let others do the cutting.

The unfairness of it lodged in her throat.

This felt worse than enslavement. Worse than the collar, worse than the arena, worse than losing her mother. Prime hadn’t just tried to break her bodily—he had reached back and desecrated the darkest hour of her life. Well after causing Angella’s death, he had found another way to use it to wound everyone who had ever loved her.

To get her people to doubt her. To circulate whispers through Bright Moon. To drag her mother's name through the mud just to force her to flinch.

She turned.

Catra stood alone near the centre of the hall, framed by banners and empty space. Still and watchful. As if she were weighing the room instead of occupying it.

For a split second Adora saw it clearly—Catra's isolation from any possible ally, so far from the easy gravity of belonging. Prime had done this to her, too. Had pared away everyone who might have stood beside her, until she was left alone and sharp-edged and dangerous by necessity.

Catra had been living with this for seven years.

Adora straightened, forced steel back into her spine.

“He thinks this will bait me,” she said, keeping her voice level. “That I’ll rush in blind and furious and make a mistake. I won’t. I’ll take Etheria back piece by piece. Province by province. And when I ride into Bright Moon, I’ll end this. I’ll make him answer for every lie.”

Catra didn’t interrupt. She just watched, eyes unreadable.

“You’re not thinking of accepting this,” Adora said. It came out sharper than she meant. “You can’t be.”

Catra didn’t answer right away.

“You can’t go to Bright Moon,” Adora pressed. “There won’t be a trial. Not a real one. He’ll just kill you.”

“I’d get a trial,” Catra said calmly.

Adora stared at her. “Catra—”

“It’s exactly what he wants,” Catra went on. “A spectacle. He’d parade fake witnesses one after another. They’d call me a traitor. Whore. Sellout. The Princess he raised so generously who handed her army to Etheria and crawled into your bed.” A faint, humourless curl touched her mouth. “And when there was nothing left of my name, he’d kill me in the square so everyone could see. He’d enjoy it.”

Adora swallowed. “Then why—”

“I’m not considering it,” Catra said. “I know how it ends. He wouldn’t even hesitate. He has replacements, remember.”

Across the distance between them, Adora felt a chill settle in her chest. For the first time, she understood the pull of it—the terrible, tempting idea of standing in the open and demanding the truth be spoken aloud. Of clearing one’s name, even if it cost everything.

But Catra was right. Prime’s version of justice was just another trick.

Adora exhaled slowly.

“Then what?”

“There’s more,” Catra said.

Adora looked up. “More how?”

“Horde Prime doesn’t extend an invitation just to have it refused,” Catra replied. Her tone was measured, but there was tension

under it, like a wire pulled too tight. “He didn’t send that herald here to posture. He sent him because he wanted something else.”

She hesitated, and when she spoke again it was almost reluctant. “There’s always something else with him.”

Before Adora could press, there was a scrape of boots at the doorway. She turned sharply.

Keston stood there in full uniform, helm tucked under his arm, posture rigid in the way soldiers adopted when they were bracing for impact.

“It’s the Qu—Princess Glimmer,” he corrected himself quickly. “She’s requesting an audience.”

All Adora could see, suddenly, was a sickbed and dim lamplight. Their mother fading, breath by breath. And Glimmer elsewhere, seeking comfort in Bow’s arms. The thought struck like a slap, and she hated how quickly it took root.

Her pulse spiked. Her hands curled without her telling them to.

She knew, distantly, that this mood was dangerous—Adora was too raw for this. Too full of noise.

She didn’t look at Keston again. She looked at Catra.

“Deal with it,” Adora said flatly.

Catra studied her for a long beat, eyes narrowing as if she were testing Adora’s resolve—or the cracks in it. Whatever she saw made her nod once.

Without another word, Catra turned and headed for the cells.

Adora went back to the window.

Five minutes passed.

Then ten.

Her foot tapped once against the stone before she caught herself. She swore under her breath and shoved away from the glass, already knowing she was about to do exactly what she shouldn't.

She left the hall.

✧

The stairway down to the cells was worn smooth by centuries of use. The air cooled with every step, damp stone leeching heat from her skin. By the time she reached the final gate, the noise of the fort above felt very far away.

She stopped.

A voice carried through echoed cells—

"Hello Sparkles."

Momentarily, Adora stayed where she was, half-hidden in the shadows beyond the door.

The prison at Cazzle Cove was underground and narrow, the stone walls close enough to make even tall ceilings feel oppressive. Guards snapped to attention as she started forward again. Her focus narrowed to the second gate, the one with the grated window.

Through it, she could see inside.

Glimmer's cell had been made… civil. Clean. Cushions salvaged from her solar arranged carefully, a carved reclining chair placed where a pallet should have been. It was still a cell—but a gentler one, by design.

Catra stood before her.

Something uneasy rolled through Adora's stomach at the sight of them together. A sense of inevitability. Of pieces sliding into place. Lies being uncovered.

She leaned closer, unseen.

Catra spoke, “She’s not coming.”

Glimmer carried herself like a ruler, not a prisoner. Her hair—rose and violet—was swept up and fixed with a single pearl pin, elegantly. She reclined rather than sat, the way her mother used to when she wished to appear at ease while measuring a room. Pale blue fabric draped cleanly over her shoulders, the pink silk shawl embroidered with Etherian motifs folded neatly around her. Her eyes, bright as cut gems, assessed without hurry.

[Very rushed Glimmer sketch]



Catra stood opposite her, weight resting against the stone wall, posture loose to the point of insolence. If there was tension in her, she hid it well.

They did not look alike. Not in body, not in presence. And yet Adora, watching from the shadowed corridor beyond the grate, felt the unsettling symmetry of them—the same sharp composure, the same cool indifference toward one another, the same habit of turning a room into a board and everyone in it into pieces—even your own allies.

Glimmer spoke first, in flawless Horde-Etherian.

“So this is who Adora sends down to see me,” she said before her eyes swept Catra up and down. “You fit her tastes well enough.”

Catra’s mouth curved faintly. “You know who I am.”

“The Princess of the Horde,” Glimmer replied. “Adora’s newest fling.”

Silence stretched.

Adora should have stepped forward then. Announced herself. Ended this. Instead, she stayed still, fingers pressed into the wood by the grate as she watched Catra shift—just slightly—settling into herself.

Catra said, casually, “If you’re wondering whether we fucked—yes.”

Glimmer’s lips twitched. “I doubt you were the one setting the pace.” Her gaze flicked over Catra again with interest. “Some things never change.”

Her voice didn't waver.

“And what does that matter to you?” Catra asked.

Adora’s heart thudded. She leaned closer, straining for Catra’s face, for some sign—anything.

Glimmer tilted her head. “I’m curious,” she said. “People tell stories.”

Catra lifted her chin a fraction. “Then by all means, let's hear it.”

Glimmer’s eyes narrowed, thoughtful rather than cruel. “You expected force,” she said softly. “Because that’s what people assume when they look at She-Ra. Strength. Heat. But Adora doesn’t move that way. She takes her time. She listens. She makes sure you enjoy every second.”

Adora’s breath caught. She did not move.

Catra’s smile sharpened. “You seem very certain about that.”

“I am,” Glimmer said. Her gaze did not leave Catra’s. “Did she not tell you?”

Catra replied lightly, “Please. Don’t stop on my account. Tell me more.”

Catra, to her credit, didn’t flinch at the implication—that Adora had lied, that it had never been Bow.

Glimmer’s voice stayed smooth, almost conversational.

“You let her undress you,” she said. “You let her touch you. People say you despise Etherians—and yet you invited one into your bed. You didn’t expect how it would feel when she focused on you. The weight of her attention. The certainty of being wanted.”

Catra answered easily, a faint edge under the calm.

“You skipped the part where it felt good enough that I forgot, briefly, who she was and what she had done to me.”

Glimmer smiled. “Ah. I didn’t expect the truth from you.”

"It's intoxicating," Glimmer went on. "She was made to rule. Not just here—anywhere. She-Ra walks into a room and it bends around her. People follow her. The way they followed our mothers."

"Our *dead* mothers," Catra supplied mildly. "Would you like to circle back to the part where I'm accused of sharing a bed with my mother's killer? Everyone seems fond of that refrain."

Catra's posture didn't change; she lounged against the stone like this was an idle debate.

"Is it difficult," Glimmer added, "to exist beside someone who so obviously outshines you?"

Catra didn't answer.

"Or is that the appeal?" Glimmer continued. "That she has what you lack—certainty, conviction. When she turns that on you, it feels like borrowing power."

Catra tilted her head. "Now we're both being honest with each other."

The pause that followed was different—

Then Glimmer spoke, quietly.

"Bow won't be joining Adora."

Catra's gaze flicked to her. "Why?"

"He was intercepted while fleeing Cazzle Cove," Glimmer said. "Prime's clones. I don't know if he's even alive."

Adora felt the cold settle into her bones.

Glimmer straightened. "So. The pleasantries are done. I have information. You'll grant me clemency in exchange. We negotiate

terms, and then I lend what I know to your campaign against Prime."

She met Catra's eyes squarely.

"That's why Adora sent you, right?"

Catra regarded her for a long moment. When she answered, her voice was flat and unimpressed.

"No," she said. "She sent me to tell you that you don't matter to her. You'll stay here until Bright Moon is reclaimed. Then you'll be executed for treason."

A beat.

"She's never coming to see you again."

From the shadowed corridor, Adora realized—with a sick, hollow certainty—that Catra had taken this worse than she'd expected.

Catra peeled herself off the stone, the movement smooth but tight, like a blade sliding back into its sheath.

"Still," she said lightly, already turning away, "thank you for the note about Bow. That's the sort of thing Adora might actually care to know."

She had nearly reached the door when Glimmer spoke again.

"You didn't ask about my child."

Catra stopped.

She turned slowly, eyes lifting. Glimmer hadn't moved from her place on the reclining couch. She looked carved there—composed, upright, her presence filling the space with quiet authority. If Angella had ever ruled a room by stillness alone, Glimmer had learned it well.

“She came early,” Glimmer said. Her voice did not tremble, but it had changed. “The labour lasted through the night. By dawn there was a daughter. I was holding her—looking at her—when word came that your army was at the gates. I sent her away before the walls were breached.”

She let the words sit. “There is no cruelty quite like tearing a child from her mother’s arms.”

Catra’s mouth curved. “Is that all?” she asked. “A sentimental appeal to motherhood? I expected more.” Her gaze flicked dismissively over Glimmer. “Did you truly think a Princess of the Horde would flinch over your infant?”

“You should,” Glimmer said evenly. “She is a Queen’s daughter.”

The words struck Adora in the chest.

A Queen’s daughter.

Adora felt the world tilt. It was not dramatic—no rush of sound, no flash of light—but a sudden, sickening sense that the ground beneath her had quietly shifted. Glimmer had delivered it the way she delivered everything else.

A child.

Her sister’s child.

Her *own* child.

Catra stared at Glimmer, comprehension clearly lagging behind without all the information at her disposal. For all her intelligence, for all her practiced reading of opponents, this had landed too far outside the game she thought they were playing.

When she spoke again, it was not mockery in her voice, but something raw and sharp.

“Did you send the baby to Horde Prime?”

The horror there was naked, unguarded, and for a breath Adora didn't understand it—didn't understand the look in Catra's eyes, or the answering cold certainty in Glimmer's.

Why?

Glimmer leaned back slightly. "You see?" she said. "I am worth taking seriously. I will not sit in a cell and wait for the verdict you've written for me." Her gaze was steady. Calculating. "You will tell Adora that I will see her when *I* decide. And I think you'll find she won't send a whore this time."

✧

It unsettled her that her thoughts kept circling back to her mother—their mother.

She'd be sick over this.

Adora sat on the edge of the bed in her quarters, elbows braced on her knees, the heels of her hands pressed hard into her eyes as if she could physically hold herself together that way. The room was quiet and she had chosen it that way. No guards. No advisors. No one asking her what she needed or what she planned to do next.

The last clear moment she could remember was Catra looking up and seeing her through the grating. The way Catra's eyes had widened—just slightly. Adora had stepped back without thinking. One step. Then another. Then she had turned and left, climbing the stairs to her rooms in a blur of motion and breath and pounding blood in her ears. No one had stopped her. No one had followed.

She had needed the space. The stillness. The chance to think.

But thinking was impossible. Her head throbbed, her chest felt tight and tangled, and every attempt at order dissolved into the same raw ache.

She might have a daughter.

And all she could think about was her mother.

It felt as though some inner wall she had relied on for months had finally split open. Everything she had locked away behind duty and momentum came spilling through the breach at once. Grief she had never let herself sit with. Longing she had told herself was weakness. The simple, brutal want of a family.

She had lost her mother.

Now there was the possibility of another bond—fragile, distant, already threatened—and the knowledge hit her like a fresh rejection. As if the world kept offering her the shape of family only to tear it out of her hands.

Like she could never escape being an orphan of Eternia.

Her mind dragged her back to Bright Moon.

The last day.

She had knelt beside the bed, her mother's hand heavy in her hair. Adora had been too naïve—too trusting—to recognize the truth in the room. The air thick with magic and incense. The slow, uneven rhythm of her mother's breathing. Words that came out thin and broken, carried more by breath than by voice.

Tell the physicians I will recover, her mother had said. *I will see what my daughters will accomplish.*

Adora swallowed hard, the memory sharp enough to steal her breath.

She had only ever had one parent. One true measure of right and wrong. Queen Angella had been her compass—kind, unyielding, impossibly strong. Adora had grown up trying to live up to her gaze, to earn that quiet pride. Even after her death, Adora had survived by refusing to look back. She told herself there was no

time for grief. There was only return. Only reclamation. Only her throne.

Now the resolve that had carried her this far felt thin.

She could almost feel it again—her mother's hand in her hair. Solid. Certain. Gone forever.

She had wanted her mother to see her like this. Wanted her to be proud of what she had become.

And standing there alone, with the weight of the past and the threat of the future crashing together, Adora felt—for the first time—that she had failed her.

A sound at the door drew her out of herself.

Adora lifted her head and saw Catra slipping inside, closing the door quietly behind her. The motion was careful—someone entering a space they knew was fragile.

Adora inhaled, the breath shaky despite her effort to steady it. *I have to deal with this too*, she thought, dimly. One more thing. One more weight.

Catra started to speak and stopped, then tried again. "No," she said, as if correcting herself. "I'm not here to—" She huffed a breath. "I'm just here."

Only then did Adora really notice how dark the room had become. Night had settled fully while she'd been sitting there, unmoving. The magic lamps were unlit. The air felt heavy, still. Hours must have passed. No servants. No aides. No interruptions.

Understanding slid into place.

Someone had kept them out.

Her generals, the Princesses, anyone with business pressing at the Queen's door—turned away. Held back. And the only person bold

enough, strong enough, to do that was standing in front of her now. Catra, feared enough that no one questioned it. Catra, who had given her this silence without asking whether it was wanted.

Gratitude hit her so hard it almost hurt.

She looked at Catra, meaning to say something—*thank you* or *I didn't know how much I needed that*—but her throat closed around the words.

Catra didn't wait.

Her hand came up, tentative but sure, fingers settling at the back of Adora's neck. The contact jolted through her, sharp and grounding all at once. Catra drew her forward without force, simply assuming she'd follow.

There was a stiffness to it, an uncertainty—like someone offering comfort without quite knowing how. But it was gentle and earnest.

Adora's body leaned in before her mind could argue. She closed her eyes.

She couldn't remember the last time she'd been held like this. Body to body, warmth shared without expectation. Maybe she'd needed it longer than she'd allowed herself to know.

They stayed like that for a while. Time softened and Adora was unsure of how long she cried for. She became aware of Catra's steady pulse beneath her hand, the narrow line of her shoulders, the quiet strength there. It was different from everything else between them. Simpler. Kinder.

Catra spoke into her ear, voice low, almost wry. "Careful," she murmured. "You're exploiting my rare charitable impulses."

Adora let out a breath that might have been a laugh. She eased back, but didn't put distance between them. Neither of them seemed inclined to.

The mattress dipped as Catra sat beside her, close enough that their shoulders brushed, as if that were natural between them.

And for the moment—strangely—it was.

Chapter End Notes

Hey, if anyone is still interested in being a beta-reader for my next Spop fic, let me know in the comments. If you drop a separate comment with your name on discord I can delete it rather than approving it so no one else sees.

I have already started it.

I might have a couple on this one just because it will be so dense and I want a few opinion with certain decisions. Even your comments are super helpful. I had an upcoming chapter I felt would no longer fit the plot and someone's comment on the last chapter has given me an idea to fix it.

Thank you for reading ❤

Chapter 23: Catra

Chapter Notes

None of you have figured it out (and I'm so glad 😊)

Anyways, enjoy 😉

Thank you to my beta reader 😘

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra had always known this was how it would end. One way or another. Prime hadn't bothered dressing it up: he would take Adora unless Catra handed herself over. Knowing the mechanics of it—the leverage, the cruelty, the inevitability—didn't soften the blow. It just meant Catra should have seen it coming for longer.

At some point Catra would need to give up and die for Adora to win.

Still, some stupid, stubborn part of her had believed—

She'd believed there would be a crack to slip through. A trick. A last-second pivot. That she could outrun it, outthink it, turn the board over before the game finished. Catra survived by finding exits. That was what she did.

But Adora's niece...

That wasn't a threat, it was a lock with no key. Prime could name his price and Adora would pay it, no hesitation, no bargaining. Catra didn't kid herself about that. Adora would burn herself alive to keep a child safe.

Prime was going to take Adora. Just like he'd taken everything else Catra had ever reached for. And Adora would go. She would walk straight into it, shoulders squared, calling it duty or

responsibility or sacrifice, and Catra would be left watching it happen—helpless, furious, too late.

Unless Catra made herself the answer.

They were closing in on the end of this spiral, the last turn before the drop. Catra wasn't ready. She'd spent so long flirting with the idea of giving up—*really* giving up—letting herself break, allowing all of it to finally stop. She'd brushed against that edge more times than she could count, telling herself she was done, that the peace of death might be worth it.

But this wasn't abstract anymore. This wasn't exhaustion or despair whispering in her ear.

This was real. And Catra was scared.

Worse—Catra wanted to live.

The realization sat heavy and ugly in her chest, impossible to ignore. She didn't want oblivion. She didn't want martyrdom. She wanted more time. More breath. More *Adora*, even if it hurt.

When she left the dungeons, her feet carried her to Adora's quarters without conscious thought. The guards stationed outside confirmed what she already knew.

"Take a break," Catra said flatly. "I've got her."

The two soldiers looked at each other, clearly weighing whether today was the day they argued with Catra. She didn't have the patience.

"Or stand farther down the hall and pretend you're useful," she snapped. "I'm not asking. Move."

For a heartbeat, she thought they'd push back.

They didn't.

They left, boots retreating, the corridor blessedly empty. Catra exhaled—sharp, shaky—then straightened, spine stiff with resolve and fear tangled together.

Catra forced herself to slow down and do what she did best: tear the problem apart until there was nothing left to surprise her. No panic. No spiraling. Just angles and outcomes.

Adora had heard enough. Maybe not every word, but enough to understand the shape of it—enough to know there was a child, that she was alive, that Prime had it as leverage. There was no walking that back. No lying it away. Adora could never unknow something like that.

Which meant there was no sidestepping the trap.

As long as Prime had the girl, they were frozen in place. He didn't need a complicated plan. He just needed to *mention* the child and every move they made would collapse under its own weight. Any resistance, any gambit, any brave speech would fold the second the threat was real. The only way around it was to remove the leverage entirely—get the child out of his hands.

And that was a fantasy.

They didn't know where she was. They didn't have agents embedded deep enough in Prime's ranks and Double Trouble could not be trusted. Infiltration would take months—months they didn't have—and even then it would hinge on luck and silence and people who hadn't failed yet. Catra didn't kid herself. Prime had planned this well.

She could refuse him. Let the offer come and watch Adora accept it. Let Adora walk into captivity for the sake of a child and keep fighting without her.

Catra snorted softly at the thought. Without Adora, this war ended. Prime knew Catra too well; he always had. He could see her moves before she made them. And Etheria wouldn't rally

behind Catra alone—not really. Adora was the spine of it. Take her away and half their strength went with her.

And—

No.

Catra yanked her thoughts back into line. This wasn't about *feeling*. This was analysis. Cold. Rational.

Objectively, Catra couldn't win without Adora. It had never been possible. Everything she'd accomplished—every narrow escape, every victory that mattered—had Adora's shadow stitched into it.

Objectively, if Catra were the one removed from the board, Adora would still have a chance. A real one. Catra had always leaned harder. Always needed others. That imbalance had been true long before Prime ever was in the picture.

Objectively—

Objectively, Catra would burn *everything* if it bought Adora another day of freedom. The territory Weaver had bled herself dry to hold. The civilians who would suffer under Prime's rule. Her own life. All of it was negotiable if the outcome was Adora still standing.

That realization landed hard.

The numbers, the projections, the logic—none of it mattered anymore. Because when she stripped it down to the bone, there was only one truth left.

If it came to it—if there was no other move—

Catra would die for Adora.

For the woman who had killed her mother. The irony almost made her laugh.

She shut her eyes and dragged in a breath. It came out uneven. Another. Then another, until her lungs stopped fighting her. When she opened her eyes again, the decision sat solid and immovable in her chest.

Fine.

Okay.

She inhaled slowly. One choice made. Simple. She would trade herself for the child. Adora would stay free. And once Catra was gone, Adora would finish this war.

Catra's soldiers would follow her—most of them, anyway. Numbers wouldn't be the problem. And Adora wouldn't *stop*. When she learned what Catra had done, her rage would be catastrophic. Prime wouldn't survive it. Even if he fled Etheria entirely, Adora would hunt him to the ends of the universe.

So what was the problem?

What would trip Adora up without Catra there to push, to plan, to see the uglier angles first? What obstacles would slow her down, cost her time, cost her lives?

Catra's breathing had evened out completely.

Eyes dry, jaw set, she began mapping a future that didn't include her.

✧

After Catra had learned what Prime had done to Kyle, Adora had stationed herself outside Catra's door and refused to give way to anyone. Just presence, solid and immovable.

Now it was Catra's turn.

She stood outside Adora's rooms and sent them all away—guards, aides, servants with excuses and trays and worried looks. No. Not

now. Not tonight. When Mermista arrived, boots sharp against the stone, Catra blocked her too.

"What did you do to her this time?" Mermista snapped, already halfway to furious.

Catra didn't rise to it. "I warned you," she said flatly. "I told you she was going to crack. This is what that looks like."

She braced for the explosion—raised voices, threats, a reach for a weapon or a claim of authority. Mermista was a storm when she wanted to be.

Instead, Mermista stalled.

Catra wasn't sure why. Maybe it was the rawness she hadn't bothered to hide. Maybe it was the way the words came out scraped thin, like she'd already burned through everything else.

"She needs space," Catra said, sharper now. "If you barge in, you'll just make it worse."

Mermista's jaw worked. When she spoke again, it was quieter, but no less dangerous. "Don't let her rot away in there."

She pointed down the hall, toward the windows. "If it's dark and she hasn't come out, you go in. If you don't—" Her eyes narrowed. "I will."

Catra flicked a glance at the fading light. Gold bleeding into grey. She nodded once.

Mermista retreated, but only as far as the far end of the corridor, posting herself with the remaining guards. They kept glancing Catra's way, whispering just loud enough to be obvious.

She's lucky to have you, Catra almost said.

She stopped herself. She wasn't dead yet, and saying things like that had a way of tempting fate—and starting conversations she

did *not* have the energy for.

Time stretched.

The shadows crept longer. The door behind Catra stayed stubbornly silent. Down the hall, Mermista turned away anyone who tried to approach, her irritation a visible deterrent. No one interrupted Catra again.

The light thinned. The sun slipped below the horizon.

Adora didn't come out.

Mermista straightened from the wall, eyes locking onto Catra. The question hung there between them.

Catra shook her head.

"I've got it," she said, already turning.

"If you hurt her—" Mermista started.

Catra didn't look back. "Yeah," she said, bone-tired. "Pretty sure we're done with that."

Adora's rooms lay in darkness—unnaturally so. Catra had waved off the servants earlier, told them to leave the lamps unlit, and Adora hadn't come looking for light herself. Now the only illumination crept in from outside: torchlight bleeding through the windows, the pale wash of moons and stars barely cutting the gloom.

It felt wrong. Like stepping into something simultaneously sacred and ruined. Like walking into a vigil uninvited.

Catra hesitated on the threshold, almost turning back. She could trade places with Mermista. Let someone kinder handle this. Someone who didn't have a long, ugly history of making everything worse. There was every chance that Catra's presence

would be the last thing Adora wanted and barging in now might only deepen the wound.

But—

But Adora had come to *her*, after Kyle.

Adora—Mara—had sat with Catra when she hadn't asked for comfort and hadn't expected to receive it. Had stayed. Had borne witness to the wreck she became. Catra could at least return that much. At the very least, Adora deserved the chance to tell her to get out.

The knowledge that Catra wouldn't be here much longer made the choice easier than it should have been.

She moved through the sitting room like a specter, footsteps barely there. The space was half-finished—crates pushed aside, belongings never fully unpacked. Adora had dismissed the servants before they'd completed the work. It left the room suspended, untouched, as though time had stalled the moment she arrived. It only deepened the sense that Catra didn't belong here.

The bedroom door stood open.

Adora sat on the edge of the bed, folded in on herself. Her shoulders curved inward, her head bowed, elbows braced on her knees. Her hands cradled the weight of her skull like it might collapse without them. Catra had seen Adora beaten, bloodied, dragged half-conscious from where Catra had left her.

This was worse.

There was no defiance in her posture. No tension coiled and ready to spring. Just exhaustion. Defeat. The kind that sank all the way into the bones.

Catra's boot scraped softly against the floor as she stopped just inside the doorway, like she'd hit an invisible wall. Her chest

tightened. The sight hurt—too much, too suddenly. Seeing the unbreakable hero brought this low made something inside her fracture.

Every instinct screamed at her to leave. This wasn't her place. It never was. She ruined things just by touching them. She was poison. She—

Adora lifted her head.

The moment their eyes met, Catra was trapped.

Adora looked at her—really looked—and Catra watched the recognition land. Her eyes were dry. There were no tears streaking her face. But the pain there was naked, unguarded, and it *deepened* when she saw who stood in the doorway.

Adora straightened, drawing in a slow, shaky breath. Her shoulders squared, bracing for impact—for the fight she clearly expected.

Catra flinched.

"No," she said too quickly, the word cracking through the stillness like a thrown stone. Too loud. Too sharp. "I'm not here to—"

She stopped, swallowed, tried again. *I'm not here to do that. I'm not here to hurt you.*

The words tangled in her mind. *I don't want to. I never—I mean, I did, I know I did, and I'm sorry for that, and I don't deserve— I don't deserve anything from you.*

She took a breath, smaller this time.

"I'm just here." Catra finished quietly.

Something shifted in Adora's expression. The rigid caution she wore like armor loosened, just a fraction, and in its place came

something fragile—relief. She looked like she hadn't expected permission to stop holding herself together.

Her mouth parted, then closed again. Her eyes shone. She ducked her head quickly, like she could outrun it, and Catra saw the familiar maneuver: the swallow, the breath forced steady, the emotions shoved down into whatever locked vault Adora kept them in. The place where pain went to be ignored until it rotted.

And then Catra was moving.

She didn't decide to. There was no plan, no internal argument. Her body simply crossed the distance. By the time Adora lifted her head again, Catra was standing right there, close enough to feel the heat of her.

Catra didn't *do* comfort. Not well. Not ever. But there were half-buried memories—small, blurry things from a long time ago, before everything had pain. She clung to those.

It felt clumsy, reaching out. She expected recoil. Expected Adora to flinch or snap or shove her away like she should. Catra lifted her hand anyway, slow, giving Adora time to refuse.

She didn't.

Catra's fingers slid into warm, golden curls. Adora looked up at her, startled, searching—and still didn't pull back. Catra hesitated, then nudged her forward gently, wordless. Adora followed the pressure, tentative, until her forehead rested against Catra's stomach.

They froze there, both of them.

Adora moved next, uncertain as Catra had been. Her hands lifted, paused, then settled against Catra's sides. Her arms wrapped around her, loose at first, like she was bracing for permission to be revoked. Catra kept her hand in Adora's hair, combing through it slowly, calming herself as much as Adora.

They were speaking a language neither of them knew how to use anymore. Something they might have once understood, back when comfort didn't feel like a risk. It took time. Long minutes of stillness. The tension in Adora's body resisted, shook, then gradually gave way.

When it finally broke, it broke all at once.

Adora exhaled—one long, fractured breath—and then she was crying.

Her shoulders hitched. Her arms tightened, desperate now, clutching Catra like she might disappear if Adora let go. Catra bent over her without thinking, one arm coming around her back, the other cradling her head, holding her there. It stopped feeling awkward. It stopped feeling wrong.

Catra didn't care about the damp spreading across her clothes.

She didn't care when her back began to ache from standing like that too long.

Adora clung to her, finally letting herself fall apart, and Catra—who had never learned how to hold someone properly—did her best anyway. She stayed. She anchored. She didn't run.

She tried to be what Adora needed.

Time blurred. The crying slowed at some point. The grip around Catra's waist loosened, inch by inch. Fingers that had been twisted painfully into her jacket relaxed, then slipped free. Catra didn't count the seconds. She didn't want to.

Eventually, Adora's shoulders softened completely. Her hands spread flat against Catra's back, steady now. When Catra's fingers returned to the familiar rhythm through her hair, Adora rubbed slow, absent circles between Catra's shoulder blades in return.

It felt… good.

That realization startled her. Comforting. Shared. The quiet between them settled heavy and warm, and Catra realized—too late, too honestly—how much she had missed this. How much it hurt to remember.

It was too much. Too gentle. Too easy to want more.

Catra leaned down slightly, closer, fighting the urge to sink into her, to breathe her in, to pretend this moment could stretch forever. She knew it couldn't. She knew better than to try and keep it.

So she stayed still.

Just a little longer.

Catra huffed softly, her mouth close to Adora's ear.

"Careful," she murmured. "You're exploiting my rare charitable impulses."

She tried to keep it teasing, airy—anything but weighty. She didn't want to be the one who tipped the balance. Not tonight.

Adora eased back, slow and reluctant, though she didn't fully let go. They lingered there, hands still resting on each other, studying one another like they were relearning familiar ground. Catra brushed curls off Adora's forehead, careful, reverent, then wiped the remaining tears from her cheeks with her thumbs. Only then did she pull away, stiff with self-consciousness, and sit down on the edge of the mattress beside her. Adora released her to scrub at her own face, sniffling, watching Catra with that quiet, measuring look that always made Catra want to look anywhere else.

The smile Adora managed was thin, fragile in a way that hurt to see. "You're really not even going to offer me a handkerchief?" she asked. Her voice was still rough, but lighter than before.

Something loosened in Catra's chest. "You could use what you're wearing," she said, reaching out to tug lightly at the hem of Adora's dress. "About the same size, honestly."

Adora let out a soft, incredulous sound. "Wow. My reputation for elegance, ruined."

Catra smiled despite herself. They both kept their voices low, like anything louder might break the spell. Adora's gaze lingered on her, open and searching, and Catra suddenly found it easier to focus on the fabric between her fingers. Adora leaned closer, conspiratorial, her mouth near Catra's ear. "All those exposed wrists and ankles."

"And arms," Catra added, her fingers brushing Adora's thigh as if by accident before she pulled her hand back, heart stuttering. "And thighs. And—yeah. Everything else." She planted her hand firmly on her own leg, resisting the urge to keep touching. Sitting like this—shoulders nearly brushing, voices soft—felt too good. Too normal. Even with Adora cracked open, it felt right to be here.

I've messed up so much, Catra thought, the awareness sharp and sudden. But not now. Not yet.

"My mother's dead," Adora said.

The word "dead" snagged on its way out, heavy and final. Catra knew that feeling—the way saying it made it real in a way nothing else did. Adora inhaled, shaky, then looked at her. "You thought she was cold," she said. There was no accusation there. Just truth. "A queen who'd crush the Fright Zone without caring who got caught underfoot."

"No," Catra said quickly, shaking her head. "We don't have to—Adora, not now." She wanted to keep this moment intact. Wanted the world to narrow to this bed, this quiet, this closeness. She didn't want the past. She didn't want the future.

But Adora went on anyway, voice steady even as her eyes stayed dark with grief. "She broke the peace with your mother. A decade

of it. She chose war." She held Catra's gaze. "You hated her."

Catra swallowed, the room suddenly feeling much smaller.

"I hated *you*," Catra said, and the truth of it tasted old and bitter on her tongue. The regret threaded through her voice before she could stop it—there every day, a second shadow she couldn't shake. "I hated you so much I thought it was going to kill me. If Prime hadn't stepped in, I would have—" She stopped herself, breath hitching. "I would've done it."

She couldn't keep looking at Adora. Not for this part. Her gaze slid away, fixed on nothing as her voice dropped, scraped raw. "And then you saved my life," she said. "Which was… inconvenient." A weak attempt at humor. It didn't land. "Every time I fell apart, every time I needed someone—you were there. Always." Her jaw tightened. "I hated you for that too."

"I killed your mother."

Adora didn't flinch when she said it. She didn't dress it up or soften it. She said it plainly, a fact that existed whether either of them wanted it to or not.

Catra sucked in a sharp breath. Heat burned behind her eyes. She could feel Adora watching her—steady, unblinking—and the silence between them grew heavy enough to press down on her chest.

When Adora finally spoke again, her voice was quiet. Careful. "Why are you here?"

The question lodged itself in Catra's throat.

She couldn't say *because I love you*.

She didn't deserve any of it. Not the words. Not the sentiment.

"I know what it's like," Catra said finally, choosing each word with care, "to lose your family."

She said it without edge, without blame. It was the closest she could get to *I forgive you*.

The quiet settled again—delicate, like it might shatter if either of them moved too fast. Catra thought of the nights in a shared tent, of the ease they'd once had standing side by side. Pain lingered in the room, undeniable, but Catra clung to the moment anyway. She catalogued it obsessively: the warmth of Adora's leg pressed against hers, the weight of her gaze, the familiar scent of her skin.

She closed her eyes, committing it to memory. This what she wanted to think of at the end.

"Is there really no future for us?"

The question burst out of Adora all at once, like she hadn't meant to say it aloud.

Catra didn't react—not immediately. She forced herself to breathe, to think, not to leap to the wrong conclusion. When she finally looked back at Adora, she found her staring straight at her, intensity sharp enough to steal the air from Catra's lungs.

"You mean," Catra said slowly, carefully, "you want me back in your bed for whatever scraps of time we've got left?" She tried for a crooked smile, tried to turn it into something lighter.

It didn't work.

"I mean *after*," Adora said, steady and earnest. "After we win. Does it have to stay Horde versus Etheria? Or could it be… one kingdom. One planet. Ours." Her words tumbled over each other now. "Would you want that with me?"

She rushed the words like if she didn't get them out now, she never would.

Adora looked away as she waited—but Catra had already seen it. The raw want in her eyes. The hope. The fear.

You know she loves you.

Mermista's voice echoed in her head.

Catra hadn't really believed it.

Not until she saw the look in Adora's eyes.

Catra waited until Adora looked back at her.

She needed that—needed Adora's eyes on her before she could even try to speak. Anything said without that anchor felt like it would shatter midair.

Yes, she wanted to say. Yes, of course. Yes, without hesitation, without qualifiers, without fear. Yes, I want you. Yes, I want that impossible future you're offering with both hands. Yes, I want to stand beside you and rule something that doesn't have to be built on conquering.

But Catra already knew the shape of the ending.

She knew how little time she had left. Knew how narrow the path ahead was, and how much blood and grief still waited on it. She knew she would not live long enough to see any shared throne, no matter how sweetly Adora imagined it.

And she had already stolen so much time from her.

"How could you trust me," Catra asked finally, her voice rough, uneven, "after what your sister did to you?" She swallowed. The rest stayed lodged in her throat. *After what I did to you*. At least Catra had never pretended to love Adora while cutting her open. She'd never hidden the knives. She'd always been honest about her anger, her hate. Adora—who loved openly, recklessly—should have known better by now. Should have learned to fear people who swore devotion.

But Adora didn't flinch.

She didn’t draw back or hesitate or weigh the question like a threat. She answered immediately, without a single doubt evident.

“Because she was lying,” Adora said simply. “And you never are.” Her voice carried no doubt—only conviction, fierce and unwavering. “I’ve never known anyone more honest than you.”

The words hit Catra like a blow.

Honest, Adora called her—when Catra had lived half her life wrapped in deception. Catra could barely breathe under the weight of it. Adora’s gaze burned where it rested on her, warm and intent and devastating.

“I think,” Adora continued quietly, when Catra couldn’t respond, “that if I trusted you with my heart… you’d take care of it.”

Catra looked away.

She had to. She couldn’t withstand the certainty in Adora’s eyes, the way she spoke as if this were already settled truth. Adora spoke as if that history was nothing when weighed against the present. Like Catra could be something better simply because Adora believed it.

Her chest felt too tight. Her pulse thundered in her ears.

“When you talk like that,” Catra admitted hoarsely, “my brain just… shuts off.”

“Then let it,” Adora said at once.

Catra squeezed her eyes shut, hard. Adora shifted closer—so close Catra could feel her warmth, could feel her breath. Her entire body reacted before her mind could catch up.

“Don’t think,” Adora said, urgent now, almost pleading.

Catra shook her head, desperation clawing its way into her voice. “You can’t—don’t play with me like this.” Her breath hitched. “I

don’t have—” She broke off, then forced the truth out. “I don’t have any defenses left.”

“I’m not playing,” Adora said, immediately, fiercely. “I wouldn’t.”

Catra knew that. God, she knew it. Adora didn’t scheme. Didn’t manipulate. Didn’t pretend. This wasn’t a game, and Catra had never been a prize to her. Mermista had said it—said Adora loved her—and Catra had dismissed it as optimism or pity or misunderstanding.

But Adora was here. Real. Trembling with hope. Asking for a future with Catra.

Adora didn’t want the throne.

She wanted Catra.

“Don’t think,” Adora said again, softer now, like a promise instead of a command.

Catra opened her eyes.

Everything she wanted collided with everything she knew was coming. Every instinct screamed at her to pull away, to protect Adora from herself, to deny her the thing she wanted most because she wouldn’t survive it.

But she was so tired of denying herself.

So tired of running.

“Kiss me,” Catra said.

Chapter End Notes

Are you excited for Chistmas?

Chapter 24: Adora

Chapter Notes

I hope everyone is having a better Christmas than me ❤️

I wanted to have chapter 25 done as well but it's a lot, and everything is a lot.

Thank you to my Beta Reader nbc22 ❤️

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“Kiss me,” Catra said.

The words came out fast, reckless. A flush suddenly worked its way up her face—color rising sharp and unmistakable beneath fine fur. Adora had told her not to think, but Catra was *all* thought right now, visibly wrestling with herself just to remain where she was. Even saying it had clearly cost her something.

The request hung between them, but Catra didn’t retract it. She didn’t soften it with a joke or a glare. She simply sat, rigid with tension, like she’d thrown herself off a cliff and was waiting to see if she’d hit ground.

Adora didn’t lean in.

Instead, she reached for Catra’s hand.

Catra startled. Adora felt it instantly: the tiny hitch, the way Catra’s fingers stiffened before she let them be taken. Adora brought Catra’s hand toward her and pressed a gentle kiss into her palm.

Once.

She had learned, during their single, strange night together, how Catra reacted when she was surprised. It wasn’t predictable.

Intimacy with Catra didn't line up with anything Adora understood—her bravado didn't mean experience, her sharpness didn't mean readiness. The gaps surprised Adora every time.

She felt it now. Catra went still, eyes dark, searching, clearly unsure what this move meant or what she was expected to do next.

"I meant—" Catra started, then broke off.

"—that you want your brain to shut off?" Adora supplied gently. "You don't want to be burdened by it."

Catra didn't answer. The silence stretched. Adora didn't rush to fill it.

"I'm not—" Catra tried again, irritation flaring to cover something more fragile. "I'm not a virgin who needs their hand held through everything."

Adora tilted her head, studying her. "Aren't you?"

The realisation settled slowly in her chest. This wasn't Catra's usual defensive posture—the high walls, the teeth-bared dare. This was different. This was someone who had lowered her guard just enough to feel exposed, and didn't know how to keep going.

After a beat, Catra spoke again, quieter. "At Talon Mountain, I—" She stopped, jaw tightening. "It'd been a long time since I'd… since I was *with* anyone. I was nervous."

"I know," Adora said softly.

"There's only—" Catra cut herself off, then forced it out. "There's only been one other person."

Adora's voice stayed gentle. "I have more experience than that."

Catra scoffed. "Yeah. That's obvious."

Adora felt a flicker of warmth at that, unearned and faintly absurd. "Is it?"

"Yes," Catra said flatly.

Adora looked at her properly then. Catra sat right at the edge of the bed, half-turned away, like she might bolt if startled. The room around them was all shadow and shapes—the curve of the arches, the cold marble beneath layers of bedding meant to soften it. Everything felt hushed and intimate.

Adora lowered her voice. "Catra. I would never hurt you."

She heard the breath Catra pulled in at that—sharp, disbelieving—and understood immediately what she'd said wrong.

"I know," Adora said, not giving her time to deflect, "that I *have* hurt you."

Catra went very still. Even her breathing seemed measured, controlled.

She didn't look back.

"I hurt you," Adora repeated, because it mattered. "And it wasn't right. You were a kid. You didn't deserve any of it."

"That's enough," Catra said tightly. "Stop it."

"Is it?" Adora asked quietly. "Is it really?"

She thought of Shadow Weaver. Thought of what it meant to lose someone who was supposed to protect you.

The room settled into a hush so complete Adora could hear every breath Catra let out.

Catra wouldn't look at her. She was still angled away, spine tight, shoulders drawn like she was braced for impact. Adora resisted the urge to reach for her again. Instead, she leaned back on her

hands, deliberately loosening her posture, making herself nonthreatening. She didn't fully understand the storm moving through Catra, but instinct told her stillness mattered. Honesty mattered.

So she spoke.

"My first time," Adora said quietly, almost wryly, "was a mess. Lots of fumbling. I was… enthusiastic. Completely clueless." A breath. "I still get carried away sometimes. Near the end of things, I almost forget where I am."

The silence stretched on—long enough that Adora wondered if she'd misjudged it, if she'd pushed the wrong door. She watched the line of Catra's body, the way tension held her in place like a coiled wire.

Then Catra spoke, the words forced, like they'd been pried loose.

"When you kissed me," she said, voice low and strained, "I liked it." A pause. "When you… when you used your mouth like that—it was new. I didn't know I could feel that way." Her breath stuttered. "I liked it when you—"

Adora pushed herself upright.

Not fast. Not abrupt. But decisively.

The movement alone changed the air between them.

She had kissed Catra before—under rules, under masks, under a version of herself that wasn't allowed to be fully *herself*. This was different. They both felt it immediately. The space between them was charged, tight with anticipation, like the kiss already existed and they were just deciding whether to let it happen.

The distance was nothing.

And everything.

Catra had always reacted to kisses like they were a wholly new experience—too much, too close, too intense. Heat and vulnerability tangled together until she didn't know where to put either. Adora could feel it now, the tension spiking as she drew closer. Catra's body was rigid, even as she'd been the one to ask.

Kiss me.

Adora lifted her hand and slid her fingers into the short, soft hair at the back of Catra's neck, cupping her there. The contact was insanely intimate in a way that made her chest ache. They'd never been this close with the truth between them—no false identities to hide behind.

Catra's breath hitched. Adora felt the moment crest, the fragile point where everything could tip.

"I'm not your slave." Adora said softly. "You owe me nothing." Her fingers curled more firmly, grounding them both. "I'm just… me."

Don't think, she'd said earlier—because saying *choose me as I am* felt too vulnerable, too bare.

She couldn't hide behind that now.

"It's me," Adora said, voice steady, intent. "I'm here. With you." She leaned closer, their foreheads almost touching. "Say my name."

There was a heartbeat of hesitation.

Then, barely louder than a breath, "Adora."

The sound of it went through her like a shock. She felt Catra give, just a little, as if something inside her had split open. No titles. No myths. Just her name, offered freely.

Adora closed the distance.

The kiss was immediate and unrestrained, Catra shuddering into it like she'd been holding herself back by sheer force of will. It wasn't careful. It wasn't practiced. It was all want and release, mouths open, breath mingling, the world narrowing to heat and closeness and the undeniable truth of *this*.

Adora didn't hold back. Whatever this was—she wanted it. Wanted Catra knowing exactly who she was kissing. Wanted Catra choosing *her*, even if it was selfish.

She guided Catra back onto the bed, following without breaking the kiss, their bodies tangling awkwardly, fully clothed and painfully close. Catra's hands fisted in her hair, desperately. Adora's hands slid over Catra's sides, nowhere near enough, every touch interrupted by fabric.

The kiss deepened as it was all they could do to release this need.

The world narrowed until there was nothing but mouths and breath and the relentless pull of closeness. Thought dissolved into sensation—the press of lips, the heat of Catra's body, the way every kiss seemed to carry Adora deeper than the last. It felt consuming, like something essential was being crossed again and again, each barrier giving way in a shudder rather than a break. Catra trembled—not once, but in waves—as if unfamiliar doors were opening inside her, one after another.

Mage-slayer.

The name flickered through Adora's mind, distant and unreal, as Catra shifted. There was a smooth slide of movement, a decisive change in balance, and suddenly Catra was above her, straddling her thighs, looking down.

Catra's breath came quick and shallow. Her pupils were blown wide in the low light, dark eyes drinking Adora in. For a heartbeat they simply stared at each other—Catra poised, a knee braced on either side of Adora's legs, the moment balanced on a knife's edge. It felt like an unspoken question: *stay, or stop.*

Catra chose.

She reached for the golden pins at Adora's shoulders and yanked them free in one sharp motion. They clattered across the stone floor, skidding out of sight. The release was immediate; Adora's Etherian dress loosened and slipped, fabric sliding away until her skin was bare to Catra's gaze.

"I—" Adora started, pushing herself up on one arm by instinct alone—and then she froze.

The look in Catra's eyes stopped her cold.

Adora became acutely aware of everything all at once: the cool air on her skin, the way she lay half-reclined and exposed while Catra remained fully dressed, boots still polished, jacket still buttoned high at the throat. A flash of ridiculous vulnerability struck her—an image of Catra simply standing up and walking away, leaving Adora alone like this.

Catra didn't move away.

Instead, she lifted her hands to her own collar. Her eyes never left Adora's as her fingers found the first button and worked it free.

Heat rolled through Adora at the sight. The reality of them crashed together—this woman above her, enemy and ally and something far more dangerous, the one who had tried to kill her and the one that she loved. Adora's breath hitched as she undid another button. Then another.

The jacket parted, revealing the pale fabric of her shirt beneath. Catra shrugged the jacket off at last, letting it fall away like discarded armor. Without it, she looked younger somehow—barely guarded. Adora's gaze snagged on the faint glimpse of a healing scar at Catra's shoulder.

Catra's chest rose and fell rapidly. Adora could see the pulse jumping at her throat.

Then Catra reached back and pulled the shirt over her head, tossing it aside. More of her laid bare—the scar low on her abdomen, the taut lines of her body held rigid with anticipation.

She wanted to touch. Wanted to map every inch with her hands, to reassure and claim in the same breath. But she stayed still, pinned by the intensity of the moment, by Catra's gaze holding her there.

For a long second, they only looked at each other.

It wasn't just their bodies that were exposed.

Catra whispered it like an oath. "I know who you are. I've always known. Adora."

The sound of her name—said like that—almost knocked the breath from Adora's lungs. She sat up without meaning to, hands rising on instinct, catching Catra at the waist. The contact sent a tremor through her; Catra was warm, real, impossibly close. Adora's whole body felt unsteady, like she'd stepped onto ground that might give way beneath her.

Catra shifted, settling more firmly into her lap, her weight sure. Her thighs bracketed Adora's, her balance intimate and unguarded. She lifted a hand and rested it against Adora's chest, fingers splayed over the scar there—the place where magic had struck and never fully let go. The touch made Adora ache, sharp and deep. In the low light, old ghosts crowded close: Shadow Weaver's echo, the cost of survival etched into both of them. The scar at Adora's shoulder burned with memory.

When Catra kissed her, it felt like reopening something that had never healed cleanly. There was need in it, fierce and unfiltered, as though Catra were bracing herself against pain even as she reached for relief. Her hands clutched; her breath came uneven. She kissed like she couldn't afford hesitation anymore.

Adora groaned softly, fingers tightening at Catra's waist, wanting her with a deep hunger that startled her. She kissed back knowing

there was hurt tangled up in this, knowing they were both pushing at something raw. The urgency wasn't just desire—it was fear, and hope, and the knowledge that time was never on their side.

She had imagined slowness. Care. But they were past that edge now, tumbling forward together. Catra's breath stuttered against her mouth; suddenly her boots were gone, her clothes loosened, shed in haste. Every movement felt like a rush.

Catra twisted in her arms, restless, offering closeness with a boldness that made Adora's vision blur. "I want you inside me," Catra said, voice desperate. "I don't care if it's your whole arm—I just need to feel you."

Adora pressed closer without thinking, one hand splayed along Catra's back. The words alone were enough to steal her breath. She wanted to answer with her whole body, to close every inch between them.

"We don't have—" Adora started, the last shred of caution flaring.

"I don't care," Catra cut in, immediate and unflinching.

They moved together on instinct, a rush of heat and momentum that was more about want than intention. It didn't need to go further to be overwhelming. Adora buried her face against Catra's neck, breath shaking, hands sliding along her sides as if to memorize the shape of her.

Desire surged, bright and almost painful, threatening to pull her apart. She wanted closeness that felt undeniable, a connection that said *it's me* without words. She wanted Catra to feel chosen—by her, as herself.

Adora's hands traced Catra's thighs, opening space rather than claiming it. She drew a breath to steady herself.

And then—light.

A glow stirred beneath her skin, familiar and restrained, answering a need she'd held back. She had learned that the sword was only a channel; the power had always been hers. For months she had kept it leashed, keeping herself hidden from Catra when she thought it was necessary.

But now—

The glow waited, patient and bright, as Adora held Catra close and chose, carefully, to stay right there with her.

Catra turned back just in time to see the change take hold.

Light gathered around Adora—answering something that had already been there. She felt taller, alive in her own skin as She-Ra's form settled over her. The form stripped bare and open for Catra to see.

She let Catra see her.

Catra's eyes tracked the transformation with a sharp intake of breath. Wonder, hunger, something like recognition flickered across her face. Her gaze dipped—to the new part of her already hard and aroused—then snapped back up again, realization dawning too late to be hidden—pieces clicking together, things she'd been told finally making sense.

Then Catra turned away.

Not in rejection. In surrender to it.

She braced herself forward on the bed and waited.

Adora moved on instinct, awkward and urgent and ungraceful with need. She leaned over Catra, close enough to feel the heat of her back again, guiding herself by touch alone as she pressed inside. Catra made a sound she'd never heard before—raw and unguarded—as her head dropped forward and her breath spilled out in a broken line.

The room dissolved into sensation.

The press of their bodies, the brush of each motion, the way Catra's shoulders tightened beneath her hands. Adora felt every tremor, every sharp inhale, every place Catra yielded without retreating.

Then she rested her forehead against the curve of Catra's neck and just *felt* it.

This closeness. This truth.

She had never felt more like herself than she did in that moment—because Catra had let her inside, knowing exactly who she was. Knowing the history. Choosing her anyway.

Catra breathed her name like a confession.

Adora's arms tightened reflexively around her, the sound hitting her deeper than any wound ever had. She wanted Catra fully with her—wanted every movement, every response burned into memory so that no matter what came after, she would never forget this: that Catra had trusted her like this.

Adora's hands trailed down Catra's abdomen, spreading her legs further as she found her most sensitive spot and focused on it.

They moved together, finding a rhythm that belonged only to them. It was messy. It was desperate. It was *right*.

Adora barely realized she was speaking until the words were already out, unfiltered and shaking. "I want you. I've wanted you for so long—this isn't like anything else I've ever felt for anyone—"

"Adora," Catra said again, breathless, like the name was enough to hold her together.

The world narrowed to that.

When Adora finally drew out, turning her before Catra was back against her, when their foreheads met and Catra pulled her close, everything broke open at once—emotion and sensation crashing together, overwhelming and incandescent. Catra clung to her, saying her name like it was an anchor, like it was *everything*.

And Adora let herself be lost in it—completely, fiercely—holding Catra as the moment took them both, bright and consuming, into ecstasy.

Chapter End Notes

> Super depressing note, skip if you want to keep the high the chapter is meant to leave you with:
>
> I have this line I plan to put in chapter 37 (or 38) and it's meant be devastating for the readers and I just feel it so heavily in my body right now. I wouldn’t have written any of the fanfiction this year if my family hadn't cut me off this year, I felt lighter without the shame of them looming over my mind. But Jesus fucking Christ does it hurt to relate to characters who never felt parental love.

Chapter 25: Catra

Chapter Notes

Thank you for the Christmas wishes, I hope you had a good Christmas 💗 Or whatever you celebrate.

TW: mentions of past rape and assault.

Thank you to my beta reader, nbc22

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Night deepened around them, the last bruised blue of twilight slipping into full dark while they lay tangled together. Moonlight and stars filtered in through the windows in restless fragments, broken by drifting clouds and the sway of torchlight outside. The illumination came and went, offering fleeting glimpses of skin and shadow—of limbs entwined in disordered sheets, of heat and closeness still echoing in the air.

Catra was still catching her breath. Pleasure lingered through her like a low current, humming under her skin, leaving her loose and warm and faintly stunned. Adora—She-Ra—rested over her, a weight that didn't feel burdensome. In fact, Catra welcomed it. She welcomed everything: the warmth, the closeness, the slight ache that kept reminding her to ask about *that* later. Even the tenderness of old bruises made sense in this moment. Nothing hurt enough to matter.

She was happy.

The realization startled her almost as much as the feeling itself.

She could feel Adora's heart beating against her chest, strong and steady, could feel the brush of her breath along her neck. Catra wanted to trap the moment between her hands, stretch it out

until it swallowed past and future alike. No Prime. No war. No endings. Just this—Adora with her. For once, Catra didn't feel like she was shaped entirely by cruelty and survival. She felt like a woman who was loved.

The thought of the future hovered at the edge of her mind, dangerously tempting. Plans. Hope. A life that might be more than pain.

She cut the thought off before it could finish forming.

Not now. Not tonight.

Slowly, carefully, Catra lifted her hand, half-afraid that moving would shatter the fragile peace. She'd spent too much of her life waiting for moments like this to be ripped away, revealed as tricks or punishments. She brushed her fingers into Adora's hair, testing reality.

Adora didn't vanish.

She-Ra's hair was warm and soft beneath Catra's touch, impossibly so. Catra had lived surrounded by luxury on the flagship, had known silk and velvet and indulgence—but nothing compared to this simple, intimate miracle. She let her fingers linger, savouring the texture, the quiet certainty that Adora was really here.

"I think your hair's softer than mine," Catra murmured before she could stop herself. It was a ridiculous thing to say, unnecessary and obvious, but it slipped out anyway.

Adora laughed, low and genuine, the sound vibrating through Catra's chest like a spark of warmth. She shifted slightly, propping herself up just enough to look down at Catra, her face half-lit by moonlight.

"I think your lips are softer," Adora replied, voice quiet and fond.

Catra arched a brow, a familiar smirk tugging at her mouth. “Bold claim,” she said lightly. “You planning on proving it?”

Adora’s smile spread slow and bright, unguarded. She leaned down again, and this time the kiss was unhurried—soft, lingering, nothing demanded and nothing withheld. Catra melted into it, letting herself enjoy the luxury of not rushing, of believing that this moment didn’t need everything. It could just be *this*.

Adora cupped her cheek, thumb brushing gently across Catra’s lower lip as she pulled back, her gaze lingering there with unmistakable affection.

For once, Catra didn’t flinch under it.

She let herself believe this was real.

“You look like you’re stuck on a decision,” Catra drawled, watching Adora squint at the ceiling like it might offer guidance. “Do you want to fuck me again or not?”

Adora made a long, put-upon sound and let her forehead fall against Catra’s collarbone. “You are actively trying to kill me, aren't you?”

Catra smirked. “Already? I’ve seen you outlast a Crimson Wastes campfire and all its attendees.”

“That was not *everyone*,” Adora muttered, voice muffled.

“Oh?” Catra’s tone turned innocent. “Must’ve been my jealousy clouding the count.”

Adora huffed. “Are you going to threaten me with that ridiculous arousal tonic again?”

“Threaten?” Catra purred. “I thought you had a good time.”

Adora’s laugh broke free, helpless and warm, and Catra rewarded herself by threading her fingers through Adora’s hair again.

“Hm,” Catra mused, half to herself, “one might argue you’ve already explored south of the border plenty for one night, anyway.” Her voice softened, unguarded. Adora answered with a low, pleased hum.

“That—” Adora murmured, “that feels really nice.”

“I’d hope so,” Catra said lightly.

Adora lifted her head at last, eyes bright with mischief. “I meant your hands,” she said. Then, after a beat, “But… yes.”

They fell into a comfortable quiet after that.

Ask about it, Catra thought.

But she pushed it away for now.

Adora had settled back against her, one hand drifting lazily over Catra’s skin—an absentminded, affectionate tracing that spoke more of ease than intent.

After a while, Adora spoke again, quieter. “I meant what I said earlier. I’ve never—this isn’t something I’ve felt before. I just—Catra—I…”

Catra stilled. She realized she didn’t want the words said aloud. Not tonight. This—this warmth, this closeness—was enough. Words had been cheap before. Silence, now, felt precious.

“I need to wash up,” Catra said gently, shifting.

Adora lifted her head, studying her with that earnest, searching look that always made Catra itch. “I can have someone draw a bath.”

“The basin’s fine,” Catra replied. “Besides…”

“Besides?”

“I left Mermista pacing the hall when I came in. I’d bet good money she’s still there. And she definitely has *opinions* about me.”

Adora’s grin came easy and crooked. “Oh,” she said fondly. “She absolutely does.”

Adora was the first to move, pushing herself upright with a slow stretch that caught the moonlight just right. Shadows traced the lines of She-Ra's arms and shoulders, familiar and new all at once. Her hair was a complete disaster—tangled and unmistakably Catra’s doing—and the sight of it sent a quiet ache through Catra’s chest.

Catra followed more carefully. Her body protested the motion in small, intimate ways, a lingering tenderness that made her mouth curve despite herself. She welcomed the reminder. She wanted to feel it later, too—to carry the weight of Adora’s closeness in every step, every breath. She wanted the memory to cling.

Somewhere beyond the bedroom, a door opened. Voices drifted through the suite, low at first, then clearer. Catra didn’t need to see anyone to know—Mermista was still holding watch in the hall, exactly where Catra had left her.

Quietly, Catra slid from the bed and slipped into the bathing chamber, timing it so neither of the women near the sitting room noticed. She spared one last glance back. Adora stood unashamed and unhidden, hair wild, posture loose in a way that left no doubt she hadn’t undressed herself. There was no plausible explanation that didn’t point straight at Catra of the Horde.

Petty satisfaction warmed her. She let it.

The bathing chamber was dim but usable, moonlight slipping in through a high window. The tub sat empty and expectant; the pitcher beside it was full. Catra filled the basin instead, steadying herself on legs that still felt unreliable.

After relieving herself, she washed methodically, muscle memory taking over. She refused to let her thoughts slide into darker

grooves—refused to pick at old instincts. Not tonight. Tonight wasn't for survival or strategy or fear. There would be plenty of time for that later.

Tonight belonged to something else.

She loves you, Mermista's voice echoed, unbidden—and this time, Catra didn't argue. It was absurd. It was impossible. And it was true. Adora didn't just want her in moments stolen between battles; she wanted her woven into a future.

Adora had people. Allies. Friends. Love that didn't hinge on Catra's presence.

And still—she wanted Catra.

The idea of one kingdom—one planet united—sent a slow tremor through her. Adora didn't need victory to be whole. She didn't need Catra to prove anything. She simply wanted her.

If Catra had more time—

She cut the thought short.

She didn't. That was the truth. Everything else was wishful thinking, and wishing had never saved her yet.

Catra dried her hands, squared her shoulders, and breathed.

For tonight, that was enough.

It would be one world again—but not in the way either of them had dreamed it.

Adora would walk the same road her mother had, blade in hand, carving unity out of resistance and blood. The Fright Zone would fall not to treaties, but to force. And when Catra was gone and Adora claimed that land in her name, Catra knew—without a doubt—that Adora would protect it. She would mend what she could. She would rule with care.

That knowledge was… something. Not enough. But not nothing.

The happiness still sitting warm in Catra's chest twisted painfully around the grief beneath it. The two feelings collided so hard it stole her breath. She leaned forward over the basin, gripping its edge, grounding herself until the world steadied. She refused to chase the thought further—to follow it to its inevitable end. She had spent too much of her life circling doom. She wouldn't do it tonight.

Tonight, she would be happy.

That, more than any battle or defiance, would be her victory over Prime.

The door creaked open behind her. Soft magic light spilled across the bathing chamber, washing the stone walls in pink and gold. Catra lifted her head and met Adora's eyes in the mirror above the basin. She straightened slowly.

Adora had been smiling.

The smile vanished.

Catra saw it the moment Adora's gaze dropped—saw the shift like a shadow passing over her face. In the dim chaos of the bedchamber, wrapped up in heat and closeness, Adora hadn't seen it.

The bruises.

The room changed. The easy warmth drained out of the air, replaced by something heavier, sharper. Catra cursed herself silently. She should have covered them.

Adora set the lamp aside and crossed the space between them without a word. Catra watched her approach through the mirror, watched the concern gather and harden. When Adora's hands came to rest on her back, they were carefull. Warm. Steady. Catra closed her eyes despite herself.

“It doesn’t hurt,” she said quickly, reflexively.

Adora didn’t answer.

Her head was bowed as she traced the marks left by their fight—new bruises, dark under Catra’s fur, unmistakable. Then her fingers moved, slower now, and found the older ones.

Catra exhaled heavily, unable to stop it. She let Adora turn her, let her pull the lamp closer. Adora’s touch wasn’t reverent anymore—it was appalled. Searching. As if cataloguing damage she couldn’t unsee.

Catra felt exposed in a way she hadn’t a moment before. They were both bare, but this—this scrutiny—was worse. She tried to turn away.

Adora caught her arm.

“I didn’t want you to know,” Catra said, the words slipping out before she could stop them. She rarely confessed anything without strategy, but this wasn’t strategy—it was pressure finally finding a crack.

Adora glanced up at her face for a brief second, eyes bright with something close to fury or grief, then looked back down at the marks on her skin.

The light hummed softly between them.

And the happiness Catra had fought so hard to hold onto trembled—but did not depart.

After Seaspray, Adora’s hands had been ruthless—fingers driven into Catra’s shoulder until pain cracked her composure clean through. She remembered the insistence of it, the way Adora had refused to let go until Catra broke and yielded. Now those same hands hovered over the healing scar as if it might shatter under the lightest touch. Adora’s grip tightened on Catra’s arm, protective and uncertain all at once.

Something unsteady stirred low in Catra's stomach. Heat flooded her eyes without warning, tears threatening the last dregs of her composure. The feeling came on too fast, too sharp, and suddenly she was back in that cell again—waking to cold metal, rope and helplessness, memory clawing at her from a place she kept buried. Her reflection in the mirror felt wrong, haunted. She shoved the image away before it could take shape.

She knew the question was coming before Adora ever spoke it.

The walls went up automatically. Brick by brick. Ice sealing tight around her chest. Catra lifted her chin, bracing, daring Adora to say it.

Adora drew a breath. Catra saw the effort it took—the way Adora steeled herself, the way she forced her gaze to meet Catra's. Catra didn't look away.

"Did Hordak rape you?" Adora asked quietly.

Catra felt nothing.

She answered with a question of her own, voice cool and distant. "Would it change anything if he did?"

Adora's expression darkened. "Of course it would."

Catra studied her, detached. She didn't want this. Not now. Not tonight. She wanted to keep what little peace she had left. But the words came anyway.

"Why?" she asked lightly. "Because it's harder to look at me? Or because it makes things… complicated?"

"Catra," Adora warned, anger flaring behind her eyes. Even restrained, Adora's fury filled the room. She never seemed larger than when she was trying not to explode.

Catra tilted her head, feigning thoughtfulness. "Or do you hate the idea of me bending over for another cock?"

“That’s not what this is,” Adora said tightly. “It matters because I don’t want you hurt. Because I hate that he had any power over you. Because the idea of it—of you—” She broke off, breath heavy.

Catra’s mouth curved in a brittle smile. “Used?” The word tasted sour. “Wouldn't I deserve it after everything?”

She stopped herself too late, the edge in her voice cutting sharper than she intended. The mockery faltered into a strangled sound when Adora moved.

In an instant, Adora pulled her forward and held her there, firm and unyielding, Catra’s face pressed against her chest. Not crushing. Not gentle. Certain.

“Stop,” Adora said, voice rough with restraint. “I know what you’re doing. I won’t let you tear yourself apart to avoid answering. Not tonight.” She steadied Catra with a hand between her shoulders. “Just—tell me the truth.”

Catra wanted to fight.

The urge rose up—muscle memory screaming for motion, for impact, for anything that would let her avoid the slow excavation Adora was forcing. Fighting was cleaner. Fighting had rules. Pain you chose was easier than pain that arrived uninvited.

But the second Adora’s arms closed around her, the resistance drained out of Catra like air from a punctured lung.

It left her hollow.

What remained wasn’t rage or cleverness or teeth—it was the bone-deep weariness of someone who had been left behind too many times, shaped by hands that had never asked permission. The grief of a girl who had learned early that being wanted was the same thing as being owned.

“Hordak didn’t—” The words stuck. Her throat burned. She forced them through anyway, flat and colourless. “He didn’t do that to me.”

Adora didn’t let go. If anything, she held tighter, like Catra might come apart if she loosened even an inch. Catra stayed limp in her grasp, too tired to push back.

“Please,” Adora said, voice rough and urgent. “Please don’t lie to me. If you’re lying—if he touched you—I need to know. I need the truth. Nothing you say will change how I feel about you. I just—please.”

Catra swallowed.

“He didn’t,” she said again, more firmly this time. “He wanted to. He told me so. He liked making sure I understood what he planned.” Her tone stayed deliberately empty, brittle with control. “I knocked him out before he got the chance.” A beat. “Let go.”

Adora hesitated, then slowly released her, stepping back like she wasn’t sure which version of Catra would turn around. Catra wasn’t sure either.

She had to *decide* to speak again. Had to choose not to reach for cruelty as a shield.

“I’m sorry,” Catra said at last. The words felt foreign, heavy. Her voice stayed cool, guarded. The old instinct whispered at her—to lash out, to sour the moment, to retreat into something familiar and ugly where she knew how to survive.

She didn’t.

“I shouldn’t have—” Catra exhaled sharply. “I don’t know how to do this. The talking part. I don’t have… practice.”

“I know,” Adora said quietly.

She took a step back, giving Catra space without abandoning her. The unspoken ceasefire settled between them. They watched each other in silence, both cautious now, both raw.

“Hordak didn’t rape me,” Catra said again.

“All right,” Adora replied. “Thank you. For telling me.”

She didn’t look relieved. Not really.

For a heartbeat, Catra almost said more. Almost let the truth spill—the other name, the pair of hands she could never fully scrub away, the night it all blurred together and never quite unblurred. The poison that still whispered sometimes in her darkest moments, telling her it had all been her fault.

The moment passed.

She couldn't bring herself to tell Adora that no, Hordak didn’t rape her, but Horde Prime had.

So many times.

Catra turned back to the basin, reaching for a clean cloth, giving herself something solid to hold onto.

“I was scared,” Adora said behind her. “I thought maybe that’s why you—”

“No,” Catra cut in softly.

Adora looked startled when Catra turned back toward her, cloth damp in her hand. Catra knew her posture was wrong—too rigid, too carefully composed—but she didn’t soften it. She didn’t trust herself to. Adora hesitated only a heartbeat before lifting her arms, compliant without being asked, letting Catra step in close.

The attention was immediate and intense. Catra felt it like heat on her skin as she wiped Adora down, her touch practical rather than

tender. This, at least, she understood. Care as a task. Care as restitution.

"That's cold," Adora murmured, not accusing. Almost fond.

"Yes," Catra replied, equally fond.

The silence that followed was brittle but not hostile. Catra finished quickly, dropped the cloth back into the basin, and straightened. Adora's gaze never left her—tracked the fading marks on her skin, the old bruises that hadn't had time to disappear. When Catra moved toward the door, Adora followed without comment.

The suite beyond had been transformed. Lamps glowed in soft, layered colors. Fresh linens smoothed the bed. Oils and towels sat waiting in hopeful abundance. A tray of fruit, cheese, wine, and water rested neatly in the sitting room, untouched. Someone had been efficient. Someone had assumed the night would go on.

Catra's mouth twisted.

She could already hear the whispers, the way they'd ripple through the fort by morning. Gossip never slept. She knew the shape of it intimately—had known it for years.

The words were old friends. She didn't need to hear them spoken aloud. The rumours were abound without this truth in it.

The warmth she'd fought so hard to preserve drained away despite her best efforts. Catra retrieved her shirt and pulled it on quickly, craving the barrier of fabric. Adora hovered nearby, uncertain. The room felt expectant, like something unresolved pressed in on them from all sides.

Catra sat down at the edge of the bed. The symmetry wasn't lost on her—this was where Adora had been when Catra first walked in. She forced herself to look up.

"I didn't think you'd still want me," she said.

If you knew what Prime did.

The effect was immediate. Adora froze, breath leaving her all at once like she'd taken a blow she hadn't braced for. She moved without thinking, crossing the space and dropping to her knees in front of Catra, the impact sharp against the floor.

"You can't mean that," Adora said, voice tight with disbelief.

Catra started to reach for her—and stopped.

Her hand hovered in the space between them, fingers shaking despite her effort to keep them steady. For a split second, instinct screamed at her to pull back, to wait for permission, to brace for rejection. She forced herself forward anyway. She reminded herself—sternly—that Adora was not someone she needed to negotiate touch with. Not like that. Not with her.

She brushed Adora's hair back from her face. The motion surprised her with how grounding it felt, how it settled something frantic in her chest.

Familiar.

Safe.

Adora looked up at her, unguarded. Open in a way that hurt to witness. There was no calculation in her gaze, no revulsion, no judgment—only focus. As if Catra was the only thing in the world that mattered.

The contrast made Catra feel wrong in her own skin. Used. Smudged. Like she should excuse herself and scrub until the feeling went away. But Adora didn't see her like that. Adora looked at her like she was *everything*.

"I knew," Catra said slowly, choosing her words with care, "that you *wanted* me." Her throat tightened. "You were never subtle about it." That part was easy. That part was safe truth. "I

thought… if you got it out of your system—if you satisfied your curiosity—"

"It was never that," Adora said immediately, fiercely. "Not even close." Her voice shook with conviction. "I've never felt this way about anyone."

The words echoed, crowding Catra's chest, making it hard to breathe.

"I often thought you were repulsed by me," Catra admitted, forcing the words through clenched teeth. "Everywhere except… *that*." She kept smoothing Adora's hair back, like if she stopped she'd lose her nerve. "I told myself you were playing some kind of game. That I'd crossed lines I couldn't come back from." Her voice faltered. The distance she'd been holding cracked suddenly, painfully. "I told myself a lot of things."

Her composure was slipping. She could feel it—the ice giving way, the ache rushing in now that she'd acknowledged it.

"Excuses don't fix it," she finished quietly. "I know."

Adora's expression softened further, something in her easing, as if a knot had finally loosened. The anger and fear that had shadowed her face earlier retreated, replaced by something gentler.

"You had to face who I am," Adora said carefully. "And who you are. I think."

"I had to face… more than that," Catra replied.

For the first time since the conversation had turned, Adora looked reassured. As if understanding mattered more to her than absolution.

"I'm sorry," Catra said, and this time there was no defense left in it.

“I don’t want that,” Adora said at once.

“I wasted time we don’t have,” Catra whispered. Her voice broke despite her efforts.

Adora shook her head. “We have time,” she said with quiet certainty. “We do.”

Catra inhaled sharply. She didn’t correct her. She couldn’t. The truth pressed too close, too sharp. She wasn’t strong enough to say it—not now, not like this.

Instead, her composure finaly, fully, gave out.

She sank forward, the last of her resistance dissolving, and Adora caught her without hesitation, arms engulfing her battered, bruised body.

Chapter End Notes

> I actually had a pretty good Christmas. As it turns out, if you are not burdened by travelling to see your toxic family, you can get high and peg your fiance for Christmas instead. There are no rules. And those things really do brighten your mood. I don't know how I'm going to explain that to my therapist on Monday 😅 Oh well.

Chapter 26: Catra

Chapter Notes

Thank you to my beta reader, nbc22.

Here's some mildly anxious, cutesy smut with a bit of humour sprikled through. I had a lot of fun writing this.

OH YEAH. One of you guessed a plot twist I have planned. Rude 🧐

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora had been kneeling, but when Catra leaned into her, she shifted without hesitation, settling back just enough to make room. Catra ended up half-folded into her, knees braced on either side of Adora's hips, her face pressed into the warm rise of her chest. The position felt absurdly vulnerable—too close, too needy—and a part of her braced for mockery.

It never came.

Adora's lips brushed the crown of her head instead. She held Catra there like she meant to keep her, hands moving with quiet certainty along her back. Not searching. Not taking. Just *there*. The touch was steady and grounding, sliding over the thin fabric of Catra's shirt and spreading reassurance everywhere it went.

Adora spoke softly into her hair. "I've been thinking a lot," she murmured. "About you. About what you're capable of. About the kind of leader you already are."

Catra's throat tightened. She pulled back just enough to breathe, to keep herself together. "Don't," she said under her breath.

Adora didn’t stop holding her. “You don’t see it,” she continued gently. “You don’t see how strong you are. How people follow you because they *believe* in you.”

Catra shook her head, a sharp, brittle sound escaping her. “You make it sound so easy.” Her voice wavered despite her effort to steady it. “Like I’m not one bad choice away from wrecking everything.”

“I followed you,” Adora said quietly. “Not because I had to. I did, but that's not my point. I followed you because I wanted to.”

Catra swallowed hard. “You’d follow anyone who showed you a little kindness.”

“That’s not true.”

“It is,” Catra insisted, her voice cracking despite herself. “You’d follow any stray animal if it looked at you the right way.”

Adora’s hands paused, then resumed their gentle path. “And what about the soldiers who follow *you*?” she asked softly. “They weren’t fooled. They chose you.”

Catra squeezed her eyes shut. The words hurt in the way truth often did. “I don’t need you to do this,” she said, the plea slipping out before she could stop it. “I don’t need loyalty. I don’t need saving.”

What she didn’t say—what pressed dangerously close to the surface—was *don’t make me hope.*

Adora kissed her hair again, slower this time. “I would’ve stayed,” she admitted. “If you’d asked me to, back at Talon Mountain. I would have stayed.”

The confession hit Catra like a blow. For a moment she couldn’t breathe. She let out a short, brittle laugh that didn’t reach her eyes. “That would’ve gone over well,” she muttered. “Mermista would’ve loved finding you serving me coffee.”

Adora huffed a quiet laugh against her. “She already hates you. I don’t think it would’ve changed much.”

“She thinks I’m using you,” Catra said. “And she’s not wrong.”

“I don’t feel used,” Adora replied simply. “I feel… whole.”

The word lodged painfully in Catra’s chest.

“I want you, too,” Adora continued, her voice low, steady. “I want a future where we decide things together. Where it’s not you against the world.”

Catra’s breath hitched. She could feel the moment tipping, the dangerous edge where hope became unbearable. She pulled back before she could lose herself entirely.

“You should eat something,” she said abruptly, pushing herself up. Her voice came out too controlled, too tight. “You’ll regret it if you don’t.”

Adora let her go, though reluctance flickered across her face. She even smiled as she offered a hand to help Catra stand.

Catra didn’t take it.

She turned away instead, heart pounding.

Catra barely had time to react before Adora’s hand closed around her forearm.

It wasn’t rough—never that—but it was firm enough to halt her retreat. Catra tensed on instinct, bracing herself, and Adora hesitated just long enough for that tension to register. She didn’t pull with the full strength she could have as She-Ra; she never used that strength against Catra. Instead, there was a brief, uneven tug between them—Catra resisting out of reflex, Adora insisting with gentle stubbornness—until Adora gave in with a small huff and stepped forward instead.

The momentum carried Catra right into her.

Adora caught her easily, arms wrapping around her and lifting her just enough that Catra's feet barely brushed the floor. The sudden closeness startled a laugh out of her before she could stop it, which Adora promptly stole with a quick, unrepentant kiss that left Catra breathless and off-balance.

"Pushy," Catra muttered, though there was no real bite in it.

Adora grinned, bright and unrepentant. "You're the one who said I should eat. I'm just taking your advice, since I'll need the energy."

"No idea what you could possibly need energy for." Catra shot back weakly, still a little dizzy.

They made their way toward the sitting room like that until Adora set her down on the edge of the table instead of the floor. The food tray waited nearby, mostly untouched, the scent of fruit and warm bread lingering in the air.

Adora didn't step away. She stayed close, hands settling at Catra's hips as if that was simply where they belonged.

"I'm already pushing my luck," Catra said lightly, though her voice wavered. "Once a decade, remember."

Adora's grin softened into something warmer. "Oh? That's unfortunate."

Catra arched a brow. "I have a reputation to uphold."

"Mmh," Adora hummed, leaning in just enough to steal the space between them. "You have two very conflicting reputations to my recollection."

"Besides," Catra murmured. "There's a whole new mess to consider now."

She shifted closer, and Catra's breath caught despite herself. Adora's hands were steady and when she leaned in, Catra thought she was about to be kissed again.

Instead, Adora murmured softly near her mouth, "I did offer you a bath."

Catra's breath stuttered. "That sounds suspiciously like an offer to serve me yourself."

"It is," Adora replied without shame.

Catra shut her eyes for half a heartbeat. Something tight and startled flared in her chest—not fear exactly, but memory, sharp and unwanted. The echo of old moments rose unbidden, her body bracing before she could stop it.

Then she opened her eyes again.

Adora was holding a small cluster of grapes, looking at her with quiet curiosity, no pressure in her gaze at all.

"Hey," Adora said softly. "You okay?"

Catra exhaled, grounding herself. "Fine," she lied. "I'm… fine."

Adora offered the grapes without comment. Catra took one with her teeth, letting the simple sweetness anchor her. Adora took one too, watching her with an easy warmth that asked nothing in return.

They ate in silence for a moment. The tension eased. Adora's thumb brushed slow, comforting circles against Catra's thigh.

By the time the grapes were gone, the tightness in Catra's chest had eased. The room felt real again. She let herself lean into Adora just a little, allowing the quiet to hold them both.

Catra felt it before Adora said anything—the subtle tension creeping back into her shoulders, the way her body braced

without permission.

“You’re tensing up again,” Adora said gently, like it wasn’t an accusation, like it was simply an observation. As if Catra tightening under her touch were as ordinary as breathing. “I thought you were joking earlier. But if that was really a no—”

“I was joking,” Catra cut in quickly. Too quickly.

Adora paused, studying her with quiet patience. “Do you want to talk about it?”

“No.”

The word came out sharper than she meant it to. Adora didn’t flinch. She only nodded, thoughtful, and turned her attention back to the tray as if giving Catra space was the most natural thing in the world.

“I like this,” Adora said instead, lightly. “Being like this with you. We don’t have to do anything more.”

Catra scoffed softly. “We’re going to.”

Adora glanced at her, amused. “Eventually, maybe. I’m not in a rush.”

She reached for a piece of fruit, examining it as if it required deep consideration. “I like taking care of you,” she added. “I like feeling… useful.”

“You were clearly jealous of Isobel,” Catra said flatly.

Adora didn’t deny it. “I was.”

Catra huffed. “She’s better trained than you.”

Adora’s brow furrowed. “You didn’t—”

“No,” Catra cut in. “Of course not.”

Adora studied her face, something vulnerable flickering there. “Say it again,” she murmured. “That you missed me.”

Catra hesitated. There it was—that quiet need beneath Adora’s confidence. The part she never armoured. Catra reached for a piece of cheese instead, buying herself a second to relax again.

She broke off a bite and ate it herself, watching Adora’s expression flicker in mock offense.

“I missed you,” Catra said at last. The words felt heavier than they should have.

She tore off another piece and this time held it out. Adora leaned forward without hesitation, accepting it from her fingers. Their eyes held as she chewed.

They finished the small offering together, unhurried. Adora didn’t look away once.

“I want to spoil you,” she said quietly.

Catra snorted. “I’m already intolerable.”

“That's because no one has spoilt you in the right ways,” Adora replied.

Catra rolled her eyes, but there was warmth there too. She looked at Adora—really looked—and felt it again, that swell of impossible feeling. This woman. This enemy. This person who had shattered her world and somehow helped her rebuild it.

“And what exactly are the *right* ways?” Catra asked.

Adora leaned closer, hands settling at her hips. Her voice dropped, warm and intent. “I want to make you come. Again and again and again.”

Catra nearly choked on her own breath. “Excuse me?” she shot back. “Some of us don’t have the stamina of a mythic war

goddess.”

Adora’s mouth brushed warm and teasing along her jaw, close enough to make Catra shiver without quite touching. “You mean you *can’t* keep up with me?” she murmured.

“That’s not what I said.” Catra’s voice came out breathless despite herself. “I said some of us are operating on reasonable limits.”

Adora hummed thoughtfully, clearly enjoying this far too much. “You mean the same limits you claimed to have already exceeded?”

Catra shot her a look. “As I said.”

“And yet,” Adora said lightly, “you don’t seem particularly eager to stop. I could use my mouth the way you like.”

Catra opened her mouth to argue and lost the thread when Adora’s fingers moved up her shirt and settled at her waist. Heat and unease tangled together inside her, equal parts anticipation and vulnerability.

“I don’t know why you’d want to do that,” Catra muttered. “Seems like unnecessary effort.”

“You said you liked it,” Adora replied, soft but certain.

Catra stiffened. “I said I liked *receiving*. I still won't be reciprocating.”

Adora smiled against her skin, the warmth of it sending a shiver down Catra’s spine. “Can I ask what your hang-up is?”

Catra swallowed. “I just… I don't like it. It's especially dangerous now that you could spontaneously pack nine inches.”

Adora paused, truly paused this time, looking down at herself. “Nine?”

It's definitely at least nine when it's hard.

Catra hesitated, then asked softly, “Is it… different?”

Adora tilted her head. “With you? Yes.”

“Being like this,” Catra tried to find the way to ask but was somehow shy. “having a...”

Adora smiled—gentler now. “Come on, I've heard filthier talk from you. Ask me.”

Catra studied her face, searching for any hint of mockery or expectation. Finding none, she exhaled slowly. “Does it feel different having a cock?”

“Yes,” Adora admitted. “Are you curious?”

She stepped back then, giving Catra space, and reached for the sword resting nearby. Carefully, respectfully, she lifted it and held it out, hilt first.

“She-Ra,” Adora said quietly, “helps me understand myself better. Her form bends to what I need her to be.”

Catra eyed it warily. “You’re telling me this thing is… your magical penis sword? How did I not notice it for all those weeks. It's a wonder you didn't poke Keston’s eye out the other day.”

“I don't always have a—” Adora blurted, annoyed, but caught herself and took a breath. “I only have one if I choose it.”

Catra snorted.

Adora smiled. “Try it.”

Catra took the sword reluctantly, surprised by its weight. “How the fuck does this even work?”

“You hold it up and say “For the honour of Greyskull”,” Adora said. “Focus on what you want from She-Ra and she'll answer.”

Catra raised the blade with little enthusiasm. “For the honor of… Greyskull,” she muttered.

Nothing happened.

She stared at it, unimpressed. “Well. That was deeply embarrassing.”

Adora blinked. Then laughed—soft, genuine, and warm. “I guess it doesn’t work unless you mean it.”

“This is dumb.” Catra scoffed letting the sword fall back down, the weight was ridiculous. “I feel like you're mocking me. What even is Greyskull anyway?”

“I–” Adora stopped. “I don't actually know.”

She laughed and Catra couldn’t help but smile at it.

“But I'm not playing with you, just try it!” Adora encouraged. “With more energy so whatever Greyskull is can actually hear you.”

Catra sighed and lifted the sword up again. She took in a breath, pictured clearly what she wanted of “She-Ra” and yelled, “For the honour of Greyskull!”

Blinding light. Her vision went white with it. Fragmenting until every wavelength of colour split into separate spaces. She squeezed her eyes shut, overwhelmed by it. When she opened her eyes she certainly wasn't eye-level with Adora, but she wasn’t straining to look up from her five foot view. Adora looked at her in awe. Then her eyes dropped downward, Catra followed, craning her neck to look down at herself.

Well, it's definitely not nine inches.

Her clothes, a single shirt and nothing else, were the same—as she had hoped. Adora had been right about that. Did Adora

choose to be so large, or was that predetermined. Catra had so many questions.

“So I'm…” Catra trailed off. “What, a man now?”

“Do you feel like a man?” Catra made a small sound of disgust. “No.”

“Do you think of me as a man, when I am like this?” Adora stepped forward.

Catra looked up at her, looking at Adora in the eyes as she stepped closer. “No.”

“You're not a man.” Adora said softly as she finally pressed her body up against Catra’s again. “I still want to, if you'll let me try it.”

Adora sounded so amused. It felt like she was smiling against Catra’s skin. Catra didn’t understand how her lips at her throat could feel so good.

Adora laughed again, then softened, stepping a little closer—not crowding, just close enough that Catra could feel her warmth. “You know,” she said quietly, “you don’t have to be on guard with me. Not all the time.”

Catra’s breath hitched despite herself. “That’s a dangerous thing to say.”

“Maybe,” Adora replied. “But I mean it.”

Catra shifted, restless. “Why would want to put *that* in your mouth.”

Adora blinked. “Catra—” She stopped herself, then smiled faintly. “I want to taste you. I want to feel it as you come undone.”

Catra rolled her eyes, but her ears burned. “Careful. Keep talking like that and I’ll start believing you.”

Adora reached out slowly, deliberately, as if giving Catra every chance to pull away. When she didn't, Adora brushed her knuckles lightly against Catra's newly acquired cock.

"You like it slow," she said softly. "So let's go slow."

Catra exhaled, tension easing out of her shoulders. "Okay."

"Okay."

Adora had pressed them together, a hand wrapped around both as she began to stroke slowly, softly. It was barely a touch on either of them.

Catra finally huffed a quiet laugh. "Is that it?"

Adora smiled. "I think it's *all* I need to do for now."

Catra laughed despite herself, a soft, breathless sound that slipped out before she could stop it. It startled her—how easily it came, how easily Adora drew it out of her.

"You're enjoying this far too much," she muttered, though there was no real bite behind it. She moved to thrust into Adora's hand, trying to gain friction in any way.

Adora's smile lingered, warm and unguarded. "Maybe."

Catra rolled her eyes, but she didn't pull away. She felt the way Adora's attention followed every shift of her body, every breath. It made her feel exposed in a way that wasn't painful.

"Bitch," Catra said, her voice lower now.

Adora tilted her head, loosening her grip further. "Manners, Princess, go a long way."

Catra opened her mouth to retort, then stopped. She exhaled instead, slow and deliberate. "Please."

"Please?" Adora replied softly. "What do you want, Catra?"

The way she said it made Catra’s chest tighten. She could feel her pulse in her throat, in her wrists, everywhere Adora touched her. Catra's hands moved up, threading through Adora’s overabundance of golden hair.

“I don't understand how you can make something feel good,” Catra murmured. “And simultaneously make me want to punch you in the face.”

“That didn't sound like a request,” Adora said simply. “What do you want?”

Catra let out a breath that might have been a laugh. It came out shaky, uneven.

“You need a haircut,” she said, and she hated that her voice wavered the way it did.

Adora smiled—soft, pleased, a little smug. “Like yours? I kind of love it, actually. It suits you.”

Catra released her hair, watching the curls spring back into place. Adora shook her head lightly, pushing them out of her eyes, and then stilled when Catra reached up and caught her chin. Their gazes locked. Catra shifted her weight, pressing closer, seeking friction without quite admitting she needed it, desperately.

Adora noticed again. Her mouth curved with quiet satisfaction, and she let Catra move like that for a moment—just long enough for anticipation to tighten painfully in her gut. Then, just as Catra found the rhythm she wanted, Adora eased her grip and stilled herself again.

Fucking bitch.

Catra made a sound she didn’t mean to—half a growl, half a frustrated breath. She kept moving anyway, chasing the sensation, fingers sliding down Adora’s arm until she caught hold of her forearm for balance.

Adora's gaze dropped, dark and intent, tracking every motion. Catra felt seen in a way that made her chest tighten. She reached for herself, impatient, but Adora caught her wrist gently and held it still.

"I told you what I wanted," Adora said quietly. "Now tell me what *you* want."

Catra glared at her, breath uneven, bracing her foot against the table as if she could force the world to give her what she needed through sheer will. Adora watched, unhurried, her grip loosening just enough to tempt.

"You're enjoying this," Catra accused.

Adora smiled. "You're blushing."

"Shut up." Catra swallowed. "Make me come."

Adora smiled faintly. "As you wish, princess."

Adora's gaze swept over Catra with open hunger, but there was patience in it too—control. Catra hated how much that undid her. When Adora finally moved again, slow and intentional, the sensation hit all at once. Catra gasped, body betraying her before her pride could catch up.

It happened too fast. Too suddenly. Heat flooded her, overwhelming, and she broke with a startled sound, breath catching as her body betrayed her completely.

She barely had time to register it before it was over.

Adora drew back just enough to look at her, eyes bright, expression openly pleased. Catra stared at her, stunned and breathless, waiting—half-expecting—to be teased, or pushed, or finished off like an afterthought.

Instead, Adora lifted her hand, studied it for a moment, then brought it to her mouth with a slow, deliberate motion. She licked

her finger clean.

“That’s two,” she said quietly.

“Fuck,” Catra exhaled.

Then, Adora began to move lower, settling on her knees.

Catra’s breath hitched sharply. Her legs trembled as she tried to straighten, a sudden jolt of nerves racing through her.

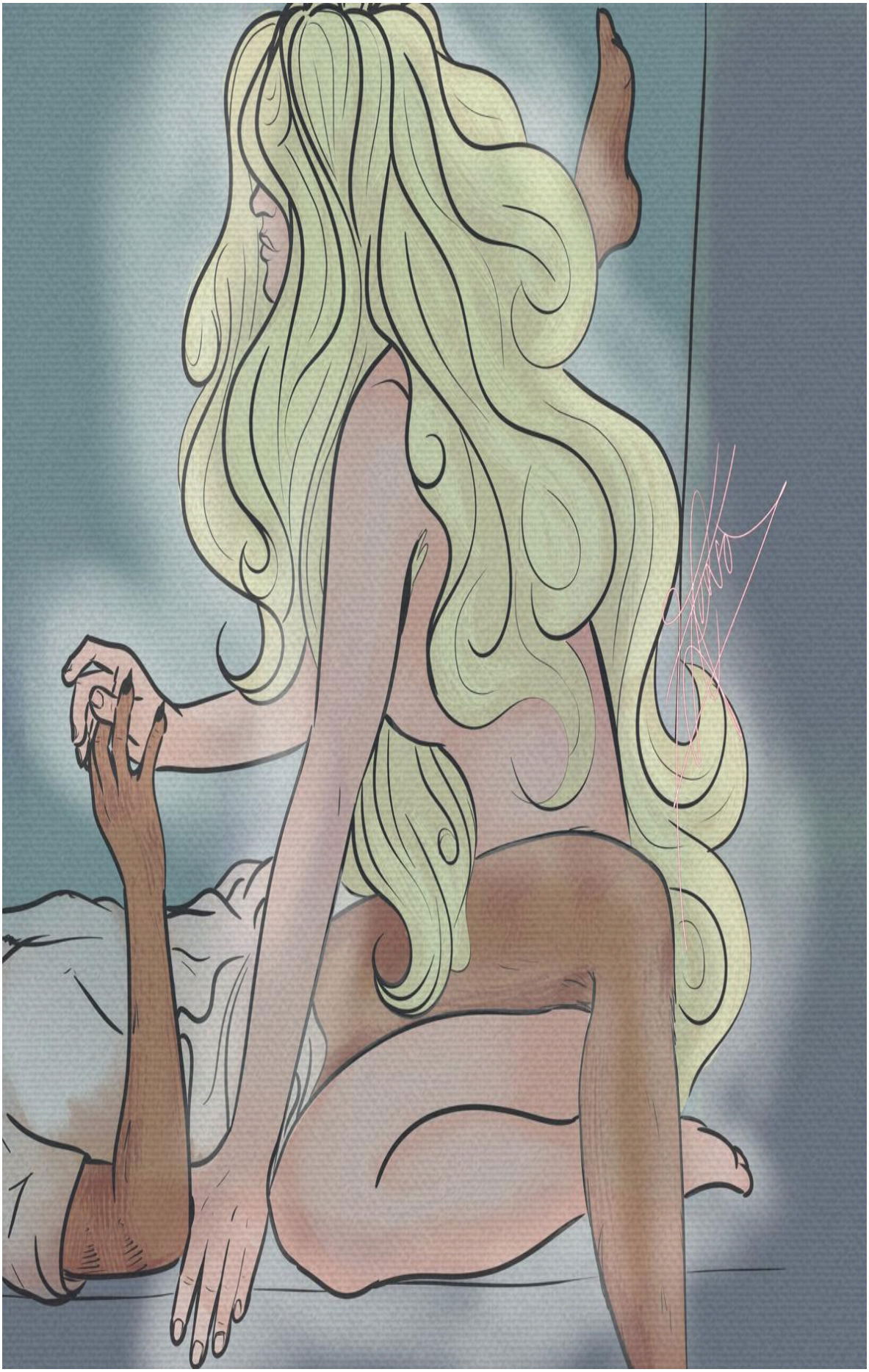
“You can’t possibly still be planning to—”

Her protest cut off as she realized, with a dizzy mix of dread and anticipation, that Adora absolutely was.

“Is that a no?” Adora asked softly, already knowing the answer.

Catra swallowed. Her pulse was loud in her ears. She tried to draw her knees together on instinct, and Adora gently—but firmly—kept them where they were. Not forcing. Just… not letting her hide.

“I—” Catra started, then stopped. The word tangled in her throat. She shook her head instead,



Chapter End Notes

So no head?

Sorry, guess it'll have to go in next chapter.

Bottom Catra, making Catra beg for it a little AND giving her a smaller cock than Adora. All in a days work. I need to add frotting to the tags...

Chapter 27: Adora

Chapter Notes

Tw: Adora being oblivious af

Sorry if there's any stupid mistakes, turns out I make a lot if those when writing at 2am. Me and my beta reader tried to catch all of them but I still found 3 more when giving it another read before posting. I mean like dumb mistakes, like forgetting to put any article words in a sentence that needed 3.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora kept her gaze on Catra's face as she leaned in, only looking away as her tongue began to trace a line of come from Catra's leg.

Catra let out the slightest hum. When Adora looked back up, her chest was rising and falling rapidly and her face was impossibly red. She might have stopped, checking in to make sure she was still okay, if not for the way Catra bit her lip. Adora leaned again for another taste and found her head suddenly pushed back.

"Wha–" she gasped, settling back on her heels.

"You can't really plan on—" Catra's voice went from a near-shriek to imperceptibly quiet. "Eating my come?"

"I *did* say I wanted a taste." Adora said with a smile, punctuating her desire with another lick—nearly brushing the tip of Catra's cock as she moved upwards.

"You got your taste, I think that's plenty." Catra said, delightfully shy. "I'm sure it tastes awful."

“Do you want me to stop?” Adora asked, smoothing her hands along Catra’s thighs reassuringly.

“It's your mouth, I don't care how you choose to torture it.”

“Do you want a taste?”

“I know it tastes foul.” Catra snapped, looking away.

Adora stood up for a moment. She knew Catra had been with someone, but she had assumed it had been Lonnie, or Double Trouble or another guard. She knew Catra's preference was for women.

Gently, she guided Catra to look at her again. She whispered, “It's okay.”

Slowly, she leaned in to kiss her, surprised to find no resistance despite Catra’s seed lingering on her tongue. Catra leaned fully into the kiss—hungry for it—letting Adora’s tongue pass over hers, trading tastes. Adora felt a wave of relief that she hadn’t scared Catra back into her shell, that she could continue to luxuriate in the intimacy they had found together. She couldn’t hold back the smile, ruining the kiss with it.

And then Catra *whimpered*, grinding slightly against her—already hard again.

“Not foul, then?” Adora asked, forehead resting on Catra’s.

“I think She-Ra come might need to be disqualified.” Catra murmured before angling her her head for another kiss. “Or perhaps your mouth makes anything taste good.”

Adora lowered herself down again, slowly, taking time to leave a trail of kisses. When she reached a nipple under Catra’s shirt, she caught it between her teeth, teasing it for a moment before moving to the next—leaving two noticeable wet spots against the white fabric. Every impatient whine and whimper sent a thrill through her, straight down into her apparent *nine inch* cock.

“I thought you were going to suck my cock.” Catra said breathlessly.

Adora let out a pleased giggle as she settledfully into her knees and—very quickly—took the whole thing into her mouth. She knew exactly how sensitive Catra would be and was not surprised at the moan that broke free. Nor was she shocked by the way Catra’s body seemed to convulse as she curled forawrds around Adora’s head.

Catra’s hands found her hair and were not shy about pulling as Catra finally let herself go again. Adora welcomed it, gleefully, as Catra thrust into her mouth. She was excited by how it felt to have Catra take that control—setting the pace, gripping her so forcefully.

Yes. Yes. She wanted to say—but her mouth was preoccupied.

Catra finally eased up, hands moving to brace againt the table again.

Adora pulled back, looking up at Catra—the way she looked as Adora had driven her way past the point of merely aroused or pleased. She wanted to commit this view to memory. She loved it—she loved *her*.

Her own hand had travelled, naturally, to her own cock. She stroked it as she looked up the beautiful woman she couldn’t believe would allow her this. She could spend an eternity here on her knees.

“Please come for me.” Adora said. “Don't hold back.”

“Okay.” Catra’s voice wavered.

She went back in, swallowing Catra down until she felt her start the shudder with a new intensity, more than just the over-sensitivity. Catra’s hands suddenly, roughly, pushed Adora down.

She could taste it, even as it travelled almost immediately down her throat. She moaned at the taste, knowing the vibration of it would drive Catra crazy.

Eventually, after a moment too-long with no oxygen supply, Catra's rigid post-climax tension eased and Adora could pull back again.

"I'm sorry." Catra whispered breathlessly.

"Don't," Adora said breathlessly before wiping her mouth. "Don't fucking apologise."

Catra's eyes widened as her for a moment, seemingly startled by Adora's choice of words.

"If I get to suck your cock again," Adora said, managing to dispel some light-headedness. "*That* is exactly how enthusiastic," a breath, "I want you to be."

✧

Adora woke to warmth and for a moment she lay still, afraid to move in case it vanished. Catra was there beside her, close enough that Adora could feel the rise and fall of her breathing.

Relief washed through her so strongly it almost hurt.

They were themselves again—no magic humming beneath the skin, no towering strength or glowing light. Just two women tangled in rumpled sheets, morning slipping quietly into the room. Pale sunlight brushed across Catra's back, catching in her hair and turning it a burnished gold at the edges.

Adora had half-expected to wake alone. She had braced herself for that hollow, familiar ache. But Catra was still here, breathing slow and deep.

Carefully, Adora lifted a hand and brushed her knuckles along Catra's cheek.

Catra stirred. Her lashes fluttered, and when her eyes opened, there was no sharpness in them—only warmth, a little surprise, and something quietly pleased.

“Adora,” she murmured.

The sound of her name, spoken like that—by Catra in particular—made Adora’s chest ache in the best possible way.

“Catra,” she replied, smiling before she could stop herself.

They lay there, looking at each other. Catra lifted a hand, hesitant, and traced a line down Adora’s arm as though she were making sure she was really there. Her touch was gentle, almost reverent.

“You’re…” Catra hesitated, searching for the word. “You’re… really something.”

Adora laughed softly. “That’s one way to put it.”

“No,” Catra said, her mouth curving faintly. “I mean it.” She seemed almost shy as she added, “You’re… beautiful.”

The way she said it—earnest, slightly awkward—made warmth bloom in Adora’s chest.

“Is that so?” she teased gently.

“Yes,” Catra said, entirely serious.

Adora let herself smile fully then, sinking back into the pillows. “Well,” she said, a little smugly, “you’re not exactly hard to look at yourself.”

Catra snorted, ducking her head. “Most people get that out of the way much faster.”

Adora studied her—the softened lines of her face, the faint smile she didn’t quite manage to hide. “I would’ve told you sooner,” she

said quietly. “If things had been… different. If I’d been allowed to court you properly. If—”

The air shifted at the word *if*. Adora felt it, the ghost of everything they’d lost brushing between them.

Catra didn’t seem to notice. Or maybe she chose not to. “Oh, I can picture it,” she said lightly. “You arriving with ceremony and speeches. My mother pretending not to be impressed.” She huffed a laugh. “She would’ve liked you. Your magic, your stubbornness.”

Adora stilled, careful not to break the moment. “Even if I’d been dating her daughter?”

Catra glanced up at her, surprised, then smiled—soft and unguarded. “Yes. Even then.”

Something warm and fragile settled between them.

The kiss came easily, naturally—unhurried and tender. Adora leaned into it, savoring the quiet closeness, the way Catra fit against her like she always had.

When she pulled back, the weight of the world crept in at the edges again. Responsibility. Tomorrow. Everything waiting beyond the walls of this room.

“I—” Adora started, then stopped.

Adora heard the certainty in Catra’s voice before she truly understood the words.

“I’m not letting him hurt you,” Catra said. Her tone was steady, unflinching. “That’s why I came here last night. I’ll fix this.”

Something in Adora’s chest tightened. She reached for Catra without thinking, fingers curling into the fabric at her side. “Promise me,” she said, the plea slipping out before she could stop it. “Promise me you won’t let him hurt her. Promise me we’ll stop him—together.”

Catra didn’t hesitate. “I promise.”

Adora exhaled, her forehead tipping forward until it brushed Catra’s. The relief hit her all at once, dizzying and too big to contain. She kissed her—soft at first, then deeper, driven by the same need that had carried them through the night before. Catra’s arms rose around her, anchoring her, and for a moment the world shrank to the space between their bodies.

Adora shifted, instinct guiding her closer, the warmth of Catra grounding her as everything else blurred. She felt the press of their bodies against one another, the reassurance of shared breath, the fragile safety of being held by someone who chose her despite everything.

A knock sounded at the door.

Catra turned her head, unbothered. “Come in.”

Adora barely had time to draw back before the door opened. Keston stepped in—and froze.

Adora felt the heat rush to her face. She was acutely aware of herself then, her nakedness, her position above Catra, of the sheet tangled uselessly around her waist. In Bright Moon, intimacy was private—never something witnessed. Never like this.

Catra, on the other hand, looked entirely unfazed.

“Yes?” she asked calmly.

Keston stared for half a second too long before snapping his gaze to the floor. “My apologies, Your Majesty. I came to ask for your orders for the morning.”

“Have the baths prepared,” Catra said evenly. “And see that breakfast is brought up later.”

“Yes, Your Majesty.” He retreated as quickly as dignity allowed.

The door shut.

Adora finally let out the breath she'd been holding. "Catra—"

Catra turned to her, eyes bright with curiosity. "You're blushing."

Adora drew the sheet up instinctively. "In Etheria, we don't… do that. Not in front of people."

Catra blinked. "Even the Queen?"

"*Especially* if you're the Queen!"

Something in Catra's expression shifted. Then she laughed—full-bodied, startled, delighted. "You're telling me," she said between laughs, "that you wrestled him half-naked but can't handle being seen with your lover?"

Lover.

"That was for sport," Adora protested weakly, mind snagged on Catra's choice of words.

Catra leaned in and kissed her, quick and warm, laughter still in her breath. "You're adorable."

Adora lay on her side, facing Catra, the quiet of the room settling around them like a held breath. The world beyond the walls still existed—war, danger, choices that would cost them both—but for this moment, there was only the soft rhythm of Catra's breathing and the warmth they shared between them.

Adora traced the familiar lines of Catra's skin with careful fingers, following a trail to the two scars she knew about now. Both told a story she wished she could have erased, stopped somehow. Her touch lingered over Catra's shoulder, then lower, as though she could soothe the past simply by acknowledging it.

"I'm sorry Hordak is gone," Adora said quietly. "I know you thought he might… help somehow."

Catra huffed a soft, humorless sound. “I thought he knew something. Secrets I could use against Prime.” She shrugged faintly. “Turns out monsters don’t make good allies.”

“We’ll find another way,” Adora said at once.

Catra tilted her head, studying her. “You never asked what actually happened.”

Adora hesitated. “You didn’t want to talk about it.”

“I still don’t,” Catra admitted. “But it wasn’t… dramatic or anything. There was a fight. I got lucky. Double Trouble and I made a deal.”

Adora blinked. “You’re telling me you escaped a cell with Hordak, talked a master manipulator into switching sides, and just walked out alive?”

Catra’s mouth twitched. “You say that like it’s hard.”

Adora laughed before she could stop herself—an honest, startled sound that seemed to surprise them both. “You’re unbelievable.”

“I survive,” Catra said lightly. “As you may have noticed.”

Adora’s laughter softened into something warmer. Her fingers stilled against Catra’s skin. “When your mother died… did you have anyone? Anyone who was there for you?”

Catra went quiet. Then, softly, “In a way.”

Adora swallowed. “I’m glad you weren’t alone.”

For a moment, Catra said nothing. She sat up slowly, pressing the heels of her hands into her eyes, like she was holding something back. Adora shifted with her, attentive, concerned.

“Hey,” she murmured. “What is it?”

“It’s nothing,” Catra said, though her voice wavered.

Adora felt the weight of everything waiting beyond the room—the war, the crown, the choices she had to address. "We should—"

"We will," Catra cut in gently, turning back to her. Her fingers slid into Adora's hair. "Just… not yet. Let's keep this morning for ourselves."

Adora nodded, leaning into the touch. For a little while longer, the world could wait.

✧

Adora lay back against the cushions, the quiet after everything settling over her like a held breath. The room still smelled faintly of sex, but the urgency had faded into something gentler, steadier. Outside the tall windows, light had begun to gather—soft and pale.

They ate together when the servants returned, quiet and unobtrusive, setting down plates of fruit, bread, and soft white cheese. Adora chose the seat nearest the wall, instinctively protective, her dress loose around her shoulders. Catra lounged opposite her, half-curled in her chair, sleeves unfastened, collar open, hair still a little wild. She looked unguarded in a way Adora had rarely seen—and never for long.

Catra spoke while she ate, voice low, thoughtful. She laid out her thinking the way she once might have laid out a battlefield: clean lines, contingency upon contingency, no wasted motion. She talked about routes, allies that would be the most valuable, which soldiers could be trusted and which would still need watching. Adora listened, struck again by how sharp Catra's mind was—how easily she saw the angles others missed.

This was new. Catra didn't usually share her strategies aloud. She guarded them like secrets, like armour. Letting Adora hear them felt like an offering.

When the servants returned to clear the table, Catra tracked them with her eyes, quiet and assessing. When the door closed again, she looked back at Adora.

“You don’t keep slaves anymore,” Catra said, not accusing—measuring.

Adora shook her head. “No.”

“You could,” Catra said mildly. “People expect it.”

“I wouldn’t,” Adora replied. “And you *know* why.”

Catra studied her for a moment. “Perhaps it's been so long you've forgotten how to use them?”

“Don't be a dick.”

“If you were anyone else,” Catra said softly, “I’d have freed you—or found a way to put you in my service as a guard.”

“There are slaves in Bright Moon,” Adora said quietly. “I can’t pretend otherwise.”

“I know.” Catra said.

Adora saw flashes—Catra moving through corridors of her *home*, assessing danger, protecting others with nothing but instinct and grit. She saw the leader she had always been, even when no one had named her as such.

“You’d be a good ruler,” Adora said before she could stop herself. “Not because you want power. Because you understand what it costs.”

Catra blinked, caught off-guard by the sudden change in subject. For a moment, she looked very young.

“I don’t want to be what Prime is,” she said quietly.

Adora nodded. “You're not.”

Silence settled again, heavier now—but not unpleasant. Thoughtful.

Then Catra spoke, carefully. “Prime won’t hurt the child.”

Adora stiffened. “How can you be sure?”

“Because fear works better when hope is still breathing,” Catra said. “He’ll keep her alive. He’ll use her to keep you still, unable to proceed.”

Adora closed her eyes. The truth of it pressed in painfully. “He knows I won’t move if it puts her in danger.”

“Yes.” Catra’s gaze didn’t waver. “Which means we need the move he least expects.”

Adora looked at her then, really looked. Not the enemy Prime had shaped her into. Not the girl who had once lost everything. But the woman beside her now—sharp, resilient, terrifyingly capable.

“We’ll get her back,” Catra said, voice low and certain.

Chapter End Notes

Should I finish this fic before I start posting the other one? Idk.

Chapter 28: Catra

Chapter Notes

Tw: post drugged/sa aftermath. Death/dead bodies.

Thank you to my lovely beta reader

And I'm sorry I really did mean to have a series of happy chapters until 38 and yet I thought of adding the flashbacks because they felt important to explore Catra's past emotions and how they contrast with her feelings now.

Adora's hand slid slowly down Catra's arm, warm and steady, until she caught Catra's fingers between her own. She lifted them carefully, like something fragile, and pressed a kiss to her knuckles —then another to her palm, then her fingertips.

When she looked up again, her eyes were unguarded.

"Thank you," Adora said.

Catra swallowed. "Don't," she murmured. "*Don't* thank me."

Adora exhaled, her shoulders lowering as something heavy settled into place. "I'm going to have to face her," she said quietly.

Catra knew exactly who she meant. *Glimmer*.

Adora nodded once. "I can't avoid her."

"No," Catra agreed. She inhaled slowly, bracing herself. "And when you do… I'll tell you how to make her talk."

A pause settled between them—thick, weighted. Then Catra shifted, rolling slightly onto her side so she wasn't quite facing

Adora anymore.

“There’s something else,” she said carefully. “You lied to me.”

Adora’s breath left her in a long, quiet sigh. “I did. But—you were my captor. I didn’t know who I could trust. And I was scared of what would happen if you knew who I really was.”

Catra turned her head. “And yet you had months to tell me after I made it clear I knew who you were all along.”

Adora winced. “I know, but could you blame me? When do you think we had a moment to share this talk before now?”

Catra studied her face. “So… who else knew?”

Adora hesitated. “Mermista and Glimmer. That’s it.”

Catra exhaled slowly. “Not Bow?”

“No, I don't think Glimmer would have told him.”

Catra hesitated, then asked softly, “And… the others?”

Adora tilted her head, catching the meaning. “You mean if I slept with anyone else?”

Catra stiffened at the teasing edge in her tone. “Don’t,” she warned.

Adora sobered instantly. “Then ask.”

Catra hesitated, then said it anyway. “Mermista?”

A beat. “Once. It was a mistake we don’t talk about.”

“And Bow?”

Adora huffed a short laugh. “No. I let people think that. It kept questions away from Glimmer and I.”

“So,” Catra watched her carefully. “You really don’t prefer men?”

Adora leaned in before Catra could overthink it, pressing a soft kiss to her mouth—unhurried, sure, reassuring. Catra let herself melt into it, the tension slipping from her shoulders as something warm and steady took its place.

The kiss faded, but what it left behind stayed—quiet, steady, impossible to ignore. Catra let herself sit in that stillness and finally look at the shape of what she was feeling. Forgiveness came to her not as a single, clean decision, but as a slow untying of knots she’d carried for so long she’d forgotten they were there.

She forgave Adora for Shadow Weaver—not because the wound had vanished, not because it didn’t still ache when she breathed too deeply, but because she could finally see the truth of it: Adora had never chosen that violence. She had been a child. Catra could see now that Adora had carried that weight too, and had broken herself over it. That mattered.

She forgave her for the lovers who came before her—real and rumour—the names she’d tasted bitterly, the imagined touches that had made her chest burn with jealousy and shame. They didn’t matter the way she’d feared they would. They were not debts she had to measure herself against. They were simply history, and Catra was not competing with ghosts. She forgave her for Bow, too—for the lie, for the secrecy, for the careful half-truths meant to protect everyone and ending up dealing Catra the blow of shock when she learned of Glimmer. She understood now that Adora hadn’t lied out of cruelty or manipulation, but out of terror—of losing people, of being judged and ostracised.

Most of all, Catra forgave her for being Adora. For being the one person Catra should not have fallen in love with, and yet remaining so damned beautiful and honourable and reliable. Her only true friend.

The forgiveness settled into her bones like warmth after a long, harsh winter. It didn’t erase the past; it made space around it.

And in that space, Catra realized she wasn’t bracing for loss anymore. She could let herself go.

✧

7 years ago

The physician’s examination lasted far longer than she had expected. Longer than she could endure without wanting to crawl out of her own skin.

Prime had left her there—calm, composed, almost kind—as though arranging medical care was some final act of generosity. He had told her to rest. He had told her she would feel better soon. Then he was gone, and the quiet that followed pressed in on her like something alive.

She didn’t understand yet. Not really. Her head hurt. Her body felt wrong—heavy, uncooperative, aching in ways that didn't make sense. She thought she was grieving. She assumed this was what grief felt like—hollowing you out, making your limbs stop listening.

The medic was one of Prime’s—another of the copies. His voice was calm and too patient. His hands moved with practiced certainty, asking questions that scraped too close to places she didn’t want touched, even by words. She hated him immediately for it.

The medicines smelled sharp and chemical, stinging her nose. She flinched when he adjusted her posture, when he tested her reflexes, when he spoke in that quiet, professional tone that made it clear he had seen this before.

When she tried to sit up, her body betrayed her. Her legs folded beneath her without warning, and she would have hit the floor if he hadn’t caught her. The humiliation burned hotter than the pain.

“I’m fine,” she snapped, though she was shaking.

He didn’t argue. He only steadied her and helped her back onto the bed as if he’d expected it all along.

Something for the pain. Something to keep her from being sick. He spoke gently, explaining each thing, as though explanation alone could make it acceptable. She refused food when he offered it, and his quiet disappointment somehow made her angrier than if he’d scolded her.

When attendants arrived to help wash and dress her, she barely noticed they were also clones. They might as well have been shadows. Everything blurred together—hands, fabric, the faint scent of antiseptic. She focused on staying upright, on not crying, on not letting anyone see how badly she was shaking.

She snapped at the medic when he asked if she was dizzy. Snapped again when he asked if she could stand. Her voice came out sharp, ugly, nothing like the obedient, well-trained tone she had learned to wear like armor. He didn’t react. He never did.

Later—much later—she would understand that none of this had been accidental. That what she’d taken, what had been given to her, had never been meant to leave her in control. She would understand that kindness, in that moment, had been the only mercy available.

But not then.

Then, she only knew she was hurting, and ashamed, and furious at herself for it.

The noise of the departure reached her through the walls—boots, voices, the low hum of machinery. They were leaving. Without her.

She surprised herself by feeling relief.

By then, the medicine had dulled the worst of the pain. She was dressed in dark clothes meant for mourning, the fabric heavy and unfamiliar. When she caught her reflection, she barely recognized

the girl staring back. Too dull. Too still. Like she might shatter if someone touched her.

“I want to see her,” Catra said suddenly.

The words came out before she’d decided to speak them.

The medic paused, fingers stilling on the latch of his case. He didn’t turn around.

“She won’t look the way you expect,” he said quietly. “Death isn’t kind. It doesn’t preserve what we love.”

“I don’t care,” Catra replied. Her voice was steadier than she felt. “I want to see my mother.”

He hesitated. Long enough that she felt something twist in her chest.

“Child,” he said gently, and she hated that gentleness more than anything else. “I would advise—”

“I didn’t ask for advice.”

Silence stretched between them.

At last, he closed his case with a soft click. “Very well,” he said. “If that is what you want.”

And in that moment—standing too straight, too proud, holding herself together by nothing but will—Catra understood something she didn’t yet have words for:

That some things, once seen, could never be unseen.

Catra didn’t make it far on her own.

Her legs betrayed her halfway across the encampment, folding with a weakness she hadn’t known they carried. The medic caught her automatically, as though he’d been watching for it, his grip firm but careful around her arm. She hated that—hated

needing it—but she didn’t pull away. There was no strength left to waste on pride.

No one else seemed to notice them. Or if they did, they pretended not to. The camp was already shifting into motion: tents being struck, crates hauled, voices raised in clipped efficiency. Prime’s forces were preparing to move on, and Catra was simply… debris left behind after her only benefactor's death. A thing that no longer required attention.

She understood why. Understanding didn’t make it hurt less.

The medic guided her forward, steady and unhurried, as though she weren’t trembling beneath his hand. The world felt tilted, unreal. She focused on placing one foot in front of the other. Each step sent a dull ache up her legs, blooming into something sharper if she moved too fast.

The medical tent loomed ahead, canvas sagging slightly beneath the weight of heat and misery inside.

She’d always hated it here.

Even before—before yesterday—she’d avoided this place. The air clung heavy with sickness, with rot and sweat and old blood. Shadow Weaver used to come here often, offering magic and encouraging words in equal measure, but Catra had never followed. She didn’t like the sounds. The smells. The way pain clung to the space.

Now it swallowed her whole.

Inside, the noise hit first—groans, murmurs, fractured prayers. Bodies lay packed together in whatever space could be made for them, soldiers and attendants alike. The air was thick with copper and antiseptic and something far worse. Catra’s stomach lurched.

None of it felt real.

She barely registered the medic steering her past the worst of it, guiding her toward a curtained section at the back. His voice reached her dimly.

"I'll find you a chair."

Which meant: *I'll give you privacy*.

He drew the curtain aside.

Behind it, the world fell silent.

There was a single table. A single form. A sheet drawn carefully over it. Catra stepped forward on her own this time. Her ears rang. Everything else—the groans, the movement, the weight of the world—slipped away. She was aware only of the table, the shape beneath the cloth, and the awful stillness of it.

She stood there for a long moment, breathing shallowly. Her hands hovered uselessly at her sides.

Then she reached out.

The wood beneath her fingers was cool, smooth. Real. Anchoring. She leaned on it, grounding herself, and only then did she lift the sheet.

The medic had been right.

This wasn't her.

Not really.

The body beneath the cloth was wrong in a thousand small ways. The skin was dull, lifeless, tinged with green. The sharp lines of Shadow Weaver's face had softened into something unfamiliar. The wound in her abdomen was crudely closed, black thread stark against pallid flesh.

Catra stared at it, numb.

She pressed her hand to the stitched wound. The flesh was cold. Not cool—cold. Empty.

A sound tore out of her chest, raw and wordless.

So this was it. This was what remained of the woman who had raised her after the death of her birth parents in the first war. Her vision blurred, but she didn't look away.

"She suffered," Catra whispered to no one. "I know she did."

Her hand trembled where it rested on the corpse. A sick, hollow ache spread through her chest, swallowing everything else.

"She didn't deserve this," she said, and then—because it had to be said—"I don't either."

Her voice cracked, and something inside her split open.

"I'll kill her," Catra said softly, the words of a thirteen year old who had no idea how cruel fate could be. "I'll kill Adora, or I'll die trying."

✧

Months Ago

"Do you need instructions?" Catra asked, her tone dry. "They do bathe you daily. I assumed you'd be observant enough to pick up the gist of it."

Catra's voice held steady because she forced it to. She had learned long ago how to make it sound even, untroubled—how to bend it into something obedient or sharp or cold, depending on what survival required. It didn't matter what she felt. It never had.

Whether the slave trembled or defied her, whether she earned a beating or limped away bloodied, it made no difference to Catra.

None of this was about the woman standing behind her now. None of it was personal. It never was.

She hated being touched. She tolerated servants only when necessity demanded it, and even then she kept her distance, performed her own fastening, her own dressing, leaving only what she could not reach. Anyone who lingered too long learned quickly enough to stop. The last person who had tried to look at her with want had left her shaking for days afterward, waking from dreams that left her breathless and sick with memory.

So she had chosen this.

She had chosen *her*.

Not because she wanted it—but because she deserved it. Because punishment felt honest. Because giving herself to the woman who had killed her mother felt like balance. A reckoning. Something earned.

She had come here prepared for pain. Prepared to endure it in silence. Prepared to count the moments until she could call for the guards and have it end. She had even braced herself for the possibility that she would freeze, or flinch, or beg—small failures she despised but accepted as inevitable.

What she had not prepared for was gentleness.

She could hear her own heartbeat, loud and erratic, filling the space between them. The baths were quiet, thick with steam and the faint scent of oils. Catra held herself perfectly still, spine straight, chin lifted—an offering, a challenge, a shield. She could feel the air shift behind her, sense Adora's presence before she ever touched her.

The first contact was careful. Not possessive. Not cruel.

A hand rested briefly at the nape of her neck, as though testing whether Catra might pull away. When she didn't, warm water followed, poured slowly down her spine. It was hotter than she

liked. Hot enough that she would have flinched if she was capable of allowing herself to do so. Instead, she braced internally and let it wash over her, letting the heat bite and fade.

Then the soap. The faint, clean scent of it curled through the steam. Adora's fingers worked gently, deliberately—no hurry, no claim. The cloth passed over Catra's shoulders, down the line of her back, then back again, slow and methodical. It wasn't indulgent. It wasn't cruel.

It was careful. *So careful*.

And that, somehow, was so much worse.

Catra felt something twist sharply inside her chest. The instinct to recoil, to snap, to run—all of it rose at once, a reflex honed by years of survival. Her eyes burned. She refused to blink. She refused to cry. This was not the place. Not now. Not for her.

She had wanted it to hurt. She had expected humiliation, degradation in this exposure—something she could endure with her teeth clenched. Something familiar.

Instead, the touch was steady. Thoughtful. Almost soothing.

It made her feel safe for the first time in years.

She hated that.

The warmth of the water slid down her spine again, washing away sweat, grime, blood she had long since stopped noticing. Each careful pass stripped something else away—defenses she had learned to wear like armour. She could feel herself unraveling beneath the gentleness, piece by piece, and panic fluttered low in her chest.

Her body wanted to lean into it.

She didn't let it.

Her hands curled tight at her sides, nails biting into her palms. She focused on the metal beneath her feet, the echo of water against panelled tile, anything that kept her present. She would not break. She would not give this to her.

And yet—

When Adora’s touch paused, when her hand lifted away just long enough for the air to cool Catra’s skin, Catra almost turned toward her without thinking.

Almost.

She caught herself just in time.

Behind her, the air shifted. Adora had noticed something—something Catra had long since stopped acknowledging. The movement slowed. That damned chip.

Catra felt it before she saw it: the change in Adora’s care, the quiet hesitation.

Her body went rigid.

"Move back," Catra said sharply.

"What is that?" Adora asked.

"It’s nothing. Move away.”

✧

The Present

Catra smiled, slow and soft, after the last lingering kiss, then slipped free of Adora’s arms and rolled off the bed. The sheets whispered as she moved, warm from their bodies, and she stretched once—lazy, unhurried—before turning back with that familiar, unreadable curve to her mouth.

“The baths, then?” she said, extending her hand like the invitation it was, rather than a request.

Adora took it without hesitation. Together they crossed the room, unhurried, bare feet whispering against the stone. They had already shed their clothes again—somewhere between laughter and lingering touches, between the quiet afterglow and the need to stay close a little longer. They’d taken turns before, shifting shapes, testing boundaries, curiosity and affection braided together. But the last time—when it had just been the two of them, no power, no transformation—had stayed with Catra the most. It had felt the most true.

Steam breathed out from the baths as they approached, warm and inviting, fog curling lazily into the air. Catra felt it brush her skin, felt the familiar promise of heat and quiet waiting beyond the threshold.

Then Adora stopped.

Catra felt it before she saw it—the subtle tension, the way Adora’s grip faltered just slightly. When she turned, she found uncertainty in her eyes, fleeting but unmistakable, like a shadow crossing sunlight. Adora caught herself almost immediately, schooling her expression back into calm, but Catra had already understood.

Of course.

A soft breath left Catra. She lifted their joined hands briefly before letting go.

“Actually,” she said lightly, offering Adora a small smile, “I think I want to bathe alone.”

Adora hesitated, then nodded. Her gaze dropped away, the corners of her mouth tightening with something like apology—or regret.

Catra stepped forward alone, the steam curling around her ankles as she crossed the threshold.

✧

Mermista was still in the hall when they finally emerged. She straightened the instant the door opened, posture snapping sharp as a blade, eyes scanning them both with open suspicion and badly concealed concern.

Catra lifted a brow. “Did you camp out here all night,” she drawled, “or did you sprint back the moment the sun came up? I’m torn on which version I like better.”

“The sun’s been up for a while,” Mermista replied flatly.

“Has it?” Catra gestured vaguely behind her. “Have you been eavesdropping on your Queen?”

Mermista’s jaw tightened. “I wasn’t listening.”

“Pity. You missed an educational experience.” Catra flicked an idle glance at Adora. “She survived our night, as you can see. Mostly intact.”

Adora cleared her throat, very deliberately not meeting Mermista’s eyes. None of last night's previous nonchalance at their dalliance was present in Catra’s lover.

“I’ll alert your troops,” Mermista said dryly, “that their Princess is at her the most insufferable after being thoroughly *distracted* for a night.”

Catra smirked. “Not even the great cock of a warrior goddess could tame my demeanour, I assure you.”

Mermista’s ears burned red. Adora grinned openly and clapped her friend’s shoulder as she passed. “Good morning, Mermista.”

Mermista exhaled sharply through her nose. “You’re not escaping this conversation.”

“Then walk with me,” Adora said easily. “Actually—good. I need you anyway. Have Glimmer’s attendants brought to her rooms.”

They were nearly to the end of the hall when Mermista glanced back, eyes narrowing on Catra. The look was sharp with accusation and reluctant concern all at once. *You talked her into this*, it said.

Catra lifted her fingers in a lazy wave, smiling sweetly.

Whatever Mermista muttered next was too low to carry—but Adora laughed, warm and unguarded, and clapped her friend on the back before turning the corner.

For a moment, Catra stayed where she was.

Adora glanced back once more before disappearing from sight.

Then she was gone.

Catra exhaled slowly.

There was work to be done.

Chapter 29: Catra

Chapter Notes

> Guys, with the chapter count steadily increasing, I'm tempted to split this into 4 parts. Maybe instead of DFD, it'll be DFDF, I don't know. I know exactly where I would separate it.
>
> Thank you to my beta reader.
>
> Slight tw: kyle

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Marzo stared at her like she'd just asked him to juggle knives while standing on a sinking ship. His face did that familiar progression—disbelief first, then irritation, then the tight, weary anger of a man who suspected the universe was mocking him personally. Slowly, he lifted his gaze from the floor to Catra's face.

"Have you finally lost your gods-damned mind?"

Catra's smile didn't flicker. It sharpened. "Careful with your tone, Captain. And for that matter—have *you* lost yours?"

Marzo waved off the correction with a short, irritated huff. "My answer is no."

"I don't recall offering you a choice."

That landed. It always did. His mouth opened, shut again. Whatever protest he'd been about to launch died under the weight of the look she gave him—pleasant, expectant, utterly immovable. At last, with obvious reluctance, his eyes dropped to the carved box resting between them. He froze. Stared. His expression tightened with something like horror before he dragged his gaze back up to her.

He didn't speak.

Catra waited.

“I don’t want it,” he said finally, the words bitten off like they tasted bad.

“He has a name,” Catra replied mildly.

Marzo gestured sharply at the box. “He’s a head. In a box.”

“Yes, and you’ve managed to offend him twice now.” Catra glanced down at it herself, just for a moment. The box was heavier than it looked—not in weight, but in consequence. Letting it go felt like another thread slipping through her fingers, another thing she wouldn’t be there to finish. She didn’t let herself dwell on that. Dwelling was dangerous. “Honestly, Captain, your manners are appalling.”

She lifted her eyes back to him, all composure again. “I can’t exactly take him with me. What do you imagine someone would say if they found a severed head tucked between my merchant's cargo?”

Marzo’s jaw tightened. “I’m still trying to understand why the Princess of the Horde had one to begin with.”

Catra blinked at him, wide-eyed and falsely innocent, as if the question baffled her. The effect only seemed to irritate him further.

“And while we’re on the subject,” he continued, voice low, controlled, and *furious*, “we need to talk about this plan of yours. Because from where I’m standing, it’s completely unhinged.”

Catra tilted her head, studying him as if he’d said something faintly puzzling rather than deeply offensive. “And?” she asked lightly. “You’re not part of this. You stay here. You keep the troops busy, you make sure Kyle is treated properly, and you ensure no one starts asking inconvenient questions about where I am or what I’m doing.” She paused, amused by her own thought. With any luck, the rumor mill would happily report that she and the

Etherian Queen were still barricaded in the royal bedchamber, too occupied with one another to remember there was a war at all. Timing, for once, had been generous to her.

Marzo let out a harsh laugh, the sound edged with disbelief. "Right. Because it's not bad enough that you've let the Etherian Queen scramble your brain—now you expect me to sit here drilling soldiers and babysitting a dead kid's head while you prance across the countryside in lacy dresses, pretending to be some harmless merchant?" He gestured sharply, frustration bleeding into every word. "I genuinely cannot comprehend how you think I'm going to tolerate that."

"Work on it," Catra said pleasantly. Then, with a thoughtful air, she added, "And you're being dramatic. I don't store my judgment where you're suggesting. If I did, there wouldn't be space left for Adora—and I assure you, she only bumped into it once or twice."

Marzo's face darkened to an impressive shade, his jaw clenched so tightly Catra half-expected to hear his teeth grind.

"Well," she went on, clearly enjoying herself now, "I'd offer to let you verify the claim, but I imagine the Queen wouldn't appreciate that. And we're both trying to avoid unnecessary jealousy."

She watched him simmer, unrepentant.

Because beneath the teasing, beneath the bravado, Catra could not tear her internal gaze from the shape of the board. Prime's moves were no longer subtle; the pattern had sharpened into something unmistakable. This was the moment he intended to take her. He always chose his weapons carefully, and this one—this message, this bait—had been selected precisely because he knew she'd recognize the trap.

Adora wouldn't. Adora still believed, stubbornly and beautifully, in fair exchanges and honourable negotiations. She could imagine a meeting where a child was returned in exchange for promises, where Prime kept his word because her word had been given as

well. There would be soldiers, hidden and patient, and Prime himself, coiled and waiting.

The place Adora had chosen was clever—too clever. It ensured that if violence erupted, Prime's forces wouldn't be able to turn on Adora's army without consequence. It meant that if Catra walked into his hands willingly, he would have to let Adora go. Prime adored obedience. He rewarded it, at least at first.

They couldn't bring enough soldiers to fight their way through a betrayal. If it came to that, they would be overwhelmed. Adora would never stop fighting, but Catra could make sure she wouldn't have to.

The thought of returning to Prime's control made her stomach twist, cold and sour. But as long as he held Adora's child, there was no path that led anywhere but him. Adora wouldn't risk her daughter. Catra wouldn't ask her to.

In the end, the exchange was inevitable.

Prime would take her.

And Adora—furious, grieving, but alive—would be forced to let her go.

It took a particular kind of discipline to chart a path that ended in one's own ruin and keep one's hands steady while doing it. It took another, rarer kind, to turn away from that knowledge afterward and decide to live happily anyway. Catra was doing both at once. She had weighed the outcome, accepted it, and then closed the door on it, refusing to let the future poison what little time remained. These days—these stolen, improbable days—would be hers. She would take them whole. She would not squander the way Adora had looked at her, the way she had touched her, the way she had forgiven what Catra had done. Whatever force had twisted the world just enough to allow that to happen deserved her gratitude, and Catra intended to pay it by feeling everything.

She faced Marzo fully when she spoke again, the humor gone from her voice, the sharpness honed into something clean and unyielding. “I’m leaving him with you,” she said. “If this ends the way I expect it might, you’ll see him buried properly. You’ll make sure Adora isn’t left alone with the fallout.” Her gaze held his, unblinking. “You’re abrasive. You’re difficult. But you do the right thing when it counts. That’s enough for me.”

She watched the color drain from his face as the meaning finally settled in.

“What did you do?” Marzo asked quietly.

Catra felt her jaw tighten. She despised that question—despised how easily it threatened to crack her resolve, how it implied there was still room for a choice. “You’ll cope,” she said flatly. “That’s your talent. I’m done walking you through your responsibilities.”

“Your Highness—”

She cut him off with a look before the words could gather momentum. She did not look at the box. She could not afford to. Leaving it behind felt like losing Kyle all over again, even though this time she had ensured there would be dignity where there had been none before. The ache in her chest sharpened, vicious and sudden, an open wound that made sentimentality dangerously tempting. Her mind flickered to Talon Mountain, to Marzo physically barring her path to stop Adora’s entance, unafraid of her rank or her reputation. His defiance had never been rooted in Prime’s whispers about her; it came instead from something far less malleable—a personal code she rarely managed to live up to. After Lonnie’s reckless lies to cover for Entrapta and Adora’s transparent evasions to conceal her identity, that blunt honesty had been almost a relief.

“I don’t like this,” Marzo said, his voice low, strained.

Catra gave a humorless breath. “I don’t recall asking for your approval. Take Kyle. Leave. I have things to finish before I go.”

He lingered, clearly grasping for another argument, another delay—anything that might slow her long enough for the plan to unravel on its own. He didn't know exactly what she intended, but he knew enough to be afraid of it.

Catra turned away, her patience finally gone. "I said get out."

✧

When Baker was shown in, Catra was already dressed for departure, however unusual this particular outfit was. Baker didn't comment on it. She made a precise bow as Ryen slipped past them to exchange the empty coffee pot for a fresh, steaming one.

"I'll handle the pour, Your Highness," Baker said.

Catra gestured toward the chair instead. Baker obeyed, waiting until the servant withdrew and the door closed behind him. The absence of a chaperone went unremarked. Catra's reputation—what remained of it—was scarcely worth guarding, and anyone scandalized by the idea of her meeting alone with another woman the morning after the Etherian Queen had thoroughly fucked her in every possible position had a remarkably poor grasp of reality.

Baker poured the coffee, slid Catra's cup across, and took her own.

"Double Trouble has briefed me on our status," Baker said evenly. "Apparently we are hostages now."

"Then I won't waste breath pretending you're offended," Catra replied, lifting her cup.

"No, Your Highness."

Catra studied her over the rim. "You'll be traveling alongside Glimmer. Understand this clearly—she's sharp, she's manipulative, and she knows exactly how to use both. I'm not questioning your judgment. I'm giving you the courtesy of an honest warning."

Baker held her gaze, unflinching. She didn't ask *what have you done?* She chose a different truth.

"They won't protect you," Baker said. "I know the assurances you've been given. I also know they won't survive inconvenience. Double Trouble will keep you hopeful until hope no longer serves them."

It would have sounded like a plea from anyone else. From Baker, it was simply information—clean, unembellished, and offered without bargaining.

Catra exhaled and set her cup down untouched. "They're a liability," she said. "But an unattended one is worse." She didn't add the rest—that Double Trouble was useless as leverage and dangerous as an ally, that killing them would only hand Prime another story to sharpen against her name.

"If I were permitted," Baker said, "I would stay and serve you."

"You can serve me better where we're going," Catra replied. "I want records. Every word Glimmer speaks. Every move she makes."

Baker inclined her head. "It will be done."

They drank in silence. When Baker finished, she stood.

"With your leave, Your Highness, there are preparations I must complete."

Catra nodded. Baker hesitated only a moment.

"The Etherian Queen," she said, carefully, "seems… decent."

Catra didn't answer. She watched Baker dip into a final, respectful curtsy and exit, the door closing softly behind her.

Chapter End Notes

Chapter 30 is ready but I'm drawing a scene from it to put into the chapter so you'll have to wait for that, sorry

Chapter 30: Adora

Chapter Notes

Thank you to my beta reader ❤️

Enjoy 😌

Adora studied Glimmer for any sign that something had shifted—some fracture in that immaculate poise—but found none. The distance was still there, cool and polished, the same careful stillness behind rose-bright eyes that never quite revealed what they were thinking anymore. Catra carried tension like a drawn blade, always humming with it even when she appeared relaxed. Glimmer, by contrast, wore her danger like silk. Calm first. Steel underneath. Adora wondered, not for the first time, whether that resemblance was what had drawn her to them both.

Glimmer waited in the solar Adora had assigned her, reinstated but caged, the guards positioned just out of reach. She lounged as if the room belonged to her by right, her ladies arranged around her in an effortless semicircle, attentive without being obsequious. Flowers, Adora thought, cultivated and well-tended. The strangest part was how little Glimmer seemed to notice the circumstances. No pacing. No testing of boundaries. She sat as if this were merely an inconvenient audience. Adora had been told childbirth had drained her teleportation; without Bright Moon to replenish her, Glimmer was grounded.

Adora took the chair opposite her. She didn't acknowledge the soldiers who filed in behind her, and neither did Glimmer.

"Is there a child?" Adora asked.

"I've already told you there is," Glimmer replied.

"I wasn't asking you," Adora said evenly.

Her gaze slid to the women. Seven of them. Familiar faces from a life she'd once shared at arm's length—long-serving attendants, handmaids who had grown up alongside Glimmer, women who had seen everything and learned to say nothing. Adora let her eyes rest on each of them in turn, not rushing, not threatening. Waiting. No one spoke. No one moved.

She looked back at Glimmer. "Here's what happens next," Adora said, her voice level and conversational. "You will be executed. Nothing you say alters that. But your household doesn't have to die with you—if they answer my questions."

No one stepped forward.

Adora inclined her head slightly toward the soldiers. "Take them."

Glimmer didn't raise her voice. "If you do this," she said calmly, "the child dies."

"We haven't proven there is a child," Adora replied.

Glimmer smiled then, a small, bright thing—pleased, as if Adora had finally performed a trick worth applauding. "You were never very good at this," she said. "I don't think you have the patience."

"I'm not who I was all those months ago," Adora said.

The soldiers paused, waiting. One of the women shifted despite herself. Adora leaned back, folding her hands loosely.

"Prime will kill the baby," Glimmer said. "I'll tell him it's yours, not Bow's. He'll do it just to hurt you."

Adora studied her, interest sharpening. "He already suspects it, I'm sure," she said. "But you have no way to reach him."

"The wet nurse," Glimmer added lightly. "I sent the child with her. She's under instructions to tell Prime the baby is yours if I'm killed."

Adora’s jaw tightened. “If you’re killed.”

“Yes.”

“But not them,” Adora said, glancing at the women again.

A beat passed.

“You’re the only one protected by your arrangement,” Adora went on. “These women die unless they speak.”

Glimmer’s eyes narrowed—not in fear, but appraisal. “You really have changed,” she said. “Or maybe this is Catra’s hand guiding yours. Should I be negotiating with you—or is she whispering the lines somewhere nearby?”

Adora met her gaze without flinching. “You’re negotiating with me.”

Adora was already lifting her hand, the decision made before the motion finished. She inclined her head toward the nearest soldier, a small gesture that carried the full weight of command.

“Begin with her.”

The room fractured into motion. Hands seized arms; fabric tore; voices rose in sharp, panicked bursts. Chairs scraped. One woman screamed outright as she was hauled from her place, nails clawing uselessly at the stone to stop herself from being dragged away. Another fought in silence, jaw clenched, eyes wild. Adora did not look away. She forced herself to watch every moment of it—the strain in the soldiers’ shoulders, the terror breaking through practiced composure, the understanding finally dawning on Glimmer’s ladies.

Sera tore free with a desperation that surprised even the guards. She hit the floor hard, momentum carrying her forward until she collapsed fully, forehead pressed to the stone, body folded in submission.

“Your Majesty—”

“No,” Glimmer said, sharply.

“—Queen Adora,” Sera amended, voice shaking now, words tumbling over each other. “You are known for mercy. I have a child. I have a daughter. Please—”

“No,” Glimmer said again, more firmly. “Adora will not slaughter a roomful of women loyal to me.”

Sera didn’t lift her head. Her hair had come loose, spilling across the floor like a dark fan. Her voice broke anyway.

“Please,” she said. “Spare me. I’ll tell you everything. Everything.”

“No,” Glimmer said.

Adora leaned forward slightly. “Tell me.”

Sera spoke into the floor, each word dragged from her.

“There *is* a child,” she said. “A girl. She *was* taken to Bright Moon.”

“That’s enough,” Glimmer snapped.

“We don’t know if she’s yours,” Sera continued, faster now, fear cracking her discipline. “My lady says she is. We took her at her word.”

“That’s enough, Sera,” Glimmer said, anger finally breaking through the polish.

“There’s more,” Adora said quietly.

Sera swallowed hard. “My lady didn’t trust Horde Prime,” she said. “Not with her life. Not with the child. If there was no other way—the wet nurse was to bring the girl to you. To offer her in exchange for Glimmer’s freedom.”

Adora leaned back in her chair. She lifted her brows a fraction and looked directly at Glimmer.

Glimmer's fingers were twisted tight in the fabric of her skirts, knuckles white with strain, but when she spoke her voice was measured—carefully controlled, as if calm itself were a weapon.

"You haven't undone anything," she said. "You haven't found a clever angle. My terms still stand. The wet nurse will not leave Bright Moon. If you want the child, you bring me there. You make the exchange yourself."

Adora turned her head slightly, eyes cutting to Sera. After a beat, Sera lifted her head and nodded once, a small confirmation.

Of course, Adora thought. Glimmer was certain of her advantage. She believed Bright Moon was untouchable—held by Prime now. And she believed Adora would never risk walking into it unprotected, never expose herself to that kind of danger.

She was right about one thing: there was nowhere in Bright Moon where Adora could stand safely.

But there were places in Etheria that answered to older powers.

Adora felt the shape of her realisation settle into place. An old structure—something older than Prime, older than Horde and Etherian borders alike. A place bound by magic and science together. A place where queens laid down weapons or paid for their arrogance in blood. Where soldiers stood watch not as enforcers of a ruler's will, but as guardians of peace itself.

A place where even Glimmer could not cheat.

"We don't do this in Bright Moon," Adora said.

Glimmer's eyes sharpened. "Then where?"

Adora didn't raise her voice. She didn't need to.

“We meet where no army can follow,” she said. “Where no blade can be drawn without consequence.”

She leaned forward, gaze locked on Glimmer’s.

“We make the exchange at the Crystal Castle.”

For the first time, something flickered—too fast to be fear, too sharp to be surprise. Calculation, then irritation, then a brittle stillness that told Adora she’d struck true.

After that, events moved quickly. Sera was taken aside to arrange contact with the wet nurse. The remaining women were escorted out, some stiff with relief, others trembling now that the moment had passed. The doors closed.

Only Adora and Glimmer remained.

Glimmer reclined back onto the low couch, regaining herself with visible effort. “Pass along my congratulations to the Princess of the Horde,” she said coolly. “Though you’re a fool to trust her. She’s never been on anyone’s side but her own.”

“She’s never lied about that,” Adora replied.

She stood there, looking at Glimmer alone in the bright room, and memory intruded without permission—sunlight through high windows, laughter echoing off stone, the awkward closeness of two girls who didn’t yet know how fragile things were. Their first kiss. All that carelessness.

It had never been built to last. Maybe it was better this way.

“You chose to trust the word of a man who wants to burn your planet to ash,” Adora said. “You chose to cheat on me—with Bow, of all people—and now look at you. No allies. No friends. Not even your own household stood with you.”

She paused, the words heavy but unspiteful.

“Doesn’t it bother you? That this is how we end?”

Glimmer’s mouth twisted. “It should have been you,” she said. “Prime should have killed you. You’re the reason they killed my mother.”

“Our mother,” Adora corrected, sharply.

Glimmer surged to her feet, control completely shattering at last.

“She was never your mother!” she screamed, the sound tearing through the solar and leaving silence ringing in its wake.

✧

Because Adora could not simply throw Glimmer over her shoulder, stuff her into a sack, and walk her bodily across the border into Prime’s territory, the problem of travel had metastasized into something maddeningly complex.

The solution they had settled on—*cloth merchants*—was ridiculous to the point of insult. Two wagons would be loaded with bolts of fabric just convincing enough to satisfy a casual glance. There would also, unavoidably, be Glimmer. She stepped into the courtyard as the final preparations were being made with a serene, cooperative air that Adora did not trust for a single breath. It was the kind of compliance that promised sabotage at the first viable opportunity, paired with a smile that said *I’ll wait.*

The disguise itself wasn’t the real danger. It might pass within Etherian territory, where traders were common and curiosity rarely rose above boredom. It would not pass a border patrol. It certainly wouldn’t pass a border patrol that had already been quietly warned to expect them. Adora had no illusions about that—Glimmer would have ensured the net was drawn tight well before they ever approached it.

She had spent two useless hours searching through maps with Mermista, tracing routes that dead-ended in watchtowers and sentry roads, and another hour alone, staring at inked lines until

they blurred. When Catra finally wandered in, unhurried and infuriatingly calm, she outlined a plan so audacious that Adora had agreed to it before reaching full understanding, with the distinct sensation that something in her brain had sheared cleanly in half.

They were taking their best. Lonnie, quick and ruthless with a short sword. Juliet, whose trident work had bordered on artistry. Entrapta, indispensable and vibrating with excitement at the prospect of engineering under pressure. Keston, triple-crowned and barely old enough to hide how much he loved this opportunity. Clone 28, whose grin suggested he knew exactly how stupid this was and approved anyway. A handful of their sharpest swordsmen to round it out.

Catra had added the Medic Clone without ceremony. Adora did not ask why. She suspected she already knew and did not care to pull the thought into the light.

And then—inevitably—Double Trouble.

Double Trouble could fight. Double Trouble's guilt, newly raw, made them more reliable than most. And if everything collapsed, if Prime tried to rewrite the story yet again, Double Trouble's testimony could burn away the last lingering lie; that Adora had murdered Queen Angella.

Catra had delivered all of this with her usual attitude, then turned to Double Trouble and said pleasantly, "Baker and Entrapta will be riding with Glimmer."

Double Trouble had blinked once. Then smiled.

"So they're my incentive, then, Kitten?"

"That's right," Catra had replied.

From the second-story window, Adora watched them assemble in the courtyard: two wagons, two noblewomen, and twelve figures who only *mostly* passed for soldiers. Double Trouble and the

Medic Clone wore their disguises with varying degrees of sincerity. The wagons looked ordinary enough. That alone felt suspicious.

Adora herself was dressed as far down as she'd been in ages—traveller's leathers, nothing regal, the platinum cuff hidden beneath a strapped leather band. She felt stripped of title and armour both, which was perhaps the point.

She was waiting for Catra. Waiting to go over the final edges of a plan that felt less like strategy and more like controlled detonation.

Adora reached for the decanter to pour wine into one of the shallow cups, but did not yet do so.

"Did your scouts manage to map the patrol rotations?" Catra asked.

"Yes— they tracked—"

Catra stood in the doorway.

The rest of the sentence never made it out.

Adora's fingers loosened without her permission. The decanter slipped, struck the stone floor, and shattered, the sound sharp and obscene in the quiet room. Wine fanned across the flagstones. Glass skidded outward like startled insects. Adora barely registered any of it.

Catra was wearing white.

Plain Etherian cotton—soft, thin, gorgeous on her. The dress clung lightly at the waist and fell away from her hips, short enough that it showed nearly all of her thighs when she moved. Sleeveless. Open at the throat. Nothing to hide behind. Nothing to soften her lines or blunt the fact of her.

Her arms were bare. Tawny fur against bright white fabric. Her collarbones stood out sharply, elegant and fragile-looking in a way

Adora knew so well. The neckline dipped just enough to draw the eye and keep it there, the hollow at her throat exposed, vulnerable and defiant all at once. The hem shifted when she breathed. The fabric moved when she moved, catching against her legs, outlining muscle and grace.

Adora stared.

"You're wearing Etherian clothing," she managed, because her mind had abandoned her and left her with only the obvious.

Catra glanced down at herself, unimpressed, as if she hadn't just walked into the room like *that*. "Everyone's wearing Etherian clothing."

Adora wished desperately that the decanter hadn't shattered. She wanted something—anything—to put in her hands, to ground herself, to keep from watching Catra walk toward her like this. Barefoot. Unconcerned. Navigating the scattered glass with ease.

"Once we confirm the patrol timing," Catra said, calm and focused, "we'll know when to move."

The dress swayed with every step. The cotton was thin enough that Adora could see the subtle shift of muscle beneath it, the easy confidence of Catra's stride, the way she held herself like she owned every room she entered—even dressed like this. *Especially* dressed like this.

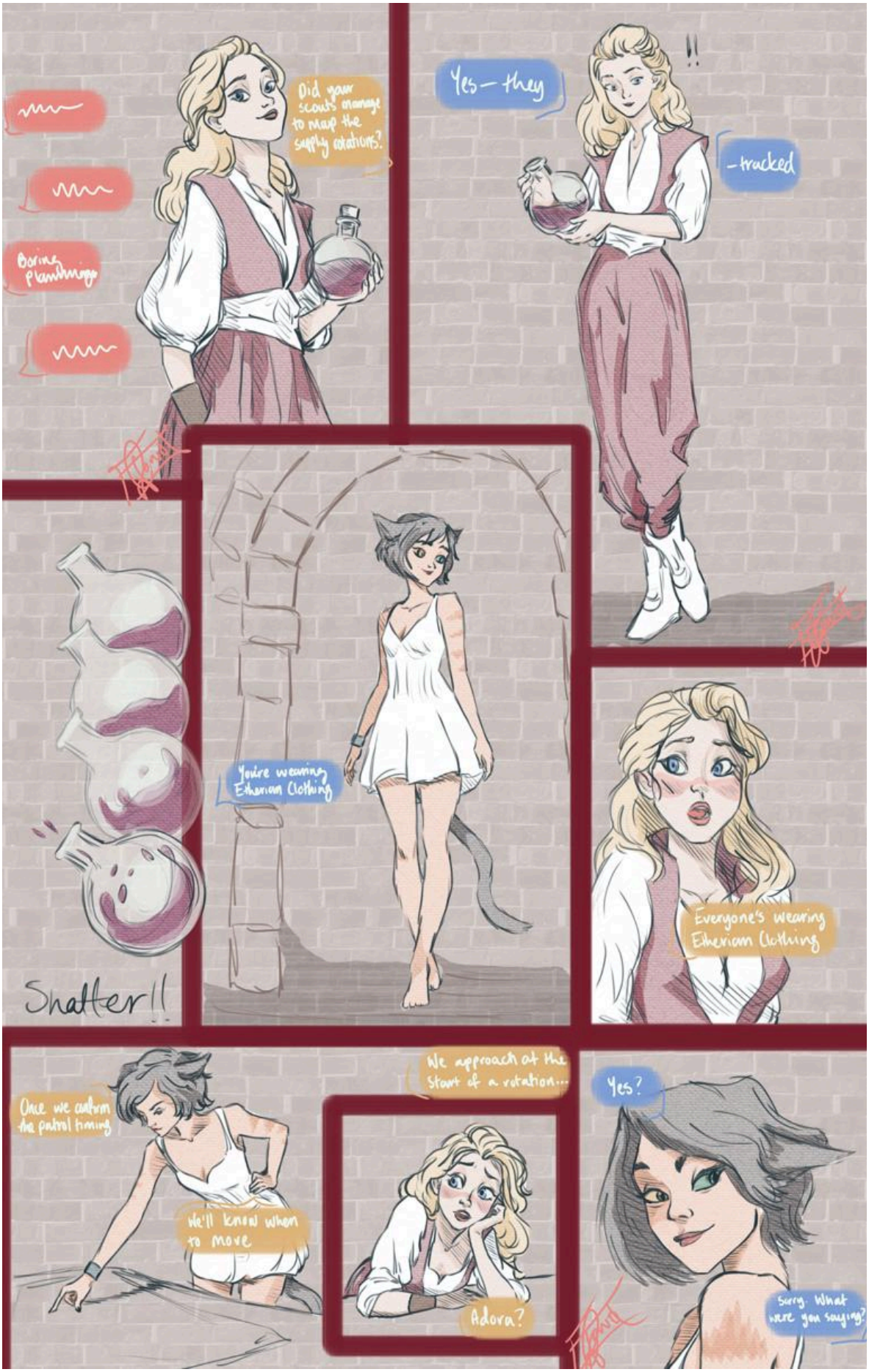
Catra reached the table and sat, folding herself into the chair with infuriating ease. The hem rode higher. The fabric pulled slightly across her thighs. Adora's eyes followed before she could stop them.

"We approach at the start of a rotation," Catra continued, leaning over the table. "That gives us the longest window before anyone checks in with the fort."

Her finger traced a line on the map.

“Adora.”

“Yes,” Adora said far too quickly. “Sorry. What—what were you saying?”


Did your scouts manage to map the supply rotations?
Boring planning
Yes— they
—tracked
Shatter!!
You're wearing Etherian Clothing
Everyone's wearing Etherian Clothing
Once we confirm the patrol timing
We'll know when to move
We approach at the start of a rotation...
Adora?
Yes?
Sorry. What were you saying?

Catra's mouth twitched. "The patrols," she repeated. "Try to stay with me."

The plan did not soften under scrutiny. It became sharper, uglier, more fragile the longer they examined it. Distances measured. Travel times calculated. Margins shaved down to nothing. If they were spotted, if even one sentry looked too closely—twelve soldiers would not be an army. Twelve soldiers would be a massacre.

Twelve-ish, she mentally amended grimly, thinking of the Medic Clone and Double Trouble.

In the courtyard, the reality of it hit her all over again. Two wagons. A handful of people. That was it. Everything they had built—months of alliances, gathered strength—left behind.

Netossa and Frosta would hold the network together, Catra had said. Netossa could manage Frosta. Adora believed her. She believed Catra about most things now, even when the belief came with a knot of dread lodged under her ribs.

An army had never been the answer. She saw that clearly, standing here. Prime was not a war to be won head-on. He was a snare. This—this small, exposed movement through hostile land—this was how it had always been destined to happen.

Mermista met her near the wagons, eyes sharp, posture easy in the way of someone pretending not to be worried. The soldiers didn't need more than the bare bones of their roles, and Adora gave them those quickly.

But Mermista was her friend.

She deserved the truth.

So Adora leaned in, lowered her voice, and told her Catra's plan.

[To watch me draw that little comic and see what I was listening to while I did, check me out on tiktok here:

https://vt.tiktok.com/ZS5fcwqhg/]

Chapter 31: Catra (and Company)

Chapter Notes

> A very special chapter, lots of art, lots of perspectives. A not subtle at all hint at the twist someone already guessed. Keston and Clone 28 have become a little obsession of mine. I will be posting nsfw art of them to patreon and bluesky because honestly gay boys are my comfort zone. I will get back to drawing Catradora very soon. I promise.
>
> Thank you to my beta-reader for their edits 💜
>
> This is very long, a little bitter-sweet, hopefully cute and funny where you need it to be.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

CATRA, TODAY:

Catra watched from the edge of the courtyard with a lazy sort of interest as Adora leaned in to murmur something to Mermista. The intimacy of the gesture was familiar enough—heads bowed, shoulders angled just so—but Catra knew, with a private and vicious delight, that whatever history lay there had curdled into regret.

Once. They'd slept together once, and apparently that had been more than enough. The thought amused her more than it should have. She found herself wondering how spectacularly wrong it had gone to sour things so thoroughly, and the answer she kept circling back to was deeply satisfying.

Catra's own experience was hardly extensive. What she knew of sex had been carved into her by Prime—and then, abruptly and delightfully rewritten by Adora. The contrast was stark enough to feel unreal at times. And yet Adora had come back. Again and again. Whatever Catra lacked in polish or ease, it hadn't driven

Adora away. If anything, it had drawn her closer, returning as if the very act of being with Catra completed something in her.

And Catra had fucked Adora. Not just once. Repeatedly, thoroughly, with a fierce, possessive joy that still made her chest feel too tight when she thought about it. Each memory—skin on skin, Adora's weight, Adora's sounds—felt like something she could hoard against the future. Something bright and irrefutable she could cling to when everything else finally burned around her.

Which meant the problem, obviously, had not been Adora.

Catra's mouth curved, slow and wicked, as the realization settled into place with all the elegance of a solved equation.

Mermista must be absolutely *terrible* in bed.

The conclusion delighted her. It made her grin openly, unrepentantly, teeth shining bright for all to see. For a moment, she even considered that this newfound understanding might make her more charitable toward the other woman. Pity was a kind of generosity, after all.

Her attention drifted back to the present as the courtyard continued to fill with motion. Crates were hauled and secured, tack checked, last-minute instructions barked and acknowledged. Soldiers moved with the restless efficiency of people who knew competence was demanded at all times.

She took in the group with a strategist's eye. Among the Salineans whose names still refused to stick was Keston—the one who had lost to Adora in wrestling, but had won three events. Out of his nautical armour and dressed like any other traveler, he looked younger, almost disarmingly so. The breadth of his shoulders and the strength in his arms were muted by plain cloth, but not erased. His hair, that striking sweep of blue fading to white, like surf breaking across the ocean, was even more noticeable without armor to frame it.

And Catra wasn't the only one who had noticed him.

Clone 28 had been circling Keston since the Games with the unsubtle persistence of a horny pigeon. Now, freed from the strictures of formal assembly, he was bolder still. It happened in a heartbeat—so quick Catra nearly missed it—but as Keston bent to lift a crate, 28 passed close enough to let a hand stray, casual as a brush of fabric, to an unmistakable grope of his ass.

Keston's reaction was not at all opposed to the attention, either.

Catra snorted softly to herself.

She made a mental note then and there to keep them off the same watch rotation. Some risks were simply impractical.

Hard to keep an eye on the horizon when you're bouncing on someone's cock.

Catra had been half-lost in her own idle surveillance of the courtyard when Adora peeled away from her conversation and crossed the space between them with unmistakable purpose. Catra missed the approach entirely. It wasn't until Adora's voice brushed her ear, close enough to feel, that Catra startled.

"What's got you smiling like that?"

There was warmth in it. Affection, unguarded and fond, the kind Adora didn't bother to hide from her anymore.

Before Catra could assemble a reply, Adora had already closed the distance, crowding her back against the sun-warmed stone. Her hands settled at Catra's hips with an ease that still managed to steal Catra's breath, thumbs pressing in as if she were claiming ground. Then Adora kissed her—as if the courtyard belonged to them and them alone.

Catra didn't hesitate. She softened instantly, opening into the kiss, letting Adora take her mouth as her own. Their tongues met and slid together, unhurried but intent, the world narrowing to heat and familiarity and the particular way Adora always kissed her—like she was something precious. Catra's hands rose of their own

accord, fingers threading into that ridiculous spill of golden hair at the nape of Adora's neck.

She tugged, just enough.

The kiss broke on a shared breath.

"You should let me cut it," Catra murmured, lips still close, her voice all sugar and threat. "This is completely unmanageable."

"Don't you dare," Adora muttered, already chasing Catra's mouth again before drifting lower, pressing lazy kisses along her jaw and down the vulnerable line of her throat.

Catra laughed softly, the sound caught between a giggle and a hum. "Careful," she warned, more amused than alarmed. "Your boy Keston might see us tangled up again. He's right there, you know."

She didn't bother to add the obvious—that half the courtyard was very pointedly pretending not to notice their Queens pressed together against the wall. Everyone aware, no one acknowledging it.

"I think," Adora said, punctuating each phrase with another lingering kiss, "if Clone Twenty-Eight walked past him in *that* dress —"

Her fingers dipped, giving a deliberate tug at the hem of Catra's skirt.

"—he'd understand his Queen."

Catra huffed a laugh, her forehead resting briefly against Adora's. "And what happened," she asked lightly, eyes bright with mischief, "to my shy, careful Adora from this morning?"

Adora groaned almost petulantly as she moved to nip at Catra's exposed neck.

“Dress.” Was all Adora said as she kissed and bit at Catra’s throat and collarbone.

(Silly little sketch of 28 in a dress)


Naw he's
cute

LONNIE, 3 MONTHS AGO:

Becoming Captain wasn't supposed to matter to Lonnie. It did anyway.

It felt like a private shine she hadn't earned loudly enough to admit to. She could fight. She could follow orders. She could be loyal without being stupid about it. None of that usually translated to a captaincy. Captains were neat, identical clones—made to fit a role, not grow into it.

She almost dropped the badge when it was thrown to her.

"I don't like repeating myself," the Princess said coolly. "And you've all just seen the consequences of ignoring me."

Her gaze flicked—briefly—toward Hordak, bleeding into the dirt.

Watching the Princess run Hordak through had snapped something into place. The new troops fell into a stunned, vacant obedience, eyes wide, mouths shut. Even the Etherian slave looked frozen, as if still waiting for the world to explain itself. No one moved while Hordak was hauled out of camp like refuse.

Then the order came to make up a full day's ride in half the time.

Lonnie found her voice and didn't lose it again.

She yelled for the camp to break. Yelled again for mounts. Yanked Mike onto a skiff herself when he hesitated. Told Rogelio to dump water on Everly, who had slept through Hordak's lesson in punctuality, Lonnie's promotion, and marching orders alike. She had to keep barking at the Princess's Guard to corral stragglers, shove mercenaries back into line, and keep the whole mess from dissolving into chaos.

"Four of you," Lonnie snapped. "Tail end. Now."

Rogelio grinned. "Tail end? You want me to—"

“No,” Lonnie said flatly.

He laughed anyway, but he went.

By the time they reached the next camp, the clones had shaken off their shock and replaced it with stubbornness. Most of them barely knew how to be a proper soldier, glorified sentries at best. Hordak hadn’t demanded discipline—just invisibility. Lonnie moved from problem to problem without stopping: loose mounts, collapsed tents with people trapped underneath, shouted curses aimed at the Princess. Icy bitch. High-and-mighty cunt. The words slid off Lonnie like rain.

When night finally settled and torchlight stitched uneven lines through the tents, Lonnie found herself drifting toward the trees. Out here, the leaves whispered louder than the camp. Firelight glowed behind her; ahead, shadow swallowed everything else. The rows of tents looked orderly from a distance, but she knew better. Prime’s mercenary clones would spend weeks probing for weakness.

She took out the Captain’s badge.

It was scratched. Bent. Nothing like the polished things she’d seen pinned on others. Prime had sent them to the border expecting failure. No one sane would volunteer to command this many mercenaries with this little support, under threat from every direction Etheria could manage.

The Princess had known that when she tossed Lonnie the badge.

Lonnie rolled it between her fingers, thumb brushing the dented wings, and smiled.

A twig snapped.

She closed her hand around the badge, heat creeping up her neck at being caught like that.

“Captain,” Entrapta said.

Lonnie straightened. “Soldier.”

The word felt strange in her mouth, especially in that tone.

“I hope this isn’t inappropriate timing,” Entrapta said quickly. “I followed you. I wanted to congratulate you. I ran the numbers in my head and—well. You’re statistically the most competent person here.”

Lonnie snorted before she could stop herself. “High praise.”

Entrapta blinked. “Was that sarcasm?”

“Little bit.”

“Oh.” A pause. “I meant it sincerely.”

“Noted.”

“I didn’t offend you, did I?”

“No,” Lonnie said. “Just not used to princesses lining up to flatter me.”

Entrapta’s mouth twitched, something like determination settling in. She didn’t look away. At twenty, she was exactly the kind of princess Lonnie would’ve been ordered to bring down in another war—if they’d both been old enough to fight it.

“I respect you,” Entrapta said. “You don’t shout unless it’s necessary. And you don’t waste people. I want to be useful here.”

“That’s easy,” Lonnie said. “Do your job. Don’t worry about my ego.”

“I wasn’t—” Entrapta stopped herself. “Understood. Captain.”

She turned to go, cheeks flushed.

“And, soldier?”

Entrapta turned back. Moonlight caught the bruises on her face—yellowed, darkened, overlapping. She'd been in the center of every clash since arriving. Prime's clones had made sure of that.



“This morning,” Lonnie said, quieter now. “What happened to Hordak? That wasn’t on you. The Princess chose to do that.”

Entrapta’s eyes widened, just slightly, reflecting the faint torchlight like glass.

“Yes, Captain,” she said.

✧

Like most of the Guard, Lonnie hadn’t sworn herself to Catra so much as to Shadow Weaver’s gravity.

People like that bent space around them. Even after they were gone, the pull lingered.

Lonnie had been younger then—too young to matter. She worked the edges of the camp, doing whatever no one else wanted to bother with: hauling water, running messages, patching canvas, cleaning tools. She’d helped feed the Mage’s ward sometimes. Slid bowls under the tent flap. Waited to be dismissed.

She’d been there before Shadow Weaver died. Close enough to see things she wasn’t meant to. She remembered the meetings—Prime and Weaver together—where Lonnie was allowed in just long enough to set down a tray before being waved away. She remembered being turned back more than once when she tried to bring Catra her dinner, Shadow Weaver blocking the entrance with a raised hand and a look that brooked no argument.

Lonnie had waited anyway. Lurked nearby. Watched Prime emerge from the tent later, pleased with himself.

She didn’t cry when Shadow Weaver fell to She-Ra days later.

She cried for the girl.

Catra had been dragged from the battlefield screaming, raw-throated and shaking, calling for her mother. Lonnie cried when Prime greeted her with warmth, with sympathy, with that soft

voice he used when he wanted to be believed. She cried when he took Catra away that night, arm around her shoulders, promising safety.

Prime was always kind when it mattered most.

Who would ever question that?

Shadow Weaver's soldiers scattered almost immediately. Folded themselves into peace talks with Bright Moon. Walked away clean. None of them asked what happened to the Mage's daughter. A year passed before Prime announced—casually, proudly—that he'd had Catra all along. That he intended to make her his heir.

Lonnie didn't wait for permission.

She hid herself among the next shipment bound for the Velvet Glove, wedged between crates and ration packs. When inspection came and the Princess of the Horde herself paced the line, Lonnie barely held herself together.

"Your Highness," she said, scrambling upright.

Catra stopped. Everyone else was meant to be counted, tagged, sent somewhere useful.

"And you are… what?" Catra asked.

Lonnie swallowed. The Princess was fifteen then—shorter than her, lean and coiled like a knife waiting to be thrown.

"I wasn't supposed to be here," Lonnie said. "I snuck aboard."

Catra's eyes stayed on her. Green. Gold. Unblinking.

"Why?"

Because you were alone.

"I worked under Shadow Weaver," Lonnie said instead. "I ran errands. I helped in camp. I—sometimes I brought you food."

“You’re barely old enough to lift a blade now,” Catra said. “Let alone back then.”

“I didn’t fight,” Lonnie said quickly. “I just—helped. I can do that ag–.”

Catra cut her off without hesitation. “You’ll join my guard.”

Lonnie stared.

“I don’t have many,” Catra went on, already turning away. “And I don’t like strangers.”

That should have been the warning.

When Lonnie arrived with the others Catra had gathered—Fright Zone leftovers, rejects, troublemakers—she saw it for what it was. Not an honour. Scraps. The kind you tossed aside and hoped might still bite someone else.

She laughed when they had to drag Octavia out of her bed. Recognized Rogelio immediately—a lizardman Shadow Weaver had kicked out for mouthing off.

Training started that same day.

Rogelio looked her up and down and snorted. “Didn’t think you’d last,” he said. “No offense.”

Lonnie smiled thinly and didn’t answer.

✧

Six months later, Catra summoned her alone to a private arena.

“Fight me,” Catra said.

Lonnie drew her sword and swung wide, careful, not meaning it. The Princess was still a kid. And besides—who knew what happened to a guard who bloodied royalty?

She woke up on her back minutes later.

Lonnie groaned, pushing herself up. “You didn’t mention you were serious.”

Catra stood over her, grinning. “You didn’t ask.”

“…Your Highness,” Lonnie added belatedly.

“I’ve been training,” Catra said. Like it was obvious.

That was five years ago.

Lonnie never imagined that same girl—now grown, sharp with authority—would grip her forearm and say, “You’re my Captain.”

The hold was solid. Certain.

It was the closest Lonnie had ever been to Catra.

Except, maybe, for those moments after being slammed into the ground—when Catra would offer her a hand, haul her back to her feet, and bare her teeth in a smile.

✧

“What did you tell her?” Rogelio asked, jerking his chin toward Entrapta.

Entrapta was slumped against a tree, knees drawn up, spine keeping her vertical only in the vaguest sense of the term. Her eyes had gone distant, hollow, belonging to someone who had long ago pushed past sensible limits and kept going anyway. The drills had been brutal—meant to grind down soldiers who already knew how to endure. Entrapta had stayed on her feet long after she should’ve quit.

“Nothing,” Lonnie said.

That wasn't strictly true, but it was close enough. *Do your job* wasn't exactly a speech.

She watched Entrapta from the corner of her eye. The girl—woman, technically—worked until she was wrecked. Then she worked some more. She'd finish drills shaking, spend the evening scrubbing armour or sorting supplies, and be up before dawn like she hadn't collapsed only hours earlier. She never dodged a task. Never complained. Took orders from anyone, no matter their rank or birth—people who, in this unit, she outranked by default.

"A princess?" Clone Thirteen had muttered when Entrapta first showed up, staring at her like she'd wandered in from a story. "They really sent a princess to fight?"

Lonnie had shut that down fast. "Drop it."

If the Princess wanted Entrapta here, then Entrapta stayed. You didn't second-guess that kind of decision. You adapted.

Two nights after Entrapta had come to congratulate her on the captaincy, she turned up again—hovering near the fire like she wasn't sure she was allowed to exist there.

"I've finished with the horses," Entrapta said, voice careful. "If there's anything else that needs doing—"

"Sit," Lonnie said, taking one look at her.

Entrapta sat immediately. Too immediately. Stiff as a board.

Clone Thirteen handed her a mug of cheap wine. Entrapta took it with both hands like it might explode. She barely spoke. That, Lonnie discovered, became the pattern. Night after night, Entrapta would drift over once work was done and sit near the fire—quiet while everyone else got louder.

Lonnie didn't know what to do with her at first. Former princesses weren't supposed to blend into camps like this. And Entrapta didn't try. She just… stayed.

They didn’t talk much. Too much distance between them—upbringing, education, the unspoken weight of what Entrapta had been before all this.

Sometimes, though, Entrapta asked questions. About stance. Grip. Balance. About why something wasn’t working.

And Lonnie answered.

She kept an eye out where she could. Entrapta screwed up, but never the same way twice. When Lonnie corrected her, Entrapta listened like it mattered—like it was data to be absorbed, not criticism to dodge. More than once, Lonnie caught her still practicing long after the camp had gone quiet.

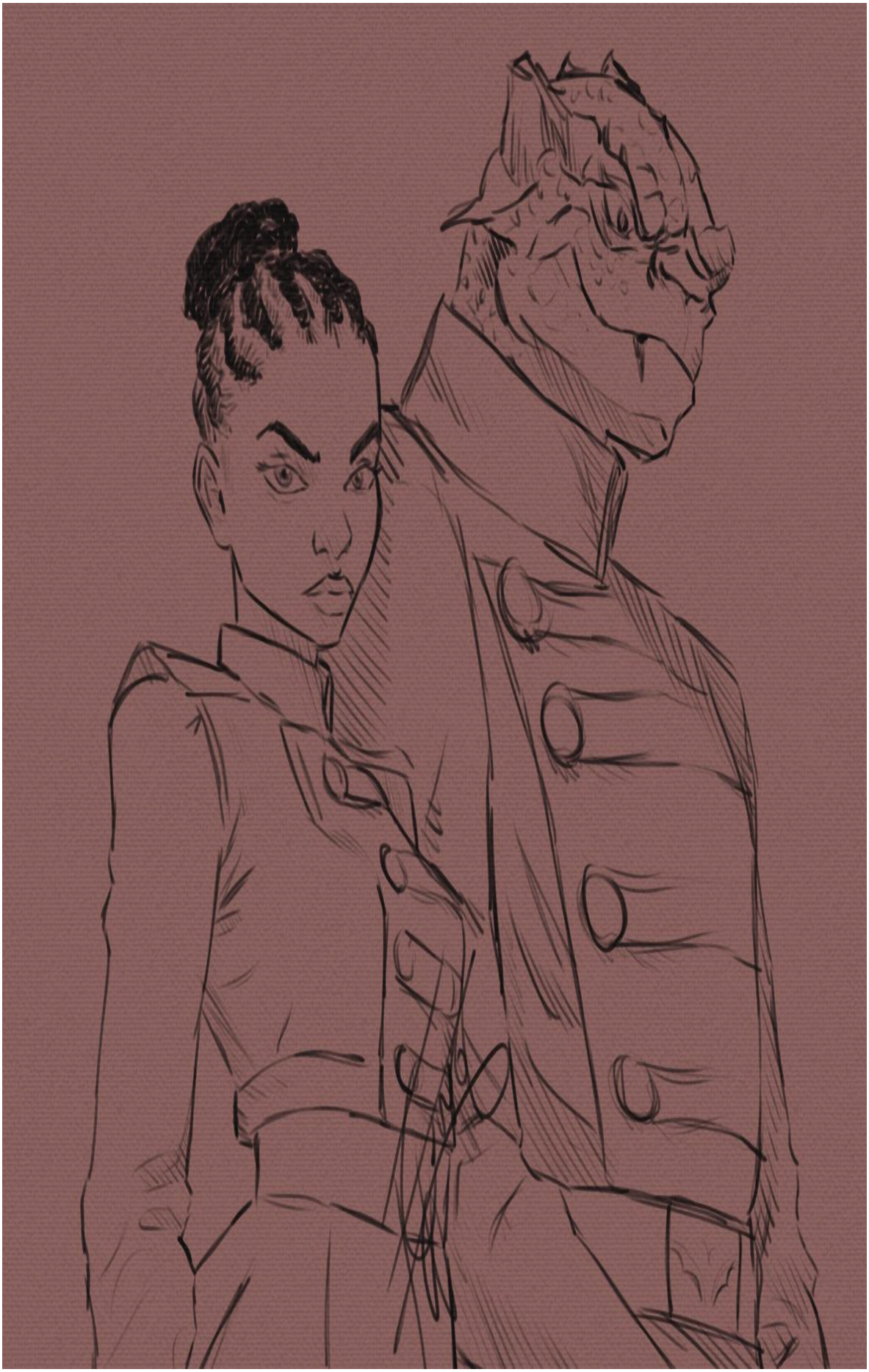
It worked. Slowly, visibly. Entrapta’s footing improved. She learned how to take a hit without folding immediately—some of the time.

The rest of the time, she looked like a stiff breeze might finish the job.

Lonnie figured that was what the Princess had seen. Not strength, exactly. Stubbornness. The refusal to stop.

“You’d better fuck her before she's too injured to participate,” Rogelio said casually.

✧



They figured it out fast: the Princess hadn’t asked permission.

Prime’s guards were clones—uniform, obedient, respectable. The Princess’s Guard was… whatever she could scrape together from the Fright Zone. Leftovers. People who didn’t fit. The friction started almost immediately. You could feel it in the halls, sharp as static.

Lonnie was halfway down the passage when her shoulder clipped a clone’s armor.

She didn’t even slow. Catra had summoned her.

Steel rang out behind her.

Lonnie turned on instinct, blade already coming up as the clone lunged. There was no time to think—only to move. The attack was fast and vicious, meant to overwhelm, but Lonnie had been training since the day she learned what had happened to Catra. She met the strike, redirected it, pushed forward hard. Their swords clashed once, twice—then Lonnie knocked his weapon free and sent him staggering back, off-balance and furious.

Silence fell.

The watching clones stopped grinning.

The one she’d disarmed stared at her, humiliated, breathing hard. “You’re dead,” he spat. “Prime will tear you apart. You’re nothing. I’m made in his image.”

Rogelio was suddenly at Lonnie’s side. “Get the Princess,” he said, urgently to another guard.

That was surely all he could think of—that Catra outranked a clone, technically.

Hands grabbed Lonnie from behind. She didn’t fight them. Fighting would only make it worse. They dragged her away and shoved her into a cell barely big enough to sit in properly. The

door hissed shut. Lonnie slid down the wall, arms wrapped around her knees.

She could see the corridor through the bars. The stairs. Nothing else.

Cut off. Alone. Waiting.

She must have slept, because the next thing she knew there was someone standing in front of the cell.

Catra.

She was alone—no guards accompanying her. Just a cat in the dark, eyes sharp and bright as Lonnie scrambled awkwardly to her feet.

"Did you start it?" Catra asked.

"No," Lonnie said. Her voice didn't shake.

Catra held her gaze for a long moment. Then: "Good. I'll handle it."

Lonnie stared. At fifteen, Catra was already done growing—lean, compact, coiled tight with fury and intent. She didn't sound brave, but she sounded certain.

By morning, Lonnie was free.

The barracks erupted around her—hands clapping her back, voices overlapping, people dragging her onto a stool and shoving a cup into her hand. Everyone had a version of the story. Lonnie pieced it together between gulps of cheap alien wine.

It had come down to Catra's word against the clone's.

The clone had raged. Catra hadn't backed down.

She'd spoken carefully, precisely—always so persuasive when she put her mind to it. Prime had smiled and called her *my clever girl*.

Said he'd believe her. With one condition.

If it happened again, the Princess's Guard was done.

Lonnie drained her cup and leaned toward Rogelio. "They're going to use this," she said quietly. "They want an excuse."

Rogelio shrugged. "Did I ever tell you why Shadow Weaver kicked me out?"

Lonnie shook her head.

"I told her that Prime could go fuck himself."

She snorted. "What did the Princess say when she heard you did that?"

"She said I was right."

Lonnie smiled despite herself. "What did she actually say?"

"She said if I embarrassed her even once, she'd personally launch me into space."

Lonnie huffed a laugh. "Yeah. That tracks."

"She's vicious," Rogelio said, fondly.

Lonnie frowned into her drink. "She's young," she said. "And she's alone."

She didn't say the rest out loud—that Catra had put her neck on the line. That she might not yet know how dangerous that was.

Prime's clones were powerful. And they wouldn't forget this.

If Lonnie was honest, the Princess's Guard *was* a bad idea. A reckless one. A pile of rejects handed titles they hadn't earned.

Rogelio snorted. "Only an idiot would give trash like us authority in a place like this."

Lonnie lifted her cup. “Yeah,” she said quietly. “Only an idiot.”

✧

Lonnie wasn’t unaware of Entrapta watching her.

She’d noticed early on. And once she’d noticed, she’d started watching back.

In a camp full of men (not Lonnie’s taste), clones, and people Lonnie had already sorted into *background noise,* Entrapta gave her somewhere to rest her eyes. She’d sit near the fire at night, tin mug balanced between her hands, shoulders hunched like she was bracing for impact even while resting. Lonnie liked that she didn’t quit. Liked the absurd purple pigtails that refused to lie flat no matter how filthy they got. Liked that when Lonnie glanced over, Entrapta was often already looking.

It was harmless. Mostly. Lonnie didn’t even bother filling in the details—daydreams stalled out on the simple fact that Entrapta *used to be a princess*.

Lonnie’s experience with princesses was limited and unpleasant. Princesses gave orders. Princesses didn’t notice guards unless something had gone wrong. Princesses certainly didn’t look twice at a lowborn captain who still smelled like oil and dust by the end of the day.

Entrapta had been highborn enough to have a life waiting for her somewhere else. A polished one. Lonnie imagined silk gloves, attendants, maybe some pretty indulgence paid to sit at a table and smile and be wanted. Not this.

None of it mattered anyway. Long looks didn’t stop rockslides. Or ambushes. Or the slow grind of Prime’s wars. The only reason any of them were still breathing was because Catra ran them into the dirt from dawn to dark—drills brutal enough to leave even veterans collapsed and too tired to complain.

Lonnie spotted Entrapta heading her way.

The log beside her was empty. Entrapta took it without asking. Firelight threw smoke between them, flickering orange over Entrapta's face. Lonnie passed her flask. Entrapta took a pull, then promptly coughed.

"That's not water," Entrapta said hoarsely.

"No," Lonnie said. "Didn't think water was what you needed."

Entrapta wiped her mouth, blinking, then tried to hand it back.

"Keep it," Lonnie said. "You need it more than me."

Entrapta held onto the flask longer this time. When she spoke, it was quiet. "I'll improve," she said. "I'll keep improving until I'm… acceptable."

Lonnie studied her. The sag in her shoulders. The shadows under her eyes. The way her pigtails had gone limp with sweat and grime. Entrapta's hands were wrapped tight around the flask—hands that might once have been soft, manicured. Now they were rough, nails chipped, dirt ground into every crease.

Across the camp, Catra dismounted a skiff with effortless grace, posture sharp and untouched by the day. No dust. No fatigue. Typical.

Lonnie snorted softly and looked back to Entrapta. "Not what you signed up for?"

Entrapta hesitated. "I was supposed to be assigned to the flagship," she said finally. "That's what Double Trouble implied."

"So why come here?"

Entrapta exhaled through her nose. "Because if Prime and the Princess are circling each other in a war, you place your assets carefully. You support the likely victor. And you send the… *less critical* piece to the opposing side."

She flushed immediately. “That sounded worse out loud.”

“You’re not expendable,” Lonnie said flatly. “You work harder than anyone in this camp. And the Princess chose you.”

Entrapta stared into the fire. “It’s not the Princess I’m worried about impressing.”

The words landed heavier than Entrapta seemed to expect.

The fire cracked, sparks lifting into the dark. The space between them felt closer somehow, drawn tight by the quiet.

Lonnie didn’t move.

Didn’t look away.

“I want you here,” Lonnie said finally. “In this unit.”

Entrapta tilted her head. “And other than that?”

“You’re an Etherian princess,” Lonnie said. “That matters whether you like it or not.”

Entrapta frowned. “Rank is an inefficient system.”

Lonnie snorted. “It still matters.”

“Does it matter to *you*?” Entrapta pressed.

Lonnie lifted her chin. “I’m your commanding officer.”

Entrapta’s mouth twitched. “So you’re officially above me.”

“Don’t push it,” Lonnie said, though she was smiling as she took back the flask and drank.



“I think about you,” Entrapta said simply.

Lonnie choked, spirits burning her throat. The air between them shifted—too sudden, too exposed. Her pulse kicked hard, betraying her. Entrapta, meanwhile, looked perfectly calm, like she’d just stated an observable fact. No stammer. No embarrassment.

“Do you ever think about me?” Entrapta asked. “Even marginally? Or am I just another variable to you. Like her.”

She tipped her chin toward the Princess’s silhouette across the camp—easy to spot even in low light, unmistakable with those

signature cat ears.

Lonnie felt suddenly hyperaware of everything: the fire, the nearby soldiers, the sense that this moment was both hidden and glaringly obvious. If Entrapta had been anyone else—someone without a title, without history—Lonnie would have already crossed that line. But Entrapta stood closer to royalty than to Lonnie's world. Power clung to her whether she claimed it or not.

Princesses didn't take guard captains to bed. And when they did, it was dangerous.

Double Trouble would never let someone like Lonnie sit at their table, let alone touch their ward. Lonnie's gaze caught on Entrapta's mouth, the soft curve of it, the stubborn purple curl that had escaped and fallen against her forehead. She had the sudden, aching urge to reach out and tuck it back.

Instead, she said, carefully, "I respect you."

Entrapta repeated it, testing the word. "'*Respect*.'"

"She's still a woman," Lonnie added, nodding faintly toward the Princess. "I'm sure she's not as frigid as everyone makes her out to be. She's just…"

She couldn't finish those words. She couldn't betray Catra like that.

Entrapta huffed. "You're alone in thinking that. She's got no place for kindness, let alone love affairs, in her life."

Lonnie glanced back at Catra. The day had been merciless—orders piled on orders, no pause for anyone who couldn't keep up. She surprised herself by saying, "I've followed her since she was fifteen."

Entrapta's voice softened. "So you didn't choose to be back here, either, really."

Lonnie didn’t respond. She knew what Entrapta meant: that this posting was a fall from grace for her. That she was isolated here, stripped of peers. A different Princess might have had companions, equals. She didn’t. Catra had shut her out, and Entrapta had ended up among soldiers and clones instead—drawn to Lonnie because she was the nearest thing to someone who might understand the burden of authority.

Entrapta couldn’t know what it meant for someone like Lonnie to wear a Horde Princess’s insignia. To be raised from nothing into responsibility.

Lonnie stared into the fire, then said, quietly but without apology,

“She’s my Princess.”

✧

Everyone remembered the weeks after Prime's ultimatum.

They learned how to swallow insults without flinching. How to pretend not to notice when their gear went missing or came back damaged. When blades dulled too fast. When straps were cut halfway through. When laughter followed them down corridors.

They didn’t file reports. They didn’t complain.

Rogelio physically held Octavia back the day a clone pissed in her bunk, hands locked around her shoulders while she shook with rage. That was early on—when the Princess’s Guard had been barred from the training halls, shut out of the courtyard, penned into corners of the ship like a bad idea that was on the edge of being discarded. Humiliation piled up until it became routine.

There was no other option but endurance.

Catra had tied her name to theirs. If they broke, she broke with them.

Three weeks after the attack in the corridor, it finally snapped.

Lonnie stood outside the guard barracks with six of Catra's Guards, Double Trouble lounging nearby, and a full squad of clones fanned out in practiced formation. Her stomach dropped the moment she realized which room they'd surrounded.

Rogelio's.

This time the accusation was delivered with relish: a Princess's Guard caught with a *pet*. One of Prime's discarded toys.

Lonnie knew instantly it wasn't true. No pet would take that risk—for Rogelio, least of all.

If someone was inside, it wouldn't be one of their own. Besides, that would mean execution or exile. Rogelio would be finished. The Guard would follow. The clone's smile said he knew it.

The soldiers moved into position. Lonnie barely registered the tight, sick dread on her own side before the door slid open.

Silence.

The room was too small for secrets. No screens. No corners to duck behind. Everything laid bare.

Rogelio—far too naked for anyone's comfort. And yes, there was someone with him, wrapped in the unmistakable cut of a pet's sheer outfit.

But it wasn't a pet.

It was Clone 28.

"Hey!" Clone 28 yelled, trying to cover himself.

Double Trouble clicked their tongue. "Well. That's profoundly uninteresting."

The fallout was immediate.

They were hauled into the council chamber, the accusation collapsing in on itself as soon as Catra opened her mouth.

"This is the second time Prime's clones have falsely accused my Guard," the Princess said.

She didn't raise her voice.

That was what made it worse.

She sat beside Prime on the dais, small and neat, hair pinned back, expression calm enough to pass for harmless. Her eyes flicked briefly to the accusing clone—soft, almost fond.

"A misunderstanding," the clone tried. "An honest—"

"Two misunderstandings," Catra corrected lightly.

The clone faltered, glancing instinctively toward Prime.

"Supreme—"

Prime sighed, irritation sharpening his tone. "Little brother, don't drag my name into your incompetence. I have no interest in mediating your personal vendettas with gutter trash."

The clones shifted, murmuring agreement. One spoke up, emboldened. "Perhaps we should reconsider the Princess's Guard altogether."

Lonnie felt the weight of it settle in her chest.

This wasn't over.

When they were finally released back into the corridor, Lonnie shoved a spare shirt into Rogelio's hands without a word. She'd grabbed it from his room while no one was looking.

"I am *not* sleeping with clones," Rogelio muttered as he hauled it over his head. "He just showed up like that and I—"

“She said everyone was supposed to be dressed that way,” Clone 28 offered, genuinely confused by the situation he had found himself in.

Rogelio snorted. “Lucky you were wearing anything at all.”

Lonnie stared at the clone. “You were sent to Rogelio’s room,” she said flatly, “dressed like that.”

Clone 28 frowned, thinking. “Yes.”

Lonnie closed her eyes for half a second, trying to make sense of it.

The next morning, the Princess’s Guard assembled in full kit. Buckles gleamed. Boots were scrubbed to regulation shine. Not because anyone told them to—because everyone knew.

The story had already burned its way through the ship. The clone who’d pushed the accusation had been quietly removed. Clone 28 was being reassigned to the Fright Zone—Dryl, specifically—far from Rogelio’s quarters. Prime had withdrawn the threat hanging over the Guard. Officially instated. Untouchable, for now.

Lonnie watched Catra enter the barracks.

The Princess stopped short when she saw them already lined up, waiting. For a beat, the only sound was the ship’s low mechanical hum.

Then Catra smiled—thin, sharp.

“This isn’t a victory lap,” she said. “I have full command of you now. And I don’t reward nice sentiments.” Her eyes swept the line. “I will run you harder than anyone else on this ship. You’ll earn every inch of the name I gave you. My Guard will be the best.”

She stopped in front of Lonnie.

Lonnie met her gaze, steady. “The clone wore the outfit well,” she said. “Your Highness.”

Catra’s mouth curved just enough to show teeth. “I told you I’d handle it.”

✧

The Princess’s command tent was a long, low stretch of black canvas, marked by a red pennant that snapped restlessly in the wind. The entrance cords were never fully closed—soldiers drifted in and out all day with updates, requisitions, messages ferried from one end of the camp to the other. It was meant to be accessible.

Lonnie paused before stepping inside.

From where she stood, she could already see the map table. Two figures leaned over it, close enough that their shoulders nearly brushed—one dark-haired, one fair. Catra stood with her weight tipped forward, hands braced on the table. Across from her, the Etherian woman—Mara—was speaking softly, tracing a route with one finger as if the terrain were already familiar beneath her skin.

Catra followed the motion intently, eyes sharp, posture unguarded in a way Lonnie had never seen. She nodded once, then again, absorbing everything. Not questioning. Listening.

Lonnie felt a faint, irrational jolt of surprise.

Catra did not do this. She didn’t linger in easy conversation. She didn’t allow closeness. As a girl, she’d kept people at arm’s length; as a woman, she ruled with distance. Seeing her here—still, focused, almost comfortable—felt like walking in on something not meant to be witnessed.

Their heads lifted at the same time.

Two very different faces, wearing the same expression: mild curiosity, as if Lonnie were a passing distraction rather than an

interruption.

“Captain,” Catra said. “What do you have.”

Lonnie straightened. “Supplies are stable. No losses worth reporting. Drills are progressing.” She hesitated, then added, “I disciplined one of the clones for inappropriate remarks.”

Catra hummed. “A merciful summary.” She waved a hand. “No bloodshed means the day’s a success. You did well.”

Lonnie inclined her head. “Your Highness.”

She left with the sense that the tent remained occupied after she was gone.

The Etherian woman had listened to the report as if it were meant for her as much as Catra—had even smiled, warm and attentive, like someone who found pleasure in the complexity of leadership. Catra hadn’t pushed that away. Had allowed it, actually.

Lonnie’s gaze dropped to the map as she turned.

It might as well have been written in another language. Sigils she didn’t recognize. Markings that meant nothing to her. Lines of intent instead of roads. She could read a standard chart, navigate terrain, plan defenses and patrols, keep people alive in bad places.

This wasn’t that.

This was the kind of thinking that reshaped borders. The kind that took years to learn, and years more to wield without hesitation. The Etherian had it instinctively. Catra was learning it fast.

They were planning for something vast. Something that would reach far beyond this camp, beyond anything Lonnie could command.

For a fleeting moment, Lonnie felt herself standing at the edge of a world that wasn't meant for her—too wide, too intricate—and then the feeling passed, as it always did.

She turned back to her duties.

✧

"Captain."

Lonnie glanced up.

Entrapta stood just inside the tent's threshold, the torchlight catching her hair and the clean lines of her uniform. Even stripped of silks and ceremony, she still carried the unmistakable stamp of high birth—posture, presence, the way the space seemed to rearrange itself around her. Outside, the camp was settling: boots scuffing away, voices dropping, the night pulling everything inward.

"I could walk you through it," Entrapta said. "If you want."

Lonnie felt heat creep up her neck. Entrapta wasn't looking at the map, but she didn't have to. Lonnie knew exactly what she meant.

"You helped me," Entrapta added, a little more softly. "When I didn't know how to be a soldier."

Behind her, the tent opening framed the darkened camp, the noise thinning as soldiers turned in for the night. Entrapta stepped forward, unhesitating, and stopped where Catra had stood earlier—hands braced on the table, eyes already moving.

Lonnie swallowed.

This *was* Entrapta's world. Heraldry. Borders drawn in ink instead of blood. Symbols layered over history and ownership and threat. Lonnie witnessed terrain the hard way—by marching it, watching her elders defending it, bleeding on it. Looking at the map made her feel like she was pretending to belong somewhere she didn't.

But war didn’t care about her comfort. And if it was coming, Lonnie wanted to understand the ground it would be fought on.

She moved closer.

Entrapta explained without condescension, breaking the map down piece by piece. She traced lines with a careful finger, translating sigils into meaning. Lonnie asked questions she hadn’t realized she’d been holding back. Entrapta answered them plainly, occasionally stopping to rethink a phrasing when Lonnie frowned.

They both relaxed as it went on.

The symbols began to settle into sense. Routes became choices. Marks became warnings. Lonnie felt something unfamiliar and steady take hold—the quiet satisfaction of learning, of *keeping up* with her new station.

Eventually, Entrapta leaned back. The tent had gone still again.

“Thank you,” Lonnie said. It sounded thin, even to her. She hesitated, then added, low and honest, “This job… it matters to me. More than I thought it would.”

Entrapta looked at her—not searching, not judging. Just attentive.

Lonnie met her gaze and didn’t look away.

Something in the space between them tipped.

Entrapta’s attention dropped—not to the map this time, but to Lonnie’s mouth. Lonnie felt it before she thought it, her hand lifting to the warm line of Entrapta’s neck, her thumb resting there like it had always belonged. The kiss came quietly, almost experimentally—Entrapta’s eyes gone dark, focused, her mouth softening the instant it met Lonnie’s.



Entrapta leaned into it fully, like she did everything else. No hesitation. No half-measures.

Lonnie drew her closer and kissed her the way she'd imagined in fragments until the world narrowed to breath and warmth and the steady give of Entrapta's mouth. When she finally pulled back, Entrapta's cheeks were flushed, her eyes bright and wide, pupils blown dark. Lonnie's thoughts scattered uselessly, words dissolving before they could take shape.

"Let me," Entrapta said quickly, before Lonnie could find her voice. "I'm—good at it."

Her hands had already moved, clumsy with urgency, catching on Lonnie's buttons. The tent entrance was still open. Firelight flickered across canvas. This was too fast—too exposed—the echo of the kiss still humming through Lonnie's body.

Lonnie caught Entrapta's wrists gently and drew them back. Entrapta stilled, confused, heat still high in her face.

"I don't—" Entrapta began. "I thought you—"

Lonnie swallowed. "I do want you," she said, rougher than she meant. "But not like this. If you'd have me, I'd come to *your* tent. Properly." She hesitated, then added honestly, "I won't pretend I'm anything special. I won't be what you're used to. I just meant it—what I said before. I respect you."

Entrapta stared at her, unreadable for a long beat.

Lonnie felt suddenly misplaced among the silks and maps and strategy. Entrapta had been a princess, even stripped of title—and yet she was also just herself: stubborn, brilliant, out of step, as out of place here as Lonnie was anywhere near power.

Entrapta took a breath. Then another.

"Yes," she said. "Okay. Yes."

She stepped back, clearly steadying herself, eyes flicking once to the tent opening and back. "You should go first," she added, practical as ever. "I'll follow after a minute. I know how to move without being noticed." She smiled, small and bright. "I'm discreet."

She drifted back toward the map table, giving Lonnie space.

Lonnie stepped out into the night.

The camp lay stitched together by torchlight—clones and Princess's Guard sharing ground too narrow to feel safe, yet full of people willing to hold it anyway. It was fragile. Uneven. And somehow hopeful.

Lonnie touched her lips, still warm with the heat of the kiss. It felt like a beginning.

KESTON, A WEEK AGO:

Keston had expected attention after the games.

It clung to him as he left the ring—looks that followed the set of his shoulders, the lingering stares that always came after a good showing. Three wins. One runner-up. Enough to mark him out. He'd expected the usual spread of reactions: tight, professional nods from the Snows soldiers who never liked losing to an outsider; loud approval from his fellow Salineans, who treated victory like a communal sport; and the cold, measuring hostility of Horde soldiers under Princess Catra, who rarely applauded anyone not their own.

What he hadn't expected was a clone trying to flirt with him.

"You looked good out there today."

The voice behind him was utterly unremarkable—flat, identical to a hundred others Keston had heard shouting orders or dying on battlefields. He turned anyway, mostly out of curiosity.

Then he found himself staring into two pupil-less, solid green eyes.

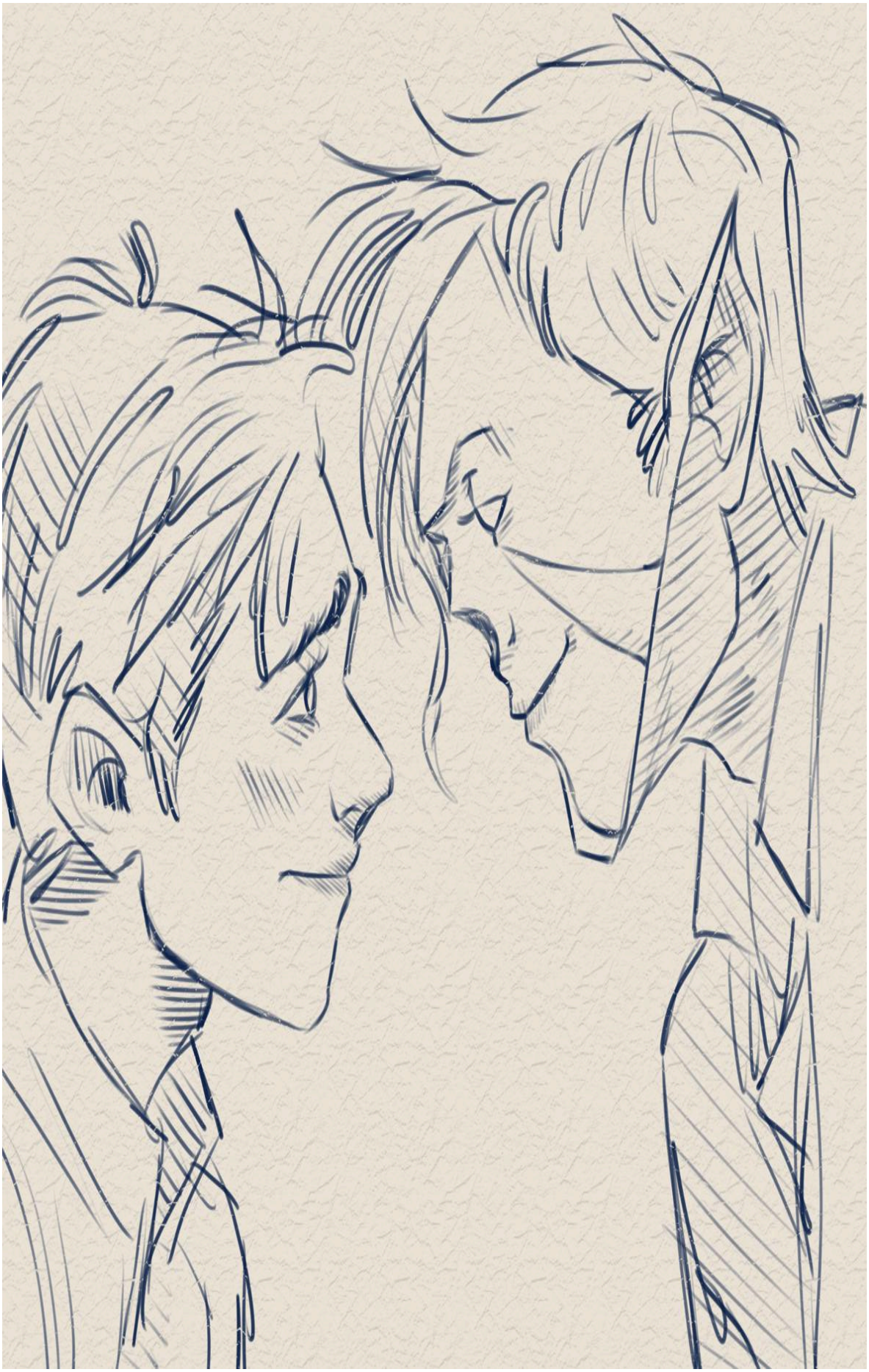
“Oh,” Keston said.

The clone flushed. Not pink—green, darkening across stark white skin in a way Keston found himself filing away for later consideration. “You—uh. I—”

Keston frowned slightly. “Are you… talking to me?”

“Yes.” The clone nodded, too fast. “We fought today. The wrestling match. You had very good form.” A pause. “You looked good.”

“While I was stripped down to my briefs?” Keston supplied, one corner of his mouth lifting. “That kind of good?”



The green flush deepened, spreading to the clone's ears.

Keston found that… informative.

He'd killed clones before, watched green blood soak into dirt without a second thought. In a fight, the colour of your blood didn't matter—only who walked away. He hadn't considered what that physiology looked like when it wasn't under a blade.

"We fought?" Keston prompted when the clone stalled completely.

"Yes. You won."

"I remember winning," Keston said, mildly smug. "I just couldn't tell which one of you it was. No offense, but you're… identical."

"I'm Twenty-Eight," the clone said quickly.

Keston blinked. "You have ages?"

"What? No—" The clone shook his head hard, embarrassed again. "That's my name. Clone 28."

"Oh." Keston paused. "Right."

Silence stretched. Keston found himself suddenly noticing the small ways Clone 28 didn't quite match the rest.

Most of the clones Keston had seen, before these past months, kept their heads severe and uniform—shaved down to regulation, every edge precise. 28 didn't. His hair was longer, just enough to break the sameness, swept carelessly to one side with a stubborn strand at the front that refused to lie flat and nearly curled on itself. At the back, it brushed the nape of his neck, soft where it should have been clipped away.

"Well," Clone 28 said, clearing his throat with great seriousness. "I should—"

He didn’t finish. He turned sharply and walked off, apparently intent on dignity. Unfortunately, he failed to notice a low table, clipped it hard with his knee, hissed a curse, and limped away pretending nothing had happened.

Keston watched him go, smiling to himself.

Huh.

That was… different.

ENTRAPTA, TODAY:

“You look… nice.”

Entrapta glanced up, then stalled, brain briefly buffering.

The woman standing in front of her was unfamiliar in the way things sometimes were when Entrapta *knew* she’d seen them before but couldn’t immediately pull the correct file. Darker skin, hair braided tightly but arranged so it looked casual rather than severe—an illusion Entrapta appreciated. She wore a plain white shirt with puffed sleeves under a commoner’s dress: brown bodice, blue skirt. The stitching looked cheap at first glance, but Entrapta clocked the reinforcement points almost immediately. Practical. Built to last.

The face, though. The face was definitely stored somewhere.

“Oh,” Entrapta said at last. “You’re one of Catra’s soldiers.”

The woman’s mouth twisted, sharp and almost pained. For a moment, Entrapta wondered if she’d misclassified her.

“Sorry,” the woman said shortly, already turning away. “This was a bad idea—never mind.”

“No—wait.” Entrapta reached out before she could overthink it and caught the woman’s hand. *Too fast. Too much*. She winced internally but didn’t let go immediately. “People don’t usually talk

to me. Not the Horde soldiers at least. They mostly just… stare." *Like you are right now, but meaner.* "Please—oh! You're Lanny—no, Lonnie. Lonnie. You were Catra's captain before Marzo, right?"

The woman froze.

"Before Adora," Lonnie said slowly, eyes dropping to where their hands were still linked.

Entrapta followed her gaze and immediately released her. "Sorry. Uninvited contact. Still adjusting." She clasped her hands together instead. "Also—Adora isn't Catra's captain. She's the Queen of Etheria. Did you hit your head?"

Lonnie blinked. "No one's told you anything," she said.

"No one will talk to me," Entrapta repeated, factual rather than upset. "Which is inefficient."

Lonnie swallowed. "You… died."

"Yes," Entrapta said, nodding. "Or a version of me did. I'm a clone. Or she was. Or I am. Double Trouble says it's unclear and frankly I agree."

Lonnie stared at her like she was seeing something fracture and reassemble at the same time.

"Would you like me to tell you what happened?" Lonnie asked quietly.

Entrapta didn't hesitate.

"Yes," she said.

CATRA, TODAY:

Catra barely had time to laugh before Adora's hand closed around her wrist and she was being dragged—actually dragged—back toward the fort.

“Oh, absolutely not,” Catra said, breathless and grinning as Adora towed her along. “You don’t get to just—”

Adora stopped just long enough to kiss her again. Not gentle. Not patient. Just hungry, like Adora had reached the point where thinking was no longer an option.

Catra melted into it anyway.

They made it maybe ten steps before Adora did it again, crowding Catra into a shadowed alcove, kissing her like the rest of the world had politely ceased to exist for them. *If only*. Catra let herself be pinned, let herself be kissed, let herself enjoy the fact that half the courtyard had been trying very hard not to see their Queen being thoroughly compromised.

Adora just tugged Catra through a narrow side door—one Catra knew perfectly well led to an unused storage room—and kicked it shut behind them.

Empty. Quiet. Close quarters.

“Adora,” Catra started, laughing as her back hit the wall.

Adora kissed her again and that was that.

It was fast. It was reckless. Fabric pulled askew, desperate hands and the shared understanding that they did not have time for this and absolutely did not care. Catra tugged Adora closer, teeth scraping, breath hot, the two of them moving with the desperate urgency of people who knew exactly what they wanted and had no interest in waiting for later.

When they finally surfaced again, Catra was dizzy, flushed, and painfully aware that she looked like she’d been mauled—in the best possible way. White dress creased and wrinkled, neckline tugged slightly out of place, hair a mess from Adora’s hands.

Adora’s no better—shirt rumpled, belt crooked, hair thoroughly wrecked. Their lips were both bitten pink. They paused in the

hallway, both of them trying—and failing—to look composed.

Catra snorted. “We are terrible at this.”

Adora glanced down at herself, then at Catra, then groaned softly. “You look fine.”

“Liar,” Catra said fondly. She leaned in, stole one last quick kiss, then stepped back. “Go. I’ll—” she gestured vaguely at herself, “—fix this.”

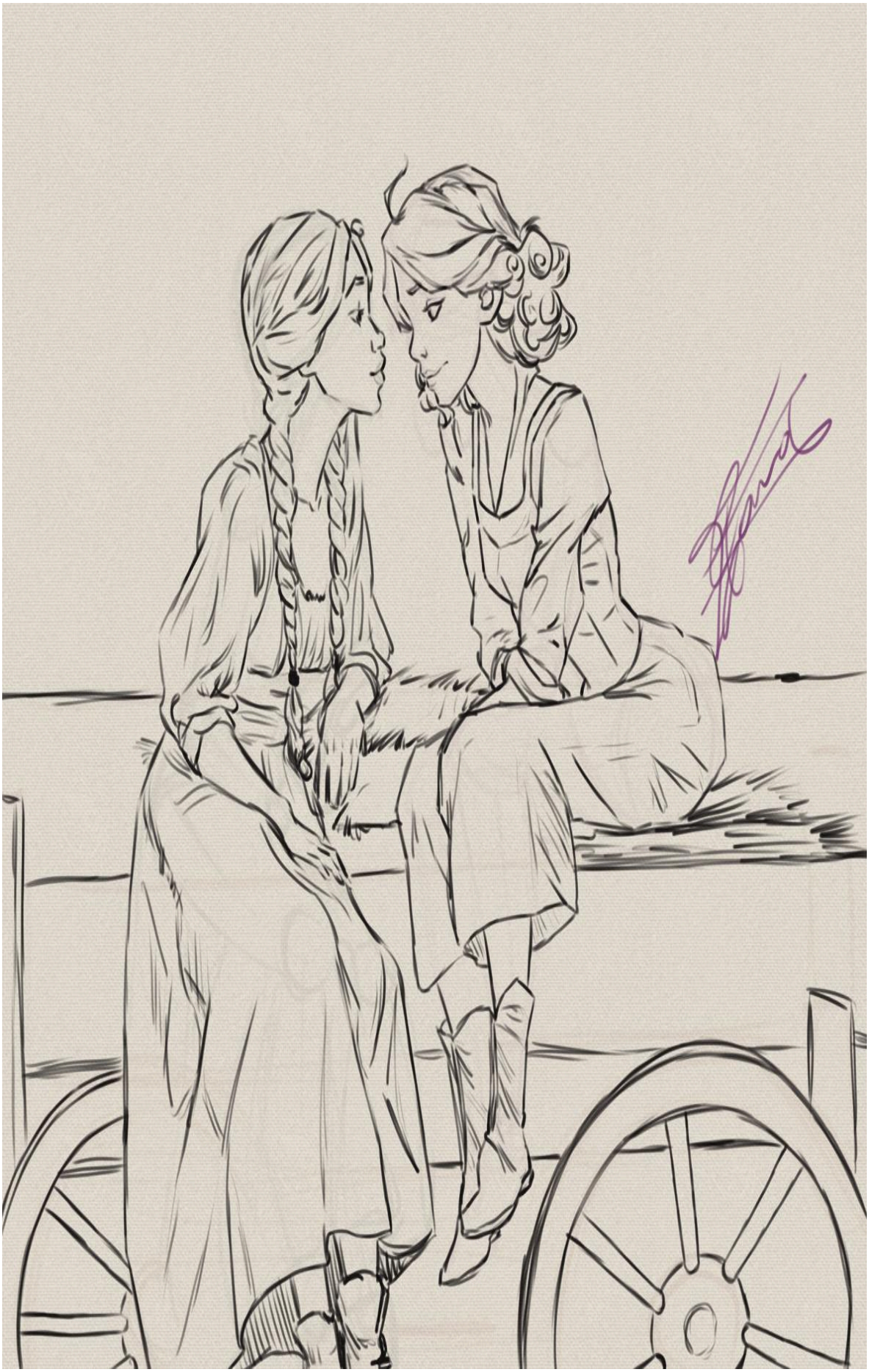
Adora hesitated, like she wanted to argue, then nodded and headed off—trying very hard to look regal and failing just a little.

Catra watched her go, warmth settling low and satisfied in her chest.

Catra stepped back into the courtyard still riding the afterglow of sex, already pulling her spine straight and her face into something sharp and passable as authority.

Then she saw them.

Entrapta perched on one of the supply wagons, legs swinging slightly, talking to Lonnie like it was normal. Not standing at attention. Not hovering awkwardly. Sitting. Close. Their heads angled toward each other, voices low enough to be private without being secret.



Catra slowed without meaning to.

Something tight and unpleasant twisted in her chest—quick and sharp, like she'd misjudged a landing. She couldn't immediately tell what the feeling was, which annoyed her more than the feeling itself. Relief? Worry? That familiar prickle of *what if I've already broken this too?*

Entrapta was smiling. Not her bright, performative grin, but something smaller. Quieter. Lonnie looked… relaxed. Catra didn't see that often—not since the last Entrapta had…

Catra folded her arms, watching from the edge of the space.

She had resented Double Trouble for springing this new Entrapta on her and the troops (on Lonnie), had seen it as a way to undermine and cause strife in her small army.

But maybe—

Maybe things didn't always turn out the way Catra expected them to.

Maybe Entrapta finding Lonnie—*again*—wasn't a bad thing. Maybe it was an outcome Catra hadn't accounted for because she so rarely took softness or happiness into consideration. Didn't consider people choosing each other without orders or leverage or threats.

The thought made her chest ache in a way that wasn't entirely bad.

Catra exhaled slowly.

She didn't move to interrupt them. Didn't bark an order or demand attention. She let the moment exist without clawing at it, which felt strange and wrong and… maybe necessary.

She couldn't control everyone.

She didn’t have to.

And Catra decided that was okay.

Chapter End Notes

I hope you enjoyed. [Please like 28 and Keston]
I hope you like all my little sketches. There are more on my patreon or tiktok. Including DT, Baker, more of Adora in her cute commoners outfit.
Patreon: cjowoart
Tiktok: cj.lyndal

Chapter 32: Adora

Chapter Notes

Thank you to my beta reader 🥰

Enjoy

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Mermista didn't bother lowering her voice. She rarely did when she thought she was right.

"This is dishonourable," she said again, reins taut in her hands, posture rigid with barely contained agitation.

They were close enough to the southern border now that Adora could see the individual pennants snapping in the wind above the blockade—Bright Moon colours, clean white and gold. The road narrowed here, funnelled by stone embankments and a line of sharpened stakes sunk deep into the earth. Forty soldiers at least stood watch across the road itself, armour polished, spears upright. Beyond them rose the sentry tower, tall and narrow, its signal mirrors already angled toward the morning sun. If anything went wrong, the alarm would ripple outward in minutes, carried from tower to tower until the fort knew exactly who had tried to pass.

Adora's eyes tracked the details automatically: the spacing of the guards, the way the cavalry were positioned just off to either side, the readiness in their stance. They had been watching the wagons for a long time. There was no element of surprise left to them.

"I want it on record," Mermista went on, jaw tight, "that I object to this plan in its entirety."

"It's been noted," Adora replied evenly, keeping her gaze forward.

What she didn’t say—what she couldn’t afford to dwell on—was how exposed everything suddenly felt. The wagons were too clean. The bolts of cloth were convincing at a distance but laughable up close. Her soldiers wore borrowed clothes and borrowed manners, and every one of them had needed repeated reminders not to snap to attention when she spoke. And inside the second wagon, bound and gagged and still radiating dangerous calm, sat Glimmer—watching, waiting, absolutely capable of ruining everything if given half a chance.

Adora adjusted her grip on the reins and forced herself to slow the horses to a steady, unremarkable walk. Any hint of haste would draw attention. Any sign of nerves would be noticed. She had learned that much from Catra, if nothing else.

The wagons rolled to within speaking distance of the blockade.

“Halt,” came the command.

Adora pulled back on the reins. The horses obeyed with a creak of leather and wood, hooves grinding to a stop against packed dirt. Around her, the others followed suit, a ripple of motion as twelve riders and two wagons came to rest.

A mounted officer broke from the line and approached at a measured pace. She wore a short white-and-gold cape over one shoulder, helm tucked under her arm, her expression composed but wary.

“Declare yourselves,” the Captain said.

Adora lifted her chin just enough. “We’re escorting Queen Glimmer,” she said, voice steady, pitched to carry without strain. “She’s returning to Bright Moon and onward to Prime following her labour.”

There was nothing to support the claim except the covered wagon behind her, canvas drawn tight, sunlight glinting off its fittings. The Captain’s eyes flicked toward it, then back to Adora.

“Our intelligence indicates Queen Glimmer was detained at Cazzle Cove,” the Captain said slowly.

“Your intelligence is incorrect,” Adora replied. “She’s inside that wagon.”

The silence that followed was heavy.

“In that wagon,” the Captain repeated.

“Yes.”

The officer studied her more closely now. Adora met her gaze without blinking, holding it the way Catra had taught her—unflinching, unapologetic, as if doubt were an insult rather than a possibility. This time, it didn’t work.

“I’m sure Her Majesty won’t object to a brief confirmation,” the Captain said at last.

“I’m sure she will,” Adora countered. “She made it very clear she didn’t wish to be disturbed.”

Behind her, she could feel Mermista practically vibrating with disapproval. To push back again was dangerous. She knew it. The Captain’s tone had shifted—less formal, more alert.

“We’ve been ordered to inspect every wagon crossing this road,” the Captain said. “The Queen will just have to accommodate that.”

Adora opened her mouth, heard herself starting to protest—too late, too instinctive.

“You can’t just—”

“Open the wagon,” the Captain said, already turning away, dismissing Adora as if she were little more than a courier.

Two soldiers approached the second wagon. Their movements were careful, respectful, almost hesitant—as though they truly did

expect royalty behind the canvas. One of them rapped his knuckles against the wooden frame.

“Your Majesty?” he called, awkwardly. “Border inspection.”

No answer.

The soldier glanced back at the Captain. She gave a curt nod.

Hands went to the latch.

From somewhere just behind Adora, Catra shifted in the saddle, leaning forward with keen interest, lips already twitching as if this were a performance they were enjoying far too much. Mermista’s knuckles had gone white around her reins.

Adora didn’t move. She couldn’t.

The latch creaked. The canvas rustled.

And the moment stretched—tight, fragile, balanced on the edge of disaster.

A second knock followed the first, firmer than courtesy but not yet force. Then a third, sharper still, impatience creeping in around the edges.

Adora opened her mouth, already reaching for a tone that balanced authority with irritation. “You see? She’s asleep. Are you really going to—”

“Open it,” the Captain snapped, the last shred of deference stripped away. “Now.”

They pulled back the canvas. She made herself stay perfectly still, spine straight, hands loose on the reins, as if this had been inevitable all along. Any reaction now—any tightening, any breath held too long—would be noticed.

Beside her, Mermista's hand slid to the hidden hilt at her hip. Not dramatically. Not obvious. Just ready. Her jaw had gone rigid, eyes fixed on the wagon door as though she were already calculating angles, numbers, the precise moment when violence would become unavoidable.

What followed was worse than shouting.

Silence spilled out instead—thick, awkward, punctuated by low, indistinct sounds Adora couldn't quite parse. A murmur. A pause. The shuffle of boots. Someone clearing their throat. The seconds stretched, each one dragging against her nerves. She imagined Glimmer inside, bound and furious, imagined a single wrong movement, a single betrayed breath—

Then footsteps. Retreating.

The Captain returned at a brisk pace, helm tucked under her arm once more. She stopped in front of Adora and bowed so deeply it bordered on theatrical. Her face had gone flushed, a fine sheen of sweat visible at her temples.

"My apologies, ma'am," she said quickly. "Queen Glimmer is—of course—free to travel as she wishes." She swallowed, then added, more carefully, "At her request, I'll accompany your party through the remaining checkpoints. To ensure there are no further… inconveniences."

Adora inclined her head, regal and composed, though her pulse was still hammering hard enough that she could feel it in her throat. "Your diligence is appreciated, Captain."

The order was barked down the line moments later. The barricade shifted. Spears lifted. The road opened.

As they moved on, the Captain rode close, glancing toward the wagon with something like reluctant awe. "The stories don't do her justice," she said, lowering her voice as if sharing a confidence. "Queen Glimmer is… beautiful."

Adora didn’t look at her. “You’ll speak of her with respect,” she said coolly.

The Captain stiffened. “Of course. My apologies.”

At the final checkpoint, the Captain ordered a full salute. Banners dipped. Fists struck breastplates. Then they were through—rolling on for another mile, then another, until the road curved and the sentry tower vanished behind a rise of land.

Only then did Adora lift her hand.

The wagons slowed. Stopped.

The rear door creaked open, and Double Trouble hopped lightly down from the wagon, brushing imaginary dust from their dark sleeves, their smile wide and entirely too pleased.

Mermista stared from them to the wagon and back again, disbelief written plainly across her face. “How,” she demanded, “did you convince Glimmer to play along with that?”

Double Trouble clasped their hands together, delighted. “Oh, I didn’t.”

Before Mermista could ask anything more, their form shimmered—and reassembled into a flawless replica of the Princess of the Seas. Same height. Same scowl. Same salt-sharp presence. They held it just long enough to make the point, then shifted back again with a flourish.

Mermista’s mouth fell open. “Catra has a changeling?”

Adora heard the words as though through water. The world tilted slightly, nausea rolling up sharp and unwelcome as Double Trouble turned and gave her a slow, deliberate wink.

She swallowed hard, forcing the reaction down.

“Unfortunately,” Adora said aloud, voice even despite the churn in her stomach.

Double Trouble’s grin widened.

This time, though—this time—it had saved them.

✧

They had bought themselves a narrow slice of time—two hours at most—before the illusion unraveled. When the Captain reached the fort and realized Queen Glimmer had not arrived, confusion would curdle into suspicion. After that, it would be minutes, not hours, before Prime’s clones came thundering down the road, snapping the countryside shut behind them like a trap.

When the gag was finally removed and the ropes loosened, Glimmer lifted her chin and fixed Adora with a look of cool appraisal, as though this were merely another inconvenience she was cataloguing for later retribution. She flexed her wrists once, testing circulation, then rose with unhurried grace.

Catra appeared at the wagon’s edge, already bored, already done with this. She offered Glimmer a hand with exaggerated courtesy, her expression flat, her eyes sharp. Glimmer took it, stepping down lightly, her balance perfect despite the rough ground.

“You’re fortunate,” Glimmer said, her voice smooth, cutting, “that you brought that creature along.” Her gaze flicked, pointedly, toward Double Trouble. “Otherwise you’d all be dead already.”

Catra’s mouth curved faintly—not a smile, exactly. “We do try to travel prepared.”

They turned east, angling away from the main road, toward a place Adora hadn’t allowed herself to think about too closely until now. The Whispering Woods spread thin and uneven across the hills, not nearly dense enough to be comforting. At its heart lay Razz’s Inn—a sanctuary and a childhood refuge—its buildings grown more than built, stone and wood coaxed into place rather

than forced. Razz had sheltered Etherian queens before. She would shelter Adora now, even from Prime himself.

The land grew familiar beneath Adora's eyes: summer Etheria, dry stone breaking through shallow soil, scrub clinging stubbornly to slopes, orchards and vineyards breathing sweetness into the air. It was beautiful—and exposed. Too open. There were long stretches where a wagon could be seen for miles, and the scattered stands of trees offered little more than hope.

As the threat of patrols pressed closer, Adora's unease sharpened. The plan required her to leave the wagons behind, to ride ahead and make herself known to Razz before Prime's attention found them. She hated it. Every instinct in her rebelled against splitting their forces, against leaving Glimmer and the others vulnerable even for a moment.

But there was no alternative.

"Hold the course," Adora told Mermista, reins taut in her hands. "I won't be long. I'll take the strongest rider."

"That would be me," Catra said immediately, already turning her horse.

They rode hard, Catra low and effortless in the saddle, guiding them off the road before any watcher might mark their passing. When they were close enough that the land began to slope gently downward toward the estate, they dismounted, tethered the horses out of sight, and went on foot.

The brush fought them every step of the way. Adora shoved branches aside, felt twigs scrape her arms, grit crunch beneath her boots. A thorn snagged her hem; a rotting log crumbled underfoot. She hissed under her breath, freeing fabric and skin alike.

"I really thought," she said, sweeping a branch from her face, "that becoming Queen meant I was done with this."

Catra snorted softly. “You wildly underestimated the job.”

Adora sidestepped a blade of exposed granite, then ducked as Catra held back a low-hanging branch for her. Leaves rustled closed behind them.

“This was thinner when I was a kid,” Adora muttered.

“Or you were,” Catra replied, dry as ever.

They crested the last rise together.

Below them, Razz’s land unfolded in a series of cool, shaded terraces—stone structures opening into gardens, gardens giving way to orchards heavy with fruit. Nectarine, apricot, and apple trees stretched in swirling rows, sunlight glinting off leaves and pale stone alike. The sight hit Adora harder than she had expected.

For a fleeting, treacherous moment, she imagined arriving openly. Resting. Standing with Catra on the open balcony as the sun bled into evening, Razz bustling and muttering and offering them food she insisted was magical. Arguing, as always, about names and faces and time itself. Safety. Peace.

She shoved the thought aside.

The land between them and the house was broken with natural stone outcroppings—cover, if you knew how to use it. Adora mapped the path instinctively, tracing the route from tree line to gate to the kitchen doors that opened onto the gardens. She knew that door. She had slipped through it a hundred times as a child.

“That way,” she said quietly.

Catra followed without question.

They moved together, low and careful, the inn waiting below them like a held breath.

“Stop,” Catra said, softly—but there was caution under it.

Adora froze mid-step. She followed Catra’s line of sight and felt the warning land a second later: a hound sprawled in the shade near the western paddock, chain slack, ears half-pricked. Beyond it, a cramped field bristled with horses—too many of them, shoulder to shoulder, stamping, snorting, packed into land that couldn’t possibly sustain them.

They were downwind. The dog hadn’t caught their scent yet.

“There are too many horses,” Catra murmured.

Adora looked again, counting automatically, the way she had learned to count enemies. Forty. Fifty. More. Not the light-boned riding stock of merchants or courtiers, but war mounts—thick-necked, heavy-chested, trained to carry armor and weapons. Her stomach tightened.

“I can’t leave Razz to Prime’s mercy,” Adora said, the words pulled from her before she could temper them.

“She’s only at risk if you’re found here,” Catra replied, calm and ruthless. “If they connect you to this place, she becomes an accomplice.”

Their eyes met. The conclusion passed between them without needing voice: they couldn’t bring the wagons here. Not now. Not until Prime was gone for good. They needed a way off the road—fast—and they needed the sentries distracted long enough to vanish.

“There’s a stream north of here,” Adora said, already assembling the map in her head. “It cuts through the Whispering Woods. We can lose the trail, keep the wheels off stone.”

“I’ll handle the sentries,” Catra said.

Adora hesitated. “You’re very recognizable.”

Catra's mouth twitched. "Your faith in me is touching."

They didn't linger. Sunlight filtered through leaves, stippling Catra's hair; a twig had caught there, absurdly whimsical set against the tension coiled in her posture. Adora pointed. "Second rise. We'll wait downstream, past the second bend."

Catra nodded once—and was gone.

Adora didn't see her leave. One blink Catra was there; the next, the space she'd occupied was empty. Moments later, the hound's chain snapped taut with a jangle and the dog tore across the yard, barking its head off, straight for the paddock. The effect was immediate and catastrophic. Horses screamed and reared; rails shuddered, then split. Wood cracked. A flood of muscle and panic burst free—into Razz's gardens, into neighbouring fields, over the eastern hill—anywhere that wasn't confinement.

The dog's frantic joy only worsened it. Somewhere amid the chaos, ropes loosened themselves. Gates stood suddenly open. The impression was less of sabotage than haunting—an estate undone by a mischievous spirit.

Adora reached her own mount, jaw set, as distant shouts rose: "The horses! Round up the horses!" A useless order without horses to ride. There would be a great deal of running. A great deal of swearing.

She galloped back to the wagons and took the lead, pushing them as hard as she dared. Even at their best, they crawled—axles groaning, horses laboring. Adora urged them on with every ounce of will she had, a sensation like trying to command stone to flow like water. Heat pressed down from the open fields; scrub and rock stretched on, offering nowhere to hide.

Mermista's face was set, hard as flint. Double Trouble fidgeted, eyes too bright. They all knew the stakes, even if they felt unevenly distributed. Everyone here stood to lose everything—except maybe Glimmer.

When Adora glanced back, Glimmer met her look with mild curiosity, unruffled as ever.

“Trouble at Razz’s?” Glimmer asked lightly.

Adora didn’t answer. She leaned forward, reins tight, and drove them on toward the stream, the seconds ticking like a drumbeat behind her ribs.

The water ahead revealed itself in broken flashes of light through the trees, silver and deceptive. Relief flared too early. As soon as the lead wagon left the road and tipped down toward the bank, the wheels skidded, the whole frame shuddering sideways hard enough that Adora’s heart lurched with it. The second wagon followed with a sickening groan, axle protesting as it struck the stony bed. For one breathless moment it felt as if they had made the worst possible mistakes—driven themselves into a shallow trap, stalled and obvious, neatly framed for anyone watching from the rise above.

The water barely covered the stones, but it resisted them all the same. The horses strained and slipped. Adora didn’t hesitate. She jumped down, boots splashing, water soaking immediately through leather and cloth, and put her shoulder to the rear of the heavier wagon. She couldn’t call on She-Ra—not here, with open ground behind them—so it was down to muscle and grit and the raw ache of exertion. Twelve soldiers followed her lead without waiting for orders, sandals and boots churning the streambed as they leaned in together. The wagon moved by inches, then by reluctant degrees, until at last the current caught its wheels and nudged it into the water’s slow, curving path toward the trees.

The sound of hooves cracked through the air.

Adora’s head snapped up. “Cover. Now.”

They scattered urgently, dragging horses and themselves into the shadow of the copse. The timing was razor-thin. They reached concealment just as the patrol crested the rise at speed, white-

and-gold capes flaring behind them. Adora went still, every instinct screaming. Lonnie and the Horde soldiers clustered tight. 28 pulled a hood low, obscuring the telltale clone features. The Etherians mirrored the formation without comment.

Adora's attention flicked to the wagon. Mermista had Glimmer locked in a brutal, efficient hold from behind, one hand clamped over her mouth, the other braced hard at her shoulder. Glimmer didn't struggle. Her eyes were sharp, furious…but always calculating.

The patrol thundered closer. Adora saw everything at once: the torn leaves, the bent saplings, the churned earth where wagons had left the road. Evidence everywhere. Too much. She had the absurd, desperate urge to press a hand to her horse's muzzle, as if she could will silence into the animal.

The riders surged straight toward them—

—and then past.

They didn't slow. They didn't look. They tore down the road in the direction of Razz's, intent on the chaos waiting there.

The sound of hooves faded gradually, then all at once. No one moved. Adora counted in her head—slow, deliberate—before she lifted her chin in a single, quiet signal.

They moved again, easing the wagons forward, letting the stream swallow the tracks. Water splashed softly around hooves and wheels as they followed the curve downstream, deeper into cover. The heat thinned beneath the trees; shade cooled skin slick with sweat. The only sounds left were water over stone and the careful rhythm of their passage.

At the second meander, Adora raised her fist. They halted.

Minutes stretched. The forest seemed to listen with them.

A twig snapped.

Hands went to hilts as one. Horde and Etherian blades drawn without a whisper. Adora’s pulse hammered, but she didn’t move. Another twig cracked, closer.

Then she saw them: sharp ears cutting through green, a flash of a white dress, a familiar, fluid grace slipping between trunks.

“You took your time,” Adora said quietly.

Catra stepped fully into view, dress smudged at the hem, hair slightly wild, eyes bright with something sharp and pleased. “I didn’t come empty-handed.”

She tossed something. Adora caught it on reflex—one of Razz's apples, warm from the sun.

A ripple of soundless approval moved through Catra’s soldiers. The Etherians stared, still processing. Mermista swung Catra’s reins toward her without ceremony.

“Is this how you do things in the Horde?” Mermista asked, voice dry.

Catra’s mouth curved as she took the reins and vaulted into the saddle in one smooth motion. “You mean successfully?”

✧

The risk to the horses was constant, a low thrum of anxiety that never left Adora’s mind. One misjudged step on slick shale, one wheel catching wrong in a pocket of softer silt, and they would be stranded with a lame animal and two immovable wagons. Progress along the stream was painstakingly slow. Riders went ahead in pairs, dismounting often to test the depth and pace of the water, checking that the bed stayed shallow and forgiving, that the current didn’t tighten into something that could drag at axles and legs alike. Adora stayed near the rear wagon, eyes always moving, counting horses, counting people, listening to the water rushing against the wood.

When the light began to tilt toward late afternoon, she raised a hand and called for a halt. The wagons were guided up onto a narrow bank where an outcrop of dark stone jutted out, breaking the line of sight from any distant road. Obsidian fragments lay scattered there too—ruins, old and half-swallowed by moss and vines. Only the suggestion of a wall remained, glossy black stone dulled by time and weather. Adora recognised the landscape at once. She had seen the same architecture near Weave's Slope, and again closer to the border: remnants of something older than the war, older than the Horde. The stones seemed to drink in the light.

A fire was built carefully, shielded by rock and ruin. Keston and Juliet vanished downstream and returned not long after with fish skewered neatly through the gills. They baked them wrapped in broad leaves, flesh turning white and flaky over the coals. Fortified wine was uncorked and passed around, sweet and sharp, a luxury compared to the usual fare of hard bread and cheese. The horses were tethered and allowed to graze what little they could find, their soft snorts and the gentle tearing of grass oddly comforting.

Lonnie and Clone 28 took first watch without ceremony, moving off into the darkening trees. The rest of them drifted toward the fire and sat in a loose semicircle, boots stretched toward the warmth. When Adora joined them, the shift was immediate and awkward—everyone scrambling to their feet as if yanked by invisible strings. She froze, half-sitting, half-standing, mortified.

Earlier, Catra had tossed her a bedroll with a lazy, "Unpack this," and Keston had looked ready to challenge her to a duel on Adora's behalf. The idea of their Queen eating fish on a log beside them was clearly not covered in anyone's training.

Adora solved it the only way she knew how. She sat down anyway. She poured herself a shallow cup of wine and then, without comment, handed it to the soldier beside her. Keston stared at it. The silence stretched while he visibly summoned

every scrap of courage he possessed before finally taking it with a stiff nod, cheeks burning.

Catra chose that moment—she wandered over as if nothing were amiss, dropped onto the log next to Adora with her usual careless grace, and launched—without preamble and without inflection—into the story of the brothel incident that had earned her a green dress. It was spectacularly obscene. Clone 28 went green almost instantly. Keston laughed so hard he had to wipe his eyes. The Horde soldiers asked blunt, fascinated questions; Catra answered them with equal bluntness. Opinions about brothels were shared, misunderstood, corrected, and misunderstood again, until everything collapsed into helpless laughter.

The wine went around again.

Not to be outdone, the Etherians told their side of the escape: the crouching in the stream bed, the wagons crawling like wounded beasts, the frantic stillness behind ferns as patrols thundered past. Keston did an exaggerated imitation of the Medic Clone on horseback that had Lonnie and Catra wheezing. Clone 28 watched Keston with open admiration. It wasn't the performance that held his attention.

Adora bit into the apple Catra had given her, juice running over her lips, sweet and bright on her tongue. For a while, she let herself forget the road ahead, the pursuit they were outrunning by what felt like inches. When she finally rose to claim the bedroll she'd unpacked earlier, the group remembered again who she was—but the stiffness didn't return.

She lay back on the thin padding, staring up at the branches overhead, listening to low voices, the crackle of the fire, the soft sounds of camp settling into sleep.

The soft tread of footsteps pulled Adora out of the loose, drifting state she'd sunk into. For a split second her body went tight, reflexive and ready, until the sound resolved itself into something familiar: the whisper of fabric, the muted thump of a bedroll

hitting the earth beside her. Catra settled down with the easy confidence of someone who belonged wherever she chose to lie, stretching out on her side so close that Adora could feel the warmth of her through the thin layers between them. Above them, the sky was an endless spill of stars, cold and bright and impossibly far away.

"You smell like a horse," Adora said, the words escaping her before she could soften them. There was no edge in her voice—only fondness, faint amusement.

Catra huffed quietly. "Occupational hazard. It's how I slipped past the dog."

A pulse of happiness, sudden and unguarded, flared in Adora's chest. She didn't answer right away. She lay flat on her back, hands folded loosely over her stomach, eyes tracing constellations she half-recognised from childhood lessons she'd never quite paid attention to. The night felt wide open around them, as if the world had briefly loosened its grip.

"It feels like old times…" Adora searched for the right words. "Like something familiar." She paused, then admitted, quieter, "Even though I don't think I've ever really had nights like this."

"This is my first proper tour of Etheria," Catra said, a note of dry irony threading through the words.

Adora turned her head. "And? First impressions?"

Catra made a thoughtful noise. "It's like the Fright Zone," she decided, "but someone turned the saturation up and added a ridiculous amount of sparkles."

Adora laughed under her breath. When she looked back, Catra had shifted onto her side fully, propped slightly on one elbow, watching her. Their positions mirrored each other without effort, a symmetry that felt intimate in a way Adora hadn't anticipated.

"I *do* smell," Catra went on. "Truly unforgivable. I'm counting that stream right there as a personal blessing."

"You're not seriously suggesting you wander around the Etherian countryside naked in the middle of the night," Adora said, arching a brow. Then, with a grin she couldn't suppress, "Besides—I smell just as much like horse as you do."

Catra's mouth curved. "I disagree. You've been marinating in it longer. Its so much worse."

In the moonlight, Catra looked smaller somehow, a scrappy silhouette edged in silver. Beyond her, the camp lay quiet—shapes of bedrolls, the dim outline of wagons, the dark gleam of obsidian ruins half-swallowed by shadow. Those stones would outlast all of them, Adora thought. They would crumble slowly, grain by grain, and slide into the water long after the names of queens and wars were forgotten.

"They're ancient," Adora murmured, gaze drifting to the ruins. "First Ones, maybe even older. People say it was a civilisation that thought it would last forever."

Catra followed her line of sight. "Like the structures near Weave's Slope," she said. She didn't mention the border.

Catra's breathing was slow and even now, relaxed. Adora surprised herself by speaking again, the words tumbling out before doubt could catch them.

"There's a palace—Mystacor," she said. "My aunt oversees it. It's quieter than Bright Moon—cool in the summer, lots of water, gardens that smell like jasmine. Most of the students go home when the term ends, so it gets… peaceful." She swallowed, heart beating faster for no reason she could justify. "When all of this is over… we could disappear there for a week. Just us."

She hadn't let herself talk about after. Not since Cazzle Cove. The silence that followed stretched, taut but not uncomfortable. She

felt Catra holding herself very still, as if considering the invitation was a task in itself.

Then, softly, Catra said, “I’d like that.”

The words settled into Adora like warmth. She rolled back onto her spine, eyes returning to the vast sweep of stars overhead, and let herself feel it—hope, fragile and bright, threading through her very being.

Chapter End Notes

I know, I know. This feels like the calm before the storm.

And it sort of is.

But!

Happy ending tag. I promise to keep to that.

Chapter 33: Catra

Chapter Notes

> This chapter is what I have lovingly refer to as a "shit sandwich"
> It's going to be sweet and happy, then pretty upsetting, then happy again, (yay?)
>
> TW: mention of CSA and SA with CSA undertones.
>
> Thank you to my beta reader whom I forgot to give a heads up or trigger warning to 😗

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra had once teased Adora about the careful, deliberate way she slept. They'd shared spaces that barely deserved the name "bed": a threadbare tent in the Crimson Wastes, borrowed rooms, makeshift camps. They had lain side by side countless times without ever drifting together by accident. If Catra worried about temptation, it had always been her own. Adora, faced with it, treated closeness like a line she would not cross unless explicitly invited. Maybe it was the scars on her back, reminders that touch could wound as easily as it could comfort. Or maybe Adora simply possessed a kind of discipline Catra had never encountered before.

Whatever the reason, morning found Catra waking alone.She lay on her side, back turned toward the place Adora had been, the only proof of her presence a strip of flattened grass and a lingering sense of warmth that had already started to fade. For a few long seconds, Catra couldn't piece together where she was or why everything ached. Sleeping on the ground after a long ride was bad enough; add a late night spent wrapped in too much heat and too little rest, and her body made its displeasure known. She scowled as Adora appeared in her line of vision—already

dressed, already alert, already infuriatingly awake—and knelt in front of her.

"No," Catra said immediately.

Adora blinked. "No?"

"Whatever you're about to do. No. Go away."

Adora only smiled and gestured behind her. "You sure?" She tugged back the cloth covering what she'd brought, letting the steam curl upward. The smell hit Catra a beat later—dark, bitter, unmistakable. "I made it."

Catra accepted the cup without ceremony and deliberately didn't inhale. "What are your soldiers going to think," she muttered, irritation sharpened by the loneliness still creeping in from her awakening.

Adora, long practiced in navigating Catra's morning moods, didn't flinch. "They'll be grateful I didn't ruin the Horde Princess's sacred drink," she said lightly. "So—did I remember how to make it?"

It was perfect. Of course it was. Catra took a sip and clicked her tongue. "Acceptable," she said, because giving Adora the truth would only encourage her. "It's not complicated. I hope you didn't exhaust yourself. If you're really that eager to be useful, you could rub my back and eat me out."

Somewhere nearby, metal clattered and Mermista swore. Adora didn't seem to notice.

"Ambitious," Adora said, amusement warming her voice as she reached out to smooth Catra's disheveled hair. Catra tolerated it, sipping again, the edge of her temper slowly dulling. "I'm good," Adora added, "but even I have limits."

Catra huffed, more awake now. "You're reasonably clever for an Etherian," she said. "I'm sure you could improvise, given sufficient incentive."

Adora was smiling—open, unguarded, infuriatingly radiant in the early light, surrounded by the bustle of soldiers breaking camp. Her affection was written plainly across her face, though she still seemed convinced that letting anyone see it would be improper. Catra watched her for a moment longer, coffee warming her hands, and wondered—as she often did—how someone could be so obvious and so oblivious at the same time.

Catra caught the way Adora's eyes flicked toward the folded white dress at the edge of the bedroll before she even spoke.

"Are you planning to wear it today?" Adora asked, carefully casual in a way that fooled absolutely no one.

Catra smiled into her cup. "Do you think you've earned that privilege?" she shot back, letting her gaze drift pointedly over herself before returning to Adora's face. "I notice certain obligations remain… unmet."

Adora's mouth curved instantly, heat flashing through her expression. She didn't bother pretending she hadn't understood. Her attention swept Catra from head to toe, slow and appreciative. "You know exactly how tempting that sounds."

"Oh?" Catra lifted a brow. "And yet here we are, with coffee instead."

That only seemed to delight Adora more. She stepped closer, large hand settling at Catra's thigh as if it belonged there—which, frankly, it did. Catra basked in it, in the clean, blinding focus of being the sole thing on Adora's mind. She raised her cup just as Adora leaned in, forcing a brief detour that sent Adora's mouth to the curve of her neck instead.Victory. Pure and simple.

Adora's lips brushed her neck with infuriating restraint—light, lingering, calculated to unravel her as thoroughly as possible. Catra kept her composure with steady restraint, sipping her coffee as though nothing at all were happening, save for her sliding Adora's hand higher up her thigh. Adora huffed a quiet laugh,

fingers tightening, her other hand sweeping Catra's hair aside so she could press a kiss to her shoulder. Catra made a soft sound she absolutely refused to account for.

Then Glimmer's voice cut through the moment.

"The *Queen* of Etheria, indulging her Horde pet in full view of the camp," she drawled. "I suppose humiliation is part of the appeal? Or is that particular skill taught in the Fright Zone?"

Adora stilled.

She didn't turn. She didn't snap back. But Catra saw it—the flare of anger, banked hard under discipline. Glimmer stood a short distance away, newly released from the wagon under Baker's watch, proud and clearly aching to draw blood with words alone. She made sure they carried, even as Baker maintained the polite fiction of a morning stroll.Around them, the soldiers pretended very diligently not to notice. The Etherians kept their eyes down. The Horde troops didn't bother; if anything, the sight seemed to amuse them.

Adora straightened slowly. "We're moving out," she said evenly, first to Catra, then louder, to the column behind them. "Keston—escort her back to the wagon."

Catra hadn't expected the offered hand. She took it anyway, allowing Adora to pull her up with a quietly defiant intimacy. Adora's ears were faintly pink, but her posture was impeccable—every inch the Queen, even when provoked.

As Catra leaned close enough to hear, Adora muttered under her breath, frowning, "She wouldn't so much as loosen a pin unless the sheets were silk."

Catra's smile returned, sharp and satisfied.



They rolled back into motion with less friction than Catra had expected. Horde discipline showed itself in their efficiency: lines re-formed, tack checked, wheels aligned, everyone moving with the quiet competence of soldiers who had broken camp under worse conditions than this. The Etherians followed suit, a little stiffer, a little more careful, but they had learned Adora's standards quickly enough. The true test was the stream—finding a pace slow enough not to snap an axle or lame a horse, but fast enough that they weren't lingering where tracks could be read like an open book.

Morale held, oddly. The Horde soldiers were relaxed, joking under their breath, while the Etherians carried a taut, inward focus that never quite eased. After an hour of steady progress, Catra swung down from her horse and stepped up into the supply wagon, more out of curiosity than concern.

She paused with her hand on the latch.Voices filtered through the thin wood.

"She's not built to rule," Double Trouble was saying, their voice pitched low but sharp with irritation. "That's the long and short of it. You can dress it up all you like, but she doesn't have the instincts."

Catra leaned closer to the narrow window. Inside, the scene was exactly as she'd imagined: Baker seated upright, back straight, hands folded; Glimmer sprawled against the stacked cloth like a queen in exile, eyes bright with quiet malice; Double Trouble pacing the cramped length of the wagon, bracing themselves whenever the wheels struck a rut. The wagon lurched again, and Double Trouble caught themselves with a flailing hand—right atop Baker's hair. Baker looked up at them with glacial contempt. Double Trouble didn't notice.

"You made your bargain," Baker said coldly, batting their hand away. "You will honour it. For Entrapta's sake, if nothing else."

“And if this all collapses?” Double Trouble snapped. “If she fails—or worse, succeeds and drags us into ruin with her?”

Baker’s expression didn’t change. “We passed ‘ruin’ some time ago. Do you truly believe your former master would welcome you back after this?”

“He would listen,” Double Trouble insisted. “I’d explain.”

Baker’s voice dropped, lethal in its calm. “This clone of Entrapta is too old to interest Prime. Or were you planning to play the part again?”

Double Trouble froze. The wagon rocked, nearly sending them sprawling, and they had to grab a crate to stay upright. When they spoke again, their bravado had cracked.

“What was I supposed to do?” they demanded, anger and shame tangled tight. “There were no clean choices. The Fright Zone was tearing itself apart. Anyone who stood in the way was removed.”

“And you told yourself that made it acceptable,” Baker said. “That it wasn’t you raping her, that it wasn’t *really* you when he did the same to you?”“You don’t understand—”

“I understand perfectly,” Baker cut in. “You chose power. Do not insult me by pretending otherwise.”

Silence fell hard inside the wagon, the kind that pressed on the ears. From her improvised nest of folded bolts and threadbare blankets, Glimmer watched it unfold with open fascination, eyes bright, posture loose, as though she were ringside at a prize fight. She didn’t interrupt. Baker and Double Trouble had forgotten her entirely.

Baker’s anger remained frozen—no raised voice, no wasted movement. She stood perfectly still, spine straight, gaze fixed on Double Trouble with a severity that made even Catra, listening from outside, feel the chill. This was not a mood Baker slipped into often, and it showed in how unprepared Double Trouble was

for it. They looked rattled, thrown off balance in a way Catra rarely saw. Baker's disapproval was not loud, but it was absolute.

At last, Double Trouble inhaled sharply, as if pulling themselves together. "Prime understands my value," they said, a brittle confidence creeping into their tone. "That slut out there doesn't. She's reckless, ignorant—she'll burn the Fright Zone to the ground."

"And the Fright Zone," Baker replied coolly, "is what concerns you most?"

"Obviously," Double Trouble snapped, seizing on the point as though it were self-evident.

Baker's stare sharpened into something lethal.

Double Trouble ploughed on, emboldened by their own momentum. "I won't back someone rotten at the core," they said. "Someone who lies, manipulates, hides behind others. The worst calamity the Fright Zone has ever faced."

Baker tilted her head a fraction. "You'll have to clarify," she said. "Are you describing Prime, or Catra? I do get muddled when you're vague. Which of them likes to fuck children again?"

Double Trouble flicked a glance toward Glimmer, recalculating. The exchange had slipped into rapid Horde-Etherian, dense with scandalous information, and it was unclear how much Glimmer grasped—but her attention was unmistakable. Catra could practically hear the mental arithmetic ticking over: risk, audience, consequences.

Contempt won.

"Those kids should have been grateful," Double Trouble said, voice hardening. "Prime's attention was an opportunity. Guidance. Advancement. A small price to pay for access to power."

Baker echoed them softly. "A small price?"

“Protection. Resources. Wealth. Knowledge,” Double Trouble continued, listing it off like ledger entries. “That’s more than most of them would ever see otherwise.”

Baker stepped closer. Her voice did not rise. “And you expect me to believe that handing Entrapta over to him was an act of generosity?” she asked. “That Entrapta was helped by this? That she emerged better, stronger, safer?”

She held Double Trouble’s gaze, unblinking. “If that’s what you believe,” Baker said quietly, “say it. Say she was better for it.”

The wagon rocked over uneven ground. Double Trouble swayed, caught themselves—and did not answer.

For a heartbeat, Double Trouble had nothing. No clever retort, no sharpened barb ready to throw back. They simply stared at Baker, momentum stolen, swaying with the uneven roll of the wagon as if the ground itself had knocked the air from their lungs. When the wheels struck another rut, they lurched, catching themselves on a crate with an inelegant grab that would have been laughable if the air inside the wagon wasn’t so charged.

Baker didn’t move to help them. She didn’t even blink.“The nights she came to me crying,” Baker said quietly, each word measured, weighted. “The nights Entrapta clutched at my apron, and you ordered your guards to send her away.”

Double Trouble straightened, anger flaring as instinct. “The Fright Zone survived because of what she gave him,” they snapped. “It was expected of her—”

“The way she begged,” Baker cut in, her voice breaking sharp despite herself. “The way she fought to stay when they dragged her out of my kitchen.”

Double Trouble sighed harshly. “Everyone endures things they'd rather avoid. It’s part of growing into power. She adapted.”

Baker took a step forward. “You had soldiers force her into his chambers,” she said. “You kept her there until he was done with her.”

“Sucking cock,” Double Trouble insisted, desperation creeping into their tone, “is a valuable skill. Especially for a princess.”

“You destroyed her,” Baker said. They stood locked there, neither yielding. Glimmer watched from her improvised throne of cloth and blankets, eyes flicking between them, absorbing every fracture, every confession. Catra, listening from the other side of the wagon wall, felt something coil tight in her chest.

Baker’s fury wasn’t loud. It lived in the rigid set of her shoulders, the way her hands trembled only when she curled them into fists. She had been powerless then—unable to intervene, unable to stop it. Perhaps she had tried to believe the stories she’d been told. Perhaps she had clung to the lie that Prime’s favour could not come at such a cost. That Double Trouble, for all their ambition, would not barter a princess’s virtue like coin.

At last, Double Trouble spoke again, brittle and defensive. “Prime’s appetites were inevitable,” they said. “And she—she betrayed us all in the end by killing herself.”

“You traded her,” Baker replied, voice cold as iron. “For nothing but your own advancement.”

Silence swallowed the wagon once more. Catra waited, breath held. Outside, the soldiers riding guard did an admirable job of not looking at the wagon, not listening too closely.

“You’re upset,” Double Trouble said finally, trying for reason, for control.

“You’re damn right I am.”

“And you’re mourning,” they pressed. “While I—”

“While you walked away untouched,” Baker said.

Double Trouble hesitated, then sank down onto a crate, the fight bleeding out of them in a slow collapse. "You never were good at seeing the larger picture," they said, quieter now. "I did this for Hell's Rest. For Dryl. Entrapta would have been gone for good if Prime hadn't had access to her—to clone her. For the Fright Zone. Baker, I—"

"You did it for yourself," Baker said, without hesitation. "And you will honour the alliance you swore to Catra. If you betray her—"

She leaned in just enough that there was no mistaking the promise in her eyes.

"I will kill you myself."

✵

Things were so close to perfect that Catra was starting to get suspicious.If she had been given the luxury of design—if someone had handed her the last handful of days of her life and asked her to arrange them to her taste—there was very little she would have changed. She could catalogue the irritations easily, because that was how her mind worked: the heat that pressed down on them in the afternoons and turned clothing into a second skin; the way privacy existed only in theory when you travelled with wagons and soldiers; the knowledge that one of those wagons held people she would rather not think about too closely. Mermista of Salineas was there, which was its own ongoing inconvenience. Her back ached constantly. Sleep came with the sharp edge of pain. And always, threaded through everything, there was the quiet, inevitable understanding of what waited for her at the end of this road—slow, deliberate cruelty, carefully tailored to hurt and hurt and hurt until she was dead.

All of that was real.And still—almost perfect.For most of her life, Catra had existed as merely an inmate who had learned the rules well enough to survive. Prime's control had not been loud at first. It had been velvet-soft, suffocating, closing around her with smiles and gifts and the promise of power, until the Velvet Glove

became a cage with bars she couldn't see. Every step she took had been measured. Every word weighed. Every expression trained out of her face before it could betray anything useful. There had always been eyes. Always someone listening. Even alone, she had never truly been unwatched. Her thoughts had become something dangerous, something to be tightly leashed and locked away.Here, now, she was outside.

The air was real. It filled her lungs until it almost hurt. She had a good horse beneath her, responsive and strong, a living thing that moved when she asked it to move. She had dirt under her nails and wind on her face and the sky stretching wide and indifferent above them. She wasn't pacing a room or circling the same carefully arranged furniture, plotting ten moves in advance just to exist without consequence. She was moving forward, literally and figuratively, and for once the road ahead wasn't entirely made of traps she'd laid for herself.

At night, they stopped and made camp, and Catra sat near the fire with people who laughed too loudly and argued over nothing and teased one another with the easy familiarity of soldiers who still expected to wake up the next morning. She watched Etherians and Horde soldiers sit side by side, initially stiff and cautious, then gradually loosening—hands gesturing as they talked, voices overlapping. She listened with a kind of sharp, private pleasure as the Etherians stumbled over Horde-Etherian words, tripping on the density of the language, its heavy syntax and layered meanings. Their own tongue was spare, elegant, built on implication and shared context. Horde-Etherian demanded effort. It demanded attention. Watching them try mattered more to her than she would ever admit.It was small. It was fragile. But it was peace, in its most unremarkable form—people who might once have killed each other on sight now sharing food and bad wine and stories. Catra took a fierce, quiet pride in it.

Shadow Weaver would have despised every part of this. The lack of control. The improvisation. The sheer recklessness of it. This wasn't a plan born of ritual or hierarchy or obedience; it was motion, risk, momentum. It was the kind of story Catra had once

devoured in secret, before the world had taught her better—smuggling routes and narrow escapes, travelling light and fast with nothing but your wits and the people at your side. Crawling through a stream bed with wagons made her feel more alive than any of the gladiatorial pageantry Prime had ever staged. Filth and exhaustion were always preferable to silk and chains.

Her body hurt. She was bruised and sore and perpetually unclean.

She had never felt more alive.

And when the sun set…night was the thing she allowed herself to treasure most, even knowing it was temporary. She laid her bedding down beside Adora of Etheria, of all people. The woman she had once despised with her whole heart. The woman whose presence now anchored her in a way nothing else ever had. They didn't touch much. They didn't fuck at all, despite Catra's persistent commentary on the matter. Adora was too Etherian about it—too concerned with propriety, with the imagined scandal of soldiers knowing what their Queen did beneath her blankets. It was ridiculous. It was infuriating. It was…endearing, in a way Catra didn't mind too much.

Even without touch, Catra felt her there: the warmth of her body, the steady rhythm of her breathing, the simple fact of another person choosing to lie beside her and stay. The echoes of Adora were still everywhere in her physical memory, yes, but also deeper than that. A presence carved out and claimed without permission, lodged somewhere beneath her ribs. Love, stubborn and undeniable.And above all else—this was what mattered most, now, at the end of everything she could see coming.

She wasn't alone.

On the third day, Catra guided her horse up alongside Mermista's without ceremony. She didn't soften her approach or disguise her intent. She never had been good at pretending to be polite.

“You and I should probably call a ceasefire,” Catra said, glancing sideways at her. Catra made a point of brightening her tone, purely out of spite. “I can be delightful, you know,” she said lightly. “When properly motivated.”

She let the words hang there.

Mermista didn’t answer. She rode stiff-backed, shoulders set as if braced for impact, reins held a little too tight. Catra could practically see the tension creeping up her spine, the way her neck thickened when she was trying not to react. A muscle jumped in her jaw. Somewhere behind them, Clone 28 was earnestly mangling First Ones grammar to Keston’s helpless amusement; the Salinean was laughing so hard he nearly slid out of his saddle.

“I don’t make truces with stingrays,” Mermista snapped at last, unable to contain it any longer. “And there’s nothing charming about poison wrapped in sugar.”

Catra inspected her own hands, grimy beneath the nails from days on the road, as if this conversation were only of mild interest. Her lack of reaction only seemed to make Mermista bristle more.

“Really?” Catra said mildly. “You didn’t seem to find me nearly so offensive in writing.”

“I didn’t know what you’d done to my friend.”

Catra’s eyes flicked up then, sharp despite the casual slouch of her posture.

“It’s her body,” she said. “Not yours. If Adora’s decided to forgive me, why are you so determined to carry the grudge for her?”

Mermista snorted. “Because I’m not obligated to be a saint,” she shot back. “Adora loves like it’s a reflex. Once you’re in, she’ll defend you until the end of the world. I’m not built that way, and I’m not ashamed of it.”

“Oh, look at that,” Catra said cheerfully. “We have common ground already.

The brightness in her voice was enough that Adora—riding ahead, focused on the road—glanced back over her shoulder. The sight of Catra and Mermista riding abreast made her hesitate, confusion written plainly across her face. Catra lifted a hand and waved. Adora’s confusion deepened.

“We have nothing in common,” Mermista said flatly. “And don’t insult my intelligence by pretending this is about feelings. How convenient that your love for her surfaced precisely when it served you best.”

Catra opened her mouth to reply just as Adora turned her horse and began threading back toward them. Behind Catra, Clone 28’s voice rang out again—

“Suck my flaccid—”

—and whatever the rest of the sentence had been was lost to Keston’s wheezing laughter.

“I’m not unreasonable,” Mermista went on, voice hard. “We can put you in chains. Let you feel what she felt. Let you receive the punishment she received. Then maybe—*maybe*—I’d listen to you talk about truces.”

Catra’s smile thinned, but it didn’t disappear.

“You think I’ve never paid for anything I’ve done?”

“I think you don’t even know what suffering looks like.”

Catra laughed—not because it was funny, but because that sound was better than any alternative that came to mind. She was still shaking her head when Adora reached them, circling her horse briefly before falling into step at Catra’s side.

“What did I miss?” Adora asked carefully.

Mermista didn’t look at Catra when she answered. “Your Horde Princess is attempting to *delight* me.”

The dryness in her voice left no room for optimism. Adora’s concern evaporated almost instantly, replaced by a crooked, unguarded grin that was far too soft for the situation.

“She is delightful,” Adora said without hesitation. Mermista stared at her. Adora’s grin only widened as she amended, fond and unapologetic, “When she decides to be.”

Catra had learned that clear thought simply stopped being an option when Adora looked at her like that. It wasn’t just affection. It was recognition. Those bright, earnest eyes didn’t skim the surface; they cut straight through, past Catra’s armour and her clever mouth and her practiced indifference, down into the places she kept sealed off even from herself. The places that still wanted impossible things: absolution, safety, an ending where the monsters were named and destroyed and she didn’t have to become one to survive. It had been days since they’d touched, days of restraint and watchfulness and stolen looks instead of hands, and the absence ached like a phantom limb. Part of her wanted to close the distance, to steal warmth and solidity and forget, briefly, what waited at the end of this road.

Instead, Catra tilted her chin and let her voice cool into something sharp and faintly bored. “Hey, Adora.” she drawled.

Adora didn’t rise to the playful taunt. She never did when it mattered. The warmth in her expression didn’t flicker, didn’t retreat, and that was somehow worse. She turned her head toward Mermista, whose face hovered in a state of perpetual recalibration—revulsion giving way to suspicion, suspicion to open disbelief.

“I swear,” Adora said easily, “she grows on you.”

“Like mold,” Catra supplied, helpfully.

“When?” Mermista snapped, the word dragged low and tight, as if she were daring one of them to answer.

Adora didn’t. Or she chose not to hear it. Instead, she shifted her grip on the reins and spoke as if they were discussing the weather. “We should be able to move back onto the main road in another day or two. The scouts haven’t found any sign that the patrols near Razz’s raised an alarm, or doubled back.”

“Fantastic,” Mermista said flatly. She shook her head, reins snapping once as she gathered them up. When Adora frowned at her, she didn’t soften. “I’ll check the trail. Make sure no one’s gotten clever.”

She wheeled her horse away without waiting for approval.

Adora watched her go, brow creasing with quiet concern, and Catra felt the familiar twist settle in her chest. *It’s just as well I don’t have a future*, she thought with a kind of bleak clarity. If she did—if this weren’t a borrowed stretch of time with a blade hanging over it—Adora would be pulled apart by this forever. Lover on one side. Friend on the other. Two loyalties that refused to bend, each righteous in its own way.Mermista wouldn’t fade quietly. Catra knew that much. And Catra herself—she laughed silently at the idea—would never have stepped aside graciously, never surrendered the sheer, destabilizing force of Adora’s love to someone else’s prior claim. They would have shredded her between them, inch by inch, without meaning to.

“You spend most mornings with Baker,” Adora said suddenly, “or with the Medic Clone.”

Catra blinked and dragged herself back into the present. Adora’s attention was fully on her now—not soft, not indulgent, but measuring. That shift set Catra’s instincts humming.

“They’re my allies,” Catra replied. Even to her own ears, the answer landed wrong: too clipped, too guarded. The kind of response that belonged in war councils, not conversations

between lovers. She felt the atmosphere tighten, the way it always did when Adora's open affection gave way to the careful gravity she brought to command. Catra didn't mind business—but she hated circling it.

"When Glimmer's allowed out to walk," Adora continued, "you're usually the one escorting her."

Catra arched a brow. "Can you think of anyone better suited? I'm all ears."

Adora didn't bite. She let the comment slide, which told Catra more than if she had snapped back. Her gaze stayed steady, thoughtful, threading connections together.

"And now, Mermista," Adora went on.Catra waited, curiosity piqued despite herself. She knew that look. Adora was assembling a picture, piece by piece, and whatever conclusion she was approaching—it wasn't going to be flattering.

Adora waited.

She had settled into that infuriating stillness she adopted when she thought patience would win her something—hands easy on the reins, posture relaxed, eyes forward, as though the answer she wanted would simply rise to the surface if she allowed the silence to stretch long enough. She wasn't looking at Catra, which somehow made it worse. She was waiting for Catra to volunteer. To soften. To confess. To give up.The thought made Catra's mouth twitch.

Hilarious.

"What is it, lover?" Catra drawled at last, letting the word curl with deliberate sweetness. "Don't tell me you're jealous."

Adora turned then, frowning in that very particular way she reserved for moments when Catra had veered sharply off whatever careful emotional road she was trying to pave. It wasn't anger. It wasn't disappointment. It was that quiet, wounded

irritation that suggested Adora believed Catra was being difficult on purpose.

"Catra," Adora said.

Catra batted her lashes. "Relax. No one in camp is even remotely threatening your position. You remain the undisputed owner of the largest cock on Etheria."

"That's not what I mean," Adora said, too quickly. Her tone carried the unmistakable message of *I know you understand me and you're choosing not to engage*. Which—annoyingly—was not true. Catra could follow a battlefield. She could follow a lie. She could follow five layers of manipulation stacked into a single sentence.

This? This was Etherian emotional obfuscation. And it was much more difficult for her to parse.

"Then please," Catra said, a little sharper now, "enlighten me. What, precisely, are you asking?"

She was dimly aware of the absurdity of it: Adora, of all people, circling and hedging, trying to be delicate; Catra, usually the one playing three moves ahead, forced into bluntness by sheer confusion. Adora, however, seemed entirely unaware of the reversal.

She drew a breath, then said it plainly, without armour or preamble. "I want you to let me in."

The words landed wrong. Too earnest. Too soft. Too close to something Catra didn't have the patience or the security for.

Annoyance flared, hot and immediate."I already did," Catra snapped. "Days ago. And for the record, it still aches a little sometimes."

Adora exhaled slowly, the sound rough. Her gaze slid away to the road ahead, jaw tightening as her hands closed more firmly around the reins. Whatever warmth she'd been carrying—the

open, lovesick glow—was gone now, shuttered behind something more controlled. Catra had chased it off. As usual.Good, she told herself. Good.

“You’re planning something,” Adora said after a moment.

“Always,” Catra replied easily. “But you’re stitching together nonsense and calling it intuition. Very Horde of you, actually—except you don’t know what you’re doing yet. I’d applaud the effort if you weren’t dragging this out past your capability .”

A voice broke in behind them, sudden and entirely unwelcome.

“You want the big cock?” Clone 28 announced in painstaking, disastrous First Ones.

Keston laughed so hard his horse was veered accidentally into 28's.

Catra didn’t turn around. Adora didn’t either.

They rode on.

The silence that followed was not the sharp, volatile kind Catra knew well—the kind that preceded shouting or violence or spectacular emotional collapse. This was smaller. Denser. It sat between them like an unspoken grievance, domestic and unfamiliar, and Catra didn’t know what to do with it.Adora said nothing for the next hour. No teasing. No attempts at reconciliation. Just the steady rhythm of riding, her presence taut and withdrawn beside Catra. It was… unsettling. There was hurt there, Catra realised belatedly—not grand, operatic hurt, but something quieter.

And that, somehow, bothered her more than rage ever could.This wasn’t the tension of enemies. It wasn’t the tension of lovers fighting over blood and betrayal and survival. Catra wasn’t pushing Adora away. She wasn’t trying to wound her. She was just irritated. And Adora—damn her—was hurt by it. After an hour, the sheer ordinariness of it began to sink in. That was what unsettled

Catra most. There was no grand betrayal hanging between them, no blood on the ground, no impossible choice demanding sacrifice. Just this—an unresolved misunderstanding, a quiet, stubborn hurt that had taken root and refused to die. Adora's silence was not weaponised, not strategic. It was rhe kind of silence that came from feeling shut out rather than wronged.

The intimacy of it pressed in on Catra's chest until she started to have trouble breathing evenly.

Mile by mile, the sharp heat of her irritation bled away, leaving behind something slower and heavier. She rode beside Adora as she had for hours now, their horses matching pace, their shoulders close enough that a careless shift would cause contact. Catra began to steal glances even as she pretended not to—at the line of Adora's jaw, set too tight; the way her shoulders stayed squared forward, disciplined even in hurt; the rigid care with which she kept her attention fixed on the road ahead.

There had been a time when Catra had hated her so fiercely that the smallest opportunity to wound her would have felt like a gift. Back then, hurting Adora had been simple. Satisfying. Worth whatever punishment followed.

This was different. This hurt had weight because it was undeserved.

The bubble between them had grown without either of them noticing—two royals riding just far enough behind the wagons that the sounds of the group blurred into the background. Hooves, wind, the creak of leather. Privacy born of exhaustion rather than intent.Catra broke first.

"I wanted to understand Glimmer," she said, abruptly, before she could talk herself out of it.

Adora startled in her saddle, a sharp, instinctive movement, and turned to look at her like she wasn't quite sure she'd heard correctly. Catra felt a flicker of irritation at herself for that alone.

“That’s why I’ve been escorting her,” Catra continued, voice deliberately even. “When she’s allowed out. I’ve got Baker reporting on her as well. It’s not—” she paused, searching for the least vulnerable phrasing, “—anything more than curiosity.”

“Curiosity,” Adora echoed.

“Yes.” Catra lifted her chin slightly. “I want to know who she is. I want to know who *you* were, when you loved her.”

The words hung between them, exposed and unarmoured.

“You could ask me,” Adora said, quietly.Catra blinked. She hadn’t expected that. Hadn’t even considered it, really.

“How very direct,” Catra said at last.

“It didn’t occur to you I might answer?” Adora asked, and there it was—that warmth creeping back into her expression, cautious but unmistakable, like sunlight edging its way under a closed door.

“No,” Catra said flatly.

Adora’s mouth twitched. Slowly, inexorably, she began to smile.

Catra scowled at her. “Don’t.”

“Don’t what?”

“Don’t look at me like that.”

“Like what?”

“Like you’ve just won something,” Catra snapped. “Wipe that expression off your face.”

“I wouldn’t call it winning,” Adora said, far too pleased with herself to be convincing.

“Amusement, then,” Catra growled. “And I’m serious—stop it.”

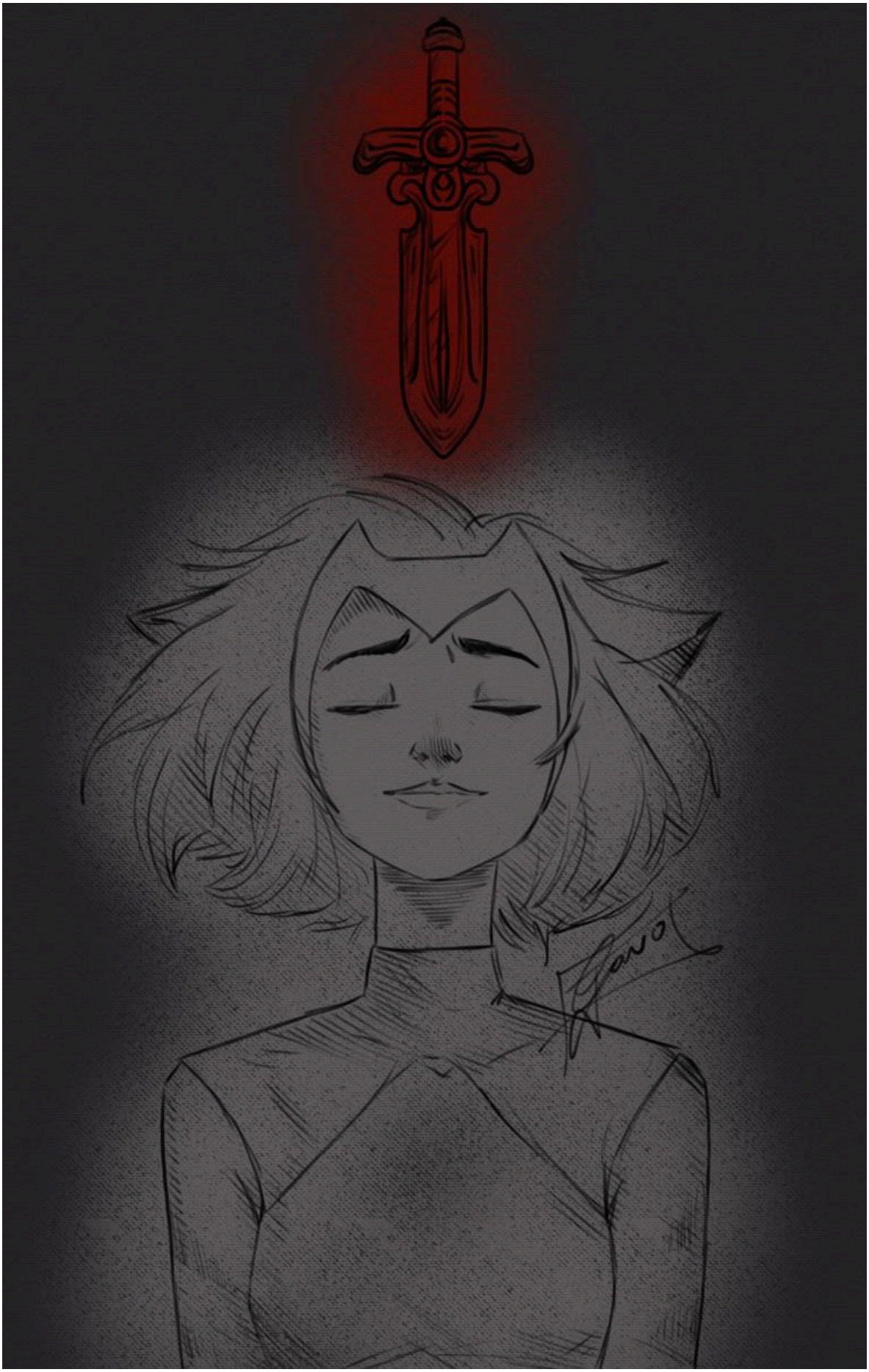
Adora made a show of considering this, eyes drifting forward again, brows knitting as if she were weighing the request carefully. It was painfully obvious she was pretending.

“No,” she said at last. “I don’t think I will.”

Catra hissed something under her breath that might have been a threat, or perhaps a fond insult. Their horses edged closer together as they rode, heads inclined toward one another, voices dropping as the bickering resumed.

They argued for miles after that.

By the time the wagons loomed closer again, Catra realised—absurdly, reluctantly—that she was smiling.



Chapter End Notes

Impending doom? 👎 I promised a happy ending.

Oh, and as an extra note, I was listening to Let Go by NewDad for this chapter.

Chapter 34: Adora

Chapter Notes

Thank you to my beta reader ❤️

Enjoy 😊

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It figured. Five days of coaxing two overloaded wagons through a stream bed without snapping a wheel or shearing a pin, only for one of them to finally give way the moment they were foolish enough to trust an open road again. The wagon sat squarely in the dirt like a defiant toddler, the second wagon halted too close behind it for comfort. Clone 28 crawled out from beneath the chassis with grease on his cheek and leaves in his hair and announced that the axle was cracked clean through.

Adora, who possessed many skills but none that could do anything about broken axles, nodded gravely as though she understood the implications, and immediately ordered everyone into motion. Horses were led off. Packs were dropped. Some soldiers braced the wagon while others hacked down a thin tree to strip it for splints. It was noisy, frantic work, edged with the brittle tension of their newfound exposure

That was when someone swore softly and pointed.

Adora looked up and felt the world narrow. On the horizon, clear as a blade laid flat against the sky, a squadron of Etherian soldiers moved in tight formation, banners snapping faintly in the distance. Fifty, at least. Maybe more. Heading northwest—until, with the inevitability of bad fate, they angled just enough that Adora knew they'd pass far too close to avoid scrutiny.

She lifted her hand, palm out.

Silence dropped like a spell. Tools froze mid-motion. Horses stilled. Even the wind seemed to hesitate. Across the open plain there was nowhere to hide, nowhere to funnel them into an advantage. Just flat land and the slow, unmistakable approach of trained soldiers.

"If they come this way—" Mermista muttered beside her, voice tight.

Adora didn't answer, because Catra chose that moment to take action in a manner that Adora would later catalogue as *completely insane*.

"Hey!" Catra shouted brightly, hauling herself up onto the wagon roof before anyone could stop her. She had snatched a length of pink silk—too bright, too noticeable—and was waving it with theatrical enthusiasm. "Hey! Soldiers!"

Adora's stomach dropped through her boots. She took an instinctive step forward, useless and furious and already too late.

"Stop her," Mermista hissed, making the same futile move. On the horizon, the squadron reacted immediately, formation wheeling as one like startled birds. They had been seen.

There was no undoing it now. Adora forced herself to think past the spike of panic, to measure distances, numbers, angles. Fifty soldiers. Open ground. No cover. She and Mermista shifted without speaking, bodies angling toward threat, calculating how many they could take before being overwhelmed, how many seconds that would buy the wagons. It wasn't enough. It was never going to be enough.

Catra hopped back down from the wagon, silk still in hand, utterly unrepentant.

By the time the squadron reached them, Catra was already in full performance. She put relief into her voice like it was a practiced art, exaggerating her Horde accent until it bordered on parody. "Oh thank the stars, officer! We were afraid we'd be stranded all

day. Eighteen bolts of cloth bound for Silky in Bright Moon, and some absolute villain sold us a wagon held together by wishes and lies."

Adora very deliberately did not look at the second wagon.

The officer rode forward, identifiable immediately by the quality of her mount and the way the others deferred to her. Dark hair, severe eyes, the posture of someone used to command. Her gaze swept the scene and landed on Adora with interest.

"You're merchants," the officer said.

"Yes," Adora replied, keeping her face carefully blank.

"Name."

Adora's mind went white. "Sea Hawk," she said, because panic is a terrible advisor and that was the only merchant's bame she knew.

The officer's brow twitched. "Sea Hawk," she repeated flatly. "The infamous Horde cloth merchant."

"No, I am." Catra cut in smoothly, as if Adora hadn't just said something deeply stupid. She dropped the silk into Adora's hands like a prop and smiled wide. "And it's the *renowned* Horde cloth merchant. Easy mistake. This is my assistant. Mara."

Adora closed her fingers around the silk and prayed nobody opened the wrong wagon.

The officer let the quiet stretch, the way experienced soldiers did when they wanted the silence itself to do the work for them. Her eyes moved deliberately—over Catra first, lingering on the too-easy confidence, the mismatched eyes. Then to Adora, taking in her posture, the careful stillness, the way her hands rested just a fraction too ready near the reins. Finally, the officer's gaze slid to the wagon. She studied it inch by inch: the grime worked deep into the wood, the scars of hard travel, the subtle tilt that spoke of a long fight against bad roads and worse luck. She saw

everything. Adora felt it like a hand pressed between her shoulders.

"Well then, Sea Hawk," the officer said at last, mild as milk. "Looks like you've lost an axle."

Catra smiled up at her, bright and untroubled, as if being surrounded by fifty armed Etherians was a minor inconvenience. "Tragic, I know. Do you suppose your patrol might be willing to lend a hand? We'd be ever so grateful."

Adora's heart hammered. Fifty mounted soldiers, close enough now that she could hear leather creak and horses breathe. Glimmer was in the second wagon. Double Trouble. Baker. One order, one curious look in the wrong direction, and everything would unravel.

The officer didn't look away from Catra. "We're searching for Adora of Etheria."

Catra blinked, perfectly puzzled. "Adora of Etheria?" she echoed lightly. "Is she a local celebrity?"

Adora heard herself answer before she'd decided to speak. "She was the Queen's adopted daughter," she said, voice steady by force of habit now. "Glimmer's sister."

Catra laughed softly, indulgent. "Mara, you can't be serious. Princess Adora is dead. Everyone knows that." She tipped her head toward the officer again, apologetic and faintly amused. "Forgive her. She doesn't keep up with Etherian politics. Obviously that can't be who you're referring to."

The officer's mouth twitched, not quite a smile. "On the contrary," she said, and lifted a hand. "Reports say Adora of Etheria is alive. That she crossed into this province six days ago. With soldiers."

Behind her, the squadron stirred at the gesture, riding forward in a slow, tightening arc. Adora's skin prickled. Then—to her disbelief—

the officer's hand dropped, not toward a search, but toward the broken wheel.

"Go on," the officer told her people. "Help them finish the repair."

A soldier dismounted and asked Mermista for a block to brace the axle. Mermista handed it over without a word, her expression somewhere between shock and the hollow calm Adora remembered from a dozen near-disasters that had begun with Catra smiling like that.

As the work resumed under watchful eyes, the officer turned back to Catra. "Once you're mobile," she said, "we'll escort you to the inn. You'll be safe there. The garrison's stationed nearby."

It clicked into place with a sickening clarity. Not an arrest. Not yet. An escort. Time. Privacy. An inn where questions could be asked without witnesses, wagons opened without spectacle, suspicion turned into certainty at leisure.

Catra didn't hesitate. "How kind," she said warmly. "Lead the way."

The officer introduced herself as Aradia as the axle was set and the wagon creaked back into motion. She rode alongside Catra, confidence settling into her like armor as they moved. Every instinct Adora had screamed danger, but any resistance now would be akin to a confession. She kept her face neutral and rode on.

The inn loomed ahead—one of the larger hostels along the Bright Moon border, built to receive nobles and merchants alike. Its great gates stood open to a broad courtyard ringed with stables and yards for heavy wagons, the kind of place designed to swallow travelers whole. As they passed beneath the arch, Adora felt the trap close on them, quiet and inevitable, and knew the next move would decide everything.

Adora's unease sharpened the moment they rolled through the gates and into the uneven stone of the courtyard. The place wasn't merely an inn; it was a hinge-point, a stopover designed to

host authority. To one side rose a low barracks with its doors thrown open, racks of spears visible inside, armor hung on hooks. Soldiers moved through the space with the easy confidence of men and women who belonged there. Adora counted without meaning to—pairs at the stable doors, clusters near the well, figures lounging with weapons within arm's reach. Close to a hundred, by her estimate. Far too many.

Arrangements like this were common enough in the provinces. Merchants of standing preferred establishments with soldiers nearby; it kept bandits away and prices stable. Inns like this were cleaner, brighter, safer—places where respectable travelers would eat without flinching. Adora had stayed in a dozen like it as a child, trailing after her mother. None of those memories made the knot in her chest ease.

"Thank you, Captain Aradia," Catra said, pitching her voice calm and courteous. "We can manage from here."

Aradia's smile was polite and unyielding. "I insist. I'll see you settled."

Catra didn't so much as blink. "Of course," she said smoothly, already dismounting. She glanced back, eyes flicking to Adora with lazy confidence. "Come along, Mara."

Adora followed, acutely aware of the way their escort subtly closed ranks, how her own soldiers were left behind in the courtyard under watchful eyes. Catra walked ahead as if she owned the place.

Inside, the inn opened into a tall, airy hall built in the Etherian style—pale stone walls rising to exposed beams of honey-colored wood, the ceiling high enough to catch and soften voices. Light poured in through tall, narrow windows cut deep into the walls, throwing long bars of gold across polished floors. Woven banners hung between pillars, dyed in soft blues and greens, depicting harvest scenes and river gods. The air smelled of bread, smoke, and sweet baked goods. To the left, a broad stone staircase

curved upward without railing, its steps worn smooth by generations of boots. To the right, an open archway revealed another chamber where a small group of guests sat clustered around a table, mid-argument, tankards raised.

Aradia's presence drew attention immediately. Two soldiers stationed themselves by the doors. Two more took up positions near the stairs. Four followed her inside. Adora's mind did the unhelpful thing of cataloguing exits, heights, angles—absurd calculations when faced with a garrison.

For one reckless heartbeat, she imagined seizing Aradia, blade to throat, bargaining their way out. The thought collapsed under its own weight just as quickly.

Aradia had already turned to the innkeeper. "This is Sea Hawk," she said, gesturing to Catra. "A cloth merchant."

"*Renowned*," Catra supplied pleasantly.

The innkeeper—a stout woman with sharp eyes and a dusting of flour on her sleeves—looked Catra up and down, lingering on the catlike features, the mismatched eyes. "That's not Sea Hawk."

Catra smiled wider. "I assure you, it is."

The innkeeper shook her head once. "Sea Hawk's already here."

The space seemed to tighten. Adora felt the moment stretch, brittle as glass. Her gaze slid to Catra, who looked—as absurdly as it seemed—like an athlete stepping up after a flawless spear throw, expression serene, ready.

"That's impossible," Catra said lightly. "Bring her out."

Aradia's interest sharpened. "Yes," she agreed. "Bring *her* out."

A serving boy darted away. A heartbeat later, a familiar voice carried from the adjoining room, indignant and unmistakable.

“Who is this claiming to be—”

Sea Hawk emerged mid-protest and stopped dead.

He had changed very little: the same earnest posture, the same merchant’s gravity wrapped around an eager core. His brocade coat was rich and practical, his slightly purple-brunette hair neatly tied back. He took in Catra in one sweeping glance—her eyes, her ears, the unmistakable air of danger—and something flickered across his face. Recognition. Alarm. Then, with heroic composure:

“Sea Hawk!” Sea Hawk exclaimed.

Aradia turned to him. “If she is Sea Hawk,” she said coolly, “who are you?”

“I—” Sea Hawk began.

“He’s Sea Hawk,” the innkeeper said flatly. “I’ve known *him* five years.”

Sea Hawk rallied. “That’s right. She’s Sea Hawk. I’m Sea Hawk.” He spread his hands, smiling with desperate sincerity. “We’re cousins. Named after our grandmother.”

“Sea Hawk,” Catra echoed, nodding solemnly. “May she rest in peace.”

“Gone too soon.”

“Sea Hawk,” Catra said smoothly, turning just enough to angle her body between Adora and the watching soldiers, “this woman seems convinced I’m the Queen of Etheria.”

Adora felt her stomach drop through the floorboards.

Aradia’s jaw tightened. “I said you might be acting on the Queen’s behalf.”

“Oh, please.” Catra laughed, light and dismissive, the sound of someone who had never feared a crown in her life. “An agent? After the Queen’s latest tariffs? She’s strangling the cloth trade from Bright Moon to the coast. If I were working for her, I’d be robbing myself blind.”

Adora fixed her attention on a knot in the wood of the floor and willed herself not to react. *Mara*, she reminded herself. *You are Mara. You sell cloth. You do not rule nations*.

The innkeeper snorted, folding her arms. “She doesn’t look like any Queen I’ve ever seen,” she said decisively. “And if Sea Hawk vouches for her, that’s good enough for me.”

“I vouch for her entirely,” Sea Hawk said at once, chest swelling with earnest conviction. “On my honour and my accounts.”

There was a pause—long enough that Adora could hear her own pulse. Then Aradia inclined her head, stiff but correct. “Very well. My apologies… Sea Hawk. We were just being thorough.”

“As you should be,” Catra replied graciously. She dipped into a precise little bow that somehow managed to be both respectful and faintly mocking.

Then, as if nothing of consequence had occurred, she slipped her riding cloak from her shoulders and handed it back to Adora without looking. Adora took it automatically, the familiar role slipping back to her.

Sea Hawk leaned in, eyes alight, voice pitched low with delight. “In disguise again!” he whispered, tugging Catra gently toward the hearth. “What is it this time? A covert operation? Royal intrigue? Say no more—your secret is safe with me.”

Catra allowed herself to be steered, a smile playing at her mouth. “You always were good at keeping secrets, dear cousin.” she said dryly.

Sea Hawk beamed and launched into introductions, presenting Catra to the men gathered at his table—six merchants in varying states of prosperity, their coats fine but travel-worn. Each reacted with enthusiasm at meeting Sea Hawk's "young cousin," delighted by the novelty of a catfolk relative from the Horde. Someone mentioned an uncle, a romance, a woman with a jaguar's purr; Catra accepted it all with languid amusement, correcting nothing.

"This is my assistant, Gregarious," Sea Hawk said proudly.

"And this," Catra added, gesturing back over her shoulder, "is mine. Mara."

That was how Adora found herself perched on a narrow three-legged stool at the edge of a merchant's table in the heart of Etheria, surrounded by men discussing bolt widths and dye yields as if the fate of the world were not riding in wagons outside.

Platters arrived—sweetcakes still warm, crisp crudité, bowls of thick dips. Wine followed, poured generously into shallow cups, shared without ceremony. It was decent enough, Adora thought, watching Catra lean close to Sea Hawk, laughing softly at something Mark the satin merchant said. No music, no dancers—just talk, heat, and the hum of life being lived.

Catra fit there disturbingly well, Adora realized. Too well. As if she had always belonged at a table like this, sharp-eyed and unafraid, playing her part while the rest of them tried desperately to keep up.

Gregarious drifted down the table toward her with the unhurried confidence of a man who believed similar stations equalled camaraderie. He had a cup in hand, already flushed from wine and self-importance, and he smiled at Adora as though they shared a private joke.

"Mara," he said, lingering on the name. "That's not one you hear often."

Adora inclined her head, polite and noncommittal. “It’s done well enough by me.”

He nodded, as if this confirmed something. “You speak First Ones very cleanly,” he added, enunciating each word with exaggerated care. “Not many assistants do.”

“Occupational hazard,” Adora replied. “Listening to her talk.”

He laughed at that, louder than necessary.

Mermista arrived at the end of the table shortly after, clearly having paced herself through the room with all the grace of someone who would rather be anywhere else. She stopped when she realised Catra had angled herself to be the centre of the group and that any report would have to be delivered to Catra. Her mouth tightened.

“The wagons are unloaded,” Mermista said flatly. “Sea Hawk.”

Catra didn’t even glance up at first. Then she smiled and tipped her cup in acknowledgment. “Excellent. See? Competent, if nothing else.” She turned smoothly to the others. “We usually conduct business out of Salineas, but I’ve been driven east by circumstance. The Princess there is catastrophically ill-suited to trade.”

Mermista’s stare could have cut glass.

“She doesn’t understand textiles,” Catra went on, pleasantly. “She’s terribly stubborn.”

“That’s true,” Mark chimed in at once, emboldened by wine. “She banned anything that wasn’t waterproof.”

Sea Hawk groaned theatrically. “And taxed my Scorpion Hill silk five coin a bolt! Five!”

A chorus of outrage followed, cups thumping, heads shaking. Mermista crossed her arms and said nothing, which only seemed

to confirm every accusation in the merchants' minds.

The talk rolled onward, gathering speed: border inspections, seized caravans, rumours of patrols doubling. Sea Hawk speculated openly that this might be his last run east before the roads closed altogether. War, he said, always strangled trade first. Someone else wondered aloud what it would do to grain prices. Another worried about dyers without access to imported minerals.

No one spoke with any certainty about Adora—where she was, or why the Horde's Princess had allied with her—but the name hovered like bad weather.

Gregarious leaned closer to Adora, lowering his voice with exaggerated secrecy. "Sea Hawk once met the Horde Princess," he said. "In Ghost's Ridge Stop."

Adora didn't look at him. "Did he?"

"In a tavern," Gregarious continued, delighted. "Disguised as a—" he paused, then whispered, "—working girl."

Adora lifted her eyes then, letting them drift across the table to where Catra sat, one arm draped over the back of her chair, expression cool and intent as she questioned Mark about Etherian dye methods and how they differed to those used in Scorpion Hill. Every familiar line of her face was perfectly composed.

"So I've heard," Adora said.

Gregarious nodded eagerly. "Sea Hawk says: imagine the most expensive pet you've ever seen. Then double it."

"That tracks," Adora said mildly.

"He knew who she was immediately, of course," Gregarious added, reverent now. "Couldn't hide it. The posture. The presence. Nobility shines through, you know."

"Undeniably," Adora agreed.

Across the table, Catra was deep in conversation, fingers tapping idly against her cup as Sea Hawk expounded on market differences. Horde buyers preferred reliability and blunt utility; Etherians prized refinement, subtlety yet extravagant. Their weaves looked simple, but every thread mattered.

“It’s exhausting,” Sea Hawk concluded.

Catra snorted softly. “You’re romanticising it, cousin. Etherians don’t want depth.” She smiled, sharp and knowing. “They want things that catch the light. Make it shimmer, and they’ll eat it up.”

Chapter End Notes

We're in another inn guys...

You know what that means

Chapter 35: Adora

Chapter Notes

Thank you to my beta reader ❤️

This is some smut guys, get ready

See the end of the chapter for more notes

By the time Adora—*Mara*, for tonight—finished her circuit of the yard, the inn had settled into the particular stillness that came only as soldiers slept. It wasn't silence, exactly. There was the shift and snort of horses in their stalls, the soft clink of tack as a strap settled, the low murmur of someone turning in their blankets. Familiar sounds. Reassuring ones.

Lonnie and the others were already down, boots kicked aside, weapons stacked within reach. Double Trouble lay stiffly in the outbuilding, pretending at sleep without much success. The Medic Clone snored loudly. Clone 28 and Keston shared a blanket without a trace of self-consciousness, limbs tangled, breathing in easy synchrony. Mermista remained awake by the wagons, posture rigid, eyes sharp, flanked by the two guards assigned to Glimmer's night confinement. Baker was there too, seated like a statue, saying nothing.

"All quiet," Mermista said when Adora approached.

"Good," Adora answered

An inn servant crossed the yard then, lantern swinging, and inclined her head. "Your room's ready, Mara. Second door on the right."

Adora followed the light back inside. The common room was nearly dark now, embers glowing dully in the hearth, the scent of wine and extinguished candles lingering in the air. Sea Hawk and his companions had retired. The stairs rose along the wall without

railing, as they always did in Etherian inns—an unspoken trust in steady feet and sober minds.

She climbed them carefully, letting her eyes adjust to the dimness. Second door. She pressed it open.

Warmth met her first: heat from the fire, candlelight pooling across plastered stone walls and patterned paper, the quiet comfort of a space meant to be inhabited rather than merely passed through. Three magic candles burned low and steady—an indulgence. The bed stood empty of its trappings.

Because Catra had dismantled it.

The mattress lay dragged to the hearth, bedding piled into a sprawling nest of blankets and sheets. Catra herself stood within that soft chaos, candlelight gilding her fur, her hair still damp from bathing and loose over her shoulders. She'd traded the day's clothes for an oversized Horde sleep shirt that slipped off one shoulder, hem brushing mid-thigh. Clean. Relaxed. Entirely, devastatingly beautiful.

Adora stopped just inside the door.

"The innsman sent me here," she said, careful with her tone, as if steadiness might keep her heart from kicking against her ribs.

"At my request," Catra replied, already moving. "It's our last chance at something resembling a bed before everything gets… complicated again."

Adora barely had time to process the dismantled bed before Catra closed the distance between them. Her hands came up instinctively, finding Catra's waist through thin cotton, thumbs pressing into familiar curves. Catra kissed her like she'd been waiting all night—and perhaps she had—fingers threading into Adora's hair to pull her down to the right height. The contrast hit all at once: Catra clean and soap-scented, Adora still marked by sweat and dust and the long road.

Catra didn’t flinch. If anything, she smiled into the kiss.

Adora let herself push Catra back a step, then another, until her shoulders brushed the wall. She took Catra’s mouth properly then, slow and thorough, letting the tension drain out of her spine. Catra made a soft sound that went straight through her.

“I need to bathe,” Adora murmured against Catra’s ear, lips finding the sensitive skin there.

“Then go,” Catra said easily, kissing her again, deeper this time. She broke away just long enough to guide Adora forward with a firm hand, creating space between them. Leaning against the wall, Catra tipped her chin toward the small washroom door, brows lifting. “Unless you were hoping I’d supervise.”

Adora swallowed. The candles flickered. The fire popped softly.

“I can manage,” she said.

“I’ll be right here.”

The washroom was warmer than the bedchamber, steam curling lazily along the low ceiling. Adora paused just inside the threshold, taking it in: neatly folded towels stacked on a stool, a bar of soap set within easy reach, the deep wooden tub already filled, water faintly rippling with heat. Someone had drawn it carefully—tested the temperature, topped it up. It struck her, with a small, startled fondness, that this kind of quiet preparation was unmistakably Catra.

She shut the door behind her and let out a breath she hadn’t realised she’d been holding.

Catra hadn’t followed. She was giving Adora the space to do this alone, to take care of herself, and that too felt nice. Washing became something perfunctory. Adora stripped away the last of the road, skin tingling as dust and sweat were sluiced off, the water turning cloudy before she tipped another bucket in and watched it clear. She worked soap into her hair, rinsed until it ran

clean, stood for a moment longer than necessary just letting the heat ease the ache from her shoulders.

The pause itself was almost unbearable—an interruption that sharpened anticipation instead of dulling it. They hadn't had time for slowness. Not really. Her thoughts kept circling forward, unwinding into things not yet touched, not yet said.

When she finally dried herself and wrapped a towel around her waist, her skin was flushed, her limbs loose and warm. She opened the door again.

The bedchamber felt different now. Quieter. Intentional. Candlelight had been adjusted—drawn lower, closer together. The bedding lay in a soft sprawl near the fire, arranged with care. And Catra stood just beyond it, clean and composed and visibly not at ease, her posture held too tightly for someone pretending to be relaxed.

Adora stopped again, suddenly aware of herself—the damp ends of her hair brushing her shoulders, the heat still in her skin.

She smiled before she could stop herself. "You planned all this."

Catra's ears flicked. "Don't sound so surprised."

"It's… nice," Adora said, and then, softer, "You didn't have to."

"I wanted to," Catra replied, quick, then added as if to reclaim ground, "You're clean?"

"Yes."

Catra didn't move right away. She stood there, weighing something, eyes tracking Adora with an intensity that made her pulse kick. Then she said, "Step back."

Adora did, carefully, until the plastered wall met her spine. She glanced aside once, orienting herself—the bedding low to one side, the fire to the other—before looking back at Catra.

“Hands,” Catra said. “On the wall.”

The command landed with a weight that made Adora’s breath hitch. She obeyed, palms flattening against the cool plaster. The room felt smaller suddenly, every sound magnified—the crackle of the fire, the soft shift of Catra’s bare feet as she crossed the space between them.

Catra stopped just short of touching her.

“Lose the towel.”

Adora’s fingers fumbled slightly as she untucked it. It slid down, brushing her legs before pooling at her feet. She didn’t move away from the wall. She didn’t cover herself. She let Catra look.

For a moment, Catra didn’t pretend not to. Her gaze dropped, lingered, then snapped back up as if she’d caught herself. There was something unmistakably nervous in it and it sent a strange, tender thrill through Adora. She stayed still, breathing slow, letting the firelight do its work.

Catra exhaled through her nose. “Transform into *her*, and—” She stopped, jaw tightening, and then, abruptly, she sank down onto her knees.

The movement was so sudden, that Adora’s thoughts scattered entirely. Her pulse surged, loud in her ears. She stared down at Catra, trying—failing—to predict what would come next, acutely aware that expectation itself was a risk she couldn’t afford.

She’s not going to…

Catra looked up at her from the floor, eyes dark and steady now, every trace of hesitation burned away.

“Don’t move,” she said quietly.

Adora didn’t.

Adora transformed, and the change hit her all at once—bone and muscle realigning, power rushing through her veins, heat pooling low and unmistakable. The evidence of her arousal was impossible to hide, even without Catra exactly eye level.

Catra wasn't looking at her face. Her attention was fixed lower, eyes darkened, mouth parted as if she'd forgotten to school it back into something sharp. The tension in her shoulders had tightened now that she was this close, drawn toward the undeniable truth of Adora's body. Adora felt the faint brush of Catra's breath and had to lock her knees to keep from swaying.

She didn't move. She barely breathed.

Catra set one palm against the wall beside her, caging her in with a proximity that made Adora's pulse spike. From this angle, Adora could see the lines of Catra's face in profile—the hard planes softened by candlelight, lashes lowered, mismatched eyes hidden. The room around them felt unreal.

Catra leaned in.

It was just the barest touch—her tongue sweeping over it.

Adora's head thudded back against the plaster. The sensation tore a sound out of her, rough and unguarded, and she shut her eyes on instinct, overwhelmed by it. For a heartbeat, the world narrowed to heat and pressure and the effort of staying still.

When she opened her eyes again, Catra had pulled back just enough to make her doubt her own senses—except for the unmistakable proof she could feel rather than see—wetness at the tip. Adora's palms scraped against the wall as she steadied herself, the coarse plaster biting into her skin.

Catra's breathing was shallow now, chest rising and falling too fast. Whatever restraint she was fighting was written plainly across her face. She leaned in again.

“Catra,” Adora breathed, the name breaking into a groan she couldn’t stop.

For all Catra’s insistence that she would never do this, she was really rather good at it. She couldn’t take it into her mouth very well, and as a result focused on running her tongue along the length of it, underneath and over, coming back to focus on the head more often than anything else.

Adora was panting, every instinct screaming to move, to close the distance, to take control, to thrust—and she couldn’t. Being held in place like this, forced into stillness, made the sensation sharper, almost unbearable. Her fingers dug into the wall, cracking the plaster under She-Ra’s strength.

Catra’s focus never wavered. There was no rush in her movements, no drive toward an end—only deliberate attention, unhurried and devastatingly precise. It was exquisite in a way that felt almost unfair.

Adora’s thoughts scattered. She was too close to the edge.

She had never imagined it like this. She knew Catra’s mouth as a weapon—sharp words, cruel smiles, the ability to cut people down without lifting a hand. In public, Catra kept that mouth tight, controlled, dangerous.

Now it was devoted entirely to Adora’s pleasure.

The realization hit her all at once, bright and dizzying—and then Catra committed fully, taking as much of it into her mouth as she possibly could, and Adora lost whatever control she had left.

She was going to come in Catra’s mouth.

The release tore through her too fast, overwhelming, leaving her shaking as she fought not to move, not to break the fragile balance between them. Her fingers clenched in the broken plaster as the moment passed.

When she finally opened her eyes, she was still braced against the wall. Catra had retreated a few steps, standing near the window, one hand pressed to her mouth. Her eyes flicked up to Adora, wary, unreadable. She hadn't turned away. She hadn't shown any sign of regret.

Adora pushed herself upright and crossed the room. When she reached Catra, she set her palm against the wall beside her head, close enough to feel the heat of her body, the quick rhythm of her breath. Catra was unmistakably affected, arousal clear despite the guarded posture.

For a moment, neither of them spoke.

It was obvious then—Catra didn't quite know what to do with this part of herself yet. The desire. The vulnerability. The fact that she wanted more, even if she didn't know what *more* looked like.

Adora stayed where she was, close but not touching, letting Catra decide what came next.

In the low spill of candlelight, Catra spoke without lifting her chin. Her voice was steady, but there was an edge to it that Adora recognised now—the sound of her bracing herself.

"So," Catra said, "we're calling it even, then?"

Adora didn't pretend to misunderstand. "That depends," she replied quietly. "What would make it feel fair to you?"

Catra's gaze flicked up at last, dark and searching. Whatever battle she was fighting showed in the tightness of her jaw, the way her shoulders held as though expecting a blow. For a moment, Adora thought she might retreat into sarcasm, might lash out or deflect—but she didn't.

"Show me," Catra said instead. "I want to know how it could have been."

The words were bare. As soon as they left her mouth, colour rose in her cheeks, a flush that betrayed how much it had cost her to say. She stood there against the plaster wall of the inn, suddenly young, and overwhelmingly adorable.

Beyond these walls lay Etheria—roads full of soldiers, enemies with long memories, dangers stacked atop one another until survival itself felt like defying all odds. Tomorrow, they would have to face all of it again.

But here, in this narrow pocket of warmth and flame, there was only Catra. Candlelight caught in her short hair, traced the line of her throat, softened the sharpness of her features into something fragile. Adora felt the strange, aching wish that this could have been another life entirely—one where she could have courted Catra openly, slowly. A balcony somewhere far away. Music drifting up from below. No war pressing in at the edges.

"I would court you," Adora said, the admission surprising her with its certainty. "Properly. With patience. With honesty."

She reached out and undid the first button of Catra's shirt. The fabric shifted, revealing a glimpse of warm skin at her throat. Catra didn't move. Her breath barely stirred.

"We would have started as friends," Adora went on, undoing the next button. Her pulse was loud in her ears now, her focus narrowing to the heat beneath her fingers. "I think..."

Another button gave way.

"If we had grown up as friends," Adora said softly. "Nothing would have separated us."

She lifted her hand then, cupping Catra's cheek, finding herself in the solid warmth of her. Leaning in, she kissed her—

Catra stiffened in surprise, as if she hadn't expected tenderness after what had come before. Then, tentatively, she kissed back. There was nothing practiced about it. Catra kissed the way she

did everything else when she wasn't acting—earnest, intent, as if it mattered. There was a waiting quality to it too, an expectation that Adora would take the lead.

When she didn't, Catra adjusted instead, fingers threading into Adora's still-damp hair, guiding the kiss deeper on her own terms. Adora felt the press of Catra's body, the quiet urgency there, and slid her hand inside the loosened shirt, palm spreading over Catra's skin in a touch that felt intimate in a way nothing else had yet.

Catra made a soft sound and broke the kiss just long enough to breathe, eyes closed, leaning into Adora's hand as if anchoring herself into that touch.

Adora dipped her head, her mouth close to Catra's ear. "You like to take it slow."

"Yes," Catra said, the word barely audible—but certain.

The fire cracked softly behind them, a low, living sound that filled every paused. Adora leaned in to press a kiss at Catra's throat, lingering just long enough to feel her breath hitch before moving again. Her hand slid with care beneath the loosened fabric, mapping warmth and tension rather than taking anything outright. Catra's skin was sensitive there—Adora had learned that much already—even if Catra spent most days wrapped in layers meant to dull sensation and broadcast control. Tonight, though, the tension in her jaw gave her away, the fine line of restraint stretched thin.

Adora felt her own body respond despite herself, a slow, insistent heat she deliberately kept banked. She let the moment stretch, imagining what it might be like to lose themselves to time, to touch without urgency, to let the world outside the inn simply cease to matter. She kept that thought to herself.

When Catra drew her shirt up and away, baring herself without bravado, Adora stepped closer, fingertips brushing over familiar

scars and unfamiliar softness alike. Her gaze followed the path of her hand. Catra watched her in return, eyes sharp and searching, as if Adora's presence was somehow larger now that nothing stood between them. It was Catra who shifted first, who guided Adora down onto the piled bedding with a decisive press of her hands, turning observation into intent.

They kissed again, the firelight throwing their shadows large against the wall. Catra broke away, breath shallow but controlled, some internal decision settling into place.

"Make me come," she said quietly, taking Adora's hand and guiding it.

Adora slid two fingers inside.

She moved with care, attentive to every small signal: the change in Catra's breathing, the subtle tightening and release beneath her touch, the way Catra's control fought to reassert itself even as she asked—wordlessly—for more. Adora slowed deliberately, grounding herself in patience, letting the moment deepen rather than rush. She could feel how hard Catra was working to hold herself together, how unfamiliar surrender remained for her.

She didn't stop when Catra tensed; she adjusted, stayed present, steady and unyielding in her gentleness. Slow, coaxing curls of her fingers at the precipice of Catra's entrance while her thumb circled the bundle of nerves right above it.

"Can't come?" Adora whispered playfully as she felt another near-climax ebb away.

"Is that a problem for you?"

Adora laughed, intentionally misunderstanding her question. "No, I can come plenty."

A sharp curse from Catra broke the quiet, and suddenly the world tilted. Adora found herself on her back, the straw mattress

pressing up against her shoulders, Catra braced above her, eyes bright with resolve.

"For the honour of Grayskull," Catra murmured softly, before she transformed into the same form she had taken just over a week ago.

Adora's confusion lasted only a heartbeat, long enough to notice Catra's hand slip beneath the bedding to where the Sword of Protection lay hidden. Even now—especially now—Catra had planned ahead. The realization made Adora's breath catch, equal parts exasperation and awe, as the firelight flared and the air seemed to tighten around them.

The reversal sent a sharp, electric rush through Adora, desire flaring bright and immediate even as she reached up and took Catra in her hand. The confidence of the gesture startled her—how natural it felt to guide Catra like this, how dangerous and exhilarating it was to give even the smallest instruction. She swallowed and managed, breath rough, "Come for me."

Catra answered without words. The first press against Adora's grip was slow and intentional, heat meeting heat, a measured test rather than a demand. Adora felt it all at once: the weight, the tension, the unfamiliarity of receiving in *this* way. Catra's eyes never left her face, watching for reaction with an intensity that made Adora acutely aware of every breath she took, every shift of her body.

It struck her then how new this was for Catra, too—the careful control layered over curiosity, the way she seemed to be learning herself even as she moved. Adora had a sudden, foolish thought about firsts and thresholds crossed, and the thought burned. She had never shared this part of herself, never allowed anyone to use the Sword of Protection like this, never let anyone touch her in She-Ra's form with such intent. Not before Catra.

"I—" Adora started, voice catching despite herself. "I've never—in this way."

Catra answered immediately, steady but unguarded. “Obviously neither have I.” A beat, then softer: “You’d be my first.”

Something in Adora’s chest tightened at that. Everything felt amplified—the slide of Catra’s body against her hand, the brush of skin on skin, the slow, deliberate roll of Catra’s hips as she found a rhythm that belonged to neither of them yet somehow fit the moment. The fire behind them threw too much heat into the room; Adora’s palm rested at Catra’s side and felt the powerful flex of muscle there, grounding and overwhelming all at once. When Adora looked up, she knew her own eyes were betraying her, laying herself bare in a way she wasn’t used to. Catra saw it—and answered, moving with more confidence now, pushing into her touch.

“And you’d be mine,” Adora heard herself say, the words spilling out unfiltered.

Catra huffed a breath that might have been a laugh. “I thought Etherians made a big deal out of the *first night*.”

“They do,” Adora said, honest to the bone. “For a slave, it’s everything...”

The words hung between them, heavy and unpolished. Catra’s response was physical rather than verbal: a shudder that tore a sound from her throat, control finally slipping as effort overtook restraint. Adora felt it cascade through her in sympathy, her own body responding in kind, the connection enough to send sensation spiraling downward.

They spilled out together, painting Adora’s torso in white.

They stayed like that for a long moment, breathing hard, Catra braced above her, the aftershocks uneven and drawn out. Catra turned her head away first, as if the intimacy of looking was suddenly too much, as if something raw had been exposed that she didn’t yet know how to tend.

Adora kept her hand where it was, feeling the frantic rhythm of Catra's pulse gradually slow beneath her palm. She felt Catra shift, already pulling back too soon.

"I'll—" Catra started.

Then she disengaged, stepping away while Adora lay sprawled on the bedding, one arm flung above her head, chest still rising and falling as she came back to herself. With Catra's weight gone, the room rushed in again: the crackle of the fire, the warmth against her skin, the quiet hum of the inn settling for the night.

She watched Catra cross the room with purpose, fetching towels and the water pitcher before her own breathing had fully evened out. Adora knew this about her—how Catra turned to order and routine after intensity, how cleanliness and motion gave her space to regain control. Catra paused by the table, fingers resting against the wood, eyes lowered as she took a steadying breath in the candlelit dim.

Adora smiled faintly to herself, aching and content in equal measure. She liked that she recognized this now, liked that she was learning the small, unspoken habits Catra used to protect herself. And she liked—perhaps more than she should—that Catra didn't bother to hide them from her anymore.

When Catra came back with the towels and the pitcher, she moved with a deliberate composure that felt almost ceremonial, as though this too was something she had rehearsed in her head and was now determined not to do badly. Adora let herself be tended to, leaning into the quiet care with a softness she rarely allowed herself.

Catra's hands were warm, thorough, almost overly precise as she blotted away the mess and sweat, lingering at Adora's shoulders and along her arms as if mapping her again, reassuring herself she was still there. Adora drank from the shallow cup Catra pressed into her hands, the water cool against her throat, then took the pitcher back and poured for Catra in turn.

The flicker of surprise on Catra's face at that small reciprocity made something ease in Adora's chest. Catra accepted the cup, sat stiffly on the bedding, and drank.

Adora stretched out on the pallet, the heat from the fire loosening the last of the tension in her limbs. She waited, without urgency, aware that Catra did not slide into ease the way other people did. The silence lengthened, full but not uncomfortable, the crackle of the fire filling the gaps. Eventually Catra lay down beside her, carefully, like someone unsure where safety was. She positioned herself closer to the hearth, the firelight cutting her into warm planes and shadowed hollows, making her look at once fierce and fragile. Adora turned her head and noticed the familiar gleam at Catra's wrist, the weight of platinum catching the light.

"You're still wearing it," Adora said, softly, the words slipping out before she'd decided to speak.

Catra's gaze flicked to her, unreadable. "So are you," she replied, just as quietly.

Adora swallowed. "Tell me why."

A pause. Catra stared up at the ceiling as though the answer might be written there. "You already know," she said at last.

They lay side by side among the scattered bedding, not quite touching. Adora rolled onto her back and focused on the wooden ceiling above, tracing the dark grain with her eyes, listening to her own heartbeat. The thought came unbidden, and once there, refused to leave.

"I think I'll be jealous," Adora said, her voice barely more than breath, "when you marry someone important and take your place properly. A prince, a lord—when you become Queen of the Horde."

The words hung there. The fire popped softly. Adora became acutely aware of her breathing, of how exposed she suddenly felt. After a long moment, Catra answered.

“There won’t be anyone,” she said. “No prince. No lord.”

“It’s… expected,” Adora said, even as she knew the argument was thin. “Your line—”

“My *royal line* stops with me,” Catra cut in. Her tone was steady, but there was something brittle beneath it. “And I was adopted anyway. It was never really mine to continue.”

Adora turned then, drawn by the quiet honesty in Catra’s voice. Catra still wasn’t looking at her, her eyes fixed somewhere in the middle distance, the firelight gilding her lashes. “I never let myself think about children,” Catra went on. “It wasn’t an option I allowed to exist.”

Adora didn’t rush to fill the silence that followed. She let it sit between them, respected the carefulness of it, the way Catra held herself as if any sudden movement might crack something open.

“I’m glad you’re here,” Catra said at last. The admission was quiet, almost shy. “I always assumed I’d face Prime on my own.”

Adora reached out then, closing the small gap, her fingers brushing Catra’s hand. “You're not alone,” she said. “Not anymore.”

Catra finally turned her head, their eyes meeting in the dim light. For a heartbeat, neither of them spoke. Then Catra smiled—small, real—and laced her fingers with Adora’s, a silent acknowledgement, accepting the promise without words. They lay there together, the fire burning low, the rest of the world held at bay, with everything else—fear, duty, and what waited for them beyond these walls—temporarily suspended.

Chapter End Notes

Inching steadily closer to sadness and pain, you're not going to like the next chapter I think.

Chapter 36: Catra

Chapter Notes

TW: **Dictionary Definition**
[Definitions from Oxford Languages]
"Oblivious"
/əˈblɪviəs/
adjective
"Adora from Disposition, Favour, Devotion"

See the end of the chapter for more notes

They were facing each other in the firelit silence, turned on their sides like mirrors. For a long moment Catra just watched Adora breathe, watched the rise of her chest, the soft concentration in her expression—like she was memorizing everything in front of her.

Catra reached first.

Her fingers slid into Adora's hair—still damp, still unruly from the bath—and she let herself linger there as though she could learn something by touch alone. She traced the bridge of Adora's nose, the familiar shape of her mouth. Adora's lips parted instinctively, chasing contact, so eager it made something in Catra's chest tighten painfully.

This was the woman she had spent years hating. This was the woman she had sworn to destroy.

And now she was here, warm and real, looking at Catra like *this*.

"Would you really have let me?" Catra heard herself ask.

Adora blinked, caught. "Let you—?"

She caught Catra's hand before she could retreat, pressing a kiss to her fingertips. Then she hesitated, searching Catra's face with

that open, infuriating honesty.

“Do you… want to?”

Catra’s throat worked.

“Not tonight.” The answer came quick, sharper than she meant for it to be. She forced her expression into something practical. “You have to ride tomorrow. You’re not used to it. It can be…” Her mouth twisted. “Painful that way.”

Adora frowned, the concept clearly foreign to her. For Adora, sex was intimate. Heat, tenderness, need. She had never had to separate it from safety.

Catra rolled onto her back again, staring up at the dark ceiling beams as if they might offer rescue from her own words.

Adora stayed propped on one elbow, studying her.

“You’ve tried it that way,” Adora said finally.

Catra turned her head slowly. “Is that supposed to be an accusation?”

“No.” Adora’s voice softened, careful. “It’s… an observation. Did you not like it?”

Catra gave a short, humourless breath.

“No,” she said. And then, because Adora was looking at her like that—because Adora always wanted truth, always reached for it with both hands—Catra added, quieter, “I might. With you.”

Adora’s expression shifted, still uncomfortable.

“With me,” Adora repeated.

This conversation could have stopped there. Should have, even. But Adora’s next words came anyway.

“But you didn’t like it,” Adora said slowly, “with the person before?”

Catra went utterly still.

Adora sat up more fully, concern sharpening into focus. “Catra.”

Catra’s jaw tightened until it hurt.

“Not—at first,” she said, controlled. “My body…” Her voice faltered, hatred curling beneath it. “Adapted. Eventually.”

Adora’s face darkened, something storming behind her blue eyes.

“Eventually,” she echoed, flat.

Catra forced herself to meet her gaze, daring her to look away first.

“Yes,” Catra snapped. “Eventually.”

She could feel it now, the cliff's edge. The danger of Adora knowing too much. The fear of Adora seeing her differently. Of love curdling into pity, and eventually revulsion.

Catra’s stomach twisted.

“Leave it,” she said.

Adora’s mouth tightened stubbornly. “Catra—”

“No.” Catra’s voice sharpened like a whip. Anger was easier. Anger was her armour. “You said it’s never been this way for you with anyone else?”

Adora blinked.

“Then let it be the same for me,” Catra said, fierce. “Don’t dig. Don’t pull at it like it’s something you can fix.”

Silence.

Adora's breathing changed, frustration mixing with helplessness.

They stared at each other, the space between them suddenly vast.

Finally, Adora spoke again, as if she was bargaining.

"Two questions," she said. "Only two."

Catra's eyes narrowed. "Adora."

"It ended badly?"

Catra's teeth clenched.

"Yes," she said, clipped. The understatement was almost laughable but she did not elaborate.

Catra felt the question before she heard it, the way one feels a change in weather through old scars.

"Do you regret it?" Adora asked quietly.

Catra closed her eyes for half a second. When she opened them, her voice came out sharp on instinct. "Adora—"

"That's the last one," Adora said, stubborn and earnest in the way that always made Catra want to both kiss her and shove her away. "I swear. I just need to know. Do you regret being with him?"

Catra let out a breath that scraped her chest raw. "Would you like me to interrogate you about Glimmer in return?"

Adora blinked. "You *did* interrogate me about Glimmer."

Catra turned her face toward the ceiling, jaw tight, teeth grinding together until it hurt. The fire popped in the hearth, too loud in the silence that stretched between them.

"Yes," Catra snapped at last. "Yes, I regret it. Every second. Every minute of it. Are you satisfied?" Her voice shook despite her efforts. "What else would you like? Shall we revisit my childhood

while we're at it? Maybe the tragic fate of my mother? That conversation always goes over well."

Adora made a frustrated sound and flopped backward onto the bedding, staring up at the ceiling beams like they personally offended her.

"You're infuriating," Adora muttered.

"Look who's talking," Catra shot back.

They lay there in brittle quiet. After a moment, Adora shifted again, turning her back to Catra and rearranging her pillow with more force than necessary, thumping it into submission.

Catra scowled at her spine. "Are you planning to wage war on that thing all night?"

"I didn't realize sleeping next to you came with a rulebook," Adora said. "I'll wrestle my pillow if I want."

The firelight danced across Adora's back, tracing the scars there—deep, pale lines Catra knew by heart. The sight punched the breath from her lungs. Even now, even angry, Catra wanted to press close, to hold herself against that familiar strength, to borrow Adora's steadiness until the ghosts receded.

Then Adora spoke again, softer. "Have I met him?"

Catra's fingers curled into the blanket. "I thought you were done asking questions."

Adora rolled back toward her. Catra could see it in her eyes. The thought of Catra's pain had, once again, taken root.

"I'm not jealous," Adora said carefully. "Not about someone else being with you before me. I just—"

"—want to catalogue my mistakes?" Catra cut in. "Put a name to the person who ruined sex for me?"

“No!” Adora said, too fast. “That’s not it.”

“Isn’t it?”

Adora pushed herself up on one elbow, voice heated now. “Whoever it was should have cared whether or not you enjoyed it. From the start. It should never have been something you had to grit your teeth and bear.”

Catra laughed once, short and humorless. “And that’s the crime, is it? That the world didn’t cater to me?”

“That’s not what I meant,” Adora said, exasperated. “You’re twisting this.”

“Am I?” Catra shot back. “You grew up somewhere safe. Somewhere that told you what things *should* be like. Out there, that isn’t how it works.”

Adora’s jaw clenched. “I know pain exists. That doesn’t make it acceptable to me.”

“Oh, congratulations,” Catra said bitterly.

Adora didn’t rise to it.

“What you’re describing,” Adora said slowly, “is someone raping you. Repeatedly. Until you stopped resisting.”

Catra’s chest tightened. The room felt smaller.

“Stop,” she said.

Adora hesitated, then went on anyway, voice low and fierce. “You didn’t deserve that. No one does.”

Catra turned away, staring into the shadows at the edge of the firelight. Her voice came out flat, brittle as glass. “Enough.”

Somehow, impossibly, the command worked.

Adora stopped. Whatever argument had been coiled on her tongue snapped short; Catra heard her teeth click together with the faint, involuntary sound of restraint. The quiet that followed was heavy enough to press against Catra's ribs.

Catra dragged both hands up and pressed the heels of her palms into her eyes until stars burst behind her lids. She breathed in through her nose, the way she had taught herself to do when panic threatened to tip into something uglier.

"What," she asked at last, each word measured and tight, "is the *point* of this?" Her hands slid down, leaving faint red marks beneath her eyes. "Plenty of people don't enjoy sex the first time. Or the first few times. It doesn't matter."

Adora didn't answer immediately.

That alone set Catra's nerves humming. There were many parts of Adora's interpersonal arsenal—earnestness, stubbornness, painful sincerity—but silent contemplation was not a weapon she typically used. When she finally spoke, her voice was slower, stripped of its heat.

"Do you know," Adora said, "that you attack when you're trying not to feel something?"

Catra went very still. A memory surfaced unbidden: Adora, months ago, gently pointing out—almost amused, almost fond—that Catra talked more when she was uneasy. Now this. Another puzzle piece slotted into place. Another weakness revealed.

The thought curdled in her stomach. *Have you always known me so well?* Every cruel jab, every sharpened word Catra had flung like a blade—had Adora seen through them all?

Maybe it had never been forgiveness that drove Adora to her side. Maybe it had just been pity.

Catra laughed, short and harsh, the sound scraping her throat raw. It echoed wrong in the small room.

She didn’t notice Adora move until fingers closed around her wrist.

Instinct screamed at her to jerk away, to bare her teeth and bite, metaphorically or otherwise—but Adora didn’t give her time. With infuriating gentleness, she tugged Catra’s hand down from her face, guiding it away as if Catra was fragile rather than dangerous.

“Look at me,” Adora said quietly.

Catra did.

“It matters to me,” Adora continued, voice steady now, unwavering. “That’s why I’m asking. Not because I’m trying to fix you. Not because I need answers. It matters because *you* matter to me.” Her grip tightened just enough to be felt. “Every time you were hurt—I can't stand the thought of it. Every time you learned to endure something you shouldn’t have had to—I feel that too. I __”

“Stop.” Catra cut in.

Adora hesitated, but didn’t pull away.

“Is it really that hard,” Adora asked, softer now, “to believe I care about you?”

“Yes.”

The word escaped before Catra could cage it.

She braced for the follow-up—for the inevitable *why*. Why can’t you believe it? Why do you think you’re unlovable? Why do you flinch when someone reaches for you?

She knew the answers. She also knew they would poison anything they touched.

But Adora didn’t ask.

Finally, Adora spoke again. “Whoever it was,” she said, jaw set, “should have made sure you enjoyed it. From the beginning.”

Catra opened her mouth to argue, reflexively—but Adora shook her head once, cutting her off before the words could form.

“I know I can’t undo it,” Adora said. “I know I can’t rewrite your past. But when this is over—if you'll let me—” Her voice wavered just a fraction, then steadied. “I will spend the rest of my life making sure you never have to endure anything ever again.”

Catra scoffed, because scoffing was safer than believing. “That sounds suspiciously like one of those dramatic and unrealistic vows lovers make.”

Adora smiled then—not bright, not teasing. Certain.

“You can call it whatever you want,” she said. “I mean it.”

Catra looked away, jaw tight, heart racing in her chest.

She still has no idea.

But the smile lingered behind her closed eyes anyway.

✧

“I'm not going to, either,” Adora said.

It was the next morning, and the world had returned to motion as if nothing had altered it last night—boots in the courtyard, tack creaking, Sea Hawk’s men laughing over barrels as they made ready to depart. The inn behind them still wore the veneer of safety, but it was only borrowed.

But now they rode with a kind of stolen credibility. Sea Hawk’s bright banners fluttered above his wagons, and his presence wrapped them in a shield more effective than steel. Who was going to stop *Sea Hawk*, the *renowned* cloth merchant, and demand answers? Patrols would see the wagon train and look

away. Soldiers would salute and move on. For the first time in days, Catra could feel the tension in the air loosen—just slightly.

She hadn't even registered Adora drawing closer until the woman's voice was suddenly there, warm and maddeningly calm at her shoulder.

Catra's ears flicked. "Were you planning on saying something that makes sense," she drawled, "or is this another one of your inspirational Etherian declarations with no beginning and no end?"

Adora made a sound that might have been a laugh. "In case you wanted to know," she said, which clarified absolutely nothing.

Catra blinked, slow. "In case I wanted to know *what*, exactly?"

Adora glanced at her, sunlight catching in her gold hair.

"There isn't going to be some prince for me," Adora said. "No lord. No political marriage. None of it."

Catra stared straight ahead, as if the road required her full attention. "That's a relief for the entire nobility of Etheria," she said coolly.

Adora ignored the jab like she always did when it mattered the most. "I don't want to marry," she continued. Then, "Not unless it's you."

Pleasure at the thought rose instinctively, bright and dangerous, and Catra crushed it down so hard she could briefly feel the pain, deep in her stomach.

"Well," Catra said instead, dryly, "you already seem to have managed an heir, so that shouldn't be an issue. Perhaps you have a whole litter strewn about Etheria, given your…enthusiasm."

Adora's grin was immediate. "I think your perspective might be skewed by my enthusiasm for *Horde princesses*, specifically."

Catra's mouth twitched despite herself. She hated that she could feel heat creeping into her face. She kept her gaze fixed forward with stubborn discipline.

"Oh?" she said. "Because I can name at least a few dozen warriors in the Crimson Waste who would be thrilled to provide testimony to the contrary."

Adora's laughter softened. "I'm sure they would," she said, tone unbearably fond.

Catra's shoulders went tight, not from anger, but from the sheer unbearable ease of it all—this strange normality, this banter.

She refused to look at Adora. She refused to let herself see whatever expression was waiting for her there.

✧

On their second night riding under Sea Hawk's borrowed safety, Clone 28 and Keston finally fucked—or at least, they were caught in the act.

The presence of actual merchants had transformed Catra's ridiculous lie into something credible. Patrols no longer haunted the horizon; no sentry tower watched their slow crawl across the countryside with sharpened suspicion. For the first time since leaving Cazzle Cove, they were permitted the luxury of lodging that was not damp earth and hurried concealment. They were no longer forced to fold themselves into hedgerows and ruined stone like fugitives. Now they could stop at inns, wayhouses, places with roofs and food that didn't taste of necessity. A veneer of mundanity settled over the party like a thin cloak.

The first night with Sea Hawk had been almost…domestic, if Catra allowed herself to name it as such. An inn small enough that propriety had nowhere to hide. Catra, purely out of spite and entertainment, had insisted the Salineans teach her dice, "the Etherian way," and had cheated with such casual arrogance that it

took them far too long to catch her. Adora, patience worn thin, had threatened in a low voice to simply sling her over a shoulder and carry her upstairs before Catra could fleece anyone else.

"Mara," Sea Hawk had hissed, horrified. Catra had simply smiled sweetly over her winnings.

The room had been shared. The beds too close. Adora's warmth pressed at Catra's back in the dark. Sea Hawk, rigid with embarrassment in the other bed, had seemed far more flustered by the indignity of imposing on the Princess than by the sight of her curled against her so-called assistant with a familiarity that would have scandalized half of Bright Moon. Gregarious had slept on the floor without complaint. Catra had slept with Adora's arm around her waist and it was very nearly perfect.

The second night, they found a wayhouse—larger, offering more space and simultaneously less privacy. A dormitory of strangers and soldiers and thin partitions. It should, in theory, have discouraged anyone from foolishness.

In practice, it only meant that Clone 28 and Keston, possessed of the kind of reckless confidence that came from surviving too much danger in too short a span of time, sought solitude elsewhere.

Why they chose one of Sea Hawk's wagons, Catra could not have said. Perhaps it was the thrill of choosing one of the stupidest possible places to do one of the stupidest possible things. Perhaps Clone 28's brain was, as Catra had long suspected, mostly decorative. All Catra knew was that the outcome involved muffled commotion, an ill-timed interruption, and Sea Hawk emerging from the incident looking as if someone had physically struck him.

There was, later, the issue of the silk.

Catra, with what she considered tremendous generosity, had offered to pay for the—*ahem*—damage.

Sea Hawk, pale and visibly unwell, had refused with the strained dignity of a man trying not to have a nervous breakdown over his

defiled textiles.

The further east they travelled, the less Catra's mind could remain occupied by petty scandal or flirtation or the ridiculousness of their disguise. With the patrols eased, the silence inside her grew louder. Each mile of Etheria felt like a narrowing corridor. The end of the journey waited with perfect patience.

At first, she had been determined to treat these days as stolen treasure. A last indulgence. A final bright thing.

But the light of it hurt more, the longer she held it.

Because Adora looked at her like she meant it. Like Catra was really hers to keep. Like Catra was not already halfway gone. Adora smiled every time their eyes met, as if the future was something they owned.

I'm finally going to destroy you, Catra thought, not with triumph, but with sickness.

A part of her wanted to cling. To pull Adora down somewhere careless and private and make the world disappear. To speak every tenderness she had never learned how to voice. Another part of her wanted to sharpen herself back into something cruel enough that Adora wouldn't bleed so badly when the inevitable came.

None of it would help. Love wouldn't shorten the distance. Silence wouldn't spare her. Cruelty wouldn't work to push her away—Adora had already proven that. Catra could cut and cut and Adora would still reach for her with those stupid, gentle hands.

That night, long after the wayhouse had settled into the heavy rhythm of sleep, Catra slipped from her bed.

She moved through the maze of bodies and soft breaths, stepping carefully over limbs and discarded boots, listening to the creak of the building, the muffled sounds of sleep.

She found Adora in the dark.

She slid in beside her without a word.

Adora’s arm came around her as if it had been waiting there all along, instinctive and sure. A murmur brushed Catra’s throat—too quiet to catch.

Catra closed her eyes.

For a few stolen hours, she let herself pretend she wasn’t running out of time.

Chapter End Notes

Sorry 😇

Chapter 37: Catra

Chapter Notes

Thank you to my beta reader ❤️

See the end of the chapter for more notes

They found another inn before night fully settled, a low, wide-roofed place crouched beside the road. Lantern light glowed in its windows. The smell of cooked grain and stewed meat drifted out to meet them.

Sea Hawk did not pry. He was too well-bred, too conscious of rank and obligation, to ask questions outright—but curiosity radiated off him all the same, a pressure that built with every mile they traveled together. He spoke around it instead, narrating his thoughts aloud as if answers might volunteer themselves. He wondered about routes, about why certain decisions were made when others might have been easier. Each wondering was offered lightly, with a smile, an invitation that Catra declined with equal lightness.

She would not tell him. Not because she distrusted him—quite the opposite. Sea Hawk had proven himself steady, generous, and far more brave than his polished manners suggested. He had sheltered them, vouched for them, tied his fortunes to theirs without demanding explanation. That was precisely why Catra refused to give him one.

Information was a blade; the fewer hands it passed through, the fewer people bled. Sea Hawk did not deserve to carry weight that would make him a target.

Adora agreed. There had been no argument, no debate—just a look exchanged while Sea Hawk was distracted with his business, a shared understanding that settled instantly between them. It was one of those moments Catra found herself treasuring more

than she meant to: the ease of it, the way Adora understood without being told, the way she made the same choice without needing to hear Catra defend it. Sea Hawk would be protected. That was that.

It went on Catra's growing list of things that had to be managed carefully. People to shield. Secrets to keep. Outcomes to arrange without being present to see them through.

Trust, she had learned, was a dwindling resource.

Once, she would have trusted Lonnie without hesitation. Once, the decision would not even have registered as a decision. Now, the thought barely made it past contempt. Catra would not live long enough to grow comfortable placing anything important in Lonnie's hands again—not after everything that had been left unsaid. Lonnie rode with them still, the same extraordinarily capable soldier she had always been, but they might as well have been strangers. They did not speak unless duty required it. If Catra needed something done, she sent someone else. If Lonnie had information, she took it to Adora or Clone 28. Neither of them made any effort to change that arrangement.

Lonnie had not come to explain herself. She had not apologized. She had not raged, pleaded, justified, or even accused. She had not tried to curse Catra for what she'd said to Entrapta, or argue about what had happened, or defend the choice she'd made. The absence of it all—of anger, of regret, of anything—cut deeper than even the worst confrontation possibly could.

Catra wished, more than she liked to admit, that they had left Lonnie behind. Or turned her off. Or that Lonnie had chosen to leave on her own.

Catra was in love. Worse, she was planning something catastrophically stupid for the sake of that love. It didn't make her generous with forgiveness. It didn't soften the ache where loyalty used to sit. Lonnie's silence said everything Catra needed to hear. Years of shared survival on the Velvet Glove had not been enough

to warrant an explanation. Betrayal had come quietly, efficiently, without remorse.

And Lonnie should have known better.

Lonnie had seen Prime at work. She had seen how he twisted people, how he framed choices so that any answer led to harm. She had seen the pressure, the manipulation, the pain disguised as necessity. She knew what he did to people.

She knew what he did to me.

Catra did not absolve herself of responsibility. Entrapta's fate was hers to carry; she had pushed too hard, cut too deep, refused to listen until it was too late. But Lonnie's betrayal had come earlier—rooted not in cruelty, but in willful blindness. Lonnie had chosen not to see what should have been obvious. Chosen denial. Chosen Entrapta, and then stood by dumbly while everything unraveled.

Now that Entrapta was gone, Lonnie was left hollowed out by the choice she'd made.

Adora was the reason Lonnie still rode with them at all. She had argued for it on skill alone, and Catra knew better than to imagine she harbored some secret hope of reconciliation. Adora wasn't naïve enough to believe time would mend what had been broken. Lonnie hadn't sought Adora out either—not for friendship. A few words, exchanged when required. Nothing more.

Adora was no longer a fellow soldier. She was a queen now. Catra's lover. On the other side of an invisible line Lonnie could not or would not cross.

Lonnie followed orders. She did her job. She did not give more than was demanded of her. She did not reach for camaraderie with the others, not even with the new Entrapta, whose presence she seemed to tolerate rather than welcome. Whatever bonds Lonnie had once relied on, she had severed them herself. She had chosen differently. And now she rode alone among allies, serving because service was all she had left.

Duty without belief. Motion without purpose. Lonnie had lost her place. Lost her pride. Lost her lover. Lost whatever respect she had once held for her Princess.

Catra told herself she didn't care. She told herself she couldn't afford to.

There were too many things still to arrange. Too many people who would need guidance when she was gone. Too many loose ends that required a steady hand and a clear eye—someone who could be trusted to see things through without hesitation, without sentiment, without even a flinch.

Marzo would have been the obvious choice once. But Marzo was not with them, and distance was its own liability. Time, too. Too much could go wrong in the space between Catra's death and the realisation that there were final instructions to be carried out. A letter could be delayed. A letter could be opened by the wrong hand. A letter could vanish.

Catra had learned the hard way that paper could not be loyal.

She would not give the list to Adora. The thought didn't last long enough to become a real consideration. Adora would be grieving; Adora would be furious; Adora would be planning a war. And too many of Catra's arrangements—too many of the things she needed done quietly, gently, after she was gone—were about Adora herself. About keeping her protected from her own worst impulses. Adora could not be both the blade and the sheath. It had to be someone else.

That left Mermista.

Catra did not arrive at the idea easily. She circled it, resisted it, rejected it outright more than once. But the logic was stubborn. Mermista would look after Adora regardless of whether Catra asked her to. If Catra framed every instruction as being for Adora's benefit, Mermista would see it done—even if she hated every second of complying with Catra's wishes.

The problems were obvious, and there were three of them.

First: Mermista would absolutely tell Adora. She would justify it as honesty, or decency, or loyalty—but Catra knew better. It would come out the moment Mermista decided Adora deserved to know, which would be immediately.

Second: Mermista would not follow instructions precisely. Not out of incompetence—out of spite. If Catra said left, Mermista would consider right just to prove she hadn't followed blindly. A single deviation could unravel everything.

Third: Catra simply did not like her very much.

She was turning that last thought over, sharp and unproductive, when a voice slipped into the space just behind her ear.

"Mermista says I need to plead for your mercy. Apparently your glare is upsetting her."

Catra startled despite herself. The proximity did it—the warmth, the familiarity. The merchant who had occupied the chair beside her moments earlier had abandoned it with cheerful haste in pursuit of a barmaid, leaving Adora a clean opening. She slid neatly into the seat, close enough that their shoulders almost brushed, her posture casual, her head inclined as if delivering a private aside to her employer. To anyone watching, it was nothing more than an assistant passing along information.

Catra did not turn. She traced the rim of her cup with her thumb, grounding herself in the small, ordinary sensation. "Did she actually say *plead*?" she asked. "Or are you embellishing for effect?"

"Does the wording matter?"

"Of course it does," Catra said mildly. "If you're going to plead, you should commit to it properly. On your knees, ideally. Has your slave's etiquette declined that badly?"

The pause beside her was unmistakable. Adora flushed easily; Catra could hear it in the way her breath hitched, felt it in the brief stillness before she answered. Catra allowed herself a thin, private smile.

"Am I being summoned to her highness's chambers?" Adora asked at last. Her voice was steady, but there was an undercurrent there that Catra felt rather than heard.

Catra finally glanced at her, just enough to catch the way Adora's eyes had gone intent, searching. "Would you prefer the barn?" she asked. "It's closer to your rank."

"Come upstairs with me."

The request was so direct it caught Catra off guard. No teasing. No circling. She turned fully this time, studying Adora's face. There was caution there, yes—there always was—but also patience, and something like resolve. Adora still moved carefully around her, still waited for cues, still treated Catra's moods as something volatile that might flare if mishandled. She was never quite sure when Catra was baring teeth and when she was smiling.

Catra wasn't sure herself, sometimes.

"I doubt that was part of Mermista's strategy," Catra said.

"I'll kneel if you want me to," Adora replied quietly. "Just not here."

Catra huffed a soft, disbelieving laugh. "Do I look like I had doubts?"

"You look like you're planning something," Adora said. As always, she didn't soften the truth. Her gaze tracked Catra's face, attentively reading her. "And if you were going to let me in on it, you would have already."

She looked away, jaw tightening.

Adora spoke again before Catra could.

“Come upstairs,” she said.

Catra kept her eyes on her cup. On the rim. On anything except the way Adora’s voice was pitched low, like she meant it.

“Is that an order?” Catra asked, because it was safer to sound sharp than to sound wanting.

Adora’s mouth twisted.

“No.” A beat. “It’s me asking.”

Her hand lifted, hovered, then brushed Catra’s cheekbone—light enough it was almost nothing. The touch didn’t linger. Adora pulled back like she’d burned herself.

“Please,” Adora said. “You’ve been glaring so hard Mermista thinks you’re planning her funeral.”

Catra let out a short breath that could have been a laugh.

“She’s paranoid.”

Adora said, “You’ve been somewhere else all night.”

“We’re close,” Adora went on. “A couple days. After that… we won’t get rooms. We won’t get quiet. We won’t get—” She stopped, jaw working, like she didn’t want to say too much.

Catra’s mind flicked, involuntary, to the future—to the child she still hadn’t made herself picture properly. To the end of the road.

“Come upstairs,” Adora said again. “Just tonight. Don’t disappear on me.”

Catra swallowed.

She set the cup down carefully.

“Fine,” she said, voice cool by force. “Lead the way, Your Majesty.”

✧

There was a farmhouse squatting near the crossroads where Sea Hawk’s road would turn away from theirs, and they stopped there under the pretence of practicality—water for the horses, shade, an hour stolen from the worst of the heat. In truth, it was a pause before the last stretch. The air shimmered above the packed earth, and even the insects seemed to move lazily, as if Etheria itself had decided to breathe slow.

The journey had begun to feel like a rope tightening. Catra could sense the end of it now with every mile. The bright, stubborn resolve she had forced upon herself—the determination to savour what remained—had thinned to something brittle. Enjoy it, she had ordered herself. Be grateful. Don’t waste it. But gratitude was hard when happiness was a knife's edge, when every good moment made the loss to come sharper.

Sea Hawk, of course, knew the farmer.

It was beginning to seem that Sea Hawk didn’t travel so much as he simply existed in a web of people who owed him favours and smiles. The man’s wife appeared, sleeves rolled, hands flour-dusted, calling to daughters who hurried out with jugs of water and bread already cut.

Catra watched it all with a faint, strange ache.

“It’s almost impressive,” she drawled, because she couldn’t let awe sit naked in her voice. “Do you collect friends the way you collect bolts of cloth?”

Sea Hawk went pink at once, caught between pride and embarrassment.

“I—well, it’s sensible,” he said quickly, as though altruism were an accusation. “Trade runs on goodwill. People remember who doesn’t cheat them. And this…” He gestured at the shade, the

water, the blessed pause. “This is a convenient stop. I can afford to be generous when it keeps us from roasting alive.

He tried for levity, but Catra heard what he wouldn’t admit: he liked being helpful. He liked that his name opened doors instead of closing them.

The soldiers dragged a long table out beneath the farmer’s trees, muscles straining, boots scuffing dust. Etherian hands and Horde hands together on the same rough wood, steadying it without thinking.

The farmer’s household filled it—platters of meat, still warm. Bowls of fruit split open, jeweled and wet. Bread that tore with a soft sound instead of cracking like hard rations. Pastries glazed in honey that clung golden to Catra’s fingertips. Wine poured into shallow cups until it caught the dappled sunlight like liquid rubies.

They sat—Horde beside Etheria, noble beside common, warriors with scars and merchants with ink-stained fingers—all of them softened for a single afternoon into something…simple.

Catra’s hands were sticky. Her mouth tasted of sweetness. Her chest felt too full.

She listened.

She listened to Clone 28 mangling a First Ones phrase badly enough to make Keston wheeze with laughter. She listened to Mermista snorting into her cup when Sea Hawk launched into some overdramatic account of his travel over Etherian seas. She listened to the low, unfamiliar sound of Horde soldiers trying—really trying—to shape Etherian vowels with their blunt tongues.

It was ridiculous. It was miraculous.

Catra had forgotten that life could look like this. That peace, even brief, could be as ordinary as a table beneath a tree.

For so long she had lived like an animal kept hungry on purpose. The Velvet Glove, Prime's rooms, the endless careful calculation of survival. She had made herself numb to softness because softness was a trap. She had trained herself not to look at moments like this too closely because longing was dangerous.

And now—

Now honey was on her fingertips. Sun was on her face. Laughter was in her ears.

She felt something in her chest twist painfully, as though her heart only knew how to turn sweetness into ache.

It struck her with sudden, brutal clarity: she had never wanted to live so much.

Just… stay. See what happened next. See the Fright Zone and Etheria stitched together into something new. Watch Adora smile in a world that wasn't ending. Watch soldiers become friends instead of enemies. Have more afternoons that tasted like fruit and sunlight instead of blood and iron.

It was selfish.

She wanted to be selfish.

The fear of Prime's hands, of humiliation, of pain—those were old fears, familiar ones, almost expected. What was worse, what was unbearable, was the knowledge that she would not be there for the aftermath. That she would not get to see the peace she had helped drag into being with her own claws.

When the meal broke apart into movement again—Sea Hawk's people checking harnesses, soldiers refilling waterskins, the farmer's daughters gathering plates—Catra slid away as easily as a shadow.

No one stopped her. No one noticed. There was enough bustle, enough bright noise, for her to disappear without question.

She found the stream beyond the orchard, narrow and cool, water threading over stones with quiet burbling. The countryside opened around it in gentle rolls of green beneath a sky so wide it felt obscene. In the distance, the barest sliver of ocean glittered, bright and beautiful.

Etheria looked peaceful enough to make her angry.

Catra crouched, letting the cool air touch her face. Her throat felt tight. Her eyes burned.

She refused to let a tear fall.

She told herself it wasn't weakness. That this was not failure. That her life had always been a debt and she was simply paying it at last.

Prime's toys never lasted long. She could endure that.

What she could not endure, suddenly, was how much she would miss. How cruel it was that happiness had arrived like a gift at the very moment it would be taken away again.

She stared at the water until it blurred, until she couldn't tell if the shimmer was sunlight or something in her eyes.

It had to be now.

It had to be when she had finally learned what it meant to be held, to be loved, to sit under a tree and feel—just for a moment—like she belonged to the world instead of to Prime.

Catra dug her nails into her palms, grounding herself in sharpness.

She would do it. She would give herself up. She only hated—furiously, helplessly—that she had wanted more time.

She didn't have to look to know Adora was behind her. She never did. Adora moved through the world like warmth itself—inevitable,

bright, finding Catra even when Catra pretended she didn't want to be found.

Catra kept her eyes on the stream. The light hit the water in fractured pieces, shining brightly where it slipped over stones.

For a second, she let herself breathe it in. The quiet. The peace.

She was starting to forget what it had been like to hate Adora.

The thought landed wrong in her chest, sharp and strange.

Once, Catra had made her into a monster in her mind. But Adora wasn't a monster. She never had been. She was… just a girl who'd carried too much for too long.

Adora stepped closer.

"It's gorgeous," Catra murmured, because it was easier to talk about water and sunlight than anything else.

Adora made a sound, half laugh, half sigh. "It's boiling," she corrected gently. "You're literally roasting in this heat."

Catra huffed. "I'm fine."

"You're always 'fine,'" Adora said, unbearably fond, once again seeing straight through Catra.

Catra finally turned her head just enough to catch sight of her.

Adora hesitated, just a beat—then she crouched by the stream, dipping a scrap of cloth into the cold water. When she stood again, she held it out.

"Here," she said softly. "Let me."

Catra lowered her chin.

Adora's touch was careful at first, like she was asking permission with every movement. Cool water slid down the back of Catra's

neck, and her breath caught despite herself. Something in her loosened. Some knot she hadn't admitted was there. Adora stepped closer, bracing one hand against the tree behind Catra, leaning in until Catra could feel her heat at her back.

Adora's nose brushed Catra's damp hair, just behind her ear. Catra's pulse betrayed her instantly. The cloth traced slowly down the back of Catra's dress, and Adora's fingers lingered like she didn't know how to tear herself away.

"Better?" Adora asked, voice low.

Catra's mouth didn't cooperate, so she nodded, reaching out without thinking, hooking her fingers into the front of Adora's jacket. The trees around them were alive with small sounds—birdsong, leaves shifting, water murmuring to itself.

Adora brushed Catra's hair aside. Then, softer than anything, she pressed a kiss to the back of Catra's neck. Catra shut her eyes.

"When you marry me," Adora said suddenly, like she couldn't keep it in, like it was a secret she was desperate to speak into the world, "we'll spend summers in Mystacor."

Catra's eyes snapped open.

She let out a faint, disbelieving scoff. "Mystacor? Please. Summers belong in Salineas."

Adora's laugh was warm, rich, impossibly happy.

"Oh?" she murmured, lips still near Catra's ear. "So you're accepting my proposal now?"

Catra's stomach flipped. It would be so easy. To let it be real. To let herself fall into the shape of that future like it was waiting for her. But Catra had never been good at believing in happy endings. She tilted her head slightly, forcing something light into her voice.

“Proposal?” she drawled. “Wow. I must’ve missed the part where you actually asked.”

Catra was cruel, maybe. Weak, definitely.

Adora didn’t take the bait the way anyone else would’ve. She never did. Instead, she nuzzled into Catra’s hair like she was stubborn enough to stay anyway.

“I’m going to give you the most ridiculous wedding Etheria has ever seen,” Adora confessed. “The kind people talk about for a hundred years.”

Catra snorted. “Scorpia already promised me that.”

“She would,” Adora said, dry with affection. Then, brighter, “Okay, fine. Then we run away.”

Catra blinked.

“We make up terrible fake names. We get married in secret. The Queen of the Horde and the Queen of Etheria, eloping. We’ll be—”

“Queens?” Catra interrupted, sharp with disbelief.

Adora leaned in closer, mouth near Catra’s ear again.

“We’re going to win,” she said, fierce and certain in a way that made Catra’s chest ache. “I know it. And when we do…” Her fingers brushed the edge of Catra’s short hem. “You’ll win with me.”

Catra swallowed.

“And do you think,” she managed, voice unsteady under the sarcasm she tried to cling to, “that these wins will come with wedding ribbons attached?”

Adora shifted until Catra could tilt her head back and see her properly. Adora hovered over her, close enough that their breath

tangled. Her gaze was bright, unwavering. She spoke softly, like she was letting something sacred out into the world.

"I think," Adora murmured, "that I want everything with you. If you'll let me have it."

Her lips hovered just shy of Catra's—

"Just… say you will," Adora breathed, so close Catra could feel the words against her mouth. "Say you'll marry me."

"Wow," she murmured. "You really don't quit."

"That's not an answer," Adora said softly. Then, quieter, like she was truly begging, "Catra. Please."

Catra's entire body betrayed her on that word.

Please.

Heat unfurled beneath her skin, immediate and humiliating, and it had nothing to do with the summer air or the sun pressing down through the leaves. Her fingers were still twisted in the front of Adora's clothes, knuckles tight, like she could anchor herself there if she held on hard enough.

Like Adora might drift away if she didn't.

And Catra wanted—she wanted—

She wanted Adora against the tree, closer, closer, wanted the weight of her, the solidity of her, wanted the future Adora spoke about like it was already written. Like it was easy.

Catra's lips parted.

Yes sat right there, trembling on the edge of her tongue.

She could almost see it. Almost let herself fall into it. The ridiculous, impossible thing: peace.

Some stubborn, stupid part of Catra—the same part that had once believed no one could want to hurt her—wanted to believe Adora could make impossible things real.

Then—

"Your Highness."

Catra jerked, just slightly, all the air leaving her lungs at once.

Keston stood a few paces away, rigid with discomfort, eyes fixed somewhere over Catra's shoulder like looking directly at them might actually kill him.

"Sea Hawk and the merchants are ready," he said, strained. "They're preparing to depart."

Of course.

Of course the universe would interrupt.

Adora eased back immediately, her hands lifting away with reluctant care. The space she left behind was suddenly too cold, too empty, even though Catra was still dizzy with heat.

Catra shut her eyes for a second, forcing her heartbeat back into something that didn't feel so obvious.

When she opened them, Adora was already turning away, jaw tight, expression carefully neutral in the way she got when she was trying very hard not to look hurt by Catra.

Catra swallowed hard.

"Yes," she said, voice sharper than she meant it to be, because sharp was safer. "Fine. Thank you."

Keston nodded quickly, grateful for anything that moved away from the moment he'd so clearly interrupted.

Catra forced herself to straighten, to unclench her fingers, to let that moment die before it could become something worse.

“I want to see them off,” she added, like she hadn’t almost ruined herself on a single word.

Like she hadn’t almost said yes.

Chapter End Notes

One more Catra chapter, then it's back to Adora

Chapter 38: Catra

Chapter Notes

> Thank you to my beta reader, I'm sorry that you have to suffer first 🫠

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Sea Hawk was still talking, bright as a banner in the afternoon heat, leaning over the long rough table where they had lunched as if the conversation was a stage built solely for him. The farmer sat opposite, jaw tight, counting out coin with the resigned look of someone watching her savings bleed away piece by piece. Her wife and daughters hovered behind her, hands already stroking the bolts of cloth. Sea Hawk had talked them into the purchase, their faces lit with delight at the colours, the softness, the dresses they will soon be wearing. A discount had done little to ease the farmer's expression. Sea Hawk, however, looked triumphant, as though he had personally saved them from a life of drab fabric and duller days.

Baker stood beside Glimmer's wagon with her arms crossed, head stubbornly tipped toward the sun. She had not rejoined Double Trouble and the prisoner, putting it off with the same grim endurance Catra had seen in soldiers delaying a march into certain slaughter. The wagon's stale air, the endless jostle of wheels, Double Trouble's voice, sweet as poison, filling every silence. Hours and hours, day after day. Baker's restraint deserved an award. Catra approached anyway.

"I can't offer you much," Catra said, because gratitude felt flimsy in her mouth.

Baker didn't turn.

"My reward," Baker said, flat and certain, "will be Horde Prime's head on a pike."

Catra's mind supplied the image with unpleasant clarity. Adora, victorious, carrying that proof of conquest like a standard. Perhaps she would plant it outside Bright Moon's gates. Perhaps she would take it with her, a reminder lashed to the front of every future battle, grief turned into a symbol. Catra wondered, idly, if Adora would keep Bright Moon as her capital when she did what her mother could not, when she took the Fright Zone and made it hers by right of force and will. Catra wondered too, with a colder detachment, what would be left of her own body by the time Adora could come for it. She hoped there would be nothing recognizable. She did not want Adora kneeling beside rot, flies and decay where she had previously seen care and even warmth.

"I'd have put you on my council," Catra heard herself say, surprising both of them with her softness. "I like you."

Baker's mouth twitched. "A Horde ruler with a council," she mused. "You do enjoy stirring the pot."

Catra almost smiled. There were things she wanted to say then—instructions, requests, the shape of what needed to happen after—but she had no right to burden Baker with any more of her decisions and plans.

"Excuse me," she said instead, and went to bid Sea Hawk farewell.

That night, Catra laid out her sleeping bag first. The smallness of the act did not lessen its weight. The camp settled around them, voices low with laughter near the orange glow of the fire, the smell of smoke and crushed grass thick in the air. For the first time, Adora came to her, as opposed to the other way around. There was no careful pause, no guarded blue look that held a question underneath it, as if some part of her still waited for Catra to turn. Adora unrolled her bedding beside Catra's and lay down as if it was simply her place, close enough that the heat of her body pressed faintly through the space between them. Once more, Catra's chest ached

She lay on her back, staring up at the darkening sky, aware of the life slipping through her fingers even as it brushed her skin. Tomorrow waited, heavy and inevitable. She did not trust her voice to hold steady. She tried anyway.

"Adora," she whispered, scarcely louder than the crackle of the fire.

She hadn't thought Adora would hear her. Adora rolled immediately onto her side, facing her, propped on one elbow, grin soft and bright in the dim.

"What?" she murmured.

Catra swallowed against the pressure in her throat, because there were a hundred things she could not say. She shut her eyes and held herself very still.

She listened to the night until it steadied her—the low crackle of the fire, the distant murmur of voices that had not yet surrendered to sleep, the soft shift of someone's boots on dirt. Ordinary sounds…

Catra breathed in.

Breathed out.

She waited until the pressure behind her eyes eased, until she was sure she would not do something stupid, like cry. Crying was for people who needed to be comforted. Crying was for people with time to waste.

When she spoke, her voice came out rough and careless, as if it cost her nothing.

"Kiss me."

It was a thoughtless thing to ask. A reckless thing. The kind of indulgence Catra should have spared them both, and yet—

Adora didn’t hesitate.

She didn’t glance toward the soldiers still awake. She didn’t remind Catra that they weren’t alone, that someone might see. She only shifted closer.

“Bossy tonight,” Adora murmured, warmth threaded through the words.

Catra scoffed faintly. “Don’t start.”

Adora’s hand came up anyway, standily cupping Catra’s cheek. Her thumb brushed Catra’s bottom lip, slow, as if she were cataloguing the shape of her mouth.

Catra’s stomach twisted.

“Something’s up,” Adora said quietly—not accusing, just… knowing, in that infuriating way she always did. “You’re—”

“I’m fine,” Catra cut in immediately.

Adora’s eyes softened. “That’s never true when you say it like that.”

Catra’s laugh came out brittle. She didn’t want to talk. Talking would lead to questions. Questions would lead to answers Catra couldn’t afford to give.

“Kiss me,” she repeated, sharper, as if she could make it an order instead of a plea.

Adora went still for a beat, searching Catra’s face like she was trying to read the spaces between her words. Then she leaned in.

The kiss was gentle. Reverent, almost. The lightest brush of lips, a careful press that asked permission even after Catra had demanded it. A second kiss followed, slower, surer. Adora lingered like she was trying to memorise—as Catra was doing the same.

When she drew back, her thumb swept Catra's mouth again, and Adora was smiling in a way that didn't quite match the seriousness in her eyes.

Catra narrowed her gaze immediately, defensive by instinct. "What?"

"Nothing," Adora whispered. Then, softer, like the truth slipped out before she could stop it: "I still can't believe I get to do this."

Catra's throat tightened.

Of all the stupid things.

"All this time," Adora murmured, as if she were thinking out loud. "All those weeks where I thought you'd never let me close again. And now you're—"

Catra forced a smirk, because softness was dangerous. "Have you mistaken me for some other cat? Was I not obvious enough about how much I–"

The words stalled as she couldn't quite let herself say it.

Adora's mouth tilted. "What?"

Then she kissed Catra again before Catra could hide behind a joke or deflection.

This time it wasn't as careful. Adora's tongue teased at Catra's lips until Catra's old reflexes flared. She wanted to challenge, bite—needed to feel like she wasn't the only one undone. Catra nipped at her.

Adora laughed against her mouth, warm and helpless.

"There you are," Adora whispered, breathless.

Catra's fingers lifted, hesitating for the smallest moment before she slid them into Adora's hair. It was still absurdly soft, all those

golden curls, and Adora went utterly still, letting Catra take that small control. Catra smoothed the curls down, making her look almost civilized. Then, deliberately, she messed them up again.

Adora's eyes fluttered. "Hey…"

"What?" Catra asked, pretending innocence.

"That feels… really good," Adora admitted, voice gone low.

Catra's chest tightened. She wanted to swallow the sound of her voice, wanted to bury it somewhere safe where tomorrow couldn't touch it.

Instead, she said, "Kiss me," again.

Adora leaned in again, kissing Catra slowly at first—again—and then deeper, as if she couldn't help herself. Adora always kissed like she was savouring, like she was terrified of wasting a second. A careful slide of tongue, an intimacy that felt like helpless devotion.

Catra's breath stuttered.

When they broke apart, Catra was breathing harder than she wanted, warmth pooling beneath her skin. Adora didn't pull away far. Her gaze moved over Catra's face, searching. Her hand drifted down, no longer cupping Catra's cheek but resting against Catra's chest, right over her heart.

Catra went very still.

Because her heart was a traitor. It hammered wildly, frantic and alive, as though it didn't know it was living on borrowed time.

Adora felt it.

Her expression shifted—softness giving way to something frightened.

“Catra,” she whispered.

Catra’s mouth opened, instinctively ready with a deflection, a bite, a joke—

Don’t.

Don’t look at me like that.

“Catra,” Adora started again, voice catching on her name like it meant too much, “I—”

“Don’t,” Catra cut in immediately.

It came out sharper than she intended, too fast and panicked. She felt Adora still above her, felt the pause settle between them.

Adora didn’t pull away. Her brow knit, not in anger, but in that quiet, stubborn concentration she got when she refused to let Catra slip through her fingers. Her thumb moved in a small, absent motion against Catra’s chest, a soothing circle over the frantic beat beneath.

“Scared to hear it?” Adora asked softly.

Catra let out a humourless breath. Her eyes flicked away.

“You have no idea what you’re doing,” she murmured, and it was dangerously close to honesty. “You don’t know where this goes.”

Adora’s gaze held steady, impossibly sure. “I don’t care where it goes.”

“You will,” Catra said, the words scraping on the way out. “And then you’ll hate me for letting you—”

“I won’t.” Adora’s voice sharpened with fierce insistence. “Stop deciding that for me.”

Catra’s eyelids slid shut.

Adora waited.

Catra could feel her attention like heat, could feel the weight of her hand against her chest, the rise and fall of Catra's breathing beneath it, the way her heart betrayed her with every hammering pulse.

Adora knew her too well. That was the problem.

Finally, Catra swallowed, forcing air into her lungs like courage.

"Fine," she said, opening her eyes again. Her voice came out brittle, defiant. "Say it, then."

A challenge. A dare. Adora's expression softened so abruptly it almost hurt.

"I love you," she said.

The words were a gift, but they landed like a blow.

Not because Catra hadn't known—she had known, in the way she knew the sun would rise, in the way she knew Adora would always reach for her even with hands that had been burned.

But hearing it said like that, deliberate and bare, made it real.

Catra turned her face away.

Her hand came up, too quick, pushing Adora's hand from her chest as if she could shove the feeling off with it. She rolled onto her side, back turned, spine rigid.

Her throat ached.

The right answer hovered there, useless.

I love you too.

It should have been easy. It was *true*. It was *everything*.

The words stuck in her throat.

For a long moment she only stared into the dark, breath unsteady, fighting the tremor that seemed to encapsulate the whole of her being.

Then, finally, she managed, voice rough and unrecognizable, “Thank you.”

She heard Adora’s breath leave her behind, quiet and shattered, like Catra had simultaneously given her something and taken it away all at once.

The bedding shifted.

Adora moved closer, careful, as if Catra might bolt even now. Then she curled around Catra from behind, folding her body in, arms wrapping firm and protective across Catra’s middle. Adora’s forehead pressed lightly against the back of Catra’s neck.

✧

Catra slept—barely.

It was the shallow kind, the sort that never quite lets go of the waking world. She drifted in and out of it, aware the whole time of Adora’s arm heavy around her waist, the steady warmth of her pressed close, the slow, trusting rhythm of her breathing against Catra’s back. Every time Catra shifted, Adora murmured something indistinct and tightened her hold, instinctive and possessive even in sleep.

That was what finally forced Catra awake.

She lay there for a long moment, staring into the dark, letting the weight of Adora’s body brand itself into memory. This was how Adora held people when she believed she was safe. When she believed she was allowed to keep them.

Carefully, Catra disentangled herself. She slid Adora's arm away inch by inch, holding her breath when Adora stirred, waiting until the grip loosened again. Only when Adora settled did Catra move, easing out from the bedding, rising silently to her feet.

She didn't look back.

The wagon loomed a short distance away, quiet, unassuming, its canvas sides dark against the pale night. Catra crossed it.

She pulled the latch and swung the door open.

Glimmer looked up immediately.

She was seated on one her impromptu throne of cloth bolts, shoulders squared, chin lifted in that infuriatingly regal way she adopted when she refused to be cowed. Even disheveled, even exhausted, Glimmer radiated defiance.

Catra didn't waste time.

"It's Bow's," she said flatly. "The baby."

Glimmer froze.

Not denial. Not feigned confusion. Just stillness, sharp and telling.

"That's why you sent the baby away the moment you heard Adora was coming," Catra continued, stepping into the wagon and shutting the door behind her. "You didn't run. You didn't hide. You handed the child to Bow and stayed put, because you knew Prime would follow you."

Glimmer's eyes narrowed, but she said nothing.

"You needed a distraction," Catra went on, voice steady, ruthless. "And you needed Bow far away. Prime would assume the child was with you—in Adora's custody—long enough for Bow to get somewhere unreachable."

Glimmer exhaled slowly through her nose. “You’ve thought about this for a while.”

“I had to,” Catra said. “You don’t survive without thinking through every detail.”

She paced once, then stopped in front of Glimmer. “Prime would never trade you for your baby—and we both know there's no nursemaid. You’re valuable, sure—but not enough. A fully grown Queen? Disposable. A child he could raise, mold, control?” Catra shook her head. “That’s the prize he wants.”

A Princess for a Princess.

Glimmer’s mouth tightened. “Like you.”

Catra ignored her.

“You were never the exchange,” Catra said quietly. “And you knew it all along, as I did.”

All that was taken from you will be restored.

What Glimmer didn’t know, didn’t understand was that Prime was baiting Catra with another trade: Her life to spare Adora’s.

She had known from the beginning that Glimmer was surplus. A hostage, yes—but not the one Prime wanted.

And still.

Catra looked at Glimmer—at the tension in her shoulders, the exhaustion barely concealed beneath pride—and saw too much of herself there. Another ruler shaped by loss. Another orphaned woman bracing for a future built on grief.

She could not leave Glimmer caged for what would come next.

Not when Adora would come apart.

Not when Catra herself would no longer be there.

“I’m letting you go,” Catra said.

Glimmer stared at her. “Why?”

Catra’s jaw clenched. “Because after tomorrow, Adora will burn everything in her path looking for something to blame.”

Glimmer’s expression shifted then, something raw slipping through the cracks. “You think she’ll hurt me?”

“I know she will,” Catra said.

They stood there, measuring one another, two false queens balancing loss on opposite sides of the same blade.

Finally, Glimmer moved.

She took her time with it—almost defiantly. She pinned her hair back. She smoothed her dress, straightened the seams. Then she sat, pulled out paper, and wrote a letter in a firm, unshaking hand.

Catra waited.

When Glimmer finished, she folded the letter and tucked it into Catra’s awaiting hands. Then she took the keys Catra had proffered and unlocked the restraints herself.

Glimmer climbed down carefully, and Catra offered her hand without thinking. Glimmer took it. When Glimmer’s feet touched the ground, she let go.

They didn’t say goodbye.

Catra had her own obligations. Her own ending to arrange.

She didn’t waste time with whatever Glimmer had scrawled. A confession, a plea, a last attempt to polish her conscience. Catra had no interest in it. She shut the wagon door, turned the key with a decisive click, and left it sealed behind her as if it had never held anything but silence.

She moved through the camp with quiet purpose, doing what had to be done. Her own letter sat heavy in her possession, weighing much more than mere paper should. Delivering it was not bravery. It was simply the last loose thread to tie.

When it was finished, she returned to Adora.

Sleep did not come again.

It would have been sensible. Catra knew that, the way she knew a hundred sensible things she had never managed to do. Her body was tired, her mind worse, but the night refused to release her. She lay awake and listened.

She heard Glimmer's horse break into a gallop as it fled into the dark.

Catra did not bother imagining where Glimmer would run. Back to Bow, perhaps, stupid with relief and longing, dragging danger behind her like a banner. It didn't matter. The world would turn the way it turned. Catra's part in it was already narrowing to a single point.

In the long run, all of this would be cleaner for Adora.

Catra would be gone.

She would not remain as a thorn in Adora's grief, not remain as the target of some furious mistake Adora would carry for the rest of her life. Catra's presence—alive, bitter, gloating—would have been useless when the trade was made. Better to cut it away entirely.

She had scarcely settled back down when Adora stirred.

As if Catra's absence had registered even in her dreams.

Adora turned toward her with an unconscious insistence, arm looping around Catra's waist, drawing her close with the ease. Her face pressed briefly against Catra's shoulder.

“I swear, Mom,” Adora mumbled sleepily, voice thick with dreaming, “it was a unicorn. Not just a horse…”

Then she snuggled closer, satisfied, sinking back into peace.

Catra lay rigid for a moment, and then—slowly—she let herself breathe.

Adora was warm. Adora’s heartbeat was steady against her, as if tomorrow were an ordinary day, as if the sun would rise on a world that made sense.

The night was full of small sounds: insects in the grass, distant shifts of the remaining soldiers, the low murmur of the dying fire collapsing in on itself. Above them the stars moved with indifferent patience.

Catra stared up at them until her eyes burned.

She tried to memorize everything.

The weight of Adora’s arm draped over her, heavy and trusting. The scent of her—sweat and dust and horse, all of it mixing together. The soft exhale of her breathing. The way her body fit against Catra’s like it had always belonged there, like Catra had not spent years wishing Adora dead.

Catra held on to the night desperately, as though she could stop time through sheer force of will.

She wanted to command the stars to pause. She wanted to order the earth not to turn.

She wanted, absurdly, to tell the sun no.

But she had never had that kind of power. And she never would.

When the horizon began to pale, when the first thin blush of morning bled into the dark, Catra felt something inside her go very still.

It was over.

She eased herself free with the same care she had used earlier, slipping out from Adora’s arm without waking her. Adora made a small sound in protest, murmuring, but did not follow.

Catra rose.

She washed quickly with a ration of their drinking water. She dressed with deliberate hands, choosing the last clean white dress folded in her pack. White, like surrender.

She smoothed it down. She fixed herself into something presentable. She told herself she was satisfied.

That she had stolen enough. That these scraps of happiness were more than she had ever deserved.

As usual, it was a lie.

The morning light grew stronger, indifferent and unstoppable, and Catra stood underneath it, bracing herself for what she had chosen.

Chapter End Notes

I'm sorry 😚

Chapter 39: Adora

Chapter Notes

TW: description of dead bodies, brief comment alluding to necrophilia, Horde Prime being a creep

Thank you to my beta reader 🥰

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It was better not to bring Glimmer with them just yet.

Catra had said it plainly, with that clipped certainty she used when she'd already run every outcome and discarded the ones that ended badly. Don't drag her out until the exchange is real. Don't give them leverage too early.

Adora hadn't argued. She rarely did anymore when Catra spoke like that. There was a difference between Catra being contrary and Catra being precise, and Adora had learned to hear it.

So the two of them rode alone.

That, at least, suited the Crystal Castle.

The Castle did not admit armies. It did not tolerate threats. It stood apart from the world's shifting borders and alliances, its rules older than most nations still standing. It was a sanctum: a place for parley, not conquest. Pilgrims were permitted. Soldiers were not. They followed the prescribed approach, because there was no other way.

First came the whispering woods. The trees grew close together here, pale trunks rising swirled and twisted, their leaves brushing one another with a sound like distant voices carried on water. Adora felt it immediately, the subtle pressure at the edge of her awareness, the Castle noticing her. The magic here was old and quiet, not the kind that flared or burned. It watched. It waited.

Catra rode beside her, light and balanced in the saddle, eyes forward—already halfway elsewhere. Adora wondered, not for the first time, what Catra was thinking. She did not ask.

Beyond the woods rose the gates, built long after the First Ones were gone. Etherian hands had raised them, stone fitted to obsidian, iron sunk deep into foundations meant to last centuries. The Crystal Castle itself speared upward after that, a towering column of purple-black glass that caught the light and fractured it, white and violet glinting along its edges. Even at a distance, it was impossible to mistake it for anything else.

They stopped where the road ended and the incline began.

A voice descended from above, small only because of the height it fell from, amplified and impersonal. "You approach the Crystal Castle. Announce your purpose."

Adora shaded her eyes and looked up. Twenty feet above them, a figure in white stood motionless against the parapet.

"We are travelers," Adora called back, steady and respectful. "We come to pay tribute to the birthplace of She-Ra."

There was a pause. Not silence—never silence here—but a subtle shift, as if the Castle itself were listening to her intentions.

"Take the pledge," the voice said at last, "and be welcome."

Chains screamed into motion. The portcullis rose, heavy iron teeth lifting with a sound that echoed through the towers. Adora urged her horse forward, Catra matching her pace as they ascended the final rise, passing beneath the iron grate and between four immense obsidian towers. The scale of it was humbling, even now. Even knowing what lay beyond.

Inside the gates, they dismounted.

An older woman approached them, her white cloak pinned at the shoulder with a disc of worked gold. Her dress was the same

color, but richer for it—threads of real gold woven through the fabric, catching the light with each step she took. Her bearing was formal, the kind of authority that came from rules enforced for longer than anyone alive could remember.

They presented the tribute together, the weight of gold heavy and unquestioned as it passed from their hands. The woman accepted it without comment, then stepped closer, lifting a gold sash and placing it over Adora's head, then Catra's, letting the fabric settle around their necks.

"This is a place of peace," she said, voice calm and absolute. "No blow may be struck. No weapon may be drawn. Any who break the peace of the Crystal Castle will face the Castle's justice. Do you accept the pledge?"

Adora did not hesitate. "I do."

The woman turned to Catra.

"I do," Catra said, equally firm.

And with that, they were admitted.

Adora had not been prepared for the stillness.

Not the silence—there was a faint hum that threaded through the stone, a low resonance she felt more than heard—but the way the space seemed to settle around her, smoothing the edges of thought and breath alike. The Crystal Castle had always done that to her. Even now, even with everything pressing in, it reached something deep and steadied it without asking permission.

She had only ever been here for ceremonies. Formal occasions, with Princesses in attendance and banners hung just so, her mother standing tall at the center of it all. She remembered flashes: being very small, lifted high, light blinding on polished stone. She'd been told the story often enough that memory and retelling had blurred together—how she'd been presented, how Etheria had rejoiced at the return of a First Ones heir after two

thousand years, how hope had crystallized around her name—named for love like every She-Ra before her.

The stories never lingered on who had been standing off to the side.

They never mentioned Glimmer.

They never spoke of a promise diverted, of a crown that would have been placed on her instead, in this hall, before these sentries, beneath this unblinking gaze. Glimmer would have stood where Adora walked now. Angella would have called the Princesses together. The old rites would have been observed.

Now the sentries lined the hall, white and gold cloaks motionless, faces impassive. They were not Bright Moon guards, nor Horde soldiers, nor sworn to any single crown. They were the Crystal Castle's own—chosen from every province, bound by strict neutrality, serving two-year terms with immaculate discipline. They lived here, trained here, slept and woke within these walls, answering only to the Castle and its laws.

It was considered the highest honour to be selected. Nobles and soldiers competed fiercely in the yearly games for the chance. To serve here was to stand outside ordinary power, to uphold something older and more exacting.

Adora felt their eyes on her as she walked.

Watching.

She kept her gaze forward, Catra's presence a steady line at her side, the gold sash cool against her neck. The Castle hummed softly around them, ancient and indifferent, as if reminding her that whatever she was here to trade, whatever she was here to lose, it had seen greater sacrifices than this—and would see more long after she was gone.

"Mermista served here," Adora said, the words leaving her almost without permission. "Two years."

It surprised her, the way memory surfaced in a place like this. The Castle pulled old things up from the deep and held them in front of her, as if it insisted she look.

At fifteen, she had been proud of Mermista's selection. She had thrown her arms around her friend, congratulating her with all the brightness expected of a future Queen. And underneath it, threaded through the pride, there had been something else. The hollow knowledge of being left behind. The awareness that service here meant distance, meant separation, meant Mermista walking among the best fighters in Etheria while Adora remained… elsewhere.

Catra's gaze flicked to her, sharp and knowing.

"You were jealous."

Adora huffed a breath. "My mother said I needed to learn how to lead. Not follow other people into glory."

"She was right," Catra said simply.

Adora glanced at her.

Catra's mouth tilted, but there was no cruelty in it, only that maddening clarity she possessed. "You're She-Ra," she added, as if that explained everything. "Whether you like it or not."

They had already passed beneath the gates. The obsidian steps rose ahead, broad and worn smooth by centuries of feet. Processions had climbed these same stairs—queens draped in white and gold, She-Ras crowned in ceremony, pilgrims bowed with reverence. The stone itself bore the proof of time: shallow erosion where generations had ascended toward something sacred.

Adora felt it pressing in around her, the weight of history like a hand at her back.

“This is where it started,” she heard herself say quietly, voice softened by the vastness. “The first She-Ra was crowned here as Queen. Every She-Ra after her. Every ruler after her.”

Her words echoed faintly in the cavern of the approach.

They moved deeper into the Castle’s heart, past yet more sentries standing like statues beneath pillars of pale stone. The hall opened before them, immense and cool, purple-blue walls carved with reliefs that ran the length of the walkway: figures caught in stone, names chiseled beneath them, deeds preserved with merciless permanence.

Catra slowed.

She stopped in front of one carving—a woman astride a horse, chin lifted, sword lowered as if the war had ended at her command.

“That’s Carys,” Adora said, following Catra’s gaze. “She was She-Ra before Mara. She took the throne from Queen Seraphina. Stopped a civil war before it could tear Etheria apart, before the days of the Horde.”

Catra hummed, studying the sharp planes of the carved face.

“And this one?” she asked, nodding toward the next relief.

“That’s Kama. She built the palace at Bright Moon back when the First Ones were still here.”

The figure was outlined in stone, arms raised, holding a block of masonry as though it weighed nothing.

Catra’s eyes flickered, then she looked at Adora sidelong. “She looks like you.”

Adora blinked.

Before she could reply, Catra reached out—lightly, almost carelessly—and tapped the carved bicep, then, with a faintly amused audacity, tapped Adora's arm in the same place.

Adora let out a breath she hadn't meant to.

There was something transgressive about Catra's presence here. About walking beside her beneath these white arches, a Horde princess at the very center of Etheria's sanctum. Adora's mother would have barred the way without hesitation. She would have named Catra poison and enemy and would have thought little of it.

And yet Catra walked here now, slender against the scale of the hall, ears pricked with attention, expression calm.

Adora's pulse beat harder for reasons she couldn't name.

They continued.

"That's Nayeli," Adora said, her voice quieter now.

The carving showed a woman on her knees, head bowed. An axe was raised behind her neck.

"Nayeli broke the Castle's laws," Adora explained. "She drew a sword inside these walls."

Catra's gaze sharpened. "Why?"

"To protect her brother," Adora said. "Rami."

She indicated the next relief: a man standing stiffly, face turned away, the weight of judgment carved into his posture.

"He sentenced her himself," Adora murmured. "The laws here don't bend."

Catra's mouth tightened at that, just briefly, as if the Castle had struck something raw.

“The first,” Adora added, “and only true King of Etheria, as he too could wield the form of She-Ra.”

They passed them in succession—Caramia, Suki, Priya—names that had once been stories told in Bright Moon’s halls, now carved into stone so they could never be softened by retelling. Adora felt them pressing closer, all those women, all those crowns, all those sacrifices.

She had carried the title of She-Ra like armour.

Here, among the carvings, she felt simply human.

They reached the oldest relief at the end of the walk. The stone was rougher here, the carving cruder, as though it had been made before artistry had mattered, before anyone thought time would stretch so long.

A single name was etched beneath it in glyphic First Ones.

She-Ra.

“The first one,” Adora said, voice almost reverent. “Her real name’s been lost to time.”

Catra leaned closer, inspecting the worn face.

“Her nose is chipped,” she observed.

Adora gave a faint, helpless smile. “Time doesn’t spare anyone.”

“She unified Etheria,” Adora continued, and she could hear her mother’s old dreams in the words. Unity. Order. A world made whole beneath one rule. “Everything I have… it came from her. Passed down.”

Catra was quiet beside her.

They stood at the threshold now. Beyond lay the inner chamber, rougher stone, older still. The place where a princess could kneel

and rise crowned. The most inviolable space in Etheria.

The sentries flanked the entrance, motionless, watching.

Adora's chest tightened.

"As it'll pass," she said softly, almost to herself, "to my daughter."

The words tasted strange—hopeful and terrifying.

They stepped inside.

And there, in the heart of the chamber, sitting with obscene ease upon the heavy carved obsidian throne, was a figure waiting as though he had always belonged there.

The air changed. The hum of the Castle seemed to recoil from Adora entirely.

Adora's blood went cold.

Horde Prime smiled.

"Not quite," he said.

Adora went utterly still.

It was instantaneous, the way her body reacted—every muscle tightening, every nerve snapping awake. For a fraction of a second her mind did what it had been trained to do since childhood: calculate exits, count threats, anticipate the ambush that must surely follow.

Prime did not sit alone unless it was a trap.

Her gaze flicked across the chamber. The shadows between pillars. The doorway behind the throne. The vaulted spaces above where clones might be perched like carrion birds waiting for signal.

But there was no clatter of boots.

No ring of metal.

No swarm of identical faces.

There was only the immense, unnatural quiet of the Crystal Castle, the low hum of old stone underfoot, and the sentries standing at their posts with faces blank as carved stone. They did not move. They did not react. They might as well have been part of the architecture, sworn not to Etheria or Horde but to law.

And in the center of it, Horde Prime rose.

He did it slowly, as if time bent for him. He unfolded from the obsidian throne with an ease that was almost obscene, pale hands smoothing the front of his robes. The space suited him. The throne suited him. The Castle's vastness made him look not small, but inevitable.

He began to walk toward them.

Alone.

Adora felt her hand tighten reflexively on her sword hilt. The urge to draw was a physical thing, a thunder in her blood. She imagined the clean line of pale blue steel at Prime's throat, imagined the relief of action, the certainty of violence.

Then the Castle's laws rose in her mind like a wall.

No blow may be struck. No weapon may be drawn.

She forced her fingers to uncurl. Forced herself to breathe. Her sword remained sheathed, heavy at her hip, a reminder of helpless restraint.

Prime stopped several paces away. Close enough that Adora could see the calm intelligence in his eyes. Close enough that his presence felt like pressure in itself.

His attention turned first to Catra, as though Adora were merely scenery.

“Catra,” Prime said softly, almost fond. “You have deeply inconvenienced me.”

Catra did not flinch. Her posture was composed, shoulders straight, chin lifted with the insolence that had carried her through half a lifetime of defiance. But Adora saw it anyway—the faint movement at Catra’s throat, the betraying pulse. Control held tightly over something timid underneath.

“Inconvenienced?” Catra echoed. “Oh, right. You had to replace one of your pets.”

Her voice was light, almost bored, as if they were discussing a delayed shipment rather than death.

Prime’s gaze moved over her in a slow appraisal. It was not lustful. It was ownership. The look of someone examining an object they wished to reacquire.

“That tone,” Prime murmured. “It never suited you. Little-girl petulance on a woman is… unattractive.”

Catra’s mouth curved. Sharp.

Adora should have known then, but only Entrapta and Kyle came to mind.

“You prefer your women quiet? No wait—you prefer them prepubescent.”

Prime’s expression did not change.

“You know,” he went on, conversational, “Kyle believed you might help him. Poor creature. He did not understand you. That you abandon people out of spite.” His voice softened fractionally, almost curious. “Or was it something else? Why did you make me kill him?”

Catra’s smile showed teeth. “Your toy? I didn’t realize anyone would miss him.”

Adora’s stomach turned. She had forgotten, somehow, the particular cruelty of Catra and Prime in conversation—words as weapons, each strike meant to cut deeper than steel ever could.

Prime’s voice remained mild. “He has been replaced easily.”

“Of course he has,” Catra said. “It's hard to keep someone around after you’ve had them decapitated. I'm sure you found use of the holes… but the smell…”

Adora’s breath caught despite herself. Her skin prickled with the wrongness of hearing such filth spoken here, in this chamber where queens had been crowned. Prime’s head tilted slightly, and his attention shifted at last, as though noticing Adora for the first time.

“I assume,” Prime said, “that whatever crude satisfaction you take from her has dulled your judgment of her disgusting character.”

Adora’s jaw clenched.

Prime’s voice was almost amused. “You are Etherian. There must be something gratifying in placing the Horde’s princess beneath you. In imagining you’ve conquered her in some small way.”

Adora felt heat rise behind her eyes. Her hands curled at her sides.

Prime continued, unhurried. “She has always been unpleasant to be around. But perhaps that disappears for you when you are fucking.”

Adora’s voice came out steady only by force. “You’re alone.”

Prime blinked slowly, two eyes at a time.

“You have no weapons,” Adora said. “No clones. No army. You may have surprised us, but surprise isn’t power. Your words are nothing.”

Prime’s smile was slight. “By surprise?” he repeated, as if tasting the phrase. “You are refreshingly naïve, Adora.”

His gaze flicked, almost lazily, toward Catra.

“Catra was expecting me.”

Adora froze.

Prime’s voice remained soft. “She has come to offer herself in exchange for the *child*.”

The words were absurd. They did not fit inside Adora’s mind. They slid off, impossible.

“Catra isn’t here to give herself up,” Adora retorted instantly, sharply, as though saying it could make it true.

The immediate silence that followed proved her wrong.

She turned her head.

Catra stood very still.

Her face had gone pale in a way Adora had never seen before, stripped of sarcasm, stripped of fight. Her shoulders were straight, her expression carefully empty. Not surprise. Not denial. Acceptance. Like a door already closed.

Adora felt something inside her drop, cold and sick.

All that was taken from you will be restored.

The bargain, suddenly visible in retrospect, laid out like bones. It was bait—a lure for Catra to do this.

The Castle's shimmering purple obsidian seemed to loom higher, colder. The sentries in white and gold looked on without faces, without mercy. The sanctity of the place was not protection. It was a cage.

Adora's voice cracked. "No."

It came out small, nothing like the great, booming voice of She-Ra. Prime watched her, calm as a tide. Catra did not look away. And Adora understood, in one terrible instant, that Catra had known the ending long before Adora ever stepped onto these stairs.

Prime's voice carried easily in the chamber, as though the Crystal Castle itself were built to amplify him.

"My ward is so very consistent with her trickery," he said, mild with satisfaction. "She released Glimmer, because she understands value. She knows I would never relinquish something truly advantageous in exchange for a false Queen who has already served her purpose. She has calculated correctly."

Adora's stomach twisted.

Prime's eyes remained on Catra as he continued, almost conversational, almost indulgent. "And then she came here. Not because she believes in mercy. Not because she expects kindness. Not even because she believes I truly have the child."

Catra stood like a drawn wire. Her silence was the silence of someone stripped bare. She did not look at Adora. Her breathing was shallow, controlled with effort, shoulders rigid as if she were bracing for a blow that could not be struck.

"She has offered herself," Prime went on, "for the child's life. It does not matter to her whose child it is. She only knows it is vulnerable. That you will never fight me freely while you believe I hold it. She has found the most efficient way to ensure that, in the end, you win—or at least that's what she hopes."

Adora’s heart hammered. The words throbbed with wrongness.

“An exchange. Her life, for yours.”

Catra’s jaw clenched, a muscle ticking once, betraying the strain of her composure.

Prime’s tone shifted, almost lazily dismissive. “But the exchange does not interest me, little sister.”

The pause that followed was razor-thin.

Catra’s head snapped up, and for the first time her mask cracked. Adora saw the flash—alarm, calculation, something tightening fast into fear.

“It’s a trap,” Catra said, voice suddenly sharp. “Don’t listen to him. You need to go. Now.”

Prime spread his hands, palms open, as if amused by the urgency. “And yet,” he said, “I am here alone.”

Catra’s eyes flicked to Adora, desperate now. “Adora. Get out.”

Adora’s feet did not move.

“No,” she said, steady only because she forced it. “He’s just one man.”

“Adora,” Catra warned, and there was something raw under the name, something that sounded too much like *please*.

“No.”

Adora made herself look at Prime fully. Pale, composed, poisonous in his calm.

“I’m the one you came to bargain with,” Adora said, lifting her chin. “So talk to me. Tell me what you want for the child.”

Prime’s expression warmed with something like pity.

“Oh,” he said. “No.”

The single syllable landed like a closed door.

“The child is not a piece I intend to relinquish, for I simply don't have her.” Prime continued smoothly. “Were you imagining some grand gesture? A heroic trade? I find such theatrics tiresome.”

Adora’s hands curled at her sides.

Prime’s gaze returned to Catra. “No, Adora. I am here for her.”

Catra went still.

“She will die for her crimes,” Prime said, as though reciting a simple truth. “I do not need to negotiate. I do not need to surrender a child”—his smile sharpened—“whom Catra has already realised I never even possessed.”

Adora’s breath caught.

Prime tilted his head, almost thoughtful. “Catra is going to kneel. She is going to beg me to take her.”

His eyes gleamed.

“Aren’t you, Catra?”

Catra’s voice came out tight, furious. “Adora, I told you to leave.”

“She will never kneel to you,” Adora said, stepping forward without thinking, placing herself between Catra and Prime.

Prime regarded her with mild curiosity.

“You don’t believe so?” Prime murmured.

Behind Adora, Catra’s voice sharpened again. “Adora.”

Prime’s smile widened slightly.

“She wants you gone,” he observed. “Doesn’t that intrigue you? Don’t you wonder why?”

“Adora,” Catra said again, and the repetition was a fracture.

Prime’s voice was gentle.

“She has knelt for me—as I am sure she has knelt for you.”

For a moment, it didn’t register. Just words. Sounds arranged into meaning that Adora’s mind refused to accept. Then Adora turned her head. Catra’s cheeks had gone crimson, vivid as blood against her face. Her eyes were bright with something like humiliation. And the meaning of Prime’s words forced itself into Adora’s skull, inexorable.

“I ought to have sent her away,” he said. “But who can deny a girl like that, when she looks up at you and asks you not to leave?”

Adora’s vision narrowed.

“She was so lonely,” Prime continued, voice soft with calculated cruelty. “After her mother died. So desperate for someone to hold on to. She's always had a tendency to whore herself out to anyone who will give her a shred of attention—as you would know.”

Catra’s body had gone rigid, as though she might shatter with any movement.

Something in Adora snapped.

The rage was immediate. Pure. Clarifying.

It burned through every other thought, every restraint, every law carved into the Castle’s stone.

Catra’s face—white, stricken, the horror of recognition widening her eyes—the sudden shift of the sentries at the sharp, unmistakable sound of the Sword of Protection answering Adora’s

call—none of it mattered for more than a heartbeat. They were impressions only, shards of sensation that glanced off something harder and hotter inside her.

Adora had her sword in her hand.

She was moving.

She was going to put it through Horde Prime.

The thought did not arrive dressed as intention or decision. It simply existed, complete and absolute, as though it had always been there, waiting for permission. Prime was unarmed. That did not register as mercy or restraint. It registered as opportunity.

A white-and-gold shape lunged into her path.

Then another.

The clear ring of steel had shattered the hall's equilibrium, and the Crystal Castle responded as it was designed to: with immediate, overwhelming force. Sentries poured in from every arch and corridor, their voices colliding in shouted commands—*Stop her! Stand down!*—boots striking obsidian in hard, echoing rhythm.

They were in her way.

She hit the first without breaking stride. Bone gave with a wet, dull crunch beneath her swing; the sentry went down screaming. Another came at her flank. She drove an elbow back, felt ribs shift and collapse. These were not ordinary soldiers—they were the best Etheria had, chosen, trained, disciplined—but none of that mattered. The world had narrowed to a single point of focus.

Horde Prime.

She tore forward, dragging resistance with her like undertow. Hands grabbed her arms, her shoulders, her waist. She shook them off, wrenched free, and kept moving, sheer strength carrying her through bodies the way a tide carries debris.

Someone struck her head from the side. Her vision exploded into black and white. She staggered, teeth clenching, then forced herself upright and drove on.

Another blow caught her squarely at the back of the skull.

Her knees slammed into the floor with a sound that reverberated through the hall.

She felt herself wrenched apart—arms twisted, forced behind her, pressure driving her down. Cold metal snapped closed around her wrists, her ankles, the sudden weight and bite of restraints locking her into immobility before she could fully process it. She surged against them, muscles screaming, but there was nowhere to go. Her body was pinned, bound, and reduced.

Her breath came harsh and ragged.

Slowly—*brutally*—awareness crept back in.

It was not a clean return. It came in pieces, like shards under her skin. Sensation first: the bite of iron at her wrists, the raw ache in her shoulders, the cold kiss of stone against her knees. Then sound: the ragged pull of her own breathing, the distant drip of something liquid striking stone, the low, stunned murmur of voices.

Her sword lay discarded on the floor a short distance away.

It looked wrong there. Not noble. Not symbolic. Just metal, heavy and smeared. The blade was darkened almost to black with blood that was not clearly Prime's, clotted in uneven streaks along the fuller. It had dragged across stone, leaving a thin, ugly line behind it, like a wound in the floor itself.

White-and-gold cloaks filled the hall.

Or rather—white-and-gold cloaks filled the floor the way fallen flags fill a battlefield.

Some were standing, rigid with shock, their formation broken beyond recognition. Others lay where they had dropped, bodies at awkward angles, limbs bent wrong beneath the weight of their fallen bodies. The sanctum had become something else entirely: a place of ruin dressed in the Castle's colours.

One sentry knelt nearby, both hands pressed desperately to her abdomen. Her fingers were slick and red. Blood blossomed across her pristine livery in a spreading stain, soaking through the white fabric until it turned heavy and dark. It ran in rivulets between her fingers, dripping steadily onto the obsidian with a quiet, rhythmic sound.

She made a small noise, not quite a sob, not quite a breath.

Adora's stomach turned.

Beyond her, another soldier lay on his side, face half-hidden by his own cloak. His helmet had rolled away, revealing a slack jaw and eyes fixed on nothing.

Further still, bodies were scattered like broken pieces.

A sentry sprawled near the base of a pillar, one arm outstretched as if she'd tried to catch herself. Her hand was still curled, fingers frozen mid-grasp. Blood pooled beneath her shoulder, spreading slowly, patiently, as if the Castle itself were drinking it.

Another lay facedown, cloak fanned out around her like a fallen wing. The gold thread woven into the fabric caught the light even now, glittering obscenely bright beside the dark smear beneath her ribs.

The three of them were not moving at all.

There was a particular stillness to death. The air tasted different around it—metallic, thick, wrong.

The living sentries stood as if afraid to even shift their weight. Some clutched injuries with shaking hands. One leaned heavily

against another, face white beneath her helm, blood running from a split lip. Another held her arm at an unnatural angle, teeth bared against pain.

They looked at Adora the way people looked at great storms.

Not with hatred.

With awe and fear and the sick knowledge of what true, unchecked force could do.

Adora's own hands were restrained, but she could feel the phantom weight of the sword in them, and could feel the echo of motion in her muscles. Her body remembered the violence even if her mind had not been present for it.

What had she done?

The Castle's white and gold—colours of peace, of sanctity—were ruined everywhere she looked. Footprints tracked through blood like muddy prints after rain, leading nowhere orderly, only increasing the chaos.

It was as though her rage had painted the hall.

The hum of the Crystal Castle continued beneath it all, indifferent and ancient. Its laws broken, its floor stained, its sentries fallen.

Adora's breath came harsh, scraping.

The worst part was that the devastation in the hall was hers—every broken body, every spreading stain, every life spilling out onto sacred stone—and it had gained her nothing at all.

Prime stood untouched.

He hadn't even stepped back.

In the raw silence that followed, broken only by laboured breathing and the faint hum of the Castle, a sentry rose from one

knee. Her face was pale but composed, her voice steady with the weight of responsibility.

"You have drawn a blade within the Crystal Castle."

Adora lifted her head. Her eyes found Prime's, locked there with a ferocity that made the restraints feel meaningless.

"I'm going to kill you," she said. It wasn't a threat—it was a *promise*.

"You have broken the peace of the hall," the sentry continued.

"The moment you put your hands on her," Adora said hoarsely, "you were dead. I became your destiny."

"The laws of the Crystal Castle are inviolable."

"I will be the last thing you see," she said, never looking away from Prime. "You will die with my blade in your chest."

"Your life is forfeit to the King," the sentry said.

The words registered. The absurdity of them cut through the rage just enough to ignite something sharper.

"The King?" Adora echoed, voice thick with contempt. "What king? Etheria doesn't have a king."

She turned her head then, just enough to see Catra.

Catra was restrained with one sentry holding her arms pinned behind her back. She hadn't fought—not like Adora had. She stood rigid, breathing shallow, eyes enormous as they fixed on Adora, terror and unbearable shame flickering across her face.

"There is a King here," Prime said.

The calm certainty in his voice was unbearable.

And then, inevitably, the reality of what Adora had done began to settle in.

She saw the hall properly—the blood streaking the purple obsidian, the disarray of the sentries, the broken bodies, the sanctum violated beyond repair. The Castle's peace lay in fragments at her knees.

"No," Adora said, and it came out rough, pleading despite herself. "You heard him. All of you heard what he said. Are you really going to let him do this?"

The sentry did not look at her.

She turned instead and approached Horde Prime.

Adora surged again, chains biting into her skin, pain flaring white-hot along her arms as the soldiers holding her tightened their grip.

The sentry bowed her head to Prime.

"You are King of the Horde, not of Etheria," she said. "But the attack was made against you. A monarch's judgment is recognized within the Crystal Castle."

"Pass your sentence."

"Kill her," Prime said.

The words were delivered with the same indifferent calm he might have used to comment on the weather. No anger. No urgency. Only authority, absolute and unquestioned.

Adora's cheek was forced hard against the cold obsidian. Someone pressed her forehead down, pinning her in place. Her arms ached in the restraints, shoulders burning where she had fought. She tasted blood in her mouth—her own, or someone else's, she couldn't tell.

There was a scrape of metal.

Her sword.

The Sword of Protection, dragged across stone with a sound that made something in her flinch. A white-and-gold-cloaked soldier stepped forward, lifting it in a two-handed grip, the stance of an executioner. The blade looked wrong in those hands.

Adora's breath came sharp.

"No," Catra said.

The single word cracked through the hall.

It wasn't shouted. It wasn't frantic. It was flat—hollowed out of emotion so completely that Adora barely recognized it as Catra's voice at all.

"Stop," Catra added, speaking directly to Prime, not to the sentries. "It's me you want."

Adora's head jerked, chains biting as she tried to turn.

"Catra—" she rasped.

Catra's eyes did not go to her. She kept them fixed forward, as though looking at Adora would shatter the fragile control holding her upright.

"It's me," Catra repeated, detached, unrelenting. "Not her."

Prime regarded her mildly.

"I don't want you, Catra," he said, as if correcting a childish misunderstanding. "You are inconvenient. A persistent irritation I intend to remove from my path."

Adora surged uselessly, the restraints holding, soldiers tightening their grip.

“Catra,” she said again, rough with disbelief. “Don’t—”

Catra spoke over her.

“I’ll go,” she said, voice steady in a way that felt wrong. “Just let her—”

She swallowed, the smallest hitch in her breath.

“Let her live. Let her leave here intact. Take me.”

The soldier holding Adora’s sword hesitated, looking toward Prime for confirmation. The blade trembled faintly in her hands.

Prime’s attention sharpened. All of it settled on Catra.

For a long moment he simply watched her, as though savouring the shape of the choice.

Then he said, softly:

“Beg.”

Catra was still restrained, one arm twisted behind her back by a sentry whose grip was ruthless. Her white dress was rumpled, pulled askew. She looked small in the vastness of the hall, swallowed by purple stone and gold-cloaked law.

The sentry released her abruptly, shoving her forward.

Catra caught herself without quite stumbling.

Adora’s chest tightened.

One step.

Then another.

It was like watching someone walk toward a cliff edge without slowing. Catra moved with a terrible steadiness, each footfall

controlled, as though she had already left her body and was simply guiding it through the motions.

She stopped before Prime.

Then, slowly, she went down.

Her knees met the cold stone.

The sound seemed impossibly loud.

“Please,” Catra said.

The word looked wrong on her. Catra, who had never yielded.

“Please, Prime,” she continued, voice low, careful. “I was wrong to defy you. I deserve punishment.”

Adora’s throat closed.

No one stopped it.

The Crystal Castle stood around them, sacred and indifferent, its sentries witnesses rather than saviors. Prime’s eyes moved over Catra with something like paternal satisfaction, finally receiving an overdue act of obedience.

Catra’s hands curled against the floor, fingers tense.

“Please,” she said again. “Take me.”

The sentry who had pronounced the laws turned slightly, rigid with ceremony, and addressed Prime.

“Is this exchange acceptable?”

Prime paused, as if considering generosity. Then he smiled.

“I believe it is.” His voice warmed with a false benevolence. “You see, Catra? I am not unreasonable. When you are properly contrite, I can be merciful.”

Catra’s jaw clenched so tightly Adora saw the muscle jump.

“Yes,” Catra said, mechanically. “Thank you, Prime.”

The sentry bowed her head.

“An exchange of life satisfies the Castle’s law. The ward will be released to you for punishment. The other will be held until morning, then released. Let the will of the King be done.”

Around the hall, the other sentries echoed it, one after another, the phrase rippling outward like a spell.

“Let the will of the King be done.”

Adora strained against her chains until pain lanced down her arms.

“No,” she said, hoarse, broken. “No—stop—”

Catra did not look back.

Her eyes were fixed on nothing, green-gold and glazed, her breathing shallow beneath the thin cotton of her dress. Her whole body was drawn tight, an attempt to hold herself together through sheer force.

Prime stepped closer, satisfied.

“Come,” he said softly, almost intimate. “Little sister. Let's go home.”

And Catra rose.

She went with him.

Adora watched, helpless on her knees, as the only person she had ever wanted was taken away.

Chapter End Notes

Alright...
2 week hiatus sound good?
I think a couple weeks away from writing this one will leave me feeling fresh and ready to press on.

Also, this is where the story really deviates from Captive Prince. My ending will be completely different to how King's Rising concluded. Still a happy ending but very significant changes imo. If you've been reading along with Capri, waiting until after this to read it, you can finish it off without spoilers. If you've already read it, you'll have no idea how this ends.

During my hiatus I will post a couple more chapters of Rise With Me, my cyberpunk She-Ra AU fic. I'm already 4 chapters (please read it, I promise it'll be good)

Otherwise I will be working on a little She-Ra comic, posted to my Patreon (cjowoart), which is only $2 (usd) btw.

I did write a lot this week (over 17000 words), didn't sleep very well (my own fault) but that will be slowing down as I focus on reopening my family day care. Money is tight and I am finally well enough to consider it again.

Thank you so much for reading. I love reading all of your comments.

Chapter 40: Adora

Chapter Notes

Happy Valentine's Day 💝

I actually forgot it was Valentine's day until my partner told me he had a present for me. This is our tradition: I forgot one year, he forgets the other. It's worked for 8 years.

Thank you to my beta reader 🥰

See the end of the chapter for more notes

They held her until first light.

Not in a cell—there had been no need. The Crystal Castle had no dungeons. It had laws, and hands enough to enforce them. They kept her on her knees against the far wall of the hall, wrists chained, ankles shackled, a ring of white-and-gold cloaks at measured intervals. No one spoke to her. No one needed to. The Castle’s judgment had already been pronounced.

Adora drifted in and out of a dark, pulsing haze. Exhaustion pressed down on her skull, but it never quite swallowed her. Every time her head dipped, she saw blood on obsidian. White cloth turned red. Catra on her knees.

She tested the chains until the metal tore skin from bone. She twisted, strained, lunged when she thought a gap opened. Each time she was driven back down with professional efficiency—no cruelty, no anger. Only enforcement.

By the time dawn bled pale and merciless across the sky, she was shaking with fatigue and fury both.

They marched her back to the camp with her hands bound again, rope biting where iron had already bruised. She stumbled once and was jerked upright. She fought intermittently the whole way,

though it was based less on strategy than instinct—small, savage bursts of resistance that gained her nothing except more bruises.

When they reached the camp, they did not slow.

They shoved her forward.

She hit the ground hard enough to jar her teeth and went to her knees, hands still tied behind her. The world swam briefly—canvas wagons, pale morning light, faces emerging.

Lonnie was already moving.

She came forward with her sword half-drawn, fury plain on her face. For a second, Adora thought she might actually swing.

Mermista caught her by the arm.

"Don't," Mermista snapped, low and sharp, eyes flicking to the white-and-gold cloaks with open calculation. There was fear there—but mainly respect. Mermista knew what those uniforms meant.

Lonnie's jaw worked, but she didn't lunge.

Mermista stepped past her instead.

Adora pushed herself upright. Her legs felt unreliable beneath her. Mermista grabbed her shoulder to steady her and, without ceremony, reached back with a knife. The blade sliced clean through the ropes at Adora's wrists.

The sudden slack made her sway.

"Where is she?" Mermista asked.

Adora tried to answer and found her throat closing. She forced it open.

"She's with Prime."

The words came out flat and unfamiliar. She tried again, but nothing followed. Just air.

She was a soldier. She had seen battlefields. She had seen what happened when men were allowed to take whatever they wanted. She had watched comrades die. She had thought she understood brutality.

Kyle's head pulled from a bloodied sack.

Entrapta's body, cold and lifeless.

She had thought she understood.

The light was too bright. It cut into her vision like a knife.

Mermista was speaking again, but it sounded distant.

"I know you cared about her," Mermista was saying, voice pitched low, urgent. "If you're going to throw up, do it now. We don't have time to stand around. Clones will already be tracking us."

Through the ringing in her ears, Lonnie's voice cut clean and furious.

"You left her?" Lonnie demanded. "You left her there? With him!"

Adora looked up slowly.

People had come out of the wagons. Double Trouble leaned against a wheel, expression unreadable. Baker stood stiff, arms folded. The medic clone hovered just behind, eyes flicking between them with clinical focus.

Lonnie stepped closer, fury overtaking restraint.

"You saved yourself," Lonnie spat. "You left her with him."

Mermista moved before Adora could. She seized Lonnie by the front of her tunic and slammed her back against the side of a wagon with a sharp crack of wood.

“You will not speak to her like that,” Mermista snapped. “You will respect our Queen.”

“Let her go,” Adora said hoarsely.

Her voice sounded wrecked. She stepped between them without quite remembering how her feet moved.

“Let her go,” she repeated. “She’s loyal. You’d be saying the same thing if Catra came back alone.”

Mermista released Lonnie, though her eyes were still blazing. She took two steps back, but her hand came to Adora’s shoulder again, steadying without asking.

Lonnie straightened, breathing hard.

“She wouldn’t have come back alone,” Lonnie said, voice raw. “If you think she would, you didn’t know her at all.”

Adora didn’t answer.

Mermista squeezed her shoulder once, then addressed Lonnie without looking away from Adora’s face.

“Stop,” she said. “Can’t you see she’s barely standing?”

“What’s he going to do to her?” Lonnie demanded, cutting through it all. “What’s going to happen now?”

Adora’s mouth moved before she could soften it, “He’ll kill her.”

Just the truth.

The camp seemed to shrink around them.

Mermista swore under her breath.

“We can’t stay here,” she said quickly. “We move. Now. Before—”

“No.”

Adora pressed her hand hard to her forehead as if she could steady the chaos inside it. Thoughts collided and dissolved before they could form. Plans, angles, contingencies—nothing would hold.

She could hear Catra's frustrated voice in her head. *I can't think.*

Now, Adora understood what that meant.

She lifted her head sharply, gaze cutting toward the wagons.

"Where is Glimmer?"

✧

Adora caught her within the hour.

Glimmer had not pushed her horse hard enough. She must have believed she had time—must have thought Adora would be contained by shock, or command, or grief. The road cut pale through the trees ahead, and Glimmer's back was unmistakable in the saddle, rigid with purpose.

Adora did not call out.

She drove her heels into her mount and closed the distance. When she was close enough to see the tension in Glimmer's shoulders, she stood in the stirrups and launched herself across the gap.

She had seen Catra do it once—clean, balanced, almost elegant. This was nothing like that.

Adora hit Glimmer hard, shoulder to ribs. They went down together in a tangle of limbs and dust. The impact knocked the breath from her lungs. The horses shrieked and bolted, reins trailing.

Glimmer twisted under her immediately.

“Get off me!” she snapped, coughing dirt.

Adora forced her flat, forearm braced across her collarbone. “What did you do?” The words tore out of her. “What did you make her do? You fucking lied! You let me walk into a trap!”

Glimmer bared her teeth. “So she went through with it?” She spat to the side. “She handed herself over. Like *you* were supposed to.”

Adora’s grip faltered for half a second before tightening again. “Have you hated me this whole time?” The question slipped free before she could contain it. “Even when we— Even after everything? Was it all just—”

“You brought him here,” Glimmer shot back. “Of course I hate you.”

Adora stared at her.

Glimmer’s eyes were bright—not with magic, but with fury held too long. “You came into my mother’s life and she never looked away from you again. I was her daughter. I was right there. And she—” Glimmer’s voice hitched and sharpened. “She chose to love you more.”

Adora recoiled as though struck.

“Then why would you sleep with m—” she began.

Glimmer shoved at her, breath ragged. “Because at least with you, I finally mattered to someone. Even if it was because you wanted something.”

Adora froze.

Glimmer vanished in a burst of pink light.

Adora’s weight hit the ground where she had been. She rolled and came up on one knee, scanning the trees, breath shallow.

“So that’s it?” she said into the empty air. “You used me to feel special?”

“It’s what you wanted from me. And I was desperate,” Glimmer’s voice came, quieter now, from behind her. “Until Bow.”

Adora turned. Glimmer stood ten paces away, pink hair loose from its pins, eyes rimmed red.

“I loved you,” Adora said. The words sounded strange outside her mouth—bare, unarmoured.

Glimmer’s expression twisted.

“She’s dead because of you!” she shouted. “I lost my mother and you still weren’t satisfied, you couldn't stay away. You ruin everything you touch.”

“I never asked for any of this!” Adora shouted back.

Glimmer teleported again, reappearing directly in front of her. Close enough that Adora could see the tremor in her jaw.

“Then fix it,” Glimmer said. “Go back. Give yourself to him. Trade yourself and leave the rest of us out of it.”

The suggestion hung between them.

What would Catra do?

Adora knew.

Catra had done it already.

Calculating, clever Catra—she had found the one thing Prime could not refuse and placed it at his feet: herself.

Adora felt the shape of her own nature pressing against her ribs—how easily it tipped into anger, how quickly she reached for steel. Every instinct screamed at her to ride straight for Bright Moon, to

cut through whatever stood in her way until she found Prime and ended him.

It was useless.

She pressed her eyes shut hard enough to see sparks.

“She thinks she’s all alone,” Adora said, and her voice broke.

Prime would not make it swift. He would savour it. He would humiliate her, strip her pride away piece by piece. He would make Catra’s death into something orderly, instructive. A correction.

There had to be time.

There had to be.

Glimmer’s voice came quieter now, almost steady. “If Prime has her, you can’t storm the Horde and walk out alive. Even if you breached Bright Moon’s walls, it’s crawling with clones. You’d die before you reached him.”

Adora let out a brittle breath. “You were just telling me to hand myself over.”

Glimmer’s mouth tightened but she didn’t respond.

Adora opened her eyes.

From the beginning, she had been a weapon. A symbol. A lever Prime used to pry at Catra’s defenses. He had always known exactly where to press.

“I know what I have to do,” Adora said at last. The words felt like stepping off something high. She looked at Glimmer. “I’m sorry.”

She left Glimmer behind her.

✧

She reached Bright Moon in the cool edge of morning, when the light was still pale and the air held the last of the night's mercy.

She came alone.

She left the horse tethered in the scrub well below the city rise. No banner, no escort, no white armour announcing her from a distance. Only a worn cloak pulled close and the weight of what she had already decided pressing steady against her ribs.

The last stretch she took on foot.

Goat tracks first—narrow, half-forgotten paths that cut sideways along the low ground. Then the land softened into ordered rows of orchard trees, their leaves dappling the path with shifting shade. The smell of fruit hung faint and sweet in the air.

The ground began to climb.

Limestone underfoot, pale and dusty, the first of the rises that would carry her upward in slow, relentless stages. The path wound and lifted, wound and lifted again, until the cliffs began to show themselves ahead, and beyond them—

Bright Moon.

The sight of it hit her harder than she expected.

Familiar enough to hurt.

On the far edge of the horizon the cove burned bright blue, only a shade softer than the hard Etherian sky above it. She had not realised, until that moment, how deeply her body remembered this place. How instinctively her steps adjusted to its slope, its angles, the quiet rhythm of a city built upward instead of out.

She had missed it.

The admission came unwanted.

She had expected resistance at the outer gates. Clones stationed and alert, waiting for the Queen who had slipped their net. But the guards watching for Adora of Etheria were watching for a different shape entirely—some armoured figure at the head of a charge. Not a single woman in a faded cloak, hood pulled low, sleeves hiding the strength in her arms—her platinum cuff.

No one stopped her.

She crossed the first threshold unchallenged.

Inside the city, Bright Moon breathed around her in its ordinary morning patterns. She took the northern road, folding herself into the current of people moving through the streets. One body among many. One face lowered and unremarkable.

When she turned the first corner, the palace came into view the way the city always saw it—from below.

It still disoriented her.

From the outside it looked impossibly tall, all white stone and open arches, the high windows thrown wide to catch the evening air. The balconies curled outward in delicate stonework. To the east stretched the long, columned hall and the airy upper quarters. To the north, the Queen's wing and the walled gardens, their shallow steps winding through green vines.

She knew every angle of it.

Just not from here.

Someone shouldered into her as they passed—a woman with a parcel tucked tight under her arm.

"Watch it," the woman snapped without looking back.

Adora kept walking.

She moved through the outer residential streets, past narrow windows cut in uneven rectangles, past storehouses with their heavy doors propped open to the morning. A mill turned steadily on its base nearby, simple magic humming through the stone as it revolved. From the lower streets came the sharp, overlapping calls of fishmongers shouting over one another, the smell of salt and fresh catches thick in the air.

The city was alive.

Unaware of her presence.

Clones marched in formation down the main thoroughfare—white and grey cloaks immaculate, steps perfectly synchronized. Adora stepped aside without hesitation. They passed within arm's reach.

None of them looked twice.

It was all uphill.

Bright Moon had always been that way—the palace crowning the peak, the city climbing toward it in layered rings. Adora realised, distantly, that she had never before made this walk on foot. She had always arrived mounted and escorted.

Now she climbed like any other citizen.

By the time she reached the palace square, the old disorientation returned, sharper than before.

She only knew this space from above.

From the balcony where her mother used to appear, sunlight catching in her hair as she raised a hand to the crowd. From that height the square had always looked orderly. Manageable.

From the ground, the palace loomed.

The guards stood at the high gate like living statues, armour bright, spear-butts planted firmly against the stone. The wide

columned square bustled with early traffic, but there was space around the steps—an invisible boundary people did not cross without reason.

Adora fixed her gaze on the nearest clone and began to walk.

At first, nothing.

She was one woman among many.

Then the attention began to shift.

It was subtle—the way heads began to turn, the way conversations faltered mid-word. It was not common for anyone to approach the palace steps directly, and certainly not with the steady, unhurried stride she carried.

She felt it gathering.

The awareness.

The weight of eyes.

The clones did not move yet, but she could feel their focus narrow.

She mounted the first step.

That was enough.

The nearest clone moved to block her path. Around the square, people slowed, then stopped, curiosity pulling them inward until a loose semicircle began to form.

"Halt," the clone said, voice crisp with drilled authority. "State your purpose under the glorious light of Horde Prime."

Adora lifted her head.

She waited—not long, just long enough. Long enough for the square to notice. Long enough for every nearby gaze to settle

fully on her. Then she reached up and pushed back the hood.

The cloth fell away from her face.

The reaction was immediate—a sharp intake of breath from somewhere in the crowd, a ripple of shocked murmurs spreading outward like thrown stone in water.

Adora met the clone's eyes.

Her voice, when she spoke, carried clean and unmistakable across the square.

"I am Adora of Etheria," she said. "And I surrender to Horde Prime."

Chapter End Notes

Now I need to cook some apology pork bao for dinner 😅

Chapter 41: Catra

Chapter Notes

Alright, lots of trigger warnings for this one, I am really sorry. Please look out for yourself 🙏

TW, that I could think of:
Rape/non con
Memories of past rape/non con
Violent treatment of a prisoner
Dead bodies and slight gore
Many csa implications
Death of a child

Thank you to my beta reader for suffering through this first.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra did not look out the viewport as the shuttle cut through the sky. She refused Bright Moon the courtesy of a final glimpse. The city was surely blazing below them—white stone, blue cove, tidy streets and open balconies—but she would not grant it the dignity of her attention.

Prime had spent the journey in a tone of idle evaluation, dissecting his new boy's performance with clinical dissatisfaction. He kept circling back to Catra, inviting comparison, suggesting she offer guidance, remarking on how much more "promising" she might have been if she had ever truly submitted to refinement. His voice droned, patient and faintly amused. Catra heard none of it. She was elsewhere. She was in a cramped tent in the Crimson Waste, ice pressed to Adora's side while they both tried not to laugh at the absurdity of being alive. She could still see the heat in Adora's eyes, the careful way their hands had brushed as if something fragile had begun to exist between them and neither dared name it.

The shuttle's hum blurred. Prime's critique blurred. The only thing that did not was the memory of Adora's mouth, curving soft in the light from the fire.

Finally, the shuttle docked with a mechanical shudder. The door split open with a hiss and harsh white light flooded in. Catra rose on instinct and was immediately seized—hands clamping her arms, dragging her forward before her feet had properly found the floor. She was hauled out and driven down, cheek striking the grit of the dock plating. Blades hummed at her throat. She did not flinch. She did not bother to struggle. The light was too bright; the air too sterile. A familiar voice cut through it all.

"You've been productive."

Double Trouble's tone was bright. A clone forced Catra's head down further, pressing her brow to the filthy metal.

"I did not anticipate your return quite so quickly," Prime replied smoothly, the faintest thread of irritation undercutting his composure. "But yes. The matter resolved itself as expected."

"Welcome home, Kitten." Double Trouble's voice dipped toward her, amused. Then, lightly, to the clone restraining her: "Ease off. She's not exactly in a position to sprint."

Catra lifted her head as soon as the pressure eased enough to allow it. She stood slowly, meeting Double Trouble's gaze without surprise. "You always did love a dramatic entrance,"

"You're one to talk." Double Trouble's smile did not reach their eyes. "You've been exhausting. I had to leave behind a perfectly good Entrapta clone just to exit cleanly. Do you know how long it takes to grow them?"

"Baker will appreciate the effort," Catra replied mildly. "When she skins you alive."

Double Trouble's attention flicked to Prime. "Her accommodations are prepared. Or we could move directly to spectacle."

“I told you,” Prime said, turning away from Catra as though she were already an afterthought, “I intend to enjoy this.” He helped the boy from the shuttle with careful hands. His knees trembled after hours spent kneeling; the paint around his mouth was smeared. Prime tutted softly and wiped it away, adjusting the boy’s hair with precise fingers. Two of his eyes remained on Catra, assessing; the other two never left the boy. “We will arrange the arena. I want her endurance properly displayed.”

Catra considered this. “You could dull the beasts’ teeth,” she offered helpfully. “Let it take a while.”

“Dull the teeth?” Prime echoed, almost amused. “Did you assume I intended a swift end? You misunderstand. You are no longer of use. There is no reason to hurry.” He tilted his head slightly toward Double Trouble. “Ensure the creatures crush rather than tear. I prefer the slow collapse of breath.”

“Poison?” Double Trouble suggested idly.

“And deprive me of the entertainment?” Prime’s voice sharpened faintly. “No.”

“You do love your theatrics,” Catra observed.

Prime’s mouth curved. “You were always most compelling in resistance. The struggle becomes you.” His hand rested on the boy’s shoulder, stroking absently. The pleasure he took in imagining the scene was visible, a faint dilation of satisfaction. Catra did not allow herself to react. She had known it would not be simple. She had known he would savour it. The brutality was ritual by now.

“It seems comprehensive,” Catra said evenly. “You’ve prepared quite the farewell.”

Prime drew his attention away from her at last, as if prying himself from a pleasant thought. “Contain her,” he instructed the clones. “She has consumed sufficient time for now.”

They hauled her upright again. Their grip was firm, impersonal. Neither cruelty in it, nor indulgence—only procedure. Catra went with them without resistance. The dock's light receded behind her as they marched her inward, towards the cells.

The cells were colder than she remembered.

Not in temperature—Prime's ship was always kept at the same sterile, regulated chill—but in feeling. The kind of cold that came from being watched too closely by things that did not blink. The corridor lights hummed overhead as the ship's scanners swept her from head to toe, thin beams crawling over her skin, cataloguing, confirming. The system took its time with her, as though even the machine understood she was not expected to leave this place.

When the scan cleared, they passed her off.

Different clones this time.

Catra rolled her shoulders once, subtle, testing the space. No shackles yet. Six of them. Not the ceremonial guard—the other kind. The ones who enjoyed their work.

Her weight shifted almost imperceptibly onto the balls of her feet.

At least Hordak was gone. One small mercy in a universe that had run out of them.

Adora could have taken all six.

The thought hit like a misstep on broken ground.

Catra's jaw tightened. She shoved it away before it could root. There would be no last-minute rescue, no golden-haired idiot crashing through the door with righteous fury and too much heart. No broad back to hide behind.

She was alone.

She had *always* been alone.

And she would never see Adora again.

“Well,” Catra said lightly, though her pulse had already begun its quiet climb, “is this the welcome committee? I expected balloons, maybe cupcakes.”

One of the clones—forty-six, if she remembered the set of his mouth correctly—tilted his head. “Has our former princess developed a preference for Etherian company?” he asked. “You look disappointed.”

Catra’s lip curled. “Please. I’ve seen prettier scrap metal in the junk bays. At least the clones who worked for me had the decency to be interesting.”

A faint murmur moved through the group.

“I see your time playing house with magic-wielding savages has eroded what little refinement you possessed,” 46 replied.

“Forty-Six,” Catra drawled, “there’s nothing refined about this floating nightmare.”

He gave a small, humorless nod. “Prime anticipated deterioration. He suggested you might require corrective instruction.” His fingers flicked outward.

Two clones lunged.

Catra was already moving.

They had underestimated her. They always did.

Her heel came up hard and fast, driving between one clone’s legs with enough force to fold him in half. As he choked, she stripped the knife clean from his belt in the same motion and shoved his collapsing body backward into the next clone. For a second—just a second—she had space.

Metal glinted in her grip.

The remaining clones slowed.

“She’s still got claws,” one muttered, tone edged now with caution.

“I remember,” 46 said mildly. He reached down and gave the groaning clone a sharp, almost absent pat on the shoulder. “If six of us can’t manage one feral little princess, we may as well hand in our armour.”

Catra did the math anyway.

Not because she believed she could win.

Because she needed to know exactly how badly she was about to lose.

Even if she dropped all six—and she wouldn’t, not in this cell, not with the ship watching—Prime would simply inform the Crystal Castle sentries that she had broken terms. A life for a life. That had been the bargain.

Adora would pay for it.

That knowledge sat like ice behind her ribs.

“I’m going to tear her apart,” the clone she’d kicked snarled hoarsely, straightening with murder in his eyes.

Catra, generous to the last, returned his knife to him.

Directly between the ribs.

For a heartbeat, everything paused.

Then the mood shifted.

Whatever game they’d been entertaining dissolved instantly. The clones moved as one now, no longer indulging the idea that 46 might handle her alone.

Pity.

Catra knew, distantly, that escape was impossible. She knew fighting only tightened the noose around Adora's neck. She thought about every logical reason to drop the blade and stand still.

Her body didn't care.

Terror had its own language. So did pride. So did the bone-deep refusal to go quietly that had kept her alive this long.

She fought.

The struggle fractured into flashes of sensation: a fist driving brutally into her stomach, stealing her breath for a precious moment; the sharp split of skin across her knuckles as she drove them into someone's mouth; the metallic taste of blood flooding her tongue when a blow clipped her jaw.

Hands caught her arm—twisted hard, joints screaming as they forced it up toward the breaking point.

She snarled and kicked, caught someone's knee, heard the gratifying hitch of pain—

Then the world slammed sideways.

Her back hit the wall with bone-rattling force. Air blasted out of her lungs in a single, helpless rush. For a moment her vision went white at the edges, the corridor tilting.

Blackness came down fast and hard.

Not unconsciousness—not quite. Just the kind of violent blank that followed a blow too cleanly placed. Sound returned first: heavy metal legs grinding against the cell floor with a long, ugly scrape that set her teeth on edge.

Catra's vision crawled back in pieces.

The table.

Of course.

They hauled her upright before she could properly orient herself, hands clamped into her arms, her shoulders. She twisted once on instinct and was driven forward for the effort, her hip striking the edge of the wood as they forced her down across it. The impact jarred up her spine. Rough palms pinned her there—one at the back of her neck, another pressing between her shoulder blades, others locking her wrists hard enough to bite.

She bared her teeth, breath coming short and sharp.

Fabric shifted.

One of the clones hooked fingers under the hem of her dress and dragged it upward without ceremony.

"Well now," one of them drawled, voice thick with anticipation. "Brothers—anyone curious what royalty looks like up close and personal?"

Her legs were kicked apart.

The motion was efficient. Casual. Like they had done this a hundred times before—perhaps they had.

Catra's pulse slammed against her ribs hard enough to make her vision stutter. She twisted again, uselessly, muscles coiling on reflex even as logic caught up and told her exactly how outnumbered she was.

Then—

"Enough."

The word cut through the cell.

Everything stopped.

Hands still on her. Dress bunched high over her hips. Fingers caught mid-motion in the thin fabric of her underwear, already tugging downward. Catra was bent helplessly over the table, breath shallow, heart hammering so violently it hurt.

Prime's voice did that.

Silence fell the way it always did when he entered a room.

Catra could feel him before she saw him. The weight of his attention settled across her skin like something physical. Cold. Interested. Pleased.

There would be no rescue.

She knew that with a clarity that tasted like iron.

Prime had not intervened out of mercy. Prime did nothing out of mercy.

Still—some stupid, starving part of her chest tightened anyway.

"I should not be surprised," Prime said mildly, "to find you in such a state so quickly, little sister."

His tone was thoughtful. Amused.

"After all," he continued, circling slowly behind her, "we are all familiar with your appetites. If you were willing to debase yourself for your mother's executioner, why hesitate now? Were you hoping this display might earn you favour?" A soft pause. "Or did you simply fear going to your death unsatisfied?"

Catra's throat burned.

Her breath hitched once before she could stop it.

Ice—she needed the ice. The still, cutting calm that usually came so easily. It wouldn't come. Panic scraped at the edges of her control, ugly and hot. She focused on the table under her palms

instead. On the cold metal. On anything but the sound of his footsteps drawing closer.

Another hand—rougher—yanked her underwear down in one sharp motion.

Laughter broke out around her.

Fingers spread her roughly—invasive and exposing. Catra's jaw locked so hard it hurt.

"Did you come to watch?" another clone—32, by the sound of him—asked from somewhere off to the side. Detached. Curious.

"Regrettably," Prime said, and he did sound faintly disappointed, "I have come to remind you that your recreation is to be postponed."

His hand landed on her ass with a light, almost absent pat—an owner's touch, casual and proprietary. It made something deep in her stomach twist.

"Are you disappointed, little sister?"

The pressure holding her down eased.

Hands withdrew one by one. The clones stepped back, the moment dissolving under Prime's authority as cleanly as it had formed.

For a second Catra couldn't move.

Her body was still braced for restraint that was no longer there, muscles locked tight with the aftermath of adrenaline. Her hands trembled once before she forced them still.

Slowly, carefully, she reached back and pulled her underwear into place. Smoothed her dress down over her hips with fingers that only barely shook.

If she closed her eyes—

Adora’s gaze flickered behind them. That first time. The slow, helpless way Adora’s attention had tracked the line of her legs, like she truly couldn’t help herself. That soft, crooked grin.

Catra shoved the memory away hard enough to hurt.

She pushed herself upright off the table without looking at Prime.

“Look at you,” he said lightly. “What a spectacle you’ve become.”

Behind her, the clones were already resetting the room wwith wholly mechanical efficiency. 32 was directing two of them toward the groaning one Catra had put down earlier. Business as usual. The interruption already being filed away.

Catra kept her back straight.

“Was I ever your daughter?” she asked. “Did you care about me at all?”

The words came out rougher than she intended. Too close to something raw. Something she had long since learned to bury.

You were all I had.

The silence that followed was brief.

“What a tiresome question,” Prime said at last, almost bored. “Come.”

His tone shifted—pleased now, anticipatory.

“I have something prepared for you.”

And Catra knew, with cold certainty, that whatever came next would somehow be worse than what she had just been spared.

Catra said nothing as she followed him.

The corridors of the Velvet Glove were as she remembered them —sterile, gleaming, too bright in some places and too dim in

others, designed to disorient and diminish. The air carried that same faint antiseptic tang that always made the back of her throat itch. Prime walked ahead at an unhurried pace, hands loosely folded behind his back, as though he were guiding a guest rather than escorting a prisoner toward something calculatedly unpleasant.

She kept her expression smooth. She had learned long ago that silence irritated him more than defiance.

It wasn't until they turned the final corner that her composure fractured.

The door.

She had never crossed its threshold. Not once. But recognition hit her body before her mind could catch up—sharp, instinctive—wrong. Something cold slid under her ribs.

"No," Catra breathed, the word escaping before she could cage it. Her feet stalled. She took one involuntary step back.

Prime's mouth curved without warmth. "Now, now, little sister," he said lightly. "You are well past the point of preference."

The door slid open.

He gestured her forward with one elegant hand.

Catra did not move at first. For one tight second she considered it—digging in her heels, making him force her—but she already knew how that ended. She stepped inside.

Darkness swallowed her.

The door sealed behind them with a soft, final hiss.

For a moment there was nothing—no light, no sound beyond the quiet hum of the ship. Then she felt him move behind her. His hands settled on her shoulders. Catra went very still.

His fingers traced upward with deliberate slowness, gliding over bare shoulders, along the line of her collarbone, the side of her neck. Possessive in a way that made nausea coil low in her stomach.

They closed lightly around her throat.

"How many Etherians," Prime murmured near her ear, voice silk-smooth, "have you permitted the privilege of spilling inside you, little sister?"

The words turned her stomach.

One.

The answer came sharp and immediate in her head.

Only Adora.

The memory swarmed her thoughts—warm hands, careful where Prime's were cold, the quiet way Adora had looked at her like she was something perfect.

Catra locked her jaw.

"None," she said.

Prime's grip tightened a fraction.

"Dishonesty does not improve you," he chided softly. "Tell me—did you offer yourself freely to your little army to secure their loyalty? Or was that merely how you persuaded Etherians to tolerate you?"

"Why do you care?" Catra shot back, the words edged despite the pressure at her throat.

His fingers tightened further, not quite enough to choke—just enough to remind her of her place.

“Catra,” he said, almost gently, “what exactly did you allow to touch you?” A pause, thoughtful and unpleasant. “Should I be concerned? Have you been… taken advantage of? You poor thing”

“Why do you care?” she repeated, more breath than voice now. “What is it, jealousy?”

For a beat, the silence thickened.

Then one of his hands slid down from her throat, slow and deliberate, tracing the line of her ribs until it settled flat against her abdomen.

Catra’s stomach dropped.

“I am determining,” Prime said calmly, “whether you remain of any functional use.”

His fingers pressed lightly—not enough to hurt, but enough to make her acutely aware of the contact.

“Is it worth the resources to keep you intact,” he continued, voice clinical now, “until whatever is developing inside you reaches viability… or may I dispose of you tomorrow?”

The words did not register all at once. They came apart in her head, slow and wrong.

Catra blinked.

“What?” The sound that left her was thin and unsteady.

Prime’s breath ghosted near her ear, almost amused.

“What did you allow to impregnate you, little sister?”

Adora.

There had only ever been Adora.

Heat stung suddenly behind Catra's eyes, sharp and humiliating. She bit down hard enough on the inside of her cheek to taste blood, but it didn't stop the sting.

Prime gave a soft, thoughtful chuckle against her neck.

"Oh," he said, interest sharpening. "You *do* care."

His hand remained where it was, possessive, evaluating.

"How unfortunate for you," he went on lightly. "Perhaps you might have reconsidered your little martyrdom had you known."

"Please," Catra heard herself say.

The word scraped out before she could stop it.

Pathetic.

She knew it even as it left her mouth.

She had let Adora close. Had let her in, in all the ways she had sworn she never would again. Had rolled her eyes at Adora's sexual recklessness and still—*still*—she had compromised herself the same way.

She didn't want anything to happen to herself.

Worse—

She didn't want anything to happen to Adora's baby.

The lights tuned on without warning.

Catra's pupils shrank painfully, vision bleaching out before it steadied. For a moment she saw nothing but glare and the faint afterimage of Prime's silhouette. Then the room resolved.

Pods.

A line of them, evenly spaced, gleaming under the sterile light. Clone stasis chambers, tall and coffin-like, each one lit from within.

Each one containing her.

Not identical in the way Prime's soldiers were identical. Not uniform, not polished. These were iterations. Variations.

Every clone wore white.

Almost every one was broken.

One body hung suspended with its chest laid open so deeply that bone shone through muscle; ribs visible beneath ragged gashes. Fingers were missing from one hand, stumps wrapped crudely in gauze as though someone had once bothered to preserve them before losing interest. It was absent an entire leg, the limb severed cleanly mid-thigh. A third—Catra swallowed—had no lower half at all. From the waist down there was only ruin, viscera suspended grotesquely within the fluid of the pod.

And then—

The smaller ones.

The ones that hadn't yet grown into her height, her angles.

Younger faces. Soft And round.

Catra's breath thinned.

One of them—small, narrow-shouldered—floated with half her face torn away, cheekbone and teeth exposed in a grisly half-smile. The jaw was too slight.

"How old was I?" Catra heard herself ask, voice stripped of its usual edge. Her eyes were locked on the smaller body, unable to look away.

“I believe that specimen was eleven,” Prime replied pleasantly.

Eleven.

Her mind stumbled over it.

“That’s not possible,” she said. “Shadow Weaver died when I was thirteen. How—”

Prime’s hands tightened lightly at her shoulders, holding her exactly where he wanted her.

“Would you care to observe?” he asked, indulgent. “I find your comprehension refreshing each time.”

Screens flickered to life along the wall before her.

She didn’t have to turn her head. He turned her for her.

The image sharpened.

She was looking through her own eyes.

Smaller hands. Smaller body. The world taller and wider and too large to feel safe.

“Catra, what now?” Shadow Weaver’s voice carried unfamiliar irritation, thinly veiled impatience.

And then—

Her own voice. Younger. Unsteady and anxious.

“Horde Prime… he did something to me.”

The air in the present room thickened. Catra felt it like water closing over her head. She couldn't hear what her younger self said, like her present body was protecting her from this particular trauma.

“Are you certain?” Shadow Weaver asked mildly. “You are prone to exaggeration.”

The younger Catra swallowed hard in the recording. “He—he told me things. The night before I woke up to him—”

“Perhaps you imagined it,” Weaver interrupted, dismissive. “You do have a dramatic streak.”

Catra’s nails bit into her palms in the present.

“I didn’t imagine it,” her eleven-year-old self insisted, voice breaking. “He said I was pretty. He said he wanted me.”

Magic sparked at Weaver’s fingertips in the memory. Red. Controlled.

“No male is perfect,” Weaver said coolly. “Must I lose everything because of you?”

“Mum—”

“What would you have me do?” Weaver snapped. “He finances my campaign. Would you rather we beg in the streets?”

The younger Catra’s breath hitched. “What about me?”

Weaver’s patience shattered.

“It is always about you!” she screamed, red magic flaring, swallowing the space around them until only her furious outline remained lit in the dark. “When is it my turn to be happy?”

Energy lashed outward.

The feed cut.

Silence.

The present returned in a rush that made Catra sway.

Prime released her shoulders as though she were no longer in danger of bolting.

"You see," he said conversationally, "without you as incentive, Weaver had little to offer me. She was… temporarily obsolete."

His gaze drifted toward the pods, toward the suspended bodies.

"I, however, am rarely inconvenienced by something as trivial as mortality."

He stepped lightly to the side, admiring his collection.

"Your mother's actions did not deprive me of my amusements."

Nine years.

Nine years of reset and repetition and failure.

Catra felt hollowed out. Like someone had reached inside her chest and scooped away anything solid.

She had been alone. *Always*. Even when she thought she hadn't been.

Her hands moved instinctively to her abdomen, palms flattening there as though she could shield what might be beneath her skin.

"It's not—" she began, throat raw. She couldn't tell him the truth. She wouldn't give him that. "It's not some aberration or abomination,. I swear."

Prime's head tilted.

"Ah." Interest returned to his eyes. "So there is something."

His smile deepened.

"How fortunate. I acquire another child after all."

Catra lifted her chin slowly despite the tremor in her body.

“So you do,” she said.

Chapter End Notes

Yeah pinkstorm you saw through my lies from the start, Shadow Weaver is a bitch and she reminds me of my mum.

Anyway, Shadow Weaver’s quotes are based on my mother's actual verbal response because I recorded the phonecall when I told her what her husband did to me.

This time last year she said to me that no one would ever read anything that wrote because I'm "not that good at writing". Thank you all for proving that bitch wrong 🥰

Chapter 42: Adora

Chapter Notes

I really hope this is a least a little satisfying.

TW: Gore

The last part is a surprise for my beta reader too 😁, but I am very thankful for their work 🥰

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The warp hit her wrong.

Space travel always did, but this twisted deeper. A cold shimmer traveled through her, crawling under her skin and leaving her stomach in a lurch. Adora staggered when the light snapped away, boots scraping the polished floor of the Velvet Glove's receiving chamber. Breathable air rushed back into her lungs in a sharp, ugly gasp. For a second the room tilted—too bright in the wrong places, too dim in others.

The two clones flanking her didn't so much as shudder.

Of course they didn't. They were accustomed to this.

"You're late."

The voice came from directly ahead—light, amused, edged with something that made the back of Adora's neck prickle. All she could see at first was green motion, a smear of color her eyes refused to resolve.

Adora forced herself still.

Breathe. Stand. Don't give them anything.

Her vision crawled slowly into focus. The room sharpened by degrees—sleek walls, console lights blinking in orderly rows, the faint mechanical hum that never quite left Prime's flagship.

"Prime's been waiting," the green blur continued, and now Adora could make out the shape of a hand extending toward her casually. "I'll take custody from here."

Adora stepped forward because standing there swaying would only make her look weaker. Her gait wasn't perfect yet—damn the warp—but she made it work.

The clones beside her hesitated.

It was small. Barely there. But Adora managed to catch it.

Double Trouble's smile sharpened.

"Oh?" they said lightly. "Unless, of course, you'd prefer to explain to Horde Prime why retrieval took so long. Were you actually searching for She-Ra, or did you simply wait for her to deliver herself gift-wrapped?"

The clones shifted back without another word and stepped onto the warp pad. The light swallowed them in a clean, silent flash.

Double Trouble watched them go with bright, theatrical satisfaction.

"I thought so," they sing-songed, leaning one hip against the control console as they flicked a switch. "Bye-bye, darlings."

The room fell quieter when the warp faded.

And just like that, the performance dropped off their face.

The smile vanished. The posture sharpened. What remained was all calculation.

Adora said nothing.

She just looked at them.

Double Trouble huffed a short breath through their nose. “Seriously, are you even trying to save her?” they asked, irritation cutting through the silkly tone of their voice. “You took your sweet time.”

Adora ignored the jab. “Did you locate my sword?”

Double Trouble grimaced faintly. “If I had it, I’d be preening about it. It’s not with his usual collection of trophies.” Their fingers drummed once against the console. “Which means he’s keeping it close.”

Adora’s jaw tightened.

Double Trouble extended a hand again, less theatrical this time. Practical.

After a beat, Adora took it. Her vision still hadn’t fully settled, and she hated that they could probably tell.

“He’s paranoid,” Double Trouble went on. “Which, frankly, is new and exciting. Your little stunt at the Castle rattled him.”

“Good,” Adora muttered.

Double Trouble’s eyes flicked over her, assessing. “Can’t you just—I don't know—feel for it? Call it back? Dramatically summon it to your waiting hand?”

Adora blinked at them. “Summon it?”

Double Trouble stared.

“It is,” they said slowly, with strained patience, “a magical fucking sword. Have you actually tried to wield it to its full potential?”

Adora’s mouth flattened.

“I hate you.”

“Mutual, darling,” Double Trouble shot back instantly. “Come along.”

Adora let Double Trouble set the pace.

The corridors folded into one another with that same infuriating pattern Prime favoured—identical turns, identical sterile lighting that made distance feel disorientating and wrong. Even with her vision clearing by degrees, the place fought her instincts at every step. The warp-sickness still clung faintly to the back of her skull, a slow, dragging pressure that kept full focus just out of reach.

She hated that.

She hated needing the steady pull of Double Trouble’s hand at all.

“What’s the grand strategy, then?” Double Trouble murmured under their breath as they guided her around another seamless corner. Their voice was pitched low, but the amusement threaded through it was unmistakable. “Please tell me this isn’t just you marching in and hoping for the best.”

“Just take me straight to him,” Adora said.

Double Trouble’s brows lifted slightly. “Bold. Reckless. Comfortingly on-brand.” They angled a glance sideways at her. “And if he isn’t conveniently clutching your glowing letter-opener?”

“I’ll manage.”

Her answer came flat and certain.

Double Trouble made a soft, considering sound. “Improvisation. Always a crowd favourite.”

Not many had ever realized the sword wasn’t the source—just the key. The focus. She didn’t need it to become She-Ra.

She would probably need it to kill him.

That part she was still working out.

“Thrilling,” Double Trouble said lightly. “Let’s hope your improvisational phase doesn’t end in catastrophic personal failure.”

“You worried about me?” Adora asked, voice edged.

Double Trouble gave a loose shrug as they kept moving. “I’m worried about outcomes. I tend to prefer the ones where I remain alive.”

“Good,” Adora muttered. “Glad we’ve established your priorities.”

A quiet hum of amusement. “Not all of us are lining up to die for your latest heroic impulse.”

Adora’s mouth tightened. She leaned closer, voice dropping sharp and low. “We might have better odds if you actually committed to helping.”

“I am helping,” Double Trouble shot back, equally soft but far more cutting. “There are currently two fewer clones aboard this ship than there were ten minutes ago. You’re welcome.” A faint scoff followed. “You and Catra really are perfectly matched—selective memory when it comes to my many sacrifices.”

Adora stopped walking.

The corridor lights hummed overhead.

“…Sacrifices?” she said slowly.

Double Trouble kept moving for exactly one step more before realizing she was no longer beside them.

“Let’s keep walking,” they said quickly.

“No.” Adora’s voice hardened. “What sacrifices?”

“Adora—”

“What exactly do you think you’ve lost here?” The words came out low and tight, heat finally bleeding through the control she’d been strangling herself with in order to talk to Double Trouble this long. “You killed my mother. You played both sides until one of them looked better. You handed Entrapta to Prime like she was just another bargaining chip. You don’t sacrifice—you pivot. So tell me what you think you gave up.”

For the first time since the warp, Double Trouble looked genuinely uneasy.

It was brief.

“This,” Double Trouble whispered urgently, glancing once down the corridor, “is decidedly not the moment for your moral inventory. You can vivisect my character after you win.”

“After I win,” Adora said coldly, “I don’t want to see you ever again.”

“Marvelous,” Double Trouble snapped, exasperation finally breaking through their composure. “Thrilled for us both. Now move.”

They reached out and caught her wrist, not gently.

“Before Prime notices he’s missing personnel and decides to replace them.”

Adora held their gaze one second longer.

Then—

“Fine,” she said.

And started walking again.

Double Trouble brought her to the circular audience chamber.

Adora knew the room before she fully crossed the threshold. The shape of it lived somewhere unpleasantly familiar in her bones—the wide, perfect curve of the platform, the way the light fell too clean across the polished floor, the way sound carried just a fraction too well. Prime favoured symmetry when he wanted to feel theatrical. The space still smelled faintly of cold metal, artificial and wrong.

Prime was already in position.

He stood at the center of the raised platform like the room had been built around him, posture loose, hands folded with that infuriating ease he wore like a second skin. And—

Catra.

On her knees before him.

In the same white dress.

Adora’s breath hitched before she could stop it.

The reaction was sharp and immediate and she crushed it down just as fast, forcing her face smooth, forcing her shoulders to stay square as she stepped forward under Prime’s watchful gaze. Her pulse didn't cooperate quite as easily, kicking hard once, twice, before settling again.

She had come here for this.

She had known what she might see.

Still—

“Well,” Prime said lightly, eyes bright with interest. “How touching. Another voluntary surrender.”

His attention flicked between them with open amusement. “Tell me, Adora—should I expect you two to continue exchanging

yourselves indefinitely? A charming little cycle of mutual martyrdom?”

Adora didn’t answer.

She couldn’t—not yet. Something about Catra was already needling at the back of her thoughts, wrong in a way she couldn’t figure out.

Prime’s smile thinned. “No,” he went on, almost thoughtfully. “I believe I will simply collect what I am owed.”

Before he could continue, Catra surged forward on her knees.

“Adora—,” she said quickly, voice breaking in a way that twisted something deep in Adora’s chest. “You need to go. Just—just leave. Forget about me. Please.”

She was crying. Actually crying.

Adora went very still.

Catra didn’t cry like that. Not openly. Not with her face going soft and wet and almost—fragile.

Something cold slid into place in Adora’s mind.

She looked closer.

The hair.

Too long by a fraction. Subtle. Easy to miss if you were only looking at the tears. And—

Adora’s gaze dropped, sharp and searching, to Catra’s bare shoulder.

No scar.

No pale, familiar mark where Hordak’s blade had gone in deep enough to leave a physical memory behind.

Adora’s expression didn’t change.

But the grief that had been rising in her chest cooled instantly into something far more dangerous.

“You don’t know who I am,” Adora said quietly, “do you?”

The crying stopped.

Not gradually.

Instantly.

The figure on the floor went slack like a puppet with its strings cut. The trembling stilled. The breath just seemed to cut out entirely.

Silence snapped tight across the chamber.

Then—

Prime clapped.

Slow. Delighted.

“How very perceptive,” he said, genuine pleasure threading through his voice. “I do so enjoy it when you live up to your reputation.”

Adora didn’t look at him yet.

Her eyes slid once, sharply, toward where Double Trouble had been—

Gone.

Of course.

Fuck.

She rolled her eyes once, sharp and tired, before finally stepping forward onto the platform proper.

Closer to Prime.

“Really?” she said flatly. “That's the best you’ve got?”

Prime moved toward her as though the outcome had already been decided in his favour. Confidence emanated from him, quiet and unshakable, as if the universe itself were aligned in orderly obedience at his back.

“You stand here alone,” he said, voice smooth and faintly indulgent. “You are unarmed. Deprived of your relic blade. Stripped of advantage. There is nothing left for you to leverage. Surrender. You have already lost.”

He took another step.

Adora held her ground. The chamber seemed to constrict around the two of them, the air tight and bright beneath the sterile glow. She could feel her pulse behind her eyes, a low drumbeat of fury she had been holding in check since the moment she stepped aboard the Velvet Glove.

“Powerless?” Adora echoed, and there was something almost amused in the tilt of her mouth. “Is that what you think?”

Rage was no longer something she needed to contain. It was something she chose to wield.

Prime’s smile did not falter. “Your theatrics do not concern me.”

The light answered her before she consciously called for it. It rose beneath her skin in a familiar, resonant thrum, not wild but controlled—an answering chord struck clean and true. She-Ra’s power unfurled along her spine, lengthening her frame, brightening the air around her until the chamber itself seemed to recoil. She did not grow to match him, but she rose enough that he no longer looked down at her.

He paused.

It was small. A single measured hesitation.

Adora stepped forward to meet him in that space.

She said, voice steady and low, "I believe I made you a promise."

His expression shifted—not fear, not quite—but recalculation. "You are dramatic," he said, almost fondly. "And yet your blade is still absent."

"I'll improvise."

She moved before he could pivot. Three steps closed the distance; her heel drove upward into his knee. There was a crack—sharp, wrong—and for the first time, genuine shock fractured his composure. His balance failed him. He went down hard, catching himself only partially before the rest of his weight followed.

Adora did not hesitate.

She seized him by the neck, fingers digging in with unrestrained force. His skin was warm beneath her palm, pulse jumping erratically against her grip. He tried to speak—some clipped, composed retort—but it collapsed into a rasp as her thumbs pressed harder against his windpipe.

Harder.

His hands came up, not yet panicked, intent on prying her off. She tightened her grip instead. Nails broke skin. She felt the first give of flesh beneath pressure, the slick warmth of blood coating her fingers. He made a sound then—small, disbelieving, as if this outcome had never been slotted into any of his carefully arranged contingencies.

Harder.

She pulled.

There was resistance—muscle, sinew, the stubborn architecture of a body built to persist—but She-Ra's strength was not subtle. It was not merciful. Something tore. The sound was wet and terrible.

His body convulsed once as the connection failed. Blood sprayed in an arc across the floor, green and vivid against the sterile white. His weight sagged, then dropped.

Adora stood over him, breath harsh, hands slick with his alien blood.

His head hung in her grip for one suspended heartbeat longer, eyes darting with furious, disbelieving life. His mouth worked soundlessly. Then the light behind his gaze flickered—dimmed—and stilled.



She let it fall.

It struck the floor with a heavy, unceremonious thud and rolled once before coming to rest.

Silence filled the chamber, thick and humming.

The door slid open.

Three clones entered in precise formation, boots echoing against the polished floor. The one at the front regarded the scene without surprise.

The clone smiled.

It was Prime's smile.

"Did you truly imagine," he asked, voice perfectly replicated, smooth and almost amused, "that it would be so simple?"

✧

Adora returned to herself by degrees.

First came the ache—deep, vibrating through bone and muscle, a low tremor that made her hands curl reflexively at her sides. Then came breath, ragged and uneven, tearing in and out of lungs that felt scraped raw. Her fingertips burned. Her nails were split and rimmed dark. When she flexed them, the skin pulled tight and sticky.

The platform was no longer a platform.

It was a slaughter.

Bodies lay heaped where she had thrown them. Limbs were not arranged so much as discarded—an arm here, a leg bent wrong there, torsos collapsed against one another in angles too unnatural to mistake for sleep. Green blood coated the polished floor in slick, reflective swathes. It ran in narrow rivers between

the grooves of the platform and pooled thickly at the base of the steps. It clung to her calves, to the hem of her skirt, to her face where droplets had struck and dried in uneven streaks.

The air reeked of blood. She could taste it.

Coppery and yet sweeter underneath—alien and wrong.

Her entire body throbbed with the aftermath of violence. Every joint protested when she shifted her weight. Her shoulders ached from wrenching. Her ribs stung where blows had landed and been answered in kind. She could feel the strain in her throat from shouting—had she shouted? She couldn’t remember.

She looked down at her hands.

The skin of her palms was tacky with green. It had gathered under her nails, in the lines of her knuckles, along the creases of her wrists. She had torn through them.

Brutally.

She turned slowly in place, surveying what she had done. The door behind her was no longer capable of closing. Bodies were wedged into the frame where she had thrown them aside in the midst of it—metal groaning faintly under the weight of the dead.

No more clones entered.

No footsteps. No reinforcements.

The silence that followed was thick and oppressive.

“Is that all you've got?” Adora asked, voice hoarse, the words swallowed by the ruined chamber.

No answer came.

She stepped forward.

Each footfall made a grotesquely wet sound. Boots sank slightly where blood had gathered deepest. She did not look down at what she stepped over. A shoulder. A severed hand. A face split open by her own unarmed strike.

She had to move.

She had to find Catra.

She was nearly to the broken threshold when something shifted beyond it.

A figure stepped through.

Smaller.

Far too slight to be Prime.

Short, scruffy hair. Cat ears. Head angled downward as if in exhaustion. The body moved with familiar lines—familiar enough that Adora's heart stuttered painfully against her ribs.

The figure did not hurry. It waded through the bodies as though the carnage were no more than inconvenient debris. Green blood coated its bare feet. It did not seem to notice.

Adora stood frozen.

The figure lifted its head.

Half of its face was missing.

The skin had been torn away from cheek to temple, exposing raw bone and shredded muscle beneath. One side of its mouth curved in a faint smile, horrifyingly incomplete. The remaining eye—bright, unnatural green—fixed on her with calm recognition.

Horror crawled cold and immediate through Adora's spine.

"*No*," she breathed.

She stepped back once.

Twice.

Pain exploded in her side.

Adora’s breath hitched as she looked down. A dagger protruded from beneath her ribs, buried to the hilt. A hand—small, familiar—held it steady.

She turned.

Catra—the clone—stood close behind her, close enough that she could see the fine tremor in her fingers as they twisted the blade slightly.

“No—” Adora choked.

The clone’s mouth curved.

“You can keep killing me,” it said. The voice was wrong. Catra’s cadence, Prime’s tone woven through it like a thread of rot. “If you like.”

The blade pushed deeper.

Chapter End Notes

I also hope I have you stressed 😊

Chapter 43: Cat-Ra

Chapter Notes

I wrote this all today and my beta reader got back to me so fast!

TW: references to sa of minors, mentions Kyle

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra had already tested the walls three times.

Not out of hope—she had learned long ago that hope inside of Prime's ship was an excellent way to make a fool of one's self—but because her body refused to accept stillness. The panels that made up the cell were seamless, each metal slab fitted so precisely that even the edges were invisible beneath the sterile glow of the overhead lights. No rivets. No weaknesses. Just that blinding, immaculate brightness that made the place feel less like a prison and more like the inside of some hysterical nightmare.

She dragged her fingertips slowly along the wall again anyway, nails scraing softly against smooth alloy.

Nothing.

Of course.

Prime always required perfection.

The room was designed to remove any illusion of escape. The bed was a single smooth platform grown out of the wall itself. No joints. No sharp edges. Even the lighting was recessed behind translucent panels so there was nothing to climb toward.

A cage built to be inescapable.

Catra's hand moved unconsciously to her stomach.

The thought had been circling her mind for hours now, gnawing at the edges of her focus like a rat chewing through rope. The scan had revealed it before she'd even had time to suspect. A flicker of data on one of Prime's screens, a sacred announcement delivered with that same unnerving curiosity he used for everything.

Too early for her to have known.

Too early for anyone to know.

She leaned her forehead briefly against the wall and closed her eyes.

Was it because of Adora?

The thought was absurd enough that she almost laughed. But She-Ra wasn't normal. Nothing about Adora had ever followed the rules. If the power that ran through her veins could turn the tide of wars and heal wounds that should have killed people—

Could it do that too?

Could it make life start faster?

Catra let out a slow breath and pushed herself away from the wall.

It didn't matter.

Speculation was useless.

She was trapped here.

The cell had no cracks. No vents. No visible systems. Even the door was nothing more than a shimmering forcefield that hummed when she approached it. Prime intended to keep her here until the child was born.

Until he had what he wanted.

Then—

Well.

She slid down against the forcefield, the light buzzing faintly in her ears. For a moment she let her shoulders sag, the exhaustion finally catching up with her.

She couldn’t get out.

The thought settled in her bones with quiet finality.

She let her back rest against the barrier for just a second.

The field vanished.

Catra dropped like a stone.

Her shoulders slammed into the cold floor with a solid, ungraceful thud. The breath punched out of her lungs as the barrier flickered off completely.

“What—”

She blinked hard against the glare overhead, vision swimming. The lights were blinding from this angle, white halos bursting across her retinas.

Then a shadow moved across them.

A figure leaned over her.

“Your saviour has arrived!” Double Trouble declared with theatrical flourish, arms spread wide as though expecting applause.

Catra squinted up at them.

“…I’ll pass,” she muttered flatly.

She rolled onto her side, pushed herself upright with a low grunt, and—without acknowledging them further—walked straight back into the cell and sat down on the bed.

Double Trouble watched her with visible delight.

“Stubborn,” they crooned. “And so tragically predictable.”

Catra rested her elbows on her knees and stared at the opposite wall.

“Get to the point.”

“Oh, I intend to.” Double Trouble clasped their hands behind their back and leaned casually against the doorway where the forcefield had been moments ago. “I’m not referring to myself, kitten. Tempting though that version of events may be.”

Catra’s ears twitched despite herself.

“I’m referring,” Double Trouble continued sweetly, “to the tall, luminous, catastrophically heroic blonde I just smuggled aboard this charming death trap.”

Catra’s head snapped up.

For a second she just stared.

“You’re kidding.”

Double Trouble’s smile widened.

Catra rubbed her face hard with one hand and let out a long, slow sigh.

“That idiot.”

She pushed herself up off the bench.

“Prime took her sword.”

“Yes,” Double Trouble replied with a thoughtful hum. “I’ve been conducting a delightful little scavenger hunt for it.” They tapped their chin with exaggerated consideration. “Any ideas as to where our dear host might have hidden it?”

Catra moved past them without answering immediately, stepping out into the corridor with quiet purpose.

“Trophy room?” she offered after a moment.

“Alas,” Double Trouble sighed dramatically, falling into step beside her. “Already checked. A dreadful disappointment.”

Catra stopped.

She stood there a moment, staring down the length of the corridor as the answer settled unpleasantly into place.

She exhaled slowly.

“If you’re actually helping me,” she said at last, voice tight, “then come on.”

Double Trouble’s eyes glittered.

“Lead the way, darling.”

✧

Catra stopped at the threshold of Prime’s bedchamber.

For a long moment she did not move. The doorway was just another seamless curve of white metal, but standing within it felt like stepping up to the edge of the cliff from which she had spent years refusing to look down. Her pulse thundered loudly enough in her ears to drown out the hum of the ship.

She could do this.

She had done worse.

Of course he would keep the sword close. Prime liked his prizes near him when he slept. He liked reminders of what he owned. The idea slid through Catra’s mind with ugly clarity—he probably

stared at it before bed, admired it, imagined the moment he had stripped it from Adora.

She inhaled slowly, forced the air down into lungs that felt too tight, and stepped inside.

The room smelled like him.

The scent hit immediately, cloying in the back of her throat. With it came a bevy of memories, whether she wanted them or not. Catra swallowed hard and forced herself to keep walking.

Every step felt wrong.

Her eyes stayed fixed on the floor, then on the walls, then merely anywhere except the center of the room. She refused to look at the bed.

If she looked at the bed she might remember too much.

Behind her the doorway stayed quiet.

Catra turned sharply, temper flaring through the suffocating heaviness in her chest. “Are you going to fucking help me or what?”

Double Trouble had stopped at the threshold.

They hadn’t followed.

“You’re doing great, kitten,” they said lightly, leaning against the frame. The casual tone came out strained, the ease cracking around the edges. “I’d only slow you down.”

“DT—”

“You can’t make me willingly walk in there.”

Catra blinked.

Double Trouble’s gaze was locked on the bed.

Their hands trembled.

For a second Catra forgot the sword entirely.

“He started with simple requests,” Double Trouble said quietly. Their voice had lost its usual theatrical lilt. “Nothing elaborate. Me, but… smaller. Younger.”

Catra felt her stomach drop.

Double Trouble kept staring at the bed like it might swallow them whole. “Eventually he asked for you.” A shaky breath left them. “He brought me into another room. Showed me the original. Your body. Told me to study it. Every detail. Every scar. Every *bit* of you.”

Catra’s throat went dry.

The room suddenly felt too small.

“I didn’t want to hurt them,” Double Trouble said. “I just wanted him to stop.”

Catra’s voice came out rough. “What are you talking about?”

But she already knew. The knowledge pressed against her chest like water closing over her head.

“Entrapta,” Catra said.

Double Trouble nodded faintly. Their eyes never left the bed. “I found them all eventually.” Their voice wavered. “I thought he was sending them back once he finished with them. Like he did with Entrapta.”

“*All* of them?” Catra whispered. She couldn’t seem to get enough air.

“I didn’t know he'd kill Kyle,” Double Trouble said, the words barely steady. “I didn’t… let myself think about what happened to

them until he sent you his head. Until Entrapta…”

Catra’s thoughts scattered.

The floor under her feet felt unstable.

She was drowning. The past was opening up beneath her like a sinkhole and she could feel herself slipping down, down, down.

But Adora.

Adora was still out there.

Maybe she was already dying.

Catra dragged in a breath that hurt her ribs. “We don’t have time for this,” she snapped, voice cracking with strain. “Why are you telling me this now?”

“I—” Double Trouble’s voice broke. A single tear slipped down their cheek. “I’m sorry.”

“I don’t care!” Catra shouted, the words ripping out of her. “She could be bleeding out right now! We need the sword!”

Her chest felt like it was about to burst. Her mind raced too fast, tripping over every new piece of horror Double Trouble's words had unleashed..

Kyle.

Entrapta.

All the others…

Everything she had thought she understood.

Catra turned back to the room before the weight of it could drag her under. She began searching in quick, sharp movements—tables, cabinets, walls, every flat surface she could reach.

Nothing.

The room was immaculate.

Behind her Double Trouble sighed quietly.

“It’s in the bed,” they said.

Catra froze.

She turned slowly.

The bed sat in the center of the room, untouched, the white cover drawn smooth across it.

Nausea surged.

“You knew,” Catra said faintly.

“The whole time,” Double Trouble admitted. “It was the only way he’d let me back on the ship.”

Catra forced her legs to move.

Each step felt heavier than the last. The smell in the room thickened, memories clawing at her throat. She kept walking anyway, teeth clenched hard enough to ache.

She reached the bed.

Her hands hovered for a second before she grabbed the cover and yanked it back.

The Sword of Protection gleamed beneath the sheets.

Catra snatched it up immediately, the weight of it cold and solid in her hands.

“Let me guess,” she said without looking up. “That little loyalty test was me again.”

“Kyle,” Double Trouble said softly.

Catra’s eyes lifted sharply.

“He told me to hold still,” Double Trouble continued, voice unsteady. “Said if I moved… I’d get cut.”

Catra stood beside the bed for a moment with the sword in her hands.

The blade caught the sterile white light of the chamber and threw it back in fractured reflections across the walls. For a second she simply stared at it, breath slow, trying to steady the violent churn inside her chest.

Adora was real.

Somewhere on this ship, Adora was fighting.

Or bleeding.

Or dying.

Catra tightened her grip.

“Yeah,” she muttered under her breath, forcing the chaos in her head into a single sharp point of purpose. “I don't have time for your existential crisis right now, DT.”

She lifted the blade up, pointed towards the ceiling.

The weight settled differently when she raised it, as though the weapon had been waiting to be held like this again. The metal hummed faintly under her fingers. Not sound exactly—more like a vibration that ran up her arms and into the center of her chest.

Catra exhaled slowly.

“Okay,” she said to no one.

She closed her eyes for a fraction of a second, gathering the nerve that had carried her through worse places than this one.

Then, quietly—almost under her breath—she said, "For the honour of Grayskull."

The last time she had spoken the words, they had been shouted to the sky like a challenge.

Catra didn't shout.

She just *meant* it, with everything she had.

Light surged from the blade like something unleashed, brilliant blue energy racing along the metal before erupting outward in a rush that filled the room. It wrapped around her in spirals of power—heatless and electric—lifting her heels off the floor as the magic took hold.

Her spine stretched first.

Bones shifted, lengthening with a sharp pull that made her gasp through clenched teeth. Muscle followed, swelling and reshaping under the flood of power until the strength in her limbs felt almost absurd. The tight white dress she had been wearing dissolved into flowing armor and fabric, the magic weaving itself around her body in luminous bands of blue and gold.

Her hair whipped outward in the light like a banner caught in a storm.

The sword burned brighter in her grasp.

When the magic finally settled, Catra stood taller—broader, stronger, the echo of She-Ra's ancient power thrumming through her veins like a second heartbeat.

She flexed her fingers once around the hilt.

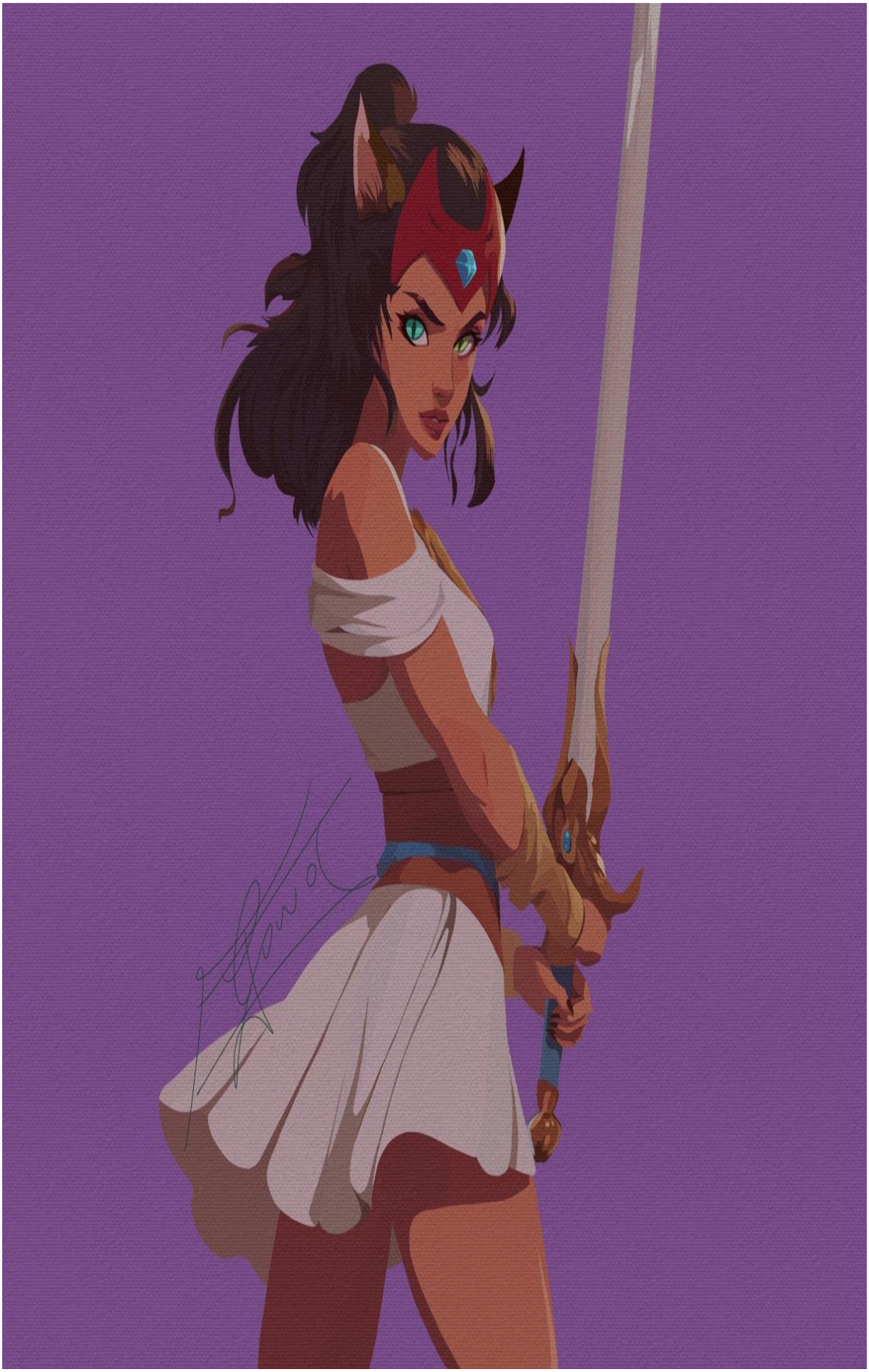
The strength there was dizzying.

Catra tilted her head back slightly, letting out a long breath as the last sparks of transformation faded around her boots.

“Great,” she muttered. Then she turned toward the door, sword already lifting in one hand. “Now I get to go rescue my dumb blonde girlfriend.”

Bonus, concept from all the way back in October. This was always the plan:





Also, I'm working on my own novel:



A ruthless elf mercenary kidnaps a sheltered princess to collect the bounty promised by a rival kingdom—but the long journey to deliver her becomes something different. Around campfires and along blood-stained roads, the mercenary teaches the princess how to survive, how to fight, and how to taste the freedom she was never meant to have. As their attraction grows, the mercenary's secret begins to surface: she is a dragon in disguise, enjoying her once a century period of mortal form before returning to her true shape. When they decide instead to kill the prince and take the bounty for themselves, the dragon expects the princess to abandon her once the transformation is complete—but the princess, newly awakened to her darker nature, finds she loves the dragon even more when the monster finally shows itself.

I'll be posting chapters to my patreon along with my other content until I publish. With how quick I write, hopefully that will be soon.

Chapter End Notes

> Also sorry, you'll just have to wait until next week to find out if Adora lives

Chapter 44: Adora

Chapter Notes

> Thank you to my beta reader, and thank you (almost) everyone for waiting so patiently 🥰

"Catra—?"

The name tore out of Adora's throat before she could stop it.

The blade drove in again. And again.

Each strike was deliberate, guided by something that understood anatomy, that knew exactly how to hurt without immediately killing. The dagger sank into her side with a wet, grinding insistence, twisting on the way out, returning with cruel precision. Pain flared bright and immediate, then settled into something deeper, a spreading heat that made her breath hitch.

Adora knew what she was looking at. Knew it in the same clear, brutal way she had known the moment she saw the blank expanse where a scar should have sat. This wasn't Catra. This wasn't *her* Catra. This was a body—Catra's shape, her face, her hands—filled with something else. Prime, wearing her like a mask.

Even if it hadn't been—

Even if this had been some broken version of Catra, some twisted echo that remembered only pain and betrayal—this Catra didn't know her. Didn't remember the quiet nights, the fragile trust, the way Catra's voice softened when she said her name.

This Catra knew her as loss.

As the girl who had taken her mother away.

There was no reaching her.

There was no fixing this.

Adora knew all of that.

And still—

She couldn’t strike back.

“Please—Catra—” The words came out ragged, useless, as the blade twisted again inside her. The pain dragged a strangled sound from her throat, her body folding inward as her strength finally gave way.

Green eyes stared up at her.

Wrong.

Too bright, too empty.

Her knees hit the floor hard. The impact barely registered. She sank into the slick mess beneath her—blood, viscera, the aftermath of everything she had done—and for a moment the world narrowed to the sound of her own breathing and the steady, methodical violence being inflicted on her.

She was going to die like this.

Cut open by something wearing the face she loved.

Adora let her head dip forward slightly, vision blurring at the edges. If this was it—if this was where it ended—then at least—

At least Catra wasn’t here to see it. At least Catra might still get away.

The blade drew back again. And then—

Stopped.

The body above her jerked.

Not the controlled, deliberate motion of Prime's puppeteering—but something abrupt, interrupted. The hand holding the dagger spasmed. The green in her eyes flickered.

A moment.

A breath.

Then—

A blade burst through her.

Something large and bright.

It punched clean through the Catra clone's torso from behind, tearing through white fabric and flesh alike. Red spread rapidly across the front of the uniform as the body convulsed once, twice —then went slack.

The green light vanished from her eyes.

Prime had already gone.

The clone sagged, weight collapsing forward before sliding off the blade and down into the slick ruin of the floor with a wet, final sound.

Adora stared. For a second she couldn't process what she was seeing.

Then she looked up.

And saw her.

She stood framed in the artificial light like an angel—impossible and brilliant and terrifying all at once. Red, gold, white—armour catching the light, the sword still held steady in her hand. Power thrummed around her, visible in the faint shimmer of blue that clung to her skin, to her eyes—

Her eyes.

They burned bright and furious for a heartbeat longer, then softened the moment they landed on Adora.



Concern broke through the fury.

“Hey, Adora,” Catra said, voice a little unsteady, like she wasn’t quite used to how it sounded in this form.

She was taller. Stronger. Radiant in a way that made Adora’s chest ache.

She-Ra.

Cat-Ra.

The realization hit all at once, strange and right and overwhelming. Something in Adora finally broke. The power she had been holding onto flickered, then drained out of her like water slipping through her fingers. The tension left her muscles all at once, leaving behind only exhaustion and pain and the quiet, stunned relief of seeing Catra standing there.

Alive.

Here.

Safe.

“Catra—” she breathed, softer this time, like the name might break if she said it too loudly.

They had barely a second. The sound came from the doorway—wet, uneven footsteps dragging through the blood. Another figure. Another Catra. This one limped as it approached, body already damaged, movements jerky and wrong. But the eyes—those same unnatural green eyes—fixed on them with intent.

“First I’ll take your lover from you,” it said, voice warped between Catra’s tone and Prime’s measured cadence. “Then, little sister, I’ll take you apart piece by piece.”

Adora looked up at Catra.

Her Catra.

“She won’t kill you,” Catra said, voice steady in a way that didn’t match the tremor still ghosting through her hands. “Not while you're wearing my clone. But I don’t scare so easily.”

“No—” Adora tried to push herself up, and the world tilted violently in response. Pain lanced through her side, sharp enough to steal the rest of the word from her mouth. Her arm gave beneath her weight. “Catra—don’t. Those bodies—they’re you.”

The realization came too late and all at once.

It crawled up her spine, cold and suffocating, as she looked at the corpse at Catra’s feet—the one that had worn her face, that still *did* wear it, even as life drained out in thick, dark, pooling streaks. One Catra already dead. Another standing. Another approaching.

How many?

How many times had Prime done this? Catra was so cold to her own death, despite the inherrent horror of the ordeal—witnessing your own body perish over and over. Prime must have done this enough that Catra could close off her emotion to easily.

The thought lodged in her chest like something jagged.

Finally, the new clone reached them.

Slick metal underfoot, made treacherous by the gore Adora herself had spilled in her onslaught. The clone’s steps were uneven, the body already compromised, but the presence inside it was not. The green glow of Prime’s awareness burned steady behind those familiar eyes.

Catra moved to meet her.

She placed herself squarely between Adora and the advancing figure, blade lifting with controlled precision. Even in this borrowed height, with She-Ra’s strength running through her,

there was something unmistakably Catra in the way she held herself—lean, coiled, efficient.

Adora saw it and something in her chest tightened painfully.

She remembered another Catra.

Smaller. Thirteen. Crying on a battlefield with everything taken from her.

Clone Catra raised her weapon. It crackled faintly with that same unnatural energy, the blade humming as if it were eager to bite. She didn't rush. *Prime* didn't rush. He advanced with measured steps, closing distance with the quiet certainty of someone who had never needed to doubt an outcome.

Adora tried again to stand.

Her body refused.

She could only watch.

And in that terrible stillness, she understood the shape of what she was about to witness.

Catra was good.

Adora knew that. Had seen it—sparring matches, battlefield encounters, those brief, sharp collisions where instinct met instinct and neither of them quite knew how to step back.

But this—

This was something else. This was what years of survival had honed her into.

The clone struck first.

A clean, decisive line of attack—no wasted movement, no flourish. Catra met it instantly, blade rising to intercept with a ringing clash that sent a shock down Catra's spine. She adjusted her footing in

the same breath, compensating for the difference in reach, turning what should have been a disadvantage into a narrow angle the clone had to respect.

Adora recognized the movement.

Her fight with Shadow Weaver at the border.

That exact shift of weight.

That same narrow evasion that looked like retreat until it became something sharper.

Catra pressed forward.

Fast.

Not stronger—but just as precise. Every strike had intent. Every movement calculated to disrupt, to redirect, to force the clone out of the clean lines it preferred. She didn't meet force with force; she slipped around it, broke it, turned it aside with sharp, efficient parries that wasted nothing.

Clone Catra adapted.

Prime adapted.

Prime adjusted mid-strike, altering rhythm, pushing harder, faster, testing for weaknesses. The blade came down in a sequence that Adora knew instinctively now—Horde forms, drilled and repeated by every clone until they became second nature. Forms Catra had learned.

Forms Catra had *survived*.

Catra didn't hesitate.

She stepped into it.

A sidestep, tight and deliberate, letting the strike pass close enough to feel the air split beside her before answering with a

flurry of cuts aimed not to overpower but to destabilize. She drove the clone back half a step, then another, forcing a break in the pattern.

Adora’s breath caught.

She could see it now.

The childhood Catra had never been allowed to have, carved away and replaced with this—this sharp, honed thing that knew exactly how to fight something bigger, stronger, more experienced.

She fought like someone who had never had the luxury of matching She-Ra's strength because she never imagined she'd be gifted with it.

She fought like someone who had learned, over and over again, that survival meant finding the flaw in something that should have been unbeatable.

And in the space between one strike and the next, Adora saw it—clear and terrible.

The subtle ghost of Shadow Weaver in the way Catra moved.

Not the innate magic, but the technique.

That elusive, evasive style—half-step retreats, deceptive angles, the way she let attacks glance past her rather than meeting them head-on. It was there, threaded through Catra’s movements, reshaped into something sharper, something entirely her own.

Opposite her stood Prime.

In Catra’s body.

A mirror of everything she had been forced to learn.

The two styles collided.

And Catra held.

They had edged back toward the rise of the platform without Adora fully realizing it.

The fight had carried them there in increments—step by step, strike by strike—until the shallow incline of the dais began to warp the ground beneath Catra's feet. The surface dipped almost imperceptibly, a subtle flaw in an otherwise perfect design, but it was enough. Adora saw it happen before she could stop it—the shift in Catra's balance, the angle of her shoulders adjusting half a beat too late.

The blade followed that misstep.

Too far left.

A fraction.

A fatal fraction.

"No—" Adora forced herself upright, ignoring the white-hot pain tearing through her side. The world lurched, her vision narrowing, but she stayed up long enough to see Clone Catra move.

Fast.

Merciless.

The opening was there and Prime took it without hesitation, the blade cutting in with the clean, decisive line of someone who had ended a thousand fights exactly this way.

It should have landed.

It should have ended it.

Instead—

Clone Catra made a strangled, choking sound.

Her eyes widened.

Shock, real and unfiltered, fractured across her face.

Catra's stumble had never been a mistake.

The moment snapped back into clarity with brutal precision. The off-balance footing, the overextended swing—it had all been bait. A feint drawn so tightly to the line of failure that it became indistinguishable from it.

Catra wasn't Shadow Weaver.

She didn't retreat into safety.

She built traps.

Catra's blade came up from the wrong angle, intercepting the downward strike with a sharp, ringing clash that knocked Clone Catra's weapon off its path. There was no wasted motion. No hesitation. Just a clean redirection—up, away—

—and then forward.

Her wrist turned.

The Sword of Protection drove straight through Clone Catra's chest.

The impact was solid and final.

The clone's body jerked as the blade punched through white fabric and flesh alike. Her sword slipped from her grip and struck the platform with a hollow metallic clang before skidding uselessly across the blood-slick surface.

She dropped to her knees.

For a moment she simply stared up at Catra, eyes already losing focus, whatever intelligence had been behind them flickering out as Prime abandoned the vessel without ceremony.

Catra didn't linger.

She yanked the blade free in one smooth motion and, with a single efficient stroke, cut across the clone’s throat. The body sagged, collapsing forward into the growing ruin at their feet. The eyes remained open, glassy and empty.

Dead.

Catra was already turning.

More movement at the door.

Four figures this time, as Prime truly began to understand the gravity of his situation.

Four more versions of her, stepping into the chamber like reflections pulled from a broken mirror.

Adora’s knees buckled.

The fight had taken too much out of her. The blood loss, the strain, the pain, calling She-Ra's form without the sword conduit—it all caught up at once, dragging her down. The chamber tilted sharply as her vision blurred, the edges darkening.

She saw Catra square herself again. Saw the set of her shoulders, the way she adjusted her grip on the sword, ready to do it all over again without hesitation.

And then—

Nothing.

When awareness returned, it did so gently.

The noise of the chamber had dulled. The sharp edges of pain had softened into something distant and throbbing. The first thing she registered was warmth.

Hands.

Catra’s hands.

Firm, steady, and real.

Adora blinked slowly, dragging her gaze into focus. Catra was kneeling beside her, close enough that Adora could see the fine details of her face—the tension still held tight around her mouth, the lingering brightness in her eyes that hadn't yet faded from the fight.

Alive.

That was the only thought that mattered for a long, suspended moment.

Alive.

Relief flooded through her so suddenly it stole what little breath she had left. Everything else—Prime, the clones, the blood still escaping her—fell away, leaving only the solid, grounding presence of Catra beside her.

Catra hadn't left.

Catra was here.

Kneeling in the middle of a massacre, lightyears from anything that could be called safe, with her attention fixed entirely on Adora.

There was nothing distant about her now. Nothing untouchable. No sharp edges held in reserve.

Just *her* Catra.

Catra's hands shifted slightly, pressing against her side, assessing, steadying.

"There's a lot of blood," Catra said.

Her voice was rougher than usual, stripped of its usual bite, threaded instead with something quieter. Something dangerously

close to fear.

Time lost its shape.

It stretched thin and strange, each breath its own small effort, each second dragging as though the air itself had thickened around her. Adora lay half-curled where Catra held her, her awareness slipping in and out in shallow waves. The pressure of Catra’s hands at her side was the only constant—firm, unyielding, anchoring her to something solid while everything else drifted.

More footsteps came eventually.

Distant at first. Then closer.

Adora didn’t trust them. Not at first. Sound had begun to blur into something unreliable, the echo of the chamber distorting everything into the same hollow rhythm. But Catra’s posture shifted—just slightly—and Adora felt it immediately in the tension of her grip.

Catra was exhausted.

Adora could feel it in the way her hands pressed harder than necessary, as though force alone could compensate for whatever she had left to give. She was soaked through with Adora’s blood, the Clone’s blood and Prime’s blood, it slicked across her arms, streaked her armor, darkened the gold at her shoulders into something heavier, duller. Her breathing wasn’t steady anymore. It came in measured pulls, controlled, but too deep.

If whoever entered had been another enemy—

Adora wasn’t sure Catra could have lifted the sword again even with She-Ra's strength.

The figures broke through the doorway.

Double Trouble first, and behind them, Mermista.

So they had come back after all. Double Trouble, unreliable in every way that mattered, had still come back.

Adora watched Mermista take it in. The bodies. The blood. The broken shapes strewn across the platform like discarded parts. Adora herself, half-conscious and bleeding out onto the floor. And Catra—

Catra, sitting there in She-Ra's form, drenched in red and green, hands pressed into Adora's wound like she was trying to hold her together by will alone.

Mermista's face shifted—shock, revulsion, and distrust.

Catra straightened.

Only slightly. She didn't remove her hands from Adora. She didn't let the pressure ease even for a second. But she lifted her head, and when she looked at Mermista there was nothing left in her expression. No anger. No fear.

Nothing.

It was the same empty composure she had worn in front of Prime.

"The girl," Catra said, her voice stripped down to instruction. She nodded once toward somewhere Adora couldn't quite see. "Unconscious. Secure her until we can get her to a healer. I want her kept alive."

"What have you done?" Mermista's voice came out low, sharp with disbelief.

Catra's eyes closed for the briefest second.

It looked like irritation. Or exhaustion. Or both.

"Restrain her," Catra said again, quieter but no less firm. Then, without looking away from Adora, "Double Trouble. Get the Velvet Glove back to Etheria."

When Catra opened her eyes again, Mermista hadn't moved.

Double Trouble had. They were already gone.

"Now," Catra said.

The word cracked just slightly.

Mermista's hand went to her sword.

"I'm not leaving you alone with her."

Adora forced air into her lungs.

It hurt.

Everything hurt.

"Then I'll bleed out," she managed, the words scraping against her throat. "She's—she's the only one who can fix me."

Mermista hesitated.

Still didn't move.

"What about Prime?" she demanded.

"He's dead," Catra said.

No emotion. No triumph.

Just cold fact.

Mermista's expression twisted. "Do you have pure ice in your veins?" she snapped, finally moving, crossing to where the unconscious body lay out of Adora's sight. She dropped to her knees, binding the girl's wrists with quick, practiced movements. "You can't even pretend you care about any of this?"

Catra didn't answer. She didn't look away from Adora.

“Adora,” she said instead, her voice lowering, losing that empty edge. “Tell me what you need. Tell me what to do.”

Adora reached for her. Her hand found Catra’s wrist, slick with blood, and held on as tightly as she could manage.

“She-Ra—” The word caught. She swallowed, tried again. “She heals. It’s—”

Her vision flickered.

“Love,” she forced out.

The word hung between them.

And in that suspended moment, something terrible and quiet settled in Adora’s chest. Catra had never said it back. Not once. “Thank you,” she had said. Only that. Never—

Adora’s grip tightened weakly.

Surely—

Surely she did.

Darkness surged up fast, swallowing the edges of her vision, dragging her down before she could hold onto the thought.

For a terrifying heartbeat, there was nothing.

Then—

Light.

Chapter 45: Catra

Chapter Notes

> Thank you for reading (only 2 chapters left 🥺), and a big thanks to my beta reader 🙏
>
> One more Catra chapter after this, and one more Adora chapter
>
> This chapter and the next were partially inspired by the song Other Side by NewDad

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The light answered her.

Catra felt it pour through her - nothing like the sharp, violent surge of battle. This was softer, deeper, something that pressed outward from her chest rather than striking through her limbs. It wrapped around Adora where she lay, sinking into torn flesh, knitting together what had been ripped apart, forcing the bleeding to stop beneath Catra's hands.

She watched it happen.

Watched the wound close. Watched the blood slow, then stop.

And still—

Adora didn't move.

At first, Catra told herself it was nothing. Healing took time. Bodies didn't just snap back into place like elastic. But seconds stretched. Then longer. And Adora remained limp beneath her, too still, too quiet.

Something cold began to creep up Catra's spine.

Maybe it wasn’t working.

Maybe she wasn’t enough.

The thought came vicious and immediate, sharp enough to make her breath catch. Maybe She-Ra’s magic didn’t answer her the same way. Maybe it needed someone like Adora—someone good, someone worthy. Catra had never been either of those things.

Her hands tightened where they pressed against Adora’s body. She didn’t realize she was shaking until she heard her own voice.

“I love you,” she whispered, hoarse and uneven, the words spilling out before she could stop them. “I love you, I love you, I love you—wake up. Please. Just—” Her throat closed, but she forced the rest out anyway, desperate and helplessly unguarded. “I’ll marry you. I swear I will. Just wake up.”

The light had flared brighter around them, almost painfully so.

And then—

Adora’s eyes opened.

Slowly. Blurred. But unmistakable.

She looked up at Catra, dazed, smiling faintly through the exhaustion, and said, “I knew you loved me.”

Relief hit Catra so hard it had almost knocked the breath out of her.

She hadn’t realized how tightly she had been holding herself together until that moment—until something inside her finally gave way and she exhaled, long and shaking, like she had been underwater for hours and had only just broken the surface.

Adora had slipped back under almost immediately.

Not dead. No longer dying.

Just—gone again. Drained. Her body pushed past its limits, now taking what it needed in return.

Catra told herself that was all it was.

She had to.

They moved her carefully.

The Velvet Glove still stank of death, but there were rooms untouched by it—sterile, unused spaces that had not yet been stained by what happened to Catra or any of the others. They laid Adora out on one of the beds, the white sheets swallowing her up, making her look smaller than she had any right to be.

Catra stood at the side of it for a long moment.

It's just the bed, she told herself.

Not the way Adora looked pale against it. Not the way her breathing seemed too shallow. Just the size of the bed.

She was stable. The wound was closed. She *would* wake up.

Catra repeated it until it sounded like fact.

Everything after that became movement. Tasks. Orders. Things that could be controlled.

Her original body—what was left of it—was returned to the pod it had been held in, sealed away once more like the fragile thing it had become. Catra didn't watch it happen. She didn't want to look at it. Didn't want to think about the years it had spent there, waiting, while she had been—

Something else.

Mermista stayed close.

Too close.

She hovered like a guard dog, eyes tracking Catra's every movement as though she expected her to snap at any second. Catra could feel it without looking—the suspicion, the distrust, the readiness.

Catra ignored her.

It didn't matter.

Nothing mattered except—

Adora.

When they returned to Etheria, the shift was immediate. People moved quickly at Catra's command, though not without hesitation, not without confirming their obedience with a glance or two toward Mermista.

Slaves arrived with water, with cloths, with everything needed to tend to a body that had been pushed too far.

Catra took it all from them.

"I'll do it," she said, already reaching, already dismissing them before they could argue.

She washed the blood from Adora's skin herself.

The cloth dragged red from Adora's arms, her shoulders, the line of her throat. Catra wrung it out, watched the water turn pink, then clear, then pink again.

People came and went.

Catra issued orders without looking up.

"Find Glimmer. Find her child. Bring them here."

"Glimmer's a traitor," Mermista snapped immediately.

Catra stilled. Slowly, she lifted her gaze. The look she gave Mermista was flat and cold and utterly uncompromising.

"Your Queen," Catra said, "will want her sister brought home."

Mermista didn't answer. Good. Catra went back to her work. More came. More interruptions. More things that needed doing.

"I want runners sent to our forces. Get me Marzo."

"I need coffee. Strong enough to wake the dead. If it's weak, I'll throw someone out a window."

She paused, glanced at the slaves hovering uncertainly.

"No slaves," she corrected sharply. "Queen Adora doesn't use slaves."

The room shifted subtly at that.

"Water. Towels. Move."

Her hands never stopped. Her mind didn't either.

"Lock down Bright Moon. Anyone resisting gets arrested. Anyone chipped goes straight to Entrapta and 28. I want names—every soldier still loyal to Glimmer, every clone that hasn't bent the knee. They all answer for this."

Adora shifted faintly beneath her hands. Her eyes flickered open. Only for a second. Catra felt it like a physical thing.

"When she wakes," Catra continued, quieter now, "she'll take their oaths."

She looked up at Mermista who was still standing there. Still watching. Still waiting.

"Adora will take yours now," Catra said.

Mermista's mouth twisted.

“And I’m supposed to swear to you as well?”

“I wouldn’t take your oath if you threw yourself at my feet for it,” Catra said, voice flat with disinterest. “Come here. Kneel. Do it while she can still hear you.”

Adora was awake. Barely. Her eyes were open, unfocused at first, then sharpening in small, fragile increments. She hadn’t spoken yet, but her hand moved—slow, unsteady—finding the fabric at Catra’s side and catching there, fingers curling weakly into the dress like she needed something solid to hold onto.

Catra didn’t look down.

Not yet.

“Come forward,” she said again.

Mermista obeyed, though there was reluctance in every step. Suspicion sat heavy in the set of her shoulders, in the way her gaze kept cutting sideways toward Catra as if she expected something to snap at any second. Still, she crossed the room and lowered herself beside the bed, kneeling stiffly. She didn’t look at Catra. She looked at Adora.

Hard.

“Adora,” Mermista said, her voice steady but edged with something sharp, something that had not yet decided whether it was grief or anger. “I give you everything that’s mine to give—my forces, my land, my loyalty. You have my word and my sword. I stand with you, and if I ever break that, I don’t deserve to keep breathing.” She paused, jaw tightening. “As Princess of—”

Her gaze flicked, involuntarily, toward Catra.

The scowl came immediately.

“—as Princess of Salineas,” she continued, but the words had lost their rhythm, broken by the interruption of whatever she saw

when she looked at Catra, "though apparently that was meant to be handed over to the Horde-"

"That's enough," Catra cut in.

Mermista's head snapped toward her, glare sharp and immediate. Catra met it without effort.

"It's appropriate," Catra went on, ignoring the hostility, "that the first person to swear to her is the one who's stood beside her the longest." Her tone didn't soften, but something beneath it shifted, quieter, more deliberate. "But Salineas isn't part of any bargain I intend to keep."

Mermista's expression hardened. "So that's it? You're just going to betray her now, after everything?"

"No," Catra said simply. "You keep your kingdom. You keep your title. You answer to Adora of Etheria."

She didn't hesitate.

"As I answer to her, too, as *my* Queen."

The room stilled.

Mermista looked back at Adora, clearly searching for some kind of contradiction, some sign that this was another game, another angle. But Adora was still watching Catra, her expression unfocused but unmistakably fixed on her.

"*Your* Queen?" Adora managed, voice rough with pain, thin from exhaustion.

Catra finally looked down.

"My Queen," she confirmed. The words were quieter now. Not for Mermista. Not for anyone else in the room. Just for Adora. She held her gaze, steady, unflinching, letting everything she couldn't quite say sit in that space between them. Devotion, sharp and

unpolished. Something deeper than any bargain, any alliance, anything that could be negotiated or broken. Adora stared at her like she was trying to understand something that hurt to look at.

"But—"

"—you're Queen of the Horde," Mermista cut in, unable to leave it alone, the interruption sharp enough to slice the moment clean in two.

Catra didn't even look at her this time.

"There is no Horde," she said. "Not anymore. It ended with him."

She adjusted the cloth at Adora's side, hands still precise despite the exhaustion dragging at her limbs.

"It always should have," she added, quieter.

Mermista exhaled through her nose, tension still tight in her posture, but something in her stance shifted—less resistance, more reluctant acceptance.

"…So what now?" she asked.

Catra didn't pause.

"Prime didn't build this on his own," she said. "He'll have people outside the city who still believe in him. And there'll be plenty who'd rather call Adora a Horde puppet or imposter clone than face what's actually happened."

Her tone sharpened again, slipping cleanly back into command.

"We need to move before that turns into something organized."

Mermista's chin lifted slightly. "Tell me what you need."

✧

Catra hadn't expected the rain.

She knew, in the abstract way one knows things without needing to feel them, that Etheria had seasons, that water fell from its skies often enough to feed rivers and soften soil and make the air carry that strange, clean weight it always seemed to have. But knowing it and seeing it were not the same.

It came quietly.

No warning. No great storm to announce itself as something to be endured. Just a soft dimming of the light beyond the open balcony, a subtle shift in the air that she only noticed because something in her stilled in response.

The scent reached her first.

Warm stone, newly wet. Dirt breathing out something mineral and clean. It slipped through the room like a memory she hadn't asked for, brushing against her senses with a familiarity that made her chest tighten.

Petrichor.

She stood without meaning to.

The movement was unconscious, her body carrying her across the room before her thoughts could catch up. Bare feet met cool marble, the chill grounding, real. The gauze curtains shifted as she passed, stirred by the faint breeze that carried the rain inward.

Bright Moon had softened. The city beyond the balcony blurred slightly beneath the falling water, white stone darkening in uneven patterns, rooftops gleaming faintly under a sky that had turned a muted, endless grey. The rain tapped lightly against the edges of the balcony, a steady, quiet rhythm that seemed to smooth the world into something gentler.

It was—

Catra exhaled slowly.

Peaceful.

The realization felt almost foreign. She hadn't noticed how loud everything had been until it wasn't. No shouting. No orders. No fury humming beneath her feet. Just the soft, persistent sound of rain and the faint stir of air through fabric. For a moment, she let herself stand there.

Still.

She didn't hear Adora move. She felt her. The warmth came first—solid and unmistakable, pressing gently into her back before arms slid around her waist. Strong, but careful. Always careful.

Catra tensed on instinct. It was automatic. Old. But the tension didn't hold. It slipped away almost immediately, a breath leaving her that she hadn't meant to release.

"Why are you out of bed?" she said, sharper than she intended, the edge more habit than heat.

Behind her, Adora made a small, plaintive sound—something soft and low that barely qualified as a protest—and buried her face against the curve of Catra's neck. Her breath was warm, her hair still disordered from sleep, brushing against Catra's skin in a way that was almost distracting.

"You were gone," Adora murmured.

Catra's eyes flicked closed.

"I was standing at a window," she said.

Adora's arms tightened slightly, as though that proved something. "You looked like you were leaving."

Catra let out a quiet huff. "You're being ridiculous."

A faint laugh ghosted against her skin. Adora shifted closer without hesitation, without the slightest concern for how much

space she was taking up, pressing in like she belonged there, because she did.

"You're supposed to be resting," Adora said, voice softer now, though no less insistent.

There it was. That instinctive push. That quiet, relentless need Adora had to take care of things. To fix. To protect. To hover. Catra felt the familiar flicker of irritation rise in response to it. She wasn't fragile. She wasn't something that needed tending.

"I am standing," Catra said coolly. "That hardly qualifies as strenuous activity. You, however—" she shifted just enough to glance back at her, eyes narrowing slightly "—were very recently stabbed. Repeatedly. In case that detail slipped your mind."

"Barely," Adora said, dismissive in that way that was both infuriating and—*unfortunately*—very Adora. "And you fixed it anyway. With your love."

Catra made a face at that, even as something low in her chest tightened in a way she refused to outwardly express just now. She reached down and pried Adora's arms loose, one at a time. It took less effort than it should have—Adora let her, compliant even as she made a quiet, displeased noise at the loss of contact.

When Catra turned, Adora was swaying.

Just slightly, but enough.

The exhaustion was still there, written in the looseness of her posture, in the way her balance hadn't fully settled back into place. Catra's mouth tightened.

"Bed," she said.

No softness now. No room for argument.

Adora's lips curved, faintly amused despite the obvious strain. "You going to make me?" she asked, already turning in the

direction of the bed like she knew exactly how this would end.

Catra crossed her arms.

“Do you want to find out?” she said, flatly.

Adora huffed something that might have been a laugh, and made her way back without further resistance.

Catra watched her cross the room.

She always did like to watch her walking away.

Even now—especially now—her eyes tracked every shift of Adora’s weight, every small adjustment that betrayed the effort it took just to move. There was something wrong about it. Not wrong in the way of injury—Catra knew injury, knew the language of it—but wrong in the sense that Adora had always moved like the world couldn’t slow her down. Now there was caution where there had once been certainty. A careful placement of feet. A breath drawn before the next step.

Magic had limits.

Adora had reached them.

Catra followed.

Not quickly. Not overtly. Just enough that when Adora reached the bed, Catra was already there to witness the way she lowered herself—controlled, the exhale slipping out of her like she had been holding it too long. The sheets were still tangled from earlier, bearing the imprint of shared sleep, of bodies that had not learned how to stay apart anymore.

Catra paused.

Then sat.

Her posture remained straight, composed, as though the space between them required formality to keep from collapsing entirely. The mattress dipped slightly beneath her weight, a subtle shift that brought her closer without permission.

For a moment, neither of them spoke.

The rain filled the silence.

It tapped gently against stone, a steady rhythm that seemed to exist outside of time. It softened everything—the sharp edges of thought, the urgency that had carried them this far. It made the room feel smaller. Quieter.

Adora looked at her from the corner of her eye.

"You're thinking loud enough to wake the dead," she said.

Catra let out a short, dismissive breath. "You're hallucinating. Probably from all that blood loss."

"Could be," Adora replied easily.

Her gaze drifted back toward the open balcony, toward the grey wash of sky and the softened lines of the city beyond. There was something in her expression—something quiet, something that lingered just beneath the surface.

Catra felt it.

She should say it. She should tell her. About everything. About what she had seen. What she had learned. What was still sitting like a weight inside her chest, too heavy to carry and too dangerous to drop. She should tell Adora that she was going to be a mother, for real this time.

The words rose.

Stopped.

“Sleep,” Catra said instead. “You’re no good to anyone like this.”

Adora didn’t argue.

That, more than anything, unsettled Catra.

She turned her head fully then, studying Catra in a way that felt too perceptive, too patient. There was no challenge in it. No teasing. Just a quiet, searching look that made Catra feel like she was being seen too clearly.

After a moment, Adora nodded.

“Okay.”

Her hand lifted—not reaching, not demanding—just brushing lightly against Catra’s wrist. A touch so brief it could have been accidental.

Catra didn’t move.

Didn’t pull away.

She told herself it was practical. That Adora shouldn’t be shifting unnecessarily. That it wasn’t worth the effort to create distance when there was no real reason for it.

Adora shifted. Made space. Turned onto her side.

And Catra—

followed.

It happened without thought. One moment she was sitting, the next she was leaning, then lying down, the distance between them closing like it had never existed at all. She fit against Adora’s body with an ease that was almost unsettling, like something instinctive had taken over where conscious choice failed.

Warmth met her immediately.

Solid. Real.

Alive.

They had survived and Prime was gone. *Finally*.

Adora's arm came around her without hesitation, loose but certain, curving along her back in a way that wasn't possessive but still somehow felt like protection. The contact was steady, grounding. It made something in Catra's shoulders loosen before she could stop it.

Her breath slowed. In. Out.

The rhythm of it synced with Adora's without effort, their bodies falling into a pattern they had found before and hadn't yet forgotten.

Catra shifted slightly, adjusting closer, tucking into the space that Adora had made for her as though she had always belonged there. Her hand rested against Adora's side, careful without being tentative, aware of the healing beneath her palm.

She could feel it.

The life there.

The steady rise and fall of her chest. The warmth that seeped through linen and skin alike. The quiet proof that she was still here.

Still breathing.

Still—

Catra let her eyes close.

Just for a moment. Just this. Nothing else.

Just the rain, soft and unending beyond the balcony, and the solid, familiar weight of Adora beside her.

For a moment—

She let herself rest.

✧

Catra pressed her face into the bedding to swallow the sounds that threatened to betray her.

The room was warm, heavy with the slow, heat of shared bodies. Adora moved over her with a care that was almost at odds with the strength Catra knew she possessed—measured, as though she was still half afraid of breaking something fragile.

Catra's eyes slipped half-shut, lashes lowering as the sensation of Adora entering her blurred the edges of her focus. For a moment she saw nothing at all—just the pull of it, the closeness, the dizzying awareness of Adora everywhere at once.

She had missed this.

More than she had let herself admit.

A week. Only a week, and it had already been too long. She had tried to be reasonable about it, tried to accept Adora's careful compromises, but it had never been enough. Not when she knew what it felt like to have Adora fully there, to be held in that way that erased distance entirely.

There was nothing else like it.

"Yes—" Catra breathed, the word slipping out of her before she could stop it as Adora settled in further.

Above her, Adora's composure cracked in a way Catra found deeply satisfying.

"Fuck," Adora muttered under her breath, the word rough, unpolished. She leaned down instinctively, forehead brushing Catra's shoulder, breath warm against her skin. For a fleeting

second, Catra almost asked if she was all right—but Adora spoke first, voice strained with an effort that was only half successful. "You're going to have to stay quiet if you want me to last longer than five seconds."

Catra almost laughed.

Really?

"All I said was 'yes,'" she murmured, tone sliding into something seductive. "If that's all it takes, you're in trouble."

Adora made a soft, frustrated sound.

Catra shifted—rocking back into the feeling, chasing some amount of friction—and felt the immediate response it drew from her.

That was better.

That was exactly the reaction she wanted.

"Anyway, you say that like you don't always finish quickly," Catra added, quieter now, a thread of smugness winding through the words. "At least with me."

Adora's grip tightened.

Catra felt it in the way her hands pressed, in the way her breath caught, in the way restraint became something harder to maintain. There was a kind of quiet triumph in it—knowing easily she could undo her.

She filed the sounds Adora made away.

For later.

For when they weren't like this—when distance and duty put space between them again, when memory would have to stand in for reality.

Adora went still once more.

Not entirely—but enough that Catra noticed. Enough that she recognized the hesitation, the effort to hold back, to prove something that didn't need proving.

Catra didn't like that.

She didn't like the pause.

She didn't like the restraint.

"Move," she said, low and insistent. "Adora."

Adora's arms tightened around her, something almost protective in the hold.

"Catra—"

"You feel too good," Catra breathed, deliberately seductive as she moaned, "Adora—please."

Adora's restraint snapped.

Movement followed—sudden, unguarded, driven more by instinct than thought. The careful pacing gave way to something faster, less controlled, and Catra's grip on the bedding tightened as the rhythm shifted, the quiet of the room breaking under the strain of it.

She truly didn't last long.

It never did, not like this—not when it was Catra, not when it was *them*. The control Adora had in every other part of her life seemed to falter here, slipping through her fingers the moment Catra pressed too close, pushed too far.

Catra liked that.

She liked it more than she should.

The moment crested quickly, sharp and overwhelming, and for a brief, suspended instant, everything narrowed to sensation and

breath and the quiet, shared collapse of tension.

Then it was over.

Adora pulled back slowly, carefully, the separation gentle but unavoidable. The loss of contact left Catra with a hollow, aching awareness she didn't bother to hide. She shifted slightly, a soft, involuntary sound escaping her before she could catch it.

She wanted her back inside her.

Already.

Adora's breathing evened out gradually, the rise and fall of her chest slowing as she regained herself, letting She-Ra's form slip away.

"I didn't hurt you, at the end, did I?" she asked, voice quieter now, concern threading through it in a way that was achingly soft.

Catra turned onto her side to face her, expression languid, eyes heavy. She took a moment before answering, letting the silence stretch just enough. Then she hummed, low and satisfied.

"No," she said. Her gaze flicked over Adora's face, taking in the lingering flush, the softness that always followed, the way she still looked a little undone. Catra's mouth curved slightly.

"So," she added, voice light, "how long until you're ready to go again?"

Chapter End Notes

> No she has not told Adora about the baby. It's a little too early and Adora is busy healing.
>
> Prime is super dead. Dead dead. I established in Favour that Prime cannot reach the consciousness of his clones on Etheria if he's too far away.

Chapter 46: Catra

Chapter Notes

> Hey guys, lifes really stressful rn but I had time to actually finish this today.
>
> Thank you to my beta reader for getting to this so quickly 🥰🥰🥰
>
> Next chapter will have a nsfw comic at the end (or I can post it as chapter 48 or something). As I have no idea how long chapter 47 will take me to write given how busy my life is, that is already available on my patreon (and has been for months) if you want to see what I envisioned for the end all those months ago. Plenty of other art there too. Currently obsessing over Zukka and all the mm romance books I've been reading so plenty of that there. Sorry I took a break from writing, but I post kind of regularly on insta and tiktok if you miss me.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra stood at the balcony's edge, one hand braced against the pale stone as she stared out into a horizon swallowed by low, drifting cloud. Mystacor felt like it existed half in the sky, half out of it—the air was thinner, quieter, as though sound itself hesitated before carrying this high. Even the wind moved differently here, sliding along the cliffs instead of rushing through them. She could hear the horses before she could see them, the distant rhythm of hooves echoing up the winding paths below.

"Tell me the second she arrives," Catra said without turning, voice cool, controlled. "I don't want to be the last to know."

A beat.

Then, closer than expected—too close—came the answer.

“I'm not a servant.”

Catra turned.

Adora stood in the doorway like she’d always belonged there, framed by light and shadow, the wind catching at her hair and tugging gently at the hem of her skirt. It was ridiculous how easily she filled a space, the eye drawn to her without effort. The golden glow of She-Ra swallowed her form, unmistakable despite its softness at the edges.

Catra’s gaze dropped, briefly, traitorously.

Her thighs.

If they had still been enemies, Catra thought—distantly, absurdly—she would have aimed there first. A distraction. A weakness. Something to exploit.

They weren’t enemies.

She wanted to sink her claws into those thighs all the same.

“I was watching the road,” Catra said, quieter now, as though the admission cost her something.

Adora stepped forward.

“Hey, Catra.”

Simple. Soft. Entirely too warm for Catra’s nervous heart.

Catra felt the heat rise to her face before she could stop it, irritation flickering beneath it—not at Adora, but at herself. A month. A month of distance, of unfinished thoughts and swallowed words. There had been no time to speak, no space to say what mattered. Too much had happened. Too much still sat, unspoken, lodged somewhere beneath her ribs.

“Hey, Adora,” Catra answered, and it came out rougher than she intended.

Adora smiled.

Not the easy, open grin she gave the world, but something smaller, more private—something Catra had learned, slowly, was meant only for her.

“It’s been a while,” Adora said. “Forgot how to do this?”

Catra huffed softly. “Maybe.”

“We’ve got time,” Adora replied. “We’re not running from anything.”

Catra’s eyes flicked to hers, sharp.

“Are you sure about that?”

Adora didn’t answer right away. Instead, she closed the distance between them, slow enough that Catra could have stepped away if she’d wanted to.

She didn’t.

“It suits you,” Adora said instead, voice lower now, her attention shifting to the thin line of Catra’s dress where it traced across her collarbone. Her fingers followed it lightly, not quite touching skin, but close enough that Catra felt it anyway.

Catra held still.

“The dress?” she asked, dry.

Adora’s mouth curved faintly. “Yeah. That too.”

The implication wasn’t subtle.

It never was, with her.

“They picked it out for me,” Catra said, as if that explained anything at all. “Rooms too. Open like this.” Her hand gestured vaguely toward the balcony, the sea beyond, the quiet stretch of sky. “I thought about you.”

Adora’s gaze sharpened.

“Did you?”

Catra exhaled, the sound quieter now, less guarded.

“I thought about what it would be like,” she admitted. “Here. With you.”

Adora stepped closer.

“Like this,” she said.

Her lips brushed Catra’s shoulder—light, careful, like she was testing the distance between them all over again. Then higher, along her jaw, unhurried, unafraid.

Catra’s breath caught.

“That’s not what I meant,” she said, though the words lacked conviction. “Thinking about you and actually being with you aren’t the same. You’re—” She faltered, searching. “More.”

Adora tilted her head slightly, a flicker of smugness returning. “More what?”

Catra shot her a look. “Don’t.”

“Say it,” Adora pressed, softer now, but no less insistent.

Catra’s mouth opened.

Closed.

“Shut me up,” she muttered instead. “Before I say something stupid.”

Adora didn’t hesitate.

The kiss was gentler than Catra expected—brief, almost restrained—but it landed like a spark, sharp and immediate. Heat followed, quick and familiar, settling low in her chest as her hands moved without permission, mapping the lines of Adora’s body as though reacquainting herself.

Adora pulled back just enough to look at her.

“You look… Etherian,” she said, voice warm with quiet approval.

Catra snorted softly. “Don’t start.”

“I’m serious.”

“Take off the armour,” Catra cut in, sharper now, though not unkind. “I don’t need She-Ra.”

For a moment, Adora held her gaze.

Then the magic slipped away.

The gold faded. The height softened. What remained was Adora—just Adora—standing in a simple white dress that echoed Catra’s own, light fabric caught at the shoulder with a single clasp, falling cleanly along her frame.

Equal.

Unarmoured.

Catra leaned back against the bannister, studying her openly now.

Better.

“The rest can wait,” Adora whispered.

Her voice had dropped without Catra even noticing—low enough that it seemed to settle somewhere just under her skin rather than reach her ears. Catra felt it more than heard it. Her hand

came up almost absently, pressing against the thin fabric stretched over Adora's chest, feeling the warmth beneath it, the steady rise and fall that was just a little too fast to be entirely normal.

This was different.

No longer the towering, untouchable presence of She-Ra. Just Adora again, close enough that Catra could take her apart piece by piece if she wanted to. It made something in her chest tighten.

She didn't think about it too long.

Catra leaned in first, closing the distance with a certainty that had nothing hesitant in it. Her mouth found Adora's, opening easily when Adora pressed closer, letting her in with a familiarity that had been learned and relearned until it felt like instinct. Adora kissed like she did everything else—too much, too earnest, too intense—and Catra met it with equal force, fingers curling into the back of her neck, holding her there.

The dress did nothing to help.

Light, soft, barely there—Catra felt exposed in a way that her usual clothing never managed. There was no weight to hide behind, no structure. Just skin and cloth and the way Adora stared at her like she'd won something.

Adora moved her back without breaking the kiss, guiding her until the cool stone of the balustrade pressed against her spine. The contrast made her inhale sharply, and she answered it by shifting closer, sliding her thigh along the inside of Adora's, deliberate, testing. The movement lifted the hem of her skirt just enough to matter.

For a second, Catra thought—knew—how it could go. The shift in weight, the grip, the push forward into something faster, less controlled, the kind of urgency they both understood too well—

—but Adora didn't take it.

Instead, she slowed.

It was worse.

Worse in the way it made Catra aware of every second, every small movement, every brush of skin and breath and mouth. Adora lingered, drawing it out with a patience that felt almost calculated, like she knew exactly what it was doing and was choosing it anyway. It left Catra chasing something just out of reach, breath uneven, thoughts slipping loose one by one.

"Adora—" she started, not even sure what she meant to say.

Adora only hummed against her mouth, like she didn't need the words.

By the time she pulled back, it was Catra who felt undone—dress askew, hair shifted loose, thoughts scattered in a way she didn't appreciate. Adora looked flushed, lips pink, eyes bright with something that made Catra's stomach twist in a way she only ever experienced in these moments.

Catra liked that look on her.

Too much.

She blinked once, twice, trying to gather herself—trying to remember—

Right.

She had something to say.

Something important.

Something—

"You're early," Catra said instead, the words slipping out as if they'd been waiting for an excuse.

Adora laughed.

Not loud—just that soft, warm sound that always caught Catra off guard.

"Yeah," she said. "Couldn't wait."

Catra huffed, though the edge to it lacked any real bite. "I was supposed to meet you properly. On the steps. Make it official." A pause. "You know— typical Horde protocol."

"Then you can do it later," Adora shot back easily, grin widening. "Come out, make a big deal of it, kiss me in front of everyone."

Catra's heart did something inconvenient.

"Shut up," she muttered, but there was no heat behind it.

Adora didn't stop smiling.

"How far back are they?" Catra asked, forcing some semblance of composure back into her voice.

Adora shrugged, utterly unconcerned. "No idea. Didn't check."

Of course she hadn't.

"Come on," Adora added, reaching for her hand like it was the most natural thing in the world. "I want to show you everything."

Catra let herself be pulled along.

Mystacor unfolded around them like something half-remembered from a story—clean and bright, removed from anything Catra had ever been allowed near. The palace rose from the clouds themselves, white stone and gold and amethyst filigree suspended in open air, its towers tapering into nothing where the mist swallowed them whole. Bridges arched between structures that seemed to float, their edges softened by drifting vapour that curled and shifted with each breath of wind.

Magic clung to the place.

Not the harsh, crackling kind Catra associated with power—but something older, quieter. It hummed faintly beneath everything, woven into the stone, the air, the light.

Catra glanced at Adora.

"This is where you ran around as a kid?" she asked, tone edging toward disbelief.

Adora's expression softened, something quieter settling into it. "Some of it. Not all."

Catra didn't press her for more — Adora showed her anyway.

They walked without direction, following paths that curved through open courtyards and into shaded colonnades where the air cooled and the light fractured through high arches. The gardens were tucked into impossible spaces—green spilling over marble, flowers growing in clusters that leaned toward the sun as if drawn by something stronger than gravity.

Catra let herself be pulled along.

She didn't think about what came next. Didn't think about what she needed to say, what she was avoiding. The weight of it all slipped, just for a while, replaced by something simpler.

Adora's hand in hers.

Sunlight.

Air that didn't smell like smog or manufactured cleanliness.

They stopped often.

Sometimes to look. Sometimes for no reason at all.

A tree here, its bark rough against Catra's back as Adora pressed her there just long enough to steal another kiss. A fountain there, its water cool and clear, catching the light in fractured reflections.

Balconies that opened out into nothing but sky, clouds stretching out beneath them like something solid enough to step onto if you were stupid enough to try.

Catra found herself smiling.

She didn't notice when it happened.

They came to a stop at one of the outer edges, where low branches leaned into the open space, dotted with pale flowers that swayed gently in the breeze.

Catra reached up, plucking one without thinking.

She turned it between her fingers for a moment, then stepped closer.

Adora didn't move.

Catra lifted her hand, tucking the flower into her hair like it meant nothing.

Like it didn't matter that it suited her.

"There," Catra said, pulling her hand back. "You look… cute."

Adora's smile softened, just slightly.

"Yeah?" she asked.

Catra looked at her until her face heated unbearably.

"Yeah," she said, quieter now.

"Are you trying to court me?" Adora asked it like a joke, but there was something searching underneath it, something that made Catra's chest tighten once again.

Catra hadn't missed the way Adora lit up. That stupid, bright smile hit her full force, disarming in a way that felt unfair, like Adora

didn’t even know the damage she could do with it. It made Catra want to look away and lean in at the same time.

“I don’t—” Catra hesitated, fingers curling slightly where they hovered near Adora’s sleeve before she forced them still. “I don’t know how this is supposed to go.” The admission came out quieter than she meant it to. “Never really did this.”

Adora’s expression softened immediately, the teasing edge slipping away like it had never been there. She reached up without asking, plucking another pale bloom from the branch above them, and stepped closer to Catra again. The motion was easy, unguarded.

“You said you had suitors occasionally on the flagship,” Adora said, tilting her head slightly as she tucked the flower behind Catra’s ear, her fingers brushing lightly against her hair. “Hard to believe you didn’t pick up anything.”

Catra huffed under her breath. “That wasn’t courting. That was dodging.”

Adora snorted, a quick, inelegant sound that made Catra’s mouth twitch despite herself.

“My mom and Aunt—this was their work,” Adora said, glancing out over the gardens, the pale stone and drifting green and the soft blur of cloud beyond. “They built it all. Every part.” A pause, softer. “Do you like it? It's ours now.”

Catra felt it again, sharp and sudden, that word lodging somewhere deep and immovable. Ours. Not hers. Not Adora’s. Not Etheria’s alone.

Ours.

It was too much.

“I like it,” Catra said, steadying her voice. “It’s… good.” She glanced at Adora, then back at the gardens. “It’s beautiful.”

Her hand found Adora’s again without thought, fingers slipping between hers, a small, grounding thing that still felt new enough to notice every time.

For a moment they stood like that.

Quiet.

“I don’t think about her much anymore,” Adora said after a while. “Not like I used to. But being here—” She trailed off, her jaw tightening slightly.

Catra didn’t need the rest.

“You’re not like her,” Catra said, blunt, because anything softer felt wrong.

Adora barked out a laugh at that, sharp and immediate. “Yeah, no kidding.”

Catra’s grip tightened just slightly. “She would’ve burned the Fright Zone to ash if it meant getting it back,” she said, tone flattening into something more certain. “Would’ve called it necessary.” Her eyes flicked to Adora. “You didn’t. You let people stay who they were. You've truly unified Etheria.”

Adora didn’t answer right away. The corner of her mouth lifted, faint, like she didn’t quite know what to do with that. In truth, they'd barely begun.

“There’s a statue of her,” Adora said finally. “Here.” She glanced sideways at Catra. “You don’t have to— I know you didn’t—”

“She was your mother,” Catra cut in, quieter now. There was something raw in it, something she couldn’t quite smooth over. “You loved her.” A beat. “I’d like to meet her.”

Adora’s smile came back, softer this time, and Catra felt something in her chest ease in response. That was the point,

wasn’t it. That was what she wanted—to see that smile, to keep it there.

Adora led her the rest of the way.

The statue stood set back from the main paths, half-framed by arching stone and trailing green, the figure carved tall and unyielding, gaze fixed somewhere beyond the gardens themselves. Even in stillness, there was something imposing about it. Familiar, in a way Catra didn’t like.

She stopped a few steps away.

For a moment, she just looked.

Seven years of hate didn’t vanish cleanly. It sat there, quiet and stubborn, even as something else pressed in alongside it.

Catra stepped forward.

The movement she made was deliberate, measured—something she had practiced, learned piece by piece, stripped of Horde sharpness and rebuilt into something that fit this place instead. She dipped her head slightly, the gesture precise, respectful without submission.

Behind her, she heard Adora’s breath catch.

Good.

Catra kept her eyes on the statue.

“I’ll take care of her,” she said, voice steady, though it sat strangely in her throat. “I’ll stand with her. Protect what’s hers.” A pause, quieter. “If it comes to it, I’d give my life for her.”

It wasn’t a vow she made lightly.

It wasn’t one she made for the statue.

Catra straightened slowly, turning just enough to catch Adora in her peripheral vision.

"I won't fail her," Catra said, quieter now, the earlier certainty settling into something steadier, more deliberate. "I won't mess this up. Not again."

The sun sat high enough to press heat down through the canopy, bright and insistent, until the air itself seemed to hum with it. Even here, in Mystacor's height, it drove them back beneath the trees where the shade pooled cool and green. The branches hung low, thick with blossom and scent, something soft and sweet that clung faintly to the back of Catra's throat.

"Catra—"

Adora said her name like she was trying to hold on to a moment that had already passed.

Catra turned back to her anyway.

"In Weave's Slope," she said, the words dragging a little as she found them, "there's a place. A grave." She swallowed. "The statue wasn't right. Not really. But she was there." A pause, sharp. "My mother."

The word sat wrong. It *was* wrong now.

"I went back," Catra continued, forcing it out before she could stop. "I tore it down. Put Kyle there instead."

Adora's expression shifted—confusion first, then something tighter. "You never said what happened—"

"She knew." Catra cut her off, breath catching slightly as she drew it in. She held it a moment, then let it out slow. "Prime showed me. All of it. The real memories." Her voice dropped. "She *knew*."

Adora didn't move.

Catra could feel it—the restraint, the careful distance, like Adora was holding herself back on purpose. It made something in Catra ache worse than if she'd just reached for her.

"She knew what he'd do to you?" Adora asked, quiet, disbelieving.

"Yes—no." Catra's arms came up around herself without thinking, claws digging into her own skin as if that might hold her together. "She didn't care." Her jaw tightened. "She traded me. Gave him access to me so he'd back her war against Angella. I was traded for troops."

Adora's face went still.

"Traded?" she repeated, like she couldn't quite make it fit.

Catra shook her head, a short, frustrated motion. "It wasn't even —" She broke off, dragging a hand through her hair. "When she killed me—my original body—Prime just… fixed it. Made another. Brought me back like it didn't matter." Her voice roughened. "That's what I am. A copy of something she threw away. They made me believe I loved her."

The weight of it hung there, ugly and true.

Adora's voice came softer, careful in a way that made Catra want to snap at her and lean into her all at once. "Can I—" She hesitated. "Can I touch you?"

Catra didn't even try to pretend.

"Please."

It broke on the way out, the word catching and twisting into something closer to a sob. Adora didn't wait after that. She stepped forward, closing the distance Catra hadn't known how to cross, and pulled her in, arms firm and steady around her.

Catra folded into it like she'd been holding herself upright by force alone.

For a moment she couldn’t speak at all. Just breathed, uneven, against Adora’s shoulder, grounding herself in the solidness of her, the heat, the familiar weight of her arms.

“That night,” Catra managed eventually, voice low and unsteady, “when you told me about this place—this stupid castle in the clouds—” Her grip tightened slightly. “That was the first time I thought about anything past the next fight. I thought about coming here. With you.” A small, brittle laugh slipped out. “It mattered. More than anything—that you wanted me in your future.”

Adora didn’t interrupt.

“What we had on the way to Bright Moon,” Catra went on, slower now, each word chosen, “that was already more than I figured I’d ever get. So when he took me back…” She paused, throat tightening. “I thought it was enough. I thought I could have that and be done with it.”

Her fingers curled into the fabric at Adora’s back.

“And then he told me that I was—”

“I’d come for you. Always.” Adora said, cutting through it, voice steady in a way that made Catra’s chest hurt. “Every time.” A breath. Softer. “I love you, Catra.”

Catra stilled.

It was right there. Everything she’d been circling, everything she hadn’t said… derailed again.

She didn’t say it.

Instead, she pulled back just enough to look at Adora, eyes sharper now, something controlled settling back over her expression.

“Let me attend you,” Catra said instead.

The baths of Mystacor opened out beneath the sky, all light and air and quiet luxury, nothing hidden unless it chose to be. Sunlight pooled in the shallow curves of carved stone, catching on the surfaces of the water until everything shimmered faintly, as though the place itself breathed magic. Each basin lay set into the ground like a hollowed jewel, steps descending in smooth arcs, the water within them glass-clear and shifting with the slightest disturbance. Some were tucked beneath the shade of pillared walkways, others left exposed, open to drifting cloud and heat. It was nothing like the baths Catra had known—no echoing marble descent, no suffocating steam, no sense of being enclosed and watched. This place was soft where the others had been sharp.

Everything had already been prepared. Cloths folded just so, oils uncorked, pitchers filled, the water stilled to perfect calm. It was waiting.

As they neared, Catra felt the shift in Adora before she saw it—subtle, but there. A hesitation. A slowing.

Catra didn't need to ask why.

The last time they had stood alone in a place like this, it had been something else entirely. Something twisted, wrong. Catra had let it happen, had stood there inside her own warped sense of control while something in her screamed to stop it. And Adora—Adora had not known how much Catra was suffering in her very presence.

Catra's gaze dropped to her own hands, to the claws she knew too well, to what they had done. She remembered the blood in the water. The way it had stained everything until it had to be drained away entirely. The way Adora had looked when they dragged her out.

She forced the memory down.

"You washed me once," Catra said, voice even, though it cost her something to keep it that way. "My turn."

Adora didn’t answer right away. Catra could almost see the thoughts moving behind her eyes, trying to place this, to understand it, to catch up.

Catra didn’t wait.

She stepped forward into the space as if it belonged to her—because now, in some impossible way, it did. Sandals against warm stone, the hem of her dress brushing her legs, the flower still tucked behind her ear.

“How do they do it?” Catra asked, glancing back at her. “Your usual attendants.”

Adora swallowed once. “They… undress.”

Catra nodded, as though it were instruction she intended to follow precisely.

Her fingers moved to her shoulders, pulling loose the pins that held the dress in place. The fabric slipped easily, sliding down to gather at her waist. She turned slightly, untying the last fastening with deliberate care, and let it fall.

She didn’t rush it.

Didn’t look away.

Adora didn’t either.

The air was warm enough that the shift from clothed to bare barely registered as cold, only a difference in sensation—the open touch of it against skin that had been covered moments before. Catra stood as she was, the dress pooled at her feet, sandals still strapped to her legs.

“And then?” she prompted.

Adora’s voice came a little rougher now. “They check the water.”

Catra reached for one of the pitchers, dipping it into the bath and lifting it again. The water caught the light as it moved, spilling over the edge as she tilted it over herself.

It ran in a clean line from shoulder to chest, down over her body, splashing against the stone and her feet, darkening fur and skin alike. The heat of it blended with the air, leaving her damp, glistening in a way that made Adora inhale sharply.

"Catra—" Adora started.

"And then?" Catra cut in, like she hadn't heard her.

The air thickened with the heat of the baths, steam rising faintly, curling through the shaded space beneath the colonnade.

"They undress me," Adora said.

Catra stepped closer.

"Like this?" she asked.

Adora nodded once.

That was all the permission she needed.

Catra reached for her, slower now. Her hands steady where once they might have trembled. She took her time with it, aware of every shift in Adora's breathing, every tightening of muscle under her touch.

It was different like this.

Before, Adora had always been the one exposed, open, while Catra kept herself hidden behind layers, behind control. Now there was no barrier. No distance to hide behind.

She didn't need it anymore.

Piece by piece, she stripped it away until Adora stood before her unguarded, the strength of her body unhidden, the lines of it

familiar and yet still enough to catch Catra’s breath if she looked too long.

Her gaze dropped, catching on the scars that crossed Adora’s back.

Catra’s hand hovered, then settled lightly against one of them, fingers brushing the healed line as if testing whether it would break open again.

A shudder slipped through her before she could stop it.

“They’re healed,” Adora said quietly.

Catra’s mouth tightened.

“Are they?” she asked.

Are we?

Adora didn’t answer immediately. When she did, it was soft and steady.

“We’ve got time to.”

Chapter End Notes

> Also I'm officially getting married tomorrow, signing the proper papers, changing my name, the works.

Chapter 47: Adora

Chapter Notes

It's done! It's over (for now)

I had a bit of writing block that I filled with reading about 50 or more romance books. Now that my stresses are less and I don't feel guilty even spending time writing, I will continue with my other She-Ra series and the comic I have planned for this one (Titled: Forever). I have many ideas, so many swimming around in this brain.

Thank you to everyone who enjoyed this story, all your comments and support have meant the world to me. You've truly gotten me through hard times. Thank you to my beta reader, you've been amazing.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

These baths were nothing like the ones aboard the Velvet Glove.

There, heat had pressed in from every direction—steam thick enough to choke on, tile slick beneath bare feet, the air perfumed with oils that never quite masked the smell of the metal underneath. Bright Moon’s baths had been different again: carved marble and gold, crowded with pattern and ceremony, beauty layered so densely it became oppressive.

Mystacor was much easier to bear.

The atrium stood open to the summer air, sunlight spilling through the arches in pale gold bands, steam drifting lazily upward rather than gathering heavy overhead. Somewhere beyond the columns, water moved softly through fountains. Birds called in the gardens. It should have felt light and airy as it was.

Instead, the air between them carried weight.

Adora remembered.

She saw immediately that Catra did too.

"I knelt for you once," Adora said quietly.

The words slipped out before she could stop them.

Catra stilled.

For one suspended moment neither of them moved. Then, very deliberately, Catra lowered herself to her knees and all the breath left Adora's body.

Catra hated kneeling. Not disliked—hated. Adora could see it in every rigid line of her posture, in the tension pulled tight through her shoulders, in the shallow movement of her chest. Even now, even willingly, it cost her something. Her lips parted slightly, but no sound came out.

Adora remembered the inn. The rough wooden floor. Catra kneeling there with the look of someone stepping willingly toward an execution block. That night had been desperation disguised as devotion, Catra trying to prove something neither of them had known how to say aloud.

And after that—

She had knelt for Prime, begging for Adora's life.

Adora's stomach turned.

She had spent so long refusing to look directly at any of it. Even while it happened, she had refused. It had been easier to treat the past like near-impenetrable fog—to acknowledge shapes without examining them too closely.

But Catra was opening it now anyway.

Not with words.

With this.

Adora’s pulse hammered hard enough she could feel it in her throat. Slowly, she extended one leg forward.

Catra’s hand touched her boot.

The contact was light at first, almost cautious, before her claws hooked beneath the fastening and worked it loose. One boot came away, then the other, set carefully aside beside the oils and folded cloths waiting near the bath.

Catra picked up the sponge.

The sight of it did something strange to Adora’s chest.

This was service. Intimate, maybe even humiliating service. The work of attendants and slaves, not queens. Not equals.

And yet Catra’s expression held no submission in it.

Only intent.

Only choice.

Heat had already flushed faint colour into Catra’s cheeks, deepened by the steam dampening the fine fur along her shoulders and thighs. The white flower still rested absurdly delicately behind one ear.

Adora could not stop looking at it.

Catra dipped the sponge.

Water streamed from it in clear rivulets before she pressed it gently to Adora’s foot.

The heat made Adora inhale sharply.

Slowly, carefully, Catra washed her.

The sponge moved over heel and arch, over the curve of ankle and the length of her calf, leaving wet trails glistening in the filtered sunlight. Soap lathered beneath Catra's fingers. She rinsed it away with measured motions, and Adora became painfully aware of every place Catra touched.

The muscles of her thighs tightened involuntarily as Catra moved higher. Water splashed across marble, across Catra's own bare legs where she knelt between Adora's feet as steam drifted around them in soft waves.

Catra rose slightly onto her knees.

She took Adora's hands next.

No sponge this time.

Only fingers.

Warm, wet fingers sliding carefully across Adora's knuckles, working soap into her palms, between each finger, thumbs pressing slow circles.

Adora let her arms be lifted, cleaned piece by piece. The curve of muscle beneath shoulder and bicep. The inside of her elbow. Catra's touch remained steady through all of it, though Adora could feel the tension humming beneath her composure.

Then lower.

Catra's eyes never lifted to meet hers while she washed her upper thighs. The deliberate avoidance only made Adora more aware of the lack. Water poured warm down the front of her body, following the lines Catra's hands had already traced.

Adora's entire body felt too sensitive and open.

And then Catra moved behind her.

Adora couldn't see her anymore.

The loss of sight made vulnerability settle over her all at once. Every sound became louder—the quiet splash of water, the soft squeeze of the sponge, the faint catch of Catra's breathing somewhere behind her shoulder.

She wondered what Catra saw.

What she remembered.

Whether the memories lived inside Catra with the same unbearable clarity they did inside Adora.

Warm water touched her back.

Adora shuddered instantly.

The sponge moved over old scars with impossible gentleness, nothing like the violence that had made them. The contrast nearly undid her. Another tremor followed before she could stop it, smaller this time but deeper somehow, pulled from somewhere beneath skin and muscle both.

Behind her, Catra went still for half a heartbeat.

Then gentler still.

Nothing could undo what had already happened between them.

No amount of softness would erase blood from their past, or terror from memory, or the years they had spent circling each other with claws out and teeth bared. But this—this forced them to look at it directly. Not to speak around it, not to bury it beneath jokes or avoidance or desperate kisses. Catra's hands on her body acknowledged every ugly thing without once turning away from any of it.

And somehow, that hurt less.

The sponge moved more gently over Adora's back than it had anywhere else, careful over the places where skin had once been

split open. The touch was attentive in a way that made her chest ache. Water first. Then soap. Then the slow rinse of warmth spilling down her spine. Flesh remembered. The body remembered even when the mind tried not to. Every careful movement seemed to loosen something inside her she had not known was clenched tight.

It felt wholly necessary.

Like breathing after holding it too long.

Even after everything between them had changed, some part of her had remained prepared for sharpness, for violence, for the quick defensive bite of someone who survived by striking first. But this was different. Catra touched her like she was trying to repair it with her bare hands.

"Catra, I—"

"Head down."

The command came quietly and Adora obeyed before she even thought about it.

Warm water poured over her head in a steady stream, soaking through her hair, running over her face and neck. Usually this part happened seated, bent slightly forward while attendants stood behind with practiced hands and lowered eyes. Adora almost said it aloud, almost named the shape of the memory between them, but Catra was already stepping closer.

Her fingers slid into Adora's hair.

Soap worked slowly into a lather as Catra's hands moved from her temples to the back of her head, long fingers massaging against her scalp with firm, rhythmic pressure that nearly made Adora's knees weaken. Comfort. That was the terrifying thing about it. Catra, who could cut a person open with surgical precision, knew how to do this too.

Catra was all edges until suddenly she wasn't.

Another pitcher of water.

The heat engulfed Adora again as Catra rinsed the soap away, water cascading down over her shoulders and chest. Adora looked up instinctively through wet lashes and found Catra already watching her.

Everything sat visible between them.

Adora could see it in Catra's eyes—the strain of it, the vulnerability she hated exposing, the terrible honesty of what she was offering. Her fur lay darkened where steam and water had dampened it, short strands of regrowing hair curling slightly against her temples and neck. The white flower remained stubbornly tucked behind one ear, absurdly delicate against the sharpness of her.

Words would have been easier.

Adora understood that now.

Catra broke the silence first.

"What happens after this?"

Adora almost smiled despite herself. "You know exactly what happens after this."

Catra's gaze narrowed slightly. "Humour me."

"Isobel used to attend you," Adora said. "You've seen it."

Catra's expression flattened in immediate irritation. "I soaked in the bath. She knelt nearby and tried not to look terrified."

That wasn't the question either.

Adora exhaled slowly. "I wanted to make love to you," she admitted. "That's what comes next."

Something softened briefly around Catra's mouth.

"You can," Catra said. "After."

The soaking bath sat open beneath the sun, steam curling lazily from the surface despite the summer heat. The water was deeper than Adora expected, hot enough that it loosened the tension in her muscles almost immediately as she descended the carved stone steps one by one. By the time she reached the submerged ledge at the opposite side and sat back against the marble edge, heat had already seeped into her bones.

She let her head tip back briefly.

Part of her still wanted urgency. Wanted to close the distance entirely, to pull Catra into her lap and kiss her until all the sharp places between them disappeared. But Catra had always understood something Adora didn't: anticipation had its own kind of sweet cruelty. Its own pleasure.

Adora watched her.

Catra picked up the remaining pitcher and washed herself with none of the performance Adora had seen from attendants or pets or courtiers trying to seduce. There was no deliberate display to it. She simply cleaned herself efficiently, practical even in nakedness, rinsing away soap and steam with brisk movements that somehow made Adora more aware of her body than anything overt would have.

It felt private.

Like being allowed into some hidden part of Catra's life no one else had been trusted to see.

When she finished, Catra approached the edge of the bath.

Adora had a fleeting, ridiculous thought that she intended to climb in still wearing her shoes.

Instead Catra lowered herself gracefully beside the water beneath the shaded colonnade, one knee drawn loosely upward, weight resting against one arm with lazy elegance that seemed habitual. Her other hand drifted through the surface of the bathwater, fingertips cutting small ripples through reflected sunlight.

"It's hot," Catra said.

She said it vaguely enough that Adora couldn't tell whether she meant the bathwater, the weather, or the marble baking beneath the summer sun. Probably all three. Steam still clung faintly to Catra's damp skin from where she had washed herself, leaving a soft flush beneath the fine fur over her chest and shoulders. She remained stretched out beneath the shade line with infuriating elegance, one knee bent loosely, dark hair still damp around her face, entirely unwilling to suffer through the punishing heat of the pool itself.

Adora stared.

Catra looked cool even overheated. Long legs draped carelessly across the stone. Bare stomach rising and falling slowly. Pink nipples darkened slightly from warmth and damp air. The white flower remained tucked behind one ear, as though she had forgotten it entirely.

Adora wanted very badly to ruin the composure of that posture.

If this had been some wild Etherian river instead of a royal bath, she would have crossed the distance in seconds—three hard strokes through cold water, hauling herself dripping onto the rocks beside Catra to put her hands all over her. She imagined it vividly enough that her body reacted before her thoughts had finished forming: palms sliding over wet thighs, Catra arching beneath her, stone warm beneath their bodies while sunlight burned overhead.

Instead she remained submerged to the shoulders, staring openly.

"I thought you were going to kneel," Adora said.

Catra's mouth curved lazily. "Oh, that does sound nice."

The words might have sounded submissive from anyone else. From Catra they somehow became insolent. She made absolutely no effort to move from her reclining sprawl, fingers still idly stirring the water beside her as though she were some pampered aristocrat waiting to be attended.

Adora narrowed her eyes.

"You are the worst servant I've ever had."

"You're alive, clean, and get to stare at your extremely attractive fiancée," Catra said. "Sounds like excellent service to me."

Adora laughed despite herself, then leaned her head back against the marble edge of the bath. Heat soaked through her muscles until she felt almost liquid with it, loose-limbed and heavy. Above her the sky stretched impossibly blue between the pale stone columns and flowering vines.

Beside the bath Catra went quiet.

Not tense. Thoughtful.

"You always knew you'd get back here," Catra said after a while.

Adora opened one eye. "To Mystacor?"

"To Etheria." Catra's fingers continued tracing circles through the surface of the water. "To all of it."

Adora thought back to those long nights in shared tents while Horde soldiers muttered outside and campfires burned low.

"You didn't think we would?" Adora asked.

Catra snorted softly. "Oh, I thought you would." She glanced over finally. "You were impossible to stop. Like fighting a tidal wave with a knife."

“That sounds dramatic.”

“It *was* dramatic.” Catra’s gaze drifted away again. “Being against you was terrifying. Having you on my side was worse.”

Adora frowned faintly. “You were scared of me?”

Catra’s expression tightened just slightly.

“Not *you*,” she said. “What you *did* to me.”

The honesty of it landed heavily.

Adora remembered all at once the tension of those months together. The near-misses. The way Catra used to look at her too long. The sharpness that only ever seemed to appear when they got too close.

“You could’ve told me,” Adora said quietly.

Catra barked a dry laugh. “Yeah, because I was famously good at emotional vulnerability.”

Adora smiled faintly.

Sunlight flashed bright across the water as a breeze stirred the surface. When Adora looked back, Catra was watching her openly now, green and yellow eyes steady beneath damp lashes.

“Sometimes it still freaks me out,” Catra admitted. “This whole…” She gestured vaguely between them. “What we've become.”

Adora’s chest tightened painfully with affection.

“I know,” she said softly. “Me too.”

Catra held her gaze for another second before abruptly reaching for the nearby pitcher.

“Come here,” she said.

Adora frowned. “Why?”

“Just come here.”

Suspicious already, Adora pushed herself upright and waded toward the edge. The moment she emerged fully from the bath, the cooler air hit her flushed skin.

Catra stood at the last second.

Adora saw the shift of her grip on the pitcher she held and immediately raised both hands. “Catra, don’t you dare—”

The water hit her full in the chest.

Ice cold.

Adora gasped so violently it hurt.

“Fucking stars—Catra!”

The shock tore straight through the heat soaking her skin, freezing and electric all at once. Instinct took over immediately. Adora lunged.

Catra shrieked laughing as Adora caught her around the waist and dragged her bodily down with her onto the slick stone. Their bodies collided hard enough to knock the breath from both of them. Catra twisted beneath her, still laughing breathlessly while Adora pinned her by instinct, knees sliding against wet stone.

“You absolute menace—”

“You looked overheated!”

“You nearly killed me!”

“You’re She-Ra!”

“I can still be cold!”

Catra laughed again, brighter this time, and Adora felt the sound of it straight through her chest. She had missed this. The ease of it. Catra alive beneath her and grinning.

Adora shifted automatically to hold her down more securely.

"Careful," Catra said, still breathless with laughter. "I'm in kind of a delicate situation right now."

Adora opened her mouth with some immediate sarcastic reply ready—

—and stopped.

Catra had frozen too.

The laughter drained out of her expression all at once.

Adora blinked slowly. "...Catra?"

Catra's eyes flicked away for the first time since Adora had tackled her. That alone sent warning through Adora's spine.

Then Adora's gaze dropped instinctively.

Down Catra's body.

Past the flushed skin and damp fur and the rise of her ribs—

—to the faintest swell low on her abdomen.

So slight Adora would never have noticed it before. Barely there at all.

Her brain failed completely for one long second.

"Wait," Adora said blankly.

Catra inhaled sharply through her nose. "Okay, before you freak out—"

“I’m not freaking out.”

“You look like you’re freaking out.”

“I literally just killed a galactic tyrant with my bare hands a couple months ago, I can handle—” Adora stopped again. “Handle what?”

Catra spoke too quickly, the words tumbling over themselves in rare genuine nervousness.

“It’s yours. Or technically maybe She-Ra’s? I don’t know how magic biology works, okay?”

Adora stared at her.

Catra swallowed once.

“It’s ours,” she said quietly.

The world seemed to narrow strangely around that sentence.

Ours.

At a complete loss for words, Adora kissed her.

Not with the soft restraint she had been trying to maintain all afternoon.

She kissed Catra with enough hunger that she almost worried she would bruise her mouth with the force of it. Catra made a startled sound against her lips and then immediately kissed her back just as hard, fingers tangling at the base of Adora’s neck as though she intended to keep her there forever.

Catra kissed like she fought: wholly. Every bit of sharpness and feeling packed into it until Adora felt dizzy from the intensity alone. When they finally broke apart, both breathing harder than before, Adora still didn’t know what to say.

So instead she stood first and held out a hand.

Catra snorted softly and let Adora pull her upright.

The moment Catra gained her feet she snatched up one of the nearby towels and immediately dumped it over Adora's head. Adora barely got out an indignant noise before Catra started briskly rubbing at her wet hair.

"Hold still."

"I can dry myself."

"Yeah? You also thought wrestling me onto hard stone was a good idea. You can let me have this."

Adora laughed helplessly beneath the towel while Catra worked at her hair with unexpectedly efficient motions. The softness of the fabric dragged warmly over her skin afterward as Catra dried her shoulders, arms, chest. None of it felt seductive. That was the dangerous thing about it.

It felt caring.

Domestic.

Small, practical tendernesses Adora had never imagined Catra capable of offering because no one had ever offered them to Catra first.

The realization settled strangely warm beneath her ribs.

"The truth is," Adora said, catching Catra's wrist through the towel, "you're ridiculously sweet under all the threatening."

Catra looked immediately offended. "Take that back."

Adora laughed again and retaliated by throwing another towel directly over Catra's head.

Catra hissed from beneath the fabric. "Adora-"

"You look cute."

“Fuck you.”

“I intend to.”

Catra yanked the towel down with a glare that lost some effectiveness because her hair now stuck up in damp disheveled tufts around her ears. Adora felt an almost painful rush of affection at the sight.

Catra ignored her expression entirely and began drying herself with the same practical lack of self-consciousness she did everything else with. She scrubbed the towel over her chest, under her arms, down her stomach, utterly unconcerned with modesty now that Adora had already seen every inch of her. Before doing any of it she carefully removed the white flower from her hair and set it aside, then bent to remove her shoes.

Adora watched that too closely.

Leave them on, she almost said.

There was something about the shoes remaining while the rest of Catra stood bare that made heat pulse low in her stomach again.

Catra straightened and glanced around for one of the light wraps attendants usually provided for moving between the baths and chambers. Before she could reach for one, Adora caught her hand.

“We don’t need it.”

Catra blinked. “Adora-”

“This is Mystacor,” Adora said, tugging her closer. “Nobody cares.”

“That cannot possibly be true.”

“It’s true enough.”

Catra still looked dubious, but Adora was already pulling her toward the open path leading from the baths.

The second they stepped fully into sunlight Catra let out a short breathless laugh that sounded equal parts disbelief and thrill. Adora glanced sideways and saw the exact moment awareness hit her all over again—that she was completely naked outdoors, walking openly through the palace gardens in broad daylight.

Her ears flicked backward.

"You're enjoying this way too much."

"A little."

Their linked hands swung slightly between them as they crossed the outer pathways. Warm stone beneath bare feet. Sunlight over skin still damp from the baths. Flowering vines spilling over pale marble walls while cicadas buzzed lazily somewhere deeper in the gardens.

Adora hardly noticed the openness of it. Etheria had never treated the body with the same rigid possessiveness the Horde had. Baths, healing pools, hot springs—nudity existed without shame attached to it.

Catra, however, noticed every single person they passed.

Adora could feel it in the minute tension through her hand.

Servants stationed discreetly near corridors abruptly became fascinated with literally anything else the moment they saw the Queen of Etheria strolling hand-in-hand through Mystacor with her entirely naked fiancée. Guards kept their expressions carefully neutral with the discipline of highly trained soldiers, though Adora definitely caught one man turning violently red around the ears.

Catra leaned closer as they entered the palace halls proper.

"They're staring."

“They’re trying not to.”

“That’s even worse.”

Adora grinned.

The interior of Mystacor opened around them in flowing color and sunlight. Gauzy curtains stirred through archways open to the vast clouds. Pink and lavender stone caught warm afternoon light while glasswork overhead scattered shifting reflections across the floor. Everywhere the palace breathed openness—balconies, terraces, long airy corridors without the crushing confinement of the Velvet Glove or Bright Moon’s heavier royal architecture.

Catra walked straight through it all in stunned fascination.

When they reached the royal chambers she immediately crossed toward the balcony overlooking the sea. Sunlight drenched her the instant she stepped outside. She leaned both hands against the balustrade and tipped her face upward with her eyes closed.

Then she laughed again softly, like she still couldn’t quite believe herself.

Adora followed slower this time.

The clouds stretched endlessly below them.

Catra looked beautiful there.

“I like it here,” she admitted quietly. “Like… really like it.”

Adora reached out without thinking, fingertips sliding slowly down Catra’s bare arm.

Catra turned toward the touch instantly.

They kissed again.

This one changed quickly.

The softness from the baths remained underneath it, but now there was heat too—the awareness of body against body, of sunlight warming Catra's body while Adora's hands moved over damp fur and muscle and the slight curve low on her stomach that still felt impossible and miraculous all at once.

Catra's arm looped around her neck.

Adora's palms slid down her waist.

The kiss deepened lazily, mouths parting slowly against each other while wind and sunlight wrapped around them both. Catra pressed closer deliberately, grinding against her just enough that Adora felt the slick heat already gathering between them.

Adora groaned softly into her mouth.

"Catra…"

"Mm?"

"You're doing that on purpose."

Catra's smile brushed against her lips, wicked and warm.

"Yeah," she murmured. "You gonna stop me?"

A gentle shove, a few backward steps, and suddenly they were no longer standing in full sunlight but in cool shade again, hidden behind gauzy curtains stirred by the wind. Adora felt soft fabric brush her shoulders as Catra hit the wall behind her with a quiet breath. The wall there stayed cool despite the heat outside. Adora's hands slid instinctively lower, over the narrow dip of Catra's waist and the smooth curves beneath, palms spreading possessively against her.

The room dissolved around them into fragments.

Not destinations. Intervals.

A stretch of time where Catra broke away long enough to pour herself water from one of the crystal pitchers left by servants. Adora leaned against the opposite wall watching her drink, throat working delicately as sunlight cut across the line of her body. Catra caught her staring over the rim of the cup and rolled her eyes without heat.

“What?”

“You’re beautiful.”

Catra snorted softly into the cup.

Then Adora had her again.

One palm braced beside Catra’s head against stone while she bent to kiss the sensitive place beneath Catra’s ear. Slowly. Not trying to get anywhere. Just learning her again through touch. Catra tilted her head back immediately, exposing more skin without thinking about it.

Adora liked that.

She liked even more the small sound Catra made when Adora’s mouth dragged lower along her throat.

The world narrowed further after that.

She turned Catra toward the wall eventually. Catra went with her willingly enough that warmth spread through Adora all over again. She pressed close from behind, chest to back, and kissed the nape of Catra’s neck while her hands wandered slowly over her body.

No hurry.

No battle waiting outside the door.

No war.

Just Catra shivering beneath her hands.

Adora explored lazily, fingertips skimming over Catra's stomach, up beneath her breasts, thumbs circling slowly over nipples already sensitive from heat and attention. Later she would take them into her mouth and listen to Catra make those helpless sounds again. The thought alone nearly made her lose patience.

But Catra liked this.

The slow unraveling.

The anticipation.

Adora buried her face briefly against damp dark hair and let herself enjoy the feeling of Catra melting backwards into her touch inch by inch. Every tiny reaction felt hard-earned. Catra leaned into gentleness like someone starving.

Adora stroked lower, one slow pass over Catra's flank. Then again. Slower.

Catra's breathing had changed.

Not dramatically. Adora just knew her body now.

The quickened pulse under her mouth. The tiny hitch every time Adora touched a certain spot. The way Catra's thighs pressed together instinctively before forcing themselves apart again.

"Adora, I'm close—"

Adora smiled against her skin, unbearably pleased with herself.

"Already?" she murmured.

Catra made an offended noise that dissolved embarrassingly into another breath when Adora's hand slid higher along the inside of her thigh. She stopped deliberately before touching where Catra

clearly wanted her most, thumb stroking only the sensitive join where thigh met torso.

Catra groaned softly.

Her forehead touched the wall.

Adora nearly lost control right there.

Because suddenly she wanted more than touching. Wanted the weight and heat of Catra wrapped around her. Wanted to pin her here and bury herself inside her slow enough to feel every reaction, every shudder, every desperate little movement Catra tried and failed to suppress.

Catra had started pushing back against her in tiny subconscious motions now. Seeking friction. Seeking more.

Adora's fingers came away slick when she finally drew them back and for one dangerous second she almost lifted them to her mouth.

Instead she turned Catra around.

The kiss hit harder this time.

Deep enough to steal breath. Catra's back met the wall again as Adora crowded fully into her space, mouths opening against each other with none of the earlier restraint left intact. Catra made that soft sound again directly into Adora's mouth and Adora felt it everywhere.

When they broke apart, both of them were breathing unevenly.

Adora's forehead rested briefly against Catra's.

It already felt like being inside her. The closeness of it. The heat.

"I want you," Adora admitted roughly.

She watched the colour climb visibly across Catra's cheeks and throat.

Catra looked smug about it despite the fact she was the one barely standing.

"So," Catra said breathlessly, "balcony's acceptable now, but gardens are still scandalous?"

Adora laughed softly.

"We're technically not on the balcony."

"Oh, okay, sure." Catra's mouth twitched. "Easy to lose track after you dragged me naked through an entire palace."

"This is Etheria."

"That's your excuse for everything."

Catra's eyes flicked briefly downward before returning to Adora's face. "Guess we'll have to do things Horde-style when we visit the Fright Zone."

Adora considered that seriously for half a second.

"It's cold there."

Catra huffed a laugh.

"And what about our new palace?" she asked quietly. "The one on the border."

The words hit Adora straight in the chest.

Our palace.

Not Bright Moon. Not the Fright Zone.

Theirs.

Warmth pooled low in her stomach all over again. Adora stepped back into Catra's space instinctively, unable not to touch her.

"Our palace," she repeated softly against Catra's mouth.

Catra swallowed.

"I'm just talking."

"You know I like hearing you talk." Adora murmured.

Adora kissed the corner of her mouth slowly.

"I want this slow," she whispered, then. "The way you like it."

Catra's eyes closed immediately at the words.

"Yeah," she breathed. "Okay."

The number of times they had been together like this was still small enough that Adora remembered every single one with painful clarity.

The first time, where every touch had carried secrets neither of them could survive speaking aloud. The second, frantic and hungry, when they had fallen into each other like people drowning. The roadside inn with the fire crackling low beside them, where Catra had looked at her afterward with such raw softness Adora had known she was in love. Then Bright Moon—after the Velvet Glove, after blood and terror and nearly losing each other for good—where desperation had sharpened every kiss into something almost bruising.

None of those had felt like this.

Now there was no fear pressing at the edges of the room. No war waiting outside the door. No need to steal moments before catastrophe tore them apart again.

They were sprawled together across sun-warmed sheets with late afternoon light striping the bed gold.

Catra lay half over her, one thigh slid between Adora's legs, dark hair falling loose around both of them. Her hands wandered without urgency over Adora's body, fingertips smoothing across her chest, tracing the line of muscle beneath skin, climbing lazily to her throat before drifting back downward again.

Adora could have spent hours just being touched by her.

They kissed slowly.

Catra kissed like no one else existed. Like Adora was the first person she had ever wanted this way and would be the last. Even now there was still something startled in the devotion of it, as though Catra herself remained faintly disbelieving that she was allowed to have this.

Every now and then soft kisses sharpened suddenly into teeth. Small bites at Adora's mouth, her jaw, her throat. Possessive little marks Catra seemed incapable of resisting leaving behind. Adora loved those too.

The openness from the baths lingered stubbornly between them.

Usually Catra's mind ran in constant circles even during intimacy, defenses stacked inside defenses until climax finally burned them away for a few precious moments. But now she seemed quieter inside herself. Loosened. Adora could hear it in the soft breaths escaping her, in the unconscious little noises she didn't even realize she was making anymore.

Tension unwound from her by degrees.

Adora felt it happen beneath her hands.

Their bodies tangled together until touch stopped feeling separate. Skin against skin. Catra's heartbeat against her ribs. Legs sliding together beneath sheets still carrying warmth from

sunlight. Adora gave herself over to the simple overwhelming pleasure of holding her.

Time stretched strangely.

It felt like forever before Adora finally slid a hand between Catra's thighs again.

Catra's legs parted immediately, welcoming her touch.

Adora kissed her again while she slowly worked her open with her fingers, feeling Catra soften and yield piece by piece beneath her touch. Catra clung tighter each time Adora crooked her hand just right, breath hitching hotly into Adora's mouth.

"Adora—"

The sound barely resembled speech anymore.

Adora soothed her with another kiss.

When she finally pushed her fingers inside her, everything went still.

The entire world had narrowed down to the tiny intimate space between their joined bodies.

Catra gasped softly against her mouth.

Adora didn't move at first.

She stayed there feeling the warmth of her, the impossible closeness, their foreheads pressed together while both of them breathed unevenly into shared air. Every part of them felt open. Connected. Even when they finally began to move it stayed slow, almost lazy, their bodies rocking together in short deep motions without ever fully separating.

Adora could feel Catra drawing closer.

Usually Catra fought her own pleasure on instinct, pushing against it right until the edge. This time there was none of that sharp resistance. She simply unraveled hotter and hotter around Adora with every movement.

Inevitable.

A broken sound escaped Catra suddenly as climax finally overtook her completely.

For a while afterward there was only kissing and breath and tangled limbs.

Then Catra surprised her completely.

Catra had barely recovered when she shifted lower across the bed, trailing kisses down her body with a kind of intent focus that immediately made Adora's pulse spike all over again.

"Catra?"

Catra glanced up once through dark lashes, expression smug and soft all at once.

Then she disappeared lower.

The sheer intimacy of it nearly wrecked Adora before Catra had even touched her properly. Want flooded through her so fast it bordered on painful. This was Catra. *Her* Catra. Alive and warm and choosing this.

Adora's head fell back hard against the pillows.

"Stars—"

Catra made a pleased sound against her skin at that.

Everything afterward dissolved into heat and trembling pleasure and Catra's hands gripping her thighs while Adora came apart hard enough to lose coherent thought entirely. By the time Catra

finally climbed back up the bed, Adora felt loose-limbed and half boneless from it.

Catra immediately tried to escape toward the wash basin.

Then they lay tangled together across the ruined sheets while sunlight slowly shifted warmer around the room.

Adora brushed a curl back from Catra's face.

"Tomorrow," she murmured sleepily, "let's plan the nursery."

The words filled her with another strange rush of happiness the second she said them aloud.

Before Catra could answer, someone knocked sharply at the door.

Adora groaned instantly into the pillow because she already knew exactly what Catra was about to do.

"What?" Catra called, not moving except to prop herself up on one elbow.

The soldier entering wore Horde colours. Impressively, he managed not to visibly react to the fact the future Queens of Etheria were naked in bed together with very obvious evidence of exactly what they had been doing moments earlier.

"Your Highness," he said stiffly to Catra, "you requested immediate notice upon the arrival of the Queen of Etheria's retinue."

Catra blinked at him.

Then deadpan:

"Pretty sure I noticed."

Adora burst out laughing.

The soldier somehow kept a straight face.

Adora lifted her head from the pillows enough to say, “Bring cold drinks. And food.”

“Yes, Your Majesty.”

He retreated immediately.

Silence returned.

Catra flopped back down beside her dramatically.

Adora kissed her shoulder.

“We can still plan the nursery tomorrow.”

“Mmm.” Catra sounded entirely unconcerned now. “Depends.”

“Depends on what?”

“I may have already scheduled us for spending the entire day in bed.”

Adora laughed softly again, then looked at her.

Really looked at her.

At the flushed skin and messy hair and marks on her throat. At the barely-there curve low on her stomach.

Warmth flooded through her all over again.

“You’re pregnant,” Adora said, like she was still amazed by it.

Catra rolled her eyes immediately and she muttered, “Yeah, genius.”

Chapter End Notes

If you want to see more of me I am cj.lyndal on tiktok and cjowoart on everything else

I will post a bonus chapter (48) that will just be a nsfw comic of Catra and Adora fucking 😇

Chapter 48: Bonus: NSFW Comic

Chapter Notes

Last warning, nsfw image ahead

I drew this months ago so my style is a little different now again 😅

Previously a Patreon exclusive, I'll now be posting this to Bluesky as well.



Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!